

100 Days of Writing

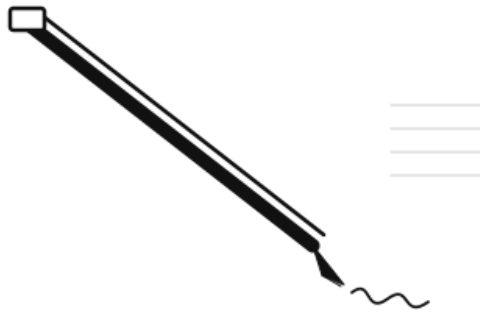
nonharvard

101 posts · 2015–2025

DAY 1

What does writing do to me

Tue, 24 Jun 2025 00:00:00 +0000



WRITING, FIRST OF ALL, IS something one can only do it alone. You can get someone to help you with proof reading, editing, and revising what you have written. But when you write, you write it alone. No original idea worth spreading, reciting, and thinking about, can come from other people telling you what to write. You have to do it alone.

In the past few years, I have spent more time writing than doing anything else party because writing is part of my job for which I get paid, but it is also the way of life, with which over the years, I have developed and familiarized myself. I sometimes tell my close friends and students, I have learned how "not to hate" writing over the years. It's tiring, boring, etc., let alone those writer's block that you'd sometimes get simply because you don't know what to write!

Writing is essential to people like me, who write to learn. When I write I think much more carefully because there is an observable yet often overlooked gap between the time when I get the idea "in the moment" of what I want to write (i.e., the time when something comes up in my head) and the "moment my fingers start to realize" and function, process the information, and eventually put it together, usually, first, in a series of alphabets into words morphing eventually into sentences.

Writing to learn is also writing to communicate. A wise man once said, "it's not a great idea if it's not worth spreading." I couldn't agree more: writing, by and large, is about helping and sharing with others, also, the joy of learning -- otherwise what's the point of writing something in a language that others can also read? I also write for myself.

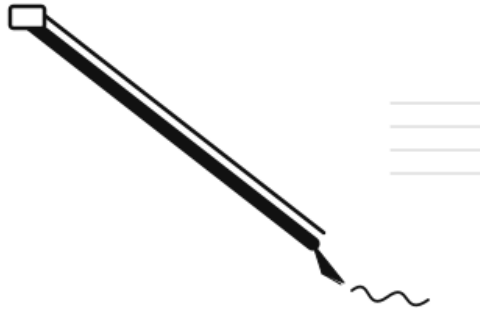
Writing Degree Zero is the title of the semiotician/poststructuralist thinker Roland Barthes' work in which he, basically, writes about the possibility that one could write for the sake of writing; in other words, writing as an end in itself. I never understood what Barthes was getting at in that book, but I did sense, when I read it, that, perhaps, the message that he wanted to convey may have to do with the idea of "just writing," without the conscious sense that one is writing for a particular reader. Why?

To put it simply, by thinking that there'll be someone reading your work, you are automatically doing injustice to the ideas that are flourishing inside of your head by consciously (and sometimes unconsciously) censor them because you have an anxiety toward the reception of your audience. In the same way that fieldnotes may have done for ethnographers who use their notes to record what they have learned each day from the field, I write because I think of writing as a friend who always spare me his profound silent words.

This friend whom I call writing is always helpful in being a proloner, a mediator -- and a mediator -- of an act of immature thinking, which I often arrive at without his kind and critical help. This friend of mine, writing, helps me think twice before making any conclusion, without doing the justice to the data received through my unfortunate and imperfect cognition. Original Title: A prelude to the my 100 Days of Writing blog. bank of Huangpu River on the Puxi side on my bike. This particular act of writing took place, and was performed there.

DAY 2

Some More Reasons to Reflect



THERE YOU HAVE IT: A reason to write. These social psychologists, in their study, have shown that "reflection leads to better performance." Just 15 minutes, they claim, after a day of work helps you find out what are the takeaways of the day, including both the lessons learned, as well as successful stories that, in the spirit of self-help zeitgeist, facilitate your sense of motivation conducive to carrying on of the next day of work.

In other words, as these social psychologists summarize at the end, "This is because writing helps 'codify' the things you have gone through." Reflection is key: Even recalling of negative feeling and emotion helps to strengthen the sense of individual personhood. I couldn't agree more: this research's finding resonates profoundly with me.

Just a couple days ago, another colleague also discouraged me from writing this blog, which got me, for the fourth time in three days, to re-think whether or not I should keep going with this effort to write this blog (after all, this is just the Day 2 of the 100-day game plan, so if I shall decide to leave it there it wouldn't be too bad). So, I have all these external pressures pursuing me, telling me not to do what I want to do.

But the more important question is, why am I so persistent in wanting to do it despite the fact that most people around me are telling me that it is a bad

idea? While procrastination is the usual suspect here, I am suspicious that which is the reason why I am writing this blog -- since, in a way, writing this blog is all about writing my dissertation. Fine. I may be a master of procrastination (sometimes) but why would someone writes just so that he could avoid writing? Fine.

Writing this blog is different for writing dissertation, and someone the feeling of accomplishment I may get from writing this blog might psychologically substitute what I "should" be doing. But, hey, still, I don't think that which is the reason why I write. Here, to explain my self, I would like to resort to a metaphor: during the past few months of dissertation writing, I have been feeling as if I had been walking in a rather dark tunnel without a torch.

There's enough light for me to see the path in front of me, so, as a young man with the vision he himself trusts, I did not think that I need a torch to walk through this tunnel. Suddenly, I slumped.

I then got up, and then slumped again after a few feet, and after a few slumps that followed I began to realize that what I was looking at through my eyes had been merely the walls of the tunnel because these walls were at the same height as my eyes. What I didn't see very clearly was the floor, on which there were rocks and bumps and so on (it's a tunnel after all, right?).

Suddenly, I realized that had I had a torch, I would be able to cast its light on the floor while walking on the path. I would be able to look at the walls while also paying attention to the floor.

That said, there was no way I could go out to get the torch since the dissertation writing process was already half way in -- wait, let's stick to the metaphor of the tunnel, or cave, or whatever I used earlier -- I was already half way inside the tunnel. So, what I could do is to pay more attention to the floor. I'd be walking much slower, because I would pay attention to every step I'd take.

I would be looking down as well as looking up when I move my foot forward. Sometimes, I would also move my foot backward if that would help me avoid big bumps and so on. I think of writing this blog, precisely, as that process. I want to have the time to look at the floor on which I walk. I can't focus on both of the floor and the wall at the same time.

Focusing on the wall is a must otherwise I'd walk into the wall and hurt myself. The chances that one of my foot might hit some rocks on the floor and bring me down might not be that high, and even though when that happens it often doesn't hurt as much as running into the walls anyway, there is a good reason not to want that to happen to you. Looking at the floor is like reflecting on your capability to move forward.

You can't just move forward. You also need to inspect the direction on which you have walked.

It's true that writing at the end of the day -- like this blog -- would be more like looking back at the path that I have walked on in order to realize either lesson learned or achievements, or both, who are we to say that we understand space-time so well that we can only think of the path in front of us as something with a much closer proximity to the future than the past?

I see the path as a reflection of the past (pun not intended!) -- we only know that something is a path on which we can walk because we have walked on it, or, in most cases, something that may appear similar to it, before, and I have, as, in my case, this has been the path that I have been walking for the past few months: the path of writing my dissertation. When I write, I consciously and unconsciously take in all kinds of experience in daily lives.

I have tried to trick myself with various techniques to believe that I can separate my daily lives from the stories that I write, but it never worked, because the main part of me wholeheartedly believe that by doing so is no more than kiddin' myself.

But, with this sense of reflexive that I now have and will forever hold dear, I will see the path in front of me with consistency reflexive eyes, in order to

make sure that the resonance between what it looks like and what the wall in front of me is telling me what it "should" look like would protect me from stepping on the wrong stone and slump.

So many people that I know write something, and then re-write what they have written something entirely the next day -- either by themselves or because of the comments they receive from their peers. Why is that the case? My theory is that when you get too absorbed into something, say, writing, the part of your mind that helps you perceive other things around you get shut off. When it comes to academic writing, once that part of your mind get shut off, your writing becomes incomprehensible.

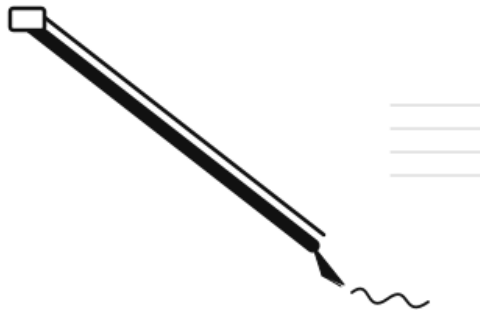
It's like talking to yourself -- such closing-off and then closing-in affects how you conceive what you write, obscuring the reason why you write at the first place. This is the reason why I tend to disagree with many people who think that writing a dissertation must be a full-time job. The process of closing-off and then closing-in might work for some, but it obviously does not work for me.

Last time I did that, as I was running late on a deadline, I ended up having to write the entire thing all over again, simply because I did not make time to reflect. Photos: These two were taken on Fuzhou Road in Shanghai.

DAY 3

Writing Stream of Consciousness

Thu, 26 Jun 2025 00:00:00 +0000



TODAY, I SPENT A FEW minutes after lunch thinking about my career. While writing a chapter of my own dissertation, I got distracted by a visit from someone I knew, and then got completely distracted by that person's question about me and my life in the past ten years. Suddenly, I realized that everything that I was writing at the time was about me.

True, I was writing about my informants, and their lives (at least that was what I had been telling myself) but merely what I had been writing about so far is nothing but the impressions of my informants that I have. The more I thought about how I came to get to know them, and how I came to justify what I knew, and how much I knew, about them, the more I felt that I didn't know anything about them.

In short, it's an identity crisis, but not in the strictest sense of the term. I wasn't uncertain or confused about my own sense of identity, but I was uncertain about who I was, in relation to the people with whom I had gotten to know over the years doing my research here in Shanghai -- my identity to them. For sure, who my informants thought I was affected how they would like to present themselves to me.

In that case, how much could I take what they have told me at face value? In other words, I wasn't sure whether I was writing about them, or that I was writing about myself. Originally trained as an architect and urban designer, I have decided — precisely 5 years ago — to embark on a long and tiring journey in getting a PhD in a field that would eventually make me an "anthropologist." What does being an anthropologist mean anyway?

It is a bit sad that I still don't know that even today. As I am arriving at the end of my PhD education, I feel inclined, more than ever in fact, to reflect upon why someone with a decent professional career in architecture and urban design like myself would go back to school and spend more than half a decade studying something remotely related to my previous training. What is anthropology anyway?

And how might it help me to become a better architect, urban designer, writer, and, more than anything else, cosmopolitan citizen of the society wherever that be. Back to writing. My primary supervisor always tell all of us his students to begin a writing process with the most powerful story that we have from the field that could think of (possibly, even suggested, with a glass of wine in hand and that is precisely what I am doing right now).

From there, without looking at the field notes, books, or any external references: simply let the ethnographic stories tell its story, and lead the writing. His argument here is that the best depository of ethnographic knowledge ain't the field notes that most of us spend so much time (often every day before going to bed) writing, "but right here in our head," said he. This is the most important lesson on ethnographic writing that I have learned from anyone since it's both unconventional and provocative.

Although this advice seems to undermine the importance of ethnographic field notes, which many anthropologists hold dear, it brings home the point about what exactly we anthropologists do best -- being qualitatively nuanced about the sensitivity of the situation that we would like to describe ethnographically. To be sure, there is no way we'd know that what we write in the field notes is true.

In fact, we only kid ourselves to think that we "must always rely on our field notes," which are nothing more than a subjective record of our own personal experience, or the "impression" of our experience subjectively projected onto someone else who we often call "informants." Then, once that projection is there, and you are ready to recall it to the very last detailed information, don't stop writing until you actually -- and physically -- drop.

Then, obviously, go to bed, and the next day come back to look at what you have written.

My secondary supervisor also once shared with me similar stories: to begin from the single most powerful ethnographic moment that I could possibly remember (although he didn't say whether or not I could look at my field notes although I always assume that it's not a big deal to him whether or not I'd look at the field notes since, quite often, "the single most powerful" ethnographic moment is something one can easily recall anyway), and then let the relevant theories come into play later once the ethnography has been meticulously laid out.

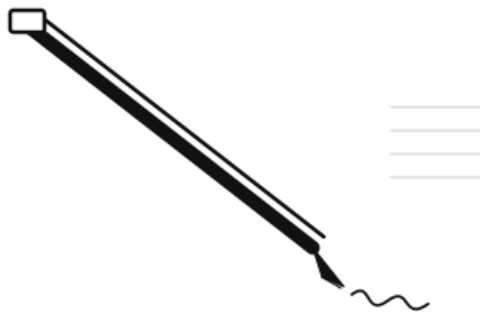
I have been taking these two advises to heart. So far I have not even looked at a page of my field notes. Writing in this way -- the way that this blog post is being written, in fact -- can also be called the "stream of consciousness" style.

Spearheaded and popularized by many modern literary figures (such as James Joyce, with whose writing style I have been having a love-hate relationship), the essence of the stream of consciousness literary style, at least in anthropology, is the depiction of an ethnographic encounter in a continuous flow. It is usually performed uninterrupted by the writer during a continuous writing period and zone. The objective here is to try to not letting anything, e.g., objective or conventional description, interrupt the flow of the flowing ideas.

DAY 4

Because We Are Living in the Best of All Possible Worlds, Therefore I Bike (and Vice Versa)

Fri, 27 Jun 2025 00:00:00 +0000



"A gentleman shouldn't go on and on about what he does to stay fit. At least that's how I see it." In Haruki Murakami.

WHAT I TALK ABOUT WHEN I Talk About Running The original title of this post was What I Think About When I Think About Biking, which, to any of you who knows who the Japanese writer Haruki Murakami is, would know that this was an almost (just almost) direct copycat of his famous memoir What I Talk About When I Talk About Running, which, by the way, was inspired by Raymond Carver's collection of short stories entitled What We Talk About When We Talk About Love.

Murakami's What I Talk About When I Talk About Running is my favorite book among all of his non-fiction -- my favorite fiction of his is The Wild Sheep Chase, a stunning gripping surreal suspense starring an ordinary Japanese man who has to become an impromptu detective thanks to a mysterious circumstance brought upon him by a seemingly mundane action which he didn't think would lead to anything at all, let alone a mysterious circumstance that would make him travel a very long distance -- with his

equally mysterious girlfriend who is both sexually liberal and openly charming -- to find out what is happening to his otherwise ordinary life (and that's a hell of a long sentence!).

Publisher Weekly has made this novel one of the top ten must-read among Murakami's novels: The original title of this novel is "An adventure concerning sheep," and it lives up to that title...Some of the most interesting parts of the novel take place in the rural wilds of Hokkaido, which has been interpreted alternately as the hero's inner mind, or as a mythological land of the dead. At its heart, this is a tale of conflict between the will of the individual and the demands of an impersonal State.

What I Talk About When I Talk About Running is pretty much Murakami's autobiography in disguise. In fact, it is his biography; hence, the only thing that is misleading about the book is its title, which should be, Talking about My Life Through Running.

On the other hand, since a large part of his life has to do with writing (duh), the large parts of the book concern his writing career (which, by the way, one could also read how he fascinatingly, and almost by accident, started his career as a writer in his kitchen in the preface to his first novel Hear the Wind Sing).

That is, Murakami could easily have called this book What I Talk About When I Talk About Writing, but the fact it seems more plausible (and believable) for someone to be able to think about something else while using his muscle to run, rather than while also using his brain to craft some of the most intriguing fascinating work in the Japanese literary art.

In the book, he basically talks about how he became interested in running, and how running has shaped him as a person, as a writer, and as a runner, which is something that he always takes as an end in itself. This is very clear, as toward the end of the book he writes that these are the words he would like to be craved onto his gravestone: Haruki Murakami: Writer (and Runner), At Least He Never Walked.

Ever since I bought my Brompton folding bike in May at a professional bike shop in Uptown Manhattan, I have been riding it almost everyday here in Shanghai. By the way, Brompton is the world's most versatile, beautiful, and mobile folding bike made in the UK. I always wanted one but because it's not cheap I had to wait until my 33rd birthday to buy it for myself.

In fact, it took me a while to make that decision, as I could have bought a cheaper folding bike (which wouldn't be as versatile, beautiful, and mobile), but cheaper. Then I thought about my father, who always wanted a Brompton. Despite the fact that his physical condition wasn't good enough for him to ride a bike anymore during the last decade of his life, he also always wanted to get a Brompton. So, I thought to myself, what would my father want for me?

He's frugal but when it came to buying quality stuff, he never compromised. So, I thought to myself that by buying this expensive bike, I wouldn't just be buying it for myself, but I'd be buying for my father, and would get to use it on his behalf. The reason why Murakami's book resonates with me is because I also do the same thing.

I like to exercise, and I like to spend the time while exercising giving myself time to think about something else outside of my immediate layers of concerns. When I bike, I don't think about anything else concerning my life. When I bike, I think of some imaginary scenarios in which, in an ideal world, I could be. I sometimes think of the world with a different set of underpinning of universal political conflicts. I also think of what else I might be doing in another universe parallel to mine.

That is to say, when I bike, my mind seems to stop working in the present, taking me to a different place, space and time, altogether. Some of the best ideas I have had in my academic life came to me when I was biking, and that may be precisely because when I was on my bike I always allowed myself to be less myself, and be more "my true self." I have a feeling that which is also the case for Murakami.

In a way, when I am on the bike, I reflect by focusing on what is immediately in front of me, which is the road. The speed, and the sense of excitement, especially when I am off-road but still able to peddle really fast, makes me want to scream out loud passionately about how much I really enjoy being in the moment. It's the best of all possible worlds.

I guess what happens to me when my true self comes out like that is that my sense of provocativeness is completely decompressed, and let out. That said, there's another side of myself when I bike. Letting true self out of its self-decompressed mode has yet to be proven to be the loyal road toward the self. As a Buddhist, I don't even believe that the self even exists.

I believe that the self is something that I construct, with the help of the society into which I was born, simply to make myself miserable.

Interesting enough, as one of my favorite psychologists Alison Gopnik writes, the philosopher David Hume was also influenced by this very Buddhist idea of the selflessness (as in, "no self," rather than selfless as in opposite to selfish) when he wrote *A Treatise of Human Nature*: When I enter most intimately into what I call myself, I always stumble on some particular perception or other, of heat or cold, light or shade, love or hatred, pain or pleasure.

I never can catch myself at any time without a perception, and never can observe any thing but the perception. Perception might not be the thing that makes us unhappy, but the caring too much for the perceptions of others on the thing that you call "I" is what brings about pain, dissatisfaction, and discomfort.

When I get on the bike, I am no longer this PhD student guy whose only job is simply to write, to write more, and to write even more, but a man who is enjoying being in the moment. I am not a professional biker, so I don't care if I don't move very fast, and I don't care if I don't bike like a pro.

I guess when you take yourself out of the immediate circle in which others think you are the expert, you also take the pressure of having to be an expert

from your shoulder. It is not a complete sense of selflessness, but it's at least providing some breathing space.

It's the mixed feeling of being my true self and being selfless, being myself and being non-self (as opposed to Non-Self; Gee my name is so handy when it comes to punning!), being something that I want to keep it alive and being something that I could simply let go, and the list goes on. Hey. I understand that at this point, you may think that I am simply exaggerating. You might be right. At this point, I want to take this message to a slightly different direction.

I did mention earlier that, on my bike, I feel as though I am living in the best of all possible worlds. On my bike, I often feel as though there is nothing else that I want in my life. On my bike, in other words, I always feel as though my life is fulfilled.

This may have to do with the fact that when I am on my bike, I'd have no choice but to stay focused on what's in front of me, such as traffic, people crossing the road, traffic light, and so on. Yes, there's a temptation to look at my phone, check my messages and emails, and so on, but none of these I could do while I am on my bike trying to balance myself on the bike while looking ahead at the road on which I am.

The quote "best of all possible worlds" owes its origin to the 17th-18th-century rationalist philosopher Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz. This philosopher, known to many of his time to be a polymath because he's knowledgeable in many fields including the sciences and the arts, has a very detailed and methodological technique of rationalization to come to the understanding that whatever happens in the world we are living in is the best of all possible worlds.

Leidniz may have been focused too much on the power of God -- that makes the world we are living in the best that is possible -- but if we read between the line and try to understand his outside the context of the all powerful God, maybe we can derived at a different conclusion. For me, I feel as though I am

being embraced by the all powerful energy when I am focused on what I do.

So, when I am on my bike, for instance, I feel as though nothing else matters. Time passes in a relatively different shape compared to when I am drinking coffee, or cooking. Spaces through which the wind generated by the directional speed of my bike cut bend different too. I feel as though I can distant myself from the phenomenal world when I am on my bike. What I am about to say here is something that a gentleman, in Murakami's mind, shouldn't do.

If the weather is acceptable, people of Shanghai will always see Non and his bike roaming around the city -- at a ridiculously fast speed. I always wear an extra windbreaker so that I can sweat more than usual. That's how I keep my belly in check. Of course, as a single man, I would like to keep my health and my physique in check.

At the beginning, I wasn't very comfortable with sitting on the bike's seat for a long time, but I could easily be on it two hours uninterrupted. This week, unfortunately, has been pretty dreadful in terms of rain, so I haven't been out on the road that much. Today, after all I had to do for the day was done, I managed to ride about 20 kilometers around the part of the city in which I am currently living, which is northeast of Shanghai.

It's the part closest to the Yangtze River Delta. There's one time that I rode my bike all the way to the very tip of the Delta, where the hyperbolically modern-looking International Cruise Terminal (but people-less) was. Biking makes me feel relax. I always use the time on the bike to listen to audio books and Podcasts that I like. Sometimes it's something totally random, such as all Malcolm Gladwell's books (you name it, and I'll tell you exactly what it is about!).

For the last few weeks, it's been Howard Zinn's A People's History of the United States that got me completely entertained, in the zone, and helped me pass time when the ride wasn't that pleasant (especially when the road was nothing but a long, dusty, and tediously straightforward). If not an audio

book I would be listening to Podcasts. Two of my favorite Podcasts are, for some reason, all about philosophy: Philosophy Bites by Nigel Warburton and David Edmund, and Philosophize This by Steven West.

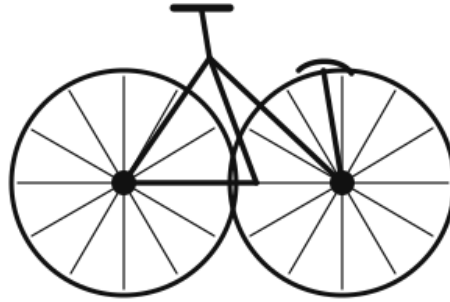
It's interesting how the names of these two Podcast program rhyme! It was pretty much the same route that I always take since there's some comfort in taking the same route, as I don't have to worry if I get lost. That said, there's something unsettling and boring about taking the same route.

This conflict has always been the conflict that I have when I think just about anything -- I like to keep doing things that I know I am capable of doing them well; yet, at the same time, I always search for new things to try out.

DAY 5

Tradition: What's Good For?

Sat, 28 Jun 2025 00:00:00 +0000



ABSOLUTELY NOTHING. BEFORE I GET to why I said so (and yes, I deliberately borrow it from Edwin Starr's song called War), let me talk about me and my bike. I was on my bike today again after taking a long afternoon nap between 3 - 5pm. I was tired.

There's a "Thai Cultural Day" at Fudan University in the morning, about which I was very excited even though I didn't know anything about it until yesterday -- when I was on my bike, and my colleague called me to invite me to the event. I came home around 1pm, and tried to write. As it was hot outside, I also didn't want to go out.

While I was walking back home, about half way through and at the point my back was all sweaty already, I saw a number of people in coffee shops. "It must be nice to be sitting in a nice and cold room when the outdoor temperature is this brutal," I said to myself. Suddenly, I began to speculate (for fun) about how and why coffee shops have become so ubiquitous here in China -- where most people actually, still, drink tea.

What caught my mind was the fact that, in the past two years, I have been meeting countless of my Chinese friends, soon-to-be-friends, and soon-NOT-to-be-friends (-because-I-don't-want-to-see-them- ever-again)

in, mainly, coffee shops. I even got a Starbucks Rewards card for that reason!

Back in the US and in the UK where I used to live, I often invited friends and people with whom I would like to get to know over to the living room of my apartment (or of my college in Oxford) where I'd make coffee or tea for them. When I say "make" I really mean it.

For instance, I'd show them the coffee beans and explain the history of the beans (which I always got from "exotic places" where I often traveled to), and then I'd use a manual coffee grinder to grind the coffee -- often twice to make sure that the ground coffee would be absolutely, well, ground -- and then I'd show how I pour hot water through the special pot that would delay the speed of the hot water coming out from its tip so that the water wouldn't run through the ground coffee too quick and that every bits and pieces of the ground coffee get soaked up, releasing both the aroma and the majestic taste of coffee for me, and for my guests.

Yet, many of the my Chinese friends who would like to meet at a coffee shop don't even like coffee. They would order a cup of sweetened drink (e.g., mocha, latte, cappuccino, frappe, you name it) and most of the time they'd only consume half of the "large size" cup that they order, and then deliberately leave the other half to be thrown into the sink after the staff come to clean the table once we're done drinking there. My question is, what underpin this custom?

Let me break it down, of 1) having to meet in the very public space despite the fact that our matter is rather private; 2) having to order what they don't even like to drink just to show that they have the cultural capital to "apprehend modernity"; and 3) having to do it in such a way that is conducive to the irresponsible rise of egregiously immoral form of capitalism?

There are today, of courses, places where a group of people drinking non-alcoholic beverages together to socialize, such as in Sichuan where there's a park there're always a lot of people drinking tea together in the open. Yet, there's also a lot of places that drinking tea is a domestic activity,

and I have always had the feeling that which is the case for large urban places similar to Shanghai.

True: tea houses have always been everywhere, maybe with an exception of the period of high communist mentality from the mid-1950s to the late 1970s.

But, as I have heard during my two years in Shanghai, when friends meet, it's more cozy to meet in a domestic space, which might have something to do with the cost associated with going out to a tea house, or the fact that a tea house is a public place "where strangers who don't trust each other yet meet" and hence there're often some senses of unnecessary formality there. Some tea houses were also associated with prostitution and brothels.

Growing up in an overseas Chinese family, that's how I see it. To me, serving tea is largely something that you would do to express your respect and generosity to your counterparts and friends (as Confucius once said, "isn't it extremely nice to have friends from a far place visiting? [and therefore we must take care of them well]").

During the first century of the foreign-controlled Shanghai (1842 - 1945), for instance, most alleyway houses had the so-called living room on the south side to entertain these friends from a far place. As we all know, this luxury lifestyle was removed from the social life of the people once the Chinese Communist Party took over in 1949. The luxury of having extra spaces to receive guests for a private tea ceremony, also, had to be eliminated from the social life.

From this perspective, it could have been the case that it's the lack of space in the private domain has been what gives rise to the public domain. I wasn't that tired when I was on my bike actually. That said, I wasn't as active as I usually was. My guess is that I must have tired from the previous night, trying to crank out more than my brain could process.

On the other hand, there's also the fatigue from the day before, during which I also spent a lot of time on my bike trying to think. This time the route I took was different. I rode my bike all the way to the end of Line 1 on Shanghai

Metro, and then looped back to Yangpu District. On the bike, I was thinking about one question: tradition, what's good for?

And this may have been because of my attempt to unravel the question of the rise of coffee shop culture, and why my colleagues who don't like coffee go to coffee shop, which I discussed it with myself earlier.

If we can agree that inviting someone to your home to serve him or her hot a cup of warm beverage at home sounds like a "good" tradition, why do people today revert it by giving in to capitalism to do the task, reducing the meaning of the ritual of serving that warm cup of hot beverage to just a matter of paying at the cashier?

One of my friends once shared with me, "it doesn't look good to meet and talk in a private space, especially that in the home, anymore because 'anything' could happen in the private space." Fair enough. You wouldn't want to make yourself vulnerable to your own feeling, and let your own feeling take you down the path of no return, but then again, what's the point of having a tradition then? Again, I am no fan of tradition, which is why I like Kant (will tell you later why).

Whenever someone tells me what I should, or should not do, without giving me a "reasonable reason" with which I could agree, I always invite "Mr. Non the skeptic" to take over my consciousness and play the role of an asshole who wouldn't let my guard down, and do things "just because someone said so" (this may explain why my life hasn't been very successful lately!).

Kant famously said something like (my ability to remember his exact quote is highly limited), "enlightenment is the process by which men emerge from their self-imposed immaturity." This quote resonates with me in a deep and sublime way. Make no mistake: I want to emerge from my self-imposed immaturity.

That said, the tradition of inviting your friend to have some tea or coffee at the comfort of the place you call home is one of the very few traditional things that I still believe in -- and I won't let anyone take it away from me,

given that I have the tolerance to accept and won't complain about the gazillions of their self-imposed maturities.

Next time when someone asks me if I'd like to go to a coffee shop because it "looks better to meet in private," I would just tell them to fuck off.

While balancing myself on my bike at 24 kilometers per hour today, I was trying to comprehend David Hume's take on custom, and, needless to say, the meaning of it all (i.e., design, aesthetics, causality, and, alas, skepticism as a way of life) while I was on my bike for two hours today, and the question that stroke me most was this question for which I always wished I had an answer.

I like Hume's philosophy because it urges me to focus on myself, not the society, and not the people around me. It's an "internal empiricism" if there's such a term. Believing whether there's someone behind the intelligent design is simply a matter of how you'd like to cope with your life, and may or may not affect others.

There's no "categorically right" or wrong way of believing, although his intention is to urge us to exercise our reason in order to fight against the fictional traditions with which we have lived for a long time.

The reason for thinking this way comes from two sources: Hume being one of them (as he always urges us to re-evaluate our own inductive assumption -- just because something happened before the way it had happen, does it absolutely mean that the result of the similar incident will always bare the same result? The quick answer, perhaps, is, "well, yeah, why not?" But for Hume, his answer is a long yet profound *A Treatise of Human Nature*.

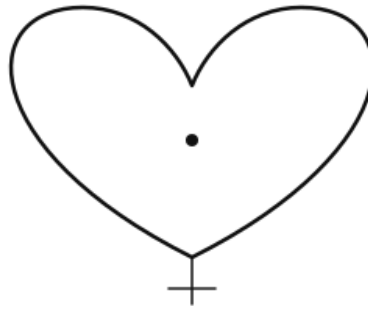
The other thinker who idea resonates with me when I was on the bike today was Immanuel Kant. You can probably imagine me getting on my bike for hours musing over these questions. I can tell you that with these questions in mind, hours seemed like minutes.

Before I knew it, the sky was all dark and I was surrounded, on a large highway, by gigantic vehicles and articulated trucks, to the point that I got scared of being run over -- especially after having read a horrifying news about an incident that took place in South China a few days earlier.

DAY 6

Why I (Give Up) Love, Part 1

Sun, 29 Jun 2025 00:00:00 +0000



IN EVERYONE'S LIFE, THERE MUST be that moment that you feel you could live forever. Imagining a middle- age person looking at his/her own photos in the 20s and mutter to his/her ownself, "that was such a good time, and it's all gone -- all of it." The time when everything around you was beautiful, and because you had the vision to enjoy it, and the energy to seek more beautiful things, you felt as if the world is yours, and it would be yours forever.

To many, it's the time when they're in their 20s. It's those time when things seem to move slow because you don't have a lot to do yet. To some, it's the time when they're in their 30s. I am in my 30s and I am beginning to realize that which time for me has already long long long gone. I look at people, and their happiness, and feel that "I was once happy, like that, too." One may call what I am facing right now a mid-life crisis.

I call it, a "mid-life understanding." There's a time during which time didn't mean much, because I had all the energy to make time fly in such a way that I did not feel that it had any importance to my well-being. Those were the time when I'd go out everyday -- and every night -- and had a "good time" with friends, enjoying all the toxic drinks, polluted air, and frustrating confusing audial environment.

My friends and I did not have a clue that the time when our bodies would no longer be able to absorb all of these unnatural malignant externalities was arriving sooner than we thought.

And, lo and behold, suddenly, I found myself desiring nothing, but a continuous moment of solidarity to, reflect, to really enjoy being myself because the happiest time of my life is when I do things for myself and there's no one else I'd have to please, and, finally, to feel that the time is not being taken for granted. I think that is the essence of our species.

Time in money, yes, but I mean it in the sense that we should all treat time as valuable the same way we treat money. I don't waste money on things that don't matter, therefore I don't waste time. The major difference here, as many philosophers will tell you, is that you cannot bring back the time that you have wasted.

If you have spent it already, presumably unwisely, the best you can do is to keep moving on without regretting it since, duh, there's no point regretting about it unless having some thoughts about what you could have done gives you some sense of guilt that lead to self-improvement. The longer you've lived, presumably, the longer you'd feel the importance of time, especially those long gone time.

I used to do a lot of things that I didn't think matter to anyone, and bared no benefits to nothing at all, such as playing video games, reading comic books, drinking excessively, gossiping about other people, talking trash, and, the worst of all, being worried about how other people saw me. Did I enjoy those moment? Maybe. Some of which did provide me some comfort that there was a way I could channel out my anxiety. And apparently, as backed by science, some anxiety is good for you.

I still do, in fact, but only when I do them with good friends, with whom the importance of time that I would be spending has a direct implication. I got some writing done today. In the morning, I was able to crank out a few pages of my next chapter in my dissertation (the tentative title of this chapter is

Anthropology of Displacement in which I'd like show the alternative consequences of the relocation process in Shanghai).

I was dying to get out of the house after the work for the day was, kind of, done. Thanks to my colleague Harry den Hartog who had decided to spend his entire afternoon and the evening hanging out with me.

Originally we were planning to attend a film event there, but as soon as we realized that it was an exclusive event for exclusive participants we just scrapped the idea and instead, quoting Harry den Hartog, "head for some beer." We started off biking almost 28 kilometers all the way to the southwest side of the city where we somehow decided that it would be the place that we would enjoy a great feast together -- without our friend Leo Pang who once lived around the corner from where we went for food.

It's ironic because three of us had, in the past 12 months, always talked about the plan to have dinner together there, but it only happened after Leo had left Shanghai to return to London to continue his study at the School of Oriental and African Studies (SOAS). I'd spent almost two hours in the bike trying to get from the northeast part of Shanghai to its southwest counterpart.

Even though, at least on the map, it looked like the path was going to be pretty simple (just a direct diagonal line) the reality was much more complicated. Among the 101 things expats hate about Shanghai (a poll recently conducted by a local magazine), one thing I can wholeheartedly agree with the Chinese drivers' excessive and irresponsible use of their vehicle horns.

I always thought that we only use it when we need it because the sound of the vehicle horn isn't pleasing (and it will never be because of its nature to function as a warning to other drivers on the road) but in Shanghai, drivers use it as if it would help their vehicles to move faster. I thought they would only honk their horns when they make a turn, but apparently they also do when they move on a straight line with no one else in front of them.

I thought they would honk their horns when they want to tell you that they are behind and therefore want to give you a warning, but apparently they also honk their horns at you even though they are far behind you and do not have any attempt to surpass you. And the list goes on. You get the idea: No wonder many urban Chinese people have anger management problems.

In other words, honking horn is a pathological expression of habit, as a result of pathological repression, compulsive suppression, and chronic sense of self-imposed selfishness. I knew this because I had a lot of opportunities, usually while waiting for the traffic light, to converse with my fellow motorcyclers who also ride with us bikers on the bike land.

Most of these drivers looked at me as if I was a mad man when I asked them why they honked their horn at me (because I usually stop my bike and ask them "what's the matter?" and I guess not many do that as a response to their horn-honking habit), before sharing with me their thoughts on the rampant and blatant urban China's horn honking culture.

For an ordinary citizen, I quote one incidental informant here, "honking a horn is to tell whoever around you that I am here." When I asked him whether or not he thought that the sound of his horn is disturbing, his response was "not when I honk it (laughter). In a way, I had a good time with drivers like Mr. Hu here (let's call him Mr. Hu for now). All I was trying to do was to spend my time wisely.

Instead of getting upset over something I won't be able to change anyway (or even if I can, what can I do since I am a part of it anyway), I would like to spend my time trying to get to the bottom of it -- with the help of the spirit of James Rachels' version of relativism. That is, maybe it's just me who gets annoyed by this horn-honking culture. Mr. Hu was, at least, very sincere about his feeling.

He said he wouldn't mind if someone honking his/her horn for no reason behind him. "I'd just ignore it," said he. Our conversation lasted about 3 minutes before we parted to go our ways (talking about him actually makes

me miss him now). He did waved good bye to me with his right hand, in which he's also holding a cigarette.

Personally, I think horn-honking is one of the very few legal and normative "gesture of authority" that ordinary Chinese citizens could do to others, since the political system of the country aims, almost wholeheartedly, at limiting its citizenry's sense of moral authority. It's like in the episode of Modern Family in which Mitch and Cam drove around the city with a car equipped with a stereo equipment and a loud speaker.

Once they realized that people tended to act differently (in a more proper way) once they felt ashamed of how they originally behaved as pointed out, through a loud speaker, by Mitch and Cam. So, on the one hand, horn-honking represents, at least, the smallest possible gesture of agency and personhood. I usually let it pass. But there were times that I got off my bike and walked to the persons who honked the horn and asked him/her what the f**k was his/her deal.

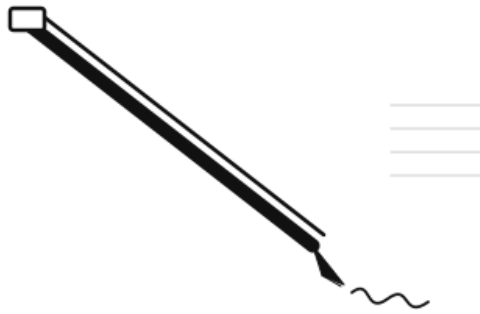
Because, on the other hand, we're all in competition here. You want to get home quick. I want to go there, also, quick. What's better than using the only means possible to provide that gesture so that you would achieve your goal sooner? That said, I felt ashamed every time they returned my anger with a smile, in which they were saying "what's the big deal?"

It's just horn." I feel like I haven't touched upon the topic I'd like to write about today, which is "why I love." Shame on me. Perhaps I'll do it tomorrow.

DAY 7

Why I (Give Up) Love: Part 2

Mon, 30 Jun 2025 00:00:00 +0000



EXCESSIVE EXERCISING IN THE PAST few days really got me tired. I couldn't get up at 6am like I used to. This morning, for instance, I was kept in bed by the fatigue from yesterday until 10am. However, that wasn't a problem, as I never liked to go out anyway. I always find comfort in staying in, and staying at home. Yes, I am a stay-at-home person, which is, quite surprisingly to me, something that not many people could picture me being.

At home, I could write (the only thing that seems to be important to me now); I could perhaps watch television (my favorite TV shows now are whatever on NHK World Channel which I happen to be lucky to have at home); I also could listen to my music and Podcasts, and, I, of course, play my ukulele or guitar. Moreover, I could take a nap (which is good for you by the way) whenever I want.

I love to bike, but at the end of the day, I'd like to come back home and have my cold glass of beer and/or a warm cup of multiple kinds of loose tea leaves that I got from many places around the planet earth. Love is not complicated. It's actually pretty simple. We have made it a complicated thing for one reason -- we tend to think that love is about possession. It's not; it never was; and it shall never sink that low.

This form of possession, in fact, makes people feel suspicious about people around them.

For instance, a question such as "are you busy today?" can simply mean "are you busy today" as a polite form of greeting -- a descriptive statement -- rather than "are you busy today, if not I'd like to take you out, and hit on you." So, the answer I often got were, "I have a boyfriend," or "I love my boyfriend," or "sorry, I didn't hear what you said because I was just busy with my boyfriend," and so on. My response was usually, "your boyfriend?"

-- did I ask you that?" simply because I didn't expect to hear about him in the context of our conversation. Suddenly, these people wanted to show not only their ability to possess, but also their ability to speak out loud about their possessiveness which they would like to stupidly use as a protective mechanism. All I can say is that I pity them.

I can't remember how many people whom I have met -- and thought we could be friends -- whose names, faces, and lives I had to remove completely from my memory because of how they answered my "are you busy today" question. In fact, the worst is that these people are feeling proud to be possessed, owned, as objects of men whom they call boyfriends because they falsely believe that loves will last, and that they will get to call them boyfriends for life.

What's the difference between a friend and a boyfriend? Perhaps, friends don't touch each other genitals -- perhaps? But the relationship as such is completely fragile and vulnerable because there is nothing that ties them together legally, religiously, or politically.

Perhaps, they're tied together financially, and, probably in most case, by their insatiable need to gluttonously engage in coitus, which, in this sense, it sounds pretty good to have a stable partner from whom you could always ask for sex without having to pay, or to be worried about how the society think about them. I would respect it if someone tell me that she has a husband, since the husband and wife bond is both legal, political, and committal.

That information, in fact, will allow me to draw the line between her and me, in the way that would benefit both of us. But, a boyfriend? isn't this, simply, absurd?

The irony here is that these people (who love to go think of themselves as possessing someone else and reciprocally being owned) pride themselves on their traditional moral ethics (usually of purity), and suddenly simply by calling some one "a boyfriend," they could simply have sex as much as they please without having to worried about either the consequences of their action, or the moral duty that they have toward their own bodies, toward their communities, parents, and social circles who might be worried about them for not being careful regarding this rather physically dangerous matter.

Seriously. Don't you think it's awkward to think that when I say something as simple as "are you busy today" I would mean more than its literal meaning -- simply because I am a man who may have the capacity to seduce you? I find this form of possessiveness repulsive, and I find these kinds of people pitiful and not worth having a life. I have given up love because I had been through so many failed attempts to genuinely love someone.

I had dreamed of one of those platonic loves purely based on the mutual and intellectual respect that each has for the other, and not on possession. I was reading Kant on his take on sex the other day. For Kant, it's immoral to have sex if the two people have not gotten married. I am quoting Michael Sandel from his best-selling book Justice here: Casual sex is objectionable, he thinks, because it is all about the satisfaction of sexual desire, not about respect for the humanity of one's partner.

That is, the prerequisite of sex here is marriage, which is a commitment that the act of sexual intercourse from then on will be exclusive to only these two committed people.

So, for Kant, coitus that is not performed in the name of commitment to procreate, approved by law, is immoral because it lacks the kind of commitment that affirms the essence of a moral human being who wouldn't

be treating each other as if he/she is "a means to an end" -- and that end is the satisfaction of sexual desire. Fine.

I want to agree with Kant so much here, but I could not because he did not say much (or anything at all) about how and why he believed that the institution of marriage is moral, and not about abusive control of women because, often if not always, the institution of marriage appears to undermine true love.

My personal dilemma with this issue was when I faced the question of what to do when I had to choose between 1) getting married in the name of love (but for no reason because no one has provided me with a convincing reason yet); and 2) loving someone for the reason that love "was the reason." I feel that treating love as a reason to be with someone, and therefore let the expression of love, whatever it may be, lead to the desire to express love in the present seems "way more Kantian" than treating marriage as an institution that conveniently provides a moral platform to express love.

This is another reason why I hate tradition. Many people I know -- including the ones that are considered very smart by the standard of the world we're living in -- allows tradition to keep them under the self-imposed sense of immaturity. They never asked why they did what they did when it's about marriage, and they just did it because "it seemed right to do so." I don't think marriage makes any sense as long as getting divorce is an option, but that's just me.

I also think that if two people want to be together, 1) why do the two people need to inform others that they are doing in "legally", and 2) why do they need to feel that they possess each other. I think true love is not about possession. It never was and it should never be about possession.

True love might not have to be absolutely platonic or romantically existentialist as in the case of open marriage between Simone de Beauvoir and Jean-Paul Sartre (although I must admit that which would be the kind of love with which I would like to associate myself), but it at least has to be

based on the mutual interest in the well-being of one another.

In my life, I have seen so many people who were great friends to one another became deep enemies afterwards because of the failed marriage, and guess what, often the root of their problems was over-possessiveness. If I'd ever like to possess something of someone I love, that would be her love to not wanting to possess me and vice versa. The only kind of marriage that will last is the union of two people who respect one another.

There are so many marriages that last because the two people in it don't want to get out of it because they couldn't think of life otherwise. That's not what I would like to think as a marriage, but a chain that tie both of them to the pretentiousness that there is such happiness in their non-mutual relationship. Sex is often seen as a way of possession your loved one. In a Kantian view, that kind of sex isn't bad because possessiveness is moral.

Just to be clear, true love -- or the only kind of love that works and will last -- should be intellectual, mutual, and non-possessive. When love become stupid, one-sided, and possessive, it's time to let it go, and that's why I did. Everything, however, has a caveat. Tonight, I got to know a new friend who shared with me his life history. This, by the way, happened in my waking life.

This new friend of mine told me that he got married to his primary school sweetheart, with whom he got to know when she was 12, which was the same age as he was then. He told me that they didn't date until the very last year of their high school, which was the time when they were both 18. Now, they're "happily married" with three kids: two two boys and a daughter.

We were at the dinner table when this topic was brought up, and, of course, the question for me was "What about you?" Although I replied with confidence that I was single, a part of me felt sick to my stomach. What's it that made me sick that way? Me -- a man who has been writing about how he cherishes the platonic non-possessive love between Simone de Beauvoir and Jean-Paul Sartre? Could it be the case that I was jealous of this new friend's happy marriage? Perhaps.

I still could not tell. I always critique the convention, and always want to prove that I have much better solutions for the society, by living my life in the way that I believe to be demonstrative of those solutions.

For instance, when it comes to love, I'd like to live a life of a "non-possessive lover," who believes that he shall only love a woman because of her ability to think, and not her ability to make herself pretty, and such form of love from a non-possessive lover should not chain to her last name, or my dignity because the last thing I would do to a woman is to objectify her as if she is not a human being. That's how I see possessive love.

That said, when it comes to the very basic thing in life, such as the matter of having someone who is going to be your companion for life, and, more important than anything else, "love you unconditionally," I just don't know how to respond. On the one hand, of course, I want everyone I love to love me unconditionally. On the other hand, I know that ain't possible. But deep down, and deep down, I also want to be loved.

Not just to be loved, I also want to be loved "unconditionally," and it would be nice to have someone who feels that way about me. And often that only happens when two people are bonded by a legal (and sometimes religious) means such as marriage. I know that my mother (and also my father when he was still alive) would give me that -- the unconditional love -- but even that, I still want to be loved by another woman, who doesn't want anything from me except my love.

I love my mother, but, as we know, our love for our mothers is different from the love we would have for someone who is in the same generation as ours. I might appear to many as a "strong liberal man" who is critical about the convention of the society as though I don't give a damn about it, but at the end of the day, I also want to be loved. I want to replicate the kind of love that Simone de Beauvoir had for Jean-Paul Sartre.

I don't want to be possessed, but I want to be loved -- unconditionally.

[soundcloud url="https://api.soundcloud.com/tracks/224744275" params="auto_play=false&hide_related=false&show_comments=true&show_user=true&show_reposts=false&visual=true" width="100%" height="450" iframe="true" /] post Day 8: On the Nature of Question Tue, 01 Jul 2025 00:00:00 +0000 What struck me today was a poll related to a recent news in South China Morning Post, as well as various news sources, about the possibility that pilots of one of the world's best airlines Cathay Pacific (CP) might have been overworked by the airlines, which may lead to very scenario of possible "seriously risky situations" once airborne. Actually this information came directly from the pilots themselves.

It's a group of pilots that publicly complained about their welfare. What I thought was funny was not the news itself, but the fact that almost immediately after the news was broadcast to the public, the same newspaper managed to conduct a quick survey on with the question, "Do you think Cathay Pacific pilots are overworked?" Soon enough, the result came in.

For people like us who may have relied -- consciously or unconsciously -- on public opinion before making decisions on various matters, the expected results on a yes-or-not question like this would, as the type of the question suggest, simply be "yes or no." Surprisingly, it turned out that half of the surveyors simply responded "I don't know." Suddenly, I came to realize how absurd this question was.

It may appear quite rigid: as a poll conducted by a top newspaper, with a larger enough samples and a rigorous sample size determination (the more random the better in this case), and with a rather convincing pie chart to show the distribution of the answers through a rather beautiful graphic means. Yet, the problem lies in the very nature of this question, which has an scarily enormous implication about other problems we have in the world.

The nature of this question alone leads to the complete uselessness of the result, and the logic here is simple: How would ordinary people on the street or on the internet know whether airline pilots -- one of the most professionally secretive jobs in the world -- are overworked or not? How

much do we know about the nature of their jobs, i.e., how many hours are appropriate for them to work, let alone whether or not they are overworked?

Even if we have a slight gist, in the general sense, of such information, how would we know that what we could apply what we know to the specificity of this case, namely the operation of this particular airline? There's so much that we don't know in this scenario. So, first and foremost, there was no point in asking the public this question. Second, making a poll out of the answers they received is simply absurd.

Finally -- and the scariest part -- how many time we take this kind of information that this poll presents you with as views prevalent among the general public, the facts, or even the truth? This actually makes me scared a bit. There're so many instances that I simply took whatever I heard, especially if they seemed to have some kinds of statistical evidence to back up their claims, at face value.

Say, "Donald Trump is winning," or "Most people agree with this XXX policy on this YYY country, according to the poll conducted by ZZZ -- one of the world's most trusted sources of independent survey research," and so on. This specific question on statistics reminds me of a rather famous quote (some attribute it to Mark Twain): "there are three kinds of lies in the world: lies, damned lies and statistics. The goal for writing this blog is simple.

I'd like to remind myself and everyone reading this blog to always read carefully the question, with the goal of analyzing its very question.

Don't easily believe anything you hear, especially when there's a claim attached to it that it's "backed by statistics." In addition to the basic technical questions about the statistics itself (e.g., sample size determination), ask the three following, what I'd like to call, "qualifying questions": Is this question the kind of question to which the informants are capable to gathering enough information or knowledge to inform their answers?

Is the "very nature" of the question points to the "very problem" that the incident leading to the question itself seeks to answer? If this question

happens to have the quality that fulfills these two qualifying questions, then ask the third question: would understanding how the majority respond to this question leads to how the problem might be solved for the better of the society as a whole?

The give the newspaper (which I actually love) the benefit of the doubt, perhaps the problem here was not that whoever decided to conduct the poll did not know what he or she was doing, but, simply, that they did not know how to frame the question in a way that would make sense.

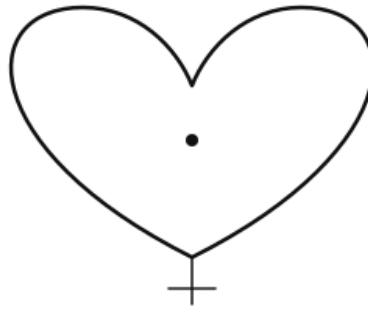
What the poll wanted to know wasn't "whether or not Cathay Pacific pilots are overworked?" but "whether or not knowing that they may be overworked has an affect on how they might perceive traveling with the airline." So, for a question concerning this particular incident to make sense, what South China Morning Post has to do is simply to tweak the question to reflect that particular angle that people like us, i.e., non-specialist on flying, pedestrians, and ordinary internet users, could comprehend.

For instance, we can simply look at the issue from the point of view of the consumer, such as "Does recent news about how CP pilots may have been exhausted from too much work affect your trust on the operation of the airline?"

DAY 9

Three Years In Shanghai

Wed, 02 Jul 2025 00:00:00 +0000



THE MASTER SAID: AT FIFTEEN I set my heart upon learning. At thirty, I had planted my feet firm upon the ground. At forty, I no longer suffered from perplexities. At fifty, I knew what were the biddings of Heaven. At sixty, I heard them with docile ear.

At seventy, I could follow the dictates of my own heart; for what I desired no longer overstepped the boundaries of right." Confucius, The Analects of Confucius I just recently read a post [How To Manage Your Love-hate Relationship With Shanghai](#) written by professional professional and executive coaching. The author's argument has to do with the fact that Shanghai is a great city, and therefore life in Shanghai is all about keeping expectation in check. You can have them all.

So balancing between the love (or hate) for your work, focusing on the aspects of the city that you enjoy despite their natural yet paradoxical co-existence with so many annoying things about the city (e.g., crowded subways, unhygienic street-scape, among the 101 things that someone has come up with the list).

This post reminds me of what I always want to blog about: my three years in Shanghai -- and I want to do so with the linguistic precision and brevity that

Confucius did two thousand years ago in the epigraph above. When I first arrived in Shanghai in the summer of June 2013 (on the evening 21st first day of the month to be precise), I never thought that I'd be spending more than a year in Shanghai.

I knew that I always had a soft spot for the city, but having been to Shanghai almost every year for almost a decade I knew how expensive the city could be and I did not think that I could live comfortably in Shanghai with a rather modest student budget that I had (since I didn't get any scholarships or fellowships to support my research at all).

Having spent a lot of time between 2006 - 2013 learning about Shanghai, I thought, and did in fact going around the world telling people that, I was a "Shanghai expert." What happened was that, during the first week of being a resident of the city, I couldn't even direct my good colleagues to a right bar! Wasn't being able to go to a right bar one of those basic skills that a good urbanist should have? Jane Jacobs would say so about that — so would I.

So, I was deeply embarrassed by such inability. Then, it got worse. I didn't realize that the city had changed so much over time, and that there were so many things that I thought I knew, such as places where I thought were perfect spots to eat, which turned out to be just so-so. There're so many areas that I thought my knowledge as an expat was adequate, but it was apparently not, and what happened afterwards was me constantly making a fool of myself.

Because many people thought of me as a "Shanghai expert," they came to me for advice, and no matter how much I tried to tell them to not listen to me so much they still wanted to listen to me and took my words seriously. So, yes, I had written a book and a number of important writings about Shanghai, and it's deeply embarrassed to learn during my first few months in the city that I did not know anything at all that would make my life in Shanghai meaningful.

Up to the present, it's been more than two years, and it seems to be the case that I have committed my third year to this city already. So, here we go: The

first year, because I let my self-imposed immaturity and arrogance lead the way. I constantly stumbled and felt. Was not helping was my deliberate refusing of helps from others -- because I thought I knew it all, already. I couldn't be more wrong. The second year, I began to understand how things worked around me.

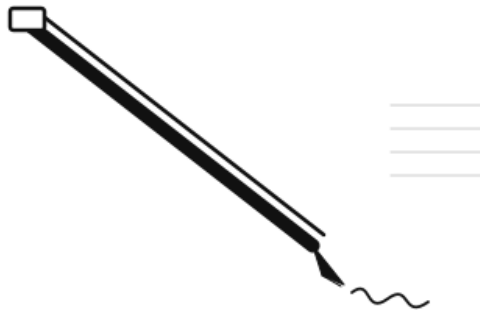
I semi-adopted a when-in-Rome attitude. While keeping my own sense of moral integrity at bay, I learned the rules from within, how to break them, and broke them without breaking apart the system at large. I still stumbled and felt, but I had friends to help me get up and running again. Third year, I am beginning to feel the current, and the cosmology of perceptions and sensible impressions around me.

While, I may more comfortable than ever, deep inside of me there's a deep sense of loneliness, which the urbanity of Shanghai has constantly bestows on me.

DAY 10

On Writing Fieldnotes

Thu, 03 Jul 2025 00:00:00 +0000



THE LAST THING I WANT to turn this blog into is a platform for me to complain about what I don't like about Shanghai, and sometimes, the world at large. The temptation is always high. For instance, I got home deadly tired today. I even slept on the bus on the way back because I had stood too long today, and the sleep I had last night was way less than adequate.

I was lucky that I didn't have my bike with me as I had no idea how I would have the energy to get on it to take it back home with me. When I set my goal to write this blog before I go to bed at night, I knew better than anyone else what were the kinds of things that got left in my brain after a long day of working, and especially writing.

While I'd like every single post to be like Roland Barthes' Writing Degree Zero, what seems to happen quite regularly is how I eventually turn it into a platform for personal social critic. Having the responsibility of delivering moral philosophy as a pedagogical subject neither help nor make it easier for me to think of this blog as a place to reflect in a positive manner neither.

I usually didn't go back to read what I wrote yesterday, or the day before, because I often wanted to focus on the present, and on what I would be

doing, rather on the past. Although one of the reasons why I had been "so damn good" at keeping field notes when I was doing fieldwork was precisely because I loved the idea of being able to go back to trace, revisit, and re-comprehend myself through what I had written, which was the best depository of my personal feelings.

By doing so, not only that I would get to revisit my own subjectivity, but also make a certain value judgement about how well I had been able to manage (or mismanage) my time when putting those slices of subjective descriptions and read them altogether. It's almost a pathological symptom that had no cure for me.

So, when I was in the field, which wasn't that long ago, my room would be the only room in the lane (and perhaps one of the very few in the neighborhoods) whose light was still on at 1am in the morning.

Since my room was up on the second floor facing the south side, it was easy to spot the light coming from my window especially when every other room's lights had already been turned off and the lane in which my place was located was pretty much pitch black already. And that small light was a little desk's lamp that I used to illuminate my small black notebooks that I had to look at in the darkness in order to decipher my own scribbles and sketches.

In the summer, I would be almost naked when writing field notes at night like that because it's so hot inside. I could have left the door open to let the breeze in, but I never liked to look at the dark, quiet, and rather haunted-looking staircase connected my room (which I would be right there by my door if it would be open outward to let the breeze in).

Growing up in Thailand in the 80s and 90s where and during which time various stories of ghost and evil spirit were almost like lullabies to get children to fear the unknown so that they would listen to their parents, I always have this deep fear for the explainable, especially ghosts.

I remember that I didn't even want to go to the bathroom at night alone when I was young, and, of course, many times I had to commit an act that

would lead my parents to have to clean up for me in the morning. I liked to sleep in the same room with someone, especially with my older brother and my mother, if they were around. I had this pathological fear of being alone in a room that was quiet and dark.

It's almost unimaginable then that for the last 15 years I have been renting a room to live alone. I sometimes still feel that I am not alone when I am actually alone (which often gets me the goosebumps like what I am having right now!). At the end of the day, the room that I rented to do my field research was at least, at the time, 80-year-old, so it's possible that someone may have died in the house or in the area surrounding it.

Long story short, even though I was not that afraid of ghost anymore, I couldn't imagine myself sleeping in the room that whose door not only was not locked, but also was opening to the darkness. True. I also feared of being robbed, hurt, and murdered. At the end of the day, the tenants were coming and going, and except the two old tenants whom I got to know well throughout the course of my field research there I did not know anyone else.

Social interaction there was limited by, I believe, the lack of trust among the new neighbors. Before it's dark in my room, I sometimes couldn't even make sense of the shorthand that I myself committed. I could have turned on the room's desk lamp, but I didn't do so because I felt that it would be more romantic to be typing under a small little lamp (in addition to the fact that I never really like fluorescent light from above anyway). Also, I would be drinking something while writing.

Mostly it's a glass of wine (thanks to a suggestion from one of my supervisors who once told me a tip regarding how a great writer like him composed and sometimes overcame his own writer's block!) I remember well how persistent I was in trying to write as much as I could, and everything I could. During the first few months, I didn't have internet there, so I would be writing without any distraction.

A small little radio that my friend helped me to buy online would keep me company only until a few minutes before midnight when the radio station that I always listened to then called it a day, and then the complete silence would take over.

post Day 11: Emotion is the Slave of Reason Fri, 04 Jul 2025 00:00:00 +0000 In the 18th century, the Scottish philosopher David Hume wrote that human reason is "the slave of the passions." If Hume had meant by "passions" what we mean by that word today, his observation wouldn't be worth noting. Obviously, when we're seized by intense feelings like lust or vengeance, our reasoning faculties are not running the show. But Hume meant "passions" in a different sense; he meant feelings, broadly speaking.

He was saying that, though rational thought plays an important role in human motivation, it is in a certain sense never really calling the shots. When we decide to do something, we decide on the basis of a feeling. Where did Hume get this idea? Apparently through introspection—carefully watching his mind at work. In a sense, Hume was being mindful before mindfulness was cool. Indeed, as Western philosophers go, Hume was pretty Eastern.

A number of his views align almost uncannily with Buddhist thought, including an argument he mounted against the existence of the self. Some scholars have suggested that this may be no coincidence, that he may have somehow encountered Buddhist ideas even though they had barely begun to drift westward from Asia. Certainly the idea that[...]" While sitting on the plane traveling from Shanghai to Bangkok, I had, quite surprisingly, a rather deep thought about how I had been seeing my life anymore.

"What if the plane goes down tonight?" For some reason, even though I always know that air travel is one of the safest modes of transportation, I always have this morbid thought in mind every time before the plane takes off (but strangely not when it's landing -- for some reason, I always find comfort in having such a thought (what could be so bad about dying, right?) although I also pray to survive.

If I get really tired when I am on that seat (which is usually the case because of my habit of getting a night flight after a long day of work so that I would get to wherever I want the next day and hit the ground running), I'd often say to myself, "it would be okay if I die today" -- and I would really mean it. This way of thinking is what some might call "thinking stoically."

"The stoics lived around the third century BCE, and their influence have been widespread across Europe. Modern thinkers such as the philosophers Massimo Pigliucci and William B. Irvine return to the thinking of the stoics with the true hope that it could be helpful in the modern era in which we, good people, are all fighting against the evil force of capitalism."

Let me share with you here my favorite quote from Professor Massimo Pigliucci's blog "How to be a Stoic": A crucial idea that the Stoics derived from their physics is that life ought to be lived "according to Nature...The first thing to get out of the way is the misconception that Stoicism is about suppressing one's emotions and going through life with a stiff upper lip. Rather, Stoics taught to transform emotions in order to achieve inner calm."

Emotions – of fear, or anger, or love, say – are instinctive human reactions to certain situations, and cannot be avoided. But the reflective mind can distance itself from the raw emotion and contemplate whether the emotion in question should (or should not) be given "assent," i.e., should be appropriated and cultivated. He then goes on to talk about the "dispreferred indifferences," such as wealth, health, and other goods.

They are indifferent "in the sense that they do not affect one's moral worth." This particular stance of the Stoic school of thoughts remind me of the writings of Laozi, Zhuangzi, and in particular Jean-Jacques Rousseau, especially his first Discourse on the Arts and Sciences, in which he lays out the entire cartography of how our morality is by no means moral simply because of the advancement in things that we do not need, and of course the Chinese thinkers such as Laozi, and especially Zhuangzi.

These thinkers, living in different eras and from different cultural backgrounds (maybe closer in the case of Laozi and Zhuangzi), surprisingly agree on the most important truth and fact that life as a human being needs: we don't need all that much to live a good life, whether or not we know what it means.

Buddha, a contemporary of Laozi, has laid out the entire map of life as such in a very profound way, and all begins with the same very important notion that "we don't, and will never, need that much; so why are we spending so much and working so hard to get those things that could only give us the short-term sense of appreciation (usually immediately when we have them) and then become useless afterwards simply because, after all, we don't need them." The artificial need, which according to Rousseau, is by-design -- as it is the strategy of the elites to keep the poor in check by creating artificial needs for them to keep craving for, so that they could work their asses off trying to get what they think they could get in perpetuity.

If we understand this, then we don't need to be slaves to these artificial desires -- that weren't ours at the first place anyway -- anymore.

The 18th century philosopher David Hume, whose idea the author Robert Wright writes about in his book *Why Buddhism is True* in the paragraphs that I quote in the epigraph of this post, however, did make it clear to us all in his *Treatises* that this won't be easy no matter how hard we try, or how easy we would like to make it look and sound to our receptive senses. Why?

Because, as he famous said, "reason is a slave to the passions." Backed by modern science, this discovery of the bifurcated relationship between the emotional and the rationalizing capacities of the mind is central to how we not only should but must think about the social relationships we have with other people.

Neuroscientists argue that the most important part of the brain that controls our emotion -- the pre-frontal cortex (also known as PFC) -- is also the most important part of how we live our lives because without the working capacity

of such part of the brain, we can't operate as social beings -- simply because the rationalizing capacity is the brain has a limited ability to only telling us "how to do things" as opposed to the initial thought of "what to do." The efforts of these modern stoics, such as Massimo Pigliucci, to relive the wisdom from thousands of years ago to help us understand the real causes and effects of our happiness is absolutely admirable, making me want to write another blog called "Thinking like Rousseau " (although I have a feeling that which is an unwritten subtitle of this blog anyway).

At the very center of the stoic philosophy is the idea that we are stronger than we think, and that if we are always prepared we will be able to encounter anything at all. Some of the stoics go so far even to, before going to bed at night, think about the worst case scenarios that could happen to their lives when they get up in the morning. As mentioned, if we're prepared for those bad things, even in our mind, we'll be likely to take them calmly and reasonably.

We will be less anxious and use less emotion to try to ease the pain caused by something that may only make sense in terms of reason. In other words, it's about turning the "hot emotion" into the "cold reason" -- because, at the end of the day, and make no mistake about it, emotion alone cannot solve anything.

In fact, I often let emotion take the steering wheel, and, I'd like to quote something that a friend (who is no longer my friend) once told me, "You are too emotional...you need to control it; good luck." The funny thing is that the moment I heard this friend of mine saying this, I got upset right away (haha).

Well, that's just a sign that I am an emotion person, and that my pre- frontal cortex is still working just fine:-) The question to be derived from this is, since when is being emotion a bad thing? Historically-speaking, human beings have been proud of their ability to be rational. In fact, to many thinkers, being able to conceive the world rationally is the only quality that distinguishes us from any other living creatures. So, for generations, we have been trying to keep our emotion in check.

Only until the late 18th century, beginning in Europe, that the opposite polar of idea began to emerge -- and this, precisely, was the idea that gave rise to an alternative way of thinking about emotion that later became the platform for artists, musicians, poets, to exercise their creativity. Machines, when being used at a grand scale, created fear among human beings who did not want to be replaced by the ability of the machinery to be more efficient, more optimal, and, needless to say, more rationale, than human beings.

The unexpected yet collective efforts by thinkers, artists, professors during the last two decades of the 18th century gave rise to the idea of Romanticism, or the idea that it's our emotion that made us human beings. For the Romantics, the question began with, "are we happy being rational?" Not everyone was. And the same could probably be said for the "emotionalists" as well.

Rationality, the 17th century political philosopher Thomas Hobbes (who was also being credited for reinventing jogging as a form of exercising) would say, was the only thing that keeps us from killing one another in the state of nature where presumably everyone is living for himself or herself with no collective goal. That said, as Rousseau would disagree by saying something like, "in the state of nature, we don't need the same kind of rationality we would be needing to live in an industrial society." There's rationality in being emotional.

Rousseau then would explain and place an emphasis on the reason why he thinks human beings are better off living in the state of nature: because we are morally adaptable to social interactions, but only when there are not too much superficial impulses from outside. Emotion, in his sense, safeguards our souls from being brutally governed by our own selfishness -- the kind of selfishness that is recursive only in advance societies.

Artists, musicians, and designers like to exercise their emotionality rather than rationality because it's the only source of their creative ideas that work -- because emotion is the steering wheel. I think Hume was right about that. So, being emotional to say, among other things, is a good thing, as it means

that you're being human -- being rational insofar as your interest in the well-being of others is what driving you to live a good life.

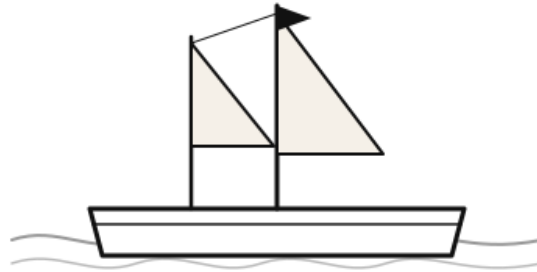
That said, the only instance that emotion could solve any problems is when the other person engaging in the problems at hand use reason to deal with it.

In fact, I read from somewhere that even modern science has a research that supports this stoic claim that thinking about the problems that have yet to reach you is not a total waste of time, but in a way, making you prepared for what might happen and what you might have to deal with, which, also in a way, is giving your life a little bit of strategies to make it worth living.

DAY 12

Emotion Versus Reason (Continued)

Sat, 05 Jul 2025 00:00:00 +0000



IT WAS A GOOD FEELING beyond my capacity to explain it in words to wake up on my bed at home here in Bangkok. The weather was far from perfect, I must admit. That said, home's always home, and there is a good reason for most people to "feel at home" when they are at home. I was tired from traveling on the jet plane, but was still able to get out of my bed before noon, which was partly because it was too hot to still be lying down.

I did manage to proceed to get every item of my morning rituals checked, except getting on my bike and ride it to work since I did not bring it with me to Bangkok (and given how hot the weather is and how dangerous Bangkok's streets are, I might have been one of my best ideas in a long time). Coffee was an important ritual, which I managed to do right after I got up.

I did try to stay away from checking my emails and texts during the first half and hour after my ears had been exposed to sunlight in order to avoid the bluelight from the screens of my electronic devices, and eventually gave in before I was really curious to know what the constant blinking light on my phone entailed.

One piece of good news concerned the fact that an interview I did with a local magazine a few months ago just came out, which I believe to the best

account of my personal history to date. Written in English, this six-page interview was written by a colleague who patiently spent three hours interviewing me, after hours of doing research on my previous and current work, for this article. This colleague of my Ms. Rhine Lu awesomely compose this piece.

My Chinese is still not good to enough to appreciate its high level of literary craft, but every Chinese person I knew who has read the interview said it is pretty amazing. So, I'd like to thank Rhine for doing this. At some point, I'll have it translated into English.

While I don't think my life is that interesting, there're some stories worth sharing about how a rural boy from an undeveloped part of a developing country in Southeast Asia has become who he is today, without much help from my parents, and why I hate pretentious people so much. One part that I remember telling Rhine during the interview was how I did not have many friends during my years in a technical school in where I studied architectural design in Thailand.

Because I found myself comfortable in a liberalism of American culture when I was there for high school, when having to return to Thailand to continue my study in a technical college because my family could no longer, in the midst of Asian economic crisis, support me to stay abroad, I found myself in a very difficult situation having to blend into the hyper conservatism of Thai culture.

I didn't have many friends -- in fact I could only remember two friends I had throughout those years in a technical school full of either children of highly traditionalistic working-class, or rich conservative families. I did try very hard to blend in, but the more I tried the most I distanced myself from them. I couldn't do things simply because it's what other people, or we all, did.

As always, I needed the people (mostly my classmates) who wanted me to do things with them a good reason why I should do things with them. I simply refused to do things with them if I couldn't get a good reason from them, and

often I gave them the benefit of the doubt so I only demanded just one good reason, not two or three. I never received any thing that satisfied even my minimum requirement.

I later found out that it was because they themselves also did not know why they did what they would like me to do with them. As for them, "because other people were also doing it" was a good enough answer for them to be convinced that they should also be doing it.

These classmates smoked, drank, and got into fights excessively throughout the years that I was their distant classmate "who never wanted to do things with them." These classmates did not like me, no matter how hard I tried. Eventually, I gave up, and spent most of my time in both the school's and department's libraries. Because our technical school had a long history, these two libraries were the most resourceful libraries for architecture, art, and urban studies books in the country.

Because I didn't have any friends, I spent 6-8 hours/day regularly in these two libraries simply reading every single book on which I could possibly get my hands. So, during those years, not only did my English reading skill was pretty much forced to improve (through the process of forced familiarization that I intentionally gave myself) but my learned ability to think even more critical rose very quickly.

By the time I graduated, I had read everything all canonical texts on Western art and architecture, which happened to be the same texts that my future mentors and colleagues at the Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT) held dear. This may explain why I was accepted to their graduate program with an extremely generous admission scholarship on top of the Fulbright Grant which I had already been awarded to go to MIT.

Although I try to be reasonable whenever I can, my close colleagues and friends seem to think of me more as an emotional rather than a rational person. I am a passionate being, who tries to make everything counts. So, whenever I decide to do something, I put all my heart and soul into it.

I want to get to the very core idea of things, and I do not see the point of stopping half way, or simply trying out with no real sense of integrity and sincerity in wanting to get to the bottom of it. So, when I am "in the zone," I let my emotion take the steering wheel, while reason are riding shotgun. Again, I couldn't agree more with Hume that we shouldn't see passion as an enemy. Passion is what enables us to operate as a human being.

I wouldn't be one without it. When my friend I mentioned in the last post (who is no longer a friend) told me that I should try to be less emotion, I couldn't help but to conceive immediately two thinking points, both in the question form, in my head. First, would my life be different from what it is right now had I been using my reason more than my emotion? The answer is there's no way I could know for sure that which would be the case.

It's true that I often regret things that I did without having thought it through first, and one of them, needless to say, will haunt me for the rest of my life because it got my father very worried and may have cost him his life.

I always think of that scene from the last season of Mad Men when Don Draper saw a plane flying by from his window when he was about to present an idea for a project about which he didn't feel that good, and then decided that enough's enough and then just left the room. I had done many of those things like that in the past.

So, yes, maybe I can't know it for sure, but I have a feeling that had I been more reasonable when I was younger, I would have had a much longer time with my father, as I wholeheartedly believe that he would have lived longer, and would have been much more happier. I was young, but there's only so much I could blame on my immaturity.

Second, if my life today is life driven by passion, what is my feeling toward my life in and of the present, say, right now while I am typing this? This I can know for sure that I am content with my life at the moment. So, although my life could have been better had I been different, I don't think my life in the present is that bad and/or regretful neither. For the above interview, the

PDF version of it could be downloaded by clicking [here](#).

post Day 13: Living Stoically Sun, 06 Jul 2025 00:00:00 +0000 Last night, while enjoying a cup of my own cold brewed coffee (and a spoon full of Bailey's Original), I had a great moment all to myself to reflect on the last few years of my life, and the result of which was the last post in which I described my rough intellectual path of becoming who I am in the present. I have come to the conclusion that I have always been a stoic.

Stoicism is an ancient philosophy that places great emphasis on how to live a moral life, by being indifferent to the a changes of circumstances or of fortune, and to do so we must be unconcerned with the temporal forms of pleasure and pain. The first time that I heard of it, I thought that this way of thinking sound as though it could have come from Buddha's teaching. The only pleasure that matters is the pleasure that is everlasting, but who on earth could possibly achieve that?

Any forms of pleasure may raise our level of happiness for a while -- think of the time when we open a box of present, when we receive an award or an accolade, when we get paid, when we get a new iPhone, and especially when we have sex, etc. Once the excitement of being happy for a while, however, dies down, then we have no where else to go but to return to the state of being normal again. Take sex for example.

Once it's over, despite the frame of passion that had been burning from the moment you see the one you'd like to be so deeply intimate with, you would rather want to rest, to sleep, and to be with yourself rather than to engage, again, in the intercourse. You know that you'll be happy again, although for a short period of time, but you'd still rather sleep because that's what you need. You can't be in the state of permanent orgasm.

That's just not what we human beings are made to achieve. That is to say, once we've reached the peak, we have to land onto the normal level. Some, unfortunately, even sink down beyond that level of the normal to the level of being sad because he or she expects that the happiness would somehow last

longer, and when it does not, nothing but the feeling of sorrow would greet him or her at the front door.

In other words, knowing that no happiness is permanent, and that the more we go out of our way to try to replace one happiness with another in order to keep happiness coming in perpetuity, Buddha suggests that we will be in, instead, in the permanent state of being unfulfilled. The only way to achieve the permanence of flourishing life, is to keep take our mind away from being obsessed with the notion of happiness. It's overrated anyway.

According to a recent research done by the University of Wisconsin's social psychologist, Happiness research, a field known as "positive psychology," is exploding. Some of the newest evidence suggests that people who focus on living with a sense of purpose as they age are more likely to remain cognitively intact, have better mental health and even live longer than people who focus on achieving feelings of happiness. The problem of thinking that "I must be happy to have a good life" begins with the notion of happiness itself.

Why is it so important to be happy? Who said so? Why can't just being okay be good enough? What does it mean to be happy? What are the levels of happiness? Is happiness universal, meaning that what makes me happy must also make you happy as well? Because there're so many answers to these questions, and therefore it's impossible to pin down, linguistically and cognitively, the meaning of the word.

That is to say, we often get confused when we ourselves think about the idea of happiness, and that is, make no mistake, the cause frustration.

When people ask you, "how are you today?" Make sure that you do know that you are not obligated to say "good." Or, if someone say something like "you must be so happy" on your birthday, also make sure that you also know that you are not obligated to say "yes." According to Buddha, we must try to do away with the temporally happiness, because they're doing more harm than good for the said reason.

Stoic thinkers living among the great thinkers in the Athenian Empire two thousand of years ago knew about this; hence, they had made us aware of this particular fact of life as the single most important fact of life. Happiness will go away, so every time we think we are really happy, the Stoics would say, try to come up with a scenario that would make you forget such happiness as soon as possible.

It's like when you are trying to make an argument (and this is an argument that this thing that is happening right now is making me happy) to convince someone (in this case, you), you always need a good counter-argument simply to say that "I have thought of the other way of looking at the situation as well" before anyone else can (and in this case, that anyone else is the skeptical you).

With a good argument (thesis) and a good counter-argument (anti-thesis), you could derive, in a Hegelian sense, at what the man Georg Wilhelm Friedrich Hegel would call a "synthesis." So, when something good happens, think about the bad thing that could follow, and then you'll arrive at the state of indifference -- the state of, say, "I'll be okay whether what will happen." This is the most important and the true quality of a, broadly defined, "happy" person, because this kind of person would be prepared to face any kinds of problems or situation.

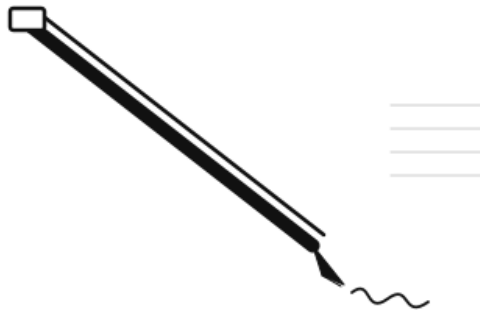
He or she will not freak out (or freak out too much) if something unexpected happens simply because that he or she is expecting it, and the quality of being able to think clearly without the influence of emotion as a result of facing something unexpected, is often what get you through the problem. I guess that's how I have been thinking about my life and its meaning.

I want to be a good stoic, who lives a moderate life, for today, and for the community and not just for myself.

DAY 14

We're Weirder Than We Think

Mon, 07 Jul 2025 00:00:00 +0000



IT IS CLEAR TO ME that being a passionately mad man is more reasonable than being a boring man of rationality. In short, I'd rather let my passion drive me to hell, than get a free ride to heaven from reason. I'd like to continue to reflect on the last few years of my life. I have no idea how long this thread is going to last. I truly hope that it will continue as long as I need to help myself to get on the right track.

The idea idea I was reading a book written by a famous writer and spiritual coach Osho on the notion of stability. He writes: There's no such thing as complete state of stability. The moment you feel stable is when you are dead. All things that make life worth living all comes from destabilizing experience. The truth is, as explorers (of your own mind as well of the external world), we will never arrive the state of stability as long as we are breathing.

Unless you're not an explorer, than you don't need to worry about anything because you are already dead. If we shall seek stability, then we shall also seek death since death is the only stable state of human beings. But seriously, do you really want to live in the world where everything is so stable? No surprise. No excitement. No nothing undetectable? Every day the same patterns repeat themselves?

(all of these questions would eventually lead me to write about Jean-Paul Sartre at one point in this post I have a feeling). We're living in the world shaped by the constant forces, whether that be natural phenomenon, or the projections of our own mind onto a mental plain created by our impressions of natural phenomenon that make us feel as if we are being destabilized from within.

The funny thing was last time I checked my Facebook (which was about, umm...yesterday) I realized that most of my former classmates (and professors) from the technical school to which I had gone have been married and having their nuclear families for years (even those who seemed socially awkward whom I thought may not be able to find anyone to be with let alone the right one). Even former classmates (and professors) from the technical school were able to find, I suppose, the love of their life.

I am not sure whether or not they think of me as a weirdo (which is probably fine since as Jean-Paul Sartre used to say "we're weirder than we think") who is still in school and finding my own life's path (if they think of me at all since I didn't have a lot of friends back then).

In fact, one of my good friends who came to my father's funeral five years ago said to me, "Non, your life must be really suck: no friends, no money, and no career, and now that your father has just passed away. I have nothing to say, but I would hate to be you." I remember what this friend of mine said really well because I was actually quite surprised to hear that.

At that moment, I wasn't sure whether I was surprised because she said something that I never thought about (seriously, I never thought about that before) or because she said something that was so true that I had no idea how to comprehend it. At the end, I think it's a little bit of both. It seems as if, in order to have stable life, everything must fall into places. I am going to assimilate Jean-Paul Sartre's way of seeing through the superficial world as such.

Life is a lot odder than we think (going to the office, having dinner with a friend, visiting our parents – none of this is obvious or remotely normal), but it's also as a consequence far richer in possibilities. It seems as if there's only one path to make life a fulfilling one, and it's all begin with a proper sexual conduct. That is, to them, one cannot simply want to engage in casual sex for life, but need to fulfill one's sexual needs properly, ideally in the following order.

First, one must find a partner with whom one would like to engage in an intimate activity. Second, one needs to convince that partner to be with one for life, and in order to make that happen a set of ritual propriety would have to be put in place to make sure that such pronouncement (and announcement to the community of both) is loud and clear.

In order to be a family, third, one must let such intimate activity lead to conception; and, forth, lo and behold, one must let an infant human being be born. But why? Really. My skepticism creeps throughout the entire process. Just because we have sexual genitals, why entails us to have use them in the way that lead to conception? Why is sex inside the domain of marriage more proper than casual sex?

Above everything else, what right do we have to give birth to someone else when we don't even know what life is? As John Locke once said in the *Second Treatise of Civil Government* John Locke (1690), children owe nothing to their parents because the parents never ask them first whether they would like to be born into the world. Following Locke's logic, it's the parents who owe their children everything, including the elementary protection and the responsibility for raising them and giving them proper education, food, and so on.

I wholeheartedly do not see why I should feel the urge to get married in order to have children.

I might get married because I believe in the morality of telling someone that you would like to commit to that person for as long as you are still breathing,

but I simply do not believe that just because nature give both of us a penis and a vagina we must use them to conceive a person into this chaotic world, especially when I still do not know what it is all about.

Sure, I could rely on the children to help me think about the meaning of it all, but is it fair? What if my children do not want to know the meaning of it all and think that being born in the world is the most senseless possible thing like I do? That is, just because we have these sexual genitals, again, does it mean that we need to get married, give birth, raise a child, and expect the child to take care of us when we grow up?

What happen if the child doesn't want to take care of us once we are old? To others, the way I live my life, and the way I think about it, might sound weird: I have no plan to get married; I have no set career path on which to move on life; I have no plan to buy an asset; I have no interest in buying anything expensive to show off my success; I have no interest in thinking about distant future.

All I want to do is to focus on the present. I want to cherish the moment that I have in the present.

post Day 15: All About Nana Tue, 08 Jul 2025 00:00:00 +0000 Nana is the love of my life. I knew that since the first time I saw her in Shanghai in the summer of 2011. She was much younger than I: she's very bright, shiny, and happy. I knew that she was the one since I first saw her, and that feeling has never changed.

Five years have past, and the only thing I regret about our short encounter is that I never get to tell her how much I love her. Brutality wasn't strong enough a word to describe that summer in Shanghai. Being hot and humid was one, and the enormous amount of people fighting for their places to stand and for the air to breathe was the other.

But for me, what made that summer unbearable from day one was the extreme anxiety caused by an unexpected encounter with a girl who looked strange, yet familiar. Her soft-spoken English with a thick flirty Spanish

accent was cunning. Must have gotten many men fall in love was her flirty eyes. Nana was her name, a beautiful 22-year-old Chinese girl with many Western features. If I shall say something to describe her, it would be the abstract quality combining cosmopolitanism, the feeling of liberation, and her absolutely gorgeous oriental beauty.

When the Japanese master novelist Junichiro Tanizaki wrote *Naomi* (1947), a story of a doomed love life between a young man named Jji Kawai, and a 15-year-old innocent and naïve waitress whom he met in a cafe -- whose name is Naomi -- he was simply telling a story of an unexplainable subconscious. Jji falls in love with Naomi because of everything she externally possesses: her Western facial features, her youth, her seductive femininity, and her mystical personality.

Jji, who in the end would lose everything because of her, has to be deprived of everything to realize that he and his deviant "bad faith" in the girl half his age are in fact the root of his own downfall. Born almost eight years after me, Nana to me was exactly like Naomi to Jji. She represented the fresh breeze of innocence as well as the tantalizing sensory faculty of juvenile sensuality: She's Naomi to my unconscious Jji.

I must admit that I wasn't sure whether I was attracted to her by her youth, or by her personality.

If it's the former, then Nana was also my imaginary Lolita to my perverse Humbert Humbert, the fictitious male protagonist in *Lolita*, a novel by Vladimir Nabokov, whose sickly sexual appetite and an insatiable thirst for the body and the soul of 12-year-old Lolita make his name a substitute for the adjective "pedophile." Seeing Nana in her summer tank-top-styled dress knitted together to her short skirt revealing her lightly freckled skin around her arms and her thighs, I felt as though she was created by the true divine power just for one reason -- aesthetics --and that's a strange feeling because I was hardly a religious person.

I never quite got it why I could like someone so much without having met her before. Well, according to Sigmund Freud, " the finding of an object is, in fact, a re-finding of it. " What he means by that is that when we discover something we really really love, the feeling of happiness as a result of such discovery is nothing but the response to the finding of something that we may once have fantasized about.

Rooted in the desire for sex (of course it's Freud), this theory may only explain the gist of the meaning of what we are searching for, as well as why we do so. In this sense, if we're to go along with this Freudian theory, the reason why I like her so much must have been because at one point in time when I was young I must have met someone who looked like Nana before.

It could have been my teacher in the kindergarten, or it could have been a waitress in a restaurant that I only visited once in my life. It could be anyone. That is, there's a true limit to freedom, and therefore free will.

I may have thought that my feeling for Nana was intrinsic, which was why it was hard to explain, but it could be as simple as the fact that she happened to look like someone I couldn't possibly possess in the past -- because I was too young, too economically dependent, too inferior in my social status, and so on. This could also be someone that I couldn't possibly possess because she was a member of my family.

Freud, in particular, places an enormous emphasis on our mechanism of self-suppression, namely cultural convention, in not wanting to talk about it, even to mention it, and of course not to do it. Therefore, I may have misunderstood my feeling, which was, perhaps, not love. It was just a reaction to the reappearance of a lost object of desire. Nana may happen to be at the right place and at the right time, and that was it. This is precisely why Freud believes that civilization is bad for us.

Had it not been because of civilization, I wouldn't have felt that I was too young when I met that someone who looked like Nana. And I wouldn't have felt that I was too economically dependent, since, at the end of the day,

economics is an invention of a civilized society, and, most important, I wouldn't have felt that my social status was too inferior, because there was no such thing as social hierarchy in the first place.

I would have come up to her and tell her how much I like her. I might get rejected and that would be the end of it, but it would be better than having to repress such desire because I didn't even have a chance to say to her what I wanted to say because of the self-imposed censorship brought about by the rules of social norms.

I felt as though she was smiling at me -- or maybe it was just me who thought she did during the first time we met when she happened to get on the same bus on which I was also. Sitting across the aisle from me, she put on her headphones as soon as she sat down. I wasn't sure whether she was in the mood for music or she did not want to invite any conversation with a stranger sitting across the aisle.

As she crossed her legs and sang silently along with the music she was listening to, her heart-penetrating dimple made me dream. Knowing that my heart would be beating fumblingly, I, still, could not resist looking across the aisle to see her every chance that I had. Troubling me then was the fact that I was already somehow in an acutely difficult relationship that was about to break apart. As a deeply troubled man, I deliberately asked my rational sense of self-control to take over my intuitive passion for her.

Be my excuses to not to speak to her was an aphorism "What's in it for me, a man much older than this young girl, for any whom he has no respect, including himself?" Nana was far too good for me. Growing in a conservative society that saw sex as sinful, I had to repress everything including my desire to have to want to have sex with her, which was quite natural to a heterosexual man who fell in love with a heterosexual woman.

I may not be wise enough, but I was experienced enough not to want to put myself in a situation that I knew would let me end up in a deep troublesome place. I knew better. I didn't have the quality of a man that would attract her.

I even thought to myself that I was just a boring man, who stuttered and often spoke in riddles because he had problems organizing words to say. Approaching my departure from Shanghai, we finally got a chance to speak.

I seldom did stupid random things like this one -- asking a phone number from a girl so much younger than me -- whatever the situation was and how I did it I couldn't quite recall I did get her number. As soon as I could pull myself together to believe that I got her number, I began texting her. Still, that was the best I could do because I simply didn't dare to speak to her.

Starting with "it's good to see you," I was texting her with the hope that she would at least read what I sent. I never expected her to reply, and she seldom did. I found out through a classmate in the Chinese class that three of us were in that Nana thought that I was weird.

"He texted me, saying very lame things, like 'it's good to see you,' or 'you look good today' -- what's wrong with him?" said Nana according to the classmate who spied on her on my behalf. Obviously, it never crossed her mind that I may be in love with her. I shouldn't, in fact, since we had never really talked to one another and she barely knew me. To be fair, I also barely knew her. I relied almost entirely on my gut feeling and my impression of her.

It's what the Danish philosopher Søren Kierkegaard would probably call a "leap of faith." She even revealed to my friend that she probably thought I was "a genuinely weird person," and that can't be a good thing. Eventually, we went out together for a quick dinner. I later found out (from the same classmate) that she eventually gave in because I was "persistent" and that she "didn't see how anything could go bad" by having a meal with another classmate.

I wanted to see her so much that I didn't even ask her where she would like to eat. It was also me who travelled to the neighbourhood close to where she lived. I guess I texted her at the right time: the time that she was hungry, bored, and alone. Although I was nervous, I felt much more comfortable than I thought I would be. I felt as though I could be myself.

We decided to eat at a small sushi bar near a metro stop right below the apartment that she rented for the summer so that she could study Chinese in Shanghai. There weren't many people in the restaurant, so it was rather quiet. We were able to engage in a very lively conversation on a verity of topics. Mainly, it was me asking her about her life because I was really interested in knowing more about her. I sincerely don't remember whether she ever asked anything about me.

Well, my impression of her was that she had no interest in me anyway, and I was just someone that happened to be texting her asking her whether she would like to eat when she was hungry. But that didn't matter at that time since I had no interest whatsoever in talking about myself. I just wanted to know everything I could in, possibly, the only chance that she would grant me an audience with her.

I, however, felt as though she appreciated who I was, how I was and was attentive to things I had to say. I, too, needless to say, was attentive to her. I felt as though I was dreaming. She smiled, and cried -- when she ate the sushi in which she underestimated the power of the green wasabi that she put on it. The more I learned about her through our short yet lively conversation, I more I couldn't stop thinking about her.

Perhaps, I wasn't that boring as I thought I was. More likely to be the case was the fact that Nana was also an absolutely wonderful person. Despite her awesome family background and cultural capital, she wasn't as lofty as I thought she was. In fact, she was not only down to earth, but also curious about many things and open to diverse opinions. Whenever I was with her, time flew. We went out again; this time on a rainy day.

I had no idea why she would ever want to go out with me again., but it happened. This time, if it was a lucid dream, it was the most lucid one. She didn't bring her so I brought mine over to pick her up from the metro stop. Under the same umbrella, we were close -- so close that I could scent her shower soap, and sensually aromatic shampoo that she used to gently rub her beautiful skin and long straight hair.

All my senses were completely conscious and alert. I never liked the rain so much before. I didn't want it to stop and I didn't want us to arrive at wherever we were walking (as I didn't care anymore). Under that umbrella with Nana, I felt as if I was truly myself with someone I truly loved and adored. The experience, to me, was transcendental. It's spiritual, and I couldn't ask for more. After that, we didn't really get to meet again.

Eventually, the last two days of my time in Shanghai had arrived. I asked her out, knowing it may be the last time we'd see each other. She could say no, and I was prepared. There was nothing to lose but my chains. This time, I didn't tell her that I thought of our outing as a date (after five hours of walking around town together).

I waited until the very last hour when we were together, almost holding hands but not quite, in a surprisingly quiet evening on the Bund. She blushed and smiled. This time her smile was intentional, but still, she was too shy to admit that we just had our first date.

I sent her off on the metro, and then before I realized it was 8 o'clock in the morning of the next day, I got her message on my phone, "I am ready; come pick me up and let's have a real and proper date:-)" Nana never told me whether or not she had a boyfriend -- either to serve as her guard to protect for being hit on, or to simply tell me that she was being wanted and therefore wasn't easy. I never met someone like her before.

Many women I met in my life loved to tell guys that they had boyfriends, bragging about how great they were despite the bitter lives that the boyfriends were giving them. Our feeling was mutual, and it was all romantic. "The magic of not expecting anything," I'd say. Our relationship reminded me of what Bill Murray and Scarlet Johansen had in *Lost in Translation*. We'd gotten to do so many things together.

Time was moving forward as usual, but I felt no urge to rush it, as I simply enjoyed the time that we spent together. Gradually, an imaginary relationship that I initially thought of as a non-romantic perverse type of

affairs was turning into something rather spiritual. We were deeply connected, yet not sexual; intimately curious, yet respectful; and full of desire yet enjoying the company of each other in every way. She was and still is, if she is even real, the love of my life. She was my Naomi.

She was my Lolita. There wasn't any expectation, and there wasn't anything that I wanted from her more than just that. As an ordinary man looking to have a love that will last, this was simply a dream. Here is the twist of the plot that you have been waiting for. Please don't hate me for saying this: I don't know whether Nana is real. I don't know where Nana is today.

In fact, since I have no records of her existing in my life; no photos, no messages, no emails, no anything, I don't even know whether Nana really existed. That's one possible theory. Nana never exists. I created her in my mind because I was so lonely, and that might be the reason why she looked a bit similar to someone I might have been in love with when I was young. Even her name "Nana," sort of has my name in it.

I may have created this name to be the name of the woman of my dream because I liked myself so much. And that might explain the story of how we eventually got to know each other which was, still today is, too good to be true. A girl of my dream who was ten years younger than me showed where I happened to be for a really short time? It does sound like a plot of a lame and predictable melodrama.

She could just be an illusion that I created for myself during the time of despair, similar to what happened to the genius mathematician in the film *Beautiful Mind*. But even if she was real, at least to me during that hot summer, it wouldn't change my life today. She came to my life and left without saying goodbye. Many things in life are similar to that, such as friends, family members, some phenomenon that you know you would really enjoy and so on.

Finally, if Nana is not my own illusion, she will turn 26 tomorrow -- November 2. Her birthday is one day after mine, which sort of makes her,

even more, an illusion. What are the chances that the birthday of the girl of my dream -- whose name is, by the way, sound similar to mine, is just one day after mine? Not only that, but she also spoke with a soft voice but a thick Spanish accent, which I really adored.

She also looked like my favourite actress Tang Wei. What are the chances that all of these qualities are qualities of one person that I happened to meet when I was studying away for a month? So that we could always celebrate our birthdays together every year? It's still too good to be true. At this point, I am game with the thinking that Nana might not be real, and she only exists in my imagination. That said, everybody needs a pad in the back, right?

The only right that nobody can take away from any of us is the right to our own imagination. I want to imagine that I could have had a great life with a woman of my dream, which didn't happen because my attachment to reality eventually overpowers my will to click on to the rosy-eyed imagination. No matter what happens, to me, Nana is real. She's real in my mind, and she is real in my heart. She might not be real in the reality of the world.

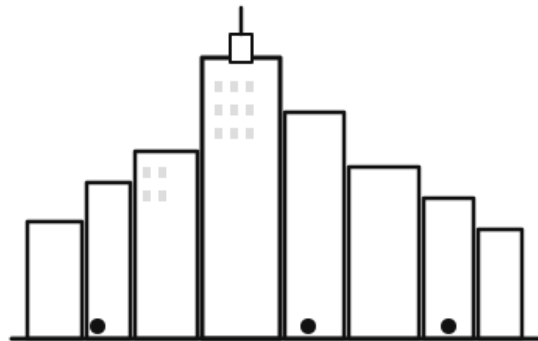
She might just be an illusion that only I can see, but her impact on how I see the world is nothing to be underestimated. If one day I become someone important in the society in which I live, it would be because of Nana -- it would be because I want to show to my imaginary woman of my dream that I can do good things. Whatever works, right? Beyond the realm of pragmatism here is my true commitment to my own belief in the love that will last.

No matter what other people might have to say -- and since I don't like myself so much that I would like to reproduce myself -- I think this imaginary relationship is more real than the corporeal one: no possession, no jealousy, no materiality. It's all about space and time.

DAY 16

On Being a Skeptic

Sat, 12 Jul 2025 00:00:00 +0000



TODAY MARKS THE TWO WEEKS benchmark of this blog, which is great, because the last time I wrote a blog I didn't get past even the first week benchmark. Today, I want to reflect on a comment about which I have been concerned lately: "You are having an identity crisis." This comment came as a surprise because I never thought, even for one second, that I was having a problem with my own ability to identify myself vis-a-vis the social context in which I live.

A mid-life crisis maybe, since it's getting harder and harder to visualize my life after my PhD in this economy, but I do know who I am and what I would like to do for the time that I have left in the world. I am thankful for the ability to read. It makes me realize that many great people in the past also share with me the notion of a good life, and how I live one.

I don't see citing others' philosophical ideas as plagiarism or evidence of not having my own sense of originality. So, I think what got my colleague to think that I am in the middle of my identity crisis is the fact that I constantly quote other people when I want to justify my action. But, does that mean that I no longer have my identity? Does that mean that I am compromising my true identity, and therefore authenticity, by simply copying other people ideas in order to live by?

Quite the opposite, I wholeheartedly believe that the only reason why we even go to school at all is to learn from the mistakes of others. Many sceptics would reject outright the notion that you can learn anything from anyone, simply because they do not believe in the replicability, let alone recursivity, of a certain experiential knowledge.

Just to be clear, we are not talking about mathematics, geometry, or natural sciences, which are fields of study that are based on specific laws governing phenomenological world (e.g., the law of gravity), but ideas of individuals who have tried to discover the most elementary form of our being. My take here is: why stumble and fall on your own when you can learn from other people's experience? True. Not everyone will have the same experience of a certain thing.

It's almost like watching a movie, say, *The Matrix*, which is one of those movies that I love to death. But guess what, so many of my friends also hate it to death. Just because I like it doesn't mean that it's a good movie, or that everyone will also like it as well.

So, in the way, we learn from what other people have to say about things, and then in order to make what we learn applicable to our life, we have to consistently exercise our sense of critical thinking, productive scepticism, and constructive argumentation. In this example, I may learn from others that *The Matrix* is more than just an action movie featuring Keanu Reeves, but a cinematic reinterpretation of Cartesian philosophy.

It's actually pretty cool to learn afterwards that many things in *The Matrix* are direct references to the Bible (e.g., Neo as "the One"), existentialism (i.e., the fact that there's no purpose in life and the Oneness that Neo believes to possess is just another version of what has already been programmed to exist to give a false sense of hope), the creationism (i.e., the existence of "the architect") and so on. I feel as though there should be another blog's post just on how I feel about *The Matrix*.

I know, understand, and see the point of being a sceptic, and I think to a degree there is a merit to being a sceptic, but what's the point of being a sceptic just for the sake of being one?

My feeling is that many people tend to mistake the idea of being a skeptic as such -- "I am a sceptic because I want to show the world how smart I am through my ability to question everything around me." I'd like to call such scepticism an unhealthy version it (it is still scepticism, but it is just not the kind of scepticism whose quality I would ever aspire to possess).

To me, being a skeptic is only good for you as long as it helps me to, as Michel de Montaigne once said, " gauge the true worth of anything by its usefulness and appropriateness" to my life.

So, I won't go around being an annoying sceptic just to prove to others that I have a brain -- simply because gaining acceptance from others (in this case, that I have a brain) is not and will never be something that I would ever consider useful let alone appropriate (as if I have so much time in life to waste?) What's the kind of thing that I would consider useful and appropriate?

This, I'd like to resort to the greatest of all (and my personal hero) Jean-Jacques Rousseau, who believes that there are so many things in life that we somehow are forced to believe that they are both useful and appropriate to possess, such as a nice car, a new cellphone, a glittering jewelry, and so on. To Rousseau (and another one of my heroes Henry David Thoreau) a good life doesn't require that many things. We need much fewer materialistic items than we think.

The reason why we tend to think that we need much more than we do need is simply because someone else in the position of power tells us so. I believe that thoughts are like these objects. There are thoughts and ideas that the privileges and elites are trying to make us believe that unless we know them we don't belong to the society. Most of these thoughts are obfuscating, hyper-complex, deeply abstract, and far from being useful.

I don't consider thinking about these thoughts a helpful exercise, and therefore worth exercising my scepticism to get to the bottom of it. So, the first challenge is to identify which thoughts are helpful to be sceptic about, and which thoughts are not. That said, as many colleagues of mine have pointed out lately, there is always a glimpse of both existentialism and romanticism in just about everything I have said and written about lately.

That's not wrong, and it has to do with my recent discovery of the French poet Charles Baudelaire (whose writings I have been learning through an awesome online course called *The Modern and the Postmodern* by Professor Michael Roth of Wesleyan University). I am only sceptical about things only insofar as it gives me the pleasure of being able to comprehend the complex world around me for the sake of comprehending it.

This may sound as though I am contradicting myself here as I just wrote earlier that I only want to be sceptical about things that are useful and appropriate to me. This is exactly the point.

I have a feeling (as opposed to think -- I want to emphasize that it's more my emotion speaking here) that what prevents us from being a healthy sceptic is simply because we have been inculcated to think too much about the end goal and the consequence, i.e., "what is useful needs to have a practical purpose that materialize." I think such way of thinking only diminish our quality of being a full being.

Why can't we make the enjoyment of things around us something of practical purposes that also make life worth living and exploring? To sum up, I think we shall take everything that we believe we truly need both seriously and with intensity because by doing so we are directly exercising our innate ability to respect, comprehend, and process practical lessons learned through the experience and wisdom of other people.

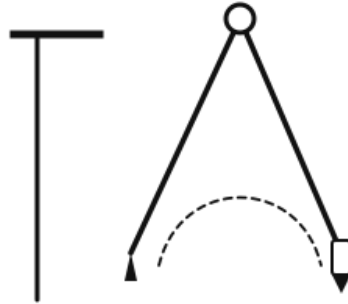
However, we shouldn't just take it at face value, we shall allow our ability to dig deeper beyond the surface of things to help us see through the superficial facade that others have put up to protect themselves from having to reveal

the undesirable inauthenticity to the world -- but this doesn't have to be done on purpose, as the purpose of life should simply be to appreciate the existence of things around us as they are without an absolute goal of trying to change it.

DAY 17

How Do I Want to Get Old

Sun, 13 Jul 2025 00:00:00 +0000



THE ARCHITECT LOUIS KAHN ONCE said that good architecture "age beautifully." And that's it -- that's how I would like to get old. The ideas about what life is are very diverse. Religious people believe that life has a much larger purpose, such as about paying off your debts, cleansing away your sin, and about living every minute to pay respect to the supreme divine power.

Ancient philosophers seem to be convinced that the purpose of life has to do with maximising the quality of life, i.e., how to live one self in accordance with some basic rules that make life worth living and fulfilling.

Modern, especially Enlightenment, philosophers tend to see life in two separate spheres: one is all about duty (AKA the deontology camp) therefore a good life is a life that lived in accordance with a set of rules created for the pleasantries of the universal whole, and the other is about maximising the happiness of the majority (AKA the consequentialist).

These two camps may have very different ways of thinking about life, but both of their ideas are based on the same systematic reasoning process called "reason." Even more modern philosophers go as far as to say that we should forget about what others have said about life, and start from the

drawing board. "Life is absurd," quoted the father of Existentialism Søren Kierkegaard.

To him, who one might also call "the master of pessimism," whatever we choose to do, we will be regretting of our action, yet we still have to do it. There's also no consolation for Kierkegaard, whatever you have chosen to do, you'd have to live with us. There is no point of going back to re-think the alternative and how the consequence may unfold otherwise.

The master novelist and Existentialist Albert Camus goes as far as to say that the only philosophical question in life not only should begin but must also be entered with the question of whether or not one should exercise one's own life to exist.

That is, the only philosophical question worth asking is whether or not we should commit suicide -- it's the only true question that encompasses both the rational exercise of the mind, and the practical process of choosing between "to be" and "not to be." In a way, Camus is very right. Because we have the free will to exercise, therefore we do have the power to emancipate, and bypass it all. Shall we do it?

Later existentialists, though in the standard of the modern time seem as pessimistic as Kierkegaard, offer much more convincing arguments. Although they are on the same page with Kierkegaard that life is absurd, they are pointing us to a much more interesting and less, quite literally, suicidal direction.

After Kierkegaard, we may be able to say that it's Friedrich Nietzsche who is kind enough to tell us that "God is Dead," and what he means by that is that we shall no longer look for a single model of goodness because the model itself, even though if we could imagine one, would be nothing but a fraudulent. Goodness is not something we should strive for, because goodness should not be universal.

True; there're some universal goodness, but the sense of morality, as I mentioned in my previous posts, has to come from the sense of shared

collective goal. The people behind the effort of making Christianity a universal religion are trying too hard to make Christianity a universal morality, which, in the sense, is a failed project from the beginning in Nietzsche's logic. We shall not live by the standard provide to us. We should only live our life based on the standard that we ourselves have created.

Who can really say the Cynics of Ancient Athens were not smart. They knew exactly what they're doing, and just because they had no interest in the material sophistication of the urban people doesn't mean they're stupid, barbaric, or primitive. They chose to do what they did precisely because they wanted to sustain their life with what "life really needs" -- nothing more and nothing less. Jean Paul Sartre has made his belief in how we should scrap all the old books of philosophy very clear.

According to him, we should live our life as a free man whose emotion could take us to places that our reason alone can't; that we should care less about how other people think of us but how we would like ourselves to be understood from within; that we should re-think social conventions and re-define them in the way that satisfy both of your sense of having the freedom to leap beyond the norms and traditions into the realm of "existence." We exist because we live in the moment.

I think Sartre is right. We should life both a free and intense life; "free" in the sense that we shall follow no nonsense order to continue doing work that we hate even if that work pays bill; and "intense" in the way that we must put all efforts into doing things we want to do without holding anything back. "We only live once," Sartre would have said this has he known the idiom, and that we should be clear how we'd want to live it.

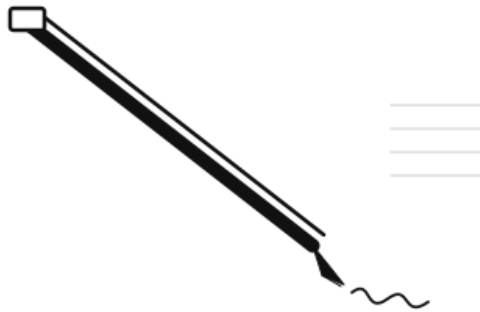
To me, I take what Sartre means as to eat a lot of spice, travel as much as you'd like, share with as many people who care, and drink as much as your body could possibly process (by the way, Nietzsche never liked alcohol which have, for years, made me puzzled about he derived so many great ideas -- while sober). Life is absurd, as it's about getting to Point A to Point B, and through the process we'll experience many unpleasant experiences.

Our bodies are made to ache, to feel the pain, to smell, and so on, so the dilemma of having to live in a temporary body is already one that makes life, to many, more painful and plentiful. As for me, all I want is to get to Point B smoothly, but not too smooth that there's nothing life to feel challenged by.

DAY 18

On Posting on Social Media

Mon, 14 Jul 2025 00:00:00 +0000



WOULD I BE OKAY IF this is my last post? That's the ultimate maxim. Before I post anything, I examine this question. No. I am not particularly feeling morbid right now or anything. It's a fact that every time I post anything, I make sure that I would be okay if that post is my last post ever.

I am writing this post on the plane right now, I am writing this post with the sense if the plane goes down and does not arrive at my destination, I will be okay leaving this post as something people will remember me for. I always make sure that I would be okay leaving that post as my last words, by which people will remember me.

By this particular way of thinking, I make sure that my post, no matter how short or long it is, is never about me antagonizing on something or someone, or me stating the absolutely senseless obvious, or me saying things that don't do justice to the precious time of whoever reads my post. By this way of thinking, I not only think twice before I write anything.

Unlike verbal speech whose temporal characteristic seems rather short-lived, written words are not just, in most cases, more permanent, but they could also play a role of an evidence to put you in an uncomfortable situation. The latter seems to be a much more convincing reason for

everyone to think not only twice, but three, four, five times before they'd say or write anything in the public realm.

The quick and dirty tips on what NOT to post on social media, based on a survey conducted among those who frequently post on social media are: don't post too much selfies, don't show off too much (especially your material affluence), don't post too many "overly and exaggerating romantic" photos, don't post too many photos of your baby, don't post too many things that are external to other people's lives (i.e., "the non-stop broadcaster"), don't post too much work out photos (i.e., "the work out freak").

The point is simply: not many people care about your insecurity. The only reason to why we all do things that other could say "who cares?" is that: insecurity. We feel insecure, so we show off, exaggerate, and do things that, in cases, seem insensitive.

We feel "insecure" so we want to show others that you have "something" that make you yourself believe to proof that you are also a member of the particular society or community in which you aren't sure whether or not they would like to have you. By the way, the Podcaster Stephen West just released an amazing episode of his show on the topic of insecurity which I'd recommend to everyone at all).

West himself provides the gist of this particular episode (which, again, I can't recommend enough): It's not really a question of whether you're a person that has insecurities that affect your behavior; it's a question of how often do your insecurities affect your behavior. Ok. So, my point is, before posting anything, think at least five times over. By that, I mean anything at all.

We must think five times even if we believe that whatever we want to write is so "true." At the end of the day, it could just be that what you think is true is just another version of the situation of which you happen to perceive a version.

In the spirit of a philosophical thoughts called fallibilism -- which I myself would like to define it as "what open-mindedness and skepticism have in

common" -- we must respect all thoughts, and more than anything else, the absolute impossibility of absolute truth, of which is absolutely too complicated and multifaceted for any human beings to fully grasp the gist.

Therefore, even if we know for sure what we think we know as truth, accepting the possibility that there might be another version of it out there somewhere is a must for a fallibilist, who is usually also a good scholar, thinker, and observer of the universe in which we live. This way of thinking is everything.

For instance, if I get home one day after a long bad fight with my boss or my colleague and feel compelled to write a diatribe monologue about that person and against his or her existence at large, I would have to think first, "how much do I really know about that person whom I am about to trash?" The point of posting anything on social media is to let other people know what you think no matter how much you'd like to intellectualize it.

I am writing this blog for myself, but I do want you to read it.

If the answer to such question is, "I don't really know, and my dissatisfaction is based on the encounter between me and that person that is far from dissatisfying whether it's because our ideas are too different, or that there is an absence of the basis of ideas, collective goal, or shared moral value, on which we would have to agree on in order to have a meaningful conversation, then, perhaps, that feeling of dissatisfaction is not merely about that person, but the situation in which we are set to go against each other.

Would we be able to grasp a couple pints of beer together otherwise? If the answer is yes, then the problem I have is really not toward the person but toward the situation. We would be super lucky if we can always choose the best situation to be in. There will be times when we don't like the situation that we have to deal with in order to get paid, to achieve good grades, or to make our family happy, to name a few.

So, if this is the condition that makes me want to write something that isn't very nice, then perhaps it's best to scrap the post, and use that precious time

to write something else, e.g., an email to a family member or someone I love and care about, or a daily dairy to remind myself what makes me think so hard today. These personal writings, of course, can include the narratives involving dissatisfaction.

That's what your friends and family members for: to hear you out and to make you feel better about yourself. They, presumably, know your personal side and emotional thrust more than anyone else (maybe not everyone but I know for sure that my mother who has been listening to me patiently and offering gray advice for thirty something years knows me more than I know myself -- thanks, mom).

Because the point is, if that post happens to be your last post -- accept it you never know when you'll die -- you would like it to be something that represent the best and most admirable (and also deeply moral) side of you, not the side of you that happens to be stuck in the temporary moment of dissatisfaction, or the side of you that is completely driven by immature emotion. One has to make an effort to post something.

Posting something isn't something that happened by itself, or naturally. Think about it. You'd have to get on the Internet, type in or click on the website's button, log in to your account, write the words or sentence(s) and eventually click post for it to be posted. It takes time and energy, so anyone who reads it would know that what makes you do something like this is both your conscious self (so, a lame excuse such as "I wasn't myself when I posted it" wouldn't work) and your conscience.

Your words represent who you are.

Would you like your last words to be, "I hope this XXX person die with great pain," or "I disgust this XXX activity so much that I could bend the reality of the world to hate it too?" Here're some of the posts that (I found on the internet) shall not comment any further why I wouldn't want them to be my last post, therefore I would never post anything like these: "I am working hard." "Eating pizza on the street -- so cool, never done this "Today I feel that

I am so stupid." "I never miss anyone like I am missing you right now."
(pictures of food) (pictures of babies) (selfies) Well.

On selfies, let me make it clear. I am okay with funny selfie. I am also okay with family selfie. What I think shouldn't be allowed are selfies that are misleading.

I don't think any of us has any morally legitimate reasons to post an egregious self-promotional representation of oneself, with the intention to mislead people since usually such photos are taken with the intention to mislead others to believe that such self-photographic representations (a means of limited two dimensional photographic manipulation) has a set of physical qualities of which the society ardently approves. That said, everything should have an exception.

There are times when I'd allow myself to sound emotional, and my post to represent my deep sense of anger, which usually only happen when I really feel categorically passionate about something, which often has something to do with morality, and our social responsibility.

For instance, I have never been a fan of the US gun policy, whenever there's a news about another incident involving mass killing and a gun that could have been preventable had people with power done something to make gun less easy to be available, then I get very upset and usually want to write something to express myself. In this case, I feel that the lack of gun control undermines the most basic need of civilians which is the right to be protected against corporeal violence.

Citizens can only work hard and produce for the betterment of the society if they feel safe, protected, and as though they are being cared for by the society. I personally won't be able to work well if I don't feel safe.

I won't be using my laptop writing my papers at a place where I don't feel safe, such as at a quiet sidewalk at night, as someone who sees the monetary resell value of my laptop could simply try to use force to take it from me and pawn it. The lack of gun control makes everywhere an unsafe place like that.

I feel the urge to post my anger so that everyone who thinks the same way I do knows that he or she is not alone, and that we might someone be able to make a difference in the world if we work together. There are times when my anger led to a series of great collaborations -- precisely because the like-minded who had read what I posted also felt the same emotional sensibility to act, do something, and not letting the senseless trick got us.

For instance, I use Facebook to read news through its (pretty awesome I must admit) news feed. In fact, I have turned off all private and personal notifications from friends on Facebook because I only want to read the news and interesting stories from the media. Whenever I read something that I feel deeply passionate about, and resonate with, I always post my responses regardless of whether or not I think anyone would be reading them or not.

Here're some of my thoughts on some current issues: On China's sexual revolution: " This is a critical question: how to educate young people to understand the meaning of sex, in a country where the history of such form of education has always been written either by men, or by the authority whose idea about it is based entirely on the convenience yet deeply unfair of subjects namely the female citizens?

Because of the economic reform, people are now more free to think outside of the rubric of duty o reproduce, while being unclear about the path to pursue. I agree with the article that China must embrace the reality of the kind of society that economic freedom also brings.

" On how many hours we should sleep per night: " I always question the "8-hour rule" just because I really, really, like the tranquility of the nocturnal hours, which often allows me to indulge myself in the beauty of silence, tasty homemade cocktails, delirious reading, and theatrical entertainment at the comfort of my sofa. Sometimes, I'd even give up making love for these activities because I often enjoy morning sex rather than giving away my nocturnal hours just to be deadly tired and therefore have to sleep.

I got scolded at almost every time share with others that I think we should all be having passionate sex in the morning because it's better for the body's adrenaline movement (as it is back by science to be true). Personally, morning sex under the sun light (and morning sunlight is good for you) makes you see your partner clearly and therefore make you appreciate her/his body more, which, in turn, strengthen the love between the two.

I guess lesson learned from this article is that we should always question the convention, and live our lives in the way that we believe to benefit our physicality as much as possible -- and of course without inflicting on other people's rights. " On whether or not I think Bernie Sanders is electable: "Of course, Bernie Sanders is electable.

His belief aligns with the majority of us, who believe that methodological individualism (i.e., respect for the freedom for all), and social capitalism that drives innovation, technological advancement, and therefore a better society for all, can work together under the banner of "setting a moral limit of the market economy." The only concern is whether he would be able to convince those who only believes in one of the two moral systems to align with him.

And to give him to benefit of the doubt, I am not certain that Hilary can conveniently achieve that neither." On how often I think a couple should have sex: "I agree. There are two points to make here. First, there is a proliferation of research and open thoughts (on media and so on) about sex, which may in some way express our collective inquiry about its usage today beyond the realm of temporary fulfillment.

Second, the best thing about sex, at least to me, is providing yourself and your partner the confidence that both of you are still attractive enough to each other, are still naturally excited when seeing each other in the most natural form, and are still enjoying the activity that hard capitalism can't force you to do and is still something entirely under your sole moral control." On Jeb Bush's comment about the refugee crisis: "I mean, I believe that a change of regime, from one party to the other, from time to time, could help foster the notion of check and balance in the society.

So, although I am always been inclined toward the Democrats, I also want to Republicans to take the stand from time to time. There have also been many great Republican presidents in the history of the US. So, whenever I see or read a comment I like this from any GOP presidential hopefuls, all I can say is that they should be more thoughtful about what they think.

Sometimes, all they need to do is to think twice, with the help of their intelligence unit, to come to senses on the big picture of issue, before making any public announcement about their views.

" On Richard Dawkin's view on the Paris Attack: "Knowing Dawkins' work, I think the purposes of this message he is sending are: 1) praying to God doesn't do anyone any good -- someone will misinterpret the meaning of praying, and bring about another hate crime against humanity in the name of the unknown superpower; and, 2) instead of praying, brainstorming about how to bring about peace through scientific ways (thinking empirically, instead of praying noumenally) might be more useful.

Long story short, despite how this message might sounds a bit harsh, I don't think he is saying anything that falls outside of the realm of our collective ability of tolerate. In a way, it's another way of making a lemonade when life gives us lemon, which I think is more useful than picking them up and throw them at each other. I think we all have in all of us the innate ability to sympathize with the victims of and the non-direct victims affected by the tragedy.

It's already a very sad thing. What's much worse is to see people hating, criticizing, bashing each other simply because their views on whether or not to pray, whether or not to post that they pray (even if they don't pray), or to shout against people who don't pray (whether or not the people who shout really know what praying means)." On women's right to orgasm: "I firmly believe that all women deserve this basic, natural, and human right.

The right to orgasm is as important as the right to be loved. I don't think men can get away with fulfilling themselves and then go to bed. In fact, I always

believe in this natural right, and always do my best to make sure that the woman I love reaches the climax she deserves at the same time or before I reach mine.

I refuse to reach that point before her." On people debating the origin of cuisines and dishes: " Ask two questions: first "who cares?" and then "so what?" If the question about the origin of the cuisine being asked doesn't entertain these two questions, "put them to flame" (said David Hume and Michel de Montaigne in two different occasions). You get the point.

At the end of the day, as I remain true to my principle, I wouldn't mind if my post about my hatred for the lack of gun control be my last post ever. This view represents who I am morally, and it will go down in the history after my time has long past that many like-minded people aren't alone.

DAY 19

On My Coffee Addiction

Tue, 15 Jul 2025 00:00:00 +0000



I AM A COFFEE ADDICT. Ever since I was introduced to coffee I have never been able to live a full day without it. Well, I can, but I wouldn't want to. Thailand in the 80s and 90s where I grew up, coffee had yet to be a big part of Thai society's cultural life. My father, for example, also brewed a flask of tea for himself to take to work.

He would consume the entire flask (also known as, a hot water thermos) bit by bit through out the day (the flask he used was one of those that the cap of which also worked as a cup). In my vivid childhood memory, he always returned home with an empty flask. The habit of consuming tea made the world goes round for him. He was a hardworking man, and he was obsessed with getting his work done.

He got up early, never late for work, spent all his time at his desk getting his job done, took only little time to eat, returned home right afterwards and never went out to socialize, tucked in early in order to get ready for the next day. His work ethics (except the not going out to socialize part) have always been the model of my very own. Actually, I am not being very fair to my dad.

Maybe he liked to go out drinking with his friends, but because he's married and had two kids to take care of, he could only have so much fun with his

friends. My father was not perfect, but he was a role model for me and for many people who learned how to be determined, clear, and extremely frank to his own heart, in many ways, but his true essence was probably his honesty and dignity.

He honestly loved his job and he never allowed anything to get in the way, including the temptation of corruption. Drinking tea was my father's ritual, but I am sure the caffeine in the strong tea that he consumed (the brand was Three Horses, which is still available in any supermarket today) also played a role in his pathological addiction. In the 2000s, even after he had retired, he still brewed his own tea everyday.

He would brew a small pot and drink it at home since there was no need to go to work and therefore no need to make a flask of tea to carry with him. But whenever we got on the car, I could always get there would be a small flask of tea in the storage compartment between his seat and the shotgun seat.

As a child until when my father passed away a couple years after his retirement, I thought it was funny that every time we stopped in the traffic, he would ask me to pour him a cup of tea so that he could have a sip while waiting for the car to move. "Dad, drinking tea ain't gonna make the car go faster," I told him.

Although there's a small cup holder on the right hand side of the wheel, he always trusted me more to hold the cup for him when he had to operate the moving car. The aroma and the light smoke that came out of the top of the tubular flask was the evidence that the tea he drank was always hot.

I didn't like tea that much because as a child growing up in Thailand during the era of global imperialism, I was completely obsessed with the "cool beverages" such as soda water and carbonated lemonade which were always served cold. So, the thought of consuming the very hot water didn't even cross my mind. That said, whenever my father asked me to pour a cup for him, I couldn't resist having a sip. It's also our ritual. It is also something that bond us father and son.

What makes my father such a great father isn't just his unconditional love for his family, but his true devotion to create a better environment for his children - the one that would be much much much better than what he has to live in as a child. This was the stance that both of my parents never once disagreed about. They both loved me and my brother so much that they'd do everything to make sure that we wouldn't have to build everything from scratch.

My father's childhood life, as he told me, wasn't all that painful, but he knew, from the deepest part of his heart, that he could be in a much better place had he been provided with better schooling and constructive guidance from someone who really knew how it's to be a Thai citizen. I wholeheartedly believe that he had done a great job for himself.

It's almost unimaginable that a son of an uneducated Chinese migrant who would barely speak Thai could hold one of the most important posts in the Thai government. It took him decades to arrive at his place in the government, and I am sure tea was a part of it. I never understood why my father liked tea that much, but he was not the only one.

Coffee culture came to Thailand, I believe, with the rise of hyper-corporatism such as the arrival of many international chain cafes (i.e., Starbucks) in the early 2000s. I left Thailand in the late 1990s, and whatever happened during the last few years of millennium was pretty much what made me an outsider to Thai culture when I returned. Thai culture had, always been in a large part influenced by the culture of South China from which most of the Chinese immigrants who later naturalized as Thai citizens came.

Both of my father's and mother's families came from that part of China. Therefore, coffee, then, was pretty much a quick fix rather than a beverage to be enjoyed (the same way my father enjoyed his tea). Like Japan, there is an impression that coffee is a highly industrious drink that could get you up in the morning, put you to work long-hour, and give you the "push" that you need to get you to arrive at the very end of the production line.

I am sure some of those are psychological but the undeniable fact here is that coffee does have the substance that makes our heart beat and our blood flow. So, every time my father needed to stay awake (sometimes to work, sometimes to watch a soccer match) he would resort to the infamous "instant coffee," which, I thought, tasted awful. It's bitter, first of all, and it didn't have the aroma (of brewed coffee, which I later felt in love with).

Maybe it was that reason, that 99% of coffee available in Thailand when I was growing up was all instant coffee, I never liked drinking it. In fact, there's also a saying that "coffee is not for kids; it is only for adults," for reasons that I haven't seemed to be able to figure out, there wasn't even a small little space in my heart for the beverage that decades after would become something that I can't live without.

When I was in architecture school in Thailand, I resorted to both canned coffee and Red Bull to keep myself awake at night. But to be honest, I never thought that any of them worked. I consumed them because they gave me the impression that they "might work." It could have been the case that my body was caffeine resistance, but whatever the reason was, all I always knew was that I could never resist sleeping.

While all my colleagues were working over night to get their projects done, almost always the case was that I would be in my bed sleeping like a log because I prioritized sleeping over getting my work done (and that coffee didn't really work on me). Laying my personal story out this way, I can't help but to feel that I have always indeed been an existentialist! So, if coffee doesn't help me getting up in the morning and be industrious, why do I like it?

Well, I like the taste of it. I also like the smell of it. Recently, there are research showing that the smell of coffee makes me happier and the taste of coffee makes us appreciate things around us more. Among many, there are also many scientific research that show the benefits of coffee. But really, apart from the taste, what do I like about it? Actually, I have been surprised by the fact that not many people have mentioned how coffee helps your

stomach.

Yes, I consume coffee in the morning partly so that I would have a much easier time in the bathroom. I am not sure if this is just me, but a cup of morning coffee helps me a great deal in removing the night soil from my physical body (AKA, makes me shit well). I don't put crime in my coffee because I never like it. Only black coffee, or coffee with soy milk, works for me. I like my coffee also to be very hot.

Lately I just found out another way of making coffee called the cold brewed method. Basically, instead of using heat to brew, the method rely on the fully immersion of coffee ground in cold water for the full 24-hour circle. By doing so, not only the coffee becomes much less acid, but it also tastes much smoother.

All I have to do is to store the brewed coffee in the fridge and everything, e I want to drink it I just have to use about 1/3 of it in a cup mixed with hot water. If you haven't tried, I challenge you to:-)

post Day 20: My Cousin, Or on Education Wed, 16 Jul 2025 00:00:00 +0000 I have been observing my little cousin over the past few days that we'd gotten to spend time together. She came over to spend a couple of nights with us, during which we swam, exercised, went shopping, ate together, and so on. It's great to have these two days with her, which was mainly because her break coincided with my visit to Bangkok.

Because ever since she was born almost a decade ago, I have always been abroad. So, we only got to spend less than a month every year together during my summer and/or my winter holidays which I always returned home. This time, because we had spent so much time together, from the morning all the way to the evening when I tucked her in, I began to realize that there're so much I could learn about life from observing someone more than 23 years younger than me.

It's somewhat painful to observe her. I love her because I have seen her since she was zero-year-old, and that she has been a part of my life in the past

decade. So, my "partiality" toward her is what makes me feel conflicted whenever I feel that I shouldn't be giving her the preferential treatment just because she's my cousin. But how can I not? She's my cousin! In a way, she represents an immature state of human being.

We were all like her when we were her age (well, maybe not everyone, but, in general). Needless to say, for someone so young in a family, she constantly receives all the attention from all of us. Both of her siblings are at least 13 years older than her. We're all helicopter family members to her, so to speak. I didn't have that privilege when I was young.

It's true that I called my parents from time to time, and thought of them also as my best friends on top of being my most revered role models, but when it came to decision-making I was left to do it alone. I did not grow up being hovered over by my parents suggesting to me what I should do. They were busy, and that was one of the reasons why they could not possibly be hovering over me.

The real reason, however, I believe, is that my parents themselves were raised as mature decision-makers, therefore they saw the true merit in urging me to make my own decision — and, more importantly, be responsible for the consequences of my own decision. Looking back, I feel that which is pretty tough for a young (and cute) boy!

Jokes aside, my parents were not hand-off, but they would help — and they did, countless times in fact — whenever they realized that I could no longer manage the situation by myself. But the lesson that I learned from being granted the complete freedom to make my own choice, and the complete responsibility to accept the mistake, admit the false, and come up with a way to solve my own problems when such decisions lead me astray, essentially made me an existentialist even before I knew of the term.

Back to my cousin again. Although all of our family members are now used to having this young little girl in the house with them, they still surrender to her drama whenever she wants it to portray her desire for us to buy her things.

Long story short, we have been incessantly and brutally spoiling her (and I truly believe that, as much as I love her almost to death, she wouldn't be spoiled at all if she's living with me full-time) and that my cousin is, by any standards, is a spoiled kid.

Again, back to my earlier point about the contradicting feeling that I have been having about whether or not I should love my cousin more than any other kids, or should I treat her as a special one because she's my cousin and that I know her more than I know other people.

This task is specially difficult for me since I am a teacher by profession, and therefore, on a daily basis, I encounter this sort of question regarding partiality: how shall I treat the students I know very well?

I wholeheartedly believe that my little cousin is, deeply, a kindhearted person because she has been growing up among and with us who love her, but the modern world has trained her to be calculating, to know which roles to play in which situation, and to use other people's sympathy to benefit her.

Not only is she interested in playing games that she know she would win, but she also, quite often in fact, tampers the rules of the games, or makes her own rules so that she could make sure that she would win. This is, somehow, human nature. We calculate, and we make moves that not only would benefit us materially, but also make us feel that we have figured out the way to get more from the labor that we've put into the process.

We strive to find a better way to live ourselves. Evolutionally, this makes us calculating mammals, who see cheating, tricking, and tampering the system not much as a sin, but a product of our own ingenuity — the same way we cherish those who know the rules so well and therefore could break them in style. My little cousin was not interested in winning per se, but in winning and taking all, and being able to bully those who lose.

I was like that too, to a degree, when I was her age because of my ignorance and because I didn't know much about sympathy. I surely would not want my little cousin to be like me (although there's so much I could do since I am not

her parents). Growing up with the curious mindset, I wasn't the most incident kid in town neither, and I knew how painful it was to be dismissed, hated, and outcasted by my classmates.

My little cousin doesn't know what she wants in life yet, and therefore she's like a sponge who absorbs everything — to her, there's no difference between good and bad influence, as they're all things with the capacity to have an effect on her. Although I don't completely believe in John Locke's theory of "blank slate-ness," I seem to see his point her.

This "blank slate-ness" (latin, *tabula rasa*) is the idea that babies are born as though they are completely, clean, blank, and empty plains with no preconditions, no preconceptions, and/or pre-destinations. They "become" what the parents make them become. I tend to go with the ancient Chinese philosopher Mencius (*mengzi*) that we may not be born with a lot of ideas, but we definitely ain't blank slates.

According to Mencius, we're all born a set of "pre-ideas" about the world, which has been built into our system, our DNA, and our modular unit of being. Central to what is built into us, among other things, is the "sense of humanity," which includes the paradoxical presets of self-interest versus sympathy for others, the desire for to be powerful versus the desire to be modest and live just adequately but not beyond, and so on.

An enlightenment thinker such as Adam Smith has shown us that self-interest and sympathy for others don't have to always be staged at the two opposite sides of the ring, but can co-exist well under the pretext of the shared goal of "moral sentiments." The best way to turn our sympathy into something meaningful to the whole community is for all of us to work hard, and simply let the products of our labor compete fiercely in the market, which would not only give the consumers the chance to decide which is a superior product, but also drive down the price, which would benefit the underprivileged in the society as a whole.

In addition, this sense of self-interest is also about letting our goodwill materialize in forms of positive externalities to make the society a sympathetic terrain for human beings who have sentiments for each other, and for all. That is, what we're trying our best to do is to make sure that our offsprings chose what is right for them.

I once found myself arguing with my little cousin over something, and it all happened was simply because she wanted to show that she could "engage in an argument" with someone older. For instance, her response to my question "who do you think live in that house?" as I was pointing my hand at a house across the street which looked a bit different from where we lived was, "who do you think?

a dog, perhaps?" At first, it was interesting to see how her brain worked, but after a while, I got very annoyed, which was mainly because I thought we were having a conversation when we weren't. Without a real sense of collective goal, our independent monologue seemed utterly pointless. Surely, she was not interested in engaging in a conversation, but to show that she could come up with something to argue with me. I later found out that she didn't even come with those responses by herself.

She heard them on television, from her classmates, and from people on the street. This particular incident reminds me of so many conversations I have had with so many people.

Our conversations, though seemed fine on the surface, led us no where because while either one of us was hoping to arrive at some solutions of a problem we had agreed to be discussing, the other person's goal was usually something else: to prove the point that he/she knew things, to deliver a statement that he/she was capable of maintaining a long conversation (in the case of my cousin), and sometimes simply to make a point that he/she wanted to make with or without the pretext of the conversation (aren't these people so annoying?) The bottom line is, and this is how I have been living my life, I would never start a conversation with someone, let alone engaging in one, if I think we don't share the same collective goal.

It's a total waste of time. At the end of the day, the purpose of this post is to get myself to think about the role of education. The title of this post owes its origin to Jean-Jacques Rousseau's *Emile, Or On Education*. My cousin follows her parents, her teachers, and whatever the media tell her. Because she's born in this generation, she's equipped with the knowledge of digital culture, information technology, and cutting-edge sensory understanding of the world around her.

The drawback of all of these is that, especially ever since her parents gave her a green light on using the computer and tablet at home whenever she pleases, her attention span has been observably truncated. Online informational pages, games, and electronic media are aiming at delivering the data (and usually with some forms of entertainment) using the least amount of time as possible, and by doing so they need to internationally leave out some core ideas, which could be very important, as they make things too complicated.

By the time the readers get to the core ideas, they would have lost their attention already. Online media, with its focus on arriving at the point they want to make as quick as possible, makes us feel that which are too complicated (when sometimes they aren't complicated at all, it's just that we need to see them, also, from a variety of perspectives to understand the clearer picture) are probably not worth reading.

There's been so many times that I encounter some negative comments on the internet made by people who have all the ability to understand complicated things, but make mindless comments simply because they lack the patience to think through using both of their emotional and reasoning sides of their brains. My cousin, born as a Generation-Z, is someone who can't spend more than a few minutes on one thing.

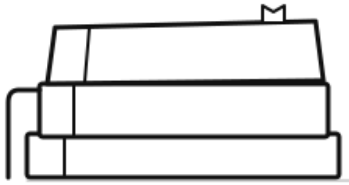
Constantly aroused by all forms of interactivities in the virtual reality provided to her by the massive spread of the internet, she feels the urge to want to move on to the next things once she finds out that what she is currently reading is too hard.

Although I have tried to read it with her to give her some good ideas so that she wouldn't think that the important contents that she's reading is too hard, once her mind has set on the impression that it's hard, she simply stops paying attention to anything — to me, to the information, and to everything around her.

DAY 21

On Duty

Thu, 17 Jul 2025 00:00:00 +0000



LAST YEAR, A FEW PEOPLE asked me how I dealt with the difficulty of my fieldwork. It wasn't just the frugal living condition, but also the crashes of self-interest in the face of contemporary capitalism that I had to deal with on a daily basis. My answer was that I coped with it by reading books on moral philosophy, mainly those of the Eastern tradition in which I have always been interested.

Whenever I found myself in a troubled situation, I picked up a copy of a philosophical book on my shelves and stared reading it. After a while, usually after 20-30 pages, I'd begin to feel better either because I was distracted from thinking about the trouble at hand or because I was so immersed with the new insight to the human condition derived from the texts that I was reading. Books on Zen Buddhism were the ones that helped me the most.

Zen stories are short, and like aphorism, they are extremely witty, sharp, and allow us to arrive at the point so quickly as if we're being splashed with a bucket of iced water in a cold winter.

I remember well that there was a time that I read 20 Zen stories in a roll, and afterwards I felt as if I had arrived at the point of perpetual content, in which there's nothing more and nothing less for me to gain, as if I was in, what

arguably the greatest Enlightenment philosopher Immanuel Kant calls, the "numeral world," or the world of things in themselves.

Unfortunately, as I wasn't that strong yet in terms of my ability to meditate deeply, I always got brought back to the "phenomenal world" the moment I began to hear motor vehicle honking on the street outside, or people spitting loudly in the alleyway, or my neighbors making very loud noise as they're shouting at one another. Kant's writings did not help me as much as Zen Buddhism because it only provides me with moral explanations, but not the normative guidance of how I shall act in difficult circumstances.

Also last year, through teaching an undergraduate-level introductory course in moral philosophy, I got to also read ideas about morality from the Western tradition, which I always make comparisons with their Eastern counterparts. The interesting thing that came out quite a bit is Immanuel Kant's idea of duty. What is the duty that we have to our self, our family, our society, and the world?

Eastern tradition seems to have a few answers, and one of which encompasses the entire spectrum of the participants in human society, that is, if we act in accordance with the moral code of righteousness and benevolence, "everything under heaven" (tianxia) will be in peace. I believe that this "everything under heaven" includes not only human beings, but also animals, plants, other betwixt creatures and the whole environment: both things we can see with our eyes and things we simply can't. The idea of heaven encompasses both God and beyond.

I think the thinkers of Eastern tradition are leaving enough room for us to think about what the heaven should be. It could be an anthropomorphic being who we like to refer to as God, or it could just be an amorphous being who lives beyond the laws of gravity, and therefore is not constrained by space and time by which human beings like us are bounded. But whatever the heaven is for the Eastern tradition, it's the idea that gives us moral guidance.

In the spirit of pragmatism, I like the idea of "whatever works." In this case, although it seems rather unscientific to think that there's a being who lives above us in the sky who has more power than anyone use. Any skeptics would say that we can't simply see the world that way because we really don't have any ways of proving that such all powerful being exists. That said, there are so many things we can't see with our eyes, does it mean that they don't exist?

Again, this kind of intellectual engagement is good for those who have a lot of time to spend (and waste), but for me, really, is, as the pragmatist William James once said, "whatever works." In this sense, I am more than happy to be friends with those who are moral because they believe in what I don't, such as the afterlife, God, heaven, and so on. In fact, isn't that great?

As I wrote in my earlier post, thinkers, both Eastern and Western traditions alike, have been coming up with new ideas about how we might perhaps do to combat the absurdity of life (i.e., the existentialists), the vicious circle of birth and re-birth (i.e., the conservative Theravada branch of Buddhism), and the lack of meaning of it all (i.e., Confucianism).

The best way, at least for me, is precisely to not think of such absurdity as merely as act of moving from point A (birth) to point B (death), but to make the most of it. One thing we know for sure is that no one who has arrived at point B ever comes back to tell us what it's like beyond point B, so, in the spirit of positive and meaningful skepticism, we might as well make our lives count.

One way is to think about life is to conceive it as a process by which each and everyone of us allows the time to past. Whether or not we are making the time past in a meaningful way is depending on each person's motif and goal in life. My goal is to give the meaning to my life, and therefore meaningfulness is not a means to an end, but an end in itself.

In order to "feel" such meaningfulness, I need to slow down my life's pace, induced by my urge to pay bills, to satisfy other people's demands, and to

follow the convention, in order to appreciate the world around me, and listen to my own inner self.

One way of doing that is by resorting to spirituality, which I would like to define it not as in the forms of practice or thinking per se (e.g., meditation, going to churches or temples), but as the way of being "thankful to the life that we have as such." And how can we be thankful?

The answer is simple: by not thinking about the absurdity of life as such, but to somehow put our faith on something, or someone, whom we believe to be the true guidance of our sense of morality.

The great Immanuel Kant, of course, doesn't believe in God, but he does make room for faith -- because, as the old argument will always ring true, just because we can't see God doesn't mean he doesn't exist in almost the same way we can't see many things so small, or the cosmos, or the universe, etc. We could also be like Kant.

Buddhism, in a way, is a theist religion because it doesn't explain the existence of the all powerful being above, but is spiritual because it teaches us to really pay attention to the true genuine knowledge, or what Kant calls, the synthetic a priori, or the knowledge that we can derive independent of our experience and at the same time is not true by definition.

The Four Noble Truths, for instance, is a great example of the synthetic a priori — we know for sure that by resorting to the understanding of cause and therefore the effect, we can arrive at true knowledge about how to go about to solve the problems without having to experience it. So, what's my duty? I believe that I am a pragmatic existentialist (here we go, I just coined a new term!) and I am not just saying that.

I know that I am an existentialist because I have lived basically in accordance with existential principles even before I knew of the term. That said, I am also a deontologist (not a dermatologist because otherwise I'd have more hairs on my head!) because I live in the present, act according to my own law, and am led by my good intention and prepared to accept the responsibility of my

action regardless of the consequences.

Whether or not there's a crash between being in accordance with my own nature, and in accordance with the universal maxim of duty toward fellow human beings and therefore the human species as a whole is another question (which I'll probably spend time justifying at some point in the near future). I don't believe in the notion of absolute freedom. I think we're as free as our freedom doesn't intervene or affect other people's lives and livelihood.

Also, I only see the sense of being free in the present, which means that I wouldn't chain myself to something (e.g., work or family) just to be free in the future. My father, for instance, believes that he himself was a free man because he chose his own job, and served in his role superbly as he believed in his duty to excel in his job as a form of personal development.

That said, he allowed himself to be chained to his job for almost four decades, as he believed that when his job was done, i.e., when he's retired, he would have all the freedom in the world, such as financial freedom through his pension, and physical freedom through not having to go to work anymore and therefore could travel anywhere he'd like.

The reality was much more painful than that, as he passed away only a couple of years after he retired, during which he suffered a great deal from both physical deterioration and psychological decline as he felt he no longer had any value in the society as a stay-at-home uncle to my cousin, and my dog. I won't let that happen to me. There's no tomorrow, or the day after, or tomorrow.

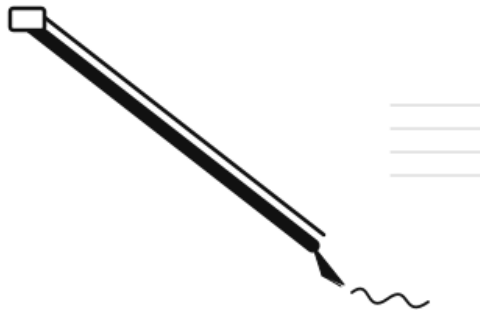
I'll act according to what I feel the urge to do today, and I won't let the hope for better tomorrow chain me to anything that I don't find to be morally satisfying in the present.

That is, I have freedom, essentially, because I act according to law I give to myself (which is the same idea of freedom for which Kant argues) and the basis of which law is my understanding of my moral duty to myself, to the society, and to the human species as a whole -- in the present.

DAY 22

On Being a Rousseaurian Stoic Existentialist

Fri, 18 Jul 2025 00:00:00 +0000



FIRST, I HAVE TO START thinking more before I write in order write fewer words! I have written more than 3,000 words in last two posts, which are a lot of words considering how far behind I still am in terms of my dissertation. I mean, if I could write 3,000 words in my dissertation in two days, I would be much much better of than what I am right now (I would have had the entire thing written already so to speak).

So, this post will be the beginning of that -- the new regime of concise posting. This post will be the shortest post I have written so far, in which I'd like, simply, to point out, using bullet points, what I believe to be true quality of existentialism: Living ONLY in the present: Because paying too much attention to the the time following the moment of speaking or writing (also known as "future") future, which we tend to do, thanks to the imagination endowment upon us by capitalism.

It's the feeling of wanting to "possess the capability to control the uncertainty of life" here that I think is extremely and therefore unhealthily hypothetical -- the speculative nature of something that might never happen. Thinking about the future, in essence, a true waste of time.

Paying too much attention to the past, on the other hand, is only useful insofar as one can draw crucial lessons from it in order to thrive, but apart from that thinking about the past is not helpful by any moral or self-help standards; Living PURELY stoically: Because being a stoic is to be in the present.

The additional merit to the idea of stoicism is that, by living like a stoic, we won't be swayed by any external impulses, such as the objects of temporary beauty to the eyes, to the belly, and to the genital. We want to see through that. Stoicism also helps us prepare for the worst.

Things will not always be what we want, so we might as well be prepared for those things so that when they come, we can deal with them; Believing TRULY that there is no such thing as a role model: As Friedrich Nietzsche writes, "God is dead," which, by that, he implies that God may have lived (since for someone to die, that person has to first live) but God is no longer there because the society has changed so much and that we have gathered so much knowledge to exercise our ability to reason to the point that we do not need God anymore.

God, in this sense, is a role model, which we shouldn't be looking for anymore because the more we're looking for it, the more we're being chained to a static template of moral reasoning (which, given to us by whom anyway?); Being OPENLY responsible for one's own actions: Because it's falsely immature to think that there will always be someone who is accountable for the consequences of what your action.

Thinking that there's someone who will always be there to catch you when you fall will make you not wanting to be free; Being ABSOLUTELY free: We aren't free if we simply follow scriptures, traditions long practiced, or natural inclination. We're chained, also, to our self-imposed immaturity.

To be genuinely free, it would mean that we shall be able to come up with our own rules based on reason, and to be able to follow them rigorously; Being, ALWAYS, thankful for everything around you: Because you "want to live a

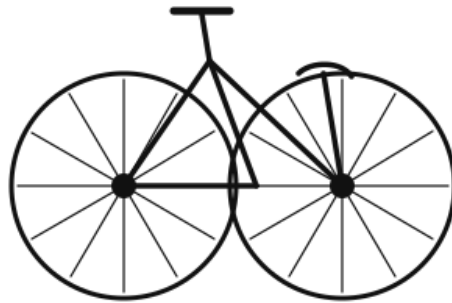
life," and not just to have a life (for which your role is to take it from birth to death).

To "live a life" you need to be able to appreciate, learn from, and be thankful for more than just things, people, and the ideas that could give you immediate material benefits. To live a life is to be appreciative of the fact that you are living one, not to simply being in the physical body trying to not end its course too prematurely.

DAY 23

A "Bad Faith" Bicycle Technician I met?

Sat, 19 Jul 2025 00:00:00 +0000



ONE EXAMPLE OF "BAD FAITH" that [Jean-Paul Sartre] gives is that of a waiter who does his best to conform to everything that a waiter should be. For Sartre, the waiter's exaggerated behavior is evidence that he is play-acting at being a waiter, an automaton whose essence is to be a waiter.

However, in order to play-act at being a waiter, the waiter must at some level be aware that he is not in fact a waiter, but a conscious human being who is deceiving himself that he is a waiter (an excerpt from Neel Burton, M.D.) I always thought that Sartre was right that we are no longer living a life of a human being once we let, what he calls, "bad faith" take part in our social life.

It's, as The School of Life puts it, living without taking into account the very essence of human being, which is to be free. For existentialist, the most immoral crime one could have committed isn't the similar kinds of crime, say, that deontologists or consequentialists would condemn, such as killing (yourself or others), lying, etc.

The most immoral crime for them is to not taking life seriously, either by living under the influence of scriptures, others, or any forms of traditional values or beliefs, and by not being intense about being free every moment in

life. Things don't have to be in the certain way, and we must not shut our eyes to other options.

In the example above -- the year was 1948 -- he went into the famous Café Les Deux Magots in Paris, and as usual, spent some time there observing people around him while writing down his thoughts (most of his writings were done at this café). He began to realize that there's something unsettling about the waiter that he was looking at.

This waiter was "too much" like a waiter, both in the ways that he held his body and responded to the requests of his customers, and how he saw himself in that situation -- as a waiter. Period. What Sartre saw in this waiter wasn't the hard-working work ethics, but the senseless emotion of this being who believes that he himself was in the position of, pretty much, a servant because he had no other choice.

Refusing to confront facts or choices in his life, he chose to be a waiter, although he was partly conscious that he could perhaps be doing something else more dignified and meaningful. Sartre calls this kinds of conformity bad faith. And once there's the word bad in there we could probably guess that Sartre isn't a bad fan of it. Yes, he wholeheartedly denounces the idea of meaningless conformity.

But, what if this waiter, unlike what Sartre saw about him, wasn't doing his job because he was refusing to be free (from his own self-imposed refusal to believe that he could be free) but doing it because he wholehearted likes his job? Fine.

There aren't a lot of observable things that about serving other people and be someone else's bitch, but what if there's a slight possibility that what drove this waiter to be a waiter was not the goal of getting paid, but his own interest and passion in serving other people? Do you think Sartre would see him differently? I was getting the flat tire fixed yesterday at a big sports mall, where I met an existentialist bicycle technician. When I first saw him I thought of Sartre's waiter.

He looked like a typical 20-something-year-old man who did not have anything else better in life to do, but to work as a customer service provider in a mall. Many of these people often don't know much about the products that they're asked to sell, so I usually don't have much faith in getting any knowledge from them.

Usually, when I go to a mall to buy anything, rather than relying on their knowledge to give me informed suggestions I often conduct my own online "consumer's choices" kind of research before I embark on a journey to get the product I want with the least amount of communication possible with the staff. This bike technician was different.

He could identify the kind of bike that I was took to the shop (without having seen it or heard it before), and the moment he saw the problem, he could identify how to fix it within seconds. Well, you may think "what's hard about identifying what's wrong with the flat tire?" I thought so too, but he looked beyond the problem as it presented to us, but made sure that he looked, also, for the root causes of the problem.

As he tested the pumped tire in the sink to see where the air was being released from since there's no observable puncture on the tire, and that the tire could still be pumped which shouldn't be the case if the tire was punctured. Turned out the tire was okay, the problem wasn't that there's a puncture in the tire but that the air was leaking out through the thin crack on the side of the tire. He then processed to disassemble the back wheel of my bike into pieces.

My Brompton bike, I thought, had a complicated bike with a complicated gear system, but only until I saw this technician removed everything from the core spinning wheel of the back wheel one by one, placing them on the moving cabinet very systematically so that he would remember the sequence of which parts to be put back before which parts. For a bike that one had never seen before, and he was honest about that, I must admit that his skill was stunning, and was a joy to watch.

At the end, as opposed to replacing my inner tire, which would, by the rule book, be something that his boss would like him to do since that would mean the sports mall could sell the tire and charge for the labor of its staff, he decided to fix the tire for me using his own tool because he did not believe in "changing things that are still working?" He did that with astute precision, and with robust curiosity, as he was asking me about the bike and how it worked as he was working.

His retinas were fixated on the bike that he was working on, and everything about him was nothing less than what Sartre described in the body's gesture of the waiter in Café Les Deux Magots. I could almost prescribe the same descriptions that Sartre gave to this infamous waiter to this bike technician: He made me feel as though he was only a bike technician -- and not a free human being. His movement was quick -- a little too precise and a little too rapid.

He was alert and responded to my request a little too quick. He came to me almost too eagerly, and his eyes and his voice were a bit too solicitous. This bike technician probably thought of himself as being modeled after Michael Jordan of bicycle fixing, if there's such a sport. He was leaving no option for himself to be a freelance designer, a pianist, an artist, a philosopher.

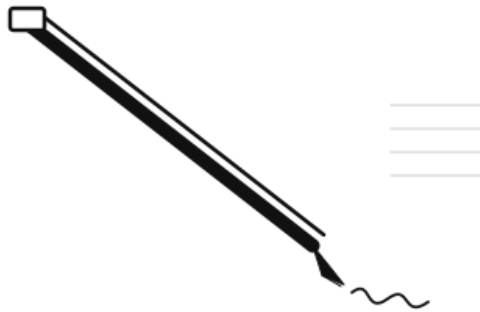
This bike technician, though, didn't fix my bike for money, and was not doing it because he couldn't think of other options he could possibly attain in his life. It's just that he couldn't think of his life otherwise. He offered me a full and honest service because he loved bicycles, and, as a bonus, I brought in a bike that made him curious. He himself was a biker and was always interested in learning more everyday about all possible kinds of bike in the world.

He told me that he enjoys coming to work because his job is a "dream job" -- he gets to fix bikes everyday which is what he likes. Can we say that this kind of person has a bad faith, Mr. Sartre?

DAY 24

On Riding a Train

Sun, 20 Jul 2025 00:00:00 +0000



I REALIZED, JUST NOW, THAT in my last post I ardently violated my own rule by writing more than 500 words. Well. There wasn't a rule or anything but I did mention that I would like to write fewer words ("fewer" by the way is correct here because "less" is used only with an uncountable noun), so that I could spend more time working on my dissertation, but I guess that I didn't happen especially when I was writing about something about which I wholehearted passionate.

I have to admit that I am a bit afraid that this post will be similar because, as the subject suggest, I'll be talking about my most favorite mode of transportation: riding a train. For the last two years, I have been taking trains to everywhere in China. With the extensive high-speed train network in China, traveling long distance by train has never been more pleasurable.

My first trip to Beijing in the summer of 2006, I still remember vividly, was from Shanghai on an overnight train that took more than 10 hours. I actually really liked the experience. In fact, long distance isn't a problem for me anymore: Shenzhen, Guangzhou, Hong Kong, Beijing? Twelve hours? Sixteenth hours? Even more? Bring it on. It all began last evening when my eyes were fixated on a half an hour NHK World documentary of locomotive train in Japan. It was, simply put, fascinating.

The setting of the show was in a cafe run by a railfan who decorates the entire place with model trains. So, in that cafe, the customers could enjoy their cups or coffee while looking at trains going around.

When I was in Japan with my mother in 2013 and happened to walk pass by a toy section at a department store in Tokyo, I couldn't help myself but to sit down with the children, who, with me, formed a group of trainwatchers vigorously watching a dozen of small model trains running around the tracks that was as big as a 5 meters by 5 meters room.

It might not be as strange -- these things do attract people -- if I'd only spent a couple of minutes there just like most of the normal people attracted by any running objects, but what happened was, turned out, that I was spending almost an hour there. In fact, had my mother not demanded that we leave, I would have stayed there for the entire day. There's something mesmerizing about watching train cars move.

There's something about trains moving on the rail tracks that always makes me feel pleasant, calm, and safe. Like Sheldon Cooper from the sitcom Big Bang Theory, I love taking the train. Period. Why? All I could recall is that there was one time when I was very young that, we as a family, traveled on the train from Bangkok down south to Malaysia together. That was my first trip outside of Thailand. I'll find photographs of that trip somehow and post them here later.

I was so young so it's hard to be sure how I felt about it, but the idea of sleeping on the train while it's moving has ever since become one of those things for which I always crave: not only was it efficient, but it also gave me the sense of being a traveler, adventurer, and explorer.

Since I am always curious about things about which I don't know much, being able to travel all over -- and experience the process of getting from Point A to Point B as it progresses -- to see and experience different things from different cultural spheres is what essentially makes my life more meaningful.

At some point I'll be writing about what I think makes life meaningful, but for now, it is the particular idea of being able to reach out to people, places, cultures that are not immediately connected to me is what makes me feel brand new.

Because I always like to do so, being able to spend time while I'm on a moving train to my destination give me the sense that I am not wasting even a second of my trip on anything since I am also moving forward even when I am sleeping. The other instance was in 2005 when I faced with a critical academic problem.

I was at MIT at the time and I was able to be kicked out from school because my academic performance then was so low -- too low for MIT to keep me even though I had a full scholarship to support my study. I had one C and two Bs, while the condition of being there was to maintain an average grade of B+. Long story short, I was this close to being kicked out of MIT.

So, what I decided to do was to take up the invitation to go down to New York City from Boston to attend a meeting with the folks at the Asian Cultural Council where I was also affiliated as a fellow that year.

Actually, there were the folks who sponsored my study at MIT, so I was mixed with the felling of guilt that I was about to let them down by being kicked out of MIT, and that I came down to NYC because I felt that this might be my last trip before I'd have to go back to Thailand because I was no longer needed in the US.

So, the folks there of course did not know that I may "drop out" of MIT and that the scholarship with which they provided me might have all gone to waste. So, I took the train down to NYC. For some reason, when I was on that train, I felt both free and carefree.

As the bucolic scenery changed as the train moved through different cities, I felt as if the problem that I was having wasn't that important, and that "it's okay even if, tomorrow, I get kicked out of school." Back then there wasn't an wi-fi on board or anything, so apart from a few books that I carried with me

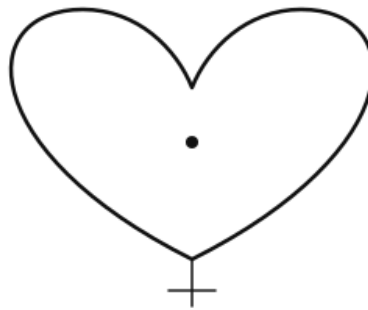
so that I could write a term paper for one of my classes while traveling, I didn't have anything else to keep me entertained.

Three hours passed so quickly, and I felt extremely clam and relaxed. The moment I arrived NYC Penn Station, I felt as if I had been renewed. I felt both refreshed, and revitalized. The moment of tranquility of which I had the opportunity to be a part pleased me deeply.

DAY 25

My Love Is Gone When I like How She Looks More Than Who She Is

Mon, 21 Jul 2025 00:00:00 +0000



I ONLY CARE ABOUT HOW I see myself, and not about how others see me. I have never been so clear on this before. In fact, I never understand why many people care so much about how they look, especially in photos. Around me there're so many people who are willing to spend a lot of time taking selfies, retouching them, and then posting them on social media platforms, with the hope that their photos will be liked and appreciated by others.

To make a long story short: I wonder how they have become so obsessed with how other people see them? And why is it something so important to their sense of being? I once knew a person who said to me that she "spent half an hour every morning putting on her makeup everyday as a form of respect to others." This, of course, also meant that she would be spending about almost equal amount of time removing them before going to bed.

I wondered what she meant so I asked her, and her response left me both enthralled and sympathetic.

"Most people, if not everyone, wants to see beautiful things, places, and people; so, if I can make myself beautiful, or at least 'not so unbearably ugly,' at least to their eyes, then I am expressing to them how much I respect

them." There are some good reasons in the way she thought about cosmetic, but, first of all, from whom did she arrive at the conclusion at "everyone wants to see beautiful things, places, and people?" My feeling is that it's her upbringing.

It could be her parents, her family member, or whoever surrounding her since she was young, who, since then, has been telling her that it's important to look good in front of other people. Fine. There's definitely some sorts of biological vis-a-vis cultural dimension to it -- I too try to shave whenever I can so I wouldn't look like a bear outside (since my bread generally grows very quickly).

But I didn't take it too far as to say that "for me to not looking like a bear is a way of expressing my respect to others." The second thing that seems problematic about having this kind of assumption is how exactly can one understand how other people see you? I, for once, do not like cosmetic ever since I was very young, mainly because it makes a person's skin looks as if there're layers of powder grazing on top of it.

As someone who is growing up in a very simple household with very simple material means, I regard, more than anything else, sincerity as a form of respect. So, as long as the person brushes her teeth, keep her hair straight and in place (as opposed to coming all over her face covering her eyes which I think is everyone's most beautiful window to the soul), and smile, she's beautiful. In fact, I like children simply because children are unpretentious.

They have yet to learn how to pretend in order to get what they want. They respect other people by being themselves, which I think is the most beautiful form of respect one can address to fellow human beings. That said, I am, of course not, not supportive of the thought that one should freely express one's own-self in every situation and circumstance.

In my earlier post in which I wrote about my cousin and her annoying unpretentious behavior, I wanted to say that although I like unpretentiality, there is a limit to what it could entail.

I would not accept unpretentious desires that encroach on other people's liberty, dignity, and sympathy (like what my cousin sometimes did to her family because she has yet to learn about how to be unpretentiously liberal, dignified, and sympathetic to other human beings -- so yes, I believe that we must both keep our faith in the good essence of human nature as well as meaningful nurturing techniques such as those that Rousseau wrote about in *Emile, Or on Education*).

But since we're talking about physical representation here, I'd like to stick to the notion of unpretentiality of the physical body. The less a person pretend to be someone -- or even something -- they are not, the more beautiful they are, because they're being beautiful from within. So, I find any comments on superficial beauty to be both meaningless and tasteless. I value the absolute beauty provided to us by nature and I enjoy how our physicality naturally change over time (aka, aging).

So, I also don't like to engage in any forms of discourse, speech, or verbal and non-verbal community pointing at how old or how young a person is. I don't care if someone think I look young or old, and I don't have time to even think about how young or old other people look both relative and non-relative to my look.

So, I always try to inform my colleagues whose friendships with me I hold dear to refrain from making any comments on how young or old they themselves or others look. I don't care about that, and I appreciate, always, the aesthetics of natural aging. Also needless to point out, don't get me started on my viewpoint on plastic surgery! Recently, right after I took a photo of a person I knew, she came right at my cameraphone and asked me if she could look at it.

At the moment she found the picture I took to be unpleasing to her sensibility, she asked me to delete it on the spot. I had to disagree because I thought the picture was lovely, and the smile of her in the photo was as enigmatic and pleasant as that of Mona Lisa. This was the verbatim defense of the photo that I took, but it in no way managed to convince her, so she

continued to insist that I get rid of it.

Photographs, to me, are more than just a two dimensional graphic memory of an event, person, place, etc., but also a record of my personal history. When I look at every photo that I took, I could recall to the very details of why and how I decided to take it, what was the motive behind composing it with a particular kind of framing, what was the dimension of aesthetics in which the poetic of such picture is located, and so on.

I can even recall the tension in my arms, neck, or parts of the body involved in the process (especially if the camera that I use is a professional one rather than a cameraphone). So, every photo has an imprint of my personal memory, integrity, and philosophy embedded. Every photo means that much to me.

The reason why I stop taking photos of other people is because I know that I will get annoyed when the person whose photographs I took ask to see the photos I just took, and, as in this case, then once that person (usually a girl) realizes that she doesn't look as good as she wants herself to look in my camera, she would ask me to delete the particular photos that she would claim aren't representative of and don't do justice to her appearance.

What happened in this case was that she tricked me to believe that I could trust her. She asked me if she could see "other photos" that I had taken in my camera. As you could probably guess, the moment I handed to her my cameraphone, the first thing she did was to find the photo of her that she did not like, and then, without my consent, deleted it.

I got so upset; the reason for which I have already expressed, and after that I have to remind myself every time that there're people in the world who only want to see themselves in a particular way, and if the photographic representations of them fall outside of how they expect them to be then no matter how historical and important such representations are, they must be destroyed. This incident raises two important questions for me. First, can I really deal with this kind of people? The answer is no.

I don't like superficiality -- in fact, I hate superficially -- and I never believe that the bodily, facially (and therefore superficially), and/or physical representation can tell us anything meaningful about a person. I like to see beautiful things, places, and people, but only for a short period of time because I know that once I become familiar with them I will no longer find them to be beautiful. So, I want something more than that -- something that stands the test of time.

I think the beauty of the nature has that quality, so does the beauty of good architecture because they naturally age. So, second, what should I do with them? One of my favorite movie of all time is *Shallow Hal*, which is a movie about a man named Hal (played by Jack Black) who fell in love with a girl -- truly because of who she is, and absolutely because how she looks.

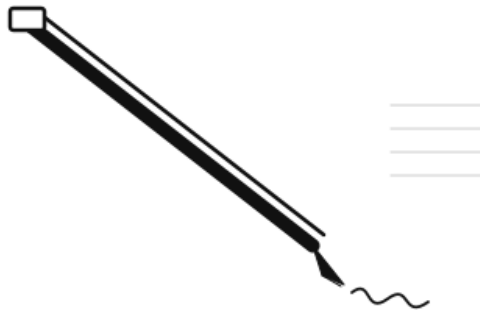
Because of his shallowness, treating beauty as the only important criteria for people whom he would date, Tony Robbins casts a spell on him: That spell makes him completely blind of the physical appearance, and makes him see only "how they are." So, in this movie, although Gwyneth Paltrow is an extremely obese woman, who in no way a shallow guy like Hal would ever want to be with if he sees the physical her, she is able to capture Hal's heart simply because she's the most wonderful person in the world; so, thanks to the spell, Hal sees her as the beautiful Gwyneth Paltrow rather than an obese woman.

I wish someone could come and cast that spell on me. I once said to a close friend of mine, "my love for a woman is completely gone when I like how she looks, more than who she is." I want to be with someone with whom I could feel at home when I am not at home, with someone who makes me feel she's most beautiful even if she does have the body to physically express it.

DAY 26

On Death

Tue, 22 Jul 2025 00:00:00 +0000



I BORROW THE TITLE OF this post from Montaigne, one of my favorite philosophers who is up there, for me, with Rousseau, Thoreau, and the Stoics. I have been thinking about death lately since the death of my father, which is more than five years ago now.

All the great writers and social psychologists are right: "we're all stronger than we think," and this wisdom is dated back to the 500 BCE with the Stoics who were the first to arrive at this golden wisdom about our humane capacity as human beings.

From a psychological perspective, our ability to predict the future is limited therefore it often leads us to think depressingly about life; however, there's also a good news, which is the fact that far better than our ability to prognosticate the future is our your ability to create it. Back then, I didn't think I could survive without having him around me, as I couldn't believe that someone could die that prematurely regardless of how illustrative his life may have been.

My father and I were very close, and therefore losing him at that time was losing everything for me. I regretted that I hadn't spent enough time with him because I had almost always been abroad during the last decade of his

life, and that I was busy with my own thing and therefore did not have time for him.

Because I was abroad and that I was so busy with my own things, our understanding of each other drifted apart, and therefore when we got to see each other, usually in the summer or during the winter breaks, we no longer talked about anything new but basically only talked about things in and of the past, such as stuff we did together when I was young and he was younger, our favorite hobbies, and so on.

The generation gap was wide, but what was much wider was the ideological gap since at the time I had been educated abroad for a few years already which, as I wrote in the previous posts, my perspective on society had changed drastically because of the experience being away from the conservative home base on Thailand. Since he passed away I have been much more aware of the fact that death is closer than we think.

It could happen anytime to me and to anyone whom I love and care about. So, to live a life, in a way, is to prepared to die, although not in a literal sense. To prepare to die, I think, is to understand the nature of things, and to live our lives in such a way that leaves no room for regret once we can no longer exist in this particular registry (as we don't know what will happen to us in the after life registry).

What has happened to me since has been that I have become much more prepared to talk about death, to see it as another thing that life provides us with, just like birth, growing old, getting sick, and so on, and to understand it as the end goal of life rather than an unexpected event that happens just to take away our faith, our hope and our sensibility. Death is the debt that we all pay. How do we make it a productive debt, rather than an NPL?

The other day I watched a short video clip about how a woman got killed by a bus, as she was pushed underneath its wheels by a car whose driver carelessly opened the driver's door without looking first whether it was clear for him to do so.

What happened was that, in less than one second that followed, the woman felt out of the motorbike on which she was riding, her head then went down between the front and the back wheels of the running public bus and therefore got crushed immediately stopping her pulse right on the spot. I was frightened by the news. This was one of those events that certainly makes many think about life differently.

Upon hearing this news I paused, stopped whatever I was doing (I may have been reading at the time) just to think about how would I respond to this if this person was someone that I knew. I have heard of how people could die so suddenly before, but what was different from this particular incident was how choreographic it was. The whole thing happened as if someone choreographed it.

At the beginning, There was a careless driver, whatever he was thinking then that made him want to open the door so suddenly knowing that he was on the driver's seat and therefore his door would swing outwards to the road. Then, there was a victim who suffered from such carelessness.

She "happened" to be on the motorbike that "happened" to be right there, at the moment when that door was just about to be open, and therefore she didn't have enough time to stop her motorbike or to make a sudden turn to prevent herself from being pushed underneath the bus by the door. Had she been one-tenth of a second faster than that she might be able to get through without any accident.

Had she been one-tenth of a second slower than that she might hit the driver, or the door, or both, but she would probably not being knocked over to the side, and therefore unfortunately got underneath the bus. Had she been one second slower, nothing might happen at all, as she would perhaps be able to stop her motorbike right before it would hit the driver or the car's door, and by the time her motorbike had completely stopped the bus would have passed them.

Want might she be thinking about when she was on that motorbike? Maybe she wasn't thinking about anything. Maybe she was listening to her favorite tune on the radio, and thinking about another good day ahead of her. Maybe she was thinking about her family, and what she would like to cook for them.

Or, maybe she felt completely about her life because she had been working so hard to support the family, and had a quick thought that "if everything could end right now, I may be happier." Whatever she was thinking, she didn't get to think it through. Suddenly, before her thought crystallized, she got pushed aside, and by the time she felt between the bus' wheel she could no longer anticipate her fate one-tenth of a second afterwards.

The whole thing might be too abrupt and too fast for her brain to process; so, before she could gather enough information to know what was happening, the life had gone off. This made me think of how Zoe Barnes was killed by Frank Underwood in the second season of *House of Cards*.

This event just showed how fragile life is and can be, and how we should think about it as such, because no matter how strong we think we are, which might be true, at the end of the day there's a physiological limit to how much we could maintain our biological being. In a situation like this, you probably wouldn't even get to think about anything, let alone the meaning of life.

I had always been under the impression that we, all of us, would at least have the chance to think about the meaning of life -- suppose when we're on our dead beds. But even that, after having watched this clip, would be something rather luxury to expect from life. I used to think that at least we would get to say good bye.

Not only did this woman not only have a chance to say goodbye to her loved ones, but she also did not have the opportunity, even, to think about what she was facing. It's too quick, and that was it. It's all over. P.S. I'd like to dedicate this post to Prof. Nicholas Tapp, a renowned anthropologist and a specialist in the study of the Hmong, who had been Distinguished Professor

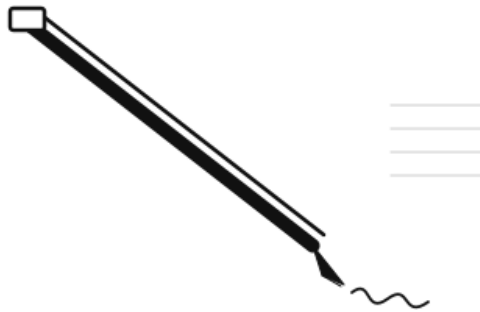
and Director of the Research Institute of Anthropology at East China Normal University since 2010. Prof.

Tapp passed away due to illness on October 10, 2015 at the Shanghai Huashan Hospital. He was 63 years old. I only met him briefly twice in the last two years as we overlapped at two anthropological conferences here in Shanghai. I was thinking about visiting him at the hospital in the summer. I sincerely didn't think that he would pass away. Prof. Tapp has left us with his illustrious legacy and fruitful scholarship that all of us could try to assimilate.

DAY 27

Cicero, On Aging

Wed, 23 Jul 2025 00:00:00 +0000



I FIND FOUR REASONS WHY old age appears to be unhappy: first, that it withdraws us from active pursuits; second, that it makes the body weaker; third, that it deprives us of almost all physical pleasures; and, fourth, that it is not far removed from death. Let us, if you please, examine each of these reasons separately and see how much truth they contain. -- Marcus Tullius Cicero (AKA Cicero, 106-43 B.C.) in *De Senectute* (On Old Age) written in 44 B.C.

I begin this post with this timeless wisdom of Cicero, who, despite this pessimistic opening of his little book called *De Senectute* (originally translated as *On Old Age*, although the newest translation of the book by Princeton University Press has renamed it to *How to Grow Old*, which, well, is a fair enough title), would in fact, come around to debunk the hollowness of getting old. He, at the end of the book, would remind us of the charm of getting old.

One of which -- spoiler alert -- is that we would be free from the desire to engage in sexual activities. While many fellow Romans of Cicero thought of aging as the embarrassing end of manhood, Cicero thought of it as a gift.

"Alas," said the great man Cicero, "I could be free from the naturalistic instinct that has for many years chained me to the unproductive anxiety...and now I can be free from it to do more important things, say, thinking and writing." That's just one of his "three golden teachings," which, needless to say, resonates with me most deeply: When can I actually be free from the natural impulse to want to have sex?!?! Damn it!

(For those who has been reading this blog for a while, the last installment of the On Sex Trilogy has yet to be written). We'll come back to the other two teachings Cicero has taught us more than two millennia ago. Cicero himself has been known more as a statement -- the master of political thinking that inspired generations of philosophers especially during the Enlightenment -- and less as a philosopher. But he was a philosopher.

His thinking on aging is almost the same as that of Confucius who had famously written the world's shortest but most elegant piece of autobiography: At 15, I set my heart on learning. At 30 I know where I stand. At 40, I have no more doubts. At 50, I know the will of Heaven. At 60 my ears are attuned. At 70, I follow my heart's desire without crossing the line.

-- Confucius, as recorded by his deciples in the Analects So, I am going to weave my reading of Cicero with my own take on the morality of aging here. It's going to be pretty hard for me to pinpoint which is my own thought and which is his as I think my original take on aging is quite similar to his already.

The reason for which is that I have seen my father aged and I have seen how he had coped with it -- both elegantly and clumsily -- and I have derived my understanding of aging from such a direct, intimate, and painful experience living, for 28 years, with the man whom I loved the most. Personally, I think of aging as an absolutely exciting thing. It is the process that, while moving us closer to death, also enables us to experience our body differently. Who wouldn't want that?

-- the ability to feel that a certain thing could have different sensible meanings to us every day in our life? Sounds pretty awesome, don't you

think? Do you remember when you read the same book and you find something interesting you didn't find the first time that you read it? The same also applies to films, places, things, and etc. It's because our body has changed, so has our mind, therefore in every thing we see we see more depths to it.

I once wondered whether or not my gold fish would be so bored swimming in a small little bowl his entire life, until one day when my veterinarian friend managed to tell me that gold fish have very short memory (like, very very short) so, no, they will never get bored with anything because they'll excited with everything they see again and again, and again. At the moment, I thought to myself: wouldn't it be nice if we're all like that?

Then, we wouldn't have to go out of our way, like what we're doing every day, to make our life more exciting, more purposeful, more meaningful. We could just stay at home and wait for our memory of everything around us to be automatically refreshed every once in a while. Wallah, everything is new and exciting again! Fine. You might not be convinced by my concise propaganda here yet, so let me try again. What got me thinking about aging is a conference on eldercare in which I just participated.

Our body is changing everyday. From a physiological perspective, nothing in our body remains the same after a few weeks -- in every moment of our life, all the cells renew themselves, allowing our body to be reshaped into a slightly different form. In this sense, both Lord Buddha and David Hume were right to say that there is no self.

The more we try to find the essence of the self, the more we find nothing, since even the very basic underpinning of the physiological self is never in a static state that we can pin point what it is. Our body is changing stably, but it's by no means permanent or static. Because this process of cell-changing gets repeated on a momentarily basis, we human beings, as the masters of the physiological bodies, are also being changed as well.

Aging to me is an exciting process because we are living in a different body every day, and therefore this different body allows me to experience new things every day as well, even though the experience itself may not seem to be that different from what I had experienced in the past.

Like I said, it could be the we're the reading the same book, but because our body has changed, our understanding of the contents of the book has changed, and so on, every time we read the same book we often learn something new from it. In other words, we're like the gold fish, in the sense that we actually never get to read the same book again. The problem here is how to let our self-fulfilling bias overpower the fact that we are changing.

So, for instance, how do we keep our egotistical feeling "I have read that book and therefore I don't need to read it again -- it's always going to be the same book" at bay.

What I usually do is to tell myself, "Dude, remember, since the body is changing all the time, any experience we have of anything is never the same." Eating (and perhaps licking and messily playing with) a cone of ice cream when I was a kid kinda felt differently from eating it properly as an adult. My physical body has changed, so has my mind, and my way of thinking.

Aging, therefore, gives me the sense of constant renewal of the agents that dictate my experience of the physical world and therefore my sensibility. This is precisely the reason why I don't think getting old is a fearful thing. Every day when I get up in the morning, I feel thankful for having another day in a life.

A few good friends of mine passed away prematurely; therefore, when I feel thankful for myself for having another day to age, I feel thankful for having known those who passed even though for only a short period of time. Because aging and death and related, we tend to think of aging as something we'd rather avoid thinking of it, talking about it, or even mentioning it.

In fact, we sometimes ridicule those who are older than us especially when we think they could have done much more with their lives. "Look, he's 60 and

he's still an ordinary staff of a company XX." I have the opposite feeling about aging, as I have laid out my argument here. Because I don't even know whether I'd live to see myself in my 60s, I am, instead of thinking of them of being unsuccessful people, admiring them for having lived, sustained their lives, that long.

Of course, I'd like to live longer than my father who passed away in his early 60s, but the only thing that I know is that there's no way I could know what the future may bring. We are obsessed with wanting to be successful, and with the said abhorrence against aging, we tend to admire those who become so successful when they are yet to be considered old by societal standards, which, I think, also makes no sense -- simply because we don't know what the future may bring.

Society always pushes us against our will. For instance, I have been ridiculed by many for having spent so many years in school and still don't have a proper career, or a stable (married) life. People compare me to younger social scientists who are much more successful than I am at my current age.

All I have to say is that, I can only agree that people who know what they want early on in their lives therefore don't have to waste a lot of time figuring out the best path to walk on are admirable -- they are lucky beings, unlike myself, who have taken so many detours in life simply because I didn't have the privilege to get access to the information that would have allowed me to know much early on in life about what I really want and what really matters.

A wonderful colleague of mine had worked very hard his entire childhood, precisely to be respected and admired for having done and succeeded so much at such a young age, and then he died prematurely by a tragic traffic accident.

I don't think he regretted that which very much because he was, indeed, a successful person, but as I know him personally to be a family man, I have a feeling that if he could he would have traded his short successful life, with a longer simply and meaningful life with his family. By this, I also don't think

that "looking old" should be something to be ashamed of. Here's when the second teaching of Cicero may add some depths to my argument.

He said that getting old -- and looking old -- reminds us of our responsibility to give our attention to something beyond just the body. A much greater care is due to the mind and soul. It is the time when how you look may no longer attract the wrong kinds of people to your life.

Your attraction and your contribution will solely be your mind and soul, and that which, though may not be as appealing at first, is what Cicero believes to be the truest reward one could get in life. I like telling people how old I am. I like to admit that I may look older than my actual age, even though I am skeptic about these kinds of aesthetic standards. Who has the right to say that this or that person look older or younger than his or her counterparts anyway?

Whoever would like to make a comment like that must be, at least, sort of certain that he or she has seen a large number of people -- large enough to make a judgement call whether a person looks older or younger than his/her peers. In my life, I have not seen someone who could sensibly make that call -- simply because there are too many people in the world for anyone to be able to make an informed generalization about how one should look at a certain age.

In addition, why does it even matter? In line with my post two days ago, I believe that it doesn't matter how old a person may look, as long as he or she is healthy. The healthiness from within is gold. So, I both condemn and abhor people who do not feel the sense of absurdity when they make senseless comments like, "you look so old," or "I look younger than you" for the said reasons.

I believe that I have learned this very aesthetics of aging from my father, who never dyed his hair in his entire life no matter how grey it looked. My father was always proud of how mature of looked, and how graceful, as a mature man, he was. I had to agree.

When I was young, I often made fun of my father (well, I could, since we're close but most people thought of my father as a scary person of whom they would never dare of making fun) by saying that his face was full of wrinkles. To my surprise, he always smiled when he heard me said so. I never quite understood because whenever I said that kind of things to anyone else, often they looked with me unpleasingly (surprise, surprise).

Quite the opposite, he always liked the way he looked. He, more than anything else, loved the unretouched photos of himself, and enjoyed comparing his photos taken years apart. Not only was he not unhappy to look old, but he was proud of being old. Only until he passed that I gradually realized that he was using his life to teach me the beauty of growing old, becoming mature, and aging.

So, I am turning 34 in a few days, and I want to live as long as I could live in a healthy body. With the healthy body, I could think maturely, and age beautifully. I always think that people who are always worried about how they look are people who never lose someone they truly love.

When you have lost someone that important to you, you will change -- you will become much more sensitive to what really matters to you, and not superficial things such as how they look. 10 out of 10 people who have made comments about how old other people look (or how young they think they look) that I met still have their parents living in the world with them.

Because they have never lost someone they unconditionally love (assuming that it's their parents), they could only think about the world in a limited way -- like the hunchbacks in Plato's cave. My father was only in his early 60s when he passed away. He wasn't that old, and I never thought he looked that old. I, at least, want to live as long as he did, and have a life as meaningful as his.

I like that when we become old our body also change to represent the fact that we become wiser, more mature, and more experienced. I always admire people who age beautifully. The first time I heard about the ancient Japanese

philosophy called wabi-sabi, which literally means "imperfect, impermanent, and incomplete," I thought to myself that was it -- that's my philosophy.

I was 18 at the time and in on way I thought of myself then as less than a "perfect human being." I was immature, hot-tempered, and egotistical -- these were the factors that made me think that I was a perfect human being. I was not. I was not even close to even being one-tenth perfect as a student, let alone as a human being.

All I could say is that I was a young man (kind of good-looking as well) with a rather successful academic life (as an undergraduate at a technical college in Thailand). Like many immature people, I was proud of how young I looked, and I went around ridiculing sad people for their old-looking faces and bodies, as well as their unsuccessful lives.

It may sound strange that I would be bought into this philosophy that celebrates cracks on the vest, wrinkles on the face, signs of worn clothes, defections on the wooden surface, dent at a corner at a laptop, and so on. The moment I discovered wabi-sabi, I became a changed man. This philosophy appreciates marks that time, space, experience, and weather leave behind.

Unlike many, I actually like the worn marks on my smartphone, because when I look at it I'd know exactly what had happened to it, what happened when those mark appeared on the surface of my smartphone, and "who was I" when that happened. Of course, as a self-proclaimed Ruskinian Art and Craft connoisseur, I appreciate the art and craft of every object, so I wouldn't no out of my way to create marks on my object intentionally just to make them look worn and therefore wabi-sabi oriented.

In fact, that would defeat the whole purpose of such profound philosophy (so, I almost punched a man who stupidly challenged me with his mindless brain, "why don't you throw your phone a few more times onto the ground then, so that it would look more wabi-sabily cracked"). I appreciate things the way they are, and enjoy them equally when they get old. Wabi-sabi

celebrates the raw beauty of Gandalf The Gray, rather than the significantly more powerful and eye-pleasing Gandalf The White.

As an architect, I appreciate how wabi-sabi teaches me to appreciate the elegance of an aging building in a natural landscape. The third teaching of Cicero about aging is that age is not a barrier to remaining engaged with life.

Like Gandalf The White, and like many intellectuals whom we all admire, being free from the burden to "look good" through the spectacles and to be "sexually active" just to fulfill the bodily desire that you simply cannot have any control over, we shall have more time to be intellectually, physically, and socially engaged with the community of true friends.

When Confucius said that "at 70, I follow my heart's desire without crossing the line," what he meant was that he had arrived at the stage where he could truly be himself. Yes, he might not have a lot time left to enjoy as people during his time did not get to live very long, but life, to him, was never about quantity but quality.

Wouldn't you say that a year of blissful travel is more meaningful than a decade-long of repetitive, tedious, and alienating work for which you have nothing to remember? An old body, at the same time, expresses attributes related to the sense of decay, fatigue, and mortality -- all of which are both unavoidable, and should not be avoided. We should welcome them with open arms.

In fact, I like my photos that show the wrinkles on my face -- they are the signs of my experienced life, and they're the marks of my spent living sensibilities. I will look older every day, but that's exciting, and all I hope for is that I age beautifully as well -- meaning that I will look older and older with more and more wrinkles that are expressive of who I am and what I do.

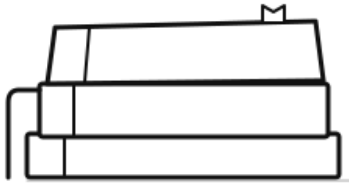
I am a naturalist in the sense and I am very proud of it. People in today's world are obsessed with looking young which, as I also criticized in my last post, is something I categorically abhor since it is also deeply superficial. I think it's a true waste of time to try to photoshop your photos so that you'd

look younger to other people's eyes. Let's get back to who we are, let's wabi-sabi, and let's remove all of the superficial facades from our lives.

DAY 28

I Was Just Lucky

Thu, 24 Jul 2025 00:00:00 +0000



IN MY YOUNGER AND MORE vulnerable years my father gave me some advice that I've been turning over in my mind ever since. "Whenever you feel like criticizing any one," he told me, "just remember that all the people in this world haven't had the advantages that you've had." That's the first two quotes from F. Scott Fitzgerald's *The Great Gatsby*. It's a great novel that has inspired many. To be (more) honest (than usual), I have not finished reading the book, but I have watched the film.

The reason for quoting F. Scott Fitzgerald above is to point to what I really believe in, which is the fact that while I think that I have a lot of privileges to have the opportunities to learn so much from so many great people, those privileges aren't advantages with which I was born. It was during my "my younger and more vulnerable years" that I realized that I had to work for those privileges. Many have asked me about how I got to where I am now.

It seems that my education background is checkered in, luckily, an interesting way. I sometimes look back and think about how many things I have gone through to get here.

There are some truths in the claim that my background is interesting: Not many people in the world have attended Harvard, MIT, and Oxford -- all with

full scholarships -- let alone someone like me, an ordinary student from a developing country on the far side of Southeast Asia who barely spoke English and was without any knowledge of western thoughts when he entered MIT in 2004.

There have been many versions of myths floating around about me being a genius, a person with the photographic memory, a special one, an outlier, which the famous (and my favorite) author Malcolm Gladwell describes as: "Outlier" is a scientific term to describe things or phenomena that lie outside normal experience. I'm interested in people who are outliers --in men and women who, for one reason or another, are so accomplished and so extraordinary and so outside of ordinary experience that they are as puzzling to the rest of us.

I may be an outlier, but I was not a genius or a special one. I wasn't even that good as a student when I was young -- in fact, I never was a good student if you look at my GPA. In fact, I find it difficult to memorize things, so I could only wish that I had the photographic memory. And the list goes on.

So, today, I'd like to sit down, reflect, and write about how and why I think I was able to obtain a few precious academic opportunities. I was lucky -- that's for sure. In my earlier posts, I discussed my childhood and how I was always different from other kids in the way I saw everything around me. I was regarded by most of my teachers as the "troubled kid" who couldn't come to grip with his role as a student.

Surprisingly, I also thought of those teachers as not living up to their honorable title. So, you could probably guess that my relationship with them didn't go very well throughout my career as a Thai student in the 80s and especially in the 90s when I was coming of age and becoming to formulate my own way of thinking which turned out to be even more radical and Socratic than when I was a kid.

I may be lucky to have been supported by the right people later on, but surely there had to be some other things that had been helping me, which I believe

was my own willingness to stick to my gun until the very end and not give up that easily in things that I believe to have done right. Let me take the opportunity to write something short to demystify those myths about me. Let me say it loud and clear: I am just a truly ordinary person.

How did I get into MIT then? In other words, how did an ordinary architecture student from a third-grade technical college in Thailand get admitted to one of the world's most prominent institutions to learn about western theories and architecture and urban design with a full scholarship? The short answer is that "I was prepared to go to MIT" from the first day of my student life as an ordinary student from a technical college.

The long story, let me share with you anyway, begins with the fact that I wasn't quite fit in at the technical college in Thailand where I spent six years learning how to be an architect. I never liked how the teaching was done there: the system was highly hierarchical. Teachers thought of themselves as being above the students, and therefore, we students must listen to them.

I didn't like that way of teaching, which was the reason why fifteen years later when I got to teach my own students I basically did everything that I thought those teachers could have provided us students with, such as giving us the freedom to think, nurturing mutual respect, and fostering collegiality. Questioning the contents of what they taught, their authority, and/or their morality as teachers were not only prohibited but could also quickly make you widely unpopular.

I ended up there because I spent my last year of high school in the US, so I didn't have the knowledge in various academic subjects to compete with hard-working Thai students in getting into the top Thai universities through a rigorous university entrance examination.

I could have stayed in the US and enrolled in a college there, but because I thought I had had it then, and that it was too expensive to study there (and that my family, though wasn't that poor, wouldn't be able to support me), and that I also wanted to return to Thailand to be with my family, especially my

father who wasn't in good health, I decided to return to Thailand.

By doing so, I could only choose a low-ranked technical college to enroll, and there I was at this technical college where throughout my six years there I felt as though I was the odd one out every single day. There're a few instances where I was genuinely curious, so I posed a few questions to the teachers, which I thought was a legitimate thing to do as an attentive student. But I was wrong.

The teachers felt as if I was challenging them, and therefore showing the sign that I was rebelliously not respecting them. So, not only did they shut me off with their abrasive shouting (abrasive even when they shouted in Thai, which is a pretty polite language), but they also made sure that I would never ask them any questions again by making sure that all my classmates also thought that I was the odd one out. These teachers made sure that I was embarrassed in front of my classmates.

In addition, these teachers also made sure that if I ever asked them any questions again, not just me but the entire class my would be punished. Ever since I stopped asking my teachers in that technical college any questions.

I wasn't sure whether they really did not know the answers to my question (which was fine, actually, as we could help each other out -- just because someone is a teacher doesn't mean he/she has to know everything) or they simply did not want me to challenge them by anything and in any ways.

But in the context and in the setting, all I could do, in order to protect myself from being (physically) hurt by my classmates who thought I was responsible for making the teachers upset, was to retreat and accept that condition as an authoritarian state as such.

These teachers reminded me, every chance they had, that I was an ordinary student, that my idea was not special, that I had questions for them because I was, plainly and simply, stupid, and not because they were not able to provide me with reasonable knowledge.

After a year of being suppressed by these teachers, there were many many moments that I thought to myself that "I may be just an ordinary, stupid, and worthless student." My academic ability may not be that great -- but that was precisely because I never got any answer from the teachers why did I need them for!

So, what happened then was that a student who wanted a reason to learn like me became an outcast, stigmatized, and bullied by the people up in the hierarchy, as well as the people who believed in it. This, of course, was not true -- not just in my case but also in most cases in the world.

The world's foremost expert on education Sir Ken Robinson has made in very clear in his legendary TedTalk which I think everyone should watch: Academic ability, which has really come to dominate our view of intelligence, because the universities designed the system in their image. If you think of it, the whole system of public education around the world is a protracted process of university entrance.

And the consequence is that many highly-talented, brilliant, creative people think they're not, because the thing they were good at at school wasn't valued, or was actually stigmatized. And I think we can't afford to go on that way. Similar to many developing countries', the problem with our education back then was quite severe. My classmates didn't know why they were there.

All they knew was that they had to be in college in order to get a degree, and once they had their diplomas they could get paid and have a life. I wasn't like that. I never was like that. If I wanted to do something, there must be either something rather deeply emotional that compels me to do it (e.g., biking), or something rather reasonable that could convince me that it has a long-term benefit or an ethical value by which I could morally live my life.

In the rural setting of my technical college, it's easy for any of us to feel both lonely and solitary, so many of my classmates got together to form social groups and do many things together such as playing soccer, smoking, drinking, playing guitar, and so on.

I was never good at playing any sports, let alone a team sport that requires such a high-leveled skill such as soccer, and I never liked to drink or smoke that much because I grew in a lower masterclass family so we didn't have the disposable income to entertain ourselves with cigarettes and alcohol.

As I was already an odd one out who made teachers upset with my insatiable curiosity, the fact that I didn't like any of the activities that my classmates had formed groups to do did make my classmates feel even worse about my presence in that place.

I felt as though it's a complete misunderstanding on their part, but the fact that I just came back from the US and therefore had some outlooks on life that may seem a little bit more mature than theirs did not help me to be liked by my classmates, most of whom did not speak a word of English and had never left Thailand. So, they thought of me as being "lofty" without even knew me.

They never asked me how I got to go abroad for high school, otherwise, I would have told them that I worked very hard to get a scholarship to go there, and once I was there I also worked very hard to sustain myself financially by doing part-time work whenever I had the chance. They, somehow, all thought that my parents were filthy rich therefore I could go abroad, which was something that I could only wish was true.

Anyway, there, they thought that I didn't want to participate in their activities because I didn't like them -- they thought that I didn't think they were good enough for me -- which was not true. I learned this from one of my close friends, who told me that this was the collective attitude of my classmates toward me, which, as soon as I heard about, I tried as hard as I could to change.

I tried, and tried, and tired, to tell them that I, simply and personally, didn't like the activities that they wanted me to do with them -- not them. I liked them because I didn't have any reasons to not like them. But because I sucked at sports, and I didn't want to smoke or drink (because I was also bad

at those) I thought that I could, simply, exercise my freedom by not taking part in them. I didn't harm anyone by doing that, did I?

I thought that was entirely my choice, but apparently I was wrong. Majority ruled, and gradually, I got downgraded from the being just odd one out to being the "person nobody wanted to talk to." gradually, my classmates stopped talking to me. They also stopped informing me about anything important whether it be about school matters, homework, and etc. They would just cut me off completely.

It may have been better if they would dismissively treat me as if I did not exist, but what they did was much worse: they belittled me, sabotaged my work and my reputation, ridiculed everything that I ever did, and spread all kinds of rumors about me to those who did not even know me so that they would not want to get to know me.

So, in less than a year, I became a friendless person. I didn't have anyone to talk to, and I always ate my lunch alone in the canteen. So, there's nothing I could do about it, so I decided to spend time where I believed I could feel at home. That place was the library. It happened to be the case that the school had two very good libraries with many good English books.

It happened to be the case that the school had a long history of ordering awesome foreign books (whoever was behind that "head librarian" desk must have been an awesome being); most of which remained almost untouched in the libraries for generations because the students had never been interested in reading them.

Well, I didn't have any friends, so I began to go to the two libraries that I had identified to have a collection of books in which I was interested, good lighting, and good air conditioning system, right after class, and just read. I found myself at ease, and at home in the comfort of the library space: There was no one to bully me, and it was the place that I could find answers to everything with which the teachers did not want to enlighten me.

Soon, I began to spend more than half of day waking hours there. I remember going to class from 10am to noon and then rushing over to one of the two libraries that had extensive art and architecture collection where I would spend the next 6-8 hours in until it closed at 8pm. For six years, that was my routine. I believe that I may have read every single English book in art and architecture that were available in Thailand then.

Although my spoken English wasn't good, having read more than a thousand books (some of which were key texts in western theories of architecture) I was comfortable with the English language. I began to write emails (back then emails were still pretty new) to professors abroad, and to online friends around the world discussing issues and topics in which I was interested.

I began to, on a regular basis, write emails to different schools of architecture abroad asking them about what their students read there, and then I would return to the libraries to see whether or not we also had those books so that I could satisfy my interest in learning something new the same way that the students in the top schools of architecture in the US such as MIT, Harvard, and Berkeley were learning.

In those five to six years, I must have spent more than 3,000 hours at the libraries, simply, reading, learning, and being enlightened by the same knowledge that the cutting-edge schools around the world were also learning. I never quite understood why a technical college like that would have such a great access to some of the most amazing library resources. That said, this was precisely what happened to Bill Gates: Gates was fortunate to attend Lakeside, a private school in Seattle with its own computer.

Back then, a very few schools in the entire world had a computer. The Lakeside machine was one of a new generation of computers that shared processing power with a much larger computer downtown...Gates had thousands of hours of programming under his belt, making him perfectly prepared to take maximum advantage of the PC revolution.

After having read Malcolm Gladwell's *Outliers* that I began to feel that, perhaps, this very special opportunity that was made available to me was the true essence of what made me "an outlier." Why was that I was the only one in the history of my technical college to study architecture at MIT? Since I also went to MIT almost directly after having graduated from there, there was no other achievements or endorsements from anyone or anything to serve as an evidence that I was worth it.

Those libraries were there. Someone must have ordered those great books hoping that some students would benefit from them. That said, I barely saw anyone at any of the libraries. Thailand, then, had very low literacy rate both in the rural areas and among students of higher educational institutions. Students barely read anything. Soon, reading became my habit -- a behavioral pattern that shaped who I was and what psychologists often refer to as character and personality.

In his greatest work, *The Principles of Psychology*, William James unpacks the very mythical notion of habit -- that it is not just something that we could conveniently treat as a given, but something to persistently learn, telling us how we might be able to live a richer moral life.

Strange enough, although I studied for years at Harvard in a building called "William James Hall," I had never felt the urge to find out more about who he was and why was he so important that someone would name a building after him. It was not until my mentor Professor Arthur Kleinman recommended that I began to I rediscovered his work -- bringing back the joy of spending time reading in the library that I had had a decade ago.

In the chapter called "Habit," William James writes: Habit is thus the enormous fly-wheel of society, its most precious conservative agent. It alone is what keeps us all within the bounds of ordinance, and saves the children of fortune from the envious uprisings of the poor. It alone prevents the hardest and most repulsive walks of life from being deserted by those brought up to tread therein.

It keeps the fisherman and the deck-hand at sea through the winter; it holds the miner in his darkness, and nails the countryman to his log-cabin and his lonely farm through all the months of snow; it protects us from invasion by the natives of the desert and the frozen zone.

It dooms us all to fight out the battle of life upon the lines of our nurture or our early choice, and to make the best of a pursuit that disagrees, because there is no other for which we are fitted, and it is too late to begin again. My classmate barely read anything. That is, they did not have the opportunity to develop reading into their habit. In fact, if you read too much, your classmates would also think of you as a nerd and therefore would bully you.

Growing up in a conservative society such as Thailand was not easy, but I was so lucky to be able to find my own little space in the libraries. I was so lucky that at least I had those books to turn to. While many fellow outcasts of mine turned to drugs, gambling, and prostitution, and therefore became excruciatingly misled to a wrong path, I at least had a space to be myself. And I actually really enjoyed it. I really liked reading.

I eventually became friends with the librarians who would sometimes extend the opening hours of the libraries for me, or allowed me to check out more books than my quota because they knew that I was serious about studying. I mean, had I liked to play soccer, drinking, and smoking, I probably wouldn't want to go to libraries to read anything neither.

I guess I was lucky that my classmates did not encourage me to be a part of their groups, and also did not bother me as much when they saw that I was doing something else that could in no way inflict any harm on them.

So, now that I am looking back, I must have read every canonical text in architecture, art, and design, which was the reason why when I wrote my application to both the Fulbright Foundation and MIT, I was able to convince them that "I was prepared" to tackle the new challenges abroad.

In the sense, William James is right to point out that in thinking about adopting something as your habit, you must into account the right intention,

as it is the only factor that matters in the psychological development of a moral being. Not all habit is good and moral. Some habits are simply meaningless. Some might even be harmful to the society.

I'd like to also quote him again (I love William James by the way): The first is that in the acquisition of a new habit, or the leaving off of an old one, we must take care to launch ourselves with as strong and decided an initiative as possible.

Accumulate all the possible circumstances which shall re-enforce the right motives; put yourself assiduously in conditions that encourage the new way; make engagements incompatible with the old; take a public pledge, if the case allows; in short, envelop your resolution with every aid you know. This will give your new beginning such a momentum that the temptation to break down will not occur as soon as it otherwise might; and every day during which a breakdown is postponed adds to the chances of its not occurring at all.

I wasn't discouraged by the situation, as I had the habit that I held dear. Reading was the cradle of my being. I did not have to rely on anyone's else when I knew I could always turn to reading by just walking to the library. Sometimes I would take a bunch of books home with me if I couldn't finish the books by which I was so engrossed by the time that the library was closing.

The librarian who knew me well would help me checking out those books even though it was already past her shift. I also developed the habit of being a book lover: I tolerated no acts that could damage any books. If I wanted to mark a page, I would use a bookmark -- I wouldn't fold the top of the page. If I wanted to highlight something, I'd make a photocopy of that page first, and then highlighted the photocopied page.

These were just a few habits that were developed as my love for books progressed. There, in situ, I also developed a friendly and personal relationship with all of the librarians, as well as student interns who worked

there (and this is precisely the reason why I really respect librarians -- and when I see bad librarians who don't care about books, all I want to do is to make them disappear from the face of the earth).

I couldn't have human friends, true, but that did not mean I could be friends with books. Fine. Books can't interact with you the same way humans do, but at least, you know, I worked with what I had. Here I'd like to return to Malcolm Gladwell, who said: When outliers become outliers it is not just because of their own efforts.

It's because of the contributions of lots of different people and lots of different circumstances— and that means that we, as a society, have more control about who succeeds—and how many of us succeed—than we think. That's an amazingly hopeful and uplifting idea. So, what's the lesson here? I don't think I would be where I am now if I was not being an outcast in the community of students that I happened to be placed.

I may have to thank those bad teachers and immature classmates who did not give me the opportunity to develop myself into the negative habit of judging the book by its cover as they did. Also, I was lucky that my parents were not financially well-off. Had I had the financial means, I would have moved myself from that school to another school, probably in the US.

Honestly, there were, of course, days that I felt so miserable that I could end my life because of the situation that I was in. I was 17, and at the age, there was no reason for anyone to want to make me an outcast. Bullying was a bad thing, regardless how we might frame it, but as it happened to me on a daily basis -- simply because I wanted to ask some questions to the teachers? And that I wasn't good at soccer?

Just because I didn't like to smoke?

(and I never enjoyed smoking until later when I was in the UK -- that said, I had quit now!) In fact, I remember that one of my teachers then even told me, "Non, you have to learn to smoke and drink -- don't study too much -- otherwise, you'll have no friends, and then you'll have no future in the field of

architecture." I couldn't believe what I heard (now, looking back, I should not be that surprised to hear that), and in fact when I told my father (who was still alive then) that I was encouraged to smoke, and to not spend too much time studying, he was ardently upset (I had not seen him that mad before in fact) and told me he would like to beat the shit out of the teacher who said that to me: You're my son; you do what is good.

You're a student -- it's just damn fucking wrong for anyone, let alone that asshole who call himself your teacher, to tell you not to study. I knew that my father was right -- he always was -- and therefore I followed his instruction. Because I didn't have such financial means, so I couldn't just leave the school and found a new place. Instead, I had to eat bitterness and try to find my own way to cope with the problem from which I could not simply emancipate.

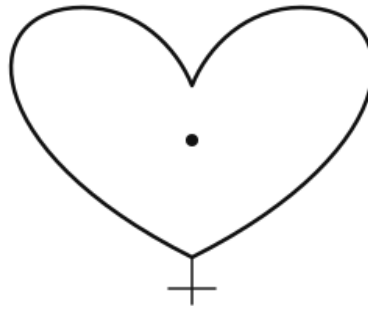
It turns out that, as I always say on my blog here, "we are stronger than we think," so how I found comfort in the libraries for 3,000 hours over the next six years did provide me with a solid ground to become who I am: a reader who loves to read and a scholar to love to research. I didn't have any professors to write me any letters of recommendation to say that I was a good student.

All I had was my own knowledge to show what I believed I knew, and why they mattered. Conclusion: When life gives you lemons, don't be discouraged -- find the way to make fuc**** awesome lemonade:-) One of the best inspiration comic strips I have ever read. This is probably one of those truest things that we can all resonate with. Salute Chris Guillebeau!

DAY 30

The Kind of Love That Will Last

Fri, 25 Jul 2025 00:00:00 +0000



****SPOILER ALERT.** THIS POST IS the last installment of the "Why I Give Up Love" trilogy. I'd have to warn you, this blog post is not a conventionally rosy-eyed blog post about "how to love." Far from it. This is a blog post about how NOT to love. I may have a very specific idea about love, but I don't know for sure what it is. In fact, I don't know even know whether the kind of love that I want for myself would involve deep and penetrative romance.

I have been in so many relationships that failed miserably -- despite both the deep and the penetrative romance. But what I know for sure is what is NOT love: possessiveness, superficiality, and "bad faith." Love, first of all, should have nothing to do with the feeling of possession. In my last post on love, I wrote about how I think possession, or the want to possess your lover, is what kills love. I really mean it.

Love is not, and should not be, about possessing, owing, or taking away the freedom from the other person's life. Freedom is the very basic human's need, whether that be the freedom to love, or the freedom to not love. It is wrong, from the beginning, to believe that true love involves an agreement that the couple shall possess each other. Possessing the other person is different from possessing an object.

When we possess an object, the love for the object is the genuine love because you love it for what it is -- for its quality whether that be its function, aesthetics, or its meaning. But when you think you possess a person, it is not the quality of the person that you want to possess -- because you simply can't possess someone else's quality -- but rather the thought that you are capable of possessing a person.

My gut feeling compels me to feel disgust from within every time I hear someone say something like, "he's mine," or "she belongs to me." What's wrong with that? Two things: first, to think that a person can be possessed is to reduce the person to a mere passive object that does not have its own agency. By doing so, you're reducing a person to a mere object that cannot think, feel, and have its own sense of active ownership of its own existence.

Human beings are free, and being free is the essence of human species. Second, to possess a person is to think that a person is no longer having a freedom to see you in a different light -- that person cannot love you less, and also cannot love you more. True.

Possessing a person by asking him or her to commit his or her life to you, whether to ask him or her to call you in a certain way (e.g., "my boyfriend," "my husband," etc.) could give you some comfort in the sense that it might make you feel that you are not alone, and that you are wanted.

But often, make no mistake about it, calling a human being "my XXX" is nothing less than a pretentious self-fulfilling way of lying to oneself that one has a socially acceptable reason to engage in a legitimate sexual intercourse, when, in most case, there is nothing legitimate about it precisely because of how one sees the other as a mere "possess-able" object. Any attempt to make something external to the dignified nature of human species will subvert itself.

The philosopher Arthur Schopenhauer goes as far as to say: To marry means to do everything possible to become an object of disgust to each other. Superficiality is another evil. The reason why divorce rate is skyrocketing in

many societies is because people get married for a really bad reason; one of which is to show his or her social circles that he or she is wanted. The root cause of divorce is bad marriage, and what exactly constitutes bad marriage?

In societies in which I grew up, the "outright" bad marriage is the marriage between two people who get married because of someone else want them to. Some marriage last a lifetime, some do not. Any kinds of relationship, marriage or not, must be based on the mutual understanding of the two people involved -- and just the two of them, not their parents, friends, society, etc.

I met a few friends who had to endure bad marriages in which they got themselves simply because they wanted to "look good" in the social circles of which they were parts. One of the most miserable people I knew said to me that she had to get married to a man whom she did not even want to sleep with, just so that she could pursue her goal which was to continue her study in the PhD level.

In China, older generation parents prefer to see their daughters getting married and producing children rather than pursuing advanced degrees because most men are still thinking in conservative terms, and therefore would rather get married with a woman whose educational level is lower than theirs. One of the important conventions in traditional marriage is hypergamy, or, by dictionary definition, is the action of marrying a person of a superior class.

So, when the woman has a higher educational level, it is difficult for the man to see how she gets married to him could be perceived as "marrying up." So, this friend of mine, who later found out that she didn't know why she wanted to do a PhD, had to get married with a man whom she did not like that much. She also had to pretend that she loved him very much especially on social media, so that she would "look good" in her social circles.

There wasn't any joy in the marriage. My question to her (which I didn't get to ask) was, "why are you doing this to yourself?" Why is it so important to

"look good" to other people? I don't understand why someone would go so far out of their way just to please other people, who don't really have anything to do with your life? Therefore, this kind of relationship is what the philosopher and novelist Jean Paul Sartre would call "bad faith" (in French, *mauvaise foi*). It's pathetic.

Relationship between a man and a woman doesn't have to be the way that most people in the society see as being acceptable. Human beings of "good faith" always have a choice, and we don't have to follow either our natural inclination, or what other people want us to believe to be the given (i.e., granted as a supposition, acknowledged or assumed) in our society.

Sartre sees bad faith as a feature of many unsuccessful relationships, as he describes its origins: When a couple secretly realize that they're not at all compatible, but then force themselves to believe that they can be "happy together." Sartre gives an example a woman wants to be loved for her mind and can't bear to pay attention to her own dark suspicions that her partner is, in fact, more interested in her body.

Meanwhile the man realizes that the woman isn't interested in him sexually, but keeps telling himself that he must be they both lie to themselves and that's why they end up together and unhappy bad faith will lead them to throw the blame on each other, saying it's the others coldness or lack of sophistication that's the problem when really it's their own doing.

Sartre didn't see bad faith has a surprising or unusual problem it's a natural outcome of how our minds work he didn't want us to feel bad, he just wanted to remind us to be as free as we really are. We are all lonely to a degree, whether because we're social beings who constantly need attention from one another, or that we are simply animals who want to engage in, and be entertained by a physiologically arousing activity involving the grinding and rubbing of, at least, one genital.

Such loneliness then leads to the excessive demand to be fulfilled both in terms of one's sexual need, as well as to be accepted by the society. Many of

us today don't see anything wrong with being sexually liberal, since we now have effective contraceptive technology, but in the past being sexually free could lead to all kinds of conflicts.

In the society where men rule (which is most of them), these kinds of conflicts often have to do with the anxiety toward the idea of possessing women as their sexual objects.

As the psychoanalyst Sigmund Freud writes in, what I believe to be one of the most important analyses of human social world, *Civilization and Its Discontents*, we human beings then, quite early on, made the decision to mark "free sex" something completely taboo, which then gave birth to a whole new enterprise involving ritualistic and semantic practices marking sex "restricted," and therefore "not free," such as marriage, boyfriend-girlfriend relationship, and so on.

But don't get me wrong, I am not saying that I am all for "free sex" or that I support wasted hookups. In fact, quite the opposite, I agree with a New York Times reader whose comment on the contemporary hookup culture has just recently been published, in which she writes: I HAVE TO BE able to trust somebody before I sleep with them, and it's hard to trust somebody that you've known for like two hours. I don't get it, either. Guess I'm just an old prude.

I wholeheartedly agree with this reader. To have sex with someone, by and large, is to open your entire physicality to all kinds of risks, whether that be physical pain or diseases. So, although the idea of freely roaming around having sex with multiple partners might sound tempting, I still don't think it's worth it mainly because of the risks that it involves. Back to Freud, he isn't talking about free and liberating sex as such.

What he's talking about is how we "cultured human beings" subvert our own desire to do so by creating a set of status markers to legitimize what he sees as being no different to casual sex: People think that in order to be able to have sex they need to have a "publicly declarable" sexual partner whom they

would call by some euphemistic titles such as "boy/girlfriend"; to be stable citizens by getting married, to be good members of the family by reproducing; and so on.

But that's not the kind of life worth living. In order to understand the very core idea of the kind of life that is worth living, we must, as Jean-Paul Sartre has suggested:...Be aware of existence as it is when it has been stripped of any of the prejudices and stabilizing assumptions lent to us by our day-to-day routines.

But once we strip down all the superficial facade of the whole matter, all of these seemingly benign and acceptable social performances come down to represent only a way for a couple to "spend an evening meal with each other," which if we are to understand it through the lenses of Sartre's kind of existentialism is much weirder than we think: in one of my most favorite philosophy's website, having an evening meal with a partner is nothing but: Dinner really means that when your part of the planet has spun away from the energy of a distant hydrogen and helium explosion, you slide your knees under strips of a chopped-up tree and put sections of dead animals and plants in your mouth and chew, while next to you, another mammal whose genitals you sometimes touch is doing the same.

That is, the end goal of getting married, or possessing someone by reducing him or her to a mere object, is simply to legitimize sex as an acceptable social norm in a particular society. But who have the right to represent the society anyway? If Freud was right, civilization is the root cause of hysteria, simply because it prevents us from achieving what we want, therefore suppressing our desire underneath the layer of the "socially acceptable." Who can tell us what we should do?

If we strip everything down, what's wrong with being who we are? I believe that human beings are naturally "not bad" (maybe not all good, but definitely not bad), then we know what we want, and it is okay to want to get what we want as long as the methods of getting what we want doesn't encroach upon other people's right and liberty, and what they want.

As Sartre writes, only when we realize that we are not free -- and that we can be free -- we can then live in "good faith." It is only when we realize that someone else is making us think that "being unfree" is the only way we could live our life, that we can then escape from "bad faith." I am putting my finger on it here: no bad faith love or marriage will last. So, what's the kind of love that I want?

I may not be the most moral person, but I still believe that a person does not need to have more than one lover. I believe in simplicity. Having only one lover who really know you, cares about you, is better having many lovers who can only use their genitals to please yours. As my good friend Kevin once said: I want someone who gets me.

When I am down, or crazy, or obsessive -- not someone who just comforts me because she should, but because she knows how I really feel and what is happening in my mind. That's the kind of love that will last. For me, to begin with, I want the kind of love that is mutual. I want the kind of love that is based entirely on the intellectual capacity of the two lovers. I just can't stand people who don't understand how to engage in an intellectual exercise.

I don't care how we get to know each other, and I don't care if our social statuses are different in other people's eyes. In fact, love is a matter between two people; so, I won't even let anyone's opinion affect any of my decision when it comes to love. Like Kevin, I want someone who gets me, and knows what I want, who also allows me to get her, and know what she wants. I am done with a possessive, superficial, and bad faith kind of love.

In a selfish way, I want the kind of love that makes me want to get up in the morning to do my best to contribute to the positive change in the world. I want the kind of love that makes me feel passionate about everything around me because I know I always have someone who is supporting me and giving me the benefit of the doubt.

I want the kind of love that makes me feel that nothing could be that bad, and even if it is that bad, she will always be there to pick me up and dust me.

Reciprocally, I want to be the person who gets her, knowing what she needs before she even needs it. That sad part is that I didn't think that this kind of love would be so hard to achieve. But it is. Therefore, I have given up love. P.S.

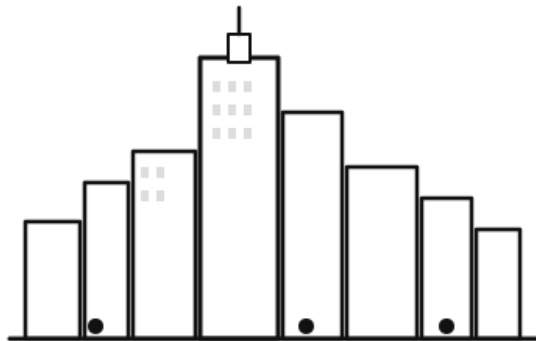
I can't truly say that the idea of closing this trilogy loop is entirely mine. It's actually not, but I actually have a few more things to say about love, and its intrinsic and intricate quilt of absurdity. This morning I was bombarded with friends' posts about Back to the Future -- arguably the best trilogy film of all time -- about the fact that today is the day that, had the trilogy wasn't just a movie but reality, Doc Brown and Marty Mcfly would be arriving from the past.

This is the last time I will write in my blog here about what I talk about when I talk about love.

DAY 31

Why Modesty is Bad for the Society

Sat, 26 Jul 2025 00:00:00 +0000



I AM NOT A PARTICULARLY modest person. In fact, for those who know me, they'd probably also know that I am not modest at all. I like to feel good about my accomplishment (if there's any), and I would like to be rewarded for what I have done well (although, usually, I do things well because I don't expect any reward). That is, I appreciate my ability to appreciate my achievements, whether that be helping myself, or helping others with or without their recognition.

As long as I recognize them, I would feel good about myself, and if I have a chance to say it I would do so. To me, modesty is something external to my being -- I think being modest is being dishonest.

According to the dictionary, modesty is "the quality or state of being unassuming or moderate in the estimation of one's abilities." Hence, to be modest, first and foremost, is to know that you have some abilities, and hence deliberately downplay the expression of such abilities in order to be "moderate in the estimation of one's abilities." It is undoubted that we are living in the world in which more and more people tend to believe that being flamboyant about how good they think they are (which, by the way, is different from how good they actually are) -- in other words, overestimating their ability to do things -- often benefit them more than being

self-conscious about their limited ability.

We can see this kind of flamboyant expression almost everywhere, such as in the media, television, classroom, workplace, and so on. So, here we can see that there are usually two origins of our collective appraisal for modesty. We are somewhat living in the world that is "harder and harder" to tell who is good or who is bad simply because modern life gives us "lesser and lesser" time and opportunity to think carefully other people's claim about their abilities vis-a-vis themselves.

Many times, we simply take the leap of faith to believe that something is good or bad. Hence, we "more and more" appreciate those people who give us some space to think carefully about them. Precisely, what makes us appreciate them is our own curiosity toward those people's unique claim to be not as good as we might think they are. That, I believe is the first origin of modesty.

Second, because of this particular "make-others-know-what-you-can-do-will-give-you-what-you-need" societal trend, emerging also as an accompanying trend is the belief that those who are modest about what can do must be rare. And, because of that, rarity becomes quality. That, I believe to be the second origin. There might be more but these are the two that I believe to be what makes people today feel that they should try to be modest even if they are naturally flamboyant. So, my argument here will be quite radical.

Unlike Confucius who believes that modesty is the cradle of the society that will prevent it from internal destruction, what I want to argue in this post is that modesty is actually "bad" for the society. So, let start with Karl Popper, who writes: Unlimited tolerance must lead to the disappearance of tolerance.

If we extend unlimited tolerance even to those who are intolerant, if we are not prepared to defend a tolerant society against the onslaught of the intolerant, then the tolerant will be destroyed, and tolerance with them -- Karl Popper. In the passage above, by simply replacing "tolerance" with

"modesty," and "intolerant" with "flamboyant," we can arrive at the theory I am hoping to propose here. Modesty is similar to tolerance.

Modesty is the willingness to tolerate the existence of opinions that one does not necessarily agree with, which, in this case, is one's own ability. It's known to many that a functioning society is a society full of tolerant people. In other words, being a tolerant person is better than being an intolerant person. Being able to cultivate one's ability to agree to disagree is the golden virtue. I don't disagree with such a remarkably true statement at all.

That said, as Popper argues in the passage above, if everyone believes that we must be tolerant, then it only takes one mindless intolerant person to undermine the entire social structure. The intolerant people will win, because they will completely enforce their intolerant-driven ill-spirited conduct on the tolerant people, who will tolerate everything because they are, by definition, tolerant.

This may sound rather extreme, but as the Italian philosopher Antonio Gramsci has pointed out, there are societies that their citizenry don't even know that they are being suppressed -- simply because the ideological state apparatus surrounding them since birth are doing so well in informing them that the true quality of a human being cannot be anything else but tolerance.

A collective fight against this notion of, what Gramsci calls, "hegemony" may have been the root cause of the rise of the flamboyant, or the idea that if you are absolutely confident about what you are doing, then you must be exuberant about it to save the society as a whole. There you have it. I have laid out the structure of my argument. Being "intentionally modest" is dishonesty. I will later show how it could backfire.

My feeling is that, as, and let me modestly take the opportunity return to the passage written by, the philosopher Karl Popper has to say about the notion of tolerance above, if we allow these people who think they are good (when they might, or might not be as good as they think they are) be the only group of people who attract attention because of their exuberant confidence

without the actual content, then we will live in the overly fabricated world focusing on the beautiful form, rather than the moral content, that they create.

That is to say, if we're all being modest, the immodest (of the flamboyant) will win; and therefore we will all be living in the flamboyant world full of artificial contents that they create primarily for themselves, which doesn't sound like a good community to be a member of, no matter which angle you are looking at it from.

That said, of course, I like it when people are being modest, because I like it when people are leaving ample room for the possibility that they might not be absolutely right about something.

We have a term for that -- it's fallibilism, which the philosopher Kwame Anthony Appiah describes it rather succinctly as "the recognition that we may be mistaken, even when we have looked carefully at the evidence and applied our highest mental capacities." I, indeed, have my own definition: fallibilism is what open-mindedness and skepticism have in common. Being modest, in this sense, is to be intelligent.

This, I think, goes better with what Confucius says about being able to learn something from anyone at all that life makes you encounter -- or, in Confucius' beautiful words, "when walking in the company of three, there must be one from whom I can learn (san ren xing bi you wo shi)." I couldn't agree more.

In fact, I even go as far as to say that we must take all of these three people as our teachers, because even those who don't have anything to teach us can teach us "how not to be teachers." So, we can learn from anyone and everyone. Life should not be about having a life and arriving at death, but about the constant process of learning.

In this sense, being modest is being honest about the fact that there could be so many things that we could learn about, and from so many people from whom we could acquire the new knowledge. I'd like to call this kind of

modesty "unintentional modesty." In this case, being aware of the fact that you may be wrong is virtue, which could save yourself from embarrassment, and could have potential to save lives. One can call it modesty or fallibilism. Names don't really matter.

For example, I have a colleague who is absolutely flamboyant about what he thinks he knows. To be fair to him, from his direct experience, he may be capable of knowing a few descriptions of a few things.

Unfortunately, because he was born with a natural ethnic attribute that works to his advantage in the country that such attribute is seen as unique and powerful (i.e., being a white male in China), he has been asked to comment, present, and provide ideas on things, problems, issues, beyond the immediate realm of descriptions of those few things that he may have the capacity to know.

Most people won't have the courage to comment, let alone present and provide ideas on things and problems outside their immediate realm of knowledge, not because one is being modest, but because one doesn't really know. But he does not.

It may be the fact that he is not a modest person that makes him feel as if he could conveniently extent his capacity to prognosticate results, or it may simply be that he, simply, simplemindedly takes those invitations to do things beyond his immediate capacity (to do justice to them) at face value, hence making himself believe that he himself must have been "good enough." What happens next is that, on the one hand, in the eyes to the unintelligent, he is the knowledgeable because he has the courage to say things he does not know for sure.

The problem isn't that he doesn't have the capacity to learn. It seems to be that there is something that is preventing him from accepting the possibility that maybe -- just maybe -- what he knows isn't the absolute truth of the world. Sound familiar? Yes, he can't make sense of fallibilism. On the other hand, in the eyes to the intelligent, he is just a fool.

What is worse, between him being worshiped by a bunch of fool simply because he has the courage to say things he doesn't know, or he being a fool in the eyes of smart people? I think they're both bad, but I would rather want the damage caused by him to be limited to him being perceived as a fool in the society of intelligent people. Can you imagine this kind of person becoming a teacher?

This guy, through his immodest immodesty, would spread his stupidity among his students, and his students, who, by definition, are those "who study" (therefore may largely not be as critical or intolerable to the nonsensical arguments) would probably believe him). What would this society be like? So, if we happen to know that someone doesn't know what he is talking about, speak up! Every time you remain silent, this guy -- an "intentionally modest" person -- wins. Please, folks, don't let them win. Be bold when we have to.

This is the only way to safeguard our society. I always tell people this -- that I am not a modest person, and that sometimes I even think being modest is a crime (maybe from now I should tell them instead that I am an "unintentionally modest" person).

Yet, it seems to be the case that many still see me as "being intentionally modest," especially when I say to them "I am not that good" (if in Chinese it's usually in the form of nali nali, or, literally, "where where"), or "I was just lucky," and so on. Am I just being modest in those situations? The answer is a qualified no.

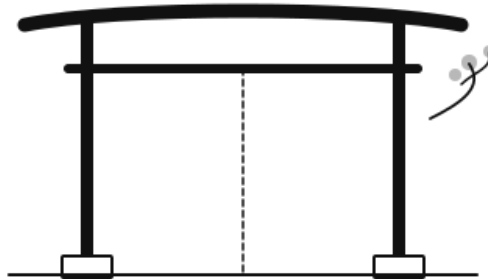
Honesty, not modesty, is my operating system -- as well as golden rule since I also want people to be honest with me -- therefore I don't say things just because I know others want to hear, or just to please people's ears.

Under honesty, my sub-operating system is fallibilism, so I always try to leave as much room as possible for the possibility that I might be wrong, that I might be seeing the situation from only one angle, and that I might be able to benefit from doubting what I know rather than believing in what I know.

DAY 32

On Professionalism

Sun, 27 Jul 2025 00:00:00 +0000



SINCE I HAVE MOVED INTO my new place, where there's a cable TV, I have been sitting in front of my flat screen television everyday, watching shows after shows on my new favorite TV channel, NHK World TV (stands for Nippon Hs Kykai or Japan Broadcasting Corporation) from Japan (but in English). Growing up reading Japanese graphic novels or manga, I always have a soft spot for Japan and Japanese culture. In fact, I'd to spend some time there -- perhaps the rest of my life.

I like everything about Japan: the art, architecture, food, culture, manga, etc. You name it, and I'll just tell you how much I like it, and why I like it. My friends who know me well would know that I could spend the entire day talking about Japan and Japanese culture. In fact, I have written a few articles and Japan. My first publication was a two-page essay on the Japanese love hotels (rabu hoteru).

It was this research that I received the honorable title from my Japanese colleagues "hentai sensei" () -- please find out by yourself what it means. The most recent book chapter that I just wrote, and just got published is on Japanese capsule hotels, which in the book chapter I argue that it may be one of the representative form of Japanese socio-spatial structure.

We shouldn't be looking at it from the perspective of an outsider, otherwise we will miss so many interesting things, but to understand it ethnographically from within. My favorite NHK World TV show is *The Professionals*, a one-hour documentary series that focuses on Japan's best professionals from various fields. When it comes to professionalism, no one can really beat the Japanese.

In the US, Thailand, or elsewhere (where I have lived), it seems as though to be a professional is to be "occupationally engaged" in a specified activity that gets one paid, and most of the time what it means is to be an employee of a company. For instance, in the US, we go to the so-called a "professional school" to become a lawyer, medical doctor, nurse, and architect.

It seems as though to be a professional is to have a stable "paid job." In Japan, if one is passionate about what one does, one can be a professional -- and it doesn't really matter what work it is. You can be a professional grocer, farmer, bartender, coffee barista, dancer, noodle stall owner, (), street performer, and so on.

There is the spirit of *kodawari* which, since I don't speak Japanese I will largely rely on the translation I found online, "obsession, fixation, hangup, determination, fastidiousness, pickiness about something." The anthropologist Merry White, in her book *Coffee Life in Japan*, translates it as "the kind of passion that is almost bordering on obsession." Japan has always been a nation where many professions easily find their places in the society no matter how niche-oriented what they do are.

That may have to do with the fact that Japanese people do respect the art, labor, and craftsmanship involved in the process of making consumable products, food, and materials.

In White's book, the coffee barista (Italian for "bartender," which, in this case, is the person who makes coffee for you at the coffee bar in Japan) who she studied in Tokyo were the embodiment of the very core spirit of *kodawari* -- they're so damn attentive, critical, and ritualistic, about what they do, so

much so that most people wonder whether these barista are crazy or not. Believe it or not, all of us are like that sometimes.

When we find something that we really like to do and want to excel in doing it, we will put everything aside, and put all out of our conscious effort it.

After watching the barista making a cup of coffee for you with the utmost performance of kodawari including the very meticulous and multi-layered process of grinding coffee beans by hand, all the way to siphoning it through the finest and most beautiful vacuum coffee maker, whether or not the coffee they make actually taste better doesn't really matter anymore (maybe it does, but how much can we, non-experts, can really tell?).

Anyone who could feel the very core spirit of kodawari could also feel the sensationality embedded in the taste of the coffee. I do feel that actually tastes better when someone is putting the heart and soul into brewing it for you. In fact, I think what makes Japan an interesting country is precisely this kind of respect for professionalism. Professionals from all walks of life, in whatever they do, are respected not only for the expertise they possess, but also the products or services that they deliver.

In turn, the Japanese appreciation for professionalism not only makes these professionals wanting to continue to develop themselves, and pass on their expertise to the next generation, but also make young people want to become professionals -- precisely because they know that there is always a room for growth. This mentality helps to proliferate both professionalism and small businesses. You don't have to have a large sum of capital to pursue what you love.

It's the love and passion (and perhaps some sense of economic feasibility) that make one stand out in the battle between professionals who want to deliver products and services which belong to the best of their class. Philosophers like Karl Marx, Adam Smith, and John Locke would agree that the work ethics of these professionals align well with the essence of human species -- the professionals put their life into the pursuit of perfecting the

object, and therefore "own" the fruits of their labor.

By owing the fruit of their labor, they are driven from the inside to deliver high quality products. In a typical capitalist society, capitalism will appropriate these products and services, and place them in the market system that would determine the value of the fruit of their labor on their behalf. If the market demand is lower than the supply of similar products in the market, for whatever reason, the price will go down despite the fact that these professionals may have put no less effort in producing them.

Sooner or later these, as Marx has pointed out, professionals will find no pleasure in producing anything because they would find out that they do not get to own, let alone enjoy the fruits of their labor, and eventually they would feel alienated from the product of their work, and that would be the end of the professionals.

So, professionalism reunites the division of the society that is often thought of as being separated into the entities and belong to two classes: the property owners (the capitalists) and the property-less (proletariat) workers. Marx, especially, thinks that capitalism has divided our society into two entities. I think that we can still live meaningfully in a capitalist society By being professionals in what we all do no matter what it is, we are playing a part in making our society less segregated.

By being dignified professionals, we don't just serve the insatiable demand of the capitalists who just want to make use of and exploit our labor, but we can use our labor in doing things we love to turn the capitalists around and make them see the larger picture of the benefits of meaningful labor force. It's the professionalism in all of us that will save us from the negative consequences brought about by capitalism.

In this arrangement, the the capitalists don't necessarily own the professionals, but rely on the professionals to deliver what they need. Therefore, the professionals don't suffer impoverishment by ways of capitalist exploitation. The professionals also get to enjoy the experience of

being reunited with themselves, with their products, with their fellow human beings, and with the essence of the human species. in a Marxian sense, to be a professional is to own the fruit of your labor, and to have the complete freedom what to do with it.

For instance, why would anyone want to make a coffee at home, if right around the corner there is a great cafe with a great barista who would always make a great fresh cup of coffee? Same goes with noodles, sushi, and so on.

What would anyone want to go to the wholesale market and try their luck on picking some fruits from an ocean of fruits, if they know they can rely on the greengrocer next door who knows exactly which are good fruits by experience, and is happy to get them delivered it to the community? I think the functioning society that works in a long-run must be the kind of society that respect professionals.

In the latest episode of *The Professionals*, Japan's most respected greengrocer Teruaki Sugimoto showed us his passion for selling vegetables. He's known by everyone in his profession as "the greengrocer who knows more than anyone in Japan about delicious produce." In the Kita-Senju neighborhood of Tokyo where more and more people are turning away from the local grocers and toward convenient stores to buy mass-produce vegetables and fruits, the 67-year-old Mr.

Sugimoto was still all about handpicked, artisanal, and high-quality vegetables that he personally inspects, bids, and buys from the wholesales market by himself. To outsiders, he may look like a stubborn old man who has devoted his life to vegetables; but, to his customers, Mr. Sugimoto's passion for selling vegetables lies beyond his interest in making money.

He wants to be on top of his game, which, as he defines, is to serve his loyal and new customers with the highest quality vegetables, as well as in helping the farmers, without whom he wouldn't be able to do what he does. "Always protect the farmers," is his motto. In a way, he's a merchant -- a middleman -- who doesn't produce anything. All he does is just to profit from the

farmers whose sweat and blood turn into produce for him to sell.

So, he's grateful for being fortunate enough to be doing what he is doing; hence, he believes that it's important to protect the farmers whose hard labor is the bloodline of his family's career for generation. The blurb on the The Professionals' site summarizes it all: The approach that sums up Sugimoto's way of doing business is "always play offense." And rather than buying everything at wholesale markets, he has developed his own channels for procuring select produce. Sugimoto says, "There are still many delicious things that people haven't tried.

I have to get out there and promote them. That's what a greengrocer should do." Mr. Sugimoto concludes at the end of the documentary that, to him, to be a professional is to "not relying only on the past achievements but to strive to be better and better everyday." The story of Teruaki Sugimoto in the The Professionals got me thinking about what it means, personally, to be a profession. I don't really know what I am in terms of profession.

Am I a student, a teacher, an architect, an urban designer, a writer, or what? Well, I am by and large still a student (a doctoral student) but I also have some teaching experience, so in a way, I could call myself a "professional teacher." In fact, it's the teaching that makes me want to get up in the morning and go to work. That said, it's not fair to use what I like to do to justify my professionalism.

It would be like judging the quality of life in a particular city, only on a good day. We must also take into account the bad days. A true professional also endures the hardship on a bad day, and turns the negative energy into a genuine passion to seize the opportunity that might not be immediately obvious.

There were times when I had to grade exam papers -- what I dread the most in my life as a teacher -- read student papers, prepare for classes, and so on, that were not that pleasant. This time last year, I was grading more than 40 philosophy exam papers. Each of which was 4-5 page-long. I was spending

about 30 minutes to one hour per each paper, while my colleagues were spending about 2-3 minutes per paper.

I both wrote comments onto the papers, and typed extra comments for each student. It was madness. I'd spent more than 40 hours grading 40 papers (including printing, stapling the comments onto the exams). Not only was I focusing all my attention on providing the most just grades to the students who deserved them, but also on writing extensive comments to those who hadn't gotten it yet in order to make sure that they would learn from their mistakes.

I felt that I could help them improve themselves in the next exam. What I did was also to help my students in learning how to write in general for their future careers. There was no incentive of anything on my part whatsoever. I could have been drinking, watching TV, going around the city, or even going to bed (because I often had to grade all the way to the very late evening hours).

I could just slack off, and call it a day at 6pm, and then went out for drinks with my friends. I didn't do that because something inside of me was telling me that I could not do that, and that I must provide equally comprehensive and considerably constructive comments to every single exam paper, even though I knew that some students might not even care.

I knew I could have done what most of my colleagues did, which was to simply assign random grades to random students, taking the responsible task of a teacher as lightly as possible, so that I would have more time to pursue something else that they believed they'd rather be spending time on. Why did I do that? I was just doing it because I think it was "my duty" -- the responsible task --to do it for my students.

Professionalism, to me at that time, was to go the extra miles on something, for which I believe I have the purpose in life. So, could it be that feeling content was the main factor that drove me to go those extra miles? It would be misleading to say so, I believe. I still remember how antagonizing I was

having to sit down on a desk reading one paper after another.

Some papers were written in such a way that nobody could understand (e.g., illegible, put together poorly grammatically, etc.) -- but I had to try to understand them regardless of how much I would rather brush them off. Every second I that was spending reading those exam papers longer than my colleague, I felt as though I was not making any sense. I was antagonizing over everything as I probed.

So, in that sense, it was clear, to me, that I would be much happier having a beer and watching NHK World News rather than grading exam papers. Yet, I was still going through each paper one by one -- at the slowest possible speed -- in order to insure the carefulness in reading each and every one of the paper. I didn't think that what I was doing was duty?

My duty could end at the official closing time of the office which was 6pm, and I could easily come back and do it the next day. So, what was my incentive for going the extra miles, doing much more work, spending much more time on grading those exam papers? If "incentive" could be defined as something that motivates you to do something, I probably did not have any real incentive then. It was neither the economic incentive, or my expectation for results from which I could benefit.

Was I simply romanticizing my intention to treat teaching and grading as an end in itself? Perhaps. But if we look closer there was actually nothing to romanticize about. To be romantic is to suggest that I could incline toward the feeling of exciting mystery, which I didn't see any.

The end was clear -- that I would be so tired after 40 something hours of work reading and grading, and the consequence was also clear, which was the fact that I could hit the sack as soon as I got the grades in. Why did I work myself so hard for no concrete result? Having said all these, I want to make it clear that I don't believe that doing things just for the sake of doing it "out of duty" is that professional, at least to me.

Professionalism is, in some ways, about duty, but on the other hand what it is really about is the way in which life could be given meanings. Unlike the great philosopher Immanuel Kant who would profess to a room full of empty chairs because he believed that to be in his role as a professional professor, he would need to profess no matter what, and whether or not there's an audience. I get his point, but I simply do not think that it is very useful.

Ok, fine, perhaps by professing to a group of empty chairs he was making a statement about his professionalism -- and one day when I am as wise and as astute intellectually as he was I would understand his rather unique course of action. For the time being, I'd rather save my time to profess to a group of empty chairs to do something else (just a little bit) more meaningful.

So, no, if I know that those philosophy papers won't be returned to the students, who therefore wouldn't get to read my extensive comments, I would not spend a lot of time writing my comments (I would, nevertheless, spend as much time on reading them regardless, assuming that they're written with the intellectual labor of love), because it would be the same as professing to a group of empty chairs. Back to why I want to be a professional.

First, I don't think being content, happy, and pleasurable, is the only things that life needs. So, when I do things that may sound difficult, hard, and demanding, I don't do it because I like it, or because I expect something from it.

I believe that we human beings also need to be straightened, shaped, forced to do things we don't want to do from time to time, so that we'd make the most meaning out of something rather meaningless like getting a job, going to work, and getting out of work, going to bed, and getting up again next day. Second, being true to what I believe is to be true to the very essence of what I do is what gives my life meaning.

In my earlier post I outlines what I talk about when I talk about passion, but passion only cannot explain why I would go extra miles on things that don't

present the immediate benefit. The incentive here is, perhaps, my belief that once we have started something we should go all the way to test my limit is what makes my life not as absurd as it would be.

This might be the same feeling that some runners might not compete just to win, but to see how fast he, as a human being, could run. The incentive here is something beyond the realm materiality. I would be a pity if we only do things because we are expecting something materialistic, or economically profitable in return. The most exciting thing in life, I believe, is to be able to evaluate our own limit. Grading exams might not be a good example here, as it's far from exciting.

But for sure the fact that I simply don't stop at glancing through them and assigning random grades is because I want to see how much I could learn from these exam papers about my students -- what they need to learn more about -- so that I could support them where they need it. Being intense and obsessive, it might look as though I am being chained to my kodawari ethics. True.

I might not be free to do whatever I want, but I feel as though am free because I know exactly what I do, and why I do it -- and that I am able to pursue it. So, when I was doing my best in what I believe I should be doing, I was "free from the natural inclination" to take the easy way out.

So, being a professional is to be able to pursue what I believe to be give myself, and my life, meaning, and it is often, if not always, involves pushing the limit of my mental and physic capacity -- sometimes, to perfect the imperfectable. So, it's not about delivering what I can, but deliveingr the best performance regardless of the outcome.

Perhaps, in the similar way that the anthropology Merry White sees the baristas in Tokyo café wanting pursue nothing but "the way of being the masters of their own universes," I am doing what I do, simply, also to be the master of mine.

post Day 33: What Makes Life Worth Living Mon, 28 Jul 2025 00:00:00 +0000
First of all, let me be clear from the beginning: I don't have the answer for such an impossible question. Second, I didn't just come up with such title to make this blog post sound more interesting than it is. In fact, I may not have anything new to share with you today, in this post.

You, actually, might find that this particular post to be the most shallow, content-less, and lack of substance of all of my posts. So, I am warning you. Reading this post might not worth you time. I didn't even come up with a title of this post. Yes, I am a blatant copycat of ideas. It is a title of a book that I plan to read next by Prof. Gordon Mathews, who teaches anthropology at the Chinese University of Hong Kong (CUHK).

Despite the grandiose title, the book is not about the metaphysics of life as such, but an anthropological inquiry into the ways in which the two groups of people of which Mathews have lived with -- the Japanese and the American people -- (, make of their lives. In Japanese, the term *ikigai* pronounced [ikiai]) is a traditional concept, meaning "a reason for being," or as Mathews writes, "broadly, that which most makes one's life seem worth living." In the Japanese society, *ikigai* is both gendered and generational.

For instance, Mathews presents in an article published in the journal *Ethnology* in 1996 (which I believe to become a chapter of the book) that most common *ikigai* of women is family and children, and the most common *ikigai* of men is work and company -- as well as family. But this concept of *ikigai*, of course, changes over time, as we become older (and probably wiser, and sometimes, unfortunately, grumpier). Mathew's main argument is there is something socially deterministic about life. We don't have the full control of it.

The society in which we're born into is responsible for the reason that you may think makes your life worth living. That said, the impact of the social determinism of the society into which we're born also varies. Some cultures of some societies have a much more profound on their citizens. I have heard about the book *What Makes Life Worth Living?* How Japanese and Americans

Make Sense of Their Worlds from colleagues who were students of his at CUHK, but haven't gotten around to read it.

Now it's the time, and I'll tell you why I think so. Long story short, I just spent 146 minutes of my life watching a 2010 based-on-true-story film called *Cold Fish*, which arguably is one of most gruesome yet realistic films in the history of cinema -- about a Japanese family that falls apart in an extremely troubled way because of the social pressure surrounding it (IMDb gives it 7 out of 10 which is a very high rating for a film in this genre).

After having watched the film, I began to think about the connection that I may have with it, since there were a lot of things in (and about) the film that resonate with me, and I found one, which is the fact that it's a film about Japan. That was how I thought of Prof. Mathew's book, since it's about Japan.

As I wrote in my last post, I always have a soft spot for the Japanese culture, so the reason for choosing to watch this film in the first place was because it's a Japanese film.

Then, I tried to think very carefully about the meaning of the film, and extract the message that it tries to send, which I believe to be the fact that not just the unbearable social pressure that has the capacity to drive us to absolute despair, making us feel that the impulse to end the life of our own, or the lives of others, is real.

Quite the contrary, the extraordinarily mundane condition of being that makes us less human beings -- what the novelist Milan Kundera would probably refer to as *The Unbearable Lightness of Being* -- also has the same effect as the unbearable social pressure. People kill themselves (and others) when the pressure is too much to bare. People also kill themselves (and others) when there is no pressure at all, and life is just an absurd process of the perpetual lack of excitement.

The latter cause of suicide is much easier to prevent than the former one.

In fact, as the French sociologist Émile Durkheim has reminded all of us with his meticulous research on social pressure, we can do nothing about suicide-by-social-pressure as long as modern capitalism still continues to advertise "freedom" as the motto of one's life, produce the false notion of "excessive hope" that only a small number of people could possibly fulfill, generate the overwhelming sense of individualism to undermine the unscientific notion of spirituality, family, and the sense of moral responsibility. *Cold Fish* is a film about the power of social determinism.

The protagonist, a man who runs a small tropical fish shop, could only do so little to make his life better. Because, at the end of the day, when one is in despair, one just needs someone to say "it's going to be alright," whether that someone is a person, a family member, or an imagined almighty God. In despair, we want a pad in the back.

In despair, the last thing we want to hear is "you are on your own." In despair, the only freedom that is available to us is the freedom to take your own life. As the Stoics once famously say, "when it's too unbearable, all you have to do is to turn up your own wrist." The existentialist (Nobel laureate) novelist Albert Camus also observes, quite accurately, that the only philosophical question worth delving into is suicide: There is but one truly serious philosophical problem, and that is suicide.

Judging whether life is or is not worth living amounts to answering the fundamental question of philosophy. To put it bluntly, nothing is more metaphysical and serious, than the question is whether one wants to be, or not to be. I can sympathize with those who no longer want to be because there are too much pressure in life. That said, this doesn't necessarily mean that I support suicide. Quite the contrary, I don't think suicide is acceptable at all, both on the moral as well as the sensibility grounds.

In addition, since I've lost my father, I have begun to realize how lucky I am to be. My father wanted to live but he didn't get a chance to, so I want to live not just my, but a good life, also on his behalf. On the moral ground, I'd like to invite all of us, again, to revisit what I still believe to be the most succinct

expression of reason not to kill yourself by the man, Immanuel Kant, himself.

In *The Foundation of the Metaphysics of the Morals*, he proposes the idea of looking at the matter of "living a life," not as a matter of choice but the absolute form of duty: Suicide: A man reduced to despair by a series of misfortunes feels wearied of life, but is still so far in possession of his reason that he can ask himself whether it would not be contrary to his duty to himself to take his own life. On the sensibility ground, what's the point of killing yourself?

There are two facts that we are lucky enough to know: the fact that we will die anyway, and a synthetic a priori fact that we "are stronger than we think." Human beings are capable of going through many kinds of hardship.

Some of which we didn't know that we were able to go through until we did so, and then looked back at it -- "I was so silly; why did I think that I won't be able to do it?" So, these are the two knowledge that we know for sure. They, moreover, seem to be supporting each other underpinning the argument that there is no point in rushing to the end process, knowing that we might, or might not get through the hardship anyway.

It's like giving up on an exam and fail it right away, without even try to pass it first. I call this the "sensibility ground" -- or, the ground on which we exercise our ability to appreciate and respond to complex influences by being sensitive to what we really know for certain. So, the goal of this post is to reason why people kill themselves (and others) when there is no pressure at all.

One reason is that such life no longer gives you the *Ikigai* or the reason for being. Karl Marx would see it the same way, although he would probably not describe it as such, but the losing of what he'd call "species essence" -- a rational being should have the freedom to exercise his or her own mind and thoughts in the way that benefit him or her. Many other philosophers also have tried to identify the condition that makes us lose ourselves, and make us forget *Ikigai*.

Let me talk about Ikigai for a couple more sentences here, because I think the idea of which is deeply powerful. In the diagram above, we clearly see that Ikigai is about balancing the four towers that are balancing our life. It's clear that only one of them has to do with the things about which we love and passionate about, and all other three polls are pretty much whatever provides us with food, shelter, dignity, and meaning and higher goal to live for.

For those who gets to be in the profession where these four towers are one, they are the absolutely lucky ones. For example, let's think of David Beckham -- he loves soccer, and he gets to play it everyday. By playing soccer, he's inspiring many people in the world, and it, well, for sure give him more wealth than he ever needs in the next ten lives of his.

That is, one day maybe he'll get bored with soccer, or perhaps his body is no longer good enough to play in the professional level; then he would need to find something else to do so that he could continue to maintain his sense of being. There are many athletes who are content when they are on top of their games. Only until when they are retired from sports and having to start doing things that fall outside their immediate realm of passion.

Many of them can't deal with it, and go into sex, drugs, and alcohol, with the hope that they would temporarily help them to get through the lack of the guiding light they once hold dear. Most of us are not not like David Beckham. I, for one, is not like that.

There are things that I love doing, but I am not as good at that as the things that I am being paid for, so no one is paying me to do things that I am passionate about, but instead paying for doing things that I am only semi-interested in.

And I am content with my life because although it's not perfect, I have to compromise, but such a compromise still allow me to extent my being into doing things that pay my bill, make me respect myself, and give me the space, time, and comfort, to think about my higher purpose. In other words, we do

things we don't want to do from time to time just to get by, and in my occasions what we do also make us feel deeply sad about our own sense of morality.

When one of three towers that is not about your passion is taking too much time of your life, that's usually when you are losing the sense of Ikigai, or the guiding light to being. So, what exactly makes life worth living? I sincerely don't know if my life is that worth living. But since I know for sure that suicide is, and will never be, an option, and that I am "stronger than I think," I don't see the reason to emancipate from it.

As I wrote in the previous posts (On Aging, I believe), I am experiencing something new every day, and that's absolutely exciting. That, for me, is enough to make me want to continue my life.

That said, the question "what makes life worth living?" is different from, and therefore not to be confused with the question, "what is a reason to live?" You could say that your family is your reason to live -- you have to pay their bills; you have to send your daughter to school; you have to take care of your parents -- but that doesn't mean that your life is worth living. Many existentialist philosophers would argue, even, that anything that you "have to do" is bad for you.

You should be free to do whatever you want. On the one hand, you could take it at face value, and as such, by saying that your life is something you can't change, and therefore the reason to live is the same as what makes life worth living.

For those who know me well, they probably know also that whenever someone says that to me I often, if not always, give them words of wisdom from Jean-Paul Sartre: We are in "bad faith" whenever we tell ourselves that things have to be a certain way and shut our eyes to other options. It is bad faith to insist that we have to do a particular kind of work or live with a specific person or make our home in a given place.

On the other hand, this is why you need something beyond what matters in the physical world would help answer this question. For the philosopher Immanuel Kant, what lies beyond the physical world is, what he calls, the noumenal world, in which everything there is a thing in itself (the German's translation of this is *das Ding an sich*, or thing- in-itself).

Human beings cannot access the noumenal world, yet, because we use our practical reasons—i.e., the capacity for acting as a moral agent— to make sense of the world. These practical reasons include, of course, paying bills, following social convention, doing what's considered "filial," and so on; but, none of these falls outside of what Jean-Paul Sartre calls "bad faith." The fact that matter here is that these things are considered "practical" because you prescribe such value to it.

It may be practical to you because you happen to have no ability to see it otherwise. Yet, you shouldn't confused your inability to change things with the nature of the world, as such. After having watched *Cold Fish*, I must say that I am more certain (than ever!) that living an extraordinary life that only pays bills won't do it for me.

For one reason -- and spoiler alert -- I don't want to end up ending my life in front of my family like the protagonist does in the film. I still believe that being poor but following your own passion is better than being affluent but "unextraordinary" like the man in *Cold Fish*.

A short (and lame) answer to the question *What Makes Life Worth Living* would be something about finding joy in the process of balancing the four towers to which you have to divide your time, attention, and space in order to sustain your life. This answer is lame because, as you also know, it's easier said than done. So, instead of that, I would like to offer my answer. What makes my life worth living is the fact that I know that I am free.

By being free, I don't have to hold on to what Jean-Paul Sartre calls "bad faith," or to what the society believes to be good for me. I am free to decide whatever I think is more meaningful for me to engage in; therefore, I don't

have to live my life in an unextraordinary way. True. I also have to pay bills. Ideally, I would like to live in the woods like Henry David Thoreau.

I can, actually, and I will probably do that soon (I am actually looking for the right woods at the moment). As of now. I am still content with paying bills, because it also means that I am being responsible for my own action. Being free doesn't mean you have to have the full control of your physical life and therefore have the natural right to do anything you want.

"Being free" means you are free to do anything you want as long as you are content with, and will take full responsibility for the consequences of your own action. Immanuel Kant, again, frames freedom as the right to have the full autonomy over your own self, which, the philosopher Michael Sandel in his bestseller *Justice* describes it as follows: When we act autonomously, according to a law we give ourselves, we do something for its own sake, as an end in itself.

We cease to be instruments of purposes given outside us. This capacity to act autonomously is what gives human life its special dignity. It marks out the difference between persons and things." In a big city like Shanghai, now that I come to think of it, I am free, as an autonomous being, to do many things I want to do because I have the consumer society to support me.

I don't have to harvest my own agricultural produce, and don't have to cut down trees by myself so that I won't be freezing to death. So, the law that I set for myself is the law of reciprocity, gratitude, and responsibility toward not only my fellow human beings but the environment as a whole. I want to be able to also support it so that it will continue producing consumer's products and services that would allow me to be even freer -- therefore, I pay my bills.

What makes my life worth living is simply because I always make everyday of my life different from the precious days. The secret here is to be thankful to have another in life to live, and see how you evolve, as a reciprocal, grateful, and responsible being. I don't rely on what I think I already know, and I don't

simply stick to what I think I already know. If I can change, things can change too.

If things can change, then why stick to the same old methods of comprehending the world around you? Every day of my life is all about being humble to new ideas, considerate to new opinions, and respectful to others who always something different from what I know to share. What makes my life worth living is the fact that I know that I am free to learn new things every day.

My life is worth living because I don't have to tolerate people, or things, that don't make sense to me, especially the people who treat me as means to some ends. I have the full autonomy to walk away from them, and live my life with and for whom my life has a larger meaning.

What makes my life worth living is that I know that, not to sound so Kantian today, I am free to take everything as an end in itself, rather than as a means to an end. It's the feeling of being free from any social conventions that could dictate my action. I am free to not having to follow things that don't makes sense. I don't have to live in bad faith.

I am an "autonomous being" who can make rational choices, even though if those choices are prearranged for me -- nothing is wrong with choosing the prearranged choices as long as they work with the law that you have set for yourself to follow. It's not the case that everything prearranged is bad for free will. I think it's misleading to think so, in fact.

Free will is our ability to exercise our reason "freely." What it means by "free" is not the condition of not being under the control or in the power of another -- we still have to force ourselves to accept the fact that we can't escape the law of gravity, the absolute governing maxim of nature, and so on.

Being free also doesn't mean that we can simply act or be done as one wishes -- the absolute free will is to have the respect for the dignity of the existence and presence of other human beings. Even though if I am free to kill other people without having to bare any consequences whatsoever, I, still, will not

do it. That law that you set for yourself to follow, as Kant argues, is the law that predicates on the absolute respect for human species.

That law is the genuine moral knowledge -- or what Kant would call a synthetic a priori knowledge, or the knowledge that is not bound by the inert definition, and does not require our unreliable subjective experience to come to grip with it. What makes my life worth living is the fact that I have people for whom I want to live -- the people who don't treat me as a means to an end.

In other words, what makes my life worth living is the fact that I am living it.

post Day 34: Waking Life Tue, 29 Jul 2025 00:00:00 +0000 Probably one of the most difficult films I have watched lately, Waking Life is. As a response to my last post, one of my students suggested this film. He probably knew a little about my obsession with dream interpretation. The film is visually fascinating. The story line is pretty straightforward -- a man got hit by a car, and then transferred into the state of unconscious, in which he lived in perpetual lucid dreaming.

What make the film utterly interesting is how his lucid dreams are not just random collages of his previous random encounters, but very specific meetings, conversations, with people from whom he then learned about the meaning of life. Beginning with the importance of existentialism from a college professor whose lecture he was attending, neither he or us viewers realized yet whether this was a dream, and that many of them were to follow.

Only until he was no longer himself, but was living in someone else's female body talking about "identity" that he -- as well as us -- began to realize that this couldn't be real. At the beginning, it seems as though he could have been a curious student going around the city in Texas knocking on the doors of former professors' houses who could educate (or re-educate) him about the meaning of it all.

The climax was when he was talking to a guy at a pinball arcade, who told him a story of writer who managed to write a bestseller so fast that he

himself was scared of the fact that the story line may not be a direct product of his brain, but was given to him by someone else. A few months he then realized that the story line was, in fact, his own future. How did he access it?

Something must have bent the space-time continuum that enabled him to live in the body of his future. This was the climax of the film, and the very zenith point of the protagonist's search for his destiny. There was not any, the answer was, but the fact that he was learning so much about how might he have lived his life differently was, rather, meaningful.

The irony, however, is that he was learning about the meaning of it all in his dream, and no matter how corporeal the knowledge he was acquiring through meeting these random people was, he wasn't going to get to use them because he might have been killed by the car accident and therefore he was not able to wake up into his physical life. This was not the first time someone made an awesome film about dreams.

The television show *Lost*, the films *Mulholland Drive* and *Eternal Sunshine of the Spotless Mind* are some of the most remarkable. For *Lost*, which is also one of my favorite shows of all time, it was great because it was such a long TV series (many people, though, got really upset at the end when they all realized that the whole thing was a story of souls struggling to get out of the purgatory; I was okay with it and thought that was pretty clever!).

The *Matrix* is one the classics. When Keanu Reeves -- I mean, Neo -- got stuck in the underground metro station after trying to bypass between the real world and the *Matrix*, he was in the same state of purgatory that the protagonist in *Waking Life* was in. But, in fact, we could also argue that the entire trilogy (*Matrix*, *Matrix Reloaded*, *Matrix Revolution*) was all about dreams. After watching *Waking Life* many may question their own existence. Are we dreaming? Are we dead?

The French philosopher René Descartes, back in the seventeenth century, has dealt with this question. Is there anything at all that we can be sure of? Skeptics of his time said no -- there's absolutely nothing we could be sure of,

and that even their consciousness could have been deceived by an evil demon who wanted to make use of us for their own benefits.

The entire Matrix trilogy was about human beings trying to emancipate from the deceptive consciousness (the Matrix) that this evil demon (the machine) has created to make use of our bioenergy (heat from human body), and proving the existence of reality outside of the Matrix. Descartes is credited for coining arguably the most memorable quote in philosophy and the study of consciousness: *Cogito ergo sum* or "I think therefore I am." This quote, unfortunately, is also one of the most misinterpreted quotes of all time.

It sounds pretty straightforward, but, the same way we should not allow the evil demon to deceive us, we sure should not let the face-value simplicity of the quote mislead us. Descartes coined the term to defend philosophy against the skeptics of his time who were making the universal argument that we weren't capable of coming up with anything philosophically meaningful simply because we just couldn't trust anything -- the evil demon was winning. By telling these skeptics "I think therefore I am," he's saying they're wrong.

If Descartes spoke English he may have said, "we can question anything, but the only thing that we can't question is simply the fact that we are questioning. " So, for Descartes, we know that we are not being tricked because we are still able to question our existence. An evil demon wouldn't allow us to undermine their authority like that. So, what would be the instance or situation in which we usually don't question the reality? I can think of one: In our dreams, we don't seem to question.

Anything could happen in your dream. People who have long past could be walking on the street and you won't even think that's weird. You could be in another person's body talking, and you would not even think that's unnatural, and so on. But something of a quandary is the fact that we also don't seem to exercise our ability to question that much neither.

So, perhaps, the skeptics should be skeptical about their dreams, in which they don't question anything, rather than the reality in which they are questioning just about everything. In this sense, the father of psychoanalyst Sigmund Freud is, perhaps, right that dreams could tell us more about reality than the reality itself -- simply because we tend to question, censor, and problematize reality too much. Often what is important is something we don't have to question or censor.

When we question things or censor things, we also question and censor our own existence, and that could be a useful exercise to understand the use of reason. But when it comes to using the medicine to solve the mystery of human's consciousness in order to cure hysteria, it's much easier for the clinical psychologists and the psychoanalysts to know exactly about those things that you don't question, rather than the things that you question. Whoever knows me well knows that I used to keep a dream diary.

I did so until the summer of 2013 when I started doing my fieldwork in Shanghai, and I had to decide between spending the precious morning observing and studying the urban neighborhood on which my doctoral dissertation was based, or writing my dream diary. Anyone in their right mind would probably prioritize writing about work over writing about dreams, I thought to myself. My decision? I decided to do both.

I could not make up my mind to give up writing my dream diary completely, so whenever I got up in the morning I tried to write down as much (and as fast) as I could by hand onto a piece of paper before I got interrupted by the social activities in the neighborhood that demanded my attention.

Years of writing down dreams have taught me that the best way to capture the memory of the dream before it disappears is to try not to move my head at all while writing. This may not be the best way to get up in the morning according to science. I began to write down my dream in a hardcover Moleskin diary when I was a student at Oxford. It was there that I developed my own techniques of capturing my dreams.

One of them was to doodle, draw, and write whatever came to mind as much as possible without concerning about the coherence of the story line, and the construction of the narratives. The memory of the dreams faded very fast, and the more I moved my head around the faster it faded. So, the best way to capture it was to write while my head was still laying down on the pillow.

So, I had a diary right next to me with a fountain pen, which was the only instrument I could write comfortable with.

As soon as my consciousness woke me up in the morning, and that I realized that whatever situation I was in was a dream, I would try not to clear my mind but to use as little energy as possible to grab the fountain pen on the side of my pillow (my head was still on the pillow) and while I was still side-sleep on the pillow I would write down as much as I could on the diary.

Usually, I would doodle, draw, and most importantly, write down a few keywords, which would be anything, ranging from the people I saw in the dream, places that I was in, situations or events, or whatever, because those were just about enough for me to recall parts of the dream, and writing them down as fragments allowed me to move on quickly to write something else. Dreams are never meant to be reconstructed neatly.

They're always fragmented, and since space and time do not matter when you are inside of your own, the law of causality and transition do not apply. When I just started to write, I made a rookie mistake by trying to connect fragmented stories in my dream through a series of transitional narratives.

For instance, I thought there had to be something that transitioned myself from one dream to another, say, from talking to my diseased grandfather in front of my own house, to being in a bowling alley with President Carter. There was no connection between them. The fact that I could talk to my diseased grandfather without me reasoning that he was already dead was already a clear sign that time and space worked differently — if they're such things at all — in dreams.

What's worse was that the more I tried to reconstruct the transitional narratives, the more other, usually more important, parts of the fading memory that were still able to be recalled fades. So, instead of being able to write down a few of those fragments, I was able to write down two of them, at most, and that was because I wasted so much of my conscious energy to reason to unreasonable.

When I sat down and wrote my daily fieldnotes at night, which was my ritual before I went to bed, I would flip through the handwritten notes about my dream that I, drew, doodled, and shorthanded down in the morning. I would then try to incorporate them (as much as I thought would make sense) into my fieldnotes. Freud once said "dreams are the royal road to the unconscious," which has the potential in revealing what I might have spotted while in the field, yet egregiously censored by my consciousness.

Since I was studying the phenomenon that my consciousness allowed me to perceive, I thought it may be useful to try to think about whatever lied beneath that. I had a true hope that I would get at something by doing so. After having shared the early draft of this post with the student who suggested me this awesome film, I was bombarded with some great questions.

One of them was "have you ever tried lucid dreaming?" This was an interesting question because it seems as though being able to exercise your imagination -- and feel very real about it -- is something we all want to do. That said, after having spent some time thinking, I responded to him "Not intentionally. I am pretty content with my waking life.

Everything I ever want to do I can do it in my waking life (smile emoticon)." In fact, there is nothing that I really want to do that I can't do in my waking life. I mean, I don't want to fly. I don't want to be the richest man in the world who can buy anything. I don't want to travel through space or to the moon and back.

I don't want to see the whole horizontal plain of the earth turning vertically (like what we saw in the film *Inception*). And I don't want to have unlimited casual sex and ultimate orgy with beautiful celebrities. These seem to be a few things that most of us aspire to achieve lucid dreaming when they go to bed at night, and I don't want any of them.

In fact, if I ever arrive at lucid dreaming, I'd probably just do nothing, because doing nothing is one of the few things that I cannot do in waking life. I live in space and time -- and I have to pay my bills -- so I have to, at least, breathe. Doing nothing would mean I get to live outside of space and time. Isn't that kinda cool? The other reason why I am not that interested in lucid dreaming is because I am only interested in the unconscious.

Lucid dreaming, unfortunately, won't serve as roads to the unconscious. The scenarios one comes up with in lucid dreaming is still pretty much based on our understanding of the space and time in which we live in our waking life. We'll still think about the cause and effect, and the consequences of the action that we, in our waking life, would think about.

Our mental illnesses are all results of our inability to act according to our instinctive nature, simply because we, as Freud explains in *The Civilization and its Discontents*, are being forced by law, social norms, etc., "to be conscious" about the consequences of our action. So, living the world that consequences won't matter won't allow the layers of free association to be revealed, allowing you to connect the dots leading to a treasure map to the unconscious.

That is, in a lucid dream, we will still be exercising your consciousness to think about scenarios you wish to be in, as opposed to those that you may not be able to think that you would like to be in but actually, and deeply would make you really happy.

post Day 35: How I Come Up with a Topic about Which to Write Wed, 30 Jul 2025 00:00:00 +0000 I must admit that I didn't expect to receive so many comments from anyone at all about this blog. In fact, since I started this blog

as a little writing project only for myself, I didn't think anyone would be reading it at all, let alone finding it worth following, or their time to spend reading it.

So, when I was notified by the system that there have been more than or thousand visitors to this blog, I couldn't really begin to express how I felt. I was happy, of course, that my writing was accessible enough for a thousand people to want to read it. I was also surprised that what I had been writing had any value at all outside of my head.

So, I'd like to thank you -- yes, you, who are reading this right now -- for supporting me and wanting to know what I think about what I think about things (pun, indeed, intended). Now, I'd like to say something about how I come up with topics to write about.

A colleague of mine said to me the other day that she thought this blog was just about my dissertation writing process, and therefore it would only include things that were directly related to my dissertation, such as random data from my field research -- and some boring academic stuff. When she found out that it was not a blog about my boring data as such, she got interested in reading it, which I thought was interesting for two reasons.

First, she wasn't wrong about the fact that this blog was meant to be a blog about how I write my dissertation -- at least that's my initial plan and that was how it was conceived. Had what I had in mind then be the idea about writing a blog about all kinds of things like what it has evolved to become, I would probably not even want to start writing it.

I would have believed, without any doubts, that it would not be a good use of my time, since I should be placing my dissertation writing above everything, and therefore should not be so generous with my time in doing other forms of writing. How this blog got swayed and became a blog about all kinds of things? That's the topic of the post today. Second, I was surprised that this colleague of mine found my blog interesting.

I was surprised that she thought that someone like me would have something to offer in terms of ideas. I never thought of myself as a thinker, scholar, writer, or anything whose work is mainly about conveying great ideas through writing. The truth is having spent a lot of time with myself during the writing process -- as I wrote in my very first post on why I write -- I have been taking full advantage of being alone.

As the German philosopher Arthur Schopenhauer once said, loneliness is not always a bad thing: A man can be himself only so long as he is alone; and if he does not love solitude, he will not love freedom; for it is only when he is alone that he is really free. Schopenhauer is not a particularly optimistic person, but everything he has said has some truth in it.

My colleague Mike once made a remark (before he deleted it), "of all the great philosophers who ever walked the face of the earth, you choose the most miserable one to guide you!" I couldn't agree more with Mike. One of the reasons I find Schopenhauer's ideas very appealing is because his way of thinking is rather close to that of the Buddha -- in the sense that Schopenhauer is making his main metaphysical point very clear that life is really about suffering.

Life is about suffering not because he is looking at life from the perspective of the pessimist, but because he realizes how easy it is to be sad, simply because sustained happiness is not something that we, as human beings, are capable of having. Like the Buddha, Schopenhauer was surely also one of the most pessimistic human beings -- but we can also think of him, and also of the Buddha, as being, simply, realistic.

Therefore, they were the ones who arrived, before anyone else, at the stage of content -- which is the state of not being too happy, or too sad. There's a danger of being too happy, or too hopeful.

We might be happy because we have just won something (e.g., an award, a lottery, a scholarship, etc.), but once the excitement dies down, or when we no longer possess what makes us happy, we, again, become discontent

simply because of one lingering question, "why can't this happiness last longer?" In the classic sociological study of the French scholar Emile Durkheim, one of the root causes of suicide in the late nineteenth century France was the fact that individualism failed to prepare modern citizens to deal with failure.

Excessive hope was another root cause -- modern society wanted us to be hopeful and everything is in our own hand because God is dead -- that we can do this and this and that. But, that said, once we find out that we can't do this and this and that as we had hoped for, waiting for us is also the excessive dreadful feeling of individual "it's our own fault" responsibility. Modern society left us with no space to rescue ourselves from sinking to the bottom of melancholy.

One might argue that Durkheim and Schopenhauer are dead, and that their thoughts might not apply to people like us who are living in the twenty-first century. Well, there's a point in that argument, but there are quite a number of contemporary social scientists and thinkers who are wrestling with the idea of happiness in the direction that is quite similar to that of Durkheim and Schopenhauer's. For instance, the sociologist William Davies believes that "Happiness is all the rage" right now.

In his new book (which I have not read but heard about it from one favorite Podcast program Philosophy Bites) *The Happiness Industry: How the Government and Big Business Sold Us Wellbeing*, he argues that "real happiness may be getting left on the side of the road choking on clouds of neuro-marketing and touchy-feely excess in the pursuit of happiness." In other words, we today are too careless about how we use the term happiness, therefore making it overrated.

When asking most people what it means to them, the answers are either something rather simplistically materialistic (like having a nice car, or a new iPhone) or physical (such as having sex), or something rather abstract - too abstract to the point that even the people who talk about it themselves have no idea what they are talking about. That's exactly the point that makes

Schopenhauer's words resonate with me deeply: I don't believe that life is about seeking happiness.

I believe that life is about seeking the point (or place) where you feel content with, and there are different ways of getting there. The "three key points" which I think would help us to realize this fact and arrive at the point where you feel content about your life, which, according to me, are: first, to realize that we already have everything we need right now to be happy; hence, longing for more (especially material objects) will make you feel unhappy.

That said, an exception can be made about longing for more non-material productive sentiments, which, according to the German philosopher Friedrich Nietzsche, could actually be good for you and make you a better person. Second, it is also very crucial to realize that, if you don't care about what other people are saying or thinking about you, what they are saying or thinking about you cannot affect you in any way, so, don't give a f*** too much about what other people think about you is one way to go.

An exception, of course, is that we should also constantly evaluate and re-evaluate ourselves. Some of what other people are thinking and saying about you, though might not sound very nice, might help you to become a better person. All wise women and men value the quality of positive, and constructive criticism. Would you rather be an unwise woman or man? Finally, the feeling of wanting to possess, and hold on to things is the primary source of discontent. Think about it, what can we really owe? Our body?

We'll have to let it go at some point. Our friend? Well, saying a wrong word one time could also destroy it? Material objects? Come on; gimme a break. You get the point. One could achieve these three key points by becoming a monk, or being an outcast; but one could also achieve them by constantly reminding oneself that they are critical to the state of sustained contentment.

Many readers have shared with me that the reason they find my blog interesting to read is because they can expect all kinds of discussion from it.

The whole discussion on Schopenhauer and Durkheim above is a pretext to the part about why I think loneliness is helpful. Yes, I am a master of tangent. Yes, loneliness is helpful, because it gives you the sense of sustained contentment, because when you are alone you do not expect other people to be responsible for your contentment.

You, therefore, take full responsibility for who you are and what you do. As for myself, when I am alone I often read books, watch television, go biking, and so on. These are activities that make me feel content with myself. For Schopenhauer, the worst form of happiness is sex, as the writers of David L. Norton, Mary F. Kille describes in their book *The Philosophy of Love: Orgasm is known as the "little death"...*Orgasm ends sexual desire, which in turns end the illusion of love.

Schopenhauer writes about how we fall in love in order to have an excuse to have sex. The ultimate sexual pleasure of sex is orgasm.

But once we have reached that point, Schopenhauer observes, "we could hear the devil's laughter in the rather scary lonely moment just after orgasm." Schopenhauer feels deeply sorry for us not only because "we are all just like animals" in one sense, but also because most of time just to reach that short moment of "happiness" we lie, deceive, trick, beguile, or even physically hurt other person. How pathetic are we? Schopenhauer wonders, and I agree with him.

For that matter, by being alone I also keep myself away from sex. This post, again, was supposed to be strictly about how I come up with topics to write about, and for some reason the past few paragraphs have been about something else completely! In short, loneliness is good for intellectual incubation. It keeps you away from wanting to long for the unnecessary; it also keeps you away from wanting to hurt other people.

But what it says, also, is the fact that I have been learning about so many things that I would otherwise may not even notice while being alone writing my dissertation. For instance, my feeling about the kind of love that I would

like for myself?

I had never had the brain energy to think about it, until I had to write a chapter in my dissertation about the meaning of romantic love in urban Shanghai that I began to think about myself in relation to the informants whom I had spent time observing and interviewing. So, when I discovered that what I had been writing did have something to offer, I was extremely delighted. It was a feeling of surprise, mixed together with honor, pleasure, and warm satisfaction.

I have a feeling that you understand what I mean. So, how did I come up with various topics to talk about in this blog?

So far, we have a few posts on love, a couple of the debate over which of the dominating forces between emotion and reason govern us rationale beings, a couple posts on existentialism, quite a few (here and there) on Freud and Rousseau, also quite a few on Stoicism, a couple of writings on traditionalism and modernity, and most recently, an essay on a film and how I think about what I "perceive" in my dreams (as opposed to "see" since my eyes are closed).

Everyone of these posts represents what I really think. There's no one telling me what to write, and no moral reasoning or divine power to censor me from expressing my true thoughts (except my ability to write, perhaps, since English is not my first language). In other words, I open myself up as though I am (literally in this sense) open book -- an open blog.

I always live this way anyway in my waking life, so it's not a really big deal for me actually to write about some of these mentioned unconventional (and at times controversial) issues. Often, someone would ask me a question about he or she is curious.

Being me, I would put forward my initial thought on the subject (as I also appreciate my own intuitiveness) and then, also being me, I would retract, back off, a bit, once my passionate intuition has done its job, to really start thinking rationally about what I just put forward. That's when I sit down and

write my blog.

So, for instance, when a friend asked me about love -- "what is love?" -- I immediately answered "it is a feeling, and therefore it is not something external, or materialistic to us." Unlike "things," "objects," "facts," "rules and norms," love is internal to us because you simply can't point to it and say "there it is -- love." It is inside of you, and because of that not all of us understand love in the same way.

Some might think of it -- feel it -- as the essential pretext of sex (so that they can deceive themselves to believe that the painful, smelly, and unhygienic intercourse that they engage is not so meaningless). Some might think of love as the part of a whole traditional norm, or a precondition of marriage. Some may think of it as a biological chemistry that makes you want to go extra miles in convincing yourself that your life has a meaning after all.

Some -- especially the stupidest of all -- may even think that love is materialistic -- "you can feel it when someone is buying you a new iPhone," for instance. These were things that I later on discussed in my own head, with sometimes helps from Internet research and conversation with friends (in which case, I'd credit their contributions if they would let me).

As I mentioned before, even those who are not my friends can also be my teachers because I can also learn from them how not to be so mindless, or, simply stupid. So, in short, in writing a response to questions that make me feel as though I want to dig deeper, I get to explore my own intuition, and do more research into reasons in relation to my own sensibility. This, that's how I come up with the topics. P.S.

I just want to add a few more thoughts here. As a lifelong Buddhist and someone who found Schopenhauer's ideas resonate deeply with me, I am not a particularly pessimistic folk to be around (am I?). I have actually heard the opposite. For me, I think their ideas are not meant to be thought of as social, but virtue ethics centered around the development of an individual.

I believe in their ideas because they make me want to get up in the morning, give my all to my work, and get back home at night to recharge so that another day to give it all to what I love could conveniently arrive. It gives me the meaning of living in the present.

post Day 36: Worst Mistakes People Make in Their 20s Thu, 31 Jul 2025 00:00:00 +0000 My colleague Mike -- yes, the same Mike with whom hitherto engaged regarding our different understanding of Schopenhauer and the Buddha in my last post -- shared an interesting article on his wall today, and that is about, as the title of this post suggests, the worst mistakes people make in their 20s.

In my last post, I put forward "the three methods" to be content with life: be happy with what you already have, don't care too much about what other people say or think about you, and avoid possessing anything or becoming a possession -- an object -- of anyone at all. Now that I get to think about it, however, the first and the third methods are related. To be happy with what you have, in a way, is to not want to take in more materialistic stuff.

Anyway, I failed all of these when I was in my 20s. During the years 2002 - 2012 (my 20s), I thought my life was far from being respectable.

So, I would do whatever -- even to go extra miles without thinking about the moral consequences of my action -- to gain other people's respect either by possessing what they believed a respected person should possess, or by doing (now I think of it, totally meaningless) things that those guys somehow believed to be the benchmark of a successful life of a man in his 20s. I was totally wrong.

So, my debate with my colleague Mike on Facebook, this time, was less fierce, because both of us could somewhat agree that we both did not do very well in our 20s. I, in particular, would like to go so far as to say that had philosophy been a part of my life earlier (i.e., in my 20s), I'd be much more careful with how I'd spent my life then.

For instance, I didn't know what it mean to be "free," and I simply thought to be free was to be able to do whatever I wanted. That's deadly wrong. Doing whatever I wanted was not good for me, and because my parents and people around me also wanted me to exercise my freedom, they did not save me from myself. I did all kinds of bad things. I lied to people just to take advantage of them without thinking about consequences of my action (I was free, yah?).

By thinking that being free was separate from being moral, I may have destroyed a few people's lives (which I actually don't know since I have not been in touch with them). In short, I did so many things that I have been regretting about, -- and am still regretting today because I thought "I was free." I do not want to be free from morality.

I wanted people -- who know more than me -- to tell me what was right, and what was wrong even if that would mean that I would be following orders external to me. These people don't have to be philosophers or anything. They could either someone older than me, therefore had seen more, or simply someone more knowledgeable because they did not spend so much time taking detours in life mistakenly thinking that those detours were freedom.

But I was young then, and therefore (almost by definition) stupid, I thought being free meant to listen to no one and to exercise my freedom by doing the opposite of what the society tried to tell me to do. Sometimes, I must say, that the society was not 100% right and in that case I was happy that I didn't just follow what it told me to do.

On the other hands, many estvalished norms were there because they were helpful in creating a society in which its members could interact with one another with respect and could trust each other. To be free, now I know, is to chained to moral values. We only kid ourselves that we are free simly because we act in whatever we want. That's not free -- that's being chained to stupidity, immaturity, and the lack of moral sensibility.

Had I begun my quest to be free by asking the most fundamentally important question: "to be free from what?" Then, the meaning of being free could be very well different from simply to be able to do whatever I felt content with doing.

My answer to that question is the same as that of the great German philosopher Immanuel Kant, and the French existentialist Jean-Paul Sartre (Rosseau also writes something interesting, but when it comes to something interesting about freedom I prefer the systems that Kant and Sartre have developed). That is, I want to be free, but only from my natural inclination -- the natural drive to lie, hurt, deceive, and trick people just to benefit myself.

I, moreover, want to be free from the thinking that things have to be a certain way, and shut our doors to other options, or what Sartre calls "bad faith." Being free from this way of thinking would need a little more courage, but it's well worth it, my dear readers. I want to also be completely free from the myth that somehow the universe will solve the problem for me.

I want to live a life that is "meaningfully free," because I am free to set up a moral system by which I would like to live my life, and able to follow it. The other way to support it is to extend the notion of freedom into what free beings often don't do, which is to "live my life to serve others." In short, we tend to think of freedom as something rather individual and independent, but that is a selfish way to think about freedom.

I also believe that the absolute form of freedom is to be free to help others. We don't have to be chained to the ideas that our lives are only for ourselves. Before I get to that point, let's talk about the list that Richard Feloni, The Independent columnist, has compiled. Here's the list (and I think it's worthwhile, especially if you are in your 20s to go through each of the item on this list one by one).

I will also add my thoughts to those I think I may have something to add. 1) They neglect their health. My father died one year after he had retired from his day to day job, at 62. The reason? He didn't care about his health when he

was young. He was a chronic smoker; and he may have realized that was not healthy, and quit by the time he was 40 -- but that was too late.

The lasting effect of which to his body made his life miserable for the next two decades. I remember so well how frequently he visited a hospital every week. How much he coughed, and how much he felt uncomfortable in his own body because he sometimes couldn't sleep because of the thick saliva in his throat that he couldn't get rid of.

Growing up in the same house, I knew very well how painful it's to suffer from not being able to breath (and in the sense, the most fundamental aspect of having a life is breathing, isn't it?) thanks to my father. So, by the time he got to 50 year of age the doctor had to begin to prepare him for the worst, which came just eleven years after that physical diagnosis that his lungs and heart were failing. 2) They equate happiness with money.

And therefore, as many (including Dalai Lama) have said doing all kinds of things that are bad for their health and their time to make money, just to find out that they won't actually have the chance to turn them into happiness.

I was like that too, until I realized that I couldn't use the money I had to buy happiness - which, to me, when I was in my 20s was to take my father on a trip because he liked to travel -- because by the time that I had accumulated enough money to do so, my father was already dead.

So, I had wasted so much time making and saving money for the person whom I loved, just to realize, in a hard way, that I could have spent those time with him and be happy right away. Now that he's dead, it doesn't matter anymore how much money I have. 3) They give up when things get tough. I guess I don't have anything to add to this because I never give up.

I don't take things for granted when they are easy, and I don't give up when they are too hard. I soldier on to test the limit of myself. Moving on. 4) They let others define them. Right. This is the true kiss of death. Young men and women, please don't let anyone tell you what you should be or should do, who you love or should love, and what to do with your own body.

By letting yourself being succumbed into others' object of deliberation, you are subjecting yourself to "bad faith," and that will be the end of it -- I mean, the end of your life since it will no longer be meaningful. You will no longer see the need to be free, and will be spend the rest of your life doing things that will only lead to slow death. Also read Day 28: I Was Just Lucky. 5) They are impatient. I was young, and I was impatient.

I thought I had everything, including the privilege to not having to wait. The attitude costed me a fortune. At one time, when the global economy was still doing okay, I thought I could "bypass" all the rites of passage to get at where I'd like to be, simply by taking out loans. Many people had spent years to earn enough to go abroad. I didn't have that patient, and decided to take out a lot of money from the bank to pay for my own path. The result?

The economic downturn hit the whole world very badly (in 2008) and my debts increased threefold. I had to spend almost 5 years after that to pay off my debts. 6 +7) They try to please everyone + They think all friendships can last forever. Yes. We can't please everyone. That's just not possible. Even if we think are can, we can't, and that's because we are not in control of what other people think. As simple as that.

The only mind that you are in control of is your own, and the best advise is to stick to what you believe is the best way to follow your own system of morality. Some people might not understand you at first, and they might never will, but that's the path that you have chosen. It could be that it's their false -- it's their loss -- to not be pleased by you, and they might or might not know that. But there's nothing you can do about it.

Friendship, also, doesn't last forever. Sometimes we come to the point that we can't agree. I have all the tolerance of differences, as long as it's the beliefs that are not egregiously in direct conflict with my own moral standards, which is actually not that high actually. All in all, I can be friends with anyone who believe that we might not be able to change the world, but we can do our part to make it better." That's the foundation of my moral standards.

I did "unfriend" (in real life) a number of people who did not share with me this very basic foundation. So, friendship is important, but you shouldn't let yourself sink that low neither if the way in which your friend thinks about his or her role in the society is in direct conflict with yours. Sooner or later, either both of you will do whatever just to serve your own self-interest, or you will no longer be friends. By the way, do savor, and keep the good memories though.

So, live by your own moral standards, play by your own moral rules. Also see Day 35: How I Come Up with a Topic about Which to Write. 8) They think moving somewhere new will solve their problems. Maybe it can; and maybe it can't. I actually think it can. It depends on the nature of your problem.

I have been moving around a lot -- not to run away from my problem though -- and every time I am in a new place, the way I think about my problem changes. I believe there's a merit in getting out of the place with which you feel familiar, and move your body and soul into a new terrain that might make you feel as though your problem isn't that intense, bad, or difficult. So, in fact, I have to disagree with this point.

I think moving somewhere new could help solving your problem. It might not change the problem, but it could change the way you see the problem and that could mean a lot. 9) They create bubbles around themselves. See Day 31: Why Modesty is Bad for the Society. 10) They see things in black and white. Yes, you shouldn't. Most of the things we see in the world aren't in black and white, so why should you be seeing them in black and white to begin with?

The true answer, usually, lies in the grey area. In one episode of the Philosophize This podcast, the narrator Stephen West talks about the two opposing viewpoints of Edmund Burke and Thomas Paine on how society should progress and implement change. While Burke advocated the slow and gradual "don't fix it if it ain't broken" kind of change, Paine only accepted "fast pace and all at once" revolution-styled kind of change as the only way to solve any kinds of problem.

They are both right, despite the fact that only Burke was thought as being "on the right" then (pun, yes, intended). Paine here represented "the left" who couldn't see that as the solution because most of the problems, to him, are deep-rooted and therefore the only way to solve them is to re-do the entire foundation. The thing is we are both left and right depending on the situation we are facing -- well, we have both the left and the right hand. Each hand has their use.

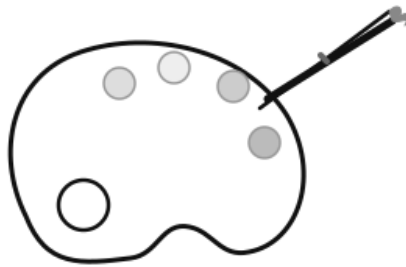
Sometimes we'd like gradual changes, and sometimes we believe that re-structuring the whole problem is the only way to fix the problem in long-term. Yet, even though sometimes we know that we need a structural change, but still prefer the slow and gradual change because we don't have the means (e.g., money) to go ahead with the face pace one, so we do whatever we can and work with whatever we have.

And sometimes we know that slow changes are better, but we have to go ahead with the face pace program because most of the people would not buy the idea of the slow changes. Also see Day 34: Waking Life. 11) They look for their "soul mate." See Day 15: All About Nana 12) They try planning years in advance. See Day 26: On Death. 13) They think they're the only one of their friends struggling. You are not. We all have our own problems.

DAY 37

Of the Standard of Beauty

Fri, 01 Aug 2025 00:00:00 +0000



SAM (AN INTENTIONAL GENDER-NEUTRAL PSEUDONYM) was visiting our city for a few days, so my friend and I took Sam out to dinner. A conversation about weight came up during our conversation about food. "I am blessed to be able to eat a lot and not get fat," said Sam. We did, in fact, order a large amount of food that evening and were successful in finishing all of it by the end of the meal. According to my standards, Sam was slim and looked healthy.

What struck me was not that Sam was able to eat a lot and maintain a desirable weight, but Sam's explanation of how Sam could eat a lot and not gain weight. I am lucky. I have a fast metabolism. Knock on wood. Sam's explanation brings to mind a series of intertwined concepts.

First and foremost, there is a shift in the understanding of how a person gains weight, from the amount of food consumed, to the "misguided faith" in missing the chemical processes that maintain a healthy life, i.e., in this case, metabolism, or the synthesis of the proteins, carbohydrates, and fats that form tissue and store energy. "I don't really know what it means -- all I know is that if you have a fast metabolism, you won't get fat," said Sam.

One of our friends there, fortunately, was a medical doctor, so he shared with me afterwards the crucial information about metabolism, which has

been well summarized in Mayo Clinic's website as follows: It's true that metabolism is linked to weight. But contrary to common belief, a slow metabolism is rarely the cause of excess weight gain. Although your metabolism influences your body's basic energy needs, it's your food and beverage intake and your physical activity that ultimately determine how much you weigh.

The fact that Sam comfortably spoke about metabolism (without knowing what it really meant) exemplifies the lack of knowledge about human biology the average person possesses about the science of human biological life available, as well as the popular knowledge about what makes us fat or thin. Second, there is a process of "self-promotion" by using a certain unique quality of one's biology to distinguish oneself from others. This process of self-promotion reinforces the misconception that there are people who were simply unfortunate for not possessing the same unique quality.

Sam's "I-am-lucky statement" struck me and, due to my skepticism and curiosity, I loosely observed how Sam ate, which got me to realize that what Sam meant by "I have a fast metabolism" was no more than a tactic of pretending to eat but not really putting anything in his/her mouth. Throughout our conversation, every 10-15 spoonfuls of rice other people (me included) put in their mouth, Sam would eat a half-spoon of a carefully selected protein-based food.

Unlike others, Sam didn't drink beer, but consumed only red wine, a diet-friendly alcohol choice, but only a limited amount (although Sam also claimed "I can drink a lot without getting drunk"). Of course, I am not trying to over-read Sam's action, as I don't think that Sam was that calculating. It could just be that this was Sam's habit of eating. Yet, what this eating habit shows is the fact that Sam actually did not really eat much, if Sam ate anything at all that evening.

The food was all gone but it was other people on the table who consumed 90%-95% of the food (oh, forgot to say that we weren't eating a la carte). Later, from Sam's friends, I learned that Sam was on multiple kinds of dietary

and weight loss products. Sam would sometimes starve at night in order to stay slim. "I never have to worry about my weight," Sam reinforced our perception of Sam's body many times that evening. Similar to Sam's I-am-lucky statement, this statement raises several questions.

On the one hand, I don't understand why Sam claimed to have a faster metabolism than others, when, like anyone else, Sam was so concerned with weight gain and appearance. On the other hand, even if Sam were worried about that, why would someone make up a claim that there was something about that someone's biological quality that is better than others? (and why rely on a scientific underpinning, i.e., faster metabolism).

From the viewpoint of bio-sociality, Sam's I-am-lucky discourse systematically connects biological knowledge, concepts of identity and self-hood, and modes of political articulation to become a "new collective subject" in order to gain an advantage over the perception of the laypeople about Sam's unique biological quality. I assume that we at the dining table were the laypeople.

The problem here is that Sam's knowledge about biology was limited (as Sam wasn't able to explain what he/she meant by metabolism), Sam's concepts of identity and self-hood were dominated by Sam's own critical pressure of finding employment (which I later learned), which, in turn, distorted Sam's modes of political articulation (as it wasn't clear whether or not Sam believed that everyone was born equal).

From an evolutionary perspective, it is advantageous for Sam to portray Sam's own thinness as the result of "good genes" (high metabolism/luck) because that is an assurance that Sam will likely stay thin where as those who constantly battle with their weight could easily loose that battle and plummet into obesity. What my observation of Sam brings to mine is a horrifying story I read in the news a while ago.

It was a story of a woman who almost died because from a weight loss surgery she sought after she was insulted by a "woman of a larger size" at a

supermarket who told her that she should be drinking fat-free instead of 2% fat milk. I could imagine that Sam's I-am-lucky statement would have a similarly negative impact on a person who is sensitive to this issue.

Without knowing that Sam was lying about the luck he/she "happens to possess," someone could be tricked into believing that he/she has to do something, including something risky, to change that because he/she "happens to lack" that kind of luck. That is to say, while one could look into Sam's statements as "seemingly" factual and self-reflexive, I cannot help but to think that they are also forms of bullying. The fact the word "fat" was not used in a direct sense does not make it less harassing.

In fact, truth be told, bullies that come in forms of benign efforts to help or indirect demonstration of biological differences can also be equally or even more damaging. P.S. This is a re-post, with minor edits, from my old blog called Life in Urbanism. The original title of the post is "All About Sam." Duh.

The reason why I am re-posting this is because I lately have been thinking about how I survived during all those years during which I had to endure the difficulty of having to live with people like Sam. Most beautiful-minded people I have met don't look like people you see in films. In fact, many people you see in films don't look like those people you want to see in films anymore.

The standard of beauty is changing, and we are more accepting to differences, which I think is one of the greatest things about our time, but only if you happen to have the privilege in living in the places that welcome and accept diversity with open arms. Unfortunately, I didn't grow up in a place like that. In fact, surrounding me were people who happened to believe that everything that happened to you happened to you thanks precisely to only one thing -- that which is faith.

People around me made comments about how other people were fat, ugly, bald, and so on, without even a slight conscience that which such comments may be unfair. Nobody can choose a body to be born into. And sometimes you can't control what happens to your body.

The same way we'd feel the deep sense of shame when we mistakenly make fun of the disabled people (like in the film *Ted 2* when Ted and Johnny were so ashamed of themselves for making fun of a blind man because they didn't realize he was blind), we should feel the same sense of guilt when we think of people who do not have the "cosmetic look" at you happen to believe to be good-looking or beautiful.

Beauty is in the eye of the beholder -- I do still believe it -- and I would also mention that we have this idiom thanks to the philosopher David Hume. His actual quote is: Beauty is no quality in things themselves: It exists merely in the mind which contemplates them, and each mind perceives a different beauty.

This quote appears in his famous (though short) essay "Of the Standard of Taste," written and published in 1757, in which he also adds to that mantra that when we feel that something is beautiful, it's largely having to do with our own upbringing. What we have been told to believe to be pretty; what we have been told to try to avoid or to completely avoid; what we shall think of being completely ugly because that which is a matter out of place.

According to Hume, beauty without a careful consideration in the name of forced objective neutrality is blind and mindless. Think about this for a second here. When we see things that we believe to be beautiful, how much time do we spend in asking "why it is/she/he beautiful?" Most people don't ask at all -- they just take the beauty of the object, of a person, as a given. One reason is that we cannot really do that in reality.

We do not have time, and conscious energy, to make sense of everything that we see (unless we are David Hume, of course), so we might as well should just forget about it -- the superficiality of life. I believe that we all have something interesting to offer -- of all us do -- and I believe that which is the true heart and intellectual energy to improve the community of which we are a part.

The other lesson that we can learn from Hume here is that the only form of beauty that is internal to our sense of biological being is the inner beauty.

The external beauty, such as your look, is external to your being. You won't know whether you are beautiful or not until someone tells you. You need someone to tell you whether or not you are good-looking, and that makes no sense to me.

People say they want to be beautiful because they want themselves to appreciate it, but that's not entirely true since the constant desire for other people's acceptance is what you desire for when you fabricate yourself to appeal to the world of external beauty. It's the only internal beauty, what you are as a person, that could make you happy because you can be content with yourself without having to rely on other people's acceptance. No emphasis, at all, should be placed on how we look.

Fat or thin, bald or full of hair, and so on, should not matter. I don't see these distinctions anymore, in fact. I don't like what Sam did because Sam was conscious of the fact that Sam was making things "seem as though Sam was born lucky," than others. Sam was not. The society in which both Sam and I are living is a developed society, in which neither of us could easily get away with making arbitrarily judgmental comments on beauty and natural attributes.

I want to say that Sam should also not be allowed to fabricate Sam's own story to replicate those arbitrarily judgmental comments. Like any of us, Sam would get fat if Sam eats carelessly and unhealthily, but the way in which Sam portrays Sam's own "given superiority," that evening, simply made me sick to my stomach. My personal story: I was bald for a long time because my father just passed away and I was in the complete state of melancholy so I was in obscurely deep and miserable sorrow.

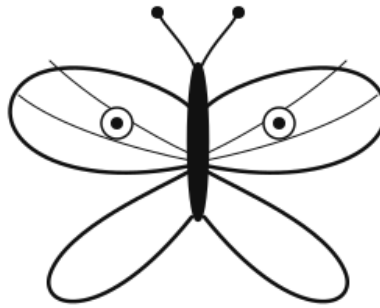
Every minute of my waking life, people came to me and said to me, "oh, you're bald; that's so sad." I was not born bald, but I was bald because I was dealing with stress, and stress -- especially because I was extremely sad -- may have been the cause of hair loss. I didn't want to be bald because I didn't want people to pity me. On the other hand, why should I care about them?

At the end of the day, I would rather spend my saving on philanthropic activity, rather than getting an expensive hair transplant surgery which is still the one and only effective way of artificially growing back the hair that you have lost.

DAY 38

My Butterfly Dream

Sat, 02 Aug 2025 00:00:00 +0000



ONCE UPON A TIME, ZHUANGZI dreamed that he was a butterfly, flying about enjoying itself. It did not know that it was Zhuangzi. Suddenly he awoke, and veritably was Zhuangzi again. He did not know whether it was Zhuangzi dreaming that he was a butterfly, or whether it was the butterfly dreaming that it was Zhuangzi. Between Zhuangzi and the butterfly there must be some distinction. This is a case of what is called the transformation of things. The above passage is from C. W.

Chan's analysis of Zhuangzi's Butterfly Dream. I have heard of it many times, but have never understood what the ancient Daoist philosopher Zhuangzi was talking about: When Zhuangzi said the thing about how he wasn't sure that in his dream one night he was a butterfly dreaming that he was Zhuangzi, or the other way around. I was lying on my bed, and was not even realizing that I was there. I was someone else who was doing something else -- what I was doing I do not remember.

All I remember was that, I was "doing something" for a while. As I wrote in my previous post about some of my very secret techniques I believe that whoever wish to methodically document his or her dream need to learn, this time I failed at all fronts because when I got up in the middle of night I wasn't sure whether or not I was still dreaming. I wasn't even sure where I was. I

didn't feel as though I was lying on my bed, even.

I wasn't sure how long I was dreaming, but it felt as though it was as long as a lifetime (as if I know what lifetime means, well, "lol"). It took me a while to suddenly get up, and realized that the entire thing that I had been doing -- whatever that was -- was just a dream that happened in a fraction of my sleeping hours which weren't that great lately.

It could have been two hours, but why did I feel as though I was completely a different person (or a being, an animal, or a thing) doing something for a really long period of time. And whatever I was doing there wasn't any association with my waking life, at all. Maybe this was what Zhuangzi experienced when he was dreaming that he was a butterfly, especially when he writes, "Soon I awoke, and there I was, veritably myself again.

Now I do not know whether I was then a man dreaming I was a butterfly, or whether I am now a butterfly, dreaming I am a man." After having this experience myself, it was clear to me that the question that Zhuangzi was wrestling with was not just about oneness of the world, or the metaphysics of transformation -- it's about consciousness.

Yes, consciousness, or the state of being aware that, as I would like to define here: 1) one is not being deceived by anyone; 2) that one, as defined by the New England Journal of Medicine, is "not being in the state of full awareness of self and one's relationship to the environment" (as in sleeping); and, 3) or that one is not being fully aware of the unconventional things, despite how pleasing they may seem, around one's body (or non-body).

Dream-like settings are often understood as deviating us away from the state of being conscious. After having the dream that night, consciousness was the first word that came my mind when I woke up sideways realizing that I was not a thing in the dream, but a man who was about to be late for his errand. What, to me, constitutes consciousness?

I asked myself then since the definitions above could only do so much good when I even doubt my own ability to understand what seems real and what's

not. Can we be conscious when we were dreaming? The answer is both a yes and a no (although I am convinced that it should be no). Again, according to the neuroscientists, there is still awareness of the environment during sleep.

And for them, the main evidence to support this claim is that we have to still be aware of the environment otherwise we won't be able to be woken up by an arousal (e.g., an alarm clock) at all. The other evidence of this quasi-awareness is somnambulism -- oops, sorry for wanting to use my GRE vocabulary, meaning, simply, sleepwalking (from Latin *somnus*, meaning "sleep," as in *insomnia*, or inability to sleep, and *ambulare*, meaning to "to walk," as in *ambulate* or moving about).

When one sleepwalks, one is not completely detached from the physical environment in which one resides, but one is also dwelling in one's own state of unconscious imaging the physical terrain through which one walks to be something else rather different from what it physically presents.

The differences between being in the complete state of coma, and simply sleeping or sleepwalking is that in the state of coma, there's no consciousness what soever that would allow the person in coma to be aware of the fact that he is lying on a bed, which is the environment into which he could wake up.

Yet, as I realize how real it was being a thing, and doing a thing (I tried and tried and still don't remember what it was) in my dream, I should, as suggested by the neuroscientists above, leave some room for the yes as well. I wasn't conscious enough to realize that I was dreaming, and when my conscious hit me the moment I open my eyes, I realized that I was conscious and that what just happened to me happened to me when I was not conscious.

There has to be some overlaps between the state of complete unconscious, and the state of conscious enough to know that one is unconscious, and the complete consciousness. It's getting confusing here... The difference between being in the conscious state and being in the unconscious state is

that in the former you are responsible for whatever you do -- whether or not you are fully conscious. In the latter, you can easily get away with things because it could only last as long as you are able to sleep.

Zhuangzi, I believe, was not that naive when he said that by having that butterfly dream one night he could begin to seriously question his existence. That would be absurd. Was he responsible for himself being the butterfly in his dream? Did he remember where he went and what he did? Did he remember how many immoral things he'd left behind when he was the butterfly?

He distinguishes very clearly the differences about being Zhuangzi dreaming he was a butterfly, and about being a butterfly dreaming that he was a Zhuangzi. For that matter, I see two separate terrains to be discussed here: first, the importance of realizing that in the unconscious state, you are not and never alone, so every action of your action counts -- otherwise why would Zhuangzi wrote about it anyway once he woke up? Second, long story short, sleeping is important, and we have many scientific evidences to support this claim.

We can only be fully conscious once we how to appreciate the unconscious state, which we called sleeping.

post Day 39: On Time Sun, 03 Aug 2025 00:00:00 +0000 Making efficient use of time is my *raison d'être* The quote above is my own. I don't usually quote myself, but this time, since this topic is about the reason and purpose of my existence -- *raison d'être* -- I feel that it's fair enough for me to be a narcissist once in a while.

Let me begin with how I got around writing this topic, before I get to why I believe making efficient use of my time is the purpose of my life. I recently had a conversation with a colleague, which went as followed: Mike (a pseudonym, of course): I don't understand what you just said. Non: Perhaps if you read this book you would understand it more. Mike: A book? I don't have time to read a book. Non: How about a Podcast episode. It's about 10 minutes.

I'll send you the link. Mike: I don't have time for a Podcast episode either. Non: What do you have time for then? Mike: I don't have time for anything. I then chug the liquid in the can of Santory Gold beer that I bought from the convenient store nearby, just so that I did not have to be so traumatized from this conversation. This colleague, by the way, even after having spent almost a decade in China, still speaks no Chinese.

His reason for not being capable of speaking Chinese despite the fact that he has no plan to leave is, as one might be able to guess, "I have no time for it." To be clear though, it's never the case we don't have time -- it's always the case that we don't make time for it. There are something else that we'd rather do instead, which might be because we don't feel the urgency of doing it, or that we don't see the need in doing it.

For Mike, even if he has 48 hours a day, we probably still wouldn't be able to speak Chinese as he probably would be spending the extra 24 hours doing something else instead, such as drinking, relaxing, or bragging about his success in having been in China for so long without having to learn a word of Chinese (his English, which is not his native language, is also very uncomfortable to hear, in fact, and guess what's his reason for not wanting to improve his English. You got it).

Mike doesn't feel as though he needs to learn Chinese; thus, he never wants to make time for it. His community accepts him as he is, and never asks him to pursue something external to his comfort zone.

I would actually be much more happier if his reason for not wanting to learn Chinese is "I don't want to make time for it because I don't need to," rather than "I don't have time for it." Having been his colleague for almost three years, I always see him doing things that are not only detrimental to his development as a professional in his field, but also damaging to his -- and our collective -- sense of humanity.

This particular instance, in fact, makes me want to evaluate our collegiality. Should we still be colleagues? Well, I'll let you read until the very end of this

post first, and then, you can make time to tell me what you think. Time is the only thing that we have, said my grandfather. I was lucky (again, borrowing a this from another post that I wrote earlier this month) born into a family that values time.

My maternal grandparents, for instance, never let a day goes by without accomplishing what they had planned to achieve. They weren't business people but tailors and grocers in a small town, so their goal weren't necessary qualitatively high (although, they sometimes could earn a lot in a day selling the clothes that they made). Instead, the bar they set high had to do with the quality of their work. Growing up in under the roof of the house they built in Northeastern Thailand, I saw how hard they worked.

In fact, one thing I remember was the "family ethics" that they told me almost every time they had a chance to when I was young, which was, "Rising early; eating fast; and working hard." All of these rules were meant to maximize the efficiency of the work that they did.

I once asked, "This doesn't sound fun -- what's the pleasure in any of these that you're doing?" My grandmother's answer was simple, "you'll find the pleasure in seeing other happy, whether that be you, my grandson, or your mother, or the customers who love the products that we deliver to them." I was about ten-year-old at the time, so it, perhaps, made a lot of sense that I didn't quite get what she was trying to convey to me.

Both of my maternal grandparents passed away almost 7 years ago now. My grandpa passed away in 2008, right before I was traveling to the UK to pursue my study at Oxford, followed by the death of my grandma less than a year after. I wasn't in Thailand during both years, so I didn't go to their funerals.

My father, who was alive at the time, and my mother told me not to come back, but "to keep pursuing my goal and being good at what I do." I was close to both of my grandparents, and really wanted to come back to the funerals -- not just to show respect to them for the last time but also to spend time

thinking about them and what they had taught me.

But I guess our "family ethics" ran very deep in our mentality toward life, nobody wanted me to come back to Thailand for their funerals. My mother, especially, told me, "the best way to pay homage to your grandparents is to continue to pursue your goal...

you can never get back the time that I have lost, so treasure it and do things that matter." I, of course, never forget that, and especially when my father passed away in 2010, the importance of time vis-à-vis the meaning of my life has never been clearer. It could have been her who told me that time is money.

What she meant was a more complicated than the very fact (that I already knew) that time is valuable, so don't waste it the same way you wouldn't waste your money. As an economist by training, embedded in her teaching was also the very nature of the economics of resource management.

What she said was that we're all born into a society that provides all of us an unconditional basic income -- we all get it, like a universal coverage of basic income guarantee -- which is 24 dollars a day. The only thing that this society imposes upon us is that you can't save it if you don't use it all. In other words, we have to spend all of the 24 dollars everyday. I guess you probably now know where she's going with that metaphor.

So, those 24 dollars are the 24 hours in every day of our life. A life doesn't give us an option of saving hours not used. We are born into the world shaped by space and time that cannot be saved for the late use. So, how would you spend those 24 hours? In my earlier post "On Death," I touched upon how I came to value time differently after the death of my father. I used to think that I could live forever.

I used to think that my father would also live for a long time, and because of that I took for granted that his time was running out. Had I known that he would pass away so soon (at the age of 62), I would not have gone to school abroad, and would have spent the last ten years of his life with him. I could

also go to school abroad, but I could not go back to live with him when he's no longer alive.

There were so many things that my father still wanted to do, but his physique did not want him to pursue. He thought he would have a lot of free time after his retirement to do things he always wanted to do, such as traveling, raising a dog, and drawing (which had always been his favorite hobby when he was young). He didn't realize that he would die only two years after his retirement. No one, in fact, thought that which would happen, so we weren't prepared at all.

The moment I received a message from my brother that my father had just passed away, I felt as though the time had stopped, and that nothing really mattered anymore, including even if my life, also, would just end there. For someone who'd been taking time for granted for 28 years, the moment when the time completely stopped such as this was painful. I wanted it to pass as soon as possible so that I no longer had to be in deep sorrow but it did not. It lingered.

I was in Boston at the time. It continued to linger. The sadness doubled when I couldn't hide my sorrow and was asked by people who thought I looked horrible. The sadness lingered. I wished it would feel like a sharp nice poking through my heart so that all would just end. It wasn't like that at all. I felt as though my heart was so heavy -- so heavy that every time I tried to get up it pulled me down. I didn't know how long it lingered.

All I remember was that I got on a plane 24 hours after. The 16-hour-long Korean Airlines flight felt as though it was a light year. Everything about my father and I -- our 28 years of our lives together -- kept coming back to me in forms of vivid flashbacks. The trip across the Pacific from Boston to Bangkok was like me living my life with my father again, but with the pretext that I already knew how it was going to end.

After his death, I became aware of the fact that my time, also, is limited, and the only thing I could do for my father is to make sure that I don't take for

granted that one day I will Time is the reason why I don't have many close friends. In fact, I often prefer to be alone. The reason for which is simple: because time is important to me, I want to spend as much time as possible with myself.

Those who I consider friends are people who I believe that I could learn more about myself by spending time with them. In other words, I only mingle and converse with people whom I believe make me a better person by helping me make efficient use of my time.

I consider spending time with people who don't improve me a waste of my time, and since my time is valuable, I would rather spend it with myself than with those who I believe to have more the potential to waste it rather than to make a meaningful use of it.

Again, because sometimes I could not know right away whether the person with whom I am about to spend time will waste my time, therefore I often have to just spend time with them just to test the depth of the water. Often, if not always, these are the characteristics of people who, as soon as I realize that they have these characteristics, I would stop spending time with them right away: First, they have bad faith.

In other words, they believe that things have to be a certain way, and outright refuse other options. For Jean-Paul Sartre, who coined the term "bad faith," it is a crime to insist that we have to do a particular kind of work, or live with a specific person -- just because we believe that things have to be a certain way without exercising our freedom to discover other options otherwise. Examples of people with bad faith? I am a student, I have to believe in whatever the teacher says.

I am a woman, my role is to be a "good girl," by acting as though I don't have my own agency, and as though my life is only meaningful when I am with a man. I was born in this social class, so there's no point trying to be something else. Just to name a few. You get the point. Second, the people who take things at face value. These are the people who find comfort in conformity.

The main idea of this point overlaps a bit with the idea of having a bad faith above, in the sense that people who lazily believe that "if it ain't broke don't fix it" are people who will always follow others as long as they don't have to do the work, or stand up for their own right, or to do anything that might be consider risk-taking. Sometimes these people don't even know that the conformity in which they find comfort are not comfort at all.

An example I find meaningful is from the TV series Masters of Sex. There's a scene in which a lady who took part in the sex research pursued by the protagonists Bill Masters and Virginia Johnson. (by the way, this TV series was based on the book written by Thomas Maier under the same title, which I think is much more accurate, though not as sexy).

The context of this show was the in the 50s and 60s when sex wasn't a topic allowed to be discussed so openly in public -- mainly because of various religious doctrines that prohibited it. Many people were not satisfied with their sex life because there's no one to educate them about how to enjoy it. Dr. Bill Masters, a gynecologist and fertility doctor, got so fed up with having to solve the problem at the tail of the cause rather than at the root was thinking.

He believed that if people learn how to maximize their pleasure from sex, most of the infertility problems will be solved even before it gets to become problems. Dr. Masters debunked the religious claim to keep sex outside the realm of proper education as "immoral" by saying: Science by itself has no moral dimension. But it does seek to establish truth. And upon this truth morality can be built.

Often, if not always, the men in the 50s and 60s did not know exactly how to have sex -- because they weren't taught how to. So, they treated women as their sexual objects. Women themselves also didn't know that they "deserved better" than that, because they "were told to conform with the belief that they were subordinate to men" (and, lo and behold, guess who cr eated such belief for the women to believe? The men!) Hence, Dr.

Masters recruited a number of ladies who never experienced orgasm to take part in an experiment to experience orgasm for the first time. This lady, who experienced orgasm for the first time during the experiment, said something like (I don't remember the exact words verbatim): The feeling [I had after having an orgasm for the first time in my life during the experiment conducted by Dr.

Masters and Virginia Johnson] was a feeling of someone who, in her entire life, had always been told to wear shoes two sizes smaller than her feet. It's ridiculously painful, but because she believed that those small pairs of shoes was her size, she endured the pain. And one day -- one day -- someone introduced a pair of shoes two sizes bigger than what she had always worn to her. Wearing those shoes her size, she felt as though she's walking on the cloud.

So, there are many things we think we are conforming to because it's easier to be among the majority -- without knowing that once you have stepped outside of it you will feel much better. I do see some values in gradual change and tradition, but I see much more value in our human's ability to critique the convention.

Of course, anyone who stands up among the crowds who are sitting down will be noticed -- and sometimes he or she will get a rock thrown at for being different -- conformity is appealing precisely for that reason. Nevertheless, there's a deep danger associated with such conformity. What if we know deep down that such things to which we are conforming is wrong, and that if we shout out we will get hurt, should we still do it in the name of being true to ourselves?

My only answer is yes. I think it's a responsibility to do so. Long story short, I can't hang out with people with bad faith, and people who find comfort in conformity without questioning the very origin of such comfort. I would feel as though it's a crime for me to hang out with them, and that's why I don't have many close friends.

The most important goal in my life, as many philosophers have suggested (e.g., Socrates, The Buddha, René Descartes, Immanuel Kant, and Thomas Hobbes) is to understand myself. Thomas Hobbes, especially, uses the term "introspect" to denote the critical importance of the allocation of time to examine one's own thoughts or feelings, which should be placed above anything else. René Descartes (who is famous for saying "I think therefore I am") goes as far as to say that if we spend enough time with our own thoughts, anything can be solved.

One can, of course, both literally and rhetorically read what Descartes says here. On the one hand, it could be the case Descartes meant that by exercising our critical reasoning on the question that challenges us, we can arrive at the stage in which we no longer have to assume that we are capable of solving. In this stage, we can actually engage in the process of solving that problem (which would be the rhetorically way of reading Descartes).

On the other hand, it could be that what he meant was simply that the problem does not really exist, it exist because we "perceive" them to exist (sounds familiar? The philosopher Bishop George Berkeley also says something quite similar to this but with an empiricist rather than a rationalist take, which I will some point revisit in this blog).

So, in order to understand how to solve it, we must thoroughly examine such perception, and often, we find ourselves already solving that problem, through the critical examination of that problem, in our head without having to even lift a finger in real life. Again, I am not an expert on Descartes, and only have a very limited knowledge in the kind of question he was wrestling with during his time. I guess if his house was on fire, he would have to do more than just thinking to survive.

That said, he himself couldn't escape the problem of death neither -- apparently pneumonia couldn't be solved only introspecting deeply, and he was killed by it at the age of 53. To conclude, time is the only domain in which we have no choice but to live our life. We can't exist outside of the domain of time (and space, for that matter).

Just to counter argue my point (before you, my friends, do!), we can, of course, live outside the domain of time -- but only if we can take off what Immanuel Kant calls "the space-time spectacles," with which we're born. Taking off this spectacles would allow us to see and experience the world of things external to the phenomenological world -- takin' off this spectacles would allow us to see and experience things in themselves (or the noumenal).

Kant, nevertheless, did not say how we could take off those spectacles, so let assume we can't take them off. So, if we can't take them off, we should, to the fullest, learn how to live with them and experience the world through them. Our time is more valuable than money because we can't get it back, and we have to use it. What else in life that we have to use it and can't get it back if we didn't use it properly? Nothing else but time.

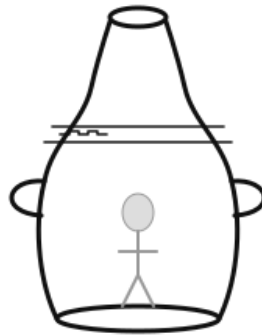
This is why time is so important to me, and this is why I often say "I don't have time," when I don't feel like conversing with someone and engaging in something (e.g., an activity) that would take away my time. Don't get me wrong. I am not saying that I have to always do things that have an effect in my personal development as such. I also enjoy relaxing and doing nothing. I also enjoy sitting at a chair and watching the sun goes down without thinking about anything.

I also enjoy drinking a glass of wine, also, without thinking about anything. All of these make me appreciate time, so it's a good use of time for me. I loathe spending time with people with bad faith, and in activities that don't value my time. And, I usually don't even have time to tell those people or to inform the organizers of those activities that I no longer want to interact with them. I just don't have time.

DAY 40

On Sex: Part 1

Mon, 04 Aug 2025 00:00:00 +0000



TRY TO IMAGINE A SOCIETY in which there is no marriage. One where men and women take multiple sex partners in their teens, 20s and 30s, and never settle down with one. Imagine a society without husbands or fathers — one that has no word for father. Impossible? We assume the nuclear family — with a father, mother, and children — is the basic building block of society, and anything else seems unimaginable.

Yes, the situation in the passage above seems unimaginable -- almost unthinkable, especially in the modern days whereby an ordinary family consists of a marriage couple and their kid(s). It has almost been hardwired into our brain that we "must" get married. Personally, I have been asked almost on a daily basis (as a single 34-year-old man), "When are you going to get married?" My answer is always silence, mainly because I really do not know how to answer. Usually, I just smile. Often, I think it's my personal life.

Always, it's difficult for me to conform to things, traditions, and norms, of which I do not fully understand the productive logic. Occasionally, I would use my standard line: "[I'll get married] when I meet someone with whom I really want to spend the rest of my life with." But that's almost a lie, since I don't plan to get married until I really understand its true purpose, which, thanks to the complicated nature of this project, could be a life-long project

in itself.

That said, quite often, this standard line isn't good enough, especially when the inquirers are my older relatives. "Don't be so picky, Non," I could hear their voice in my head -- "just pick someone -- anyone -- you're too old to be single; you need someone, a woman, to take care of you." Well, for those who have read a few posts on love on this very blog, you'd probably have learned that it's never because of my pickiness that makes me single.

Instead, it's my own absurd criteria: the kind of person with whom I would like to spend my life has to be intellectual, non-possessive, and have good faith (as opposed to bad faith in Sartrean term). Believe it or not, it's not that easy to find a person whose personality, being, and soul tick all the boxes.

Although I thought that it's already so so so absurd just to think that the idea of "picking anyone" is even on the table for a man (just because I am old?), this situation is much worse for the Chinese women, whose country targets them as the quick-fix to the rising problem of the gender imbalance. Long story short, because of the recently dismissed one-child-policy, China now has more boys than girls (as a result of intentional "gendercide" of the baby girls, and giving the baby girls up for adoption).

The Chinese state, using the All-Chinese Women Federation (ACWF) as its mouthpiece, sees this gender imbalance as a potential source of social instability (and therefore population decline), and thus hopes to rectify it by "encouraging" people to get married. Guess what's the strategy they have come up with? Hint: this strategy is targeting at those who are vulnerable to the way in which the society sees them.

The strategy they have come up with is to brand the women who are selective in choosing their mates "leftover women." By the ACWF definition, "leftover women" are urban females who have not gotten married past the age of 27. Personally, I found this strategy to ridiculously absurd, as I could not wrap my head around the idea that a mindless policy as such would have any impact on such a modern society such as that of the Chinese. Chinese

Women are now educated, intelligent, and independent.

Why would they let a government arm such as the ACWF to tell them that they have to get married to someone they turn 27 year of age, other they'd be no longer wanted — leftover? It just seems absurd to me, which is partly because I personally really admire working women who are passionate about their professional life. I find working women to be very attractive, both physically and emotionally, as they are both mature, intelligent, and beautiful in the way that they chose to be.

That said, I may have underestimated the gravity of this "leftover women" phenomenon. As many scholars and journalists have written about, this "leftover women" phenomenon has a profound impact on the social anxiety and market economy in China.

Many educated urban professional women are anxious about being branded "leftover." I don't think these women, initially, are willing to change their standard just to get married with someone, but once the branding technique has been put in place, they are "feeling the effect" of being branded as outcasts when they are still single past the age of 27.

Today, just by looking around, we can see many various observable signs of the contradiction between this form of "traditionalism" regarding the role of women and their "proper" behavior, and the ideas of modernity and individuality brought about by the rapid economic development. By creating the stigma of being unwanted, ACWF is responding to the request from the central government to help easing the problem with gender imbalance in China's urban areas, with the assumption that married citizens are more stable citizens.

In other words, by ways of ACWF, the Chinese state is using what the French post-structuralist Michel Foucault calls "biopower," or a technique for achieving the subjugation of bodies and the control of populations, to its advantage. The educated urban professional women are anxious about themselves being "unwanted," when, only by looking closely, there is no

actual underpinning factor to think that they are.

In other countries, not only is it completely ordinary to get married in one's 30s, but it's also more than okay to not getting married if one does not think one has met the right person.

While there is no reliable data to indicate that whether or not this state intervention has an effect on social stability (perhaps it's still too soon) — whether or not women tend to get married earlier to avoid the stigma introduced by the state — it cannot be denied that this state intervention has an impact on the society.

The state intervention of the Chinese state -- by ways of telling many educated urban professional women that they may be unwanted -- gives rise to numerous public discussions regarding the phenomenon, mushrooming of both online and offline matchmaking activities, and dynamic activities especially in housing market and urbanization. Lately I have been thinking about the question of marriage: Why are people still getting married?

As a fan of the kind of love (that will last) that Jean-Paul Satre had with Simone de Beauvoir (about which I have written in the past), I admit that may have a too-romantic (and existentialist) view of love. But really, why do we, modern people, still need to get married? The originally the idea of marriage is tied to religiosity and traditional beliefs.

Now that we see the decline of both thanks to the rise of modern society which is both more atheist and more rationale, why do we, modern people (I'd like to say this again and again) still get married? I mean, if the two people want to be, live, and spend your life with one another, why do we still need someone, or some event, or some people, to endorse the legitimacy of such commitment?

What matters me the most is the idea that there will always be the idea of divorce. It would make sense to get married, if getting divorce is not an option. But it is! So, what's then is the point of committing to someone, just to know that there's a possibility to break such commitment?

I may have liked what I know about Sartre and de Beauvoir so much that one should be spending time thinking about one's own life ("introspecting," in Hobbes' words) in order to excel in one own's sensibility than to spending time to think about marriage. The purpose of this post -- once we get to the third of this trilogy -- is to share with you my version of an ideal society, in which men and women are not just completely equal, but also respect each other.

Just to give you a hint, my ideal society is not just a dream, but can be achieved. In fact, a few communities in the world is operating using the framework similar to that of my ideal society. The key to the complete equality here is simple: removing taboo from sex. Do you still remember the society without fathers or husbands that I mentioned in the beginning? Yes, the unimaginable community. A French- trained anthropologist (who is now a professor at Peking University in Beijing) Dr.

Cai Hua has found something else in an independent area of a province in "Zomia," a geographical term coined in 2002 by historian Willem van Schendel (later on popularized by the political scientist James C. Scott in his writings about anarchist societies of mountain people who do not want to be subjected to any state's rules) to refer to a mountain range in mainland Southeast Asia that has historically been beyond the control of governments based in the population centers of the lowlands.

This area is at the southwestern edge of China near the border with Burma. This is not a "new" or "experimental" society. In fact, the Italian merchant traveller and world explorer Marco Polo, who visited China in the thirteenth century, wrote about a people he encountered who did not mind if visitors had sex with their women, "provided the act be voluntary on the woman's part." The people, who call themselves the Na, number about 30,000. In Chinese, we know them as the Mosuo.

They tend to be farmers of rice, wheat, corn, and oats; most households spin their own flax and brew beer. Their religion is a mixture of ancestor-worship and Tibetan Buddhism. Genetic fathers have no recognized kinship with

children and play no part in their upbringing. Dr. Cai Hua studying this society was told by a 67-year-old Na woman when asked why she did not have a husband or father: No one asks that kind of question. If you hadn't mentioned it, no one would ever have even thought about it.

In procreation (i.e., having sex), the Na believe that males are "waterers," like rain falling on seed, and females are primarily, if not solely, responsible for childbirth and child rearing. Men and women, therefore, take multiple sex partners. Men normally make furtive nocturnal visits to women's homes and must return home before sunrise, and develop no economic and or social bonds with their sex partners. One of the Na women said to Dr.

Cai: An attempt to monopolize one's partner is always considered shameful and stupid...and the villagers will mock it for a long time. Simply put, we can think of this society as one that is matrilineal, or the society that is a reverse of a patrilineal, or the system of kinship based on relationship to the father or descent through the male line. Children belong to the mother's lignée (line of blood-related descendants of a common ancestor), and the basic relationships in a household are mother-child, and brother-sister.

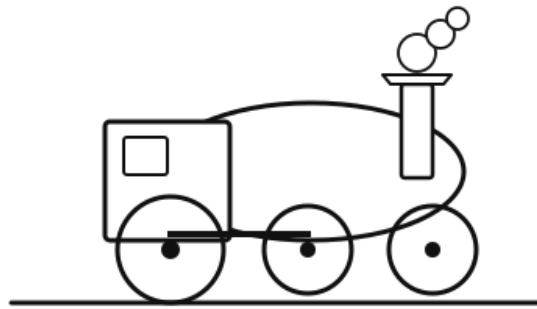
Siblings live and eat together all their lives and help to raise whatever children the women bear. "We are closest to our mothers, our maternal uncles, and our brothers and sisters," a Na man told Dr. Cai.

"To leave your mother and sisters for a wife, that would be shameful." Incomprehensible as this might appear, especially in today's context in which no society is able to operate outside the framework of the nation state which tends to insist on a nuclear family structure for its citizens, this society is one of an archetypes of an "ideal society" that I would like to think should be examined carefully by us, people of the modern society.

DAY 41

All About Nana: Part 2

Tue, 05 Aug 2025 00:00:00 +0000



EVERY TIME I TOOK A train through Hailun Road Station, I feel as though I cannot breath. There's something inside that propels my emotion toward bitterness, like being thrown out of the top of the building. The feeling of free-falling, being pulled down by gravity but without knowing how far the floor is ahead of me, is both a source of anxiety and penetrative fear. In short, it's always a real pain to think about what happened summers ago. I, still, miss Nana very much.

That summer, our language program took us on the famous and expat-ish boat tour up and down the stream of the Huangpu River. I took that tour before a few years earlier during my visit to Shanghai, and thought it was fine, but I probably wouldn't want to do it again for no good reasons. Nana, whom I did not know personally yet at the time, said she was going to be there, so I thought I'd go too.

I wasn't the kind of person who would do something without a true purpose like that, until I got to know Nana. She somehow taught me how to be irrational. I went as far as to try to get on the same bus on which she was getting. I sat next to her on the bus, and got to have a look at her beautiful face and skin. She was tired and felt asleep.

I never liked traffic jam, except that day, when I was able to look at her beautiful face. It'd be nice if time could stop, so that I didn't have to face the fact that she would be getting up and walk away once we'd arrived at the destination. It's one of those immature moments that you wish you could possess it for good. We didn't get to talk much on the boat, but it was nice knowing that she's around and that she knew who I was.

This was the girl I thought I could be with for the rest of my life. When I think of Nana, and the way I describe her, I am usually reminded of how the Japanese writer Haruki Murakami writes about how he invented his writing style.

I like his unintentionally way of jump- starting his career as a writer so much that I would like to quote how he talks about it in full here: As long as they were sitting in front of me, what I was doing felt like "literature." In their place, I pulled out my old Olivetti typewriter from the closet. Then, as an experiment, I decided to write the opening of my novel in English. Since I was willing to try anything, I figured, why not give that a shot?

Needless to say, my ability in English composition didn't amount to much. My vocabulary was severely limited, as was my command of English syntax. I could only write in simple, short sentences. That meant that, however complex and numerous the thoughts running around my head might be, I couldn't even attempt to set them down as they came to me.

The language had to be simple, my ideas expressed in an easy-to-understand way, the descriptions stripped of all extraneous fat, the form made compact, and everything arranged to fit a container of limited size. The result was a rough, uncultivated kind of prose. As I struggled to express myself in that fashion, however, step by step, a distinctive rhythm began to take shape.

In short, it Murakami's constant yet focused rambling of disjointed ideas that are written one after the other until they form disjointed narratives that remotely "make sense" as the ideas floating around begins to connect to one another to form a unified whole.

That may be how Murakami writes, but that's precisely how I think about Nana. My memory of her is disjointed, but it's always there, and it comes back to me whenever I expect it least. The memory of her presents a strong rhythm based on short memories I have of her. They may be disjointed, but they are always straightforward. My recollection of her is always clear and free of emotional baggage (until I start thinking of it as such). My Shanghai is all about Nana.

Everyday when I walk home from work, I would have to walk past the the east part of Wudong Lu. The road called Xueyuan Lu (University Road), and the only reason I remember it was because that was where I first saw Nana outside of class. She was walking toward direction to the train station where she'd travel back to Hailun Road station where she was living at the time. That was the same road that we took the day I bought my first umbrella in Shanghai.

Yes, I never bought an umbrella before. For some reason, I never felt the urge to get one, especially in China. I liked the weather when it rained, when the temperature cooled down and damped, and often I just stayed home as rather than going out. So, I never needed an umbrella. This may, yes, sound ridiculous, but then it's just me, right?

There's so many things I could do without going out, such as watching TV, reading, writing, and, needless to say, participating in an activity best done in bed. So, when it rained, I just stayed home so that I could get some work done. I would call to cancel a meeting.

All my friends, colleagues, and professors knew, if it rains, "Non won't go out." That day, not only did I decide to go out to see Nana, but I also bought my first umbrella just to be able to pick her up, save her from getting wet, and to walk her from the metro station at the end of Xueyuan Lu to the university where we would get on the bus together. That day, the language program took us to see a traditional opera.

The memory is still vivid as though it could have happened yesterday. I still remember the fragrance of the soap that she uses, the arising aroma of her shampoo, and the scent coming from her breathtaking body. I make mistakes all the time.

Often when I use my gut feeling to lead the way, I'd be met with absolute misery, especially when it comes to love, feeling for something that I can't explain using my stock of words, and which is why I don't like to trust my gut feeling very much anymore. I have simply given up love altogether. I don't have the arousing appearance that attracts anyone to like me in a positive way, and in a society in which appearance is everything, it's easy to feel hopeless.

I don't like to judge people based on how they look, so I feel disgusted by those who do that to me. I'd rather be alone and being with someone who cares only about the appearance. No one is like Nana. No one cares about me more than she cares about herself, her family, her face value, and her future. In this note, I want to write about two very personal things.

First, I have a confession to make: I am still feeling very attached to Nana, no matter how much I try to think that she may have been immaturely young, and my love for her may be a result of me not having thought through and thoroughly about what I wanted from a woman. It may have been that she is no longer with me anymore that I desires for her. Psychologists have suggested that which is the reason why many of us are anxious when we meet someone new.

Those who reply a text message from a kinda- stranger right away are likely to not being taken seriously by that kinda-stranger. Those who wait for a few minutes and reply the message are likely to receive more attention because they have created the "anxiety" on the person who is waiting for a response. That anxiety is the source of desire that is eventually mistaken, by many, for love, sadly enough. Every time I think about her, I could still feel how much I want to be close to her.

It could have been that anxiety after all. I still remember those awkward moments when I didn't know how I could possibly approach her. From the first time we got to talk to each other, I felt that she's the kind of person who could easily be distracted because she's always looked for someone to pay attention to her. She loved to speak Chinese, and, unlike most students from Europe in the program, showed no interest in showing off that she understood perfectly the "cool kids" culture.

Nana wanted to be a cool kid, but she's also kind, warm, and very attentive to you. Nana was, is, and probably will always be the most beautiful girl, partly, again, because we human beings tend to romanticize the time, things, people, whom we could no longer return to, be with, or possess. Although I know that there's no way we'd get back together, will always think of her as the Nana who has stolen my heart for good, and the one who will always be in my heart.

So, what I'd like to think carefully about here and now is the notion of the "uncanny." What got me to want to know about her at the onset was the fact that she may look slightly like an actress that I really liked: Tang Wei. So, she had all the advantage in the world to make me hers from the very beginning.

The strange thing was that, now that I thought about it, the only thing that her advantage had to do with wasn't her personality, but solely her appearance. There're also other instances that I got drawn into the company of someone with whom I had nothing in common except the curious and sensual fond of for their "uncanny appearances" to those with whom I have had an intimate relationship.

Whenever I see anyone who looks slightly like someone with whom I have had intimate relationship, I automatically feel attached to her (sometimes almost right away). I wonder if this is something that should be addressed in my research. In a way, how can I see anything, let alone understand anything, if I am totally biased like this.

I am sure this notion of obsession with the past impression is not just about people I have met, but the places of which I might thought I have a true impression of because thanks to their uniqueness — which could have simply been because of their uncanny appearance similar to whatever built or spatial terrains I have seen in the past.

I don't want to go deep into the exercise of analyzing my own sexual obsession here, but I need to begin to do something to try to understand myself before it's too late. I have all the time in the world to do it now. In a way, this fieldwork in Shanghai — where I met Nana — is for me to learn about myself.

Someone probably have said this before and I just want to paraphrase: "when you write about the field, you are writing about yourself" because everything that you write about is basically a subjective description of your reflexive understanding of the environment by which you are surrounded. For instance, do I like Shanghai because it's Shanghai, or because it's the place where I was fond of thanks to the TV show I watched when I was a child?

My childhood impression, of course, plays a big role in my decision to embark on this project. Or, is it the fact that I like Shanghai because it's where I met Nana. Although, to be fair, I met Nana in Shanghai because I had to be here to conduct a preliminary survey of my field site, so I was in the process of choosing Shanghai as my research's field site. With Nana, it made it much easier for me to want to fall for Shanghai.

But why do we fall in love? In the spirit of Epicurean philosophy, the Guardian writer Zoe Williams writes: You might just as well say, why fall in love when you can be friends? Love is a whole shitstorm of anxiety and vulnerability, poor judgment, one arm hanging off with the fierce gusts of luck and chance and other people blowing straight into your open wound. You would be far better off with a nice, level friendship, with mutually respectful boundaries and cooling-off periods. I agree.

I think there's no point of falling in love, just like what the philosopher Arthur Schopenhuer also one said: "what doesn't make sense is when you fall in love," said he. But when I think of Shanghai, I think of Nana. If not because of something that Shanghai had to offer then, I wouldn't be able to get so close to her.

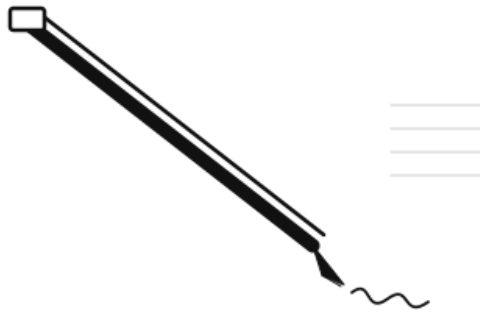
If not because of the traditional alleyway houses called the lilongs which I had been studying for the past three years, I wouldn't have anything to offer to Nana, and there's no way she would feel curious about me, let alone walking around the city with me (and that was our first date). The Bund -- probably the most romantic place on earth when we walked on it together -- was the place where we both felt that there's indeed a true feeling for each over developing inside of us.

It's the Shanghai's time and space that got us together.

DAY 42

On Bad Arguments

Fri, 08 Aug 2025 00:00:00 +0000



DID ANY OF YOU REALIZE that I had skipped Day 42? Anyway, that was what happened, so I am writing this post right now to make up for the poor Day 42 that I unintentionally skipped and nobody cared enough to inform me (sob)(sob). Alright, the anthropomorphic Day 42 who is standing right next to me right now has just told me to let it go (meaning he's forgiven me -- and you, my dear readers), and instead make it count.

I want to write, again, today about what I have learned from my colleague Mike, who, in a way, has taught me more than many people who have formally been my teachers. Recently, in fact, I posted on my wall an article from the English newspapers The Guardian regarding why we have children?

Many people who know me probably know that I personally have been wrestling with this question for a very long time, although I have, also for quite a while already, come to the conclusion that I won't have mine.

The reason for which was simple: there's a way for me to take care of myself when I am old, and that I don't need an heir to inherit any of my materials or financial remains after I die (I have decided to donate everything -- including my body -- to those whom I believe would make the best out of it whether or not they are related to me by blood, and also to charity).

I have come to this conclusion after having deeply and thoroughly exercising my ability reason. I can't think of any other reasons to want to throw someone into the world without his or her consent just because I want that person to take care of me when I am old, or to inherit my last name, or my assets (not that I think I'd have very many for anyone given how stoic my life after beginning to think about myself philosophically has been).

Mike, then, commented with the following words: Yeah right, how absurd it is that a person who hasn't got any children is trying to answer the question whether to have any children. Mike was right about one thing: I don't have any children. It was obvious that he was attacking me, by pointing out that I should not be able to say anything in this matter, that this question was out of my intellectual reach.

This form of attack, in a form of a argument, has a name: Ad Hominem, which is a Latin word meaning "against the man" or "against the person." The definition of Ad Hominem that I can possibly come up with goes as followed: By discrediting the source of information, whether by attacking the source's lack of arbitrary qualities or, simply, by attacking the person (therefore " ad hominem "), the person using ad hominem argument succeeds in disengaging himself or herself from the argument completely. It's true.

Mike was trying to shut me up, by saying that I did not even possess the right to even come up with this question. After having read Mike's comment again for the second time, however, I spent a few minutes thinking silently to myself about I may have done wrong (again, I am a falliblist, so I don't always think of myself as being right even when I have adequate evidence that I may be right).

Was I wrong to think that I wouldn't want a kid because I don't want anyone to have to take care of me? Was I wrong to think that I could try to draw a conclusion about a problem without having to experience it? Was I wrong to think that I do not need to have kids to know whether I would want to have kids, or not?

(By the way, tangent alert** The German Enlightenment philosopher Immanuel Kant, building on the theory of knowledge hitherto developed by Scottish Enlightenment thinker David Hume, has the answers for all of these questions covered, in what he calls a synthetic and analytic and a priori and a posteriori analysis, which is a topic for another time). After spending some time musing over Mike's comment, I eventually arrived at the conclusion Mike's comment was ridiculous for two reasons.

Contextually, the goal of the question that I posed in relation to the article was to get people to think carefully whether or not they should have kids. What are the pros and cons, and what are hidden pros and hidden cons of having someone who is an biological and analog product of your marriage, and so on. So, to point out that only those who already have kids can answer this question is just missing the point. It's not about competing to show- off whose experience is more legitimate.

The goal of the post was to try to get people, as many as possible, to entertain both their trained and innate ability to reason to come to grips with something that might allow us to save ourselves from a mistake.

I mean, what if one really shouldn't have a child because one is not ready, not interested in having someone to be around, not wanting to spend a large part of one's income on another member of the family, etc., and would have to take the responsibility to taking care of -- or not, as one can always disown a child and let that child starve to death, give him or her to the orphanage, or worst, sell him or her in the black market -- for the rest of one's life?

Second, Mike's argument is full of fallacies, the ad hominem fallacy was one, and there's an obvious another, which is what many would like to call a "slippery slope" fallacy. In Mike's case, he believes that it is always the case that a person could only know what it means to possess something after he or she has possessed it.

If that's the case, since "slippery slope" means to claim that the only possibly scenario once something is believed, allowed, and acted upon is the most

extreme version of that particular view, then there's nothing any one of us can know at all. For instance, one can argue that Mike doesn't know anything about having children because he only has a child (and therefore, by definition, not children) therefore he himself also has no access to the knowledge of the experience of having more than one child.

Even that, he still wouldn't know it anyway because his child is different from other child, and therefore, since experience of a person varies hence there's no way of grasping the gist of the complete idea of parenthood. The list goes on, and you get the point.

In other words, the person with a particular experience gets to monopolize the knowledge., which would mean that, when applies this principle elsewhere, there is no way to foresee any problems because you are going to need to have those problems yourself before you could get to say about them. In that case, what is the purpose of education then?

In fact, I would go so far as to say that we human beings have not extinct because we listen to each other, we exercise our reason, and we learn from the mistakes of others. Otherwise, make no mistake, we would all be dead. Examples of counterarguments to this kind of "slippery slope" fallacy are all over, and you can tell how ridiculous they sound.

For instance, "are ou saying that you can't know whether a snake is poisonous until you get bitten by it." Or "are you saying that you can in no ways know that an act of suicide is bad until you try it." Good luck with that, Mikey. I'll learn from the expert which kinds of snakes to avoid, and I will not commit suicide because I can imagine (sort of) how would my loved ones feel like to not having me around any more because of my untimely death.

Another colleague of mine, Bill, also wrote a response. Bill was a proponent of the idea of having children, and his argument was: Why have children? For me, it's one major thing to experience in life as a human being. I wouldn't not have a baby for the fear of what I've missed out on! Like me, Bill also doesn't have any children (so, if Mike happened to know Bill, Mike would have

smacked Bill with the same ad hominem argument).

But what's the problem with Bill's argument, especially on the part in which he said "it's one major thing to experience in life as a human being.

"One of the most common fallacies in argumentation is what we call "Appeal to consequences," and the idea of which is just because something, when appear to be true, will fit into the domain in which one happen to believe that which would make one's life better (in this sense, "to not missing out on what life has to offer") does not mean that it is true.

Bill and I are good friends, and I can see the point from which he is coming, and I can't say that he's wrong to say that. My problem is, solely, with his argument.

Another side note on the Appeal to consequences fallacy is another form of Appeal to consequences fallacy, known as "using consequences as antecedents." The description of this fallacy goes as followed: just because one happens to believe that a consequence is something one personally would be happy to have doesn't mean that which is the only option, both for oneself and for others.

Just because one see, feel, think of something doesn't mean that which one see, feel, and think is the only way that which could be seen, felt, and thought about.

So, in the sense, the kind of argument that Bill was making might sound similar to something like, "I don't want to miss out on the opportunity to go out hunting large wild animals -- because it's one major thing to experience in life as a human being, as hunting is a true proof that culture is above nature, and that human beings are above animals in the food chain." Think for a second here.

These two argument are the same kind of argument -- they appeal to the consequences that one wish to obtain: to have children for Bill, and to prove human being's ability to kill lives (which may result in having a feast or having

a trophy stuffed animal heads afterwards). This is a dangerous kind of fallacy. I then went on to listen to the latest episode from my favorite Podcast program Philosophize This, in which the host Stephen West discusses common fallacies in argument.

He wrote the blurb: Have you ever found yourself in the middle of an argument listening to your opposition, and you have a strong feeling that something is very wrong with the point that they're making, but you can't pinpoint exactly what it is? So, as always, I jumped into the shower (whenever I run out of ideas I always like to pour some hot water on my head).

While taking a shower this morning, listening to this particular Philosophize This episode, I came up with some thoughts on common fallacies we use (sometimes without knowing them) in arguments. Knowing them, I believe, we can avoid making them, and therefore will become much more careful when making arguments -- a very useful thing to know in debating anything at all.. First, "Appeal to consequences" and "Using Consequences as Antecedents" -- see above à la Bill's comment.

Second, "Appeal to ignorance": Just because there is no definite proof that something doesn't exist, or isn't true, doesn't mean that which doesn't exist or isn't true, and therefore must exist and then true. This is a very very common fallacy. The Internet Encyclopedia of Philosophy provides the following example: Nobody has ever proved to me there's a God, so I know there is no God. There're so many things we don't know.

Just because we used to believe, at one time, that the world wasn't spherical (and that it was flat) doesn't make the world not spherical and therefore flat. Simply put, just because you don't know, can't prove something doesn't mean they don't exist, or not true. For this particular fallacy, the key is to be open-minded and constructively skeptical. Even better, to be fallibilistic or to have the essential quality of being open- minded and constructively skeptical at the same time.

Third, "Appeal to comforting status quo": Also known as the "if it ain't a broken don't fix it" fallacy. Status quo here means "the existing state of affairs." Some might even call it "an argument of a lazy swine." Just because something works for someone -- for now and perhaps the immediate future -- doesn't mean that it will always work. My college Mike No.

2 (yes, there're two Mikes and they're both my great teachers on how not to make an argument -- ouchs), once said to me: If I have been in China for 7 years -- doing well -- without having to learn Chinese, why would I need it now?

The extreme version of this kind of fallacy would be to say, "the plane is still flying, let's wait until it is no longer flying properly to fix it." Well, once that happens, one often does not have the opportunity to fix it, doesn't it. My friend Max has helped me putting it into words by noting that it might also not be the best way for something to work in the status quo, not only that it might stop working at some point.

Well, one can also see this kind of argument being based on the idea of arrogance, and the lack of the understanding of self-development. Another related fallacy to Appeal to comforting status quo is "Appeal to personal incredulity," meaning just because something seems too difficult or complex for one to understand, that one has the right to say, assume, or make judgement that which isn't true, or that which is not necessary.

An example of this comes from my friend Sands, who said to me one time after her effort to try to understand the very basis of Socratic ideas of arguing-by-questioning failed miserably: I think all philosophers are stupid. All I need is my own philosophy. I don't give a damn about other people's thoughts.

Fourth, "straw man fallacy": This fallacy takes place when one of the parties engaging in an argument takes the direction of the argument differently by creating a simplistic straw man to attack based on his or her misunderstanding of your original argument, and therefore making you feel

as though the original argument with which you have come up is weak. Dr. Michael C.

Labossiere, the author of a Macintosh tutorial named Fallacy Tutorial Pro 3.0 has provided us with the following example (with a minor modification to fit the current world's situation) of a straw man fallacy. Senator Jones says that we should not fund the attack of the ISIL (Islamic State of Iraq and the Levant) in Syria. I disagree entirely. I can't understand why he wants to leave us defenseless, and be killed by the terrorist like that.

There're a few more, actually, but I got to go home now, so I'll stop here (what kind of fallacy is that???). I am still at my office, typing this, guys. Okay, two more. Fifth, the "False equivalence" fallacy. This is also known as the "black and white" fallacy. Basically, you happen to believe that either A or B is true, and you happen to also believe that B is not true. Therefore, A must be true.

For example, imagine you really love someone, and therefore you believe that which person has to either love you (A) or not love you (B). Then, because that person still talks to you so therefore that person must not not love you, therefore that person must love you (A is true). What happens next is that you would then decide to leave no room for any alternatives because of your fixation on the fallacy that A must be true.

This is the kind of conversation that could happen when you do so: Look, you are going to have to make up your mind. Either you decide to marry me, or you decide you are going to live the rest of your life without me in it. Finally, sixth, a "bandwagon fallacy": Just because most people like it doesn't mean it has to be true.

The website above describes it as followed: The Bandwagon is a fallacy in which a threat of rejection by one's peers (or peer pressure) is substituted for evidence in an "argument." You hear this all the time, especially in China. I also call this kind of argument "the social structure is bigger than me" fallacy. For example, what I hear all the time are: I have to get married

because I turn 27, otherwise the "whole society" will think of me as being unwanted -- leftover to rot.

I have to study hard, otherwise why would anyone look at me? I have to make a lot of money, so that I can be a member of that group. Whenever you happen to say "you have to" do something and you don't know exactly why, and after you carefully entertain your reason and find out that there's nothing there except the peer pressure, then you're under the malignant of a bandwagon fallacy.

So, as opposed to saying "I have to," say "I should." These are questions that provide you with better preconditions to your decisions: You should get married because you have found someone you love with whom want to spend the rest of your life (or as long as possible), no matter how old you are. You should be studying hard because you believe in the power of knowledge not because you want someone to look at you.

You should be making money because you want to make good use of it, not because you want a membership of a certain group that judges a person based on how much money he or she has. This fallacy is also a slippery slope. You could say something like, "I must do this because if I don't do it then I'd be the odd one out." Here, one can substitute "this" with all kinds of horrible things (e.g., steal, rape, kill, just to name a few).

So, when someone says that he or she is doing it because he or she believes that which to be the only argument that is valid, you could tell that person to "get off that wrong bandwagon" -- and walk, run, bike, or whatever. Therefore, living his or her life, instead, in "good faith."

post Day 45:Philosophy of Everyday Life Sat, 09 Aug 2025 00:00:00 +0000
This post is going to be brief. It's 1am in the morning and I need to hit the sack.

Although I just had a weird dream -- I wasn't sure where exactly I was in my dream, and when my eyes finally opened I had to spend a few second thinking about where I was until I eventually came to realize that I was in my

room, here in Shanghai, and not in Bangkok, Boston, Tokyo, or any other places.

Tomorrow, although I sort of know that it won't be a crazy long day like any other days this week, will still be an important day for me -- just like any other days. As always, I want to get up early although I don't have to. I want to start working (which, these days are mainly) writing as early as I can, although I could cut myself some slack since I have been working quite hard in the past four days, particularly, this long week.

I want to get drinks with friends at the end of the day, as always, to relax and let out some steam. Fulfilling my life in my way, I want to make the best out of each and every day of my life, with no exception. Weekends and weekdays are the same to me. I want to feel as though in each and every day of my life I have accomplished something.

Frankie, once a student of my moral philosophy class, also once asked me to tell him about what I thought I'd learned from teaching it. Lingered, still, in my head since I have never got around to answer him, this question was coming from him right after our last meeting, during which I asked the entire class, including Frankie, "which morality ideas that we had discussed in class they think they could use in real life?" So, what have I learned from teaching moral philosophy?

I believe that we should be learning philosophy because it has a true usage in our life. It can make our life better since it can change the way we see things in the world -- and most of the time, believe it or not, we are unhappy just because we aren't looking at things from the right angle. Philosophy can also make your life better by equipping you with the basic tools of making convincing arguments, which can enhance your career, study, relationships, and self-respect as a whole.

Again, this post is going to be brief. I will try to restrain myself from writing a bunch of words. There're so many great people -- thinkers, philosophers, idealists -- living throughout the history of the world and of human kind.

These people have great ideas, and their ideas, in essence, make me realize two things: First, that nothing I will ever be able to come up with in my lifetime will ever be novel, as all these thinkers have gotten it all covered already; yet, that doesn't mean I can't live an authentic and innovative life.

In fact, thanks to their great ideas I can, by building on the great ideas they have come up with, my ideas, though will never be as great, will be something that is applicable to my time, to my people, and to my life and myself. Second, these people make me humble.

I am not obsessed with coming up with my own ideas to the point that I would appeal to my own ignorance and incredulity by saying something like "I don't care about those dead philosophers -- I live myself by my own rules" (for those who have read my last post on how not to make an argument, you would be able to tell right away that such claim is also a 'slippery slope' kind of argument).

Last time someone said "I don't care about those dead philosophers -- I live myself by my own rules" to me, I felt sick to my stomach.

We can our own rules, and in some way that might make us a little bit more unique and more authentic, at least to ourselves if not to no one else; yet, to dismiss other people's great thoughts just to be unique just doesn't sound right (for those who have read my last post on how not to make an argument would be able to say why right away) knowing their thoughts not only make me humble, but also open-minded. What makes ideas and thoughts great is their timelessness.

I used to take for granted ideas from the past. I used to think that there's no point learning ideas from thinkers who are long dead. I was dead wrong. Great ideas are timeless, because they are not about the particular forms, surfaces, and facades of a particular situation, but the "deep structure" which, by definition, never changes. I exist, therefore I am. This sentence summarizes the basic premise of a modern philosophical school of thought called existentialism.

To exist, simply put, is to choose to be (i.e., choose not to commit suicide, and to make it an option when things get bad), and only once one is in the state of being, one can then decide what one wants to do freely, based on the key assumption that one is to be, also, fully responsible for one's own action. This way of thinking is powerful for two reasons.

First, it makes me realize how uneasy it is to determine between to be and not to be — to give up the option of taking one's own life completely for once and for all no matter how hard my life will ever get. The ancient school of philosophy called Stoicism leaves room for suicide — but only when one comes to realize that one is no longer stronger than one thinks.

Then, "to be" is to set up ground rules for my own conduct, so that I can follow them. Second, this way of thinking gives me a better definition of freedom. Many people mistake freedom for being able to do whatever they want, including not doing anything, sabotaging their own health by drinking and smoking excessively, and, in an extreme case, killing other people. That's not freedom.

Existentialist thinkers would argue that those are not acts of freedom, but acts of those who are, to put it plainly, slaves of their own naturalism, animal instinct, and their self-impose immaturity. The German philosopher Immanuel Kant would condemn these people for wasting their potential to develop themselves into fully mature human beings through reason. Kant would go as far as to say that these people aren't human beings anymore once they have chosen to exist outside the realm of reason.

To be free, that is to say, is not to be able to do whatever I want and whenever I want, but to be able to come up with my own system of morality and rigorously follow it.

Reading philosophy makes me feel more certain that ever that I want to be, and that I want to be in my own way, and that way is the way that recognizes myself as a being that is not just another slave of my own natural inclination or the society, but of my own rational reasoning. A good argument is power.

Learning about philosophy may not have benefited me metaphysically (i.e., I still don't know whether there is God) although some of the great ideas have provided me with some ideas on how I may want the form of my moral compass to be shaped (and when I won't be able to do it regardless of how hard I try).

But what learning about philosophy has provided me with that is lifelong and fruitful are lessons on "how to come up with convincing arguments," as well as how to stop myself before I commit myself to fallacies. At the end of the day, preaching philosophy is about using reason to convince yourself, and then others, through language.

So, learning about philosophy has given me numerous opportunities to explore, analyze, and comprehend how great thinkers (and not very great thinkers) of the past and of the present construct their arguments, come up with their persuasion, as well as how they deliberately counter-argue themselves at the right time (namely before their readers do it) in order to make the point that they have thought about the possible drawbacks of their arguments, and therefore, by saying so before someone else does, bring the point home about how and why they think their arguments are still better than any other arguments.

This way of thinking resonates with me, and I am "practically" (because it's practical) using the philosophical methods in construction arguments in every second of my waking life. Moral philosophy is the only branch of philosophy that resonates with me. The reason we need morality? Simple. Because we're not alone. I do care about metaphysics, epistemology, ontology, and so on, but insofar as they could help me explain my role in the society.

We are dealing with the state of being a member of a larger whole; hence, a set of principles concerning the distinction between right and wrong, good and bad behavior, is the most important to me in the study of philosophical thoughts. I don't let the society make me who I don't want to be, but I want to be useful to the society whenever I can.

As the French sociologist Durkheim famously describes human nature as being "in the middle of the dualism between the expectation of the society and each and every individual's own desire." I hate it when some people who think they are so cool when they go around saying something like "I don't care about the society at all" really say it. Why? Because it's a false statement by definition.

If that person doesn't care about the society, what makes that person want to use the language of this society to construct an expression of his or her discontent in such a way that is expected to be communicatively understood by the entire society? Shouldn't that person be inventing his or her own language to speak to himself or herself only? Shouldn't that person go live in the woods? With the wild trees and wild animals?

What this person says, basically, is not that he or she doesn't care, but that he or she "only care about the society as long as it benefits him or her," which, to me, is the most irresponsible, shameless, and selfish attitude one could have. That said, as we all know, people like this are everywhere, which is annoying (sadly). I do care about the society, and because I care about it, I want to make it better.

I don't want the direction of the society to benefit me, but I do not mind receiving some fruits of my contribution to the society in return from time to time. We should spend more "alone time" with ourselves. I once thought that to be happy was to be surrounded by friends, to be accepted and admired by a large number of folks, and to receive a lot of attention both from those you know and those you don't.

Reading great ideas from great thinkers have changed this way of thinking that I once shamelessly called mine completely. It was through reading ancient philosophy (especially those of the ancient Chinese Laozi and ancient Athenian Epicurus) that I eventually came to senses that I had been misled by my own misunderstanding about what it meant to be respected. I also realized that I was lonely even when I was surrounded by many people.

I didn't know what I wanted, so no matter how many people were there to help me I still couldn't possibly tell them what was in my mind. It was because I never felt the need of making any efforts (light or serious) to spend time with myself — to talk to myself about what's been going on (i.e., reflecting on each and every of my life) and to ask myself what it/I needed.

Simply put, I thought that I needed a lot of people because those people told me so. They somehow made me feel that they "represented the society," under whose authority I lived myself, and therefore whose attention and approval I must attain as a prerequisite even to respect myself. Reading philosophy makes me realize this way of thinking is not just wrong — it's ridiculously wrong, logically fraud, and argumentatively nonsensical. How could the thinking of other people possibly make you respect yourself? It's the other way around.

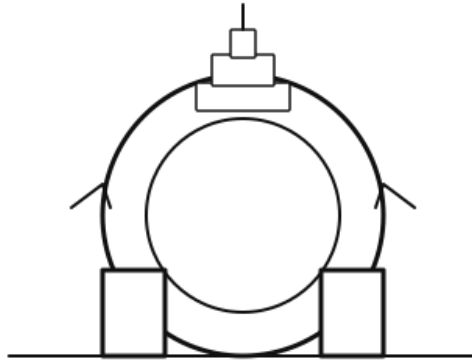
Reading philosophy allows me to come to sense with who I want to exist to be, what I want to exist to want, and the goals in the life that I want to achieve. Then, the society will have to decide whether they like whom I am, what I want, and my goals in life. If they don't like it, I will not bother them, and will stay in solidarity and continue to introspecting.

If they like it, I will do my best to contribute to it in the way that works with own my moral sensibility. You can't have a clear thinking when you are surrounded by a lot of people. Find time to be with yourself, and you will learn about yourself, which, needless to say, is the most important subject to learn in your life. All for now, Frankie. I need to sleep!

DAY 43

On Loneliness

Wed, 06 Aug 2025 00:00:00 +0000



WATCHING ONLINE A NEW TELEVISION drama Manhattan, a story about the famous atomic bomb research program led by J.

Robert Oppenheimer between 1942–45 that gathered US best scientists together to produce the nuclear weapon to fight the Nazi Germany, while holding a glass of affordable French Merlot (a type of red wine from France; known as the second most popular red grape in America after Cabernet Sauvignon) I bought this afternoon from the "foreign goods" section of Walmart here in Shanghai last night, I was finding myself in a strange place as well as state of mind.

I made sure that the only light in the room came from the 12-inch screen of my laptop, and the only source of sound also came from the speaker of the same laptop. By doing so, I felt as though my mind was being dictated by whatever stories, narratives, and conversations that were being released frame-by-frame, and word-by-word, from this little electronic source.

I managed, first of all, to have all the light in my room turned off while writing this paragraph in order to simulate an atmosphere of being home, alone, with myself, but I have to admit that I was kind of liking it. It was the kind of loneliness that was not simply empty. It was the feeling of being without

companions that empowered me with the sense of independence and individual agency, reminding that I needed to please no one and that I was in control.

At the climax of the two episodes of Manhattan that I had time to watch last night (will continue to watch the rest tonight), I was suddenly reminded of Jean-Paul Sartre's words which simply came to me without any lead: Everything that exists is born for no reason, carries on living through weakness, and dies by accident. We all born with no fixed purpose, says Sartre, and to come to "be" we must first exist, and in order to exist we need to make sense of it.

This quote isn't as pessimistic as it might sound. He simply urges us to get away from the false belief that there is a set of value that we are born with and born into, thus we have to love our life the way it wants rather than the way you want. Weaknesses are what we all share. We are strong, but it is never our strength that enables us to see the true color of life.

It is, instead, the weaknesses, in what we are fearful of for no reason to, in what we strive to achieve and we don't know why, and in the act that we try perform so well but eventually for no reason and no one, that drag us through life. Realizing that there is no fixed purpose in life and that we are all weak, we then strive to exist, in which case when we die by accident we wouldn't be feeling as bad.

When Sartre, the father of existentialism, wrote the above passage, I believe that what he meant may have to do with the absurdity of how all of us have the tendency to prescribe our own judgments on things.

For instance, Loneliness is bad, but having a lot of friends is good; being alone is bad, but being married to someone is good; believing in God because there's no otherwise way to believe how things pre-exist in the world is bad, but believing that God exists because he exists is good, and so on. Sartre did not see this way of thinking as being productive. Many philosophers have urged us, through a wide variety of rhetorics, to sidestep from engaging in

loneliness.

The most optimistic of them all is the ancient Greek philosopher Epicurus, who believes that friendship is the most important element of humankind; thus, we should all be living in a commune as friends who care about each other, diminishing the moment of loneliness (and yes, I am quite sure that I am simplifying Epicurean thoughts by a large margin here, but I believe that it serves the purpose of this post for the time being).

On the other side of the spectrum, the German philosopher Arthur Schopenhauer (1788 - 1860) may be the most pessimistic of all of them (and I have written about him also in my earlier post). That said, he is not all pessimistic about our relationship with loneliness, as he writes: A man can be himself only so long as he is alone; and if he does not love solitude, he will not love freedom; for it is only when he is alone that he is really free.

In fact, if we take down all of these general facades of judgmental assumptions that we have about certain things, loneliness is not necessarily a bad thing. An act of writing, for instance, can only be done when you are alone, having a dialogue with yourself. In my post *On Time*, I wrote about how I'd rather be alone than be in company with a person with bad faith. In a way, perhaps we should look at loneliness existentially.

In an essay, "Abiding Loneliness: An Existential Perspective On Loneliness," the medical ethicist and philosopher Michele A. Carter writes: Many portray the existential form of loneliness as an unavoidable condition of our humanity, residing in the innermost being of the self and expanding as each individual becomes aware of and confronts the ultimate experiences of life: change, upheaval, tragedy, joy, the passage of time, and death.

Loneliness in this sense is not the same as suffering the loss of a loved one, or a perceived lack of a sense of wholeness or integrity. Further, it is not the unhealthy psychological defense against the threat of being alone, especially if being alone means we must confront the critical questions of life and death. Rather, existential loneliness is a way of being in the world, a way of

grasping for and confronting one's own subjective truth.

It is the experience of discovering one's own questions regarding human existence, and of confronting the sheer contingencies of the human condition. That is, one very important thing that Sartre's fellow existentialist Friedrich Nietzsche has taught us is precisely that: Jealously might not be all bad (if it leads to us wanting to become a better person), and loving your neighbors without questioning their intention (whether or not they would want to love your back)

might be the stupidest thing you could do to yourself. The same goes with loneliness, as Nietzsche sees it, loneliness forces us to make a decision. Loneliness is something I often do not think about because I am often too busy to be lonely. No kidding. When I am busy with what I am interested in working on, I don't really have the time to spend on musing over my emotional independence.

So, maybe, hypothetically-speaking, the reason why I have been so hard on myself is because I don't want to leave time for loneliness. I know that the best cure for loneliness is to be busy. And if this could be the case for me, it could also be the case for many. I have a feeling that there must be an evidence from neurosciences that proves my point about how much data our brain can operate, and how much emotional baggage it can cope with at one time.

If there were too many things on its plate (yes, I am using this metaphor with the brain; apologies if it'd remind you of a brain on plate depicted in the movie Hannibal) the feeling of loneliness won't find form, and that's how, so far in my life, I'd like to believe it. When my father passed away in 2010, what saved us from the absolute despair was precisely the fact that we really had no time to think about the fact that he was no longer alive.

Our family were insanely busy during the first two weeks after he passed organizing all kinds of things, i.e., funeral-related events, both to ritualistically send him off to the other side, and to properly honor his

illustrious, though short, life. It was my first week of class and I rushed back from the US, flying across the Pacific to Bangkok the day after I heard the news (I also wrote about this in the post *On Death*) to be with my family for two weeks.

Although I was in the complete state of despair, I believe that I was able to get through it not so painfully because the whole two weeks in Bangkok left me with literally no time to extent my grievances beyond the realm of pragmatism. Simply put, my dad was already dead, and the idea of him not being able to speak to me again left me vulnerable to all kinds of possible ideas regarding the origins of the collateral sadness that could shape my sense of being.

Some of those could have shaped me to believe that it was my very own fault to never want to adequately spend time with my father that we didn't get to know each other as well as we should.

In fact, as someone who has studied suicide, I have learned that many people who decide to seek a permanent solution to, often, a temporary problem, do so because they, as I'd like to put it, "have too much time in hand and thus let their mind wander too far outside of the realm of pragmatism." What's pragmatic is whatever works, and usually, if not always, suicide doesn't work, and most of us know that in our heart but many of us still want to walk toward that destination because we, simply put, "have too much time in our hand." During those ten days, my mother was busy from 5am in the morning all the way to midnight.

My older brother was also extremely busy helping not only with the funeral, but also planning for the publication honoring our father (It's customary to have a book about the life of the diseased to give to the guests at the funeral. Since his death was unexpected, we had nothing prepared for so we had to work really hard to put it together).

So, during the day, we would be flipping through hundreds of his photo albums, personal diaries and documents, and his personal collections of

objects, looking for photos, artifacts, ideas, his quotes, and so on, to put in this publication. The most tiring part, needless to say, was the funeral itself. In the heat of Bangkok's rainy season (which felt like summer elsewhere), the rituals began in the early morning (5pm) when all of us would be offering food to the monks.

Then we would be spending the rest of the morning on the publication. The funeral-related activities would begin again after lunch when we would be preparing to head to the temple. We'd be putting on our black clothes and head to the temple to receive the guests who would be traveling from all over the country to pay respect to my father's body.

Those were ten days of that proved that I had both the physical and mental strengths to deal with whatever challenges I would be facing for the rest of my life. According to the Theravada Buddhist ritualistic protocol, a funeral of a Theravada Buddhist believer like my father had to be held ten days in a roll. During the ten days, we had to devote the entire afternoon all the way to the early evening of each day to letting those who knew my father pay respect to his body.

The funeral was held at a small pavilion of a temple nearby. All of us had to be there from late afternoon all the way until the evening. It was good in the sense that I got to see all of my father's friends, old colleagues, relatives, and so on, who I had not seen for ages; and they all came with great stories about my father to share with me.

Everyday my mother and I were busy greeting the guests and making sure that the place was clean after the monks came to perform a funeral prayer every night around 9pm.

We would be deadly tired every night, and would still head over to a restaurant to eat (during which I'd always get a cold iced beer to go with super tasty and spicy meal) and chatted about things (mostly about the funeral and my father) until late before we eventually headed home preparing to get up again a few hours later for another day of the same rituals. This is

reason why I keep myself busy.

To avoid being lonely, I do things that I like to spend my time engaging with, and doing things that I feel they matter to me and my personal development, to others, with or without a prospect of an immediate return of profits (whether that be mental, emotional, professional, or financial). From time to time, especially when I watch an American television series, I would think about my life back in the US.

The latest I could think about was back in 2013 when I was about to finish my residency at Harvard as a doctoral student and move to Shanghai. That year, I was not only a student at Harvard, but also a residential adviser at a fraternity house at MIT. I grabbed a bike from a bike-sharing stall in front of my fraternity house in the morning to bike to my office at Harvard, which was a few miles away.

At the end of the same day, I would grab a bike from the closet bike-sharing stall, and get on whatever bike I could get there to bike back to my fraternity house. My life was very simple and straightforward (and probably not very exciting). But it's a busy life.

I did not have many friends then because I spent most of my time teaching (4 different courses in 4 different departments at Harvard), studying (Chinese and other subjects in preparation for my general exams), reading (all kinds of things to be up to date), and writing, so there were plenty of time that I could easily sink deeply into the abyss of loneliness.

That said, it didn't happen, and that was the most productive year of my life so far because I managed to keep myself away from loneliness by staying healthily busy. I learned so much from that year. At least, it was the first year of my life that I managed to learn how to put things in their places, and put things in order.

It was the first time that I managed to see through the underlying structure of my life: the fact that my life was meaningful because I was able to contribute to the society in which I lived by maintaining my ability to

contribute to it, simply, by setting up the time to get up in the morning, making time for exercising (in which case, it was biking), and doing what I had to do to be able to want to learn more every day of my life.

To end this post, I'd like to share with you a story. In fact, the original idea of this post is to write about (and therefore the original title of which) "four lonely lives," but I guess I have gotten into too much tangent (as always) so I guess I won't have the time to do it within this post. So, let me just write about one of the four. Lonely Life Number One: This person was a young woman. We got to know each other through work.

We came in contact with each other because we happened to share a similar interest in a research topic. As much as I liked her as a person who was always full of energy, I was reluctant to get to know her because she -- her existence -- represented the embracing of all kinds of contradictions.

For instance, she liked to say that she's truly independent and thus no non-sense (e.g., "I don't give a f*** when it comes to XXX" kind of attitude), but when our e-communication abruptly broke down (because of the lack of human touch of such form of communication) and I decided to no longer want to use e-communication as a means of our dialogue, she got really anxious. She was mentally concerned with how we were no longer "friends" on social media.

She liked to prove that she could "walk very fast," and she showed me that which was true by intentionally walking so fast that even she herself needed to catch her breath from time to time while moving her physicality forward. Because of her intentionally fast-pace, she obviously could only focus on moving forward. On a peaceful sidewalk on which we were supposed to have a conversation about our shared interest, she decided to walk so fast so that we could not have a proper conversation.

Walking fast was one thing, but when she arrived at an intersection where there's not a single car moving, she would stop, stand still, until the dormant and passive traffic light tell her that she was then allow to cross the road.

That is, to me at least, I felt as though she's the kind of person who liked to prove that she could excel in the rubric, with which other people provided her, as opposed to create her own sensible rubric in which she would need to work hard to establish it as an acceptable category.

As independent as she may want to represent herself to be, not only did she obey, but also submit herself to the authority, without a clear idea regarding whether or not her perception toward the authority and its structure governing her individual capacity to act, think, and be rational (i.e., agency) is constructed.

She would talk about how smart she thought she was with absolute confidence, but she would act in an excessively subservient manner (i.e., kowtow) to those whose superficial credentials, such as where they went to school or where they worked. She took cultural capital very seriously. She would say that she believed herself to be among the smartest people, but when it comes to conformity, she would conform without having even a slight urge to question the convention to which she was conforming.

I believe that she was a lonely person because she's locating herself in between, what the French sociologist Émile Durkheim, calls "the dualisms of human nature" -- one of which is structure, and the other is agency. According to Durkheim, we all live our lives struggling to be a part of this dualistic whole -- we want to exercise our capacity to act (i.e., agency) while wanting to benefit from being a part of the structural whole.

In a traditional society, it's always been the structure that has more power than any of the agency, but in a modern society, in which most of us have access to new ideas, new thoughts, leading to various definitions of new forms of individualism, we tend to think that the structure could be subverted.

This person whom I have been writing about wants to be recognized as a special and unique individual as such by the structure which she'd like to claim that which had nothing to do with her sense of conformity. In other words, she

liked to compete, but did not know what she was competing for. This kind of loneliness, I believe Durkheim would call, "insecurity loneliness." This person got stuck in the middle of the dualisms.

She wanted to be special and would like to conform to the idea that special-ness with which the society has provided, rather than define her own. By this, she could only share her "true thoughts" with a few people.

She wanted to be accepted in the society, and wanted to have somewhere to fall back onto, but couldn't because she had created an image of herself to be perceived by the rest of the society as "independent, intelligent, and, literally, fast pace." What if one day there's a moment of weakness in which she would rather want to be weak so that someone could say to her "I got your back?" The answer I got was pretty clear: she would not show it, and would accept the fact that she's a lonely person at heart because she had chosen to be stuck in between what she thought she wanted and what she really wanted.

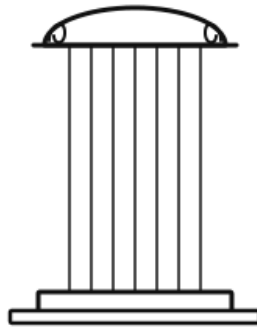
Sartre has reminded us that everything that exists, including life itself, "carries on living through weakness." Why shouldn't we openly accept that weakness? Why pretend to be someone else you are not? Here I want to also show my weakness. There's no reason for me to appreciate someone with such a bad faith, but I did. I really liked her. Perhaps I am just too weak -- too. But as Sartre points out, weakness is all we share.

Don't get me wrong, I agree that there's a sense of comfort in conformity, and that's the reason why many of us choose to conform. I, too, conform, especially to my own sense of morality. There's no way I would break it, because I always find comfort in it. But if you want to conform, don't pretend as though you are not, because that would get you stuck between the dualisms -- probably the loneliest place for a vulnerable human mind.

DAY 44

On Bad Faith

Thu, 07 Aug 2025 00:00:00 +0000



THERE IS ONLY ONE REALLY serious philosophical problem and that is suicide. Deciding whether or not life is worth living is to answer the fundamental question in philosophy. All other questions follow from that. This was Albert Camus (1913–1960) who was a novelist, and arguably, although he came to deny it, a philosopher, who helped to spearhead the idea of existentialism. Camus is right about the fact that we have to choose to be before we can choose which teaching from which school of thoughts to believe in.

He's right that we're all thrown into the world without having been given options whether or not you'd like to be or not to be. But since we're all being thrown into the world, the sound default is then to be, because we are in the world. That said, in the spirit of existential freedom, one can always choose to not to be by ending one's life -- and therefore the philosophical argument over the idea of suicide that Camus has famously posed.

Camus may have be wrong on one thing: it's not that easy to stray away from the default, which is to be. The decision to end one's own life is arguably the hardest one to make. You'd need at least two main ingredients: depression and impulsibility. The first ingredient is what makes you want to not to be, and the second one is what makes you want to go ahead and make it happen. So, for many, it's easier to be, because they cannot put together the two

ingredients.

There're also many who may add the third ingredient, which is philosophy to the equation. Once one sees no point in moving forward, and one finds comfort in the moving in to the terrain of the unknown, one doesn't need to be depressed or impulsed to take one's own life. So, "to be" -- to not committing suicide -- is, by default, the state of being. You can't opt in, but instead you'd have to "opt out" in order to end it.

That said, what's worse than being thrown into the world (opted in) without your consent is when you choose to believe that your life has no other choices but to do whatever it's said to be your designated path by other people.

The French philosopher Jean-Paul Sartre has written extensively about "bad faith" or what the Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy defines as the way in which an individual is lying to oneself that the way one lives is "the only way one could possibly live; thus shut down all the opportunities for other ways of living one's life." In other words, you have a bad faith when you decides to place your complete trust on, or confidence in, someone or something without thinking that you don't have to, you don't need to, and, most of time, you shouldn't be doing it because whatever it is in which place your complete trust on or confidence in might not be based on anything mildly reasonable.

Taking marriage, for instance, Sartre never got married, and he didn't see why that was a problem. Many great people in my life also have never gotten married, because they never think that they need to since the contract that bind them and their counterparts are neither social or legal, but moral. They question the convention of the institution of marriage, and therefore decide that the rationale basis of which existence of such institution is based is too weak for them to believe.

Many couples get married simply because "they couldn't think of other ways or options to live their lives as full citizens of a community," therefore they get married, therefore they suffer, and therefore they live a life that,

according to Sartre, is not worth living. Sartre calls this way of thinking "bad faith," which, for a long time even before I began to read Sartre, I also believe to be the underpinning cause of my meaningful existence. Again, I don't believe that I have any essence before I exist.

In fact, I exist, and I choose to continue to exist, therefore I possess the essential characteristics of a human being, namely a being who live freely (according to the moral rules that I have set for myself), with good faith (meaning that I would never reject anything outright just because someone has said that by doing so I would be perceived as having more value). Many people whom I have met lately seem to believe in bad faith.

Although I don't blame them, I don't want to associate myself with them. I don't even have time to judge them. I just walk away. As the German enlightenment philosopher Immanuel Kant once said, a human being is a human being because he or she is rational; once he or she is no longer being rational, he or she is no longer a human being.

I tend to think that a person who has bad faith is not rational, and therefore does not deserve to be categorized as a human being. We are human beings simply because we are able to think for ourselves. I get upset when someone comes to me and tell me he/she wants to learn; yet, the last thing he/she would like to do is to critique the convention of the society in which he or she is living. That's not learning. That's living a bad faith kind of life.

I often respond, "there's no learning here if you don't even fucking know what you are learning for." Many people often believe that they are learning as long as they are students in a classroom, or are mentees to some kind of academic mentors, or registering as learners at institutions offering quick-fix courses. I don't see any of those as learning.

I believe that one can only learn when one has "good faith." So, most of the time, even though I'd love to help someone, I have to give up the moment I realize that the person who I was about to help believe in bad faith, therefore has no goal in life. Wanting to be the best in one's field isn't good enough for

me. In fact, that's the worst.

When someone wants to be the best without knowing what is to be the best for, I often ask them what's the point of being the best beyond the individual recognition that someone could get? I only compete with myself. I set my own standards to achieve, and I achieve the goal I set for myself everyday. I want to do my best everyday. The most important recognition that one could have is self-respect, and that often doesn't come from achieving what other people believe to be good.

It's what you, based on your moral belief and critical thinking, believe to be valuable enough for you to strive for. Most of the time, and for most people, it's not money. Most of the time, also, it's not the material benefits, but the good feeling that you are doing something to help others, or doing something that isn't simply based on your often-false belief that by doing so other people would think that you are a proper member of that particular community.

I have a very high standard for intellectuality; therefore I don't have time for bad faith. These are ways I think could help combating bad faith (most of these are "don't" rather than do, and I do apologize): Don't be too quick to say no -- just because saying "no" would make you feel as though you are in the position above the person who is looking forward to your yes.

In my life, I have met so many people who say no just because they believe that saying no would make them look good, e.g., "I am a girl I can't say yes to a man whom I just met [although I like him]," "I have to say no because by saying yes my counterpart would think that I am too easy and will take me lightly," and so on. Don't you think that the world is pretty complicated the way it is already? Come on.

Let's be honest and believe in who we are. I don't usually cite Martin Heidegger because I don't think that he's that right about many things, but I'd like to cite him here: we have to be authentic. I don't believe that avoiding certainty, or showing your interest in someone or something will make you

look bad (and if that's the case, then why would you care about that person who would judge you so superficially anyway?).

Most of the time, if not always, we say no because we think that saying no is "culturally good." Taking some time to think about your answer carefully would allow you to develop your ability to resist the temptation to simply conform, because, sadly enough, it's so easy to conform rather than be yourself. Don't judge a book by its cover. Many people I have met say "no" to things, persons, places, activities, simply because they don't like how the cover looks.

These are the worst kind of bad faith people because not only they take very lightly the human's dignity that everyone deserves, this person also believes in the idea that is not his or her own. When you judge a book by its cover, it's pretty clear that you are based your judgement on your subjective sense of beauty without even wanting to spend some time understanding the contents.

Those bad faith people who fall into this category, needless to say, may not deserve to have honorable roles in any societies at all. Don't think of yourself as better than anyone else. You are not. We're all the same. Wait. People with good faith all the same. This "we are all the same" doesn't apply to people with bad faith. The bad faith person with a PhD from Harvard is, to me, a scum of the earth.

I would rather talk to someone, a stranger perhaps, whom I might run into on the street with whom I could share with him or her the free conversation about his or her good faith life. Always act spontaneously. Many people whom I met don't do so. Whatever questions they'd get, they'd think over and over, weighting pros and cons, doing a detailed calculation of the material benefits they would get from saying yes or no.

By doing so -- being calculating -- you are simply making yourself a slave of material profits, and most of the time you'll miss so many things in life simply because you never leave room to think about other kinds of benefits, which

sometimes have the ability to make your life more meaningful. I have this problem all the time in Shanghai.

Many people I meet here are extremely calculating (and being an expert on Shanghai, I can only say that it's something that cannot easily be educated), and therefore in everything that they do, invest their time in, has a very deep foundation in how they believe that they will get something back in return. Being overly calculated pretty much kills sincerity. Don't take life lightly.

Nietzsche and Heidegger might not be the best role models on how to live your life, but at least what they have shown all of us is how to live your life with intensity, and to the fullest. The key here is not to take anything lightly. Be focused on things that you do. Be careful of the path on which you walk. Be professional. Be mindful of the feeling of the person with whom you are engaged.

And, most important, be true to yourself as if there're always someone watching your every step. There should be no single moment in your life that you'd wish you are alone per se. You can't commit a crime even if no one is watching you, so to speak. Don't simply believe that you are at the top of your game already.

I know that I have written a post about how I believe modesty is bad for the society -- this only applies when you know for sure that what you know is morally sounded. But in most cases, you don't. So, when you don't, always leave room for the possibility.

There're always chances that you aren't the best person (and believe it or not, that's always the case), so in order to save yourself from disappointment you might as well believe in the philosophical idea of fallibilism, or the idea that you could still be wrong even if you absolutely believe that you are right (personally, I define fallibilism as what open-mindedness and skepticism have in common). Don't think you're so good, pure, and superior than others, just because your parents are wealthy or have given you advantage.

Many people whom I have met think that they are better than anyone else because they are not aware that they have better "quality of life changes." Many of them just want to take advantage of me; and therefore I don't have any other option but to turn them down. Many of these people have been getting things handed down to them their entire life.

So they are expecting everyone to like them, give them what they want, and support them to pursue competitions that, unfortunately, they themselves don't know what they're competing for. In most cases, I have to turn them down just so that they could feel the sense of not being satisfied, and hopefully by that they would come to term with the idea of good faith. Value silence as much as your words. As Sartre once said, both words and silence have the same responsibility.

You can't simply deny your responsibility for an action just because you refrain from getting involved verbally. Everything counts. When you say nothing is all, it doesn't always mean, to others, that you mean yes. Make it clear. Don't avoid clarity. As the psychologist Geert Hofstede once said, uncertainty avoidance is good for no one. Don't believe in luck. There's no luck. Everything happens for a reason. I do believe in destiny, but not luck.

When you don't believe in luck, you would be more focused on the actuality of the situation and would make your life worth living based on it. Don't fall into the belief that your life will be over if you don't act the way you are acting. Among many fallacies, many would call this an "Appeal to Consequence" fallacy.

Arguing that a belief is false because it implies something you would rather not believe already sounds, at least to me, pretty stupid (this kind of argument is, by the way, also called *argumentum ad consequentiam*).

I have met so many couples who are so unhappy with their marriages or their relationships, but all they said, as a reason to not getting divorced or breaking up, is "I can't think of my life without him (or her)." What this means is that the person not only disrespect the fact that we are all much more

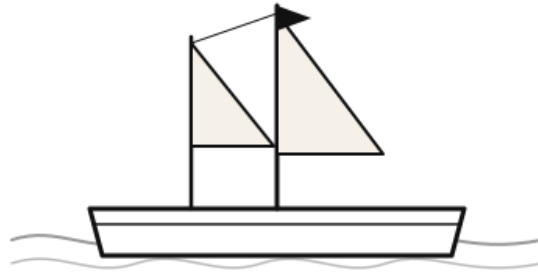
stronger than we think (and the fact that everyone is born, in order to depart from you either by death or other often more painful and more difficult-to-accept forms of departure), but also the fact that one has the freedom to control one's life.

If something is not right, make the effort to change it -- don't wait until it reaches the point where you'd have to commit a crime to change it. Now, go live a good faith life.

DAY 46

16 Things I Never Have

Sun, 10 Aug 2025 00:00:00 +0000



HERE I AM, WAITING AT the boarding area for my very first "non-business" trip in years. How am I feeling? Mixed: my feeling is caught between great and weird. It's great because I don't have to prepare a presentation, or a transcript for a talk, or any plans for meetings, or anything. It's also weird because I have not done this for years. In the past decade, as I can recall, all my trips have been work- related.

So, this trip is special, as it marks a new me: the me who can travel by myself and for myself, and not for someone else. Tokyo (Haneda Airport, to be precise) is the destination, where I will get to meet my former student Stephane, a few friends (such as Matt Williams), perhaps, to visit my most favorite country in the world. In my last life I must have been a Japanese! Well, so in the next few days, I'll be writing my blog posts about Japan and in Japan.

In this post, I'd like to write about the myths many people might have about me. For instance, no, I have never won any awards — not even at a school or a community talent show; not even the tenth place of any small competition; and not even in the tiniest possible contest anywhere. I am just not special, and I am just not the kind of person who ever do well in any competitions.

I want to make it clear, for once and for all, who I am, and what I did not, and sometimes never possess. So, as opposed to keep writing as I go like I usually do, this time I'll write each of the numbered points, and then explain them later for those who want to read more.

I have never won any awards in my life; I have never been good in languages -- in any of them including my mother tongue; I have never been the best in anything -- I have never been the best in my class no matter how small; I have never been the best in anything in whatever I do no matter how easy the task is; I didn't really speak English until about ten years ago; I never received the letter grade A in any subjects throughout my childhood years.

My first letter grade A that I received was when I was in high school (and I believe that subject was ceramics!); I never thought I could take part in any forms of sports no matter how light because I had severe and chronic allergy when I was young; I stuttered throughout my childhood (I still do sometimes), so I never thought that I could communicate with anyone, let alone deliver any public speaking performances; As a child, I never thought I'd any chance in graduating from high school since I failed so many main subjects (my hobby, then, was to re-sit exams just so that the teachers could pass me out of sympathy); I never thought I would be able to go to college since I was a C-Minus average student.

My high school GPA was just above 2.0 (in the 4.0 system); I never thought I'd get to leave Thailand and go abroad to study because I was such a horrible student.

I never enrolled in any particular tutoring schools (mainly because our family's financial situation wasn't good enough to allow me to do so); I had never written anything -- in any languages -- apart from essays and school reports that I had to write to get by, until I finished graduate school in 2007; For the same reason (plus that I was a bad student throughout my childhood), I never thought I would have a chance at teaching anyone in anything; Unless asked, I never tell people where I went or go to school; I never feel comfortable where I am.

Never a day that I do not doubt my ability to do my job. I never feel that I am better than anyone. So, yes, contrary to what many may have thought about me, I have never been good at anything, particularly in competitive settings. I am not even good at speaking my mother tongue language, which is Thai.

I remember a few years ago when I had to write anything in Thai, I need at least 4 pairs of eyes to run grammar and spell checks for me (and my father who had spent his entire life as a civil servant dealing with bureaucratic documents was one of those pairs and he was excellent at editing my paper).

Throughout my childhood (until I was 18 perhaps?), I participated in many competitions (e.g., athletic, artistic, talent show, you name it) but I have never won anything -- not even a tenth place in a competition of 15 kids. I have always been bad at competing with others. Perhaps it's never in my blood to want to compete, which, in the way, I believe is good for me.

Since I have never tasted the taste of victory (pun intended) I don't feel as though I need to win, which I think makes my life today much easier than many's. Looking at many people today, who are competing just for the sake of competing, I can't help but to think that it might be helpful for them to stop for a while to think about what they're competing for. In a way, I think I was lucky to have such a humble background.

Because of that I never get the pressure of having to fight or compete, or prove to anyone that I am worth for something and, for anything. Because of that, I get to enjoy quite a humble life. It's good not to be the number one (or even number ten for that matter) in anything. It feels good to be among many human beings in the world, who are, like me, never win anything.

People who never win anything are the majority of the world, I believe, so we are in this together. It feels good to be among the majority who want to be laid back and get by by being understanding to sympathetic to one another. I didn't really speak English until about ten years ago.

I may have studied some basic English (in order to read signage and identify some basic words in advertisements and products) since I was in my

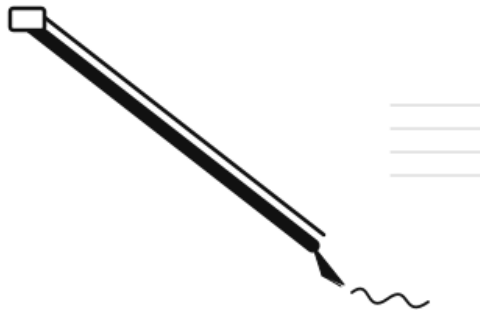
secondary school, and of course in high school and college during which time I was interested in learning English in order to leave Thailand and explore the world, but I didn't get to speak English at all until 2005 when I arrived in the States.

My spoken English then was virtually non-existence (pun intended; one more time!), and therefore my first semester as a graduate student in the US was nothing but hell. I couldn't communicate with anyone and not many people were interested in making the effort of communicating with me. I almost got kicked out of school because I couldn't communicate my thoughts in speaking let alone in writing. It's a difficult time, really difficult. I am still not sure today how I got through them.

DAY 47

Days 47: On My Relationship with Objects

Mon, 11 Aug 2025 00:00:00 +0000



I GUESS IT WOULD BE unfair to write about what I don't have without writing about the opposite side of the spectrum: What I have and (hopefully) will always have. But let me begin with telling you how I spent my last 24 hours here in Tokyo.

It's actually quite basic: I walked 28 kilometers from Tsukiji (the fish market) area where I stayed to the nearby area called Ginza, to Tokyo Station, to the Imperial Palace and the area where all governmental buildings are located (i.e., the Diet Building), to Roppongi, and eventually to Shibuya where I spent my last two hours before the metro system closed at a mega music mall called Tower Record (we used to have one in Bangkok, and I remember going there almost every day growing up in the 90s) listening to some easy-listening mellow sound at its coffee shop on the second floor, and then some serious work of art at its classical music floor on the 6th.

As the motto of the shop writes "no music, no life," being there resting with a cup of coffee (followed by a glass of iced cold draft local beer) listening to great music, for free, is life. Now, what are the 16 things that I have? Let's get into it!

My Montblanc fountain pen; My family, especially my mother and brother; My anthropological relationship with every single object that I owe; My love for architecture and built environment; My self-critic buddy who will always be with me when I think; My absolute hatred for conservatism; My unconditional biological and mental appreciation for women and their womanhood: their bodies, psychologies, and maternal instinct; My belief in open-mindedness plus skepticism, AKA fallibilism; My appreciation for art, language, music, and philosophy; My eternal abhorrence for superficiality; My self-imposed doctrine in doing things because they're the right things to do, and not because they may yield material and other forms of profits; My obsessive-compulsive disorder (AKA OCD) for personal and environmental hygiene, which, goes without saying, also encompasses my OCD for wanting to organize things and putting them in their right places; My obsession with Japan; My insatiable desire for hot spring (especially Japanese onsen), alcohol, and technological gadgets; My unquenchable thirst for knowledge and something new; and, lastly but definitely not leastly, which is why you are reading this, My writing.

I am going to head out soon to start my second full day here in Japan (yeah!) but let me lay out some of the explanations of why something are more important to me. I'll explain more about other points in my next (and next next, and next next next) posts. Right now, let's get into the only object on the list that I think I have. OBJECTS IN MY LIFE: I also have an anthropological relationship with my objects.

Everything that I buy -- and by this I really mean everything at all -- I always use it to the very last day of its life. I never throw anything away before they arrive at their timeliness demise. My mother often gets crazy over my obsession of wanting to use everything until its very last day. For that matter, I always try to prolong that by recycling everything possible.

I mean, imagining if everyone is having the same relationship with their objects that same way I do, then there would be no consumerism, as we would just need one pen for 2 years, one note pad for a few months, and

probably just one set of silverware of life. That said, the continuity of consumer society is not my concern. In fact, I wholeheartedly believe that we should only consume what we need. I have no respect for conspicuous consumption.

Someone has asked me before if I see my relationship with objects as fetishism. Since I don't think I have an excessive and irrational attachment to objects, I also don't think that's the case. This may have to do with the Buddhist belief in me. I believe that we are all born into the world naked and we will also leave the world the same way, so there's nothing that I actually possess, and in fact, possession isn't going to get one very far in life.

Possession will, in fact, bring you down and make you fall from grace. So, in my life, I try not to possess anything, and try to give away what I don't need any more to those that may need them.

In my earlier post (the part three of On Why I Give Up Love trilogy, I believe), I have written about why possessive love is toxic: because when one treats the other as an object to be possessed, one devalues both one's own capacity to be free from the false idea that one has any ability to possess anything, as well as the humanity of the counterpart. I don't think anyone should be treated as an object, don't you think? That said, to me, objects are like people.

I don't think anyone should be treated as an object because in general objects are dispensable, although that's not necessarily the case for me. I believe that objects should only be replaced, like people, when they have reached the limit of their timely existence, which the owner of the object gets the privilege to decide when.

Objects are products of human's intelligence and labor, and therefore they are dignified, and that is precisely why I feel as though I should love and respect them as though they are people -- and that's what I mean by having an "anthropological relationship" with them. Everything that I call mine (in my room, in my bag, and elsewhere) I still know exactly where I bought them.

They are have their personal histories. I know, also, why I bought them.

For instance, I am still using a glue stick and my red-inked pen that I bought at a W.H. Smith stationer located on Cornmarket Street in Oxford, UK, in the winter of 2008.

I bought them that day because I needed the glue stick because I need to write my daily dairy in which I always cut and pasted stuff in an old-fashioned way, and I needed to red-inked pen to mark my own Chinese reading texts because I needed to remind myself which were the new vocabulary that I should re-write on my flashcards in order to try to memorize.

When it comes to replacing things, I take it very seriously that I only get a new thing to replace the old one when I know exactly with the old one. For instance, I don't get a new smartphone's case very often at all (although it's something that you could do it very easily as if almost it's designed to be changed all the time) because, simply, I don't know what I'd do with the old one. Keepin' it in my drawer?

I believe that to honor an object is to put it into use, so when it's not used the way it should (but I am very open to defining a new usage for an object too) I feel sad. This goes also with my computer, which I only get a new one when the old one is no longer running, smartphone, electronic devices, and simply, just about everything at all.

THE OBJECT: My Montblanc fountain pen is, no argument here, the single most important (and probably expensive) object that I owe. It's important for two reasons: first, it was my father's before I inherited it -- and the fact that it's my father's may be the single most important reason why I love it and will always keep it close my heart and won't never let it be stolen and lost (hopefully). I have been using it for more than ten years now.

My father gave it to me as a graduation gift back in 2004 when I graduated from college. Second, because it's so so so good! Monblanc fountain pen is the best fountain pen in the world. The ability to fully be in control the

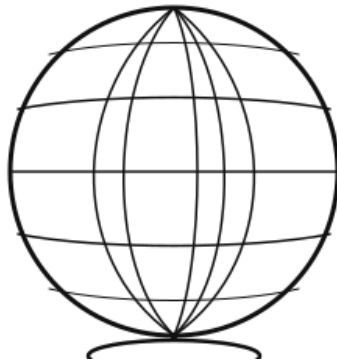
amount of ink to be released which correspond which how much pressure you put on both laterally and quasi-vertically (since most people write in 45-degree angle) is, simply, amazing. As an architect, and an self-proclaimed armature writer, I can't ask for more.

I can only write anything important with it. I always sign important documents with only this pen. It's almost like a ritual -- superstitiously speaking -- to me. If I don't get to sign important documents with this pen, then deep down I have a feeling that there might be a chance that something about that document might go wrong.

DAY 48

Things I Can't Live Without

Tue, 12 Aug 2025 00:00:00 +0000



AS ALWAYS, SINCE I AM a master of tangent (sounds like a title that can become a reality TV show, doesn't it?) I didn't get to talk about the 16 things that I cannot live without which was what I originally set out to do in my last post. So, let me do it here. But since the list itself also appears in my last post, I'll reorganize it based on the three ethical categories that I believe to serve well for this particular purpose.

Note that the first thing on the list has an entire post dedicated to it -- on Day 47! (yesterday!) PERSONAL: Personal to me, these are what I cannot live without. My Montblanc fountain pen; My family, especially my mother and brother; My anthropological relationship with every single object (by objects I mean things that exist external to me) that I owe; My obsession with Japan.

VIRTUE ETHICS: Defined by my trusted source for philosophical ideas and knowledge Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy as the normative codes of conduct that emphasize the self-development of a person's own moral character (which is different from those of the deontological that emphasizes the duties of a person to the society based on good moral intention, and consequentialism which only emphasizes only the consequences of actions). As a Rousseaurian stoic existentialist, I cannot take deontological ethics seriously.

I do believe that there are things that we should do, but to believe that we have to treat those "as duties" are nothing less than making a conscious attempt in taking away your own freedom from life as such. I would rather believe, instead, that things that I must do are things that I can't live without -- because of my personal sense of morality. Deontological ethics, by the way, could inspire my personal sense of morality, as well as any other forms of ethics for that matter.

The difference here between following the deontological ethics and only using it to inspire my personal sense of morality is that in the latter I still get to exercise my sense of criticality, and get the freedom to say what I want to believe in, and what I would like to follow. Consequentialism is, on the other hand, should not even be considered ethics at all. None of my actions has been inspired by consequentialism. I believe that anything we do, we must begin with a good intention.

Without good intention, whatever is the result cannot be thought of as a product of malignant desire which I do not want to have it as a part of my moral system. Cheating in an exam, for instance, might be considered moral in a particular circumstance, but I still would never do it and would rather fail because I do not believe that such action, despite its appealing short-term consequence, could yield any long-and-eternal-term consequences.

So, to see the result as the mere justification for what we should do is, simply, ridiculous. So, virtue ethics it is.

These are things virtue ethics that I cannot live without: My unquenchable thirst for knowledge and something new; My appreciation for art (including films and photography), language, music, and philosophy (mainly moral philosophy and epistemology); My eternal abhorrence for superficiality; My self-imposed doctrine in doing things because they're the right things to do, and not because they may yield material and other forms of profits (therefore, my absolute disbelief in consequentialism); My self-critic buddy who will always be with me when I think; My absolute hatred for conservatism; My belief in open-mindedness plus skepticism, AKA fallibilism;

My love for architecture and built environment; My writing ("I write, therefore I am," said Non).

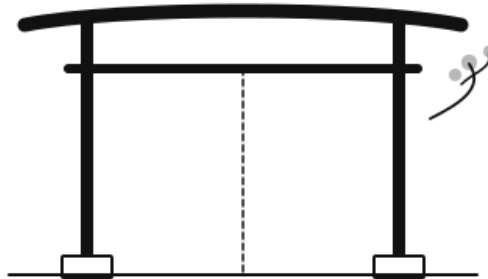
SELF-DESTRUCTION: These are things that I know I can't live without but I am trying to live without because living with them is absolutely self-destructive! Around four years ago, cigarettes would probably be the first on the list (so thank god I am no longer a chain smoker). About a decade ago or so, graphic novels (AKA Japanese manga) would probably be also up there on this list as well. But now, only these three.

My unconditional biological and mental appreciation for women and their womanhood: their bodies, psychologies, and maternal instinct My insatiable desire for hot spring (especially Japanese onsen), alcohol, and technological gadgets.

DAY 49

On Sex: Part 2

Wed, 13 Aug 2025 00:00:00 +0000



HAVING SPENT THE LAST THREE days of my life in Japan, I can't help but to feel overwhelmed. A society that on the surface seems both socially orderly and culturally conservative is in fact very liberating when it comes to sex. In the area in Tokyo called Akihabara, where shops for toys and knickknacks and electronic stuff stand side by side with each other, there are many "underground shops" (both literally, as in located in the basement, and metaphorically, as in seeking to be an alternative way of doing things).

These shops sell DVDs, graphic novels, souvenirs, toys -- all related to sex. And when I say sex in Akihabara, it's more than just a matter of sexual activity, specifically sexual intercourse, but every thing one can possibly imagine to be relating the sexual organs, of all sexes, of all ages, and of all possible walks of life.

In one popular DVD shops, there are literally more than 50,000 pornographic DVDs featuring men, women, gay men, gay women, and transgender; both young and old-looking actors and actresses; both between human beings, between human beings and dolls, and human beings and animals; both consensual and non-consensual; both ordinary and over-weighted; and, so on. So, whatever one has in terms of sexual fantasy, one can always find a DVD (or DVDs) that suit one's desire. Period.

It's an interesting, at the same time sort of disgusting, to be at a place like that DVD shop. I had to take a look because I had never been to one and I was curious to learn about how liberating sexual sphere in Japan can be. In Japan, pornography is a \$20 billion industry.

On the one hand, there are many men who are too socially awkward to want to engage in a conversation with a woman, let alone to be able to engage in other forms of intimacy that would satisfy the woman in a respectful way. On the other hand, there are many women who are lonely.

Apart from the obvious fact that quality men are difficult to find in a society that seems conservative on the surface as such, these working women are also direct beneficiaries of the pressure from the society above them to find a man to whom to get married, be a wife, bare a baby, and eventually recognize their conservatively subordinate role from the cradle to the grave -- while being fed the information from various media about the possibility of them having the potential to do something else more ambitious which doesn't necessary have to be the above.

Therefore, many of them choose to be alone. I was already blown away by the first section, which featured only "light" pornography such as a normal couple having sex -- because these normal couple were "exaggerating everything," from the unusually and systematically loud noise that they made to the unusual positions that looked as though they were performing them for a camera since they weren't natural, which made it easy for me to tell that they may be pretending to be happy.

I asked myself: Who would want to see these "fake" things? At least, to be convincing, a pornography has to be based on reality. That said, it's precisely the point that there is nothing "based on reality" about pornography, in fact, that makes it appealing. By definition, pornography is visual materials containing the explicit display of sexual organs or activity, intended to "stimulate eroticism" rather than aesthetic feeling (otherwise it would be called "art form" perhaps?).

So, in order to do so, it has to do away with the mechanical stuff that sex involves, and take it to another level by incorporating a series of cinematic probes to take the viewers on the journey to the place where they will never get to go by themselves. The second-wave feminists, in fact, have brought up the issue like these in their writings -- that pornography is a form of human trafficking. These second-wave feminists are members of a radical feminism of the late 1960s and early 1970s.

Their agenda is to shed light on what was now termed "women's oppression." The idea that a pornography could be seen a form of human trafficking has been spearheaded by the legal scholar and a member of this movement Catherine McKinnon who is now teaching at University of Michigan Law School (which is one of the best law schools in the US).

To Professor McKinnon, pornography does not have the same effect of trading in something illegal in a direct way as in abducting someone and carrying her over the boarder, but these exaggerated "pornographic" scenes give the ordinary people (both men and women) who happen to watch them a false impression that women would love it when the intercourse is painful, when the penetration involves force, and when the woman says "no" she actually means yes.

So, morally, it's pornography provides a false impression of what a woman needs, which could lead to the demand for prostitution since many of the things seen in pornography are not the kinds of things that can be easily replicated at home by a loving wife or a partner, but only by an experienced professional sex worker.

To Professor Catherine McKinnon, not only does pornography, argues the second-wave feminists, posits violence as a form of masculinistic expression, but it also creates "delusion of sexual polarity" that there is the men who are the active doers and there are the women who are the passive receivers of violence.

One of the ardent voices of this second wave feminist movement John Stolternberg has provided these following advice: Don't let your sexuality be manipulated by the pornographic industry; Don't let drugs and alcohol numb through your "sex life"; and, Don't fixate on fucking. So, what should I make of these customers of this DVD shop?

At the time when I was there (late afternoon of a Saturday) there're around 10-20 people in a tiny space in the basement of a building that sold graphic novels (AKA Japanese manga) and other cute souvenirs on the ground floor.

While I often do not judge people (because I only have very little knowledge that I have about anyone at all) there's something in my gut feeling which tells me that it "ain't right" for anyone at all to have a desire for a graphic rape scene, or a scene in which a man is having sex with an obviously under-aged girl(s) although one knows that it's just a show and therefore isn't real.

I do judge people sometimes -- like, "when they have bad faith, they are dead to me" kind of judgement, so the thing I absolute hate is bad faith. Can I say that these people, most of whom look normal, just like you and me, have bad faith when they want to see a man, and a woman who looks as though she is under-aged, performing a sex scene in action in a staged and themed cinematic setting?

I can't think of a reason to think that they have bad faith. This afternoon I saw a man in his 50s, whom I could easily mistake as a professor if I see him on the street. He looked very neat; with his suit and tie. And his slightly curly and messy hair with a pair of thick yet stylish professorial eyeglasses made him look just like any normal middle-aged man with whom you could go out for lunch.

He's the one I saw in the "short girls" section of this DVD shop. He was browsing latest DVDs featuring girls who "looked young" (in the adult videos, AKA "AV" world these girls are those who aren't actually that young; they are just shorter than 150 centimeters and therefore when putting them in "cute girl uniforms" one could mistake them for being the real children).

I observed him for a good 30 minutes -- ethnographic style -- while walking through a series of very tiny low of DVDs, encountering other browsers who, like this professor-looking guys, could be anyone that we know. They weren't creepy looking people that you'd like to avoid -- they looked like us, normal people. After those 20 minutes, this professor-looking guy was holding about five DVDs in his hand, and all of them were the latest in the "girls being raped" section of that DVD shop.

And then he left the shop, looking very very happy. I don't know anything about this guy. I don't know whether he has a family, whether or not he has a daughter, whether or not he has ever slept with a real woman, and so on.

So, say, he might be interested in watching an actress playing a role of a young girl getting raped by an adult male, but he's only watching it to satisfy his fantasy without any intention to take it to the next level (in the sense that he has no interest in actually raping a woman) hence he will never hurt anyone, would that be okay? Many people would say it is not okay.

To be a pedophile, or a person who has a sexual interest in children, is never okay in any developed countries, societies, and communities; the idea of which comes from our modern society's collective and unanimous interest in the well-being of the youngs, as we do believe that they do not possess the full knowledge of the world to make a informed judgement by which they will not be regretting afterwards.

We want to protect the children; thus, we keep them off the hands of the older people who want to take advantage of these young people's lack of capacity to act rationally because of their lack of knowledge about the world -- that there are people in the world who only want to take your body as a means to an end.

So, even though I am an open-minded person (I believe I am), there's something in my gut feeling that was telling me this ain't right, which, an experimental psychologist would call it "intuitive ethics." This idea of intuitive ethics has to do, precisely, with the idea that most of time

something seems wrong and we don't have an immediate rationale reason to justify it, mainly because the "feeling" itself is based on one of the six domains that are commonly used to judge whether an action is right or wrong, which are: Care/harm; Fairness/cheating; Loyalty/betrayal, Authority/subversion; Sanctity/degradation; and, Liberty/oppression In this sense, what my gut feeling tells me is that the action of this guy has a tendency violates at least three of these six spheres.

His act of wanting to watch someone being hurt violates the care/harm domain. If he has a wife or is in a committed relationship, his action might also considered as being a betrayal to that vow. Lastly, it's degrading, as in impure, defiled, and immoral. His intention in watching these DVDs, although he has no intention to reenact the scenes in real life, is considered a practice.

Who knows whether or not one day his action would be influenced (and, worse, driven) by his uncontrollable desire to reenact the gruesome rape scene he holds dear? So, in a society that bases its societal premise on the idea that everyone should owe his or her society at least some sense of civility, his action would be considered immoral, and therefore he should be condemned, convicted, and paying for his wrong doing in whichever way his society believes to give him a lesson for being a bad citizen.

That said, in the liberal consequentialistic world, his action would be alright. The master, and one of the founding fathers, of consequentialism Jeremy Bentham himself once makes it really clear that it does not matter when it comes to casual sex: One could have uncommitted sex for fun, with a member of one's own gender (i.e., homosexuality), with one own's family member, with an animal, with oneself, and so on -- it's all alright as long as one keeps his sex within his private sphere, and, by that, hurts nobody.

Whatever one chooses to do, as long as one doesn't cause other people discomfort and harm, it's within one's domain of natural right, said Bentham (not these exact words but it's a decent paraphrasing of his). I am getting into the habit of writing a long post again. Well, but this time I'd like to end it here.

The point that I am trying to make here is something that recently (as in today's afternoon) I had a pleasure of engaging in quite an interesting set of conversations with my colleague Matt who is not working here in Japan.

We started off by talking about the kind of love that is considered "non-possessive" and whether or not that is possible (the Sartre and de Beauvoir example came up as the most vivid and obvious of all), and then we went on to debate whether or not it's possible to have a non-possessive love, in the sense that two people could love each other unconditionally and wholeheartedly, but would also want sleep with someone else from time to time.

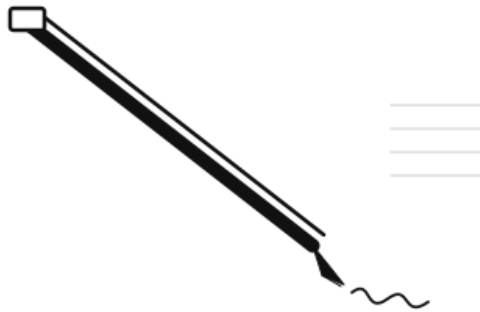
In other words, does sex and love are naturally tied to each other? Can one love someone and have sex with someone else? I argue that the concept of love and sex as being one is culturally constructed, mainly by religions and the powerful as they see the idea of monogamy to be more suitable for a society in which stable "married" citizens are the essential element.

I don't think that which is the case before we have social order in the west, and before the modern revolution after WWII in the east that the two concepts are no longer a dichotomy but a part of each other under the banner of "romantic relationship." I don't know how to got to this point where I decided to see how far a conservative society such as Japan could go in terms of letting the Pandora's Box permanently open, but it seems to be the case that in any society that seems on the surface to be conservative about sex there are a lot going on underneath which are detrimental to the psyche of the overall population, such as the underground pornography in Akihabara.

DAY 50

On Sex Part 2.5 (Q & A)

Thu, 14 Aug 2025 00:00:00 +0000



IT FELT AS THOUGH I had dropped a bomb yesterday. After the last post was up, I have been receiving a number of questions about how I come to grips with the core idea of sex that seems to be quite different from the conventional belief.

So, instead of writing the last installment of the trilogy On Sex which I originally planned to do, I would like to use this space, today, instead to answer some of the questions -- therefore the topic of this post On Sex Part 2.5 (Q&A) -- that have been posed to me in the past 18 hours ever since the On Sex Part 2 has been posted.

"What is the definition of love?" "Why are people making it so difficult to break the ice?" "What's the function of sex?" "What is the metaphysics of sex?" "What's the foundation of sexual morality?" There're many more questions, in fact.

I believe I have answered most questions somewhere in this blog (it's really here and there in this blog; my guess would be in the Why I Give Up Love Trilogy) so I'll let you decide whether you would like to return to those posts to find out about your answer. In this On Sex Part 2.5, I'd like to answer just two questions -- these two questions are pressing questions that I believe deserve detailed answers. Those two questions are: Can sex and love be

separated?

Should a non-possessive lover be okay if his or her partner dates and/or sleeps with other people? In other words (and thanks to my colleague Matt for this question by the way) it is possible that you can "be in love" with someone, without wanting to have sex with him?

(This may or may not mean that you would rather engage in a sexual relationship with someone else, as it could just be that you love someone but hate to think about the idea of that person so you'd rather not having sex at all as well). Most of us, in today's society, are so embedded in the idea of romantic love that the modern society has given us, it seems naturally that sex and love should be a part of each other in order for them to be meaningful.

Yet, to play devil's advocate, it is possible to put sex and love in two different domains? If we say, "yes, it's possible," sex, in this sense, would just be a purely biological act whose only function is to satisfy one's demand for a particular type of physical pleasure. I want to start with my personal take on this.

My answer is actually the above: "yes, it's definitely possible." There isn't anything intrinsic about the relationship between sex and love -- as one is emotionally/spiritual and the other could be (if we want to) purely biological. As the American actress Betty Davis (1908 - 1989) once said: Sex is God's joke on human beings. I don't believe in an anthropomorphic God, and I don't remember when was the first time I heard this quote.

All I remember is that it struck me too hard when I heard it for the first time that I felt as though I would need share it with everyone. I agree with Betty Davis, I even think to myself that, as a heterosexual man, my relationship with most people of opposite sex would be much much much better if I no longer need sex. So, sometimes I wish I am just an infertile man who can't erect himself.

In fact, if that happens to me one day, I would tell myself that which isn't so bad: now I can see, talk, and meet women, as a purely rational man whose natural inclination is no longer driving him to feel excited by the possibility of to engaging physically and intimately with them. In fact, I'd make it very open so that they we could be clear from the beginning that the possibility of us going to bed is zero because I don't have the physical capacity to do so.

When that happens to me, I have a feeling that I would be able to spend more time writing since I will be less distracted, and that I would be able to get to know more people because I will no longer have to play the guessing game and try to speculate how the person to whom I am taking think of me. It'd be a great world to live in, actually!

And this is why it would be so nice if we no longer need to have sex, and that's why as Davis said, "sex is God's joke on human beings." My relationship with any women would be completely intellectual, based on absolute friendship and unconditional respect for each other.

When sex is on the table, and it is still so easy to get -- meaning that sex is, make no mistake, probably the downright most enjoyable thing to do that requires nothing else, but two physical bodies of two people; so it's both easy and economical -- people of opposite sex tend to be less sincere because they don't know what the other expect from them. If there's no sex in the world, we would just be engaging with each other with much more sincerity, I believe.

That said, and this is something I'd like to write in Part 3 of my On Sex trilogy, perhaps a quick-and-easy fix to remove sex from the loaded meaning that it currently possesses, which is precisely that it has to be more than just sex. Hence, I think sex and love are not, and do not have to be synonymous at all. Yes, you can want to have sex with a stranger.

In fact, most of us get that feeling all the time (and that is why there's a phrase "sex sells," especially in advertisements, right?). Yet, first of all, although I believe that sex and love are not the same thing and one (namely

love) does not necessary have to be the prerequisite of the other (namely sex), I nevertheless think it's useful to have a feeling for the person with whom you'd like to have sex.

We human beings are weakest, most passionate, most vulnerable, and most irrational when we engage in a sexual intercourse. So, letting someone you don't trust see, feel, and experience your body in that state is extremely risky (d0n't you think so?). It's almost as though you are opening your entire physical and mental body to another person to do whatever he or she wants with it. Why would you want to do that with someone you don't trust? Isn't that just insanely risky?

I think it is risky, and that's the reason why I only have sex with someone whom I trust -- and often, if not always, someone whom I trust is the person with whom I could imagine being in a loving relationship. And why is trust so important? It saves you from the vulnerability that you creates for yourself to be in when you have sex. Personally, I believe that I can only have sex with someone I truly trust.

Therefore, by that belief, I could never have had sex with a prostitute, or someone I have only met for a short period of time since I know myself well enough to know that it often takes quite some time for me to trust someone truly. So, for me, through trust, I connect love and sex. That's just my reason though. Most people I talked give a qualified no to this question: "love and sex have to be together.

period." The most common argument that they make often goes like this: Sex without love is like two (or more) swines having sex; both swines are driven only by their natural desire which they can't control, and we are human beings who aren't like that. It's true that for millenniums, human beings have tried to distinguish themselves from animals. The philosopher Immanuel Kant uses reason as the single most important factor that distinguishes us -- "rationale beings" from animals.

He even goes so far as to say that such honorable title of rational human beings can also be stripped of if we don't act rationally; for example, Kant regards suicide as an act that exists outside of reason so those who commit suicide are not rationale beings.

They are simply just "beings." As many social scientists (e.g., social and evolutionary anthropologists) have also argued, the invention of eating utensils and complicated process of food processing is no less than creation of layers of cultural elements to accommodate the consumption of the "culturally" cooked food.

The reason why such cultural sensibility is so important is because we human beings want to remind themselves how we are different from the "naturalistic" animals who eat food raw using their natural body parts, such as their mouths (to eat directly from the ground) and their paws (to put the food directly into their mouths).

When someone eat with their hands or without mannerism, many of us automatically tend to see them as "eating like an animal." Like eating, sex is also something that both human beings and animals share. Human beings have the urge to assign explicit significance to sex, also to distinguish themselves from being animalistic. The idea of human sexuality which is to be radically different from that of animals, then emerges.

A set of rules (made, of course, by human beings themselves) to make the difference between them and animals becomes more and more obvious as society develops. If what defines animalism is the purely and contentedly natural desire and instinct to have sex, we human beings feel as though we can be different by using reason to monitor such instinctual desire.

We have also been telling ourselves that by closely and carefully monitoring such desire, we are doing ourselves some good deeds by staying away from troubles -- namely our instinctual inclination to imposing our own's desire onto other physical body without a consent, which could lead to many problems at many levels from crimes (e.g., rape) all the way to the ambiguity

in the structuring of a society (e.g., giving birth to someone whom you won't have the ability to take of).

Since the building block of society consists of the notion of family, community, (and the avoidance, at all cost, of incest is also there to prevent people from engaging in something, e.g., an activity, that would lead to biologically and genetically hazardous results) casual sex, in this sense, could lead to all kinds of problems. A more sophisticated argument (often made by anthropologists and sociologists) involves the idea that sex is a means of reproduction.

Since reproduction is important to the continuation of a community, the action that leads to it, then, has to be sacred because the meaning of reproduction as such is tied to the notion of the transcendence. One of the most convenient way to make something scared is to make it difficult to get, so tying it to something rather vague and conceptual, at least on the surface, provides that sense of delirious difficulty.

Having sex is also related with procreation, and that's why religions and religiousities have also been playing a very important role in demarcating a clear boudary between lone and sex. Now, let's get to the second question. I do remember that I have written at length about my love affairs with what I call "a non-possessive" love (and I believe that which is in the Part 3 of Why I Give Up Love trilogy). The logic is quite simple: You can't possess a person: A person is free.

The only things you can possess are objects. So, when you're possessing anyone at all you are reducing that person into a mere object that you can have control over. I think it's utterly unfair for anyone to reduce someone with whom he or she believes to be in love to a mere object to be possessed in that way.

That said, as I have outlined earlier in this post that I don't just have sex with whomever I feel like having sex with, and it has to be someone whom I trust, what kind of "sex" would that be? I'd say it'd be, first and foremost, a

non-possessive sex since, under the same logic, a possessive sex would be the kind of sex that one of the partner, or both, is/are the possessable object(s) of the other.

On the other hand, I don't go around having "non-possessive sex" with whoever I meet because I believe that there should be something that allows me, at least, to feel safe when lying next (or on top, or below, or sideways, or whatever -- you get the point) the person with whom I have sex.

Hence, does this mean that I am sort of contradicting myself when I think that people should not feel as though they are capable of possessing entirely the right of his or her counterpart to have sex only with themselves (which sort of implies that the person should be free to have sex with whomever they wish as long as there's a true sense of trust there), but at the same time I don't go about and do that?

I think the best way to go about answering this question is to return to the very meaning of "possessive love." Let me provide you with two examples. One of my ex-girlfriends was obsessed about possessing me. She wanted to possess my time, and also my right to live the life the way I'd done so before I met her. She didn't like it when I worked because she believed I should be spending more time with her.

She didn't like it when I spent time with my family for the same reason. On the other hand, she spent time with her family and had a true love affair with her job, so she could spend as much time as she wished with her work and her family. So, because she thought of me as an object to be possessed, she had all the rights to do whatever she saw fit, but I could not and had to follow her rules. That was a deal breaker for me.

The other example is a good friend of mine who wanted to get out of an unhealthy (and abusive) relationship, but the only reason holding her back was, according to her: The fact that we have been together for a very long time. I felt as though he's mine. And I can't imagine my life without him. When I inquired further about this relationship, she burst into tears. She said

there's nothing good about it. He may be cheating on her as we spoke.

He had no interest any more in her physical body, and the love and the respect that were there when they were dating was nothing more than archaeological facts. She wanted to leave this toxic relationship, and she believed that if she was able to do it her life would be better (as she's an attractive person with a very kind heart).

What held her back here is what Sartre (again, who else) would call "bad faith." The feeling of wanting to possess someone so badly made her believe that her life as such cannot exist otherwise and therefore she had to endure living her life that was not entirely hers. This desire to possess the one who love is bad for both of you. It's difficult to say which comes first between her boyfriend's decline in his interest in her, or her over possessiveness.

But there seemed to be some correlation here. The more she's possessive of him, the less he wanted to spend time with her. The less he spent time with her, the more she felt as though he needed to be hers, although just mentally. The irony is that, as she said that he could be having an affair right now, he apparently didn't give a damn about her possessiveness.

He simply didn't think that she owned him, and may even be hinting at that so that she would be the one to call for a break up as opposed to being him. Every time I saw this friend of mine in the hallway of our workplace, she looked as though she was living the last day of her life, which wasn't the case just a few months earlier. This "possessive love" should go to frame. It's not just useless, but also immoral, in my opinion.

So, let's get back to my very first argument again. I think we can live in a "non-possessive world" -- and yes, I'd like that because that world sort of has my name in it (kidding). Seriously. Non-possessive love is not necessary an orgy of casual love and irresponsible sex -- that's not what I meant by non-possessive love.

For me non-possessive love is the true love in the sense that each of the two people would be non-possessively giving to one another without the desire

to take anything from the other person.

Because a human being cannot be possessed, the only way to keep the love is, then, definitely not by ways of signing a paper (e.g., marriage certificate; and everyone in their right minds know how useless a marriage certificate is in keeping two people together) or by seeking other people's approval (e.g., by telling the world that this person is her "boyfriend"; that's downright "bad faith" -- how could you love someone who thinks of you as an object?), but to respect each other from within, and want to develop oneself to be better in the everyday of his or her waking life, and in various capacities both in his or her profession as well as in treating each other (so learning more about each others' basic biological and physicality would be key here).

Living together this way, these "non-possessive lovers" would both feel the sense of dignity in each other. But most important, they would both feel that there is no reason whatsoever, to not wanting to be someone with such a heart of gold, for the rest of time. This way, despite the decline in superficial physical beauty, or other form of decline, the development of companionship will continue to run throughout the relationship.

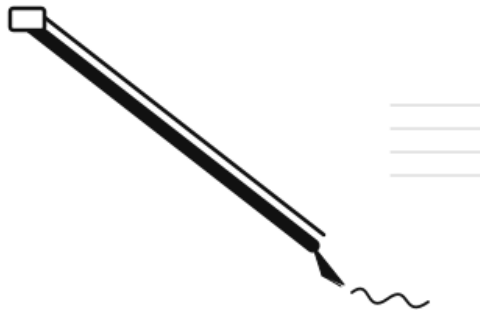
For those of whom who know me (through this blog and outside) would know that what I hold dearly is Jean-Paul Sartre "open marriage" with Simone de Beauvoir. I think it's beautiful. There were ups and downs for sure in their relationship (for those who wish to know more, Sartre's *Witness to My Life*, and Simone de Beauvoir's autobiography is a must!) but that which is the case in any marriage either open or close anyway.

The fact that matter to me here is that what bond them together is not some kind of magical power or legal status, but their love to develop themselves intellectually so that they could engage both purely in an intellectual way and under the guise of romance whatever they shall want to define. Do you agree?

DAY 51

It's a Non-Issue

Fri, 15 Aug 2025 00:00:00 +0000



I FORGOT COMPLETELY TO MENTION how happy I was that I got to Day 50 in my last post -- that's halfway through the goal of one hundred days that I had set for myself at the beginning a few months back. It's been, of course, more than 50 days since I have not been consistent about writing a post a day. I have always been very bad at disciplining myself.

The original plan was to write about 1,000 words a day to reflect on moral and personal issues that I'd anticipate to be facing in the dissertation writing process. But as you know, as I've begun to write passionately, everything and anything have become more and more personal. My posts have become longer and longer, as my ability to restrain myself to write more than I had planned to become more and more limited. At the end, I just gave up altogether.

As I have begun to reflect on my dissertation writing process, "the issue" that I would like to spend the rest of my life unpacking has become clear: the meaning of it all. It's true that I should not try to bite off more than I can chew. Although I have a deep and sincere belief that writing could somehow get me there, I also always wholeheartedly acknowledge the limit to the ability of words in expressing and describing the "things in themselves." Language has its limits.

Language is shaky, as often because more than one interpretations could be derived from even a single word, it's confusing to understand fully the message that the language is being used as a vehicle for sending it across from one mind to the other, and also from oneself to the other-self residing within oneself (i.e., communicating with your own self).

Like the philosophy, Laozi once said, "The way (dao) that can be expressed is not the everlasting way; The names (ming) that can be named are not changeless names." If we're to interpret Laozi in a contemporary way, we might want to resort to Ludwig Wittgenstein's argument about the problematic role of language in philosophy, in which the idea that one cannot think about complex philosophical inquiry without a language (try it, can you?) paradoxically entertains the idea that it is not possible to communicate ideas through language because not everyone understands a concept in a similar way.

For instance, how can we begin to talk about the philosophy of "love," without an absolutely shared and common understanding of love? Can we have an absolutely shared and common understanding of love? Wittgenstein would probably say no, and so would I. That is, language itself may be the obstacle that prevents us in arriving at the meaning of a concept (in this case, love). In this post, I'd like to share an essay written by a student who interviewed me for her journalism class' paper.

The original title of this post is "My Oral History (as Written by Someone Else)," but I changed it to the current title to honour the creativity of the student who wrote the piece. I had guessed that the point of the interview was for this student (and many of her classmates who had to produce similar assignments) to learn how to compose and coherent essay based on a single interview with someone from whom the student had an interest in learning more.

I was more than happy that this student, Kaiwen "Karen" Wu, was interested in my story, as a teacher, and as an architect. So, with her permission, of course, I'd like to share with you this assignment of hers, in which she wrote

about me based on an informal yet in-depth interview she had with me one morning a couple of weeks ago.

To make it read better, I have made a few edits throughout the piece, with her permission of course from Karen who would like to call this piece, "It's a Non-Issue." The parts written in different colours are my annotations to help contextualize the piece. It's a Non-Issue Born in Bangkok, Thailand in 1981, Non is a trained architect, urban designer, historian, and anthropologist. Growing up in Thailand until he was 16 [after which he left Thailand for Oklahoma City for high school there], he has a simple childhood.

His great grandparents were from Chaozhou, a small town in the southern province of Guangdong. Unlike his great grandparents who came from China, Non's [both paternal and maternal] grandparents were all born in northeast Thailand in the 1920s [therefore Non considers himself more from northeastern Thailand rather than Bangkok].

As members of the overseas Chinese community, Non's [maternal] grandparents [to whom he had been much closer compared to the grandparents on his father's side, told him that they often] felt as if there were not many interesting things for them to do [as the opportunity for the second generation Chinese migrants like themselves were not abundant, especially before and during the anti-Chinese movement and campaign by the elite Thai in the 1950s-1960s]; they only farmed and made a living by running a small grocery store.

[In fact, his maternal grandparents often told him the "family ethics": always get up early in the morning; always eat fast; and always work diligently. All of these were to reinforce his grandparents' sense of identity, which was the outsiders to the Thai community; hence, working hard was the only possible way to live a decent, dignified, and comfortable life].

His grandparents' frugal lifestyle is the reason why Non believes his childhood life was "pretty simple." He played with his friends in the rice field, and there was not much intellectual stimulation at all. This was the

environment in which the young Non grew up. When he was 16, he went to a high school in Oklahoma City as an exchange student. In 2005, he was awarded the Fulbright Program scholarship and was admitted to Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT).

[It's not that there wasn't anything interesting between 1998 and 2005. There're many interesting stories. Some of which have been written about in the I Was Lucky post]. Non received two graduate degrees from MIT: one is history and theory of art and architecture [a field combining architecture, aesthetics, and general philosophy], and the other in urban planning and design. According to him, MIT was the school that was most pivotal to his personal development.

The experience at MIT has contributed immensely to his way of thinking later on in many ways. He has often written about his years at MIT on his blog. For example, he gave an example that if a student said that he or she is "not feeling well that day," whereas that student might get an extra day to work on his or her projects, nobody at MIT would be bothered to care. If your exam result was bad, then you're out.

[MIT during Non's time was one of the toughest schools that were happy to kick you out if you were not good enough to be there]. You may complain to people as much as you wish about your failure, and nobody would care to listen because most people would be fighting their own fights.

Complaining, for instance, that "I am not a native speaker of English [which was something for which Non had blamed himself with regards to his first few unsuccessful semesters there], I have to struggle to learn so much English every day," would not do any good, as no one would show any sympathy. The goal is to achieve good grades. My goal was to learn as hard as I could. If you're not a native speaker of English, then read more books and try harder to promote your English.

There's nothing about which to complain! The reason why MIT made him stronger is that it left him with no room to waste his time by blaming his

destiny, or himself, or other people for his failure. "If you fail, you fail," said Non.

[Non's life at MIT got him the first glimpse of an existentialist way of thinking about life, which was to perform his best with the greatest intention without wanting to resort to someone else to be responsible for the outcome of such performance.] Non claimed that this made him very strong because he had to fight his way through everything. After MIT, he was admitted to Oxford University and earned a master's degree in Modern Chinese Studies [with the focus in history and anthropology] from the Oriental Institute there.

Non, however, does not believe that he had learned as much from Oxford as he did from MIT. Oxford was a very lofty place. "People were reading articles from decades, or even centuries ago without any critical mindsets," said Non. Discussions were not based on intellectual engagement, but on the ground that nothing except memorization.

For instance, if students were going to discuss history, they wouldn't be talking about how to understand history, or what they can learn from the history; instead, they would be talking about in a specific year something happened: An example of a typical Oxford discussion that he partook goes in the following manner: Student A: Let's talk about the movement that I believe happened in 1961 Student B: Oh no no no, it's in 1962, it's not 1961; by the way, it's in May and not April," don't you know that?

How could these two students arrive at anything meaningful in history if the objective of the conversation was, simply, to compete in showing off how knew more encyclopedic sort of facts? These people were simply debating facts, which they believed to override the importance of the crucial historical lessons from which they could learn.

Like one of his favourite philosophers Michel de Montaigne, Non only cares about what he can get from studying history and how history tells him how and why one can attempt to "not make the same mistake again." That's the most important thing for which he thinks history is worth studying. When

discussing how he has developed his interest in many of his fields of study, Non said that he had been most interested in architecture -- the core around which his other fields of study spun.

He started with architecture but after he has taught it at various universities, and practised it for years, he realized that he did not know enough about the subject and he needs to know more. He believes that to design a building that nobody wants to use is not architecture. He thinks that people, human beings, should be at the centre of architecture. So he wants to engage in a study that allows him to better understand human beings.

By better understanding the users of the architecture – the people – he believes that which will, in turn, make him a better architect, as he writes in an essay in honour of his friend and mentor at MIT, Professor Jan Wampler: When I first started learning about architecture, I too naively thought that excellence was equated with distinctiveness – and to be distinctive and architect would have to invent something from scratch.

Unfortunately, as I have also learned through personal experience that when distinctiveness is created for its own sake, the excitement often dies quickly, giving way to architecture that is soon looked upon as hackneyed, mundane, and obsolete. Personally, I credit my architecture education under Jan's mentorship with my current academic career studying history and anthropology.

While Jan would probably never admit that he is as much an anthropologist as he is an architect, I am always reminded by his teaching that regardless of what I do for a living, I will always be an architect – not because I was trained as one, but because like him I hold paramount the goal of making a better living environment for all. That is why he made the switch from architecture to humanities, to history, and then to anthropology.

Although he was originally trained as an architect and urban designer, Non has taught many courses in humanities and social sciences. As a teacher in these two broad fields, he always make sure that the course's learning goals

are set at the beginning. These goals include making sure that his students can learn how to absorb and express ideas critically -- in other words, how to read and write intellectually. He always wants to make sure that his students are able to engage in critical discussions and debate with open-mindedness.

His personal goal is that he always wants his students to learn from his classes not just for grades, but to achieve the goal of becoming better people and to be better at living their lives. Also, there is something, which he believes wholeheartedly -- He believes that as a moral person, he needs to be able to voice his own opinion regarding his personal sense of morality. For instance, with regards to gender equality, he believes that we should be able to make man and woman equal.

There should be only one gender in this world: the human gender. In his spare time, Non likes to bike around Shanghai. He bikes 40 kilometres a day because biking makes he feel liberated. Non cares a lot about faith. He believes that he has good faith, as opposed to "bad faith," which is a concept coined by the French existentialist philosopher Jean-Paul Sartre. He believes that there are two kinds of faith: bad faith and good faith.

Bad faith is when you happen to believe that things "have to" be the way they are, and therefore close the door for other possibilities. In Non's view, speaking to people with bad faith is a waste of time. If he realizes that someone has bad faith, he will not bother trying to talk to him or her again. ["If you have bad faith, you're dead to me," said Non].

He believes people of bad faith do not see the complexity of human diversity -- that there are many unique people and experiences in the world. Talking about his plans for the future, Non told me that he does not usually plan much. He used to plan a lot, but because things didn't always go as planned, therefore he'd stopped spending too much time on planning altogether.

The pivotal moment for him was when he realized that his most important plan, which was to take his father around the world, was shattered into pieces because of his father's abruptly and unexpectedly died. In Thailand,

his father worked for the government therefore his retirement age was strictly at 60. Non had hoped that once his father retired, he could take his father around the world with his savings. His father retired at 60, but unfortunately at 61 he passed away owing to his chronic illness.

Non planned really well, but that around-the-world trip didn't happen, because his father's untimely death. Since then, Non had stopped planning altogether. Non told me that if he had known his father would die at 61, he probably wouldn't go abroad. He probably wouldn't have gone MIT. He probably wouldn't have gone to Oxford, and he probably wouldn't have gone anywhere. He probably would have just stayed with his father. Non would have spent the last ten years of his father's life with him in Thailand.

He would have given up everything for his father. So after his father passed away, he simply stopped planning, and instead begun to open himself up for serendipity – by not having fixed plans. He doesn't know what he's going to do for the future. He is still working on everything because he believes that no one really knows what the future will be like. You never know which comes first: tomorrow or an accident that could end your life there.

He is living in the moment, in the present, and therefore he always wants to make the best of his life every day. His goal in life is as simple as in his described childhood: To be able to get up in the morning with energy; to know exactly what he is going to do that day to make his life meaningful; and, then to give it all into whatever that is that gives him the meaning in his life.

If he teaches, he would put everything –passion, energy, love, care, and so on – into his teaching. So when he gets back home in the evening, he could go to bed and rest reassuringly because he knows that he has done his best to do everything he could for those who he cares whether that be his students, colleagues, or the education and the society as a whole. He just lives his day to the fullest. He believes that life is that simple.

At the end of the day, the only right that Non believes he has and will always possess – in the sense that no one can take it away from him no matter what

– is his right to be critical.

Like the writer Ernest Hemingway who refused to go on with his life when he realized that his ability to write had been taken away by his illness, Non thinks that he would not be able to live a meaningful life if he were not allowed to be critical [although he rejects suicide as a way to emancipate because he values life -- every life, including his own]. He is most critical about himself. He is mildly critical about his students and his colleagues.

He is somewhat critical about the entire world -- precisely because that's what allows him to be himself. When people talk about Non in the school, they always say, "oh, Non, he is very critical." And he believes that it is usually a good thing.

post Day 52: What Does "God is Dead" Mean?

Sat, 16 Aug 2025 00:00:00 +0000 Arguably one of the most misinterpreted quotes of all time is Friedrich Nietzsche's "God is Dead" (i.e., the title of this post in case you haven't noticed). This post is going to be a short one. It occurs to me that many people to whom I have been talking interpret this famous quote by Friedrich Nietzsche in a variety of ways.

Since we all have different ideas of "God" based on our faiths (and non-faiths), it's not surprising that we may also have very different ideas of how it would be like for this figure (or non-figure) called "God" to be alive, let alone being dead. As a devoted and practicing existentialist, I feel the urge to try to explain this quote, which, as many might argue, is the basis of the existentialist doctrine.

I'll probably write a long(er) version explaining this quote at some point in the rest of the 100 days, but for now I want to provide you with a short version of my explanation. First, when there's an imaginable omnipotent figure called "God" to look up to, we do not tend to take life seriously. Everything, whether it's good or bad, can be explained as a "God's will," which removes all sorts of human's responsibility from the equation.

When things are good, it's due to God's will, and not to our ability to make good things happen. When things go bad, it's also due to God's will, and not because there is someone, a non-God human, who makes those bad things happen to us. Whatever happens happen because God wants it to happen.

This way of thinking alone is problematic, but for the great philosopher such as Friedrich Nietzsche, he sees through one layer deeper: Nietzsche believes that the idea of God's will is problematic precisely because the idea of the existence of God distracts us from reality. As Karl Marx later put it, "religion is opium for the masses," the idea of "God's will" has the potential of making us feel as though we are in the powerless position owing to our own lack of ability to be in a better position.

Imagining you have a harsh life; and at the moment you are about to explode, rebel, and protest against your employer who unfairly work your ass off and benefit from your labor without paying you adequately, your employer offers you an opium pipe to calm you down. By curiosity, you try smoking it, and almost immediately what dons upon you is the feeling of content -- that life isn't as bad as it seems, and that your employer are actually quite awesome in many ways.

The reason why you would feel that way has nothing to do with the sudden change of attitude because of your employer's kindness in offering you an insatiable taste of opium, but the chemical substances in the opium that give you the euphoric feelings. For Marx, religion is precisely doing that to people. It makes us feel sleepy, drowsy, and euphorically relaxed, to the point that we forget why we were offered the opium to smoke at the first place.

Marx disdains religions because he believes that the money that go into funding religion establishments and their monuments (such as churches) come from the rich -- precisely because they know that by keeping the poor in check by giving them something to look up to would make them slaves forever. Religions, to Marx, is the most cost effective way for the rich to keep the poor believing in the unfortunately life that they live.

Napoleon Bonaparte has a much more straightforward view on this, as he once said: Religion is excellent stuff for keeping common people quiet. Religion is what keeps the poor from murdering the rich. There you have it: Napoleon and Marx are on along the same line when it comes to religions.

Friedrich Nietzsche was never (and never deemed himself being) a social engineer as dealing with his own mind was already hard enough for him, so he never went as far as Napoleon and Marx in denouncing all forms of religiosity. This effect of religion makes us shy away from questioning why we are where we are and only take the difficulty in life as such. For an existentialist, to believe that there's such a thing as a "God's will" is to believe that there's no free will.

To have no free will is to make a choice to choose not to be -- since to be is to choose to believe in your own responsibility to carry on your life -- hence, to believe that God is alive is, by default, to choose not to live altogether. Second, God, especially the anthropomorphic one, has long been a "role model" for human beings. In particular, God provides the model for morality: God is good, and God is great.

But, as Nietzsche has written about in his 1887 book *On the Genealogy of Morals*, morality as such is not absolute, but socially and culturally constructed. In one of his famous examples, the idea of "to love your neighbors" is almost universally seen as "good," and mostly everyone would agree that whoever disagree is, by default, a "bad person." Nietzsche argues that this is a wrong way of thinking about morality, which has a long historical root in the teaching of the Christian faiths.

Good or evil depends on the goal of a particular community. For instance, quite often it is in the name of "goodness" to perform an act of atrocity to protect the immediate community (even patriotic, in cases). But is that evil? Or is it just acting to survival (aka evolutionism)? At the end of the day, both goodness and evilness are religious concepts because it is only the normative guidance provided by religion by which believers follow strictly.

Religious people do not have their own mental and moral space to analyze contextually and independently about what is good for them. Questions that arise includes: What and how much do we know about our neighbor, whom God tells us to love? Nietzsche goes so far as to say that not only should we not love our neighbors, but we should also be jealous of them if they're better off than we are. Why?

Because only through the jealousy in wanting to have what we do not have that we could push ourselves to be better. In addition, a more crucial question also arises: What does it mean to "love" strangers -- since by definition, a neighbors are not your relatives, and therefore not someone you would know very well? W ouldn't that be considered pretentious to love strangers? Nietzsche does not want us to lie -- neither should you want to do so anyway I believe.

In this sense, Nietzsche urges us to re-think how we come to see things as moral and immoral, and to come up with our own set of morality based on our own free will to be, to exist, and and to be responsible for our own actions. So, "God is dead," for Nietzsche, in my opinion doesn't have much to do with the rejection of the idea of religiosity as such.

Nietzsche, like Marx, may be denouncing the idea of religion on the conventional and conservative grounds that the idea of religion provides nothing but euphoric illusion, but the message that Nietzsche, especially, is trying to send is much more conceptual: to see things as they are, and not as they appear through the reflection on a certain religious mirror. At the end of the day, to refuse the idea of religiosity outright is also killing free will. Finally, let me also apologize for my long absence.

Since I came back from Japan on X'Mas Day, I had been busy working on my actual writings (i.e., my doctoral dissertation) with my adviser, as well as my very good friend from my hometown, who happened to be in town at the same time (both of whom somewhat demanded my full attention, which I'd like to give to them anyway) for the past two weeks; hence, although I had so many ideas about what I'd like to write, I did not have the time to sit down

and write anything.

Here're some of the ideas that I had during the last two weeks: My new year's resolution.

The idea of this post is divided into two parts: First, on the things I -- and we all -- can do, and should do to live better, such as drink more coffee (I am not kidding; it's not been proven that coffee, which has long been used in many parts of the world as medicinal substances, is good for you), eat spicy food, consume red wine moderately, and so on; and, second, on what we might be able to do in order to see the world from a different angle, namely the angle that is not relying too much on the convention, such as, what if we do not have to believe that there's a role into which we are born?

What if there's no specific set of belief that is set in stone to be true universally and timelessly? Since they have to do, by and large, with our existing beliefs, the ideas of my new year's resolution that belong to the second set is, almost by default, more difficult to follow than those in the first set. On Sex: Part III.

Since the last three posts on this topic have been receiving a large number of visitors, I have a feeling that I should try to satisfy the demand of my dear readers by providing the last post in the trilogy, which will be on the "ideal society" that I believe would promote both the equality and dignity between the men and the women. I want to write about a society in which both men and women are dignified beings.

As Sigmund Freud might have argued (but still wouldn't be as forceful as what I aim to write), the first thing to achieve is to getting rid of all forms and kinds of sex taboo, which will, almost instantly, put both men and women at the same playing field. In the similar fashion to the experimental psychologist Steven Pinker's *How the Mind Works*, my ideas for this ideal society are based on both the evolutionary as well as cultural understanding of sexual and gender dynamic.

As Pinker argues in *How the Mind Works*, some aspects of evolution can explain why men hold the power to decide what women should do. But, no, it's not the evolution as such: It's not that evolution makes men stronger and therefore could wield more power.

Quite the opposite, in fact, it's that evolution tends to force men who have certain amount of chemical substances in their brains to want and desire to possess certain things (i.e., the genetic continuity of their DNA), and to be willing to sacrifice their lives for a number of things (i.e., wars) -- all of which have to do with the desire to reproduce and protect their right to do so for the survival for the human species.

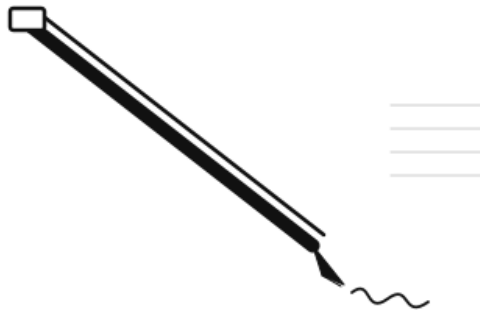
Based on the statistics and economic underpinning of the unbalanced availability of reproductive resources (e.g., there, in general, are more women than men in the world in general), it seems plausible that the only function of men in reproductivity is providing a spoon full of semen, and the women could just take over the rest from there. For what both Freud and Pinker have to say about sexuality and the possible origins of gender inequality, I have a feeling that I could work out a blueprint for an ideal society.

So, hang in there, I'll write this eventually (hopefully in the next few days!)

DAY 53

Writing by the Yangtze

Sun, 17 Aug 2025 00:00:00 +0000



I KNOW, I KNOW, I haven't written anything since January. In fact, I haven't written anything since the beginning of January. So, it's been more than a month now that this blog has been dormant. That's not my intention at all. Some of you might even be wondering, "Is Non going to get the 100th day as he has planned?" Well, once and for all, I have never doubt that I'll eventually get to the 100th day. I set the goal in order to achieve it.

What explains why I haven't been more active lately is the fact that, also lately, I have encountered a series of unfortunate events which show the dark side of human beings: People who I used to trust threw me under the bus with a false accusation, an insecure and opportunistic work colleague who weren't interested in putting her jealousy of my teaching skills into a good use tried to make me her subordinate using, also, another false accusation, and students for whom I have been working my ass off did not seem to appreciate what I did for them.

All of these unfortunate events came all at once just about when the Spring Festival was arriving. I, however, was lucky, though, to have been given a great book by my mother. The book was *Mediations* by the Great Marcus Arelius. At some point I will talk about this book at length but for now I have to say that it is the most single influential book I have read so far. The prose

is clean and clear, and the ideas are vivid.

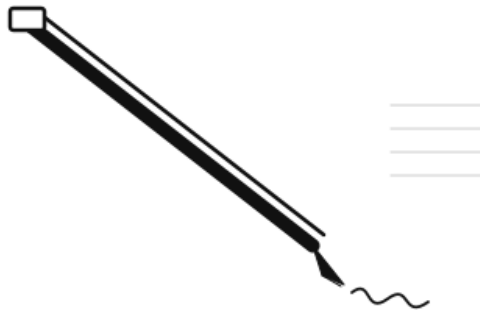
Marcus Aurelius was a lifelong stoic who believed that a simple life is the life that brings joy. Anything extra brings complication, and unnecessary complexities that would end up making our life more disturbing. So, I have been reading this book for the past few days and I have come up with many short and clear thoughts in the fashion of this great book. Here, I'd like to share all of them (many more to come in the next days). So, no, I haven't stopped writing.

I am just experimenting with a different way of writing: something short, concise, and true. Happy Chinese New Year. May everyone be kind to one another.

DAY 54

Giving up the Urban Life

Mon, 18 Aug 2025 00:00:00 +0000



THIS MIGHT SOUND LIKE ME rambling, but as the Spring Festival (Chinese New Year) is about to depart, and the people are coming back to the city again, I want to write about how much I like Shanghai when it's so empty like this when the memory and feeling of it being empty are still fresh in my mind.

In the past week, the city was empty owing to the migrants, whose population constitutes almost half of the city's population, returning home to be with their families over the course of one-week annual holiday known as chunjie or Spring Festival -- better known in English as the Chinese New Year.

Thanks to the emptiness of the city, I was able to sit down and think about my love-hate relationship with the city, as it was reaching its limit as I probed inside of my own head: Cities are full of crappy people. Selfish people. When they don't like each other, instead of talking it out between them, they instead hire two lawyers, involved law enforcement, get all kinds of resources and time to be used at their expenses.

In a rural area where I used to live, we just met and talked it out, and that's done. In fact, there's nothing new about my love-hate relationship with the city, especially Shanghai.

I have, for quite a while now, begun to feel that Shanghai has been gradually and consistently changing me into someone who I am not — by way of changing other people around me to pressure me, both directly and indirectly, into accepting the fact that in order to survive here, I must take part in the larger system as a member of a counterproductive community where the sense of community is defined by material reciprocity, rather than respect, sympathy, and the true unity under the basic idea of right and equality.

This is unhealthy on all fronts. I think it's Shanghai is the kind of city that attracts these kinds of people. I'd be unfair that I feel this way because Shanghai's today is packed of people who need to make ends meet therefore they need to put themselves and their families before other things. Shanghai was, in fact, like this too in early 20th century when Shanghai was dubbed "Paris of the Orient." It's a bad land where bad people could do unimaginable things to advance their own interest.

So, as I mentioned in my last post, I'd decided to leave town to go to Chongming Island, an rural island north of Shanghai. I cycled 10 miles to get to the boat pier, and took a 45-minute-long boat ride to get to the island, and then another 30 miles of cycling to a house and a farm of a friend of a friend who lived on the island. I didn't think I could survive there at first because the lack of basic amenities, say, a normal toilet!

(the last time I used squatting toilet was when I was 10). Also, there's no heating whatsoever there, and the weather was cold. Because it's in the middle of nothing except plants, the wind blew through the vast and flat landscape very easily. Every time the cold breeze touched my skin, I felt as though my bones were decaying. It's that cold.

I thought it was the way for me to reconnect with my rural nature (the place where I grew up in the northeastern part of Thailand was just like this island). It's my colleague Leo (a PhD student working on organic farming movements and consumption at the University of London) who took me there first last year since many of his informants were farmers growing organic produce.

Being away from the city of Shanghai that I loathed, I felt as though I was able to communicate with myself more efficiently.

The weather was cold, again, but the people's hearts were extremely warm. I was touched by the hospitality. I slept in a metallic cabin that the farmer who hosted me that night bought second-hand to use as housing for herself and for her guests. There's a small little house there but because the heating system was non-existence, she only used that building to store her produce, and to accommodate the kitchen, toilet and shower room, but nobody stayed there at night.

In addition to being fed by Leo's friend, I was also being fed by a friend of Leo's friend, a villager who worked with Leo's friend in the farm. He fed me a large meal (after many meals that I hitherto was fed with, as we're in the celebrating mode), and there I recalled a conversation with my PhD advisor about the alliance versus the descent theory.

The former, the alliance theory, argues that people tend to "marry out" in order to create alliances among groups in order to share resources, knowledge, and good genes. The proponents of this theory believe that the most remarkable evidence of this idea is the process called "bride exchange," as the name entails, women are the protocol through which the process of allying operates. In Chinese society, in particular, women are married out for the same reason, if the cultural phenomenon is to be explained by this theory.

The descent theory, on the other hand, argues that people tend to "marry in" because that's the only way to keep the property intact, and scarce resources in check. Of course we all know about incest taboo for which the descent theory also has an explanation: there is a rule about who can marry each other. Obviously direct siblings would not marry one another, but cross-cousin marriage is both acceptable and quite popular. It's all about protecting the property. I wholeheartedly believe now that the alliance theory makes more sense.

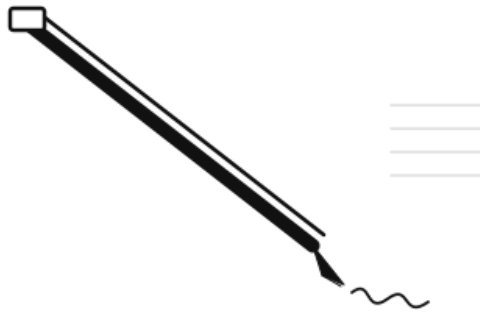
It is simply because, after having been fed by strangers who had nothing to do with me and had nothing to gain from feeding me, we simple human beings deep down want to spread our empathy to those who are not necessarily members of the same lineage group. The villagers wouldn't let me stop eating and drinking. I passed out many times in those three days. When I got up, I was fed with more food, and more alcohol.

I got to hang out and treated as a member of many families that I visited, including those who I met for the first time. I didn't want to return to the city. In fact, I have been enjoying labor work lately. I don't know if the urban work is something that suits me. I know that I should not romanticize this pastoral vignette, but I do think that a simple life is what, not only I but, all of us should desire.

DAY 55

On Writing Well

Tue, 19 Aug 2025 00:00:00 +0000



THANKS TO THE RESPONSES FROM the students at the Global Studies Program at Thammasat University in Bangkok where I had the honor of giving a talk on the topic All About Writing (and the Art of Doing it Well), I had the opportunity to sit down and write about how I think makes me want to write well (although this does not, in any way, imply that I write well). Well, I think my writing is not bad.

Well, I should not contradict myself especially after that I posted my opinion on why I think modesty is bad for the society in general. Well, fine, I think I do write well, and here are some of the tips I want to share with you. Writing is good for you. It's good for your brain, as it helps you organize your thoughts and therefore your life.

Writing is good for your mental health because it helps you to rethink the happenstances in your life, giving you a second chance to appreciate every moment of it. There are many research results that show that people who write regular tend to be much more satisfied with their lives than people who do not write (and you can find them in some of my earlier posts in which I write about why I write).

Writing is also good for your career, as it helps you to set your goals straight whether that be your short-term or long-term goals. Make no mistake about it: those who write down their goals have a much higher chance of accomplishing those goals than people who don't; and the reason for which is simple, writing down your goals not only remind you of what you should do, but it also helps keeping you on track.

Think about how many times in the past that you'd forgotten to get something done -- simply because you'd forgotten it. There are so many benefits to writing. Long story short: Writing is good for you, so start writing! Do it everyday and make it your habit! In this post, I'll keep it short by using original questions that the students had sent me as the prompts (with slight modifications to some of them to make them ready comprehensibly). How to be inspired to write?

Especially when you are completely blocked and halted The trick is to get to the keyboard and start typing — and try not to hit that demonic button called "backspace." Just keep typing. Some experts said that it's easier to get going when writing with your hand, rather than using the keyboard, and if this is the case for you, hit the notebook with your pencil instead.

Personally, I think the main problem is not that we don't have anything about which to write, but the fear that what we write might not be as interesting as we would like it to be. Come on. We'd never know that anyway. Even some of the greatest writers of all time sometimes aren't sure about whether or not what they're writing about would turn into anything good.

Yet, the fact that matter is that it's precisely because they don't know whether or not what they're writing about would turn into anything good is actually what gives them the pressure-free attitude to focus their attention on the writing itself, and not the fear that surrounds it, that makes them great writers. This kind of fear is unproductive. We wouldn't know whether what we write would be useful or not until we have written it down, would we?

As Non has studied in many top university, I am curious about what mottoes does he apply in his routine that keeps him moving forward to become a successful and inspiring person? I have a lot of mottoes, but most of them don't have anything to do with "success" as such — they are almost all about morality and the meanings of life. The pivotal moment in my life was when my father suddenly passed away in 2010, which changed everything for me.

I used to be a counterproductively individualistic, self-preserved, selfish, and absurdly cruel being. The irony was that I wasn't even mildly successful then neither, yet I thought I was because of my counterproductive egotism. Simply put, I didn't care about any one else, but myself. It's until my father, who I never thought would leave me — at least not when he's just 60 — passed away that I eventually woke up and started to think much more carefully about the meaning of it all.

Suddenly, I realized that the meaning of it all has nothing to do with what other people think, especially what they would like to think for me as "markers of success"; and it was then, perhaps, which was the moment I suddenly realized I had lived someone else's life all along. That was the time when I began to think about what made me happy, and the answer was clear: I was happy every time when I was told that what I did made other people happy.

Of course, as many of you perhaps already know, I have been sharing some of the thoughts that keep me going on my blog. How can we detect what is the strongest argument among other? And which sorts of evidence would be considered strong enough to support the respective argument? When considering what is the best argument to make, think of two factors: the source of knowledge, and the premise on which you are making your argument.

You will be likely to fail argumentatively if the source of knowledge lacks credibility. And we have talked about the importance of premise — pick the premise that is relevant to your argument. For instance, nobody in their right mind is going to make an argument about the scientific importance of gravity

wave (which is a hot topic right now) based on a superstitious notion of a particular religious premise, right? What is a useful habit to know in order to avoid mistakes in academic writing?

To always think critically and never take anything at face value; and to believe wholeheartedly that a good question doesn't have to be complicated, but simple — all you have to do is to look at the problem from a different angle. Do you find any differences between writing essay in Thai and English? Is there any linguistic aspect by which one language to be, either simpler or more difficultly, expressed compared to the other one? In terms of grammar, English is much harder because of the tenses.

The writer has to keep in mind always the tense which he/she is writing in, which is not easy because it's not always the case that which is clear. On the other hand, Thai is also hard because of the linguistic nuances concerning social hierarchy and honorifics. I have yet to write anything in Thai for the past decade and I have a feeling that it'd be very difficult for me to do it well, although I always ready for the challenge!

What do you do when you get what they called "writer's block?" Sometimes I just cannot think of what to say and get stuck. Same answer as in question#1. I am interested in writing a blogs also. Is there any recommendations you have for people who are new to this that will help make the starting process easier? To have a theme. What would your blog be about? Is it going to be about your life, your thought, your photos, etc?

After the theme is set, then all to have to do is to start writing it. Make it interesting! Think of the kind of blog that you yourself like to read. What makes them so interesting? A lot photos? (nobody wants to read a lot of texts, right?) or maybe a lot of casual informal language? Whatever that be, you may want to start your blog by assimilating the style of the blog that you like.

Be consistent as if millions of people are following you and waiting to read your blog (although in reality only a handful are). Once you have gained the

right momentum you won't ever slip back to the state of dormancy again. How do you decide on what you want to write about? I have many ideas and questions I like to explore, but sometimes I am not sure if it is really the right topic. There's no right or wrong, right?

Unless you are given a prompt, e.g., as in your exam, then whatever you write is yours and yours alone. I like to read all kinds of things (from books to magazines, to Facebook posts, to online catalogs, to whatever whatever) and usually I spend a lot of time everyday doing nothing but observe and listen to other people talking on the street and so on (am I weird?:) and these are usually the sources of what I want to try to put into words (i.e., essay).

Often, I write about what I want to try to understand. Again, you'll see what I mean in my blog:-) What do you do if you started writing something, and halfway through, you'd decided that which is not what you really want to address? If that happens to me, should I stop and find something else I rather write about or continue even if i lost the drive for this question? Yes, and no. It depends on what kinds of writing you're doing.

If you're being asked to write something very specific, then it might be useful to stop for a moment, have a cup of coffee (or a glass of wine — but never a mug of beer) and think about what you might better and more efficiently address the question about which you are writing. On the other hand, if it's an expository writing, the technique is to keep going.

You'll go in loops from time to time but you'll get back to a certain point where your thoughts and ideas usually lace together. So, be patience. Let it sit a few days and go back to it again. What should I do for the process of shifting my novel-style writing to academic writing?

The audience for academic writing won't be someone who share with you your subjectivity (e.g., your close friends), thus you'd want to be clearer in your expression, which usually means 1) more formal in narration; 2) more rigorous in delineation, and, last but not least; 3) more mindful of the readers in making your assumption about what you think they might or might not

know already. What is the most important part of the essay? The question, and how you answer it:-) How to write great introduction and conclusion?

What do you mean by "get to the point as fast as possible?" How many sentence into the introduction should the main point be stated? What tips do you have to make sure that we have a hook or a catchy phrase in the beginning of any writing to make sure the reader is interested in the piece and continues reading? Come on, really? You're asking me "how to," after all those tips in the lecture. Alright. Fine.

A great introduction has to follow the "Herzfeld's rule" [or the rule that states that whatever you have to say you'd need to say in the most concise, succinct, and comprehensively way in the least amount of time possible otherwise someone as important as Professor Michael Herzfeld (who is probably one of the world's most productive writer) would not have the patience to listen to you]. It has to be short and punchy. It has to be able to grab the attention of the audience instantly.

Usually, a question takes the reader right where they should be. Use a rhetorical question if you have to. Use a well-know quote, or idiom, or set phrase if you think it'd to the job. The conclusion shouldn't be a repeating of what you have just written — it should provide a few bullet points of takeaways.

Why is it that after having majored in a subject like Anthropology and lived in Shanghai, he writes about "sex?" In addition to the fact that I love sex (surprise, surprise), it's due to my true belief in the idea that sex is the most beautiful thing ever. For those who haven't indulged yourself in my Sex Trilogy on this blog, I'd highly encourage that you'd give it a chance.

The truth is, after having spent so many years studying so many things, I have come to the conclusion that my lifelong journey that on the surface seems to be about searching for an objective truth through reason, is nothing but an excuse to find my own self trapped between the natural drive for a good sexual companionship and the societal expectation that sex must be

something more than animistic.

Isn't that so interesting that sex, cross-culturally, seems to be a subject that brings shame and embarrassment, when it is what we do, as human beings. Isn't that so interesting? An intro is a thesis of your argument but in the concluding sentences, it also reiterate the same argument. How do you create an ending sentence that differentiates from your intro sentence? Think of you giving your essay to President Obama, who would have only one minute to read your 20-page essay.

Of course he won't have the time and would probably flip through all those pages and jump right to your one paragraph conclusion. In the short conclusion, what do you think someone as important as he should want to take away from your essay? The answer to this question is how you'd write your conclusion. Finally, I want to share with you one book on writing that I hold dearly, and, I can see it with confidence that I believe these books can change your life too.

So, please take them seriously! It's Harvard cognitive psychologist (and also historian, philosopher, and so on) Steven Pinker's latest book *The Sense of Style: The Thinking Person's Guide to Writing in the 21st Century*. It's probably one of the best books on writing in the past decades if not the entire twentieth century.

The book is not a manual on how to write well in the strictest sense of the term (but there're portions of the book that are specifically about how to improve your writing) but a book that tells you why writing we tend to think that writing well is difficult. Dr. Pinker believes that we believe that writing has to be difficult because there're so many people out there who are watching you and waiting for you to make mistake. This is something that I could resonate with very well.

When I was younger and learning to write, I was afraid of writing even a short passage. Why? Because my teacher would find something wrong in that passage, and then I would be punished for making it! (Damn it). Well, lo and

behold, the world of English language is no different from that, argues Dr. Pinker. In *The Sense of Style*, Dr.

Pinker explains why the standards on which the notion of writing well rest is not always as objective as we would think through the history of how words get picked to be added into a dictionary by its editors, and how a set phrase, a neologism, and expression are socially created. I am sure that I'm not the only audience who was amazed by everything I read when I read it for the first time.

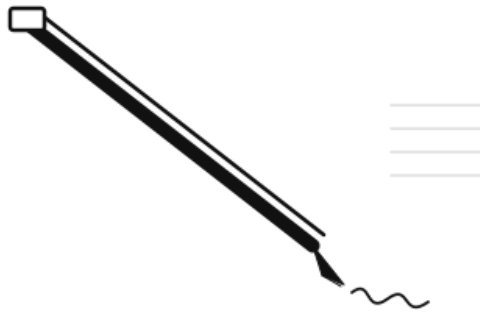
I was like, "what, it's that easy for a new meaning to be added into an existing word in a dictionary???" I always thought that whatever listed in the dictionary are fixed, objective, and rule-bound. Anyway, let me spoil the book no more. Hence, argues Dr. Pinker, writing well is all about how you'd like to put your thoughts into words, rather than how you'd follow what the "grammar police" of whom (Dr.

Pinker calls "the purists") would want us to do so in the style that if you do otherwise you wouldn't be let into the "gentlemen's club" of the English language.

DAY 56

New Year's Resolution

Wed, 20 Aug 2025 00:00:00 +0000



I WAS PLANNING TO WRITE this post more than a month ago, but somehow I totally forgot about it and did not have a chance to look at my little notebook where I put down quite clearly by hand "2016 New Year's Resolution -- Day 52." Well. I missed it by 4 days, since it's Day 56 today. But let me get to it anyway. Let me begin with a question: What's the difference between being a flip-flopper and someone who evolves and improves?

I have been thinking about this question quite intensely in the past few weeks, especially as I was watching the debates between the presidential hopefuls whether that be the Democrats and the Republicans. They're the same, in the way that almost everyone of the contenders has been attacked for being a "flip-flopper." So, I looked up the meaning in the most trusted source of knowledge on the planet called Urban Dictionary, and this was what I got: A flip-flopper is someone who goes back and fourth.

For instance, this person could one day be someone's friend and the next day this person is not. I was kidding, of course, about how I see Urban Dictionary as the most trusted source (although I use it regularly because I always want to connect with the younger people).

So, I also looked up Oxford English Dictionary, and what I got was much simpler but extremely well crafted and to the point: "make an abrupt reversal of policy." So, it seems to be the case that in politics, people do hold dear the notion of consistency. If you'd happened to believe in something, you'd have to stick to it until the very end of your political life. It seems, though rather extreme, fair enough. That said, something hit me hard when I was in the shower the other day.

So, does this mean if you don't want to be a flip-flopper, you'd then have to stick to a certain belief even though you've become smarter and hence know that which isn't the case anymore? For example, I once believed that coffee is bad for you because it's what "only adults drank" to keep them going, alert, and on their feet. There had gotten to be something malignant in coffee that would do something like that to people.

Yet, one day in 2010, I learned from an academic journal on a recent research on the benefits of coffee that in fact coffee is good for you -- and in fact, it's so good that everyone should drink it often: the more the better.

I thought to myself then, "oh, wow, this is great, so what I once misleadingly believed in then was just something that I happened to believe in because I didn't have the scientific knowledge that wasn't available hitherto." So, I turned around 360 degrees at that very moment. Since then have become a coffee drinker who not only loves to drink coffee, but also to learn more about coffee cultures in and coffee beans from different places as well as to become an amateur in the world of coffee-making.

Am I a flip-flopper? I might be because I, by definition, make an abrupt reversal of my decision to believe in something. Right? But is it bad for me, and/or for the society? Well, by definition always, someone has told me that you would have to be able to flip back to the original position also with the same intensity of abruptness to be considered a serious flip-flopper. Let's leave that discussion for another time.

The point of all of this is to say that we are all flip-floppers in some ways. If we aren't, we probably would not have survived as a species all this long (I mean thousands of years). We would have extincted from the face of the earth if we only stuck to something that we happen to believe in because we didn't have any information to believe otherwise, and still did so even if we have a proof that believing would be better.

So, this new year's resolution is all about me being a flip-flopper. I have learned over the years what is good and what is bad for me and for the society; hence, I have decided to make a systematic change in the way I think about my way of life.

If you don't have time to go through the list below, here's the short version of it backed by research: In *6 Things That Determine How Long You'll Live*, the researchers then scored the participants on six behavior measures: Smoking, alcohol use, dietary behavior, physical inactivity, sedentary behavior and sleep. Yes, so, don't smoke, only consume alcohol moderately (a little bit is good for you actually but too much will kill you), do eat healthily, do exercise, do not sit down too much, and do not deprive yourself from sleep.

For the long version, here we go: I will get more sleep -- in particular more "deep sleep" because, as research has shown, sleep is good for you and sleep deprivation not only can make you less efficient at work and at life, but can also actually kill you as it could slowly increase the chance of you getting Alzheimer. Scary, right? So, do go sleep, guys.

So far, I have been sleeping about 6-8 hours a day (with only less than 1/3 of that which is the deep sleep phrase) -- in fact, the best way to sleep is to sleep naked!; I will drink more coffee; I will monitor my alcohol consumption.

I will not stop drinking completely because as Harvard has shown moderate drinking "both protects against cardiovascular disease and helps guide the development of an embryo's spinal cord, has equally important jobs later in life." Plus, as a recent research has shown, drinking is a great way to de-stress yourself and socialize with other people, getting to know people who would

want to make your life more meaningful!; I will eat more organic produce. In the past year, I have lost about 10 pounds from only eating healthy organic food.

I think it's clear that food that were organically produced (without using synthetic fertilizers, herbicides and pesticides) is good for you; I will learn more about positive psychology.

I don't know what have gotten into me recently, but I have become much more aware of how my mind could be shaped by reading academic papers about positive psychology, such as why keeping my house tidy is good for my mental health, why writing is good for my brain, why exercising in the morning is great and why checking emails after getting up is a no-no. Whatever it is, I believe that I owe my interest in psychology to two authors: Drs Steven Pinker and Jonathan Haidt.

So thank you!; I will write down my daily goals every day. It's clear, as I have written and spoken elsewhere, that writing down goals that one would like to set for oneself regularly could increase the chance of the goals becoming true. Writing is like magic. It has so many great benefits.

Let me summarize other thinker's words: Writing down what you want will force you to clarify what you want, motivate you to take action, provide a filter for other opportunities, help you overcome resistance, and finally writing will enable you to see—and celebrate—your progress (thank you, positive psychology!); I will travel more. Although every time I travel I lose something (I mean, objects -- during my last trip in Japan I lost my father's fountain pen; crying, crying), but at the same time I also learn more about myself.

There's a magic in being in an unfamiliar place and surrounded by strangers. This kind of situation forces me to think about who I am. In a place where nobody knows me, and usually can't communicate with me because of the language barrier, I often have to let my quality from within shine in order to survive.

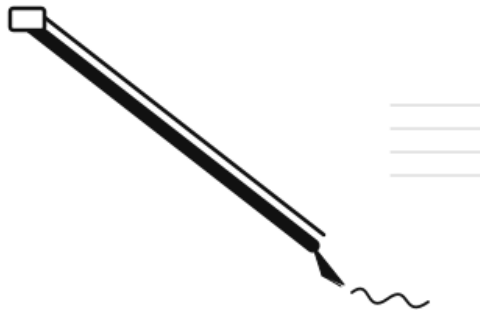
That's the trick and that's what I'd love to have more time and chance to explore; I will bike more (duh...); I will give more, and talk less; I will walk and exercise more (now that I have a pedometer of which I set 10,000 steps a day my goal) and sit less; I will continue to believe that people are naturally good, so that I continue to be a human being. That's it.

I hope to be able to accomplish them (most people give up their resolutions within the first two months). I won't!

DAY 57

On the Economy of Words

Thu, 21 Aug 2025 00:00:00 +0000



LATELY, I HAVE BEEN WRITING many short aphorisms. Almost everyday, in fact, as though my brain can't stop thinking about what makes life worth living. The more I read, the more I write. The more I experience, the more I come up with thoughts that speak to my very essence as a human being about what it means to be born into the world. Am I a philosopher? Well, I would like to think that I am. Lately I have been bombarded with words that don't convey any meanings.

These words are sometimes rhetorical, sometimes patronizing, and sometimes, simply, mindless. I always hold closest to heart an admiration for people who would express something so true using the least amount of words. Yes, we are talking about writers like Hemmingway and Dickens, and a scholar like Steven Pinker (who is now, by the way, my role model for good writing). So, lately, I have been experimenting with a new kind of writing.

So, for those who have been asking me about my absence from blog writing, yes, I have not been writing my blog at all because I have been investing my time in doing something else slightly different, that which is writing aphorisms: a short phrase that expresses a true or wise idea. It's much easier than done writing aphorisms. Before I started doing it I did not think that it would be so hard. "How hard could it be, compared to writing a long blog

post?" Well.

Turns out it's much harder because for an aphorism to have a true effect on the reader's mind it has to be precise, concise, and, most importantly, poetic. Yes, it's important that either the parallel sentence structure is absolute parallel; even better, with a part of parts of the sentence containing words that rhyme. For instance: I hope this aphorisms bring the point home. Writing these are hard because it's not easy to get it right in one go.

In fact, usually writing one of these takes me a few minutes. Sometimes I stop half way because I cannot be satisfied with what I see.

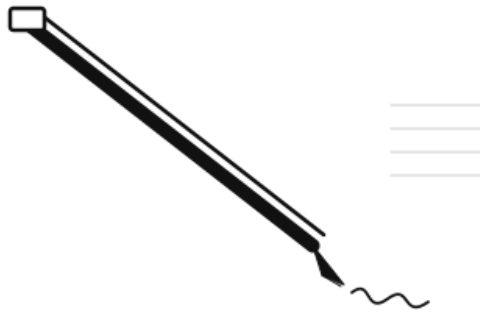
It would be great if there is a medium on which I could show how I come up with these aphorisms: to capture what I have been trying to do, which is, usually I would just start to type as soon as a good idea comes to mine, and then I would change my mind, which would mean that I would be deleting words and then typing and retyping them again and again.

And then I would delete more words and then modify the sentence until I have the "truest" prose that satisfy me both philosophically and linguistically. Here's another one: Now, you get the point. I believe in the economy of words. I want to speak less, write less, and mean more. I want this way to thinking -- the less is the more -- to be my way of life. So, let me share some of them with you in this post.

DAY 58

On the Experience of Writing about Morality

Fri, 22 Aug 2025 00:00:00 +0000



I HAVE BEEN ASKED, A few times, about my experience of writing about morality. In my last post, I have laid out the blueprint of my reasoning for moving from writing a longer blog post to a shorter series of aphorisms, or, as defined by a dictionary, a concise statement of a scientific principle. Typically by an ancient classical author, aphorisms are a series of words laid out to bring home the point that are hardly contestable.

I have been enjoying doing it for about three months now and I am inclined now to move () to the next experiment: the haiku or a traditional form of Japanese poetry, consisting of just 3 lines. I, however, will leave that to the next post. For this post, I'd like to write, shortly, about my experience of writing aphorisms and receiving comments regarding them. I don't think that my words and thoughts are that great. I think they are true but they are still not perfect.

All I hope is that they may be useful to some people; that which would already make my day. I once had a friend, with whom I hung out a lot until one day I found out about our difference when she said to me: I don't think anything that we do could make the world a better place; I don't even think

that the world will be a better place no matter how hard we'd try. So, I do what I do just to survive, have a comfortable life.

It doesn't matter if other people don't. I decided to walk away from our friendship on the spot, and I felt as though I had a good reason to do so. The world won't be a better place over night, but I believe that in everything that I do, for everything step that I take, I am moving the world closer to the betterment for all. I can't be a friend of someone who doesn't believe in this very thing that I believe in.

Ok, let's get to business: The comments I have received have given me a few lessons: Lesson One: There are people who have their very own problems -- their counterproductive sense of pride -- and won't open to you no matter how hard you'd try to open them up to help them.

The reason for which may have to do with their own sense of insecurity -- in fact, it's usually just about their own sense of security, which usually leads to the lack of self-respect (although they wouldn't see it that way). For these people, they can be helped, but not through powerful words, but through powerful medications. Through the consumption of prescribed medications, these people may be able to get through their own counterproductive sense of pride to receive help and support for those who love and care about them.

Described, sort of, clearly in this meme: Less Two: There is so much your words can help others. Sometimes the only reason why you can't help them is because you simply do not have the access to their subjectivity. Described in this meme. Lesson Three: There are people who always see anything that other people would say to them as different from what they would have in mind, even if that which is not the case.

These people have the same problem with those from whom I have learned in Lesson One. These people will not accept even a paraphrasing of their words even if such paraphrasing would make their words convey meanings to the ears of the audience with better grace and clarity. There are two reasons for these people to act the way that they do. First, they do not like you -- which

is often because they see you as a threat to their authority.

In this case, it's natural for them to reject your words even though what you were trying to do was to help them. They will reject everything you say because they aren't hearing you, but only hearing their own sense of insecurity telling them that if they'd let other say things that they would like to say better than they could possibly do so they would lose face and sense of authority. These people are easy to detect.

Just last week, I had this silly encounter: Mark (pseudonym): I have just read this book by Jacques Derrida again and I think that what he means in his work is: X is an expressive Y and Y is Derridian version of Z; and because Z and also the form of A; I think X and A is the same thing. [Note: these X, Y, Z, and A are just being represented here as arbitrary symbols of philosophical ideas that we were discussing at the same.

I have also simplified what this person said to disguise the typos and grammatical mistakes that this person had made throughout his philosophical yet unsyntagmatic locution] Non: Wait a minute, just because some aspects of X is the same as Y doesn't mean that you could make the leap in your argument that Y and is the same, let alone saying that then Z and A are synonymous. Right? Are you saying, instead, that X, Y, Z, and A have something in common?

Mark: Non, you go to hell and go fuck yourself. You don't even have a PhD. You don't have anything to prove that you know more than I do. My argument is logical because I have a PhD in philosophy [from a local university in the Philippines] so I know EVERYTHING ABOUT PHILOSOPHY. PERIOD. Second, they are being possessed by, what I would like to call, the curse of egotism.

These people always want their voice to be heard the way they want to because they want their uniqueness to be seen, their irreplaceability to be perceived, and their existence to be praised. There is no way to help them, but to leave them alone. I always leave them alone. However, there is a way to

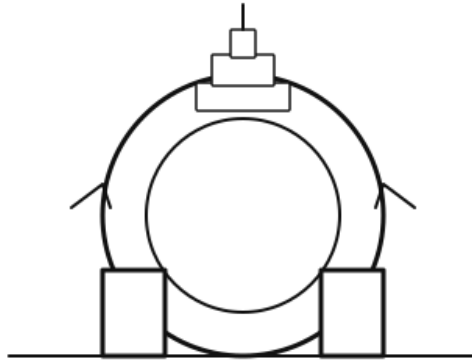
help yourself to not being like these people.

Do constantly check yourself whether or not you have become like these people, and don't give up on making sure that you always set a goal to learn more today than yesterday -- from everyone and everything. And maybe the way to let that go is this: Now, here're a few more I have been thinking about lately.

DAY 59

What Brought Me to China

Sat, 23 Aug 2025 00:00:00 +0000



HOW DID A THAI NATIONAL attending a university in the US end up spending three-third of his life, and counting, conducting research on China? I do not remember how many times I had answered this question. Again and again -- almost every time I gave a lecture, talk, tour about China -- at least one of the audience, or sometimes my colleague, would ask me this question. The short answer, as dull as anyone could probably guess, is that from an architectural perspective China is interesting.

The "full version" of this answer, however, could only begin with the Tsinghua-MIT Beijing Studio that I, almost by accident, took part in 2006. Ten years after the Studio, in 2016, I am getting my PhD in anthropology with the focus on Chinese society. How did all of this happen?

Even though I came from an ethnic Chinese background, growing up in Thailand to parents who had to suppress their culture in the face of strong anti-Chinese sentiment led me to have very little knowledge (let alone interest) in anything related to China. So, it was quite by accident that I stumbled upon the Tsinghua-MIT Beijing Urban Design Studio, and – looking back – incredibly surprising to me that I would encounter something there that would ignite a lifelong passion.

A trip with 20 other colleagues from MIT in 2006 was the trip where I discovered the deeper meaning of urbanism, which not only changed the way I saw the role of architecture in society, but would also inspire me to write an entire Master's thesis on the subject, get a second and third Master's in Chinese Studies and Anthropology of China, learn Mandarin Chinese, and eventually get a doctorate in Anthropology. This was the trip that started me on the track to become a scholar on Chinese society.

One year before the Studio, the summer of 2005, I just arrived in Cambridge as a Fulbright scholar from Thailand. My goal in traveling half way around the world from a warm tropic to a strangely cold place in the east coast of the US was to obtain a master's degree in History, Theory, and Criticism of art and architecture (HTC) from MIT.

HTC was (and still is, I believe) a highly specialized field of theoretical study, which many of my colleagues in the design section of MIT School of Architecture saw it as something farthest away possible from any real world's implication of architecture. Owing to my reputation in freehand architectural drawing -- and my ethnic Chinese background -- my colleagues would from time to time asked me about my interest in architectural design, and China.

My answer to them was always "no." At the beginning I took their question rather offensively: "Just because English isn't my native language doesn't mean I won't be able to read theoretical stuff; and, worse, just because I look Chinese doesn't mean I should be studying China!" I didn't share with them, though, how unappreciative I was regarding their comments.

Looking back, it must have been because I was trained in such a technical way back in Thailand, so when I had the chance to get out of Thailand my mind was occupied by something else completely. It wasn't the practical design that drew me to MIT. It wouldn't make sense for someone who did not like what he studied hitherto to travel half way around the world, leaving his parents and friends to an unfamiliar place, to study what he did not even like.

I could have easily learned practical design back home in Thailand, or somewhere in Asia where I came from. It's the critical studies of abstract ideas that drew me to MIT. To be precise, I was attracted to MIT by the scholarship of one man, Prof. Stanford Anderson (1934 - 2016), who later on became my adviser, mentor, colleagues, and friend.

Stan, who just passed away in January, hadn't written much, but his career as an educator had spanned five decades, and he himself had single-handedly educated almost every single one of respected architectural theorists in America and beyond. I wanted to study with him, and that's the reason why I applied to become a Fulbright scholar. When I was awarded the scholarship, I didn't even have my eye on any other school and program except MIT.

Of course, I knew how far removed the western critical theory paradigm was from reality, and it was precisely this aloofness that was attractive to me: I was looking up to it as the "model" for architectural thinking. Almost by accident, a classmate thought that we should check out the session introducing the Tsinghua-MIT Beijing Studio to the potential student participants.

As soon as I heard that this Studio was to be a traveling studio in which participants had to travel to China in group, I thought to myself that there's no way I would be interested in it! That said, remembering vividly, I just really needed a break from reading boring piles of books I had to read to prepare for my pro-seminar in art theory (and didn't have anything else to do). So I tagged along.

Back then, all events that would gather more than 20 students took place on the 4th floor of the building near the 77 Massachusetts Avenue dome where our school was located. There, I was surprisingly captivated by the briefings of the Studio by Professors Jan Wampler and Dennis Frenchman, the two professors who would be leading the Studio in China in the summer of 2006.

Images after images of the "non-postcard Beijing" — of dilapidating hutongs, huge roads and highways under which lay densely populated housing, and

massive urban projects — gave me a wake-up call and brought me back to reality. I had never seen any of these before. I thought Beijing was all about the glamorous Forbidden City (and that's it!).

The project proposed to the potential participants to tackle that year was a real urban challenge — an urban design of a complex and a transit node for the public in a globalizing city that was to host the Olympics. I thought I was at MIT for high theory, but in fact what excited me the most was this very idea of building for the public, and affordable housing. Hence, I'd decided to apply for it.

Despite the fact that I didn't have anything related to design to show to the selection committee, I was selected to take part in the Studio, and as the saying goes, the rest is history. Arriving in Shanghai for the first time in the summer of 2006 for the Studio, I felt as though I was someone who was born a hundred year ago, frozen in a time capsule, and one day awakened to face reality.

That was because I really didn't know much about Shanghai apart from the famous TV Series Shanghai Grand () that I had watched when I was a child, and a few books that Tess Johnston had written about Shanghainese architecture that I had previewed in preparation for my trip to China. Traveling on the elevated highway connecting the newly built airport in the southeast of the city to the sophisticated waterfront representing the semi-colonial Shanghai, I was amazed by basically everything I saw.

From the vast difference between the countryside where the airport was, and the urban center where neon light kept the city busy 24-7. In addition, the urban symbolism made the city appear grandiose but also difficult to read: I felt as though I was in a dreamland where everything is embellished for visual pleasure. Although I was not immediately interested in Shanghai, but my interest in the city grew the deeper I probed. The Studio introduced me to China, a place I never thought I'd be interested in going.

Then I discovered the lilong: a unique housing typology based on western-styled low-rise row houses built in the concession areas during the Treaty Port period. Every Shanghainese who lived in Shanghai before the Economic Reform and Opening Up Era of the 1980s-90s has memories of the lilong. Since that time, however, more than two thirds of this typology have been demolished to make way for the now ubiquitous high-rise.

Noting how the lilong provided a dense residential fabric with a sense of neighborhood community, I took interest in it immediately, and, given the programmatic requirements of our Beijing site, found the lilong worth exploring as potential starting point.

Through the course of developing the Beijing site, I found many of the features of the lilong highly adaptable – its mixed-use perimeter spaces provided a basis for meeting points in the community, and its alleyway mentality created a fabric encouraging exploration for visitors and a sense of an "urban village" for residents.

In the end, our project was well received, but finishing the Studio left me wanting to discover more about this unique type of housing that reflected a Chinese city already beginning globalization in the early parts of the 19th century. Traveling in-group by a slow overnight train from Shanghai to Beijing, we arrived in the capital city that had yet to be upgraded for the Olympics.

Ironically, the first meal we had was not authentic Chinese food but McDonald's, which seemed to excite our local host as we all thought they must have had in mind "our friends from the US must feel at home eating the hamburgers." I learned later on that the reason for which was that we were behind schedule and therefore wouldn't have enough time for a proper Chinese meal; hence, American fast food was the only remedy.

There were still only three metro lines in the city (one of them, in fact, was not even a part of the system yet) that which didn't seem to be the problem because people at the time were still moving around the city by bicycles and

the taxi was relatively cheap. The air was still nice then, and we could see the blue sky almost every day (a luxury in today's Beijing).

Hitting the ground running, we were divided up into groups: three of us MIT students spent days and nights for the next four weeks with two talented Tsinghua students — who would come to MIT as well two years later for their graduate degrees — visiting the site again and again, doing library and statistical research, pinning-ups our drawings and diagrams for professors and colleagues to offer critiques, and talking with each other into the night and the morning about our ideas, responsibilities, and roles as builders of this emerging economy.

Every morning we would, like most people in Beijing, rode our bicycles from the dormitory to the building of the School of Architecture by the East Gate of the beautiful and spread out campus (until my bicycle, of course, got stolen only after the first week of the Studio!). After I knew how to order the Chinese buns stuffed inside with pork, almost everyday on the way to the studio, I would drop by to pick up a few for myself and my colleagues.

Despite the painfully unbearable heat of Beijing summer, we would be staying in the studio all day long (I'd made a corner in the studio my place for an afternoon nap) and staying up all night to work on the project. Field trips to see various historical and architecturally important sites helped to ease the tension among us "serious designers," giving us a time to take a break from our own obsession with the task at hand.

Every day, I'd learn a new body gesture to communicate with the cashiers at local supermarkets and restaurants. Every day our Chinese colleagues would teach us a new Chinese word to learn. Instant noodles and instant coffee, however, were our best friends, and perhaps partly owing to the excessive consumption of carbohydrate and caffeine pumping blood through our veins we would eventually create a studio environment that was nothing less than the "master-and-apprentice" type we all had read about in biographies of Frank Lloyd Wright and Louis I. Kahn.

Our professors would come in the morning, and we would be discussing the designs — through hand-drawn diagrams on yellow drafting papers, and models made of scrap card boards and foams glued together to present our ideas. At the end, we'd learned from what we had been through together. The month in Beijing was a revelation: there's so much I could contribute as an architect, and there're so many people and places that needed people like us.

Beijing Studio, once and for all, taught me that I was an architect, and not a high theorist. My decision to pursue a doctorate in anthropology all began in Beijing, as my wish was to combine architecture and anthropology creative a trans-disciplinary field of moral practice that places collective interest in urban environment above any forms of self interest.

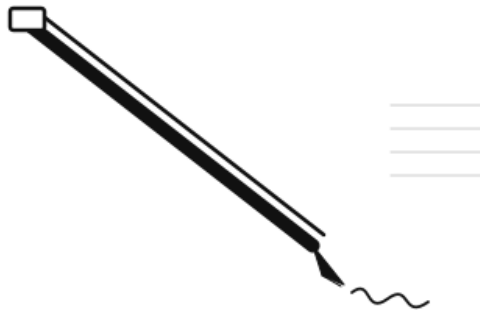
Before I knew it, I was going back for my master's thesis research in 2007, and then again in 2008 for a personal research project, in 2009 to conduct even more research and learn Mandarin Chinese, and nearly every year afterward for my PhD research. Since 2013, I have been living in Shanghai, where I am writing this blog post. Beijing would become the city that I would return to almost every year to learn Mandarin Chinese and conduct research in history, sociology, and anthropology.

Shanghai would become my research home for the entire decade and serve as case study for my doctoral research project on economic anthropology. How did I end up studying China? For the better or for worse, I blame it on Beijing Studio. Shanghai, China March 2016

DAY 60

The 60th Day Anniversary

Sun, 24 Aug 2025 00:00:00 +0000



WHEN YOUNG PEOPLE "DISCOVER PHILOSOPHY" today, it usually means either that they have come upon writings that call into question what they thought they knew, or that they suddenly feel awake to new modes of perceiving and interacting with the world. Michael S. Roth The quote above is from one of my favorite philosophy teacher. I quote him all the time but I have never had the pleasure of meeting him.

His online course on Couresa is a knowledge depository on philosophy and social theory to which I always turn whenever I am in doubt. Do you ever have the feeling of not wanting to stop watching something? Once I had begun watching videos of Professor Roth teaching this course on modern philosophy, I simply couldn't stop watching, and before I knew it I had sat through the entire course. This quote of his works for me.

I think it's his course that has helped me discover philosophy, and to want to pass on what I know about it to those who may be interested in learning how to think about life in a much more meaningful way. Now, this is my 60th post on this blog. You may notice that lately my blog post doesn't have a topic of anything, which is lame. Yes. I agree.

I have been asked, "where is that On Sex Part 3 you have promised to write?" and "where is that post on the idea of justice that you have said you would be writing for me," and so on. I haven't forgotten any of that at all. I know that it's been more than 6 months since I had started this blog. So, had I been writing one blog a day as planned, I would have gotten close to the 200th post already. But, sadly, that's not the case.

As I mentioned in my earlier post, I have been interested in a different kind of writings, namely aphorism that which has been captivating my attention owing it to my recent interest in the so-called "simplicity turn" of my writing. Some of my followers do not like reading aphorisms that much. One of my friends, Max, had even pointed out to me: Your writing style is moving more and more towards the modern and rushed snippets of condensed thought that are too open to interpretation.

I was more fond of the blog posts. No doubt they are succinct, but I don't think there's a way to convince someone of an argument or substantiate your stance/viewpoint with severely limited word counts. And I'm just not a fan of the Twitter-140-characters era of creating and consuming information. And I will agree if you call this a personal preference issue -- it might as well be. I just lean towards quality over quantity in this spectrum. Point taken (although, what's wrong with open interpretation?).

That said, I always think of my writings as pretty straightforward. Each of my aphorism is as economical and direct as a sentence (or two) could be. I promise that as soon as I have lost my interest in the simplicity turn I will go back to the previous writing mode!

I have done the math and it seems to be the case that even if I write every day from today until the day I will be getting my doctorate I still won't reach "100 Days of Writing," as I had planned almost 6 months ago.

It's true that the goal of this blog has always been to keep me on the track of getting a PhD -- and it has, in quite a remarkable way -- by getting me hooked on writing, and keeping me interested in the art of sharing ideas

through writing. I have to admit that, although I had been writing a lot (since it's how I had survived all these years in academia without an advanced research degree like a PhD).

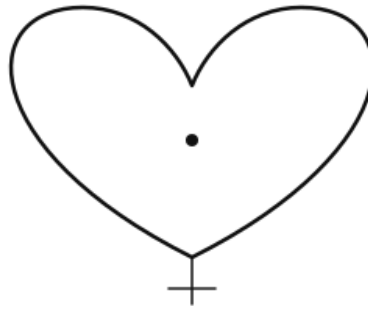
Writing this blog has gotten me interested in reading style guides and writing manuals, which were the kind of books that I never had, even the slightest, interest in reading! Writing this blog has also re-linked me to my almost-forgotten interest in philosophy. Writing is, in a way, the art of transmitting one's thoughts and ideas across and through space and time, for those who will be leaving long after me.

I have enjoyed writing this blog, and although I won't get to Day 100 before my PhD is commenced, I will continue to write this blog. PhD is my academic project; writing this blog is a life long project. Here're some aphorisms I have been writing lately.

DAY 61

Home is Where the Heart is

Mon, 25 Aug 2025 00:00:00 +0000



LIVE FROM LOS ANGELES AND Boston. I just got back to the US less than 4 hours ago. About 8 hours ago, I was sitting at a bar inside the American Airlines terminal at the Los Angeles International Airport (LAX) enjoying my Californian-styled pizza (whatever that meant) and a full 5L pint of Samuel Adams lager (which was slightly larger than a typical Bostonian pint). Sam Adams, by the way, has since I arrived in Boston been my favorite lager.

It's great to have three pints in a roll for the first time since May 2015. As I was getting tipsy, and as the batteries of both of my cellphone and laptop were dying (and apparently there wasn't any outlet around me to charge anything), I suddenly had a chance to think about what I had been too busy to think about what had happened in my life in the past 20 years. Yes, 20 years.

At the same time, I also had a sudden feeling that writing this blog has been one of the key moments in my life: The one that has gradually grown on me and turned me into not just a writer but someone who truly believes in the power of words.

Writing, at the end of the day, is the most efficient form of communication -- it's the only form of expression that cuts across space and time and is truly unique in its own way for how it has changed the way we think, read, and

communicate with one another. I have become a better person as I have learned how to write, and how to want to write well.

There was nothing more that I would like to do than getting the Day 61 post out for you guys to read.

The question for this post, which I was thinking about as I was flying over the Atlantic, was "where is home?" Here I am back at Harvard where I have spent my last 6 years studying anthropology and trying to make our world a better place through education, which I believe to be one of the very few reliable solutions to the problems that we are all facing in the world today. Cambridge is my home.

As I walking past the statue of John Harvard, donning on me was the sense of nostalgia. In the spring of 1999, I flew to Cambridge from Oklahoma City with my host family who wanted me to see "the city where two of the best universities in the world are located." I was, of course, excited. Nonetheless, there's no way I'd think such a trip would have any impact on me since I wasn't a good student.

It's already a fluke and a stroke of pure luck that I'd got to spend a year in Oklahoma City as an American Field Service exchange student. That trip did change everything. It wasn't the prestige of MIT that made me want to go there to study. It's the people that I met during the trip. Many of them were engineering students from As I walking past the statue of John Harvard, donning on me was the sense of nostalgia.

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That trip did change everything. It wasn't the prestige of MIT that made me want to go there to study. It's the people that I met during the trip. Many of

them were engineering students from humble backgrounds similar to mine.

They told me that they got to MIT not because they were able to hire someone to write beautiful statements of intent for them, or because they had parents who were willing to spend money to fake their applications for them -- the practice that seems to be the standard and the name of the game today. They got into MIT because they had "one thing" about them that was special.

I had a long conversation with a Chinese- American student named Billie, who said, "I was, and still am, a nerd, but when it comes to programming nobody in my high school knew better than I was." That's the only thing that Billie was good at, and what got him to MIT. MIT also paid for his tuition, room, and board.

Because of Billie and a few friends of his whom I met during this short visit, I suddenly realized that if I'd look hard enough, I might also be able to find something special about me. There was, of course, a chance that I would not find anything, but the fact that mattered then was that there's literally nothing to lose. At MIT, I came, I saw, I almost immediately wanted to go there.

Once I'd returned to Oklahoma City, and then Bangkok, I'd kept reminding myself every day that I had to get out of Thailand and explore the world. As I have written elsewhere on this blog, I had a low-keyed childhood during which time I did not get to learn much about anything that was useful to kids at a young age to learn owing to my family's lack of financial resources among other things (such as the fact that we're members of a underprivileged class in the Thai society).

This low-keyed childhood of mine may have been what made me both humbled about myself and what made me feel uneasy when I meet people who do not respect the opportunity that they have in life, as well as those who are opportunistic because they think they could be so.

My father was the one who came up with our family's Thai last name in order to get the family registered and to get himself to go to school since during the time he was growing up there's a strong anti-Chinese sentiment everywhere. Despite our long need-no-introduction last name, it's a made-up one. My father came up with it by looking up words he liked in a dictionary and put them together. Our last name, therefore, does not have a long history let alone any prestige.

It's a clear marker, also for us, that we're ordinary citizens. My childhood was boring. It was, in fact, deadly boring. Every day I would read comic books (Japanese manga). Same old comic books. My parents tried to make it special but we couldn't really do much, again, owing to our lack of resources, which mainly was the reason why I had become so emotional and vested in the development and maturity of my students.

My students today have 100 times more opportunity than I had through both formal education and the globalizing world of education. We didn't have the internet in the 80s-90s when I was growing up so things I got to learn were limited to things teachers wanted us to learn and were willing to share with the students. Students today are very lucky, and it's always been my goal to make sure that they are not taking their opportunity to learn lightly.

The reason for which has to do, always, with my own sense of responsibility: I will not let any students have the same experience I had when I was young. I will not let my students think that their lives are boring. I want them to see how amazing their lives are, and how great it is that they are learning something new every day. Until I came to the United States, I didn't get to learn English or any skills.

I didn't even speak a word of English less than a decade ago; thus, in most cases where I write, speak, or say more in English than I need to, one could be almost certain that which have to do with how I unconsciously replicate Thai sentence structures and syntax. In my life, I have never won a single award in any competitions of any kinds. I wasn't even an average student -- I was a horrible student all the way from kindergarten to high school.

There's no one to tell me that I could do better. It seemed to be the case that most people around me (mainly my parents and family members) had accepted me for who I was: that I wasn't going to be like any other kids who won awards and were bringing fame and reputation to the families to which they belonged. It's a very normal childhood, about which I do not have a clear memory.

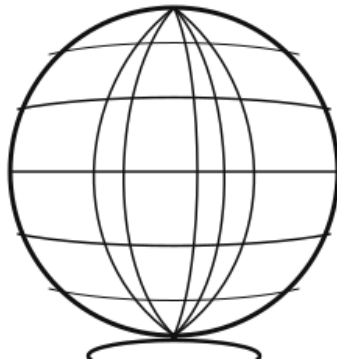
The only thing I could remember was that I was never told that I could do anything. My parents were happy as long as I got myself out of trouble, which was exactly what I did throughout my childhood years. If I got into trouble, none of them would have the power to get me out of it, as we didn't have any financial means, let alone connections with the privileged class -- usually how people got themselves out of trouble. I stayed out of trouble. That's my job.

Ok, here is the time for more aphorism!

DAY 62

Paradise; or, Reflecting on the Urban

Tue, 26 Aug 2025 00:00:00 +0000



I WENT TO THE WOODS because I wished to live deliberately, to front only the essential facts of life, and see if I could not learn what it had to teach, and not, when I came to die, discover that I had not lived. I did not wish to live what was not life, living is so dear; nor did I wish to practice resignation, unless it was quite necessary.

I wanted to live deep and suck out all the marrow of life, to live so sturdily and Spartan-like as to put to rout all that was not life, to cut a broad swath and shave close, to drive life into a corner, and reduce it to its lowest terms, and, if it proved to be mean, why then to get the whole and genuine meanness of it, and publish its meanness to the world; or if it were sublime, to know it by experience, and be able to give a true account of it in my next excursion.

Henry David Thoreau An Excerpt from Walden; or, Life in the Woods (1854) I am writing this blog post by a lake in Massachusetts -- Paradise Lake. I am hearing both the birdsong and the sound of the wind touching the surface of the water on the lake. The combination of both, with no manmade sound whatsoever, creates a powerful melody of natural sound that makes me feel

peaceful. I can't recall how long ago was the last time I had felt so peaceful.

Having lived in big cities in the past 20 years -- Bangkok, Boston, London, and Shanghai -- the most peaceful place I could ask for has been my room, because anywhere outside of it is full of cacophony and loud noise. Only once in a while, I would get a chance to travel outside of the city to spend a few days away from the chaotic urban life.

I am also working on proofreading my dissertation which I am going to present it to my advisors in less than three weeks. Although I have been working on the writing of my dissertation for the past ten months, this is the first time that I am writing it outside of the city. As I am writing this blog right here where the only sounds I could hear aren't those of human beings, I can't help but think to myself: This is so great; why haven't I done this sooner?

I would like to think that I could have been much more productive had I not been so distracted by the cacophonous interruption brought about by urban life (even though I'd really like to think so). So many times that I had planned to write and be productive, but I slept as soon as I got home from after spending a day out in the urban. The urban has been making me sick: Its selfish and superficial people, its polluted environment, and its unnecessary rushing.

I am thinking to myself: It's either the case that I don't deserve to live in the urban or the urban doesn't deserve to have me. It could also well be a matter of structural incompatibility. My favorite philosopher Jean-Jacques Rousseau never has any positive feeling about cities.

He thinks they are places whose economic nature not only give people the impression that they have to be shamelessly selfish to prevent themselves from being taken advantage of (i.e., pseudo-self preservation) but also the negative reinforcement that the sense of morality only exists as they'd like to define them -- as if there is nothing intrinsic about the "good" nature of human beings. Although many people (including my colleague, Mike No.

2) believes that Rousseau, like Schopenhauer, is a self-proclaimed pessimist, self-taught skeptic, and self-funded gloomy writer; therefore, could only permit himself to see only the dark side of things, I personally don't think that Rousseau is that off in his way of thinking about the urban.

As more people are now living in urban areas than ever before, the defining characteristic of the twenty-first century is unquestionably that of the urban, all thanks to the major shift in the world's economy toward service-oriented economies, and the emergence of industries catering to the demands of contemporary consumerism. Still ringing true are the basic aspects of the urban suggested by classic urban sociological theories (i.e., the Chicago School of Sociology such as Louis Wirth and Robert Park): population, density, heterogeneity, and complexity.

Also still true is the major divide in the perceptions of what might constitute the conditions that the urban brings. With the decline of religiosities and the advent of the new faith in sciences, urban populations are faced with how to deal with the fast, massive, and intense move toward an arguably better quality of life, while also dealing with an underlying deeply troubled sense of personhood.

While technological advancement, innovation, and creativity are direct by-products of urbanization, some undesirable consequences such as high divorce rates, widening income inequality, pollution-related health problems, and, needless to say, suicide, are "tragedies of the commons" acutely felt by many urbanites. My motivation for writing about, and reflecting here on the urban owes its origin to both my ethnographic findings from my field site in Shanghai, China, and my personal feeling about where I have spent almost three years to date conducting anthropological research and residing as a resident.

It may be true that I have been spending most of my life in the urban, but the intensity of the feeling I had had living elsewhere is nowhere near that of Shanghai. During my first year, I could barely survive mentally. It's the time when I had begun to read philosophy (mainly Eastern, especially Daoism and

Zen Buddhism) to cope with the aggressiveness of urban life. Everywhere I went to, I was usually faced with the money-comes-first attitude.

Everywhere I turned to, I was often faced with the unnecessarily difficult situation that only the senseless competition of the urban life could incubate. For instance, in a case of downright and sincere misunderstanding with which I faced, my counterpart, instead of speaking to me directly about it, had chosen to resort to a third party who then only had the information on one side when questioning me about the point of concern that he had regarding the misunderstanding I had with the counterpart.

Why couldn't this counterpart speak to me directly so that we could have gotten this misunderstanding solved right away? In my third year in Shanghai, I have had it. During the past two years, you have noticed, I have become much more philosophical than before. The reason for which is quite simple: The only way I could maintain my sanity is to find a way to maintain a peace of mind.

Since I do not believe in orthodoxy religiosities (such as Christianity) I do not have a road map to the "Kingdom of God" by which I could navigate; hence, it's more convincing for me to try to come up with my own way of dealing with the hardship -- through reason. Many people I know have become much more religious once they had arrived in Shanghai. It may be true that the city was too much for them in terms of competitiveness. In addition, I always believe in synthetic knowledge.

Although I am a religious person myself -- I am a practicing Buddhist -- the only explanation that could ever please my serious sense of skepticism and fallibilism about anything at all must come from synthetic knowledge. I am talking specifically about a specific form of synthetic knowledge that the philosopher Immanuel Kant calls synthetic a priori: the platform of reason on which access to the true knowledge could be gained without us having to experience the phenomenon in which we would like to find out why and how it happens, and how to deal with it.

As strange as it may sound: How can we understand anything without experiencing it? Kant has a clever answer. First, Kant argues that our experience can lie to us (as our senses are often dictated by non-reasons, i.e., "passion" according to David Hume) and that there's a limit to what we can do as we are living in the domain of restricted time and space in which we live our lives.

Hence, what we do, what we deem we should do, should come from that non-sensory platform of knowing that which is appropriate simply because it cannot be otherwise. That platform is the reason and the reason alone. For a teacher, for example, it would only be an end in itself for her to show up to teach the students even if the students themselves do not yet see the value in her teaching owing to the fact that the consequences of my teaching may not be able to be measured.

It's synthetic knowledge that teachers should teach, teach well, and dedicate herself to teaching whether or not the students is appreciative of her teaching. I, of course, would hope that my students would think of the consequences of being good students, such as that they could achieve a good life, but the truth here is that they might not even get to see or feel such consequences in their lifetime since the consequences as such could not come easily as a success often depends on many factors.

This was precisely the point where Kant argues that we cannot get access to the synthetic knowledge by way of measuring the consequences. We cannot think about the true knowledge from such angle the same way we cannot think about the way in which we treat other human beings only as a means to an end. So, what's the synthetic knowledge about the urban?

Many of us may remember what the 17th-century philosopher Thomas Hobbes has to say about his synthetic knowledge of the state of nature: solitary, poor, nasty, brutish, and short. I don't have the same set of powerful adjectives that Hobbes has for the urban. In fact, I think because it's the urban, it's by definition much more complex, but let me try. How about these: Gesellschaft (impersonal ties), pseudo-self preservation, superficiality, and

lack of interpersonal sensibility. I am leaving Shanghai precisely because of those.

Hey, I mean, this is not the first time that I have been rambling about how I would like to hit the road. This post might sound like me, again, re-rambling, but my love-hate (or, more precisely, hate-hate) relationship with the city and how such relationship has already reached its limit. Ironically, it's only a week ago that I had written about how my love for Shanghai was precisely what initially brought me over to China.

It's true that I have, for quite a while now, begun to feel that the city is changing me into someone who I am not. A few months ago I had to deal with my own feeling of not wanting to get up in the morning because I knew that the person I would be seeing that day was someone who would like me to do things that I knew would be against my own personal sense of morality -- but for her, it's the right thing to do, as in, helping her to get rid of her enemy for the sake of our "urban" unity.

And yes, I have made the preceding sentence unclear for a reason. I didn't want to give it out too much to the point that you'd know how this person was. Although I think that she never was a nice person, I also believe that it was the urban that made her evil.

It has been doing so by way of changing other people around me to pressure me, both directly and indirectly, into accepting the fact that in order to survive here, I must become a member of a community where the sense of community is defined by material reciprocity, rather than respect, sympathy, and the true unity under the basic idea of right and equality. It's unhealthy on all fronts. I think it's the condition of the city that counterproductive attracts these kinds of people.

The urban has been doing this to many people. It has been doing so by way of changing other people around me to pressure me, both directly and indirectly, into accepting the fact that in order to survive here, I must become a member of a community where the sense of community is defined

by material reciprocity -- rather than respect, sympathy, and the true unity under the basic idea of right and equality. It's unhealthy on all fronts.

I think it's the condition of the city that counterproductive attracts these kinds of people. China is a special case owing to its long history of agrarianism and popular religions; both of which are undergoing swift change. In pursuing my research on urban religiosities -- and pursuing my quest to stay sane -- I always seek to understand the changing mental structure of the non-urban residents in the city. As socialism declines, being re-evaluated by the urban population are taboos on "non-scientific" practices as well as on mental illnesses.

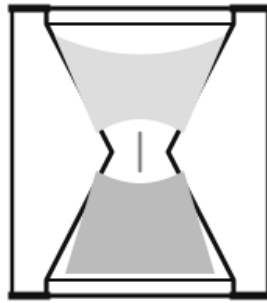
The recent rise of religious practices and psychotherapy (also known, as my colleague Dr. Hsuan-Ying Huang at the Chinese University of Hong Kong has termed "psycho-boom") signals the rise of individual needs for moral and psychological support: While the former harks back to traditional values, the latter attracts troubled urbanites with its scientific appeal.

Living in Shanghai, I always make it my goal to deal with the intensity of its urban condition by building a trans-disciplinary platform to critically engage in sociopolitical and geopolitical situations (which is, the least I can do to stay sane) through the lens of traditional spiritual beliefs, and the distinct cultural and social formations owing their origins to psychotherapy.

DAY 63

I Wish I Had Never Done a PhD

Wed, 27 Aug 2025 00:00:00 +0000



" EDUCATION IS AN ADMIRABLE thing, but it is well to remember from time to time that nothing that is worth knowing can be taught." – Oscar Wilde "To live is not to breathe but to act." Jean-Jacques Rousseau This is an afterthought, which, sadly, occurred to me six years after I had started my Ph.D. This thought came to me when I was answering a series of questions required by the graduate school toward the end of my thesis submission process.

One question was: "If you could make a decision on whether or not you would do a PhD again, would you have done your PhD?" "Of course, I would have." That was my initial reaction. "What a stupid question," I felt. And then, when I was about to click the button to submit the answer, I had a second thought. I suddenly began to have feelings of doubt.

Some of which were self-doubts, and some were doubts, in general, about my answer, about how I think about, and about whether or not "of course" was the right answer. This was the kind of questionnaire about which I did not think anyone would care. The graduate school probably wanted to come up with a set of report to show that most students were happy with the program. But have I ever been one of those students?

(That said, it seems to be the case that the graduate really wants to know the value of its PhD program owing to a series of harsh critiques on the enterprise as a whole.) What makes someone want to do a PhD? I am sure that many people have different reasons. For some fields of study, however, not getting a PhD is not an option, as the PhD is in itself those fields' professional degrees, needed by graduates in those fields to qualify to join the workforce.

So, let's keep this conversation to the PhDs that are optional, rather than required, such as in humanities and social sciences. I want a PhD because ultimately I want to teach, and to be qualified to do so, having a PhD helps although it is not always required. Many people think of PhDs as a pathway to job security. Many people, strangely enough (at least to me) think of PhDs as ways to kill time. Let's say there are generally three things that people aim for in life.

Let's simplistically put them in three broad categories: money, respect, fame, and perhaps, knowledge. First and foremost, for people who want to be respected, they should not get a PhD. In the society today, the chances are that you will be respected if you have money (or fame). Also in the world today, there are many more ways of becoming innovative entrepreneurs making money at a very young age than ever.

This is a trend set by many in the technology fields, giving rise to an entourage of millennials who see going to college as a complete waste of time and opportunity. Time is money, and youth cannot be reversed (trust me; been there). It is, in fact, easier to be respected in the world today by first making money, and then using the money to raise one's fame, and then using the fame to spread the words about what you think you know - in that order.

People tend to listen to your words that way rather than from your words written in academic books. So, if getting a PhD is for the respect. The answer is no. What about those who cannot find a job and therefore want to buy time from spending time getting a degree, since universities are such safe places?

From my multiple personal encounters with people who have this attitude, there's a high chance that they would get out of the program both indebted and empty-handed.

As many types of research have shown, too, if buying time is your goal, getting an internship with businesses and learning from amazing Massive Open Online Courses (MOOCs) we have available for free today are much more effective methods to learn the transferable skills that you'd need to get yourself going or get back on your path. Getting a PhD as a way of making money, either through having a job or having a job security, then? You have got to be kidding me.

The answer is also no, which leaves us only one reason for wanting a PhD: To seek to know very deeply about something. How about that? Well, if the time and money are not your concerns, then yes. But if they are problems; Then no.

That's exactly my problem with my own PhD A few years back I met a student applying for a PhD program at our department who shared with me her admirably frank view about getting a PhD: "It's a fast-track to receive respected from other people," she said. At the time, I had already started my research, so I knew that PhD was not all about that.

In fact, as I always thought PhD was largely about research, I felt that it would also be important to ask her idea regarding her research.

"I don't have any ideas about my research; I'll do anything that my future advisor would want me to do," she said and then continued: You know, Non, all I want is somewhere to spend the next 5-6 years of my life getting paid just to build my cultural capital; at the end, I don't really care about the output of my PhD, and as I said, I see it as a fast track to "get people to respect you." Those who know me well can probably guess what my reaction was toward her attitude toward PhD.

I never spoke to her again ever since. The sad part is that this conversation was the beginning of a whole new perspective that I have on why many have

decided to do a PhD. She might be right after all. We are living in search of respect. I had, then, begun to look around and found that many people, even those who were my comrades-in-arms were no different. "Don't be too idealistic, Non," one of them said to me.

Turns out I could only think of a few people who have gotten themselves into the PhD program for the same reason: The love for research. In the past ten years, I have been working in one geographic area, and almost exclusively on one issue: Shanghai, and how to bridge the gap between architecture and other academic fields.

This way of thinking has been with me ever since I was exposed to anthropology and realized the potential of such a field in enriching architecture, which could make a difference in the real world. Good architecture saves lives, incubates good social relations, and transforms a society through its built quality – whether that be monumentality or else. This was the sole reason for me to leave my home in Thailand and to depart from my family, relatives, and friends.

The time spent on learning things about which I have been passionate has a price that has to be paid. After ten years of living abroad, I barely know any of my friends anymore. Good friends and lovers are now just acquaintances who I only know of through their Facebook pages, and lovers have gone on to establish their own families without me. I also did not get to stay close to two of my grandparents, to whom I was very close when they were terminally ill.

The saddest part was that I could have spent those ten years with my father, who also passed away during the time I was doing my PhD. Now, I can't think of a better way to take my argument regarding the useless of the Ph.D. to the next step than to answer some of the questions that I have had recently received from colleagues, friends, and former students who were curious about what I thought I had learned from doing a PhD.

Q: I want to teach so I want a PhD What do you think? Non: Teaching in a higher educational institution often requires a PhD, but that is not always the

case. There are many people who do not have PhDs but are teaching at universities. Good universities, in fact, are going out of this conventional method to hire people without PhDs: thinkers, movers and shakers in emerging fields, writers (especially those who have awards in hand) and so on.

It is true that getting these accolades take as much sacrifice, but from an investment perspective, one might as well shoot for that from the get-go. Most of them are famous and therefore they are being hired to teach. Because they write books or have worked in established companies and firms, their experience and skills are sought after by the universities who want their students to learn from the professionals rather than academics who often do not understand the real world.

Also, there are many PhDs who will never get to teach because there are simply not enough jobs for them in academia. That is to say, getting a PhD doesn't guarantee any teaching job — there're too many PhD graduates when compared to available teaching jobs so this problem has to do with the basic notion of demand-supply. Q: Apart from the demand- supply problem, why do you think many PhD graduates don't get jobs in academia?

Non: That has to do with the nature of many PhD programs, which do not teach PhD students how to teach. Most of those programs are research-based. Also, most of them focus on getting the students to do work for their professors and then graduate. Second, even PhD programs that were once known for training their graduates to teach are encountering financial problems, making it more sensible for them to reduce the period of time once made available for teaching training.

So, many PhD graduates are having problems with how to be good teachers, and for that reason, they are not that employable. Q: Getting a PhD makes people respect you? Non: Perhaps, having a PhD may have the potential of drawing a pool of superficial people toward you. These are people who are likely to respect you because of your degree and not because of who you are.

By accepting respect from these people, you are making yourself an accomplice to social inequality because you are simply accepting the idea that a random status marker (i.e., Ph.D.) could, in actuality, change you to a respectable person. That is to say, only people who do not respect themselves enough think that way. I personally never respect anyone just because they have PhDs and would be very mad if that which is the only reason why anyone would respect me. Q: Getting a PhD is not a dinner party.

It is hard, right? Non: I like how you are quoting Chairman Mao there ("revolution is not a dinner party")! No, nothing is a dinner party. If you ask Jean-Paul Sartre, even the dinner party itself is not a dinner party. It's a weird thing that we human beings have invented to ritualize our way of socializing, but that's a topic for another time. I think getting a Ph.D. is not as hard as I thought.

In fact, as a financially struggling graduate student, I have learned quite a few things. I had to teach to survive, so I did, but I also used that opportunity to master of my teaching skills. I never turned down the opportunity to teach or to assist in teaching even if some of the opportunities were unpaid. In my mind, having someone listening to what I had to say about what I wanted to be able to teach well was already in itself a great opportunity.

I should be paying my audience for having to listen, sometimes, to my complete nonsense! I had to juggle two or three tasks to make ends meet. During the first few years of my doctoral education, I worked as a resident advisor at a fraternity house (not the easy kind where you get a free housing just by being there), taught part-time at a local university, guest lectured at universities abroad, wrote articles for popular magazines, and so on.

All of this was to pay my bills and to have some money to send home to my mother. Our awful financial situation at home (it was actually never good) made my life as a PhD student quite difficult, but thanks to the fact that members of our extended family in Thailand have always supported each other — and supported me — I was able to get to the end of the process Q: So, was it hard getting a PhD?

Non: I can only speak from my personal experience, which is no. In fact, it was not hard at all. I got my PhD in six years.

The minimum length for a PhD in anthropology, I believe, was three to four years, which is reserved for those who do not need money from the school and therefore do not have to spend a year teaching just to receive stipends and those who conduct research in their first language, who therefore do not have to spend time learning the second or, to many, even third language. A "fast-track" PhD for those who need to learn another language and need money is five years.

I got mine in six because I had to take a year off to work in order to survive. Otherwise, I believe, I could also get my PhD in five years or fewer. Q: Do you feel as though you have made a difference in the world with your work? Non: No. Not at all. That's the biggest problem I have with my PhD. I could have gone into journalism or architecture and do the same.

With the advent of technology, free online courses, MOOCs, etc., I could have taught myself what I needed to know. Most of the time I have learned about what I wanted to learn by myself anyway though reading and watching my favourite MOOCs (if you wonder which ones they are, I have quite a few suggestions on my blog). I could have spent the six years in the field, doing things, and making the differences in the world felt by the community that I cared, and by myself, already.

Of course, I cannot possibly know for sure if that would be the case. One thing I know, though, is that I am persistent and I would have made my life and my work meaningful to myself, and to others, with or without being enrolled in a PhD program. Q: Would your life be different had you not done a PhD? Non: Absolutely. In a way, I would have questioned traditional values less. I would have been much more conservative.

I would have also been much less critical about how I think about the meaning of it all. I would have been like Mike, a former colleague who I often quote whenever I need to refer to someone who doesn't give a damn about

critical thinking, who believes that his only purpose in life is to follow his parents' path, which is to get a degree (any degrees), get married, and have a kid. Seriously.

I dislike Mike so much, I believe, partly because he is a reflection of who I was. I hated that part of myself when I was in my 20s — the part that seems to be critical only insofar as the conservatives would be approving of me and therefore giving me easy time. Had I not done my PhD, I would have been like that.

I would have mindlessly gotten married because I thought it was about time, that I needed to, and that I thought I would not be able to live my life being cast aside as a leftover. I would have tried to create another human being to suffer in a world of which I myself do not even know the meaning. That said, I would be swimming with the mainstream, which would probably make me content.

I would just like most people living in Plato's Cave, living with limited lighting, looking at the world through shadows of objects, and believing that they were real and that the Cave itself was the world and that there was no way out. All of this might not seem like a negative thing and seems rather to suggest how enlightening it can be to do a PhD. That said, the point is that there is always comfort in conforming.

Doing a proper PhD will expose one to unconventional ideas and will therefore make one's life more difficult. It's your choice. I have a hard life today because I am questioning everything thanks to having done the PhD. Is it a good thing? The answer: I really don't know. It's like having opened the Pandora's Box. It is impossible to imagine what it was like before it was opened. Q: Was it fun, though, I mean, doing a PhD?

Non: Yes, despite the ups and downs in terms of my financial situation, these past six years have been like a work-holiday for me. I got to meet many people. I got to read so many books. Some of them have changed the way I think about life. I got to travel to places to which I otherwise would not have

any reasons (and invitations) to go. I learned how to teach, how to express my ideas, and how to write with grace and clarity.

That said, this might actually be just me. Many PhD graduates, in fact, write with muddling complexity and obfuscating prose and shamelessly call it "academic." For me, academic work is what people can communicate with, and I expect nothing less. Q: Getting a PhD is super cool, right? Non: Are you f***ing serious? I began by thinking about my personal reasons. Why not having done a PhD. would have been a better choice for me.

Ever since I had earned an undergrad degree in architecture, I have always been hungry to learn more, which might have been because I was young and I did not have a good undergraduate education thus I wanted to see how far I could push myself. Many of my heroes and heroines in life have PhDs; hence, as I was looking up to them, I also wanted to see if I could get one.

So, with that in mind, a young and reckless youth in his early 20s began his quest to get a PhD, which began with an advanced research master's degree. At that point, I was still happy with studying. In fact, I would love to take more courses and graduate even later from that first master's program at MIT had I received more financial support. That master's degree left me hungry, so I had decided to embark on another one.

By the time I was finishing that second one, it seemed that the only sensible path for me was to get a PhD — I had a project that I really wanted to pursue and a prospective advisor who thought that such a project would make a good addition to his program at Harvard. Looking back, it was not all that easy emotionally.

During the past decade of my intellectual endeavour to get three master's degrees and a doctorate, I have lost three grandparents and a father; all of whom I had been very close to. As I had been living abroad, I could only weep in silence and alone. Every time I heard the news I felt as though it would be fine if my life were to end that very moment. What kept me together, away from home, were the words and support from my extended family.

During the past six years, there have been, of course, times that I felt as though I was realizing that I was on the wrong path, but I preferred trying different methods to trick myself that I was on the right track than to accept it. Now, with a Ph.D.

in hand, I have never felt so sorry about how I had spent my last six years: Six years that I could have spent to make a difference in the world; the six years that nature had equipped me with youth and its productive persistence and recklessness; the six years during which I had so much time to cultivate many natural and practical thoughts about how I would like to live the rest of my life.

But nothing has been worse than the fact that I had not learned any other transferable skills during the last six years because all I had been doing was technical reading and academic writing.

I have lowered my expectation of academia thanks to the voice of my colleague that has never left my ear: "You are too idealistic." But even that – even after I have lowered my standards – I still see academia as being a place in which it is utterly hard to get anything started let alone do something groundbreaking off the ground. In other words, I have lost my hope.

Formal education, just like any other businesses from which I had been running away, is no different and as hopeless as the mode of elitist reproduction about which Oscar Wilde and Jean- Jacques Rousseau once warned us a long time ago (and the irony is that had I not entered academia I would not have the opportunity to read Wilde's and Rousseau's). During the past six years, I have been training myself to think like a scholar, and also to act and write like one.

It's unfortunate that I have made myself into someone even I myself never wanted to be. The kinds of scholars that I like are those who live in the real world and write in the way that is, rather than scholarly, humanistically engaging. I like the kind of writing that cuts right to the chest, poetic, and simple. None of these, sadly, are the writing styles encouraged in academia

where I have spent six years.

Although many would like to argue that academia is still one of the few places where merit works to people's advantage, I can hardly think of an instance that I got what I got because of merit. Like any other industries of which academia tends to be critical, it's all about connections - who is who in which groups, clans, tribes and so on. I can, however, recall quite vividly how many times I was turned down with no reason simply because I was on the wrong side.

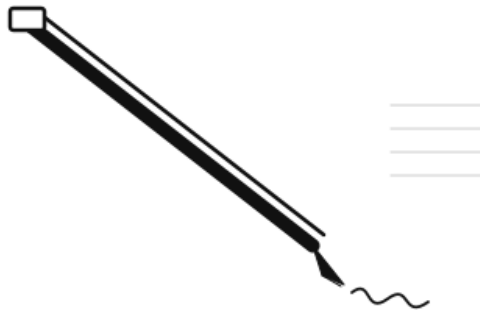
To put it bluntly, I was turned down for grants, fellowships, etc., because I did not have the right connections. Now, at 34, I neither have the energy and persistence of the youth, nor the skills needed to be useful in the world today. I wish I have never done a Ph.D.

post Day 64: My Honest Résumé Thu, 28 Aug 2025 00:00:00 +0000

DAY 65

On a Failed Relationship

Fri, 29 Aug 2025 00:00:00 +0000



IT'S GOOD TO BE BACK on my blog, writing again. Thank you all for all of the kind words of congratulation. It's good to have a Ph.D., although I wish I hadn't done it. It's good, still, to have accomplished something in life no matter how trivial it may be or may sound in the infinite universe of things, people, and knowledge of which I am a tiny part.

Now, let me ask you a question: Have you ever felt that you were so lucky -- because you'd won something, met someone, and achieved something -- and then later, after a while, felt that which was more a curse rather than a gift? There're many philosophers in the history of thoughts. The most famous among whom were Pyrrho (c. 360 BC – c. 270 BC), an Ancient Greek philosopher who was a big fan of Eastern philosophy.

In the podcast that my favorite podcaster Steven West had done on his teaching, the basic principles of Pyrrhonism could out described as follows: Something that seems good is not always good. Something that seems bad is not always bad, and even if it is bad, adversity is what strengthens you to better navigate future problems in your life. Your level of success is not determined by whether there are hurdles in your path, but by how well you jump over them.

Like Lord Buddha, Pyrrho wants to tell us to try not control our mind. If we're to be too happy, we're deemed to be hit by sadness when such happiness is not longer with us. In fact, Pyrrho is making a point in a very rational way (so is Buddha) by saying that everything that can be evaluated, can only be evaluated with time as the main variable.

West uses an example of a man who had won a lottery (which, by the way, was a true story) who wished he had never won it. I have a tendency, as usual, to enhance the dramatic effect of a particular story so I will do so a bit here just to make my point a little bit clearer.

Of course, he thought he was the luckiest man in the world when the hundreds of millions of cash were given to him as a result of him randomly buying the winning Power Ball lottery ticket. A few years later when his life was bombarded by requests from those who had thought were "his" friends, "his" relatives," and, saddest of all, "his" family members.

All of them, once they knew what he had won, wanted a piece of him, and any decision that he had made would result in some kinds of conflict either between him and his counterparts, or among the different parties, and so on. The story ended tragically: suicide. Before he died, he had said, "Winning the lottery was the worst thing that ever happened to me." There's nothing new about how winning lottery isn't a good thing.

In "The Tragic Stories of the Lottery's Unluckiest Winners," Time Magazine succinctly summarizes what had happened with the previous winners that the Magazine had previously reported: Distant relatives and fair-weather friends can come clamoring for their share; spouse can turn on a spouse; kidnapping and murder can suddenly become very real threats. And sometimes, the greatest danger to the newly well-off can be the winners themselves. So, let's go back to think about the wisdom with which Pyrrho has provided us. What is, then, things that would make us lucky?

I believe that all of us have had the moment of regret, as in, "Jeez, I wish I had never met that person." In the case of my very close friend who had just

divorced his wife, my friend Tony had shared with me, and in multiple occasions, how he thought he had met the love of his life when they met each other, and the love and the romance were aptly maintained by two two's willingness to make it work during the honeymoon period and then over to the next two years of their marriage.

"But something wasn't right," said Tony. She was so negative -- just about everything," Tony said. "She would come home feeling sad; she would be thinking back and forth about what had gone wrong with her life; she would muse over things in the past that had made her unhappy She was so negative -- just about everything," Tony said.

"She would come home feeling sad; she would be thinking back and forth about what had gone wrong with her life; she would muse over things in the past that had made her unhappy; she would be telling me about how her parents had raised her inappropriately; she would be procrastinating so that the problems at hand did not have to be taken care of by her, and with the hope that someone (me) would take care of it for her so that she would not have to do anything at all.

It's a series of blaming, finger-pointing, senseless skepticism, and the denial of the most important elements in the life for the couple, at least to me, which are respect and the ability of giving to each other the benefit of the doubt. Love is not as important as these two. Sooner or later, as I could tell, Tony had become an aggressive person. He got easily upset and agitated by things around him. He was less productive (before his marriage he was a production powerhouse of his company).

His lack of sensibility and his negativity were felt by all of his friends around him. It's unbearable to us to the point that we had to pull him aside and ask him what had happened.

That's when he burst into tears -- the first and the only time I saw him crying -- and shared with me how his marriage was a failed one, and that had to do with the fact that he could not longer go home to expect his wife's negative

narratives, passive aggressiveness, and the senseless urge to argue with him in just about everything without wanting to listen.

"The worst part is that she's lying to herself, all the time, that she has a job while she's basically spending the seed fund from her family's estate just to stay afloat," said Tony.

"Which reminds me that which isn't yet the worst -- the worst is that she is money- conscious, so she'd get upset when she's spending money, while, again, while, she's so passionate about making her parents suffer by spending their money, which, according to her, they were obligated to give her, on senseless items, trips, meals, and so on, just, simply, to sub it on their face showing how much she's unhappy about how she's raised by them." Tony was also aware of that some of the problems also came from him.

He said that he could listen to her more, and be more sympathetic to her problems although, he also said, "I don't see where her problems are?" So, I was inclined to believe that both were guilty of this failed relationship. Tony was wrong to place so much expectation on his wife, and his wife, needless to say, was wrong to not letting him know from the start her true self. Having met his wife and learned about her charming personality, I could not see her being abusive.

Yet, this story was common among many couples that many social research papers have shown, couples undergoing problematic phases of life tend to result from how they treat each other with less respect than they would to outsiders. To outsiders, each of the two tends to want to maintain his or her social position; hence, wearing a frontality that shows only the kind side of the personality.

I didn't get to see how Tony and his then-wife dealt with each other at home, but given that the neighbors had complained about their chronic and pathological shouting at one another, it wasn't surprised that neither of them had treated one another the same way that they'd treat an outsider. According to the psychology professor John Gottman who was made famous in Malcolm Gladwell's *Blink*, here're the "four horsemen" that kill marriage:

Criticism – Complaints are fine. Criticism is more global – it attacks the person, not their behavior.

They didn't take out the garbage because they forgot, but because they're a bad person. Contempt – "...name-calling, eye-rolling, sneering, mockery, and hostile humor. In whatever form, contempt – the worst of the four horsemen – is poisonous to a relationship because it conveys disgust. It's virtually impossible to resolve a problem when your partner is getting the message that you're disgusted with him or her." Defensiveness – "...defensiveness is really a way of blaming your partner.

You're saying, in effect, 'The problem isn't me, it's you.' Defensiveness just escalates the conflict, which is why it's so deadly." Stonewalling – Tuning out. Disengaging. This doesn't just remove the person from the conflict, it ends up removing them, emotionally, from the relationship. I asked Tony whether any of these four appeared in his marriage.

His response was not that surprising: "all four of them." He then continued, "She is defensive to my criticism, and I am stonewalling whenever her contempt seems to rise." According, also, to Gottman, once these four things are at play, there's no going back. I was also in tears when hearing Tony's story.

This was the man, who, less than a few months ago, had told me that he felt as though he was "the luckiest man in the world" for having met and gotten to know the love of his life at a casual outing that many people had also been invited to join and it just happened to be the case that the two were the ones standing closest to one another and therefore had gotten the opportunity, before anyone else, to get to know each other, first superficially, and then formally, and then socially, and then, needless to say, intimately.

Tony was a man who was obviously in love throughout those first few months. It must have been at least 4-5 times a day that he'd sent me photos of him and his then-girlfriend just to share with me how happy he was as a person. But only a few months afterward, after he realized that his wife had

the chronic negativity symptom.

I helped Tony by getting him to meet with a counselor, Kevin, who had shared with Tony and me the following: How your partner grew up, and the environment in which she grew up, is incredibly important. If someone has spent their whole lives being resentful of their parents, it isn't that they want to be that way. But they don't know of any other way she wants to be different. She simply doesn't know how.

Like kids growing up with alcoholic and abusive parents, they tend to be abusive too, even if they want to be exactly the opposite. My childhood was too simple. This advice is by no means cutting edge of extra special. We tend to know and believe that one's upbringing could affect one's ways of looking at oneself and the people around oneself.

The problem with this relationship is that Tony did think that he was in the right place and the right time -- the same way the guy who won the lottery was -- and that was destiny, faith, and beyond that all wanted him to meet the then-love-of-his-wife so that they would be together. He didn't realize that which would then become something of a deep regret and resentment.

"I can't stand negativity -- I just can't," said Tony with tears in his eyes while pounding heavily on the table on which our glasses of red wine were placed. The pounding was so hard that I thought I heard the sound of his fingerbones being cracked. I have never seen someone that angry before, especially on someone whom he thought was a "gift from God," and especially from an atheist such as Tony, pronouncing God's name there was no picnic.

The advice from Kevin, the counselor, continues The solution is actually quite simple. I realize in your mind it seems muddled, but really, this is just like an investment. You want to put your life savings in an investment, and that will determine how well you live in the future every investment is a risk-reward balance. In this case, you know what the risk is you are going to have to work hard and long with her to understand how to develop a trusting, loving relationship.

that is going to be very hard for her to do, and she may never learn to do it. So you will have to be incredibly patient, tolerant, and understanding. But you need to assess, what is the reward? For you? Is the reward of trying to keep her worth the risk you will be putting in, knowing you may never see the payoff? If the reward is great enough, then yes. if not, then no. Well, as you might have guessed, Tony didn't want to continue.

Who would want to? This was the toxic relationship that could turn the happiest man alive into the miserable man in the universe in a blink of an eye. This was the state of the unbearable lightness of being a couple in which one always tried very hard to make sure that the other one would feel bad about his life, small about himself, regretful about his family, and resentful about his love for her.

This was, all in all, an uncommunicative relationship that everything got misinterpreted thanks to the feeling of wanting to let the negative feeling rule. So, was Tony lucky -- at least to have spent those honeymoon period with the woman of his dream, even though it only lasted for a very short time? I think it wasn't worth the pain that he had to endure afterward. I just wish that I would never be in his position. I just wish that I would never have to be in his position.

post Day 66: The Herzfeld's Rules Sat, 30 Aug 2025 00:00:00 +0000 The topic today is about effective communication, which, I would like to define, is the effective conveying of ideas from one person to another. The conveying of ideas that is not effective is not communication. Then, I should make it clear that the use of the apostrophe (the punctuation mark ') in the title of this post does not indicate the authorship.

In other words, it's not Herzfeld who has come up with the "Herzfeld's Rules" (as in, the rule of Herzfeld's), but it's his way of thinking about the effective conveying of ideas makes me want to refer to him when I think about the most essential rules governing the conveying of ideas.

So, the Harvard Professor of Social Sciences Michael Herzfeld, who is like a father to me, is a social anthropologist, activist, teacher, writer, etc., who has composed more than a hundred of high impact academic papers and ten books. He is a master of storytelling and a true embodiment of the art of communication. Unlike many famous professors, Prof. Herzfeld always has time to listen to everyone.

I have come to realize that which is not only how he collects social data (and to him, all social data are equally important) so that he can write a book about them afterward, but also how he maintain his culturally intimate relationship with his colleagues, students, friends, and informants. Although, in most cases, the line between the last two categories is often unclear since he treats everyone with respect in the "everything is professional; everything is personal" fashion.

What I have learned from him over the year includes: "One often needs a glass of wine to overcome writer's block." "Coffee is not only the morning's cure, but also the best companion to put you to sleep." "We are who we are owing to how we express ourselves linguistically; hence, always respect rules and observe grammatical integrity, but break all of them for the poetic effect." To name a few.

But the most important that I have learned from him is nothing else but the undergirding idea of how to communicate itself. To get a polymath like Prof. Herzfeld to pay attention to me, I must cut right to the chase so that I would not waste his time telling him what he already knows.

Also, because he has many stories ready to pour onto his audience -- and most of the time his stories are much more interesting than anything that the audience may have to share with him anyway -- he does not give his audience a lot of time to grab his attention. Personally, as I have learned over the years, the more I speak, the more I'd be likely to bore him and the more I'd be likely to make mistakes (either verbally or idiomatically).

So the key is to be concise, to the point, and get the main ideas or whatever that might have the ability to grab his attention out there within the first 15 seconds, or 30 words. The story of how the Herzfeld's Rules came about has to do with how I wanted so much to get him to help me with my research proposal.

At the time, I had suffered greatly from the symptom called "the lack of ability to get to the point." Alright, frankly, I was just really bad at getting words out in the right order and in the right tone. Every time I went to see Prof.

Herzfeld, with the hope of getting him to help me craft some particular points that were mine and mine alone, I came back with more of his ideas owing to the fact that I was not capable to addressing my points in the way that would make him "think with me," rather than, simply, "help me." So, over the course of my first three years as his student, I had worked hard to develop a set of guidelines that would help me get my message across to him in the way that would give him no other choice but to respond to me in the way that I would like him to.

These guidelines -- the so-called "a general rule governing any forms of effective communication that those who follow will achieve the goal standard of communication and not be wasting other's time as much as they might have been" -- were a combination of philosophical ideas, elements of communicative style, and common sense. I stand by Herzfeld's Rules in all forms of verbal communication. I write this way. I speak this way. I get annoyed when I hear people violate these rules. Why?

Because we only have so much time in the world, we might as well get right to the chase so that we can learn from the core message and then live our lives. As John Lennon once said, "life is what we live when we aren't busy doing other things." I believe that the Herzfeld's Rules will make you like your life better. It's the art of cutting down to the very core of social relations: communication that works.

When you are economical in the way that you express yourself, you are optimizing your time to enjoy every lesson that life has to offer. I would like to summarize these in 15 points, here: Don't worry about chronology. Think about the most important idea that you would like to express, and start there. Not many people have time to listen or read through the chronology no matter how important it is.

The technique, then, is to swing back to the chronology (if it's so important) after you have gotten the attention from your audience and not before; Try to start with something related to the subject matter that precedes the conversation. In other words, try to make the narrative relevant to the previous conversation. You don't want to look like a narcissist who only wants to talk about yourself!; The first 15 seconds are the key.

If you can't get your audience to be interested, your communication is no longer effective; "Omit needless words." This is probably William Strunk's most famous lesson to all of us.

Words that can be omitted are not words -- they're redundancies which have no room in an effective conveying of ideas; Be witty but do not overdo it; Don't state the obvious, e.g., "the housing bubble is about to bust -- and if that is the case an economic disaster would seem unavoidable." The idea of an economic disaster is already built into the analytical meaning of "housing bubble"; Don't repeat yourself.

Whenever you need to say "in other words," or "that is to say," you are about to repeat yourself. That said, do repeat yourself to get your message across when you realize that you may not have been as clear as you could have been with the sentence previous uttered; Avoid using idioms of which you are not sure. Idioms may make you look cool but if you don't use them correctly, or at the right moment, or in the right situation, they can be confusing. Be direct.

Try to be clever somewhere else (your chance to do so will come!); Avoid needless adjectives, such as "very," "completely," "awesomely." Use them only

when you know your purpose in using them, e.g., when you want to be strategically sarcastic; Avoid using "actually" -- and never again saying "honestly." Be actual and be honest all the time if you can; Never say "no" right away, even if you think that what you have just heard is not true. Give it some thorough thoughts.

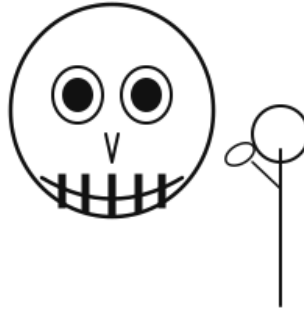
It's both polite and courteous to make sure that your audience know that you are "actually" listening carefully; Avoid, as much as you can, the use of verbal tics -- some single nonsensical words added at the end or the middle of sentences -- such as "like," "sort of," "kind of," "you know," "hmmm," and so on. These verbal tics not only impede your communication but also makes you look like a boring person to listen to; Never, ever, use a rhetorical question. Be direct.

Ask a question whose answer you would like to know; Avoid using metaphors. Again, be direct. Say whatever you want to say. Not everyone has the same understanding of the same metaphor. Use metaphors, though, but only when they are the best way through which you could make your abstract ideas more concrete for the audience to understand.

DAY 67

On Disappointment

Sun, 31 Aug 2025 00:00:00 +0000



WHY, LATELY, I HAVE FELT so beaten up? It's almost as though a number of people have sandbagged me and then put me in a bag before throwing me into the river with a large piece of steel attached to it to make sure that no way I would escape the death penalty. Why?

The best method to answer this question, needless to say, is to ask myself and then look inside my own mind, trying aggressively to find out what has happened in the past few days, weeks, or months. We have a name for this method: introspection. It was the political philosophy Thomas Hobbes who popularized the term.

In *Leviathan* or *The Matter, Forme and Power of a Common Wealth Ecclesiasticall and Civil*, Thomas Hobbes argues that the only way to arrive at the best system of governance is by introspecting: What is it that we want the most from the government? Is it wealth or happiness? Or, it is a constant pleasure? Hobbes argues that it's none of these. What we want the most -- which is the reason, as he has famously said, "why else would we lock our doors at night?" -- is safety.

Therefore, for Hobbes, the role of the government is to provide safety at all cost. What about ourselves, then? The key to introspection is to be reflexive

and objective. Being honest about oneself is the only way. When you're looking inside your own mind, you don't need to pretend that other people are watching. You can honestly ask yourself what exactly has made you feel the way you feel. Often, those things are not the things conventionally acceptable by the society.

It could be your excessive (and most of the time illicit) sexual drive; it could be your aggression against the religious establishment. Or, it could be how you feel so uncomfortable about something simply because we're lacking in words to describe all the discomforts. Most of the time, it's easy to tell ourselves a lie when we feel this kind of discomfort. It's even easier to blame your emotional discomfort on others: that it isn't you where the problem lies.

Once and for all, let's get this right: there is only one cause of an emotional discomfort, and that is our expectation. I like reading Hobbes but I must also accept that I have not read him thoroughly enough to discuss with rigor how he frames his use of the term introspection. The way I see it is that it has to do with the mismatch between what we expect and what we are getting.

You might say, at this point, though, that "sometimes I didn't even expect anything but I'd still feel the emotional discomfort." That's true; yet, what is likely to be the case is that we "subconsciously" something without even knowing it. We might subconsciously expect a bigger or a more expensive gift from someone because the gift we have given to that someone earlier was big.

But once you've found that what's in the box is small, it's hard to think of such a disappointment as simply the encounter with an unexpected. It's a disappointment, and it usually shows, because you have an expectation of what you would like to get whether or not such expectation was clear to you. I felt deeply sad when my father, someone so important to me and someone who I didn't expect to leave me so quickly, passed away. Did I consciously not wantibg him to die?

Of course I didn't want him to die. It's because he's important to me. Love is another thing -- maybe the worst thing out there to talk about expectation and most of us' failure to deal with our inability to arrive at a good compromise when the expectation is not met. Heartbreaking, that is to say, is nothing less than a solid mismatch of expectation. We usually think of a divorce, or a falling out between two people, as a state of incompatibility. It's not and it's never about incompatibility.

It only is the state of incompatibility only when you think of yourself as having done everything right, and other having done everything wrong. Love dies when your expectation is not met. For instance, Tony, a friend whose life story I had mentioned in a couple of posts ago, had fallen out of love with his partner because his expectation was not met. He expected her to be understanding, to give him an unconditional support and love, and to be there when he wanted her.

Tony had framed these expectations as "minimal" for a relationship and he could well be right, but the fact that matter was that his way of understanding of unconditional support and love was different from those of his ex-partner. She also had her own understanding of these; so, it's not possible for them to be together which was not because they were compatible, but because they expected someone else totally different and they could not discuss those differences in their expectations. Tony was disappointed because he had expected too much.

I think he was a perfect match with his ex-partner. They liked similar things. They shared the same interest in many activities. The only thing that was "incompatible" between them was their expectations. I was disappointed too, about love, because I used to expect too much. I wanted I was disappointed too, about love, because I used to expect too much. Once upon a time, I thought I had met the love of my life, but that relationship did not last long at all. Here're the reasons.

I used to want someone to want me unconditionally -- but that wasn't her goal in being in a relationship with me. All she wanted was someone to love

her unconditionally -- but only when she needed it. She didn't want me to love her to the point that I would try to protect her from herself.

Also, while I wanted her to reciprocate my unconditional love by giving me the benefit of the doubt whenever something might not seem right to her urgent emotionality in the moment, she saw my expectation as unrealistic because she did not think I wanted that. I thought she liked me because I was critical, but it turned out that was not the case at all: She didn't want anything critical from me but a pat in the back, always. These were unfortunate mismatches in our expectations.

So, here is the takeaway message: If you don't want to be disappointed, don't expect too much from anyone (including yourself) and from anything. Lord Buddha had said this more than two millennia ago. The only way to be content with life is to not expecting life to give you what you "think" you need.

Some of what people "think" they need, as Lord Buddha had pointed out, are unrealistic, such as wanting someone to be with you all the time, to love you no matter what, to have the best of everything and anything, and to live a fulfilling life without any efforts to fulfil it meaningfully. Lord Buddha's suggestion may be too radical and too difficult to implement in real life. The French Enlightenment thinker Jean-Jacques Rousseau, meanwhile, has a better suggestion that is, in fact, along the same line as Lord Buddha's.

Rousseau's idea is that the root of our desire for external objects (e.g., clothes, cars, jewelry) is the creation of an artificial superstructure that the people in power produce to keep those in a socio-economically inferior position in a perpetual stage of poverty. We don't and never ever need any of these, Rousseau has argued centuries ago (I'll return to this point in my next post on my take on the new -- and the only way of a good life -- thinking about life: minimalism).

The same goes with the notion of romantic love and family. Karl Marx, adding to Rousseau's claim, argues that we "love" because the powerful and

economically superior people want us to think that it's a "good thing to love." By "wanting to love," we are reproducing more and more laborers to serve the economically powerful (God damn bastards, aren't they) -- and therefore chaining ourselves to the perpetual chains of inescapable slavery. We are worse than slaves, Marx argues, because we can't emancipate from this slavery.

As waged laborers, we have to get up to work -- because of our love for our spouse, parents, and kids. We work long hours to pay bills because we feel as though there's an aura of actuality that makes us feel that we do so because we are responsible for other the lives of those whom we think we love. According to Rousseau, those whom he calls the "noble savages" are the ones who are free from all of these superstructures.

They're freer than we are, and they're happier than we are, claims Rousseau. This superstructure makes the inferior class desire what they do not need. By constantly creating a series of unnecessary desires, the superior class is essentially putting the inferior class to work in pursuing desires that can never be completely fulfilled. Members of the inferior class are made slaves to the superfluous needs that the rich have created to keep them in check. We have too much and too high expectations and that is not natural.

It's by design. So, the takeaway, again, here: Don't expect too much from anyone and about anything. Most of our desires are not that necessary anyway, so why expect them? Why want them?

post Day 68: A Minimalist (or -ism) Manifesto Mon, 01 Sep 2025 00:00:00 +0000 Why all the sudden am I becoming a "minimalist?" (At least I'm hoping to become one). For one I am moving out of the city that I have been living in for three years and I cannot possibly take all my belongings that I have mindlessly accumulated over the past three years with me.

So, I am becoming a minimalist not only to manage my expectations and objects that I own but also to keep track of what "realistically" and practically matters to me. The real reason, however, is that I have recently realized,

thanks to many of the failed relationship I have had with people, that the more doesn't mean the better. The more expectations you have, often, the more disappointments to which they lead.

There is a cost for maintaining everything, whether that be the financial cost or the cost of opportunity; say, how many great opportunities you have missed by keeping an unworthy person in your life? I have stuff kept in a storage that I have been paying money to rent, and I have never gone back to take them out and use them. I'm sure I'm not the only one who is doing this.

But since I have accumulated so much in that storage room, it's impossible to go there and to spend days sorting out what are there and what are there that are worth keeping and what are not.

It's like a lost and sunk cost which I will have to continue to pay until that one day (when I don't have a full-time job anymore, perhaps) during which I could and would have the time to go through my stuff and find the way to throw some of them away, once and for all. The same principle also applies to talking. Most of the problems we have, make no mistake about it, are results of ineffective communication.

Hence, the more we talk, the more we tend to make some kinds of mistakes that would make other misinterpret your intention, your point, your stance and things and therefore misunderstand you. So, it's better to keep everything in life to just a "bare minimum." Identifying what are not meaningful to your life, and what kinds of people are too selfish, sociopathic, and superficial will help you make a decision.

This blog post is timely one because the trend of being a minimalist is picking up steam, especially in Japan where not being a minimalist can cost you your life. In the country constantly hit by an earthquake, the more stuff that you own, you riskier for you to be buried under them when your house collapses because of when the earthquake strikes. Take this Japanese minimalist for example: Take Fumio Sasaki, for example (pictured below).

The 36-year-old book editor lives in a single-room apartment in Tokyo with three shirts, four pairs of pants, four pairs of socks, and a few other belongings. He wasn't always like this. The transformation to minimalism occurred two years ago, when Sasaki grew tired of trying to keep up with trends and maintaining his collections of books, CDs, and DVDs. He got rid of it all, which he says isn't as difficult as it seems, thanks to the sharing economy.

My suggestion is: Think minimalist; do it now and do it fast. You can't afford to wait to be a minimalist. Once you have started to look around you, carefully, you'll see that there are so many things, people, and matters that are extraneous to your life. They not only weigh you down but also hold you back. The sooner you can get rid of them, the faster your emotional engine will work at full speed.

I will get to the philosophy behind it at some point in this post, along with some indirect philosophical ideas such as Marie Kondo's *Life-Changing Magic of Tidying Up*. What I want to say right now is that after having done so, quite rigorously, I have never felt better with my life. The trend of "minimalistic living" is not new.

In fact, it's quite old and this blog post is to give the best reasoning (ever, yes, ever) to convince us that going back to those ancient wisdoms might be the way to get out of the troubles we have in the modern era.

While the Japanese and the Daoists are among the best known for this type of living in the east, the famous Cynics in Ancient Greece are the epitome of the so-called "bare minimum life." The Cynics, in fact, have taken the bare life idea to the extreme by famously living in a pot, and only wrapping themselves with used cloths that other people did not need. The Theravada Buddhist monks, in essence, are supposed to have done the same.

These monks, in fact, are supposed to reuse the cloths wrapped around corpses in preparing for the cremation (once the bodies are unwrapped for the preparation for the cremation, the monks can take the clothes and re-use

them as their clothing fabric), as, that way the monks are truly re-using both of form and essence of life.

The idea behind it is simple: The more things, relationships, and commitments that are floating around your life without any purposes, the more you're likely to be drawn away from understanding your true needs. The political philosopher Thomas Hobbes has made these belonging essential to his doctrine. According to Hobbes, we "lock our door at night" because we are afraid of people coming to you house and taking your properties, and hurting you in order to take your belongings.

Well, if you live like a Cynics, a Daoist, or a Buddhist monk, the chances that you won't have anything valuable that anyone would ever want to take from you is probably quite high. So, you'll a much better sense of your life and a peace of mind. As I have discussed, also, in my previous post, we don't need a lot of things to have a decent life.

All these desires -- for the tasty, beautiful, and lustful things -- are temptations to divert our attention from the reality; to make us not living in the moment. When you are not living in the moment, it might be sound to say that you might not be living at all. In the words of the talented John Lennon, "life is what we live when we are not busy doing other things." That is to say, these unnecessary things are, essentially, distractions.

Tasty food distracts you from the essence of food which is nutrition. Beauty distracts you from the essence of relationship which is compassion. Money distracts you from what you really want which is a healthy life that provides you with the ample ground to thrive for the betterment th society. You get the idea. I personally disdain the sweet desert, beautiful faces and bodies (especially cosmetic), and money, for that reason.

Think of yourself, for instance, opening a closet just to find out that you have more than ten sets of dresses of shirts from which to choose. You're likely to spend a lot it time finding the right match for the day. Sometimes, you might even antagonize over the abundance of choices. Most of the time, that is to

say, the more doesn't lead to better time management. Truth be told: the more sometimes doesn't lead to the effective pairing of clothes neither.

This conundrum is precisely what leads many people living in the contemporary society to think, "wouldn't it be nice if there is only one 'perfect' dress or shirt in the closet instead of ten?" This notion of, what the renowned psychologist Barry Schwartz calls, "the paradox of choice" is the emotional underpinning of the real need to cut down on unnecessary consumption.

This very idea can be related to the notion of constructed desire that I have discussed in the previous post (just to recap here: we have so many desires that are given to us by the society). The idea of having "a closet full of dresses or shirts," for example, is also one of those constructed desires.

The society, by ways of consumerism, wants us to consume, consume, and consume, by shaming us to believe that wearing the same dress or shirt every day is a symbol of economic lack, anachronism, and the shortage of financial capital to pursue a variety of available forms of aesthetic representations. But why should that matter? Even in the innovation field, the idea of going out there to learn to live like the "not have" could essentially become a true source of innovation.

In the book *The Ten Faces of Innovation*, Tom Kelly of IDEO, a world-renowned creative consultancy, writes about how IDEO has been able to come up with so many cutting edge ideas simply by taking away the luxury of life. It's easy to not seeing any problems when you are surrounded by objects that are providing you with convenience. "Try to live without a computer for one day and you'll realize that there're many other ways to receiving news," Kelly writes. That's true.

It's very unlikely for anyone to be able to think about anything creative if being surrounded only be convenience. There would no discontents to think about, no problems to solve, and no design questions to tackle. Innovation is about creating something that is new and effective -- and innovators usually

think about something new and innovative when they have to live with the old objects/ideas/services by which they feel discontent.

In my own experience of working as an architect, the best way to learn what is needed to be built is to live like the people for whom we're building. For instance, when we're building a housing community in a remote area, we'd decided to spend two weeks with the local, living like them to understand their basic needs. In that community, the locals didn't have running water and electricity, so they're living a very different kind of life to which I was acquainted.

It's a minimalism from a different perspective. The locals got up in the morning when the sun came up and did everything for which they needed the power of the sun to do before going to bed once the sun had come down. This way of life got me thinking about the design that would fit their needs and benefit them rather than me because, at the end of the day, they're the ones who would be living in the architecture that I would create.

"Scarcity is the mother of all innovation," Tom Kelly has provided an example: To create something new, you may have to take something away. For example, MTV does what they call "deprivation studies," where they get their most frequent viewers to go "cold turkey" (the abrupt and complete stopping) for thirty days of no MTV, just to see what clever alternatives they come up with. So try your own version of scarcity. That is, want to learn about sustainable food consumption?

Try to limit yourself to a small budget per day for food and you'll realize your physical need and the value of money that could fulfill such need. Want to learn about the importance of physical communication? Try to live without a cellphone for a week would do the trick. "Not having enough makes you realize not only the beauty of what you already have, but also the problems that you can use design thinking to tackle," Kelly writes.

He calls those who are good at "doing more with less" (whom I'd call "minimalists") "hurdlers," as they love to turn lemons into lemonade. "Give

them a constraint, a tight deadline, a small budget, and they're likely to excel," Kelly also writes. I am determined, in the next 3 weeks, to get rid of 90% of "stuff" in my current room, and two-thirds of people with whom I no longer want to be in touch.

I am also determined to let go of the collections of feelings that are hurting my soul -- the feeling of having a burden of having to care for others who do not care about me, as well as the weight of having to maintain relationships with are no longer fruitful. I believe that this would be a solid step toward a "bare minimum life," in which I could eventually get to live it.

[gallery ids="4997,4996,4995" type="rectangular"] Let me end this post with the best description of minimalism by no one else except the legendary fictional detective Sherlock Holmes in Sir Arthur Conan Doyle's first book *A Study in Scarlet* where Holmes responded the following to his pal Watson when asked what does Holmes' understanding of what he thinks he needs to know: I consider that a man's brain originally is like a little empty attic, and you have to stock it with such furniture as you choose.

A fool takes in all the lumber of every sort that he comes across, so that the knowledge which might be useful to him gets crowded out, or at best is jumbled up with a lot of other things so that he has a difficulty in laying his hands upon it. Now the skilful workman is very careful indeed as to what he takes into his brain-attic.

He will have nothing but the tools which may help him in doing his work, but of these he has a large assortment, and all in the most perfect order. It is a mistake to think that that little room has elastic walls and can distend to any extent. Depend upon it there comes a time when for every addition of knowledge you forget something that you knew before. It is of the highest importance, therefore, not to have useless facts elbowing out the useful ones.

post Day 69: The Herzfeld's Rules Part 2 Tue, 02 Sep 2025 00:00:00 +0000 In this post, I'd like to introduce some more titbits of the Herzfeld's Rules. I have learned over the years from the man himself that some of these

mistakes do have an impact on how you are perceived by your colleagues and superiors. As one anonymous person once said: "Grammar is what about knowing the difference between your shit and you're shit." I could not agree more.

In fact, also over the years, I have learned the joy of learning about grammar, especially syntax or the arrangement of words and phrases to create well-formed sentences. Syntax, a topic elaborated in beautiful and great detail by the linguist Noam Chomsky in the classic *Syntactic Structure* (published in 1957), is definitely a topic that I would like to write more about, but it's a topic for another time. I'd like to suggest, in this post, an additional 12 easy-to-remember and easy-to-practice rules. Now, let's get right into it.

First (and just that, not Firstly) when you feel the urge of using "scare quotes," (or "air quotes" when you make a gesture with your fingers in the air as though there's a pair of quotation marks around the word you're saying) ask yourself: do you really "need" it? Scare quotes could mislead your readers to think that you are being sarcastic when you might just well be honest. Over the years, I have seen excessive uses of scare quotes.

#It's #almost #as #annoying #as #seeing #excessive #use #of #hashtags (#). Only use scare quotes when you want to draw attention to an inaccurate use of a word, or when you are quoting someone directly. Scare quotes, in these two cases, indicates the idea that you are being sarcastic, or that which is not your words. You'd absolutely need it when you are quoting an offensive term used by others to tell your audience that it isn't you who had said it.

The misuse of scare quotes could easily lead to your audience thinking of you as being uncertain about the complexity of the meaning of the world around which you put the scare quotes, and, the worst of all, being "simple-minded" for not knowing that doing so could lessen the credential of your claim. By the way, you should know by now that the scare quotes around "simple-minded" aren't actually needed. Second, use "due to" only as an adjective and not as a conjunction.

So, "it was due to the rain that I come late" and not "it came late due to the rain." In the second example, use "because" (a beautiful and probably the most useful conjunction) or "owing to." This is not a matter only obsessed with by a grammarian, but a matter that those with the astute logic of the sequence of actions could make use of in making their expression clearer and, usually, more meaningful. Third: This is one of my favorite: Fewer/less.

Although many grammarians have all agreed that we could be chilled out about this -- both works as long as the core of the message about the quantity is clear -- it's still good to be able to know the distinction between these two adjectives. Why? Because it had made Stannis Baratheon "the One True King"!

Yes, I am talking about (**spoiler alert for those who have not seen but planned to see Game of Thrones -- skip this part immediately; knowing the difference between fewer and less doesn't worth being spoiled of the joy of watching the show uncontaminated). What's the fuzz here? Educated people (like Stannis) would know that we must use the determiner fewer, not less, with numbers of individual items or people.

So, yes, he's right to correct Yarwyck that the correct locution was "fewer enemies" and not "less enemies" -- because it's about the numbers of the individuals to be killed rather than a group of an uncountable noun for which less is appropriate.

For instance, "less than £200," "less than 700 tonnes of oil," "less than a third," and "less than 5 minutes," because, according to The Economist's Style Guide, "these are measured quantities or proportions, not individual items." Fourth, avoid saying "of course" and "needless to say" when you are not sure that everyone would agree with that you that there's no other way of thinking about it. It's better to not use them altogether.

Usually, the proper use of them is when you need to occasionally give your prose a personal tone. Fifth, indecisive singular gendered pronouns are ugly. In the words of the great anthropologist Sir Edmund Leach writes in his

classic Social Anthropology published in 1982: Humankind is male/female, betwixt and between. However, the English language faily consistently treats "unmarked" nouns as male rather than female.

Ordinarily this does not matter but a male anthropologist, writing in the 1980, risks his neck with feminist colleagues if he implies, even by oversight, that either the anthropological observer or the individual who is observed is more likely to be male than female. But I must risk it A text which is excessively littered with "he(she)," "him(her)," expressions becomes unreable. And anyway, why not "she(he)?" I fairly stick to male pronouns for unmarked category nouns. I should not on that account be rated as a male chauvinist pig.

It's also violating Bill Strunk's "omit needless words" rule. I am talking about the use of "he or she," "him or her" and "his or hers" in a sentence. Turn them into a plural pronoun.

So, instead of "each student needs to think about his or her need," instead say "students need to think about their needs." If you absolutely need to use a gendered pronoun, the rule of thumb is to use the male pronoun for a neutral matter (or whatever you are not sure of whether or not it is a good or bad thing), so "each student needs to think independently about his individual and personal need." And use a female pronoun for the matter that is absolutely more good than bad; for instance, "a great philosopher is consistent with her own words." It has recently been acceptable to use "they" as a singular generic personal pronoun, although it may seem a bit counterintuitive as "they," as we all know, is a plural pronoun.

So, the advice given by Grammar Girl (my frequent source of knowledge about the topic and one of my favorite podcasts) is to use "he or she" if you want to play it safe, or use "they" -- if you feel bold and are prepared to defend yourself. Sixth, try to not putting anything between the "to" and the verb that follows.

The fancy name for this verb form is "infinitive." We use this kind of verb form all the time, such as "to go," "to play," "to drink," and so on. If you have an adverb that you would like to put before the verb (which, commonsensically, is the most appropriate place to place an adverb) put them after the verb instead.

So, instead of "to actively play soccer," instead say "to play soccer actively." Many grammarians and language specialists have debunked that this act of "splitting infinitive" is not a crime and the original of the myth that infinitive shall never be splitter comes from the mistranslation of a Latin grammar rule into that of the English language, i.e., verbs in Latin are all one word so by default one can never split an infinite in Latin.

Avoiding placing anything before the verb helps to remind the reader what is it that they are being told, as sometimes the adverb can be very long, such as, "I like to occasionally and sometimes thoughtlessly though not that intentionally play soccer." By the time one gets to the verb play, the meaning of this sentence has already been lost. Seventh, avoid using a foreign word when an English word can do the job -- and 99% of the time that which is the case.

It just gives the sense of pomposity. So, say "blank slate" instead of "a tabula rasa." Say "masterpiece," and not "magnum opus." Say "existing condition," and not "status quo." Eighth, avoid using idioms that you do not know the origin of -- because sometimes people can be sensitive about it. It's easy to hear something that sounds "kind of cool" from the television and want to use it in real life right away. Look it up first, and make sure that you really know what it means.

I have met a number of people who use "lo and behold" in lieu of "surprisingly," which is the opposite meaning of it. Someone I happen to know use "if you're up for it" as lieu of "if you would like to" without knowing that the former implies, also, a challenging tone which is not her intention. Ninth, "like," in addition to being a verb (as in "I like soccer") and a noun (as in "the like") is a preposition and not a conjunction.

So, "I feel like having a drink now" is wrong because a proposition can only govern (be followed by) a noun; hence, instead, say "I feel like drinking" (or "I feel as though I'd like to have a drink now").

"Drinking" here is a grammatical element that looks like a participle (a word formed from a verb, such as running, jumping, standing) but is actually a noun (surprise), so "drinking" -- and an act concerning how a person take a liquid into the mouth and swallow) is a noun and therefore can be governed by the preposition "like." Most of the time "as though" and "as if" are interchangeable, so you could substitute them to give your prose a variety.

That said, "I want to have a drink now" might also do the trick. Many are saying "like" all the time these days without knowing what its linguistic function is (especially teenagers). We would call this wrong use of "like" a verbal tic. (if you don't remember what it is anymore, please visit the Herzfeld's Rule Part 1). Tenth, still on the common mistake with gerunds.

"Gerunds are nouns" -- say this mantra as many as times as it'd take for it to wrap around your nervous system -- and therefore should never be preceded by a personal pronoun. For instance, "I was awoken by him snoring" is wrong, and it should be "I was awoken by his snoring." Eleventh, think twice before using "zombie nouns." The linguist Helen Sword has coined the term to explain the kind of nouns formed from other parts of speech.

In *The Sense of Style: The Thinking Person's Guide to Writing in the 21st Century*, Stephen Pinker explains: " The nominalization rule takes a perfectly spry verb and embalms it into a lifeless noun by adding a suffix like -ance, -ment, -ation, or -ing." For instance, instead of "he intensifies the situation," writers who use zombie nouns would instead write "there is a manifestation of the intensification of the situation. "This way of turning parts of speech into nouns has a linguistic jargon: the nominalization.

Helen Sword writes: Academics love using zombie nouns; so do lawyers, bureaucrats and business writers. I call them "zombie nouns" because they cannibalize active verbs, suck the lifeblood from adjectives and substitute

abstract entities for human beings. That's pretty damn harsh! In *The Sense of Style* (again, one of my favorite book): Stephen Pinker is no less harsh: Zombie nouns lumber across the scene without a conscious agent directing their motion.²¹ They can turn prose into a night of the living dead.

Don't let nouns like that sucking lifeblood from adjectives! So, instead of thinking nominalized nouns, think what exactly you would like to say. It may seem cooler to say "my current introspection of my physicality is imposing a sanction on the optimization of my verbalization of contestation, than simply "I'm too hungry to say anything now," but we all know which one better convey the message.

As Bill Strunk (again) has reminded us: "Write with nouns and verbs." Finally, Restrain yourself from the temptation to write long sentences and from using "weak verbs": Think of Ernest Hemingway and his writing style. What makes it so profound is that, first, his sentences are always short. And how do you make short sentences meaningful? Hemingway also has an answer for you: Think active verbs that connect the subject with the rest of the sentence.

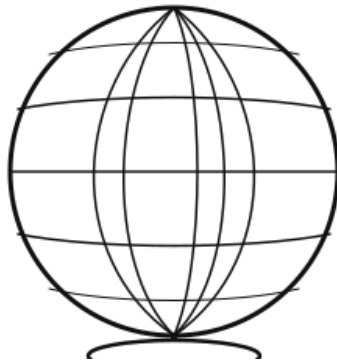
Is/am/are is a weak verb because it doesn't say much about the action that the subject is engaging let alone how such an action affects the situation. Psychological speaking, as Steven Pinker has pointed out, we have a limited cognitive capacity to understand the linearity of the contents provided to us in a form of verbal communication. The more you remove the main idea from the subject, the less likely your audience will get the gist of what you are trying to convey.

The weaker the verb that you use, the more likely your audience will misinterpret your meaning. For instance, "an old man lives by the sea" is better than "there is an old man whose life and livelihood is depending on his residing by the seaside, therefore he is living close to the sea." All for now, have a great (for some, the rest of the) weekend, guys!

DAY 70

A Nonism Dictionary

Wed, 03 Sep 2025 00:00:00 +0000



GENERAL ABSTENTION FROM ACTIVITIES AND substances regarded as damaging to one's health or well-being. The above is a dictionary definition of the term "non-ism." I, in fact, did not know about the existence of this term until a few years back when my colleague asked me whether or not my name had anything to do with the doctrine. Well, it's a surprise so I looked it up and found that the etymology of term had to do with the Latin word "non," meaning not (surprise, surprise).

So, non-ism is, in essence, minimalism (those who have read my post on minimalism would probably understand this right away). I like the term "non-ism" for two reasons: My name is in it (duh), and that I think it's the way of life by which from this very day I would like to live my life.

Let me be "super" honest with you here (despite the fact that I am always honest with you), the original idea of this post is simply to lay out some of my thoughts in an aphoristic way (for those who may have forgotten what aphorism means; it means an expressive and poetic observation that contains a general truth).

But then as I'd gotten myself on the plane my seatbelt fasten, I had felt as though, physically and emotionally, I was not going anywhere for a while;

hence, something in the back of my head was pushing me to think beyond writing a few aphorisms to writing a post that lays out, in its entirety, concepts that matter to me.

I then thought to myself, these concepts, then, should have an umbrella; and what would be a better conceptual container of the many different concepts I was about to write than an "-ism?" So, here you are, a lite version of my conceptual dictionary. Architecture: A profession whose primary concern lies in the thinking, planning, and building of humanistic built environment for all, or an edifice that combines such humanistic sense with the understanding of the laws of nature and their phenomenon.

Anthropology: A useless field of study if one is to study it with the sole purpose of preaching it to others, but the most useful form of liberal knowledge if one is to study to enhance "how to be a human" in a society all thanks to its primary concern on how we human beings are more similar than we think. Anthropology#2: "A comparative study of common sense." -- Michael Herzfeld Argument: An exchange of diverging or opposite views that could end with an agreement to disagree.

Anxiety: What you cannot avoid when coming to terms with yourself. Be: The marker of existence that should -- and must always -- precedes essence. Belief: An unfortunate result of an often irrational thought process commonly known as a "leap of faith." City: A physical place where strangers have to try to live together without killing each other. Communication: The only thing that which must be effective because the failure to do so is the true cause of almost all problems we have in the world.

Critical Thinking: Often an oxymoron since the only acceptable form of thinking is that of critical (also see Thinking). Culture: A practice of everyday life that has been repeated so much by a community that it has become both a sensible norm by which the members of such community would like to live their life and sensuality of which those same members would like to make sense of their life -- regardless of whether or not they know the origins (often multiple) of such practice.

Design: The process with which all great works and everything that is truly meaningful to our existence begin. Education: One highly flawed way of getting anyone to learn anything, but, alas, is still one of the few reliable solutions to the problems that we are facing in the world today. English: The language that one should pretend to use when getting any forms of services in China to avoid being treated like shit.

Enlightenment: "Man and mankind emerge from their own self-imposed immaturity." — Immanuel Kant Expectation: The one and only true cause of disappointment. Existentialism: An admirable way of life focusing on being aware of the strange nature of "conventions" around us and true to oneself by letting your existence precedes the socially-prescribed "conventional" essence. Freedom: The ability to act by your own moral codes.

God: Often a symbolic entity we human beings create to conveniently explain things for which we do not necessarily want to go through the difficulty to find out the answer. Grammar: "The difference between knowing your shit and knowing you're shit." — Anonymous. Humility: Often the best mechanism in protecting yourself against senseless attacks.

Harvard: A for-profit company in Massachusetts that is authorized by law to act as a single entity that thinks of itself as an educational institution designed for learning named after a square in the city in which it is located. Idiosyncrasy: A mode of behavior seen by the society as peculiar to an individual but is not, in any ways, harmful to the society. Joke: A thing that someone says to cause amusement or laughter because there is some truth in it.

Knowledge: A body of ideas that personally matter to you. If it doesn't matter to you that way, it's just data. Law: A form of distant control mechanism that has the aura of actuality in preventing human beings from directly killing each other but does not necessarily prevent them from doing so indirectly.

Liberalism: An ideology building on the false belief that human beings can be good to one another if each of them is driven solely by his or her own

(broadly and vaguely defined) self-interests. Life: A biological process that is a reverse of hiccup that, spoiler alert, always end in death and for which there is no cure.

Life is like a reverse of a hiccup because, while a hiccup only goes away when you stop thinking about it, you will never get to live a life if you keep thinking about how to live it. Life#2: "What we live when you are not busy doing something else." -- John Lennon Love: "Something I would do anything for except THAT (whatever that is)." -- Meat Loaf. Men: Often used as a euphemism for jerks who misleadingly believe in the false sense of masculinity expressed through violence.

Money: What we want to think is a means of happiness when most of the time it leads to the opposite. Marriage: The one and only true cause of divorce, and "the main cause for two people to be disgusted by each other." — Arthur Schopenhauer Minimalism: The way of life whose underlining idea is to cut the lost cost concerning how we human beings tend to be easily distracted to spend time on things that do not really matter to the productive development of our existence.

Morality: The one thing about which none of us should try to too hard to be creative or unique. Nation: A community whose members must, in order to survive, remind themselves to believe in the constructed sense of unity despite the obvious differences among them. Neoliberalism: An idea based on the belief that removing "as long as you don't hurt other people" from the idea of "you can do whatever you want" would lead to a better society.

In other words, it's a system of belief of sociopaths (Also see Sociopaths). Non-Action: The way of life preached in the Taoist doctrine in which the practitioners believe in doing nothing in order to leave nothing undone. Old: In humans, it refers to having the characteristics or showing the signs of age because of the consumption of food and water, and the breathing of the air.

Passion: "The driver of reason; without which there would be nothing to drive the reason alone to act." — David Hume Ph.D.: An academic degree that

consumes years of life and often ends in unemployment. Philosophy: The practice of, through careful and rigorous reasoning, not taking everything around you as "had been that way, is that way, and will always be that way." PQIRST: Not an acronym and simply a string of consecutive alphabets that means nothing to no one else but Michael Herzfeld and Cristina Paul.

Poetics: Something that so dearly resonates with our inner consciousness -- to the point that we would break rules to achieve. Pollution: "A substance or thing that understood to be harmful or having poisonous effects because they are understood as not belonging there -- rather than their actual harmful or poisonous effects." -- Mary Douglas Power: What we human beings want to possess in order to compensate for the lack of sex. Property: A burden that is often being misunderstood as a possession.

Rights: Something morally intrinsic to an individual that I would fight to the death to protect even if it's not my own. Ritual: The process by which meanings are systematically ascribed to the meaningless so that some people could feel as though their lives actually have a meaning. Religion: A system of faith believed by many to provide normative guidances for those who want to live in the world with a purpose, and a pathological treatment for which rationality as such cannot provide.

Religion#2: "What distracts the poor from the real cause of the problems and therefore keeps the poor from mass murdering that cause, which is the rich." -- (a paraphrase of) Napoleon Bonaparte and Karl Marx Research: An excuse that by saying you have done it prior to taking an action may help in preventing yourself from being blamed if the consequence of such action is not the undeniable one.

Self: What we would like to think that we have in order to have an excuse to possess other things (if you don't even have the self, why would you want to possess anything else?) Sex: The most overrated mundane activity that most of us human beings cannot suppress the need to engage therefore want to learn more about how to better engage, but at the same time always feel pressured to pretend to not wanting to. Society: An epitome of a structure in

which individuals are contained.

Shanghai: A city known as the largest training ground for neoliberalism (also see Neoliberalism). Sleep: The state to which we exhaust our body to get back daily. Sociopaths: What most of us are when we do not think or think but not care about the consequences of our action that we will not directly feel. Suicide: The most preventable form of death.

Suicide#2: "The most important philosophical question: To exist or to not exist in the world." — Albert Camus STDs: Sexually transmitted diseases, among which life itself is the most preventable. Time: The solution of 99% of the non-physical problems. Thinking: Where skepticism and open-mindedness overlap. Utopia: My place because it means, in Greek, a "non-place." Get it? Women: The one true cause of tears -- as in the song "No Women No Cry" by the reggae legend Bob Marley.

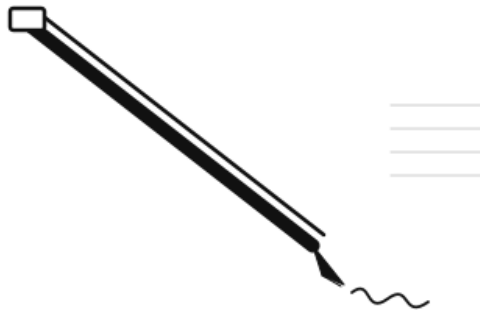
Xenophobia: A symptom expressed in the intense dislike or fear of people from other places often as a result of a problematic anxiety that one is having with oneself.

Yet: An adverb that I always add to the end of the sentence when responding to a question concerning my current inability to do things that I see benefitting to my personal improvement and therefore want to happen in the future, such as "I don't speak Japanese — yet." Zen: The way of life focusing on the inner health by reducing worries brought about by the external possessions and desires that are extraneous to us. We should have another celebration for reaching, alas, Day 70!

DAY 71

How to Change the World Part 1

Thu, 04 Sep 2025 00:00:00 +0000



I KNOW. I KNOW. IT'S been a while since my last post. Apologies for those who may have been waiting for a new post. It hasn't been easy moving from one place to the other, leaving an old job for a new job, and so on. But I am back!

Although I can't promise (not even to myself) that I would be updating my blog as frequently as I may want, I will try my best to keep up with the requests on the topics and ideas about which you would like to see my writing. More than anything else, it's embarrassing that I have not been able to complete the "100 days of writing" mission in a year as planned. Well, that's life.

One thing that I know for sure is my own writing style and pace: It's difficult for me to stick to a weekly schedule (although I will try to make it a habit) but whenever I have good ideas to write something about I could go 6-7 hours in a roll just writing one post after another. So, do bare with me. This morning, I got up with some thoughts about what make me who I am.

It could have a been a result of a difficult conversation I had with someone about whom I cared so dearly. That thought, though begun with how a seemingly caring conversation could go so wrong, had eventually led me to my thinking about what could I have done to change the situation. About a

decade ago, I have set the goal in life to not chase after money or fame, but after things that would give me the total feeling of contentment with my life.

I had come to the realization that I could live a good anonymous life with subsistent- leveled income (seriously, I have tried it). The possession of too much money and fame violates both the principles of minimalism and nonism (about which I had discussed also in this blog).

One of the way to feel content with my life, to me, is to thinking constantly about a social engineering program that would make everyone turn inward to introspect the need of their inner self, rather than what they "think they need" as a result of the society's telling them what to do through peer pressure. I have, then, come to realize that two of the root causes of the problems we have in the world today are miscommunication and illogical thinking.

These two factors constitute about 50% each for all the problems we have in the world today. My argument is simple: we could live in a much better world if we can solve these two problems. I am determined to dedicate the rest of my life of solving these two problems. This blog post, however, is dedicated to discussing the first problem only. I promise that I'll write more in my next post about the power of logic as the way to combat logical thinking.

Why do people fail to communicate? As many philosophers, linguists, and thinkers have reminded us, our thought process is often both intertwined and non-linear. The problem we have with the verbal language is, then, that it forces us to communicate our thoughts through the non-intertwined and linear system. In other words, language always simplifies our thoughts.

And it's also true that language constraints thoughts (i.e., what linguists call Sapir-Whorf Hypothesis): We cannot possibly conceive any complicated matters without having the language as a system to connect the strings of words to make sense of our own thoughts, as a lens through which one could see the layout of our own idea, and finally as a tool by which one can construct a meaningful thought process.

For example, when we think of anything that we may want, the essential pronoun "I" appears in your thought process, e.g., "I want that," and "I need that." The verbs that follow -- want and need -- are essential elements in the process of putting words in a string so that you could communicate your idea, first to yourself, and then to others by demanding or requesting that they'd provide you with what you "need" or "want." In other words, we need the "I" to be there as a conscious marker of our desire to construct a meaning that underpins our egotistical and, even, our biological needs.

Most of the time, the subject + verb construction is followed either by an object or a conjunction; for instance, "I want water because I am thirsty." Can you give me an answer of why you're reading this blog post right now without thinking in terms of language? Can you answer me this question without using any nouns, pronouns, verbs, and adjectives? We think with words. We need words to think.

Your brain is always going and it's estimated that we say between 300 - 1,000 words to ourselves per minute. That is, we need language to think, and the limitation of our vocabulary is also the limitation on how effective we are in putting our thoughts into comprehensible strings of words. The trouble with language is no picnic. You may have witnessed people who were talking about the same things but could not come to a conclusion that they did.

You may have seen people who loved each other to death but their relationship ceases to continue to exist because they were not able to communicate their love in the way acceptable to the other person. A classic case: You may have heard how people get upset about how they think the other person has a view on things that were "too simplistic." True, it's may often the case that "that someone" may have a simplistic view on things. But most of the time, I believe, it's not just that.

To me, nothing is that simplistic. Even when we want it to be so, unfortunately, what constitutes our "view on things" are our experience, upbringing, education, and so on. So, even on things about which we feel absolutely sure, they are often, if not always, an exception. Why is that? --

Because our thoughts are way more complicated than the ability of languages to communicate them (well, some languages may do a better job in conveying the subtlety of the ideas, but that's a topic for another post).

First, the language we know doesn't do justice to our thoughts. Second, we think that something sounds "simplistic to us" owing to the fact that our brains, for the same reason as in why we couldn't put complicated thoughts into words, are often hostile toward strings of words that are too complicated. So, we tend to be more receptive, rather, to simple prose.

But we are also hostile to simplicity because we are living in the world in which simplicity as such could induce misunderstanding, violence, racism, and other forms of discrimination; hence, we human beings are often caught in the middle: While we may want to communicate our true ideas, we are also not very receptive to complicated strings of words.

The result is that we don't get the full meaning of other's ideas because the corporeal limit to how much a non-intertwined and linear expression of the strings of words could make you absorb all the meanings. A classic case: You may have heard how people get upset about how they think the other person has a view on things that were "too simplistic." True, it's may often the case that "that someone" may have a simplistic view on things.

But most of the time, I believe, it's not just that. To me, nothing is that simplistic. Even when we want it to be so, unfortunately, what constitutes our "view on things" are our experience, upbringing, education, and so on.

So, even on things about which we feel absolutely sure, they are often, if not always, an exception, as in "I hate XXX but I would accept it if there's YYY involved." What's the meaning of "hate" (a dictionary definition: feel intense or passionate dislike for someone or something) then if an exception can be hate? I used to think that many people have simplistic ideas because they're incapable of seeing all dimensions of the problems or situations.

But most of the time, as I have been taught in my training as a linguistic anthropologist, we tend to think that something sounds simplistic simply

because the message that we receive is linear and non-intertwined, hence leaving out many of the important messages. The absence of those messages that did not make the cut is what make us feel as though such message is not as comprehensible as it should or could be.

So, as an anthropologist, I have learned to overcome this particular prejudice against something that may sound, when I first hear them, simplistic. Over time, I have become much more sensitive to those "messages that did not make the cut." What are the core ideas of those messages that have been intentionally left out owing to the inability of the language to convey all of them and still stay meaningful and understandable?

Our brains are hostile toward something that is too complicated and tend to be more receptive, rather, to simplicity. But we wouldn't need language if we are only to communicate simplicity. We need language because we need to communicate with other human beings more than just the information regarding our biological needs. We think something is simplistic because of language, by nature, suppresses the full thought to convey.

The linear and non-intertwined nature expressed through a string of words that we utter to communicate ideas often fails to convey our comprehensive ideas to others. People usually either hear what they want to hear (because our brains love to take the meaning simplistically) or do not have the patience for complicated thoughts carried through the lumping together of a complicated set of strings of words put together. What we have left here is miscommunication.

In the perfect world, each of us would take, as the most important goal in life, the learning of how to communicate with others with precision, brevity, and respect, holding to heart the sincere goal of benefitting everyone engaging in the conversation. In the perfect world, intentional ridiculing of others and the failure to listen would be considered impolite and outlawed. In the perfect world, we would have all the time and patience to pay attention to each other. Unfortunately, we are not living in that world.

We're living in the world full of strangers (especially those living in cities). We're living in the world in which we deal with different sets of interest. We're living in the world that urges us to protect our own right to be individual and egotistical rather than give other people the benefit of the doubt. The problem gets worse when we also deal with translation from the one language to the other. You get the point.

This was the whole premise of my writing about the Herzfeld's Rules (both Part 1 and Part 2 are available on this blog). I believe that changing the world isn't that difficult -- as we can eliminate almost 50% of the problems we have in the world today by our becoming better communicators who communicate to get the true points across and not to ridicule your counterpart or to show off that you happen to know what they do not know.

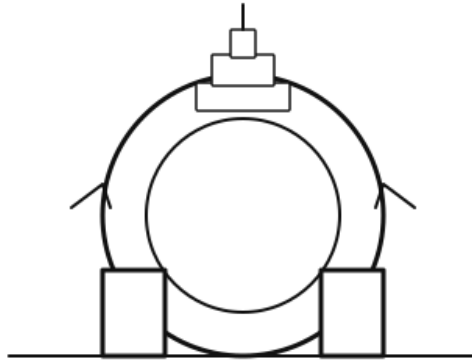
Even if becoming a better communicator doesn't change the world, it would change your life. It would make your life easier and better. The conversation I had with this person that I care so much about broke down half way because this person did not understand any of the "logical processes" behind the norm of communication as I have described here.

This person got mad at me by the message this person had heard only half-way, misunderstood my message by this person's own problem with the comprehension of the nuances of language (as, unfortunately, English was neither of ours mother tongue although I had written elsewhere that this shouldn't matter much), and got disappointed by this person's own ability to understand my intention altogether.

I could only feel sorry for this person, and this is why I would like to address the second factor through which we could change the world -- logical thinking -- by the power of logic, which is the topic of my next post.

DAY 72

The Power of Logic (How to Change the World Part 2)

Fri, 05 Sep 2025 00:00:00 +0000

I HAVE TWO STORIES TO tell. All of which speak to one central theme: The power of logic is limitless. Let's begin. One: Hot Pot One afternoon I checked myself into a restaurant serving buffet lunch. It's a traditional-styled Chinese hot-pot. For those who have no idea what a hot pot is, it's a traditional Asian cooking method. They call it *huoguo* in China, *shabu-shabu* in Japan, and *suki* in Thailand.

The differences between these are not that noticeable and mostly due to the ingredients particular to the certain geographical location. So, the one that I was eating was *suki* since it was in Bangkok. There's a pot of simmering broth in the middle of the table, and around which are plates of meat and vegetables. All you have to do is to dip them into the broth and cook them.

It's the best meal to be consumed with a lot of people: Because of the sharing nature of the meal, the more people is the merrier. There're many styles of hot-pot meals. My favorite is the Chongqing-styled, in which the broth consists mainly of Sichuan peppercorns and other mouth-numbing ingredients. It's the spiciest of all (and yes, spicy food is good for you according to Harvard T.H. Chan School of Public Health).

Unfortunately, I was in Bangkok so the broth was not Chongqing-styled but rather typical chicken broth (which wasn't the problem because I had a bowl of chili and pepper sauce in front of me). I was at the restaurant alone that day.

It was on a weekday which might explain why there weren't so many people there; hence, I was receiving all the attention from the waiters and waitresses who would have to do the work in bringing whatever I was ordering to my table so that I could dump them into my pot to cook and then eat. Ok, enough about the hot-pot. What happened next was just overwhelmingly puzzling. Starting from around noon to 4pm I didn't leave my seat at that restaurant. I was constantly eating, eating, and eating.

The waiters and waitresses had to keep bringing me food.

"One more plate of squids, please," "More bok-choy (Chinese cabbage)," "Yes, I would like more broth, please," "Can I have more chili sauce?" "Two more plates of beef and lamp, please," "One more glass of Coke here," "A seafood platter followed by a bowl of udon (Japanese thick noodle)." No matter how many plates were put in front of me, I would slowly but steadily take whatever were in those plates, dipped them slowly and gently in the boiling broth with my chopsticks, pulled them out of the boiling broth once cooked, dipped them gently in the super-spicy garlic pepper sauce that I had made for myself by mixing four types of sauces on top of a pile of minced garlic, and then put them in my mouth so that I could chew, swallow, and let them eventually run down my throat thanks to the force of gravity.

The waiters and waitresses were amazed by how much I could consume, although I must not be the first customer whom they had seen to be eating this much given that the restaurant was, alas, serving a buffet lunch. After 4 hours had passed, I was still eating. Crossing into the 5th hour, I still felt as though I hadn't had enough food.

Because the waiters and waitresses had always taken the empty plates away right after I had finished them, I did not have a physical evidence of how

much food I had consumed: By my own estimates, it must have been at least 10 kilograms already (more than 20 pounds). But I still felt as though I could eat more. What happened to me? That was when the logic kicked in. I stopped eating and started thinking.

"Wait a minute, I have never eaten this much before....and why am I still not full after 4 hours of eating constantly, and alone?" It's said to be true that you could eat much more when you're eating with friends and family but that wasn't the case there. How much can a person really eat in a meal, especially someone with a normal Body Mass Index (BMI) like myself (which was 23.5 at the time; those whose BMI are over 25 are those considered heavy)? I began to think deeply.

The waiters and waitresses were not surprised after five minutes of my not pausing. They were, nonetheless, still there standing in the distance and in the corner looking at me, who was then the only customer in the restaurant. I suspected that they would like to be ready in the case I would like more food to be served, or to get a check.

The deeper I think, the more I felt as though "nothing was making any sense" and for the following reasons: In general, I don't eat that much. I like to eat, but I don't eat that much. I am not a foodie. I just enjoy eating to live and not living to eat, which has always been the main reason why I don't usually do well at a buffet.

My body just can't take that much food -- and why was I eating so much today?; It didn't make sense for a restaurant to allow me to stay and eat for as long as I pleased. Wouldn't it be more sensible for the restaurant to restrict the amount of time one could sit down to consume food to 1-2 hours maximum? It's been almost 5 hours and I must have eaten half of whatever they had in the entire restaurant already!; How did I get here?

It's a weekday and I had a job, what on earth was I doing in a buffet restaurant in the middle of the day, by myself, eating like that? This doesn't make any sense!!!! That's the moment I woke up. Yes, I woke up from the

dream. Surrounding me was nothing but a bunch of pillows my legs. The thickest pillow was lying on my stomach with my hands embracing it from below.

I hadn't had food for dinner the day before so I must have gone to bed with an empty stomach. It's not logical to be a human who could eat without being full, and to continue to be in that state knowing that which is not real. Hence, I woke up from my dream by the power of logic. Two: Cigarettes I had quit smoking almost 4 years ago now -- after about 5 years of being a chain smoker.

I didn't start smoking until I had finished my first master's degree, during which I had been bombarded with many problems in love, life, and work.

It's to the point that I had decided to join the "smoking corner club" at work in order to find understanding friends with whom I could share my difficulties, and through our collective one-cigarette-every-hour rituals that I could spend time thinking more carefully about my situation thanks to the rhythmic breathing that the act of smoking gave me (if you don't breath rhythmically when smoking you'll choke).

I was addicted to not only the taste of the cigarettes ("nicotine sort of helped clear my mind," I felt then) but also the effect that whatever substances inside of the cigarettes had done to me, and, most importantly I think, the sense of community among the fellow chain smokers that I had acquired through becoming one of them. Growing up, I had asthma. I remember well the instances during which my mother had to carry me to the emergency room because I had a hard time breathing.

Smoking cigarettes, needless to say, only made it worse. My body, furthermore, simply absorbed every negative effect of smoking. I lost so much weight over those 5 years of smoking, to the point that everyone thought I was perpetually sick. I had bad breath. I had bad teeth. I lost a lot of hair and that small amount of hair that I still had left smelled bad almost all the time because of the smell from smoking. I caught a cold very easily and I

had contracted flu quite frequently.

When I got sick, my body recovered very slow. I also became an alcoholic because, as one European classmate at Oxford who introduced me to drinking and smoking said to me, "nothing feels better than when you're drinkin' and smokin', mate." I had become a very unattractive person because I would need to smoke almost every half an hour or less. I could not pay attention to a long lecture. A long meeting -- and a long flight -- from which I could not leave was nothing but a nightmare.

What's the worst? Well, my sexual pleasure also massively deteriorated. I might never have been a "superman" in terms of sex but after I became addicted to smoking I had become, simply, sloppy. I could feel that I had become much less, and almost zero, active in terms of sexuality. Although I didn't have a complete erectile dysfunction (must have been close though), I recognized that my sexual pleasure was extremely short not matter how wonderful the woman with whom I was engaging in the intercourse was.

With what was happening with my manhood of which I had always been proud, I felt that this wasn't just the decay of the mind but the decay of the soul, altogether. Was the only two pleasure I got from smoking? Funny enough, even after two master's degrees from two of the world's top universities in hand, I still thought that it was worth it. It wasn't the case that I didn't try to quit smoking.

I had tried many times and I had used many methods, such as chewing both normal and nicotine gum, reducing the amount, exercising, etc. I tried every possible method. I even consulted a medical service at then my university to help me with the problem. I would quit for a day or two and I would return to smoking again in no time. The worst part of it was when my father unexpectedly passed away in 2010.

Even though I knew that what killed him, partly, was cigarettes that he smoked in a large amount during the first two quarters of his adulthood, I still couldn't let go of cigarettes. Ironically, as a person who always told

others that my father was the person I loved the most, I couldn't let go of what killed him. The year was 2012 and I was in Beijing then for a summer language program.

I was smoking a local cigarette called Panda at the window of my room on the 13th floor of a foreign student dormitory. Cigarettes, of course, weren't permitted anywhere in the building but I was smoking them every day anyway because I was a chain smoker. Then I had a moment. I remember that I was sitting at the bottom frame of that small window to the large and open empty field below. I was reading a self-help book and was inspired by every word of it.

As I was looking the ashes falling down to the ground below, I had an epiphany: "What am I doing?" It was that moment that I was able to come to terms with myself: I suddenly realized that in order to do those great things in the self-help book I was reading, I would first need a healthy body.

"And why am I smoking this thing?" "It doesn't even feel good." That was the moment that the power of logic kicked in which helped me realized that the reasons I had been coughing every since I landed in Beijing might due to both my excessive smoking and the rising level of air pollution.

"Yes, I have been coughing every day -- in the class and outside of the class -- I am feeling so disgusted by myself!" Finally, "I couldn't even breath properly because of the air pollution, why am I smoking this shit??" It's simply not logical for me to still be smoking. And that was it. I stopped smoking half way and threw that cigarette away -- together with the rest of the pack.

In that moment, I didn't think about the future (as in, I wouldn't have a healthy life 10 years from now I'd still be smoking then) or the past (as in, it's what killed my father). I was just thinking about the present: "Why am I doing this illogical thing?" I never return to smoking ever again after that incident. That was the moment I realized that I must have been a rational thinker.

The power of will didn't help me quit smoking (I tried and failed) but the power of reason and logic did. It's not logical to want to live a good life and continue to smoke. That said, am I missing smoking? Yes, I always have a dream about myself smoking with friends. So, if dreams represent my subconscious as Sigmund Freud believes, I must not have been so happy with quitting cigarettes.

That said, I wouldn't mind my dreams being my "smoking room." So, what's the moral of these two stories? I believe that it has to do with the way we human beings need to think for ourselves, in the present, about how we would like to live our life. We have the gift (or the curse depending on how you look at it) to be able to exercise our ability to think, rationalize, reason, and make a logical decision. The key is to use that ability.

The power of logic has changed my life. These two stories are just examples of many stories that I have regarding how I had removed bad habits from my life, how I restrained myself from plunging into the wilderness of auto-piloting attitude (especially when it comes to sexual desire), how I turned problems into critical tests for myself, and how I saw opportunities in the challenges with which I had faced, to name just a few. If I can do it, you can do it too.

Believe it or not, we all have the ability to use logic to live a better life.

Here're the 4 key takeaways: Sometimes the will alone cannot save you from yourself, but the power of logically will; "The unexamined life is not worth living." One encountering a problem that gives you sense that there is a deeply embedded sense of cognitive dissonance (i.e., you know that it is not right but you'd still want to do it), do take a step back, instead of move forward, and carefully scrutinize the problem.

This is along the same line as Malcolm Gladwell's suggestion when facing a problem of auto-acceleration when driving in his podcast which I highly recommend to everyone; As mentioned in my last post on communication, the attempt to change the world must begin with ourselves. We can do it by

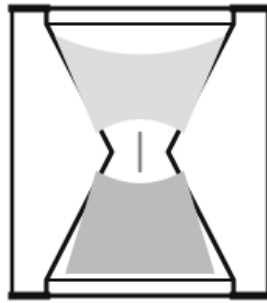
putting the dignity of being a human being at the center of your logical processing, as in, we are thinking human beings who possess the ability to think for ourselves -- hence, use logic to think for ourselves.

In the first story, I got out of my dream by exercising my logical thinking. In the second story, I use the same logic to confine my self-destructive behavior to the dream so that it would not affect my corporeal life.

DAY 73

Six Basic Human Needs

Sat, 06 Sep 2025 00:00:00 +0000



WHILE I WAS ON THE treadmill yesterday, I listened to Tony Robbins' podcast episode called "Six Basic Human Needs." For those who don't know who he is, Tony Robbins is one of the world's most famous inspirational speakers, business, and personal coaches, and gurus in self-improvement. He appeared in one of my favorite movies of all time *Shallow Hal*, featuring Jack Black and Gwyneth Paltrow.

Robbins' Ted Talk "Why We Do What We Do" is number six in the top ten most watched and listened to Ted Talk of all time! His podcast had gotten me thinking about myself. Before we're going to that, let's talk about what's Robbins' "Six Basic Human Needs." Although he sometimes calls them interchangeably as "things," they're not really things (as in objects). He wasn't talking about food, houses, cars, or luxury watches. Sure, we need them (especially food) but they are varied across cultures.

Robbins was talking about the "true needs as social beings." They are six "qualities" that fulfill the main purposes that we have to live our lives in the society. To Robbins, these six needs are universal. He also extends his argument to say that the secret to understanding your business counterparts, partners, customers, and so on, is to understand the importance of these six basic needs in their lives. What are they?: Certainty,

uncertainty (variety), significance and recognition, love and connection, growth, and contribution.

Okay, after spending an hour listening to it, I felt that this was awesome. I felt that all of these qualifies make perfect sense to me. In addition to the fact that what brought Tony Robbins to come to this conclusion about these six needs was his 30-year-long research on human beings with whom he had interacted regularly in his line of work, he's also such an inspiring speaker. No wonder people pay a lot of money to his event! Ok, back to his points.

Let me try to summarize all of these points in a #nonphilosophy way. We all want a secure job and sometimes hostile to change because "certainty" is what underpins our sense of the continuity -- that our livelihood would continue into the future. That said, if everything is all about certainty, we would be bored to death; and that's why we would like some "uncertainties," challenges, surprises (that we want), and a wide variety of experience from time to time.

There's an episode of Freakonomics Radio that I had also just listened to that talked about boredom as one of those things that everyone, even the unproductive people loathed. Yet, having job stability and variety in life isn't enough to most of us. We want to be different, to be unique, to have the "significance" in the society in which we live.

This is the need that Robbins argue to underpin the reason why human beings often go out of our ways to search for money and fame, to the point that, as Dalai Lama has remarked, "Man surprised me most about humanity because he sacrifices his health in order to make money; then he sacrifices money to recuperate his health." But all in all, we want to be able to connect intimately with another human being.

There are things that money and fame cannot always buy, and that is the unconditional love and connection with another human being(s). Beyond that, as a species, we need to develop ourselves in order to survive, and that's where the need for "growth" comes in, which eventually leads to how we

think about the growth of another human being through our hard-wired ability to sympathize.

We want to "contribute," because life is about creating meaning which does not often come from what you get but from what you give, including good news to share with your loved ones and things or money you give it away to those who need them.

The best way to summarize this notion of contribution would be in the words of William Shakespeare himself: "The purpose of life is to discover your gift; the meaning of life is to give your gift away." You could discover your gifts by finding the certainty in your career, or by shaking things around by facing occasional uncertainties, or by finding what makes you special, or by finding the right person with whom you could connect, or by developing yourself -- but at the end of the day, if you don't find the way to give those gifts away, you'd be imbued with the sense of unfulfilling because there's a limit to all of the above qualities without your knowing that your life also means something to other people.

So, those are Robbins' "Six Basic Human Needs" in a nutshell. So, here's what I really want to write about today, which is my take on these six basic human needs. I agree with Robbins, in principle, that the secret to any productive relationship is the reciprocity between the counterparts in understanding how each ranks these six qualities. You are not going to go well trying to befriend someone who unconditionally believes in challenges by giving him the sense of certainty and vice versa.

Personally, I rank the following: Contribution; Love and connection; Growth; and, Uncertainty. As for the other two qualities - certainty and significance - I don't find them to be important in the way I live my life. Let's go through them one by one. 1) Certainty. I think the only thing that is certain about certainty is the fact that we are made to believe that which can be certain.

I believe that Jean-Jacque Rousseau was right when he made an argument a few centuries ago that the sense of certainty, whether through job security,

marriage, or commitment to a certain system of belief, is what the upper-class elites has created to keep the lower- class workers in check. By doing so, the upper-class elites provide the reason for the lower-class to continue to be aspired to want what they don't need.

Take job security for instance, what's so secure about working long hour on a manual labor every day making money for the upper-class who is benefitting from your labor? Wouldn't it be better if we're all living in nature, catching our own fish and planting our own vegetables, so that we could spend time with the people whom we love, with the hobbies that we like, and the with the ideas that we cherish?

The upper-class elites have created the system that makes us feel as though we need to get a job, work hard, and pay bills so that we could forever be slaves for their service. What's certain about that kind of certainty is the chain around our hands and legs. I also think "certainty" is an enemy of growth.

There're so many brilliant people (some of whom I know) who had stopped working after they're certain about their "secure job." For instance, there's a professor whom I dearly love who has basically stopped working and doing anything academically meaningful after he had received his tenure -- or a lifetime contract to teach -- from his university. "Certainty," in this sense, leads to complacency and eventually to smugness, self- satisfaction, self-congratulation, and self-regard.

In his new mega-hit podcast Revisionist History, Malcolm Gladwell talks about the concept of "generous orthodoxy" or the idea that should one want to follow one own sense of morality -- what one believes to be right from within -- one needs to re-think the role, teaching, and of course, "certainty" associated with the institution that has defined your life. At the end of the day, most of the forms of certainty are associated with conventional institutions which do not change much over time (therefore "orthodox").

The definition of a moral life is the life in which one is determined to be "generous" about being on the side of uncertainty when facing backwardness defined by this conventionalism. I highly recommend that you listen to an entire podcast (there are 10 episodes in general) -- especially this episode! So, certainty is not always good.

This was the secret reason why I like Don Draper in the first three seasons of the TV series *Mad Men* so much -- he refused all attempts to get him to sign any permanent employment contracts because he believes that once he's settled he's done as an advertising genius. 2) Uncertainty: Ok. this is where I tend to agree with my friend Tony Robbins.

In fact, I think the reason behind people's interest in traveling (which is the umbrella of today's largest global economic activities) as the German philosopher Johann Wolfgang von Goethe, once said was to find new experiences in unfamiliar places, just so that the productive uncertainty would be experienced. To me, personally, challenges and variety are one main quality that urges me to still want to get up in the morning.

Although I hate surprises in general (like, when my brother sent me a message that my father has just passed away) it would be boring if everything is so certain. I like the fact that there'll be new things for me to look for in my email inbox every day. There'll be challenging problems for me to solve on a daily basis. And that there'll be things that my ability to help to contribute, either to help alleviate or improve, would be appreciated.

Because I do not care about getting recognized for any of the achievements but will take full responsibilities for the failure should it help to teach the public a lesson, I feel that my love for uncertainty is intrinsic and is not determined by the outcome. In other words, uncertainty is what I want my life to be challenged with because I believe that which is helpful to my ability to live like a human being who is principled yet flexible, and idealist yet practical.

3) Significance and recognition: I personally think that this is the quality that shall be suppressed. As I have written about, half of the problems we have in the world have to do with miscommunication. And guess what? Those miscommunications are often, if not always, results of one party wanting to be recognized rather than communicating the message.

I have encountered many instances that the communication broke down because one party did not want to accept any messages that weren't implying that which party was "doing the right thing," or "operate with a good intention," or "should be rewarded," and, the very worst, "so right that this conversation should not even take place at all." I think Robbins is absolute right that many people want to be recognized and that we should understand this fact in order to make the world a better place through giving these people what they want, namely recognition, but I also I think that we should also try to push it one step further: To teach the world that the need for recognition is a root cause of many problems.

Recognition is purely symbolic, and many philosophers including the ancient Taoist master Laozi had reminded us more than two millenniums ago (he's a contemporary of Socrates) that the more we try to be symbolically recognized something, the more we will lose the grip on what we think it is. This is simply because symbolic objects, thoughts, or qualities cannot be held constant. They change all the time -- I mean, literally all the time (and this idea is vivid also in the writing of David Hume about the self).

An attempt to recognizing something symbolic is the same as an attempt to recognize the quality of the water in the creek. The moment you want to recognize how clean and clear the water is, that water whose quality you want to recognize is already running down the stream and the water in front of you is no longer the same water whose quality you want to recognize.

You can only compare the general idea of it -- the general cleanness and clearness of the water in the creek -- which cannot be held constant. As in a person, the moment you want to recognize the quality of yourself, you are no longer the same person whose quality you want to recognize. In my earlier

post " 16 things I never have," I wrote about how I have never won any competitions nor received any awards in my life.

One of the reasons for my seemingly unrewarding life is the fact that I rarely apply, self-nominate, or get myself involved in anything that would lead to an official recognition. I just want to add my personal story here. Our brain consists of about 100 billion (100,000,000,000) neurons, which are specialized cells transmitting nerve impulses (also known as a nerve cell). Hey, those are about ten times more than the population of the world today. What if my life is just one of those 10 billion neurons in someone's brain?

I mean, what if everything I have done in life with the hope to leave the mark on this world for people to think of me is just an attempt of a neuron of a person's brain. And that person is just a person in a world of billions of people. In other words, what all of this -- what we know as life -- is just a joke?

This feeling scares me because it would mean that there is no meaning in any of this thing we call life whatsoever. In order to deal with this feeling, we have to think, do, and act on things as if everything is an end in itself. 4) Love and connection: This is something that is very important to me. Although I think that loneliness is a powerful force in life, I think that a meaningful connection with someone outside of yourself is a true need.

Loneliness is a productive space that sometimes plays a significant role in helping you to grow since coming to terms with yourself -- the person with whom you would be spending most of your time -- is the same as coming to terms with your own reality. Most of the time, although I enjoy spending time with myself, I always enjoy having a fierce critic, a receptive companion, a caring colleague, and a loving family by myself.

I might not completely define love and connection as "needs," as I also believe in a stoic life in which one has to always prepare to be alone and in the state of bare life -- which is the state of life from which we come and at which we will eventually arrive.

In other words, loneliness helps us to come to terms with death so that we won't get so nervous when it's arriving but caring and connection gives us the meaning so that we would want to prolong the state of living as much as we are healthy enough to reciprocate their love and care.

5) Growth: I think it's true that in business, one has to "grow or die." We're happening to be living in the society in which the market not only dominates the way the economy works but also pushes all of us who are in the system to constantly find our comparative advantage so that we don't lose our jobs or opportunities to still be in the system to others -- or to the machines. I don't define growth that rigidly.

I think growth should simply mean "do better than yesterday." There're many ways to do that. As the podcaster Stephen West always says at the end of his podcast Philosophize This!, "thank you for wanting to learn more today than yesterday." I believe that we must learn from the past mistakes whether that be our own or someone else's (in which case, we'd call it "History" -- maybe that's the reason why we should all learn history).

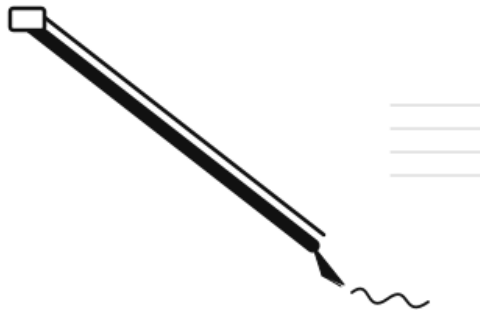
There is no gift from one stranger to the other that is more special than their experience so that we could live a healthier, livelier, and in general, better life. 6) Contribution: This is a topic for a standalone post! For short, contribution -- giving -- is the reason I still want to live in our hectic society and among many people who have views on the world that are very different from mine.

I might not like some of their views, but I deeply believe that we are all intrinsically "good" but what drives us to act in the way that is not always good to others or the environment are either ignorance or wrong incentives. I believe that I could use my skills to improve both conditions: To make people less ignorant and to change their views about incentives. Keeping this blog has been one of the channels through which I try to contribute.

DAY 74

What I Learned Getting Stuck at an Airport for 12 Hours

Sun, 07 Sep 2025 00:00:00 +0000



THIS MIGHT BE A BIT of a surprise to many: How I eventually return to writing this blog again. The truth: I have always been wanting to return to write this blog. It's just that for the past two years since my last post, I have been living a different kind of life -- no longer as a student who had the time to sit down daily and write his thoughts to share, but an employee in a super cut-throat profit-driven field.

I have learned over the past two years since my last post that there is no difference, really, between the business and academic fields when it comes to the cut-throatness. It's all the same. Education, too, is becoming more and more profit driven. I'll leave it at that for now. I'll, at some point, return to share with you my life since September 2016. A lot of things had happened and at one point I almost lost my life. I am sincerely happy to be alive.

So, as the title of this post suggests, I have been at an airport for the past 10 hours and counting. My employer who bought me the tickets, with or without the knowledge of the 12-long-long layover hidden in these tickets, confirmed them with the travel agent before speaking to me whether or not I would be fine with it. Actually, I probably would not mind if I were told that

which would be the case. Caught off guard, I wasn't prepared anything.

I did not have the visa to leave Kiev Airport to see the city; hence, I could only stay in the lounge trying to be as productive as I can. Now, what have I learned during this 10 hours and counting? Let's begin with what I've been doing for the last 10 hours. The first 3 hours were all devoted to catching on sleep. From the fourth hour onward, I have been reading, writing, and listening to a new audible books that I have just downloaded.

The book is *Maps of Meaning: The Architecture of Belief* by Professor Jordan B. Peterson, whose works has become one of the authors that I've become addicted to following. As a clinical psychologist who speaks with the clarity and wit of a philosopher, he reminds me of great minds (and my heroes), Professors Daniel Kahneman and Amos Tversky (I'll also write about these two at some point). In short, Professor Peterson wants us to think clearly using logic and sciences.

He wants us to see the world the way it is -- no matter how discomfort it is for it to be seen that way -- and not the way others try to convince you to see it. Happiness, for instance, should not be the goal of life in Professor Peterson's logic. Happiness should be something that you get out of doing something moral and something right, for which he has created a set of rational thoughts to help us think.

He blatantly criticizes identity politics driven by postmodern and hyper-left activists to be detrimental to the improvement in which we are living. I, in fact, finished his second book *12 Rules for Life: Antidote to Chaos* first. It's a great book which I highly recommend. It's worth it just to study his storytelling technique -- it's a technique of a truly literary genius. It's this book that got me thinking about the resonance between the 12 rules and my 12-hour-long layover.

So, I tried to write one rule that I hold dear in my life for every hour that has passed. Again, I may return to rewrite these at some point too. I am sleepy and fatigue as a result of not having been exposed to any sunlight at all for

the past ten hours trying to breath the limited amount of air available in a badly ventilated airport terminal. Let's start with the first 6 rules for this post: Social proof is dangerous.

We tend to not think too much when following what other people are already or about to be doing. So, don't hang out with selfish people. You will be doing awful thing before you even know it (and worse, sometimes you wouldn't even know that which was bad); Be kind, not right.

It's simply the fact that we do not always know everything that we should know about any particular situation to make an absolutely true judgement; so, based on that, be kind to others and cut our own ignorance some big big slack; Don't confuse what you want with what other people want you to want. In our life, we have our own pace of moving forward.

Just because someone seems to be getting ahead of you doesn't mean that you should always speed up, or worse, get off your own path to compete with that person on his/her path. It's important to define your own path and walk on it.

Freedom, alas, is the ability to set your own path and walk on it without allowing any forms of arousal to distract you from it; Success needs both determination (49%) and luck (51%) — by which I mean the kind of luck that puts you in the right place at the right time.

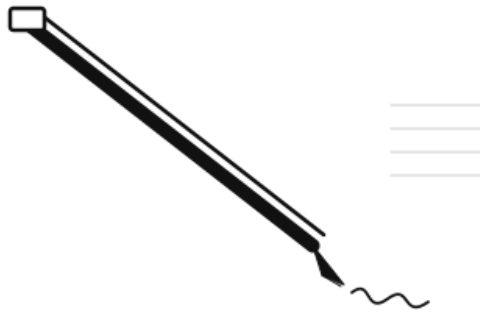
But you first need the determination (AKA will power) — simply because without it, you won't recognise luck when it appears (and you would just be blaming other things or people for your failure); Do not tolerate a bad boss. Bad boss is the parasite and deeply troubled symptom of evolution as a whole. It's a disgrace to our humanities as a whole. If you continue to tolerate and work under them, they will use their power to make you a scapegoat.

Histories have shown that which to always be the case. Do not tolerate bad boss. Call them out. Period; and, Get older and wiser. Now, you are oldest than you have even been. Don't become an old person who nobody wants to see being alive. To be continued to Day 75!

DAY 75

12 Rules for Life

Tue, 09 Sep 2025 00:00:00 +0000



A CONFESSION: I FORGOT TO continue writing this post! Many thanks to a big fan of this blog Bhawara for reminding me that I still owe her (and everyone of you) the last 6 rules. Well, but the fact that I also skipped Day 75 and wrote a new post as Day 76 might be a sign of the fact that I knew that I was about to skip Day 75.

Sigmund Freud would call this process of deliberate forgetting "parapraxis" -- known to most of us as "Freudian slip" (thanks to the latest episode of Malcolm Gladwell's Revisionist History podcast that gives me even deeper insight to what it means). It could be the case that I wasn't ready to write this post, which could be due to the very fact that I really did not have that many rules in life.

I must confess, again, that the idea of "12 rules" wasn't entirely mine and was that of Jordan B. Peterson whose bestseller 12 Rules For Life: An Antidote to Chaos had inspired me to think very differently about me, my life, and my own existence in the world. Dr Peterson is special to me in how he does not simply give in to the nonsense -- and stick to his rules in living a meaningful life. Think about it: What would life be without some, if not all, meaningfulness?

Is there more to the reason for breathing, eating and seeking temporary pleasure. I am not trying here to allude to religiosity (especially Buddhism which is my main moral compass and guiding system of belief; in fact, it this alluding were meant to direct somewhere, it would be more to the philosophy of Stoicism rather than Buddhism). So, to make up for my forgetfulness (please, please, please forgive me), I will reiterate and simplify the first 6 rules before going into the next 6 rules. Like Dr.

Peterson's, these rules are simply "antidotes to chaos." I had failed at all of these rules in the past and the results of such failure were wide ranging: from hurting myself to hurting others, from a small thing that could be fixed to a manmade disaster, and from a trivial human error to a PTSD-like kind of trauma with which I will forever have to live. Human beings evolve because we learn from mistakes of others, not by making those mistakes ourselves.

Can you imagine, if we should experience the biting of a snake before we can learn that which isn't good for us? Well, we would all be dead already. So, learn from my mistakes, please! I have not lived very long but I have seen, experienced, read and studied quite a few things. I will, in this list, try to tell these rules to you in a manner that combines both my limited personal experience with what I have learned from, mainly, other people.

To make this list a bit more useful, I will also add the "practical advise" to the end of each rule to make it easier for you to see how you may think about adopting, or rejecting, some of these rules in your life. Stay away from selfish people. There is a sea of scientific evidence from the field of social psychological to support this rule. The gist of it is that what psychologists call "social proof" is dangerous.

It's true that following others allows us to survive as a species. But that doesn't mean that what a lot of people do is right. Don't do something just because a lot of people do it. A practical advise for this rule: Don't hang out with people who are either selfish or have bad faith. Such selfishness often leads to justifications in engaging in many other things driven by bad faith.

You, too, will be doing awful thing before you even know it -- and worse, sometimes you wouldn't even know that which was bad). In the spirit of design thinking, there is even a saying that to be creative is to be able to think of something as if that something has never been there before. In other words, just because a lot of people use something doesn't mean that there's no better option to that something.

It just means that such option has not yet to be created; Be kind, not right. I myself had been in many situations that I would fight just to "be right" -- about a certain knowledge or moral principle -- just to, later on, lose a friend (or friends), or worse, realize that I was fighting for what I wasn't even sure of. It is the simply the fact that we do not always know everything that we should know about any particular thing or situation.

To make an absolutely true judgement on anything, we're risking making a bad decision. When Steven Jobs tells us to "stay hungry and stay foolish," he's asking us to accept the fact that we can might as well be wrong on just about everything we think we already know well based on whatever reasons we have created for ourselves to believe so.

So, based on that, a practical advise is always be kind to others and cut our own ignorance some big big slack; Live your own life, and not the life others want you to live. In other words, don't confuse "what you want" with "what other people want you to want." In our life, we have our own pace of moving forward.

Just because someone or some people seems to be getting ahead of you doesn't mean that you should always speed up, or worse, get off your own path to compete with that person on his/her path. A practical advise: It's important to define your own path based on what you want to be and what makes you feel content -- and, most importantly, stick to it.

I shall cite one of my favorite thinkers (although I do not always agree with his ideas) Immanuel Kant who writes (and I paraphrase because I am not that good at memorizing the exact quote) that "Freedom, alas, is the ability to set

your own path and walk on it without allowing any forms of arousal to distract you from it"; Don't compete senselessly, but always be ready for challenges.

My mentor MIT Professor Jan Wampler once said to me that, for him, his success is a result of 99% of hardwork on his part, leaving just 1% for his intelligence. I want to revise this formula, success needs both determination (49%) and luck (51%) — by which I mean the kind of luck that puts you in the right place at the right time.

But you first need the determination (AKA will power) — simply because without it, you won't recognize luck when it appears (and you would just be blaming other things or people for your failure). So, a practical advise is: Follow your own path at your own pace, but don't be too complacent and always stay alert and curious for the opportunities, which you will only see them only if you are trained to; Do not tolerate a bad boss.

My father once said that a bad boss is the parasite and deeply troubled symptom of evolution as a whole. It's a disgrace to our humanities as a whole. They are the reason for our transgression. This rule goes hand-in-hand with the first rule, but with a larger impact. If work is what makes us content with life and gives meaning to what we do, you want your work to define who you are -- and you can only do that under a boss whom you respect.

If you continue to tolerate and work under them, they will use their power to make you a scapegoat. Histories have shown that which to always be the case. A practical advise is the same as the rule itself: Do not tolerate bad boss. Call them out. Cut them off, and move on. Period; Get older and wiser. The philosopher Cicero once remarked about the beauty of getting old, and we should all embrace the very same philosophy. Getting old naturally is great!

We become less a slave to our biological desire as we grow old -- please love that feeling! A practical advise is to try to be that old person that younger folks want to come and learn from your embedded and built wisdom, Don't become an old person who nobody wants to see being alive. Now, you are

oldest than you have even been; Do not give a fuck about everything (but give a fuck about something that matters to you).

In *The Subtle Art of Not Giving a F*ck* by the today's most famous successful writer in the world Mark Manson, the author argues that we only have a limited amount of fuck to give in life, so if we give a fuck about everything that comes our way we won't have any of it left to give to what really matters. I first thought that he was apt to say something so true in such a witty way.

Then, I soon realized that what Manson means is based on something much more scientific: According to the principles of cognitive psychology, we have very limited cognitive capacity, so we can't let ourselves be dwelled by all socially-induced thoughts that come our way. You may have heard of how science has shown that we can only keep up with a certain number of people in life, we can only engage in so many multi-tasking responsibilities, and so on.

The same goes with this very key idea about not giving a fuck about what don't matter.

The truth is that we can be almost certain that most of the time we will fail to control what people think about you (what people think about you is in their heads -- not yours!); so the practical advise is to accept such fact that only try your best to engage in what you can control -- your own mind to not giving a fuck too much to too many things of which you are not in a position to be in control; You do not need to have an opinion on everything.

It's true that we tend to want to have an opinion on everything. Why is the desk you're working on your laptop right now not as clean as you want it to be? Why is the cup you're using not as nice as the one you used to hold? Why is the spoon you are using looks so strange?

Why is it that the cover of the book the person sitting across the row from your in orange and not in white (it would be much better if it were to be in white)? Why is the world not going the way you want? You get the point. There're so many things in life that you either 1) Do not have enough

knowledge about to have an opinion?

-- what do you know about the ergonomic design; engineering and building construction; mining, molding, and melting process; and publishing industry and its complicated advertising campaign to know about the design of the desk, cup, spoon and book cover? Even if you happen to be a keen industrial designer who knows everything about a desk, cup, spoon and book cover, you must still be practical and flexible.

I like to live by the wisdom of the economist John Maynard Keynes: "When information changes, change your opinion." Again, not only do we not know everything in the world, but for many things that we think we know there can also be new data, research, information to disprove it; and when that happens those who can adjust will benefit. And, 2) There are so many things in life that do not matter to you at all whether you do or do not have any opinions about them.

Restrain yourself from wanting to show off how much you want other people to think you know by criticizing everything. A practical advise is to look at things the way they are, and appreciate them that way -- if you can; Don't be a victim to your own ability to think about something.

It's a blessing to have a brain to be able to think, but it's also a curse that we tend to focus too much on what we think about while we're thinking about it -- to the point that we often, if not always, miss the point. Confusing? That's intentional by the way. Let me try again.

My favorite thinker Professor Daniel Kahneman once said "Nothing in life is as important as you think it is, while you are thinking about it." What Dani means here is that we tend to fall into the trap of what he calls "focusing illusion." We tend to give too much weight to what we're thinking about -- especially while you are thinking about it. So, a practical advise is whenever you are writing an important email, don't send it after at least 24 hours.

It's backed by science that you are likely no longer wanting to send it after having read it again while you are not "obsessively thinking about it"; Be

distrustful of gossips. People do gossip -- and many argue that it's our nature. That's actually not quite right according to what we know about the science of human's evolution. What's our nature, argued by the literary theorist Jonathan Gottschall, is not gossiping, but telling stories. We love stories.

Gottschall calls humans "storytelling animals." We also tend to like to create stories that are based on something that we are NOT certain about. The anthropologist Michael Herzfeld always tells his audiences that anthropology is the study of gossips, and he is spot on. Myths, ultimately, are forms of gossips speculating how the world was pieced together and how might we -- small people who weren't there when it happened -- deal with our own existence. It's this very ingredient that makes stories interesting, suspenseful, gripping and lovable by readers.

Gossips, in many ways, are "highly entertaining lies" put together with some grains of reality and that's why we love to justify hearing them. Why are gossips so entertaining? First, it's not about you, so it's like watching an intensely drama in the comfort of your own armchair. Second, it promises "exclusiveness," making you feel important to be chosen as the one to whom the intimate story is to be told.

Third, it speaks to what you feel lacking in your life -- in other words, gossips "fill some of the voids of your malignant desire," allowing you to tell yourself that the unsatisfied situation in which you are currently is because of someone else and not because of you. Gossips have so much power to shape our perception on or against someone or something. And many times because we believe gossips, we misjudge people, situation, and things. That's unfair to humanities. In fact, Pope Francis himself said something extremely similar.

He, in fact, compares gossips to "bombs," and people who gossip to "terrorists." What the Pope said encompasses all the three aforementioned points of why gossips are, in this sense, sinful: "Because gossip is like a bomb. One throws it, it causes destruction and you walk away tranquilly." Some

even go as far as to say that, even though stories are fun to learn, we are most peaceful and content with life when we don't make up stories in our head.

Buddhism monks choose to chant lines from ancient scriptures that they are not fully understand so that they can stay away from making up stories. That's the only way to be calm. I personally stop people from telling me gossips. A practical advise here is simple: Resist the temptation to make up a story that you do not have any solid "court case" kind of evidence to back it up; and, even easier, stay away from listening to any of it.

There's a lot of scientific evidence in Steven Pinker's new book that the quality of your life once you have disengage yourself from the availability of an unevenly distributed but highly entertaining fabricated information.

Or if you don't trust Professor Pinker, you could perhaps trust the Pope when he said "No gossip -- and know that the best remedy against gossip is to bite your tongue" What's the point of being a terrorist who carries a bomb with you wherever you go?; Don't attach yourself to an image of anything -- even if that thing used to be what you most revere and respect. In my very own religion Buddhism, any forms of attachment is a source of suffering. Like people, things change.

When time changes, things also change with it. I used to get so upset over the fact that someone I once loved no longer loved me, to the point that I was almost driven to a complete self-destruction. It's until I realized that I was too attached -- not to this lover -- but the image of her that I wanted to stay permanently, disregarding the fact that she must grow, change, and become whoever she wanted to be in life.

So, this kind of attachment not only disrespects the nature of our universe (AKA the fact that time does exist) but also disregard the individual's right to change his/her self image. This also applies to your own self image. How do you think you could freeze that despite your becoming older daily as well as the circumstances surrounding such change? Come on, dude: don't be a jerk

and be respectful. A practical advise?

Do thank the owner of the restaurant you have been going to for years for keeping the restaurant open even if the food is no longer as good as it was. If the owner asks you why you thank him/her, tell him/her that you have detached yourself from the curiously delicious image of the food that the restaurant once served. LOL and kidding. Just say thank you again; and, finally the last rule, Don't try to change the world -- try to change yourself.

A while ago I wrote a personal memoir in a form of a meme to myself that "I do not want to compete with anyone, and all I want is to be better than yesterday." In design thinking, we like to think that we can "prototype" our life simply by eliminating what we no longer want in our life (e.g., smoking, drinking) when we get up in the morning and trying the live that life for a week.

If it works out just fine, the prototype works and we can go on living our life based on it. If it doesn't, then we go back to see what can be fixed, tweaked or re-booted in order to achieve the goal. Dr Peterson provides something quite similar in one of his 12 rules: "Rule 6: Set your house in perfect order before you criticize the world." Actually, I would go as far as to never try to criticize the world.

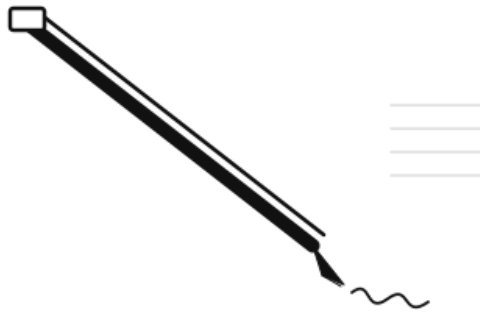
The world will change when you change the way you view it -- with a clearer mind of a constantly prototyping life. Up to this point, now I know why Dr. Peterson needs to write a book to discuss his 12 rules -- I couldn't easily do the same thing in fact. There're so much to talk about concerning the reason for each of these rules to exist. A practical advise: Life is only meaningful when you see, think, and experience it as fun.

So, try to get up in the morning knowing what you want to do on that very day and, don't be too greedy, try to live one day at a time.

DAY 76

On Design Thinking Part 1: The Gist

Mon, 08 Sep 2025 00:00:00 +0000



(PLEASE SKIP THIS PARAGRAPH TO the next if you are a first-time visitor to this blog. This first paragraph is going to be all about my confessions and apologies to the die-hard readers, especially those who're kind enough to subscribe to it. So, yes, I have been rather lame. I thought I could get back to writing again after my last post Day 75, after getting stuck at an airport's terminal for 12 hours. Since then, I have been busy again and not been able to get back to writing.

This post is something that I have been wanting to write for the past few months. That said, the good news is that I now feel inspired again. Guess what? Now I have a book to which I am looking forward; this blog is going to become alive again!).

Over the past two years, I have been giving lectures, workshops, seminars and talks on a goal- inspired multidisciplinary creative process known to many as "design thinking." In this post, I want to summarize the three key points of what I think design thinking entails, produces, and, most importantly, is. This blog is the beginning of, hopefully, a long term and consistent commitment on my part to keep up with this blog. Man, I have to, at least, get to the 100th day as the name of the blog entails!

I will. That's not even a question, now that I have a much firmer ground of what I want to write about over the next couple of months. It's one thing: design thinking. It's the topic that I have been investing most of my waking hours thinking, musing, and writing about. I have been approached by, and for which I have been grateful to, a few top publishers in China who reveal to me that there "isn't any good books on the topic of design thinking" in the Chinese market.

I have always believed that China is the most important nation on earth in the present -- and will continue to be so in years to come -- for the reason that whatever it does will have a profound impact and effect on everyone on this planet.

Hence, I feel as though my work (and eventually, at one point this year, a book) will have a small contribution to how China may want to see its development and growth vis-a-vis its responsibility -- ecologically, economically, socioculturally -- as the most important nation on the planet. Over the past two years, also, I have taught more than 60 courses to hundreds of curious learners -- from primary school students to entrepreneurs running companies of millions of dollars (and RMBs) industrial assets.

I have learned so much along this continuing journey. In this first installment of this design thinking threads, I want to talk about something closest to my heart about design thinking: It's three most important principles. There are many versions of and various popular meanings that some have given to the term (in some 40 books and hundreds of blog posts available in the market at the present).

The most important message I have been trying to convey, however, are the following: Design thinking requires a much much "deeper" level of participation (i.e., "Don't just ask what people think they want" principle -- most of us simply can not want what we do not know of; don't you agree?

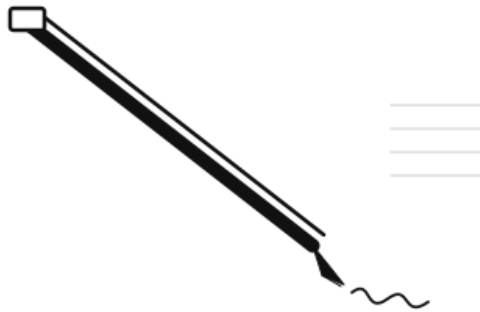
); Design thinking requires us to imagine the world in which any status quo does not exist (i.e., "How would you design something if we had something that has not existed before" principle); and, Design thinking does not always have to require expensive invention (i.e., "Can't use a pen in space? Don't spend money to invent a pen to write in space, just use a pencil" principle). These are the three most basic principles of design thinking. I will continue with the details of these three points in my next post.

To be continued....

DAY 77

Gossiping, or, by Definition, a Crime Against Humanity

Wed, 10 Sep 2025 00:00:00 +0000



I WAS INITIALLY PLANNING TO continue the writing of my newest series on design thinking, of which the first part had been written as the Day 76 post. I, however, have been engaging in many meaningful discussions with friends, colleagues, and guests of this blog who were highly entertained by my last post on the 12 rules for life, especially on the tenth rule: Be distrustful of gossip.

In fact, I think the name of this tenth rule should be changed to the very title of this post: Gossip is a crime against humanity. Coincidentally, the feeling that this title radiates coincides with Pope Francis' who has recently warned us against both conscious and unconscious engagement in the "terrorism" of gossip. In other words, gossip is murder. I, too, wholeheartedly disdain gossip. It all began when I was young.

My father was a kind man; so it's no surprise that I barely remember a situation in which I was being yelled at by him. Yet, I remember the one and probably the only instance very well. It was because I told him what I thought I knew about my classmate -- gossip about his cheating at an exam. My father immediately asked me, " How did you know for sure that he cheated?

Did you see it yourself?

Did you report it?" My response was clumsy: I told my father that I "didn't actually know." And, in fact, I heard about this cheating from another classmate who was probably told about this cheating by another classmate. That was it for my kindest father: He didn't snap (I would have if I were him, knowing what kind of man he always was) but he said to me: "There's no room for gossip in this house." He went on to talk to me about the destructive power of gossip.

In fact, I remember well how he said: It's your responsibility to report this cheating if you have the evidence that it happens. We do not accuse people without any evidence. On the other hand, if we have the evidence of a crime and don't act, we are no different from being a criminal ourselves. That's why I asked you How did you know for sure that he cheated? Did you see it yourself? Did you report it?

So, like my father, I believe that gossip is a sign of cowardice, immaturity, insecurity, weakness and lack of moral capacity to act on one's own. It's also a sign of envy and unconstructive self-doubt. I'll write more about these unwanted qualities in a person in the later part of this post. If I were to continue with the pontiff's metaphor of terrorism, gossiping is nothing less than throwing a bomb at someone and then walk away with no responsibility (the point which I will get back to later).

Writing this blog post also as a trained anthropologist, however, I also recognize how gossip shed light on the micro politics of the particular community -- which, I would then argue, should not in any way justify the existence of gossip. The anthropologist Michael Herzfeld often says how he sees anthropology as a study of gossips.

He derives this very understanding both from the Greek etymology of the term (*anthrpos* and *logia*) and the social theory of his predecessor the British anthropologist Max Gluckman who partly argues for the legitimacy of the study of gossip and scandal in modern anthropology.

Herzfeld argues that what makes rich ethnography is "when anthropologists are trying to get their informants to get off the stage and whisper all those intimate and slightly disreputable bits of gossip that make good, juicy ethnographic data." That said, there is something quite unsettling about such statement. This is because of my having learned over the years that my informants tend to walk out of a gossipy conversation as much more stressful, angry and aggressive individuals after having gossiping.

Like Gluckman and Herzfeld, I used to believe in gossip as social duty and one should not be stressful, angry and aggressive when engaging in such duty. That said, over the years I have learned that which is not always the case. When two parties were in conflict with one another, despite the power dynamics, things often get solved more effectively when those two parties engage in a direct and transparent and form of nonviolent communication (which I occasionally had the pleasure of moderating).

To me, hearing their gossip feels like my throwing an emotional bomb at them. I would go so far as to say that it's unethical to motivate the informants to engage in gossiping. Why do I insist on a gossip-free ethnography despite the misopportunity to get "juicy ethnographic data? Should we, in the name of knowledge, do everything to get data?

Just because gossip tells anthropologists about the tension between members of a particular community -- and therefore makes "juicy ethnographic data" - - it doesn't mean that these anthropologists have the solid moral ground on which they could build their case in pursuit of knowledge to encourage their informants to engage in the act of terrorism against one another, especially just to "get more juicy ethnographic data." An anthropology colleague summarizes it vividly: Gossip often harbors malicious intent.

Frustration at others can often boil over into anger and malice leading to gossip. Anthropologist should understand frustration, anger and malice, but not encourage it. That is, it would be like getting someone to throw a bomb at each other so that you can, in the name of the benign anatomical science,

study how their bodies disintegrate. There're many other ways that anthropologists can learn about a certain society. In my own anthropological research, I have never sat through a session of gossip.

Well, there might be a few instances or two that my language skill wasn't good enough for me to know whether I was about to be listening to gossip. But when I am fully conscious and in control of the command of the language used in the conversation, I always make sure to my informants that I am only interested in hearing from them their perceived experiences, and not their personal attacks on other people.

Sometimes I let my informants share with me their feeling of discontent (that's why friends are for, isn't it), but it's known among my circle of informants that I would interject with a question "How do you know that?" should the sharing begin to incorporate any forms of gossip. This strategy occasionally urges my informants to re-evaluate their assumption and prejudice.

It's also good for my research to make sure that my informants know that I am not the kind who is fond of gossip -- as those who is fond of gossip tend to judge, take side, and engage in malicious action of coward betrayal. What would your position be in a community that you study if all of your informants think of you as a gossip's collector? In other words, in the language of nonviolent communication, I am only interested in "evaluation-free" prose.

Many might argue that this is not the right way to do ethnography, but I somehow insist on it. I sincerely do not want my view on anyone in the community where I study to be clouded by the personal evaluation of the informants who might like or hate one another. Of course, once the close friendliness with the informants is established, my informants and I are prone to share with each other something deeper information- wise.

They would ask me about my personal life, e.g., my love life and whether or not I am married. My answer would also be evaluation-free, such as, "No, I

don't have a girlfriend." And if they insist on knowing whether there's anyone, I would tell them right away. There's nothing to hide among friends, I believe. That said, I always tell my informants that it's more important for me to learn about what actually has happened or is happening, rather than what they think who did what.

In my research, I have other methodological means, such as participant observation, to understand those without having to resort to gossip. So, it may be true that my ethnographic data is not as "juicy" as it could be. I can live with it. By writing this blog post, I hope to convince you, with all my knowledge, why gossip should have no place in the society in which we are living in today, and why all of our effort would help to make that happen.

I will prove to you that gossip are like bullets from an automatic gun; once you let it be heard by your ears, you will be wounded the same way you let a bullet hit your body. Your judgement will be clouded with biases, which will lead to many decisions that you otherwise would be in a better position to make. P.S.

I was blessed by these amazing readers with a series of thoughtful discussions, especially with the philosopher Dr Mark Calano and a recent graduate and my former student and now a good friend Robert Zajc who, probably, is one of the most curious and remarkable students I have ever had the pleasure of teaching. My mother too contributed quite a few great thoughts during our ride to a shopping mall this morning. So, thank you, Mark, Robert and my dearest mother for inspiring this blog post.

How did it all begin? Humans don't always gossip -- what we always do is telling stories. In a gripping prose, the writer Jonathan Gottschall tells us in his bestseller *The Storytelling Animal: How Stories Make Us Human* about how we have always been prone to create, make up, and piece together stories. "We are wired for stories," said he. Archeological evidence of ancient paintings and scriptures on the wall are evidence of that.

As Gottschall's research shows, we humans make sense of the world by creating stories that are based on something that we are not certain about. Religious myths and stories about the origins of the world, ultimately, are forms of gossip, speculating how the world was put together -- because none of us were there when that happened. Gossips, in many ways, are "unproven speculations" put together based on some grains of possibility observable in real life. That might explain why we love to justify hearing them.

Anthropologists and historians argued that some sort of structure of power emerged and the sense of repression rose at some point in the short history of our existence (compared to that of the universe). Long story short: Those who saw themselves as being in the weaker position began to communicate, among themselves, their anxiety, fear, and discontent toward those whom they saw as being in a superior position. In his best work *Weapons of the Weak: Everyday Forms of Peasant Resistance*, the political scientists James C.

Scott coins the term "weapons of the weak" to describe gossip as one of many weapons used in the manner of "hidden transcripts" by the weaker population against the superior power to whom the the weaker population have no "official" source of gauging and voicing their discontent with each other. Scott argues that "gossip as hidden transcripts" are important because otherwise the individual who sees himself/herself as weak would no clue whether he/she is the only one feeling that way.

So, by gossiping, these individuals get to gauge the landscape of discontent. Most of us must have had this feeling: How many times that we talk to voice our sense of worry to our friends and colleagues when we feel as though we should have been treated better by our boss, teacher, superior -- even though we know that the best way to actually get to know whether that which is the case is to go and speak directly to the boss, teacher, superior?

The argument that Herzfeld's predecessor the anthropologist Max Gluckman has made in his monumental paper "Gossip and Scandal" published in 1963 is similar to mine: Because unlike an open discussion, the closed-circuit nature of gossip create the kind of "exclusiveness" that plays a role both in

indoctrinating a new member to the social group, unite the existing social group, as well as preventing any strangers from the group.

In this sense, it's the weak who needs the function of gossip to stabilize the existence of social group to give them some sense of security. Gossip, on the other hand, also have the function of maintaining the morals, unity, and values of social groups for which those who consider themselves to be more powerful also have an important role to play.

The argument here, however, lies in the idea that those in the powerful position know that the weaker population (which can be those with the younger, new, or those with pre-designated lower tier membership) are aware of their inferior status and is actually more susceptible to "informal activities" that define the unity and membership of the group. These information activities are obviously not written in their job descriptions but are essentially to their not being a victim of vicious gossip.

In any companies, for example, we all know that it is not enough just to be a good employee. In many countries, many employees attend social activities (such as drinking) with their bosses even though they don't have the financial means or time to conveniently do so. Why do they still have to do it?

Because they know that even though their bosses cannot use their absence from these social activities to fire them, they can easily be prejudiced against because of their lack of participation in informal activities that is understood by the norm as uniting and defining the membership of the group. This situation also works sideways among those who are in the same social status but fear of losing such status.

In other words, why do many of us spend money we don't really have to buy things we don't even want just to please those whom we don't even like? Gossip, in this sense, is intentionally created either to: Undermine the authority to which the weak do not have the "formal" power to fight against; and/or, Undermine the power of the weak by the authority who know that the weak tend to believe that they can undermine the authority by using

gossip.

In other words, those who see themselves in an inferior position are also made to believe that they "actually" have the power to undermine the authority while what they are actually doing is to play by the authority's game. The social psychologist Robert B. Cialdini shows in his recent research about the power of publicity that those in the position of power and/or authority actually like those who see themselves in the lower position to gossip about them.

Summarizing in a short quote "There's no such thing as a bad publicity," this principle of, what Cialdini calls, "pre-suasion" plays a role in constantly injecting the image of the authority in the mind of those who think that they could confront them through a back door. In *Pre-Suasion: A Revolutionary Way to Influence and Persuade*, Cialdini summarizes: It's often said that the fate celebrities fear most is to be ignored, forgotten, or otherwise dropped from the cultural consciousness.

Powerful publicity of any sort spares them that worst of all fates because it brings them attention; and raw attention anoints them with presumed importance. "The last two words "presumed importance" is key, and now that we know this we must not forget that we can be complicit in promoting the power structure simply by gossiping about them. The line between gossiping to gauge the collective discontent and gossiping to make those powerful even more presence in terms of presumed importance is blurry.

In fact, even the anthropologist Max Gluckman himself doesn't think just because gossips are "useful" to the study of social anthropology we should simply endorse it. He actually says quite the opposite alluding to the danger of doing so: My argument about gossip and scandal is similar: If I suggest that gossip and scandal are socially virtuous and valuable, this does not mean that I always approve of them.

Indeed, in practice I find that when I am gossiping about my friends as well as my enemies I am deeply conscious of performing a social duty; but that when

I hear they gossip viciously about me, I am rightfully filled with righteous indignation. For those who justify gossiping as an heroic act, it may be dismaying for them to hear that gossip don't lead to a successful revolution. Gossip may help those who see themselves in an inferior position to know that they are not alone in the battle.

But, ultimately, it's the selfless act of those who are willing to risk everything confronting the injustice who gathers the momentum of public support to win the fight. Gossip is often seen a sign of immaturity, insecurity and parasitic aspect of those who are prone to emotional violence. Those who gossip, therefore, do not have the social credit let alone the charm or charisma to lead the revolution. Staging a revolution against the oppress requires much more than constructed narratives. The difference between useful information and gossip is to follow.

Why are gossip so entertaining? As I wrote in my last post (and quite rightly and accidentally coinciding with Gluckman's argument) gossip are entertaining because they are -- and here I am also alluding to my concern of this kind of vicious entertainment: Not about you -- so, listening to gossip is like watching a bomb being thrown at and killed civilians at the comfort of your armchair; and telling gossip is like throwing a bomb at an innocent people and walk away without any responsibilities.

As Dr Dennis Hunnell MD writes, "Gossip has little regard for the human dignity of its victim"; Gives you the sense of importance through exclusiveness -- when telling or listening to gossip, you are creating an exclusive club consisting of invited-only guests to join an orgy of terrorists; and, Fulfill the desire for vengeance -- gossip makes you feel as though someone else is responsible for the situation in which you are. Why are gossip so bad?

Gossip create an image of a thing, person, and event before you yourself experience it. This image is what social psychologists believe to lead to a kind of systematic prejudice commonly known as "confirmation bias," which is a kind of mental shortcut that we use to make most of the decisions in our life.

Say, you have heard a gossip about your newest office's colleague "being lazy." And say you don't have any other information about this person. On Monday's morning, you're then asked to mentor this new colleague.

It's very likely that you would take the gossip that you have heard about his laziness as a heuristics of "mental shortcut" in dealing with him during his first assignment with you. You will be likely to watch him carefully and try to find any sign that confirms your bias about his laziness, and it's very likely that you will find that sign -- not just one and many. Why? Because you are deliberately and carefully looking for it. Now imagine if the situation is a reverse.

You're this newest colleague. You did not do anything wrong and you were not lazy -- but everything you did was considered laziness just because that person who was supposed to be mentoring you saw you through his "confirmation bias lens" induced by gossip. Would you be okay with that? This goes almost with everything you experience in your life.

The comedian John Oliver once showed how confirmation bias work in a episode of his award-winning Last Week Tonight show, during which he presented a few yet-to-be-fully-investigated scandals about Hilary Clinton. And then he went on to mention a few other scandals of hers, such as the Swiss File Transfer case to which most people simply knotted their heads. And then Oliver surprisingly revealed that "I just made up the Swiss File Transfer case...but for a second, you kind of remembered it." Let's put that to a test.

Read the following passage. You have a need for other people to like and admire you, and yet you tend to be critical of yourself. While you have some personality weaknesses, you are generally able to compensate for them. You have considerable unused capacity that you have not turned to your advantage. Disciplined and self-controlled on the outside, you tend to be worried and insecure on the inside. At times you have serious doubts as to whether you have made the right decision or done the right thing.

You prefer a certain amount of change and variety and become dissatisfied when hemmed in by restrictions and limitations. You also pride yourself on being an independent thinker and do not accept others' statements without satisfactory proof. But you have found it unwise to be too frank in revealing yourself to others. At times you are extroverted, affable, and sociable, while at other times you are introverted, wary, and reserved. Some of your aspirations tend to be rather unrealistic. Done? Now, go back and read it again.

This time do keep in mind that this is a statement describing YOU based on hundreds of thousands of data points that I've collected from the comments, e-mails, and other browsing information generated by WordPress.com all cross-referenced with demographics information over the half-life of this very blog. The process of doing so has been long and tedious, but I did so anyway to come up with this statement about you. So, trust me on this, I have a good idea of who you are.

Now, please go back and read it again. Now what do you think? Does it sound like you, my dearest reader? It should, but not because of how this paragraphs is written based on any data that I just described, but because it's written in such a broad and vague term that it should describe everyone.

The tendency that you are likely to think that this is about you the second time you read it is because of your unconscious using of the "mental shortcut" to make sense of this paragraph vis-a-vis you. Everything seems to fall into its place, isn't it? You may be disappointed to learn that the paragraph above comes from David McRaney's book *You Are Not So Smart*, which describes, tests, and provide scientific findings of this kind of mental shortcuts.

The paragraph above, in fact, come from a 1948 experiment by the Stanford University psychologist Bertram R. Forer in his study of, what he later terms, "subjective validation" showing that we are all prone to believing vague statements and predictions, especially if they are positive and address you personally -- in this case, through the use of, also, our proneness to be

prejudiced, anchored, and mislead by a tactic of confirmation bias (i.e., the entire paragraph in red above).

In the example above about your newest colleague at your old workplace, you might just want to protect yourself from being taken advantage of by this "known to be (through gossip as being) lazy" newest colleague; therefore, you justify using gossip as a base of the information on how to avoid being taken advantage of. That said, why would you be afraid of your being taken advantage of if you're certain of your ability in your role to mentor a new person joining the office.

Even if he's lazy, isn't that one of the behavioral and cognitive change that you can help this person change through your role as his mentor? Because gossip can also easily grow up of jealousy and senseless egotism, people who constantly engage in gossiping entertained themselves at the expense of their own ability to grow out of their own self-imposed immaturity and cultivate their sense of self efficacy.

At a personal level, to emphasize, gossip only represents your immaturity, insecurity, and your desire to be parasitic to the community of which you have become a member. In other words, those who gossip tend to have sociopathic personality -- in the sense that they lack conscience and do not care about the negative consequences of their action on other people. At a societal level, gossip create an image of a society that is worse than before.

The psychologist Steven Pinker has written in many occasions about how many of us think of the world as being more violent when, in reality, we are actually living in the most peaceful time in the history. As Pinker writes, a news about a plane safely landed at an airport doesn't make a headline whereas a news about a slight disputation of an engine of a plane causing an emergency landing; so, we tend to hear more about bad news than good.

Owing to that nature of media, we tend to think of the world as becoming more dangerous when all statistics available are pointing to the opposite. The great psychologists Amos Tversky and Daniel Kahneman in 1974 calls this

kind of cognitive fallacy "availability bias," which clouds us from seeing the situation, circumstance, and the world the way it is.

The same goes with how we tend to hear news about someone's winning a jackpot and not millions of people who wasted their precious bucks on a piece of useless paper they once call lottery. This might explain why those who watch news tend to buy both lottery tickets and travel insurance when flying? Gossip are like that too.

We like to hear stories that fill the void of emptiness in our soul and that usually means we like to hear a drama involving how others are not as superior as we are. Gossip, in this sense, only makes us see the world through the same lens as those ubiquitous bad news we see in the media. Sooner or later we will soon think that most planes crash, flying is not safe, and most people in the world want to kill you (and therefore you must act first).

Rules Against Gossip and for the Humanity There's only one rule: Don't engage. What it means is that you: Should not listen to any of it -- again, I must emphasize that gossip are (not just like, they are) bombs and bullets to the soul and to your character. So, literally walk away from it when someone is about to say it as if you are walking away from someone who is about to throw a bomb and shoot you in the chest; and, Don't gossip.

It's obvious that the second one is much harder than the first. For the first rule, I usually just walk away. In a situation in which walking away is not possible, I change the topic or politely make it clear to the counterpart that I do not wish to engage. There is no possible justification for letting yourself hit by the bullets of a terrorist who is selfish and is only see you as an object of malignant desire.

Again, you could use my father's words "Give me a hard evidence -- There's no room for gossip in this room/table/meeting." It is hard to avoid engaging in gossip if we do not first distinguish it from, simply, "informational prose." A few friends asked me whether it's okay for them to tell what they have heard

-- what they call "a piece of truthful information." First, you need to know difference between an information and a gossip? Try to point out the difference between these two sentences.

A hint here is that one is considered to be a piece of information that you happen to know, and the other is a gossip. The situation/context here is that you're being asked whether you know that Mr. Adams is married. "Mr. Adams told me that he is married." "Mr. Adams said he's married, although I personally do not believe him." I hope that you can tell right away that the first sentence is an informational while the second is not. If Mr.

Adams has given you just one piece of information that he's married -- in this case, he must have "told" you in person, which is different from your looking at his personal profile and saw the box "married" checked without his consent. You do not need to add any of your personal thought to the truth that Mr. Adams told you that he's married. The added information about your not believing his words is considered unnecessary and gossipy.

This is the kind of information that will consciously or unconsciously cloud the judgment of the listener. For whatever moral justification you have regarding your assertion of your personal belief, the consequence of this unnecessary prejudice you have created is on you. Just to be clear, let's have another exercise. Which of these is gossip? I did not see Mr. Boyles in my class today. Mr. Boyles deliberately didn't come to class because he doesn't like the teacher. In other words, Dr.

Marshall Rosenberg says, "do not confuse observation with evaluation" (i.e., the #1 principle). He writes in his monumental theory of non-violent communication: Differentiating observation from evaluation, being able to carefully observe what is happening free of evaluation, and to specify behaviors and conditions that are affecting us is the first skill of non-violent communication. When you are telling what you are observing, you are in a much better place to not be prone to gossip. Another way to think about it is to abide by Dr.

Peterson's Rule#8, which is "Tell the truth – or, at least, don't lie." You might argue that you are not lying when you add "although I personally do not believe him." Well, don't try to be too clever here. Yes, you won't be lying when you share your honest opinion if you really feel so, but based on what? Your personal opinion?

How do you know that your personal opinion is not based on any other forms of prejudice that you probably have heard from other sources -- such as gossips -- that someone has shared with you. Just because you don't know whether what make you think you know is not a lie does not give you a moral justification to convey it as a truth, even with your most honest opinion.

In other words, just because you "think" you are telling your honest opinion doesn't mean that you are not lying. In fact, in his 12 Rules for Life: An Antidote to Chaos book, he outlines very thoughtfully what lies, and forms of lies based on your own belief that what you think you know is not a lie, can hurt you pathologically and emotionally.

So, in this case, saying what you know for certain and, to your most honest mind, that which is not a lie -- the very fact that Mr. Adams told you that he is married -- is not just enough but appropriate. Any information added to this is considered gossipy. Don't tell gossips -- Bite your tongue if you need to! We love stories; the more is the better, and the more of them is the more convincing the argument is.

I actually understand how hard it is to stop at "Mr. Adams told me that he is married" or simply "I did not see Mr. Boyles in my class today." In the study of, what later on called "conjunction fallacy," by the great psychologists Amos Tversky and Dani Kahneman (again) in 1983, it's clear that we humans are prone to make rather innocuous errors when information presented at them with stories. In their famous example, "Linda," they show vividly how this conjunction fallacy finds form.

Basically, Tversky and Kahneman presented a story of a fictional character Linda as followed: Linda is 31 years old, single, outspoken, and very bright.

She majored in philosophy. As a student, she was deeply concerned with issues of discrimination and social justice, and also participated in anti-nuclear demonstrations. The question that followed was: Which is more probable? A) Linda is a bank teller. B) Linda is a bank teller and is active in the feminist movement. What's your answer?

Anyone in their right mind would answer A) Linda is a bank teller because "more probable" simply and straightforwardly means "more statistically probable." For Linda to be a bank teller who is also active in the feminist movement, she would have to be a bank teller first. So, Linda's being a bank teller is more statistically more probable. Well, I am not sure what was your answer but most people actually chose B) Linda is a bank teller and is active in the feminist movement.

When asked why, those who chose B in a series of experiments that the two psychologists had conducted promptly referred to the fact that Linda is a bank teller and is active in the feminist movement sounded more like a realistic answer based on the information about who she was and what she did as a student and before she became a bank teller. In this case, the additional information "is active in the feminist movement" is the element of emotional "representativeness" that undermines rational statistical probability.

Imagine if Linda is your former classmate and you do not know what Linda is doing, and how easy it is for you to add those last few words: "I haven't see Linda in a while but last time we met she was a bank teller -- and was probably still active in the feminist movement." Bite your tongue, resist the temptation to be complicit in an act of terrorism. All you actually know is that she WAS a bank teller.

Because we like stories that are more than just facts -- like in this Linda's story -- therefore it goes the same as how our mind (and mouth) would like to interject more than what we actually know, and are capable of knowing. Be careful of that.

There was time that I mistakenly sent two messages to my friends upon the death of my dog Paolo -- one wrote "Paolo just passed away," and the other was "Paolo was a dog that loved to eat everything," Lo and behold, I received many messages from those friends who mourned the loss of my dearest dog to obesity, obesity-induced diseases (such as diabetics) and obesity-induced immobility. There're even gossips going around that I was a "pug's killer" because I "constantly overfed" my lovely Paolo.

The truth was that Paolo was only allowed to eat only one meal a day of dog's food only. I didn't even know whether, as a dog, he was considered overweight.

All I wanted to say was that Paolo was dead and that I remember him well as a lovely dog that loved to eat -- these two information had nothing to do with one another but all my friends, though "conjunction fallacy," connected the invisible dots brought to them by their proneness to see a story in the two separated ideas. In fact, all of us should know the principles of non-violent communication and converse freely, with good intentions, with one another.

In fact, there is a plethora of evidence showing that a transparent workplaces that disdain and reject gossiping tend to thrive and retain their productivity while those who are not tend to collapse. In organizational psychology, for instance, there is a plenty of research findings that show how a company would be much better off when the employees feel as though they can voice their concerns about their superiors freely and directly with their superiors.

But we all know that which hardly happens, most of us (if not all) go to someone we like -- such as our friends or colleagues -- to voice our discontent with our superiors, which, needless to say, became gossips with the tendency to spread and therefore get distorted among the friends/colleagues of those friends/colleagues with whom you share your initial discontent. The evidence is clear that this circulation of information doesn't benefit any individuals in the situation let alone the organization.

The entrepreneur (and to me, a thinker) Ray Dalio, in fact, writes and speaks at length and especially in his book *Principles*) about how he owes the culture of transparency the success of his company Bridgewater Associates. Combating gossip with nonviolent communication So, what exactly is nonviolent communication? I would suggest that you read Rosenberg's book, which I believe, to date, to be the best psychological guide on how to "communicate to live" in the world today.

Indeed, if we are all to follow his principles, we won't be engaging at all in gossiping. That is to say, gossip is, in Rosenberg's book, one of the violent methods of communication that his principles aim at preventing us from engaging. In short, here're the four principles which have many overlaps with what I have discussed earlier in this post (and please read the book!). When communicating your thoughts: Only speak of your observation -- and refrain from your evaluation.

Saying that your boss "talks too much" is the latter and won't solve any problem, whereas saying that your boss "occasionally speaks of his personal irrelevant personal experience during the meeting, extending the meeting's time by 20-30 minutes, may be an issues to be discussed" could lead to an action that helps your boss to change himself for better; Connect your moralistic judgement (if you happen to have one) to how you feel.

For instance, instead of saying that "You are so stupid for saying that -- how could you?" you might want to connect your immediate judgement (i.e., stupid) to the feeling that makes you feel that way, which could allow you to put together something that also weaves in essential facts, for example, "When you're talking specifically about this issue in a way that seems to imply that you are not aware of the very news that most of us should know by ways of our office's mass weekly e-newsletters, it makes me feel sad that we haven't been able to make sure that all the important news have reached all of us.

I'd like you to tell me how you feel when I tell you this"; Avoid adverbs such as always, never, ever, frequently, and state the facts -- how often is a

statement such as "You never listen to me" is true?; and, Be explicit about your request, and not your demand -- try to motivate others to want to do things that are basic to human needs rather than demand that they do it. Most people do not want to be demanded but welcome polite and, most importantly, non-violent, requests.

Finally: Blame it on me! Again, I cannot emphasize enough that I disdain gossiping. I do not trust any news and media that base their reports on unfound rumors and especially gossips aiming at discrediting other people -- and so shouldn't you. Those who gossip always either uses pseudonym and do not want their name to be revealed to any third parties.

How many times that we have heard someone about to engage in gossip saying "Don't tell anyone that I am telling you this." It should be a commonsense that one should always be super cautious when told anything by anyone who does not want to be responsible for their own words. When one do not have to be responsible for your own words, one can say whatever one wants -- and that's a deeply, insanely, and outrageously dangerous thing.

According to this logic, not only should those words not be heard by a sensible person (and I mean YOU) but they should also be condemned by everyone who wants to live in a better society. I do not trust -- and therefore I do not read anything -- written by anyone who does not want to be responsible for their own words. I hope that you feel the same way.

I would not want to live in a society in which anyone could simply be a victim of false accusation and gossips. I believe in justice. Hence, I believe that the best way to bring anyone to justice is to stop speculating, and especially circulating false accusations, and simply bring all the parties involved in the accusation to a transparent investigation. It's always hurtful for me to hear that it's so easy for people to make false accusations about others.

But since I am a fan of Steven Pinker, I will continue to believe that even that which is the case, we are still living in the most peaceful time in the history of mankind (although that doesn't and shouldn't mean that we should just sit

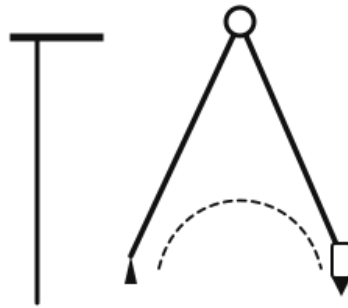
back and relax now). But hey, if those people still do not stop trying to get you to listen to their tasteless gossip, I have another suggestion.

Say that although you'd like to be a good listener, you once read a blog post that urged you to consider engaging with gossip unsafe even for innocent individuals. Go ahead: blame me. You can even use my name.

DAY 78

On Design Thinking Part 2: It All Began in Kraków

Thu, 11 Sep 2025 00:00:00 +0000



SO, LET ME TELL YOU a bit about the background of this design thinking series. For most of 2016 and 2017, I had many opportunities to conduct workshops on this very topic, which I found to be speaking directly to the question that I had been having for many years: How could I use years of theoretical knowledge that I had learned from school in real life? Design thinking came to me first as a surprise.

I, too, taught that it's one of those terms that people liked to name-drop because "it sounded cool," without knowing its true meaning. Only after a few months of a truly deep dive, I realized that this was a gold mine. In fact, I personally had long been doubting my own ability to be an individual in the world.

In many posts prior to this, I talked about how I felt that the educational and social system in which I was born were too rigid for me, to the point that I, at several points in my life, felt as though I did not have a lot to contribute to my community. It's until I had recognized some of the key principles of design thinking (about which I talked in my Day 76 post) that I began to see myself, retroactively, somewhat as a natural design thinker.

Hold on right there. I am not saying that which was a good thing. To be a design thinker, as I wrote in my last post, one has to constantly challenge himself/herself with the idea that there's always a possibility for things to be better than it is. In other words, one has to see things the way they actually are, and not through the lens of acceptance by the majority.

For instance, I saw I was a horrible good student throughout my formal education simply because I didn't always good grades (actually, almost never) and I had never won any awards at all. The society thought me as an ordinary majority, who would probably go on to become a much-less-than-extraordinary employee in a mediocre company.

That's the way things were presented to me through the lens of acceptance by the majority -- so, what psychologists would call -- "social proof." Then, I asked myself to take a look at the situation differently. The question I had for myself was, What was the reason for me to feel no inspiration at all for what I was studying? Hence, the bad grades and hence the award-less student life. That's exactly the time when I realized that I was starting to see things the way they were.

If anyone were to study what he/she was passionate in, there's very likely he or she would do much better than. Wouldn't you agree? I knew that I enjoyed making drawing. I liked to travel and look at great buildings. Most of the film photographs I took back then were all buildings, monuments, and edifices. Thinking about architecture, and how I could re- design my house to fit my own customized need, made me feel really happy. Every day was a holiday when I thought about architecture so to speak.

Of course, it would be nice if I was also good at biology (my worst subject in high school), geography, mathematics, and chemistry. But maybe I wasn't interested in those fields as much -- so why would I let things that I wasn't even interested in define who I was? So, I shifted my focus from being "good at what the society thought I should be good at" to what mattered to me and my passion, and that which, back then, was architectural design.

I then decided to enroll in a modest technical institution where my entrance examination score was just enough to be admitted outside of Bangkok. Anyone who knew my academic attributes as a student would not be able to predict how I would go on to receive a First Class Honors in architectural design from the technical institute where I enrolled as an undergraduate student. After that, as they always say, the rest is history. I did not know how to call my way of thinking then.

So, my classmates helped me by calling it "thinking out of the box," "critical thinking," "thinking laterally," and most amusingly, "thinking like Non." Years have passed, and I have come to see design thinking in a much more interesting spotlight. And now that I have a name to call it, I have become much more interested in exploring what it has to offer. Design thinking wasn't just a cliché, it's a combination of practical philosophy, cognitive psychology and robust strategy for innovation.

My realization that I could just focus on what I was interested in came from my (then quite) shallow understanding of the self improvement. But for sure my ability to see things the way they were got me a jump start. Of course, my love and obsession with both cognitive psychology and robust strategy for innovation started much later (from early this year onward to be precise) so these two fields, in fact, gradually grew on me as profound elements of design thinking.

Many of my classmates back then still made fun of me by calling design thinking "thinking like Non" -- they could never forget that, couldn't they? So, to begin, I offered myself as a laborer and keen observer to a company that used design thinking to innovate. Then, I read as many books as possible on the topic.

I continued to search as many examples and case studies as I could online, and in real life, to get the sense of what might be the practical gist of the idea: To see what worked and what did not.

And most important, I learned from hundreds of students from all age groups, academic levels, and placements in life in their professional career paths not only what is the apt way to introducing this concept to them, but also what might help them to become a better individual in whatever they were trying to do. In the process that took more than a full year of a combination of self-reflection, self-closing (so that I could think clearly), and self-exploring, I indeed had learned quite a bit.

The real challenge that I had was when I decided to offer a course called "design thinking" as a semester-long undergraduate course for non-designs students at a new university where I would soon be lecturing as a visiting instructor. This was supposed to be a sabbatical semester for me; so I was in that mode of thinking as well (i.e., an "I can teach anything" mode) when I almost carelessly gave the title of the course to the administrator of the university I was a visiting instructor.

Well, normally a course that I offered were merely a two-day-long workshop, so there're so much to instruct during the 16-20 hours of lectures, workshops, and intense seminar. But a semester-long, as in 15-week long, undergraduate course? For students who did not necessary have any knowledge of academic or non-academic background in design? More importantly, was I mad? In the spirit of design thinking, I took up this very challenge anyway. I thought to myself: What if I could use design thinking to "design" this course?

The course eventually had the following aspects: A 15-week-long course; for each week, a reading introducing the key definition of "creativity" from a variety of academic fields that are totally new to students is introduced to the class; Every 2-3 weeks, students would be asked to engage in a hands-on workshop designed to test their synthesis of those key aspects of creativity ranging from a coffee cup to a gift-giving experience, to a better uncluttered life; and, There's no final paper -- students would determine what they want to do for their own good at the end of the course How did I come up with this?

Let's look at the three principles that I wrote about in my last post and how I used them to come up with a design thinking course at Jagiellonian University in Krakow, Poland. First, don't always assume that the end-users of your design know what they want. This was the most important factor for my designing the course the way I did.

The classic joke goes, "You can always be sure that your boss will never see what you bring for him to see if that thing is an innovation -- and you can also always be sure that he will not like it right away because he won't know how it works." My first idea was to teach design thinking as a design course, and that was basically what students were looking forward to as they had signed up for the course weeks earlier even before they met me in person and received the preliminary syllabus!

If I were to give them that course, I would be giving them exactly "what they thought creativity was." What's the point of learning about creativity if you already know what it was? And to the point -- my own point -- what did I know really about design that made me feel so confident to teach them? So, that idea was only partially saved and the rest of it got immediately thrown into the garbage can.

I realized that both me and my students were not any of kinds of design experts. I knew architectural design, but not industrial, graphic, communication, etc, design. So, I decided to offer the course with the most basic sets of knowledge that would get the students attention throughout the 15-week-long semester -- the idea of creativity and innovation. Second, don't always assume that things exist because they work. Far from it actually.

The reason why things "look like they work" has to do, first and foremost, with our "availability bias" and "social proof." I cannot recall how many times I heard people's saying "That building is great; they're so many people there so it must be a good building." So, the assumption is that because a lot of people are using it, so it must be good; and/or, because the definition of a building is something that doesn't collapse, so it is standing and people are using it, so therefore it must be a good building.

This is not all wrong, but definitely not all right. Most of the time, we use whatever that is available to us. In Bangkok, I drink instant coffee -- although I know that brew coffee is much more delicious and better for my health (there're many research that show that the process by which the instant coffee grain is made dried is unhealthy). But it is not that easy to find a brew coffee where I live in Bangkok, so I drink whatever I can find! Instant coffee does works!

And if a lot of coffee-lovers like me feel the same way, we would all be buying up instant coffee from the supermarket, which should not be confused with the impression that "Bangkok people like instant coffee" or that "Instant coffee is good." O.K.

So, this example is easy to understand because of the comparative benchmark that I have (i.e., I have drunk better brew coffee elsewhere in the world), so that which is the reason why I know that instant coffee exist not because it was the best, but because it was the best viable option in a particular circumstance. Now, I want you to take a step further -- by imaging that everything around you can be better.

Look at everything around you; a pen, a notebook, computer, mobile phone, etc., and asked yourself, "If you were to design the world's first pen, notebook, computer, mobile phone -- as if they have never existed before in the history of mankind -- how would you go about and design them and what will they look like? This was a challenging question that I also asked myself when I was putting together this design thinking course.

So, instead of hitting the internet and search as many available and existing syllabi for courses with a similar name -- and perhaps learn from those in designing my own course -- I started with finding a nice spot in my apartment's compound where I could see the trees, smell the glass, and listen to the singing of the birds. These were the elements that made my apartment in Poland sort of a heaven on earth even though no other amenities were there.

Then, I visualized how should creativity be taught. By doing so, I wrote this following paragraph that became the basis of this course: This is an experimental class. There are three reasons behind its experimental nature. First, the idea of "studying creativity" seems like an oxymoron. A fixed set of conventions may provide guidelines for what might be useful to learn but it should not overshadow the creative process that learners should design for themselves.

Second, as design is not about thinking about what to design, but one step beyond in not only conceiving but also producing it to test out in reality, the best methods to deliver design education should also be similar. This aspect of learning, therefore, requires a high level of flexibility from both the instructor and learner. Third, design require a "focused chaos"; hence, we will rely on our intuitions to deliver the best possible learning outcomes based on that.

This class meets once a week for a 1.5-hour session that will consist of an interactive lecture, learner-oriented seminar, spontaneous workshop depending on the week, and extensive "design homework." After the first session during which the instructor will give a general overview of the particular session and some thinking points, most sessions will be devoted to discussions and hands-on experience of creative process.

The close reading and critique of required texts are essential to the preparation for each session, so students are required to have read all the required readings before each session. The experimental nature of this course would require students to use design thinking and design research methods to critique and analyze special topics and assignments given to the students for the workshop session each week. Finally, don't always think that design thinking process has to involve high-tech and advanced stuff. For me, this was the key.

I used to think that I would need to do all sorts of things to make a course with the name like "design thinking" sound and appear super high-tech. It should, shouldn't it? I was trying to make contacts with the departments of

engineering and the industrial parks associated with the university with the hope that they would let me use their workshop. I was hoping to create an "app" on a phone for students to write and report their progress.

I was aiming at spending around \$3,000 of the course's budget (which I had yet to have) on things that I thought would make the course more sophisticated. But then, I was caught off guard by my own principle when I revisited it: What makes something good isn't always need to be that high-tech, is it?

I often use an example of a carry-on luggage that I would like to get a permission of my mother to buy (yes, I am always 36 but I still need her permission if I want to buy anything that is more expensive than \$100). I was convinced that a carry-on luggage with a new bluetooth capacity would forever give me a peace of mind -- I will always be able to track it, find it, and see where it is on the conveyable belt.

This carry-on will be a bit heavier because of the battery-powered bluetooth technology and probably a few hundred dollars more expensive than a typical all-around Samsonite carry-on, but it still, to me, seemed like a good price to pay for such a convenience. It's not until my mother told me that "if you want your carry-on luggage to be distinguishable, why don't you just put a colored-ribbon around the handle?" Eureka! That was the moment for me. In this sense, designing a course like this design thinking course.

So, at the end, to learn about the concept of prototyping, for instance, all we used were paper cups and scissors -- and we got to learn quite a lot actually by doing that as the goal of the exercise was not to create the most innovative coffee cup, but to learn and experience how one could establish his/her ability to "make" rather than just to think.

We also learned about the concept of " nudge, " which is widely known and cited in the field of behavioral economics, as a creative process to encourage (not force) people to do things that they should do and to not do things that they should not do. Sometimes, nudging has a large and impact on the

society without the society's having to spend its hard-earned taxes on anything. Perhaps we'll get back to that in the later post. I'll stop here for now today.

Will be back soon for the next in this very series of design thinking!

post Day 79: On Design Thinking Part 3: The Black Swan Fri, 12 Sep 2025 00:00:00 +0000 First, this is not about the film Black Swan starring Natalie Portman, but the book The Black Swan: The Impact of the Highly Improbable by Nassim Nicholas Taleb. But what does Taleb mean by the black swan? It means, as the subtitle of the aforementioned book suggests, something that "seems improbable, but possible.

He derives this term from a story of how we humankind believed "all swans were white" until 1697 when some explorers, for the first time, saw black swans in Australia. "Impossible," was the feeling that these explorers had, but since they saw those black swans with their own eyes they had to believe it. So, in the design thinking course that I had the pleasure of teaching last semester, I did not introduce this concept until the last 4 weeks of the semester.

I was not sure that the book and the concept of black swans (which is arguably one of the most important concepts in risk management today) would be useful to design. Thanks to the lively discussion with my students, I was confirmed energetically by the interaction throughout the 1.5-hour seminar on this very concept that it's crucial for design thinkers to understand the impact of the highly improbable.

One of the design concepts that I have yet to allude to is "resilience," or the idea that something that is well designed should be able to recover quickly from the difficulty or robust in difficult situations. If the design is resilience, it will be popular. Think of something as basic as tiding the ribbon around the handle of your carry-on luggage to help you identify it when coming out of the conveyable belt with many other look-alike carry-ons.

This "design thinking" is more resilience than a \$500 bluetooth-operated carry-on luggage -- for which to work you would need batteries in both your smartphone (yes, you'll also need a smartphone) and the the bluetooth-operated carry-on itself. You would also need to spend time taking the battery out of the carry-on upon your getting through the security gate. Finally, it will only do the job that the ribbon does despite its much higher realm of technology.

You'll still lose it if someone steals it, or it still won't be arriving with you if the airline misplaced it. What about for a company, city, or an individual to be resilient? Since we don't have the superpower to predict the future, what we need is the ability to be less vulnerable to the improbable difficulty. Kodak, as a company, invented many things. The reliance on the market for film blinded the company from seeing the then less-productive child --the digital camera technology.

For that reason, Kodak got pushed out of the market by surprise when most people decide that they would go for the memory chips instead of films. So, as Taleb sees it, we need to be resilient in order to survive the unexpected. He also coins another term for this form of resilience -- an antidote to the black swans -- called "antifragile," which features also in his book *Antifragile: Things That Gain From Disorder*. Although I really like this term, that's another topic for another time.

For this post, let's stick to "resilience" rather than "antifragile" for now. Let's get back to the black swans. I want to use the three most vivid examples that Taleb uses in the book to illustrate what kinds of things are considered highly probable. First, 9/11 attacks -- it goes without saying that we could have prevented it if we thought that it was highly probably.

The problem that Taleb outlines is that the 9/11 attacks make many of us feel as though we could "sort of" or "almost" predicted them, which is only because they are explained retrospectively.

So, the first practical thing to learn about the notion of the black swans is: When the improbable takes place, don't look back at the past in pursuit of justifying why it happens (as it only looks justifiable after the fact); so, do quickly move on and be antifragile (dang, I just said let's stick to resilience). To show you more why 9/11 attacks were only explainable retroactively, let's look at the second example: "the turkey." Consider a turkey that is fed every day.

Every single feeding will firm up the bird's belief that it is the general rule of life to be fed every day by friendly members of the human race "looking out for its best interests," as a politician would say. On the afternoon of the Wednesday before Thanksgiving, something unexpected will happen to the turkey. It will incur a revision of belief. Right?

Just because it was well fed every day, the turkey was under the impression that everything was under its control -- it might even thought of itself as important whereas the bigger power over it operates at a much higher and completely different ontological plane. How many times have you been in this kind of "turkey situation?" For me? Plenty, plenty, plenty (I thought I was fed to strive, but at the end I found out that I was fed to be consumed -- metaphorically). One more example.

Third, you: Imagine a speck of dust next to a planet a billion times the size of the earth. The speck of dust represents the odds in favor of your being born; the huge planet would be the odds against it. So stop sweating the small stuff. Don't be like the ingrate who got a castle as a present and worried about the mildew in the bathroom. Stop looking the gift horse in the mouth—remember that you are a Black Swan. So, we are all black swans.

Definitionally, we do not have any clue about our birth. Even if we could trace one step back to the meeting of our biological parents: What brought them together and made them decide to have a family? In other words, you are thrown into the world as a black swan. Now we know what the black swans are. How do we deal with them?

Taleb argues, and I hereby add practical advice to his argument in red, three main things about the black swans: Black swans are improbable, and often almost impossible, until they happen (just like the "discovery" of the black swans in Western Australia 1697). Don't beat yourself up too much if you happen to suffer a lot from it because you weren't prepared for it. You are not alone.

Think of the way to be resilient, think of stoicism, think of antifragile and quickly and robustly learn from it in order to rise up as fast as you can again to tackle the existence and aftermaths of the black swans. In design, we cannot always come up with something exclusively "for the black swans" since we don't know when they are coming (and more importantly what they are); yet, this doesn't mean that you cannot be somewhat prepared.

The same reason we will never know for sure what would be the best antidote to which of the black swans in your life, we also do not know which one of our ideas previously thought as useless might become useful. So, never throw away any notes, drawings, post-it notes, sketches, and prototypes of ideas that you have. Systematically organize them in a shelf, or scan them and organize them on your computer.

They might not seem to be useful now, but you may need some of them in dealing with black swans; Black swans cannot be explained by the past -- think of the turkey story. So, don't try to make sense of it. What you could do is to make yourself as resilient as possible.

This might mean: Don't get over-consumed by data, take small risks to test the water, do not take any big risk (putting all the eggs in one basket), and try your best to keep your option open and welcome. In design, too, this can be practiced by thinking about the variety of ideas that you are investing your time and resource in.

For instance, a lot of people who get laid off from the company for whom they have been working for years often do not know what else to do or how to make a living afterwards. The closing of the company or the lay-off can be

the black swans but those who stay afloat after the fact are resilience. A practical advise: Always have a small pet project on the side -- something that you are interested in and feeling good about when you engage in.

Did you know that WeChat (China's largest social media + mobile payment network) was sort of a pet project of the mother company? There're many of these examples. Work on your pet project and enjoy it, as it might become handy to you. There are always unexpected factors involved in just about anything. For example, there's one time that I was so focusing on an exam, which I hoped to ace.

I have read all the books, set an alarm on my phone, and I even let many of my friends know that they must call me should I not be present at the exam room at least half an hour before the exam. That morning, well, truth be told, there's a problem with the main electrical circuit board of my building, so my phone was not charged and therefore was out of battery, which meant that no one on whom I relied could call me. A practical advise?

Do not set your alarm clock on your phone; get a real alarm clock from IKEA. Sorry, that was a joke. I would never do that to you. The problem here is that there're always more factors that we thought we have already covered. One way of looking at any problems is to expect that something might not go as planned (like a stoic) which may include visualizing some worst-case scenarios beforehand and walk through in your imagination, with positive thoughts, about how you might go about and fix it.

Moreover, I think those who tend to be at the worst receiving end of a black swan that happen in this way are those who have been criticizing others something that if they could see it through this very lens, would know that it could well be them who make the mistakes.

So, a practical advise is, and I shall quote Dr Jordan Peterson, "set your house in perfect order before criticizing the world." And since the idea of anything that is "perfect" is probably just a fantasy, just don't criticize and focus on your very own pursuit and care with great care and carefulness. In my life,

there're many times that I suffered greatly from black swans. I can tell you the most impactful one: The death of my father.

He was 62, and just retired from work for about one and a half year. My father, at the time, lived in Bangkok with my mother and brother. He was no Hercules but he seemed to not be in any stages of seriously bad health, which I found out later that he was not well at all (and he just didn't want me to know). As for me, I was only a few hours away from my very first class of my doctorate.

I had a wonderful girlfriend and was happy to be in the US where I called my intellectual home. My father was planning to come visit me in the States with my mother and we had a series of grand plans on what we wanted to do. Everything was pictured-perfect (at least to me, the turkey), until I receive an nerve-wrackingly short text message from my brother: "Dad passed away." My father, in this story, was the farmer, and I was the turkey.

He had an operational assumption that it would be unlikely for him to live as long as to visit me in the US, and he had subtlety made this gesture to some of his close friends, such as excusing himself from a wedding of one of his former co-workers, not attending an important gatherings and meetings, and procrastinating on packing up for a health check-up at a hospital. He knew that he was about to leave us but he didn't want me to be distracted.

So, even since he passed away, I always do three things -- in the spirit of design thinking. Go back home to visit my friends and family whenever I can. I make it a routine. During my time at home, I would not let anything else distracting me from my precious time with my family, especially my mother; Now or never when it comes to meeting someone I'd like to see. We tend to postpone meetings that we do not see immediate needs.

But how do we know that which are going to be a great meeting that changes your view (i.e., a positive black swan) or the last meeting between you and that person since we sincerely do not know when are we going to leave this world? Call, text, and keep in touch with those whom I care but do not have

the time and resource to see them.

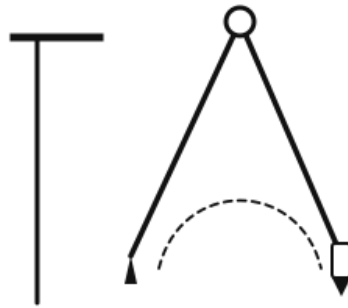
Sometimes my friends ask me why I send them random posts or photos, I answer "to keep in touch," and that which is precisely the reason. Thinking of what they would be interested in seeing and reading is a practical act of compassion that reminds you of your value and friendship. Like good gifts, according to Robert B. Cialdini, this very way of keeping in touch, though seen as weird by some friends (to which they eventually got used), are meaningful, unexpected and customized.

Sometimes I get to strike a conversation with someone I haven't seen for decades -- and see them in person (thanks to the above now or never rule) for a coffee right after I share with them those random posts.

DAY 80

On Design Thinking Part 4: Design, Fast and Slow

Sat, 13 Sep 2025 00:00:00 +0000



AS THE TITLE SUGGESTS, I am going to talk about design in terms of "heuristics" and "general probability." Wait, wait, wait, don't close this browser yet. Those two terms may seem like jargon but basically what they mean is rule of thumb (for heuristics) and statistics (for general probability). We owe this very important domain of knowledge to two psychologists: the late Amos Tversky and the Nobel Laureate and Princeton Emeritus Professor Daniel Kahneman.

Yes, it is the same famous genius Amos as recounted by the New York Time best-selling author Malcolm Gladwell in *David and Goliath: Underdogs, Misfits, and the Art of Battling Giants* -- Tversky Intelligence Test was: "The faster you realized that Tversky was smarter than you, the smarter you were." In addition to being a genius (in the sense that Amos was almost always able to see things the way they were) Amos was a hardcore optimist.

In fact, I quote him most of the time whenever I need to see things clearly: "When you're a pessimist and the bad things happen, you live it twice." In fact, there is a sort of psychological theory that shows that you are actually likely to make that mistake that you think you would if you are a pessimist --

it's called a "negative self-fulfilling prophecy." I recall how I thought I would fail an exam because I was so bad at this very subject.

I was anxious during the exam because of that thought, and lo and behold I failed and had to re-sit that exam. Looking back, that exam wasn't even that hard. My anxiety gave me the sense of uncertainties, which later on became the root of my emotionally immobility and therefore inability to focus to the exam task at hand. In other words, if you are a pessimist you would worry once about it and the second time when it happens.

Sadly, because Amos prematurely passed away in 1996 (at the age of 59) before another genius Daniel received the Nobel Prize in Economic Science based on the work that the two had done together over the three decades (I know, I know, it's actually not one of the original Nobel Prize's categories but it's a good substitute).

Otherwise, it'd be no question whatsoever that both of them would be the joint-winners of the Prize together (a wonderful biography, and also one of my favorite books of all time, of their collaboration is Daniel Lewis' *Undoing Project: A Friendship That Changed Our Minds*.) In probably one of the most important books in the field of psychology (and probably the most readable one) *Thinking, Fast and Slow*, Kahneman takes us through a tour-de-force of, what has been known for half a century as, "cognitive psychology." He shows us the anatomy of consciousness, telling us where we are actually not as smart as we thought we are -- but that's also not all that bad given that sometimes evolution doesn't always pick the smartest ones.

Kahneman's key idea is simple yet complex. Let me give you two tests to prepare you for that. The first one is a classic and it comes from Rolf Dobelli's *The Art of Thinking Clearly* (also another wonderful book that I highly recommend). Grab a pen and quickly jot down your answers to the following three questions. These are problems that are not designed for a calculator or a deep calculation, but your commonsense: In a department store, a Ping-Pong paddle and a plastic ball cost \$1.10.

If the paddle costs \$1 more, how much is the ball? In a textile factory, five machines take exactly five minutes to make five shirts. How many minutes will it take one hundred machines to produce one hundred shirts? A pond has water lilies growing in it. The flowers multiply quickly, each day doubling the area they take up. If it takes forty-eight days for the pond to be completely covered with water lilies, how many days will it take for it to be half covered?

Don't read on until you have written down the answers. Don't spend too much time thinking about it. If you're like most people, the quick intuitive answers that come to mind are: 10 cents, 100 minutes and 24 days. And these answers are all wrong. You could go back to those questions again, and this time you could use the pen and paper to do some calculation if you'd like. The correct answers are 5 cents, 5 minutes, and 47 days. I'll show you just the first question.

The ball costs 5 cents, and therefore the Ping-Pong paddle, which is \$1 costlier, would cost \$1.05. The bill for two items would be $\$0.05 + \$1.05 = \$1.10$. Actually, we don't even need to use those pen and paper at all. Why did most people think that the answer was 10 cents. Then? Here are another two questions that do not require any calculation and come from my own experience of teaching a design thinking workshop. When was the QR code invented?

(you know, one of those codes that you can use your phone to scan and can do almost everything with it these days?) Who invented it? Well, if you're among the majority of people, it wouldn't take you more than a 2-3 seconds to answer the first question. What's your answer? 5, 8, 10 years? And for the second question, if you are like most people, you would have pretended to think as if you actually knew (because somehow you have heard it from somewhere?).

At the end, if I insist that you give me the answer, you probably would not mind using your phone to look it up on Wikipedia. Did you get the answers right for both of them? If you are among the majority of the people, you

would not have thought that the QR code was invented in 1994 -- yes, 28 years ago. Second, you would not have any idea who invented it, let alone for which reasons (I'll leave that to you to find out on Wikipedia).

Here, why most of us think we know the answer to the first question without having to insist on looking it up on the internet? In *Thinking, Fast and Slow*, Kahneman argues that there're two fictional systems that we use when we think. We tend to use our "hot" automatic system to make a decision, which for most of the time would work.

This hot system is precisely the one that helps you quickly recall when was the first time you saw anyone's using QR code and calculate how many years that was. This hot system also has many academic names, such as emotion (for David Hume), nature (for Jean-Jacques Rousseau) and id (for Sigmund Freud). The cold system, on the other hand, ponders over the question.

When you have to think about something that you do not have the answer off hand, you would resort to this cold system to help you evaluate, argue, and therefore make an optimal decision. The cold system (Kahneman calls it System Two, as opposed to the hot System One) often only works when it's obvious that System One won't do the job -- as the question of who invented it.

Neurons in your brain will work very very hard to find out whether you have the answer, and if we don't the System Two won't pretend that we do and will tell us to find out on your laptop or your phone. Kahneman argues that we humans are prone and tend to make mistakes when we use the hot system when we actually should be using the "cold" system, which is almost always better than the hot "automatic" system, to make a decision.

This is especially the case when we are to make a decision under some pressure and uncertainties, during which it's very likely that we would let the worst system of the two to do the job (when that's the last thing you would want). The only problem with the cold System Two is that it is, unfortunately, kinda lazy and we usually just resort to whatever comes quicker to mind --

like that answer of when QR codes came about.

In fact, we have many casual terms for this hot system, such as "gut feeling," "rule of thumb," and "hunch." Where and why are we so confident about this hot system? As the writer Malcolm Gladwell eloquently points out in *Blink: The Power of Thinking Without Thinking*, it is because this system is based on our empirical experience and it can be pretty awesome especially if it comes from an accumulated knowledge over time. Truth be told, it's this system that keeps humans alive all these years.

When most of us see a snake, for example, we should thank our hot System One that tells us to "run" from it instead of activating the cold System Two to want to spend time pondering whether the snake is poisonous. There's also other uses of this hot system. In the first chapter of *Blink*, Gladwell discusses how the experts' cold system fails to detect a counterfeit feature of a statue.

Only when those experts rely less on their scientific findings from the statue but on their "gut feeling," they would be able to tell that "something doesn't feel right." What does this thinking, fast and slow, has to do with design? Because people are prone to use their hot System One to make a split second judgement of what they like and do not like, design has to somewhat appeal to this very system.

When asked, the Nobel Laureate Richard Thaler and the father of what is known today as behavioral economics argues that "People are not stupid; it's just the world is hard." So, according to a survey by Columbia University decision researcher Sheena Iyengar, we make more than 70 decisions everyday. Some of which have the potential to lead to a life-changing outcome. Wait a minute, 70 decisions???

That's a lot of decisions, according to Iyengar these decisions range from whether to take the usual route to work despite the traffic, or take a new route that you would risk getting lost and be late at work; to whether or not to ask your colleague next door out for lunch because it'd be a polite thing to do so even though you would rather eat alone because that's your habit and

you'd enjoy your meal better that way.

"The world is hard," as Thaler argues; it would have been much better if there's one way to get to work that is always free of traffic and that you and your colleague next door can speak your mind freely about what you would like your lunch to be like. Decisions, by definition, are paradoxical in nature, otherwise you would not have to make them.

You have to choose one and every time you choose, there's a path that is not taken that could lead to a totally different outcome. And sometimes that/those path(s) that are not taken would give you the sense of regret. The term "paradox of choice" coined by Barry Schwartz comes handy into the circle of popular lexicon in business, management and philosophy. Schwartz shows that the more choices we have to choose from the more likely we will regret those that we end up not choosing.

In fact, our obsession with choice thanks the doctrine of liberal economy (i.e., the more choices they are the better it is for the consumers to choose liberally and at will) encourages us to, unfortunately, seek that which makes us feel worse off after that choosing. Cognitive psychologists have shown us how limited our cognitive capacity is; hence, we resort to the quick intuitive system based on your gut feeling (sometimes quickly rationalized as the cold System Two) to make those decisions.

Well, I have been thinking that perhaps this very concept can be applied to design too. Many of us tend to think that we know and have solutions to things that we don't because of our hot, automatic, emotion-based, and "blinkish" System One. We tend to think that you can or can't design based on the split second decision that should not be used frequently to come up with a meditated solution. Before Kahneman, we might or might not already know that gut feeling is not always our best bet.

But it's Kahneman who first scientifically shows us that our judgments tend to improve if we remove our gut feelings. This is a truly meaningful knowledge that I always recall whenever I encounter any difficult situations

-- for whatever I was about to do to mitigate the situation, have I looked at the question and the situation enough with the cold System Two?

Because the gut feeling relies on your emotion before you have thought clearly about the problem, Dr Marshall Rosenberg, the father of the theory of non-violent communication, would also argue that the use of the hot System One to respond to a difficult question is a recipe for a violent communication. So, most designers will lose our jobs if humans are always rational in the economic sense.

We, in the words of Kanehman an Tversky, "are NOT intuitive statisticians" so we cannot always see through the big picture of things (i.e., the law of large number), and are always well prepared for the unexpected, unfamiliar, and unacquainted. As we know, that's not the case. We tend to prefer the expected, the familiar, and the acquainted; which explain somewhat the difficulty of any new products, services, and experiences into the new market.

There're so many instances that a great product failed to stay in the market because it did not appeal -- customers couldn't connect to it. So, the designers' task here is how do you design something that appeals to the intuitive system of the users so that the users would like to give it a try, and hopefully, to like more of it.

Here are the three main findings after having used Thinking, Fast and Slow in my design thinking class last term: First, Simplify, simplify and simplify -- The media and digital designer theorist and guru John Maeda writes in The Laws of Simplicity "The simplest way to achieve simplicity is through thoughtful reduction." Simple design tends to work better with human's limited cognitive capacity. Things that "look" and "feel" overly complicated tend to trick the hot System One to refuse it off hand.

Look at these remote controls below, which one would you want to hold in your hand and use? [gallery ids="4617,4618" type="rectangular"] Second, disentangle "truth" from "attitude" -- when we use the hot System One to

make a decision for us, we are prone to fail to distinguish between what is the truth and what is just an attitude.

Almost always, when you use the cold System Two to carefully evaluate a statement such as "That's impossible," you'll find out that that which is actually possible, but perhaps because it has never been done the idea of which automatically goes to the defensive mode of being called "impossible." There's a time, not so long ago, when it's understood as the "truth" that the Mainland Chinese was and would always be the cash-based society.

Credit card companies found it hard even to sell the idea of credit cards to their prospective customers. It's believed as the truth that Chinese people only trusted the materialistic aspect of cash -- if it's not red and in your hand then it's not money. Today, China is the fastest growing cashless society. One can walk out of the house for months without having a single Chinese Yuan and live a good life -- they can even buy a car or a house using their smartphone!

This was mainly because the pioneer of cashless payment in China understood that the idea that "Mainland Chinese was and would always be the cash-based society" was "just an attitude." Chinese did not trust the idea of credit cards, let alone third-party companies to whom the banks could resort in building cashless ecosystem, so they did not want to risk losing their money into the cyber clouds.

So, the first thing that this company did was to strengthen the financial security between the banks, rigorously test out the system in various condition, and eventually show it to the prospective customers how it work in reality -- using the "first rule of simplicity" as a guide. Third, shifting the existing perspectives -- What's the most important par of a toothbrush? Quick, quick, I need an answer now.

It had long been believed that the most important element of a toothbrush is the brush (dur!), until the company Oral-B sought help from an anthropologist to find out that it really did not matter how good the brush

was if the handle did not well fit the hand and facilitate the various movement needed for toothbrushing. Our hot system one tends to resort to the easiest way out -- and easiest answer too in this sense, but don't be too quick.

This is when the extended version of cold System Two that involves a long-term anthropological research in the community of people would help you to understand the key to problem-solving. A bonus -- find a uniform a wear it daily. People ask me why I only have a few shirts and pants.

All my photos in the past 3 years only feature myself in, at most, three kinds of outfit: a black or red t-shirt (98% of the time), a blue or white shirt (3% of the time) and a blazer on top of either a t-shirt or a shirt (2%) -- and those are basically all I possess in terms of clothing. My two pairs of pants are in dark black and navy blue. Those are all I actually have.

Because I have so few choices, my decision in the morning is automatic. I walk to a closet (or my balcony where I hang my clothes to dry), pick whatever I find first without wearing eyeglasses (hence I couldn't see and therefore my choice would be all random), and then whatever I picked up would become my outfit for the day.

These options that I have are also quite swap-able, so a combination of any of the available choices of pants and shirts would result in something quite acceptable (not like a red shirt, green jeans, and blue suede shoes of anything). Lo and behold, those are a lot of decisions that I no longer have to make in the morning, leaving more room for other things that are more important!

I do the same thing for fragrance -- I only have one of them so that I could skip the step of choosing which one to wear. The same research above about choices result in this very fascinating analysis about the success of people who like to wear a uniform by choice, as reported by Elle Kaplan: Look no further than President Barack Obama for the perfect solution. He once said, "You'll see I wear only gray or blue suits.

I'm trying to pare down decisions." It might be that our Commander in Chief and a slew of other successful business people (including Steve Jobs and Mark Zuckerberg) are on to something. Obama's approach might be a little extreme for the average businessperson, but he has the right idea. He's simply avoiding what many refer to as "decision fatigue", by trimming down the amount of choices he makes each day, and keeping his "willpower" in check for the right ones.

I sense that this "willpower" has something to do with Kahneman and Tversky -- in fact, it's another way of saying "cognitive capacity." In fact, most creative people stick to a few "classic clothes." Have you heard of a little book called *Why Architects Wear Black*? Honestly, I have not read it -- but I just couldn't agree more with the observation in the title of the book. So, starting from today, save your willpower for what really matters.

DAY 81

The Power of Now

Sun, 14 Sep 2025 00:00:00 +0000



WHEN MY FATHER PASSED AWAY in 2010 -- the black swan event of my life -- I was left with nothing much for which to live. I was not just devastated but also purposeless. All I felt was deep depression and that perhaps I could try to end all pain, the same way those who couldn't handle it anymore usually did.

I often couldn't sleep, and when I could I had a nightmare full of terrifying thoughts, from which I would get up only a few minutes afterwards with a sweaty palms, forehead and back. In fact, I found the writing about one particular moment in the life of Eckhart Tolle resonates directly with how I felt back then: One night not long after my twenty-ninth birthday, I woke up in the early hours with a feeling of absolute dread.

I had woken up with such a feeling many times before, but this time it was more intense than it had ever been. The silence of the night, the vague outlines of the furniture in the dark room, the distant noise of a passing train — everything felt so alien, so hostile, and so utterly meaningless that it created in me a deep loathing of the world. The most loathsome thing of all, however, was my own existence.

What was the point in continuing to live with this burden of misery? Why carry on with this continuous struggle? I could feel that a deep longing for annihilation, for nonexistence, was now becoming much stronger than the instinctive desire to continue to live. I was about to turn 29 when my father passed away. The state of mind described vividly by Eckhart Tolle in this passage from his book *The Power of Now* was identical to how I felt back then.

Not only did I not want to live, but I also loathed my existence, with the lingering dreadful question "Why me?" As Nicholas Nassim Taleb writes in *The Black Swan*, events that have a huge impact on our lives can easily be reasoned backwardly. We human beings tend to do that in order to make sense of it, so that we can continue our existence. Such a viewpoint is not wrong, but the effect of which is not always positive.

In other words, what's the benefit of telling yourself that you could have prevented what you could not possibly know was coming? In fact, psychologically, it's even much more damaging than just to let it go, and accept that we human beings have so many limitations -- be it cognitive or physical -- so what we can do is to learn from the past so that, perhaps, we can try to avoid making the same mistake.

That said, not all mistakes are the same, and most of the time, as history shows, conditions leading to a particular mistake is never exactly the same. As Taleb uses both the 9/11 attacks and the 2008 financial meltdown as examples of black swans, perhaps we can argue that we have been preventing another one of those from happening using the knowledge we have learned from the past.

More close-circuit cameras have been installed in public areas and more regulations against irresponsible investment and potential harmful derivatives have been put in place. But these would only prevent the exact horrors of both events from happening the way they happened. What if they're taking slightly different forms, based on completely different sets of pre-conditions? So, every mistake is, in fact, a black swan in itself. How can

we learn to prevent that from happening?

As I continued to think about my father again during those dreadful suicidal sleepless nights following his departure, I kept rewinding in my head what I could have done. I could have spent more time with him when he was still alive. I could have visited him more often when he was still alive. I could have been a better student so that he would not have to be so worried about me when he was still alive..

I could have been a better son so that he didn't have to be so stressful when he was still alive. In fact, I reasoned backward -- it would have been nice had I never been born. Two reasons: He wouldn't have smoked so much owing to stress (which perpetually had severe impact on his health) had I not born to become a financial burden to our resource-poor family; and that if I had never been born, I would not have to be depressed.

All of these were the true feelings that came to me during the time. Recently, I have been writing a series of posts on design thinking.

As I wrote about in my last post, one of the key issues with "thinking" is that we have two systems in the mind: the "hot" and automatic System One that, based on our past experience, wants to make all the decisions quickly; and the "cold" and lazy yet meditative System Two that wants to take into account as much data as it could (like a sage) before making the most optimal decision on our behalf.

In the ideal world, we would all preferable prefer System Two, but the only problem is that System Two, as the psychologist Daniel Kahneman writes in *Thinking, Fast and Slow*, "is lazy and the mental effort is aversive." Only after a few months after my father's death that I had begun to see things differently. First, my mother was worried because I looked suicidal. She, too, was as sad as I was, if not more, losing the love of her life and her marriage partner for 35 years.

My father and mother knew each other before they got married; so, they, in fact, already celebrated their 40th anniversary of their love before my father

died. In other words, overshadowing the very fact that I still had my mother was my worries about the past. I did not live in the moment -- and that "thinking" almost killed me. Almost a decade after that, I asked myself, was that "backward reasoning" System One or System Two?

Clearly it was not hot and automatic, so it could not be the System One. On the other hand, I failed completely to see a slightly bigger picture -- the fact that I still had my mother, my older brother, my extended family members, my caring friends, my colleagues, my teachers and mentors, who did not want to see me in that state of deep depression. Both the psychologists Daniel Kahneman and Amos Tversky have written about the difference between the "experiencing" and the "memorizing" selves.

These are the two selves that are not the same, and there're, in fact, many tricks to appeal to the "memorizing self" that a painful and earth-shattering event that we have "experienced" isn't that bad.

One of the examples frequently use to illustrate this very idea was their experiment with patients undergoing colonoscopy, or (and I resort to a dictionary) "a procedure in which a flexible fiber-optic instrument is inserted through the anus in order to examine the colon." The process, needless to say, was a not a painless process (and since I have never had one myself I could not say much about my "experience" or the "memory" of it).

The illustration above might give you some idea of how painful the process could be. Both psychologists were able to show that the group of patients who had gone through a longer operation, which presumably meant that they had to endure more pain, could walk out of the examination room feeling "less painful" about the operation than those who went through a much quicker process. How could that be?

Anchoring the "memorizing self" was what they call the "peak-end rule," a mental shortcut in which we judge any particular experience based on how it was felt at its peak. So, since the most painful part of the colonoscopy was the end of the process when the instrument was moving. Leaving the

instrument in the bodies of the patients without moving for three extra minutes though yielded an uncomfortable sensation actually did not involve pain; therefore creating a "memory bias" that the overall process was not as painful.

To those from whose bodies the instrument was taken out right away after the operation, they reported the process as "painful." The patients whose operation time was three minutes longer, therefore, tended to remember the process as "not as bad as they thought," compared to those whose "memorizing self" remembered the peak of the pain as the peak end of the process. So, in this sense, if I try to use this theory to understand my pain toward the departure of my father.

What was the peak-end of my father's death? As I wrote earlier, my father passed away unexpectedly in Thailand, while I was away in the States. I did not have a chance to say good bye. I did not know much about his sickness. In other words, there's no closure. Would I feel less pain if I had mentally prepared myself for his death? Would I feel that it's less unexpected?

Would I feel that his death was timely, knowing that he had endure the pain for years and this was the right way to go? In Daniel Lewis account of Daniel Kahneman's own pain of losing his twenty-one-year-old nephew Ilan who was a navigator in the back of an Israeli fighter during the Yom Kippur war in 1973. There's a "black swan" kind of incidence during which Ilan could have been killed but he survived the war.

But a year and a half later, in March 1975, five days before he was to be released from service, he was killed in a plane crash. Lewis writes in *The Undoing Project: A Friendship That Changed Our Minds* about Kahneman's state of mind: After Ilan's death, Danny couldn't help but notice the urge in those who loved him to mentally undo his plane crash.

Many of the sentences that came from their lips might just as well have started with the words "if only." If only Ilan had been released from the Air Force a week earlier. If only he'd taken charge after his pilot was blinded by

that flare. People's minds coped with loss by drifting onto fantasy paths, where loss never occurred. But this drifting, Danny noticed, wasn't random. There appeared to be constraints on the mind when it created alternatives to reality.

If Ilan had still had a year of service remaining when his plane crashed, no one would have said, "If only he had been released a year ago." No one said, "If only the pilot had the flu that day" or "If only Ilan's plane had been grounded for mechanical problems." For that matter, no one said, "If only Israel had not had an Air Force." Any of those counterfactuals would have saved his life -- but none of them came to the minds of those who loved him.

Again, was this the operation of System One or System Two? In a black swan incident such as this, the activation of System One would blind us from seeing a bigger picture -- that many people also got killed. It's a war, what do you expect? Anyone going into a war should be prepared to give their life to the service, so should the family members. But in an incidence like this, does thinking about it that way help to ease the pain "memorized" during the unfortunately lack-of-closure peak-end?

What this shows is that we are not all the rational, even with the use of System Two, especially when we are blinded by the force of the memorizing self. Why should we feel about something according to what we "memorize it" rather than how we "experience it?" That would be like hating someone for what he/she did not do.

A death is a death. It should not matter when a person dies. We will die anyway and there's no way out of it. So, if we're to use the hyper-meditated System Two, we should actually be celebrating the passing through of, what the writer Milan Kundera would call, "the unbearable lightness of being." But we know that's not how our mind works. In fact, the experience of someone's dying is not upon us. Surely I wasn't with my father when he died. I didn't know his pain.

I wasn't "experiencing" the colonocapic pain with him the way my mother, who had taken care of him during his last months, was probably experiencing. Yet, how come I came to remember his death as untimely which almost drove me to an irreversible act? If only I was there when he died, there would be an "memorizable closure," and thanks to that I would feel less pain? I asked myself this question. What's it? A deep regret for not being there for him? A moral backward reasoning?

Then I slipped into the thinking that it would have been painful to everyone around me had I decided to leave this world upon the death of my father. Eckhart Tolle didn't and he's now using his experience to help other people through his teaching of what he calls "the power of now." Eckhart Tolle argues that most of us are not living -- because we do not see ourselves in the "now." This may sound like an absurd thing to say. What do you mean?

Of course I know what the now is, the now is now. I am who I am at the moment. There's a even a tense to describe that state of being -- it's called the "present tense." We seem to miss a few points here according to Tolle. Here're the key point: First, we "think" too much, so we lose our grip on the "now." When Tolle himself was depressed during the 29th year of his life, it's because he thought too much about the past and the future.

None of us is perfect and we're living day by day with our imperfection. The idea of the mistake in the past that keeps expounding upon our present is what drives mad, and, more important, away from the "now." Often, our memory of the mistakes in the past may not have much to do with the actual experience -- remember the difference between the "memorizing" and the "experiencing" self?

But when we "think" about something, the memorizing self cabinet is, by default, that which we open in order to recall our memories. Daniel Kahneman calls this psychological effect the "focusing illusion" which is well summarized in his quote: Nothing in life is as important as you think it is while you are thinking about it. Think about it. It's important (while you're thinking about it). So, Tolle suggests that actually should not be "thinking,"

not fast and not slow -- but not thinking at all.

As I have shown, even the cold and often-reliable System Two is a victim of our "memorizing self" -- and where does that memorizing self come from? It comes from the past. Now, what about the other devil: the future? Tolle argues that the future is equally problematic.

I recall a famous Zen comic strip by the legendary Taiwanese illustrator Tsai Chih-Chung: The Buddha asks his disciples to guess "how long a person's life is" -- of course, like any Zen's teaching you could never guess the right answer although whatever it is it would be profound. And the answer is "a person's life is only as long as the length of our breath." This example resonates with me deeply, especially because that was the true reason for my father's death.

Illness might be the reason why he felt ill, but his chronic lung disease that prevented him from "making that one breath" was what eventually killed him. My father was thinking of coming to visit me in the States once he had gotten better -- but that never happened because he could no longer take the one breath at a time he needed to, simply, stay alive. Think about that for a moment. Tolle suggests that we should systematically "break down" the "now" into its most atomic element.

The "now" is not today, not this hour, not this minute, not this second -- and not even this very moment. Let's not talk about your planned holiday next year, or your dinner with your lover tonight: What if you cannot breathe anymore right now. So, the now resides in the length of our breath. So, a practical advise? (I am not yet there myself but I want to say what I think I want to make it my goal to achieve).

Breathe and, while breathing, be thankful for every breath that you and I are still able to take -- and just that (and let't just focus at that for now and forget, also for now, about that every move you make, every bond you break, and every step you take -- no one is actually watching you).

As I said, I have not been able to do that fully myself but I believe that which is the best way to activate our System Two to work with our actual "experiencing self" in the now. Now, was it accidental that, 8 years after my father's death, I got to inherit Eckhart Tolle's *The Power of Now A Guide to Spiritual Enlightenment* from my mother who happened to have just finish reading it and left it in our apartment? It doesn't matter.

All I want to focus on is my breath.

post Day 82: How not to "Choke" Mon, 15 Sep 2025 00:00:00 +0000 I have received a lot of wonderful comments from my last post: *The Power of Now*. In this post, I want to combine the 12 rules for life and the power of now, in order to lay out clearly why and how the life we are living, no matter how difficult it seems, is not all that bad.

In a few words, the real enemy here is what the psychologist Daniel Kahneman (and by now you should know how much I admire him) calls "focusing illusion" an important concept in cognitive psychology to which I have previously alluded. We tend to "think too much" about something that is usually not as important as it -- but only seems important because you happen to be "thinking" about it.

In fact, many people "choke" (i.e., a nickname for the act of failing something miserably when you almost win) when they're focusing too much about winning -- when they should be focusing on the very drive, chip and putt that they're about to perform. Confucius then uses the example of an archery contest to illustrate the harmful effect of consciously focusing on extraneous concerns: "If you're betting for broken bits of potsherd you can shoot with perfect skill—there is nothing at stake.

If you start betting for belt buckles, you become worried about your aim. By the time you start betting for gold, you're completely petrified. Your actual skill is the same in all three cases, but because of the relative value you place on these objects, you end up paying more attention to extraneous things. It is always the case that those who focus on the outside become clumsy on the

inside." We couldn't ask for a better summary of the problem facing the athletes and performers.

Such people have fallen out of their usual, they have become alienated from the goals, the values, and the "flow" of play. It is not that their actual physical skill has changed, it's that they've allowed concern with externalities to make them "clumsy on the inside." The above passage comes from a gem of a book *Trying Not to Try* by Professor Edward Slingerland, using an ancient Chinese way of looking at our ability to focus.

When you do not pay your complete attention to the "now," and focusing on the idea of winning, that idea of winning becomes the focusing illusion that makes you think that which is so important -- more important than the action you're about to engage in. When that happens, you happens to "choke." the renowned researcher on this topic (and also the current President of Barnard College) Sian L.

Beilock argues: And the idea is that if you normally devote lots of cognitive resources to what you're doing and being in a pressure-filled situation robs you of those resources, you can't perform as well. The writer Mark Mason writes vividly in his *The Subtle Art of Not Giving a F*ck: A Counterintuitive Approach to Living a Good Life*: Chances are you know somebody in your life who, at one time or another, did not give a fuck and then went on to accomplish amazing feats.

Perhaps there was a time in your own life when you simply did not give a fuck and excelled to some extraordinary height.

post Day 83: On Design Thinking Part 5: The Power of Diversity Tue, 16 Sep 2025 00:00:00 +0000 In my previous blog *On Design Thinking Part 1: The Gist*, I have outlined the three key ideas of design thinking.

Let's recap in these timeless words: "If I had asked people what they wanted, they would have said faster horses" -- Henry Ford who, as we know, did not create a faster horse, but a car; "Imagine if this building will become the prototype of every building of its kind, what should it be like?" (I obviously

paraphrase the architect Louis I. Kahn's here).

Kahn argues that relying on the existing precedents don't lead to great design, or what he calls, a "thoughtful making of space" (also, simply put by Black Panther) "Just because something works doesn't mean it can't be improved"); and, finally, "Simplicity is about subtracting the obvious and adding the meaningful" -- John Maeda, the author of *The Laws of Simplicity*, in which he obviously argues that more is not more, and less is not more, unless the less is full of the meaningful (think about it for a moment -- it's important).

Rhode Island School of Design (RISD) President John Maeda and the author of *The Laws of Simplicity*. So, how do we bring all of this together. Based on my years of working with creative minds, the solution is simple: Diversify. That is, the more you can get people who have other ways of seeing involved, the more you can come up with better strategies to enhance your competitive advantage. So, here're the practical solutions.

First, when starting a project, form a group that consist of people from, at least, three different disciplines. Of course, for example, to design and build a house you'd need an architect, a civil engineer, and electrical engineer and so on. But these disciplines are not considered as diverse -- as they're all "technical." They're the defenders of practicality. Now, imagine if you could get an artist who could conceptual the mass, volume, dynamics, and quality of the interior space.

Imagine if you could get a writer who understands where best to put a desk. Imagine if you could get a chef who would know very well the essential circulation of a kitchen. These are "experts" in their own light who can help you to form a different way of thinking about a house. Now, if you imagine something less concrete, say you would like to re-write a policy, regulation, rule, or something.

"If you only have a hammer as a tool, you'll see everything as a nail," the old saying goes. Your policy, rule, and regulation will likely to be one-sided if you

think alone. One time behavioral psychologists only think of behavioral change in terms of punishment and reward: give people what they want when they do the right thing and punish them when they don't.

Maybe you'll come up with this similar "punishment-and-reward" scheme to get people to do things that you deem appropriate, but what if "nudging" -- or motivating the right behavior by ways of cognitive psychology -- is another option that is simply more effective both in terms of behavioral change and cost? Second, show your project idea to a child. This might sound absurd but believe me you'll learn something rather intriguing.

The executive of a world's famous design consultancy IDEO Tom Kelly also writes in *The Ten Faces of Innovation* that one of the secrets of the firm's success is how they constantly test out their fun prototypes with curious kids. One of the things that I always learn from kids are how much what I see in the world as "truth" are simply my own "attitude." Again, the former cannot be changed, but the latter is all up for grabs.

My little cousin, who will turned 12 this year, for instance, is amazing at giving me interesting advice based on: Simplicity: My little cousin though can easily be pleased sometime with the most basic things, she dislikes complicated things. The more complicated things are, the more she's likely to be bored by; Imagination: She can conjure up a lot of interesting ideas that have yet to be confined by our adult's experience; Fun: My cousin would not engage in anything that is not fun.

So, she's trying to make everything fun (including studying). So, when testing my idea on anything with her, I need to make sure that whatever I propose will give both the meaning and playfulness to those involved in the process; and, Elevator pitch: My sister doesn't have a lot of patience. So, if I can't get my idea across to attract her attention within 15 seconds, her mind would have wondered elsewhere and that I would have to buy her an ice-cream to get her back.

Third, before brainstorm, "brainwrite." There have been many research that show many detrimental aspects of brainstorming, even at some of the world's most famous creative agencies. The problem of brainstorming is the problem of human's survival, namely "social proof," "appeal to authority," and sometimes, simply, "the loudest get to lead." We tend to be "intimated" by ideas that (may not be as good, but somehow) garner a lot of support from other people. We tend to want to lay low when our idea is that of the minority's.

Most of all, we tend to not wanting to risk if the ideas that are being discussed belong to the authority and superior. We haven't even taken into account here the gender, age, and social class dimensions, let alone implicit biases on race, gender, sexual orientation, and so on.

Many times I find myself in a situation whereby I have something to say, but everyone else seems to have formed a stronger opinion on something else so I don't dare to say anything else that will contradict such an already-established opinion. This is especially the case when these brainstorm sessions are conducted in the languages that I am not good at, and among those whose socioeconomic statuses are higher than mine. All of these make voicing one's ideas very very difficult in a brainstorm session.

All of these are enemies of creativity. So, to get some creative ideas to come out, we must eliminate all of these fertile grounds of miss opportunity for creativity (i.e., "mis-creativity"). We must not let what the psychologist Robert B. Cialdini calls "social proof," and "appeal to authority" get in the way.

In one instance during which I was asked by a CEO of a start-up to help him build his new company, he says that the biggest problem of his company is that: Even though I have tried to eliminate hierarchy in my company (e.g., by eliminating dress code, everyone including the CEO rotates hot desks, nick-names only workplace, etc.), it still seems as though no one wants to speak up about their fresh and great ideas.

It's like we have to wait until the New Year's party that some of these great ideas are heard -- but in a form of, "Today is the end of the year, for the past 365 days of this year I had been having this great idea but I didn't think it was good enough so I had kept it to myself." And that's not helping. It's bad for the company when great ideas are kept to the employees themselves.

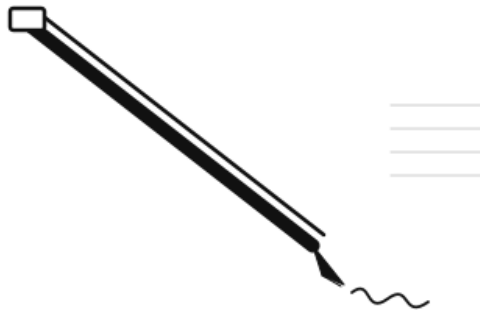
How can we enable these great ideas to come out all the time? The suggestion here is get the team to write their ideas on post-it notes -- and the same rules for brainstorm, which is to go for quantity and not quality, must apply here. Since nobody has heard anyone else's ideas yet, this "brainwriting" process will incubate individual's ideas without any external influence.

Brainwriting also helps the manager or anyone in charge of the creative process to gauge the diversity of the team as well as the potential of the team dynamic.

DAY 84

On Design Thinking Part 6: Stoicism

Wed, 17 Sep 2025 00:00:00 +0000



IF I WERE TO WRITE my own list of " what I should have known before turning 20," the top of the list would have been Stoicism.

In fact, it might have been the only thing on the list -- as the philosophers Zeno, Musonius Rufus, Seneca, Epictetus, and Marcus Aurelius have summarized it all for us on the very topic of "how to live a good life." Wait, wait, wait, I am not selling you stoicism as a philosophy of life here in this post (although I am actually very tempted to).

My goal in this post, as the title suggests, is to show you how and why this 2,000+ years old way of thinking could enhance our way of designing in the 21st century. Let's start with why I think I would have lived a much better life past my 20 had I known about Stoicism back then.

I must have alluded to my love for Stoicism somewhere in the past 80+ posts, and for sure in an interview (in Chinese) that I gave to my former student, I did talk about how Marcus Aurelius' personal note to himself compiled as Meditations has completely changed my way of seeing the world. Over the past few months, I have been re-reading Stoicism from the perspectives of Zeno, Musonius Rufus, Seneca, and Epictetus, through which I have learned so much about what I missed reading only Marcus Aurelius' Meditations.

When dealing with the death of my father, for instance, I perhaps would have been much more calm and accepting had I used, a psychological trick that the Stoics calls, "negative visualization" to pre-live the world without him in it before he passed. I would have been much more prepared, and therefore less shock when it happened. I would also have cherished every moment with him more; hence, wouldn't feel so much of a sense of regret.

I would have also thanked him for the 62 years my father's contribution to the world (and 29 years to my life) rather than his absence. And the list goes on. In other words, had I been a Stoic, I would have dealt with that black-swan-kind-of-blow much more calmly. First, a disclaimer I am not philosophy major student and my reading of classical Greek and Roman is non-existence. So, my knowledge of Stoicism here is second-handed, based on what I have read from the four books below.

[gallery ids="4674,4675,4676,4677" type="rectangular"] I'm going to get right into it. These are the 4 things I learned from Stoicism that I wish I had learned at least 16 years earlier. The single most important idea of Stoicism is "know what's in your control." Rule#1: There're only two things in life you can control: Your opinion and your value. Marcus Aurelius once said: "You only have power over your mind, not outside events.

Realize this, and you will find strength." This rule, I believe, is the foundation of everything that has to do with Stoicism. Everything else is not in your your total control. So, knowing this very important fact, we should live a worry-free life about the tennis game we are going play, the result of the job application we have just submitted, the opinion of other people on you, etc.

Those are things that you do not have the total control; hence, they're not worthwhile your time; Rule#2: Opinions of others should have no effect on you. Insults, gossip, rumor and hateful words can be sources of misery, sadness, grudge. We all sort of unrealistically want the world to like us -- however absurd that sounds. I have seen so many people who cannot get over the fact that someone just criticized them -- someone whom they don't even like!

When a Stoic is asked how he feels about an unreasonably hateful opinions from his oppositions, his respond is simply (as paraphrased by the philosopher William Irvine) "If he [my opposition] disapproves of what I am doing, then what I am doing is doubtless the right thing to do." Again, other people's opinions are not one of the two things that you can control. Rule#3: Seek joy from what you already have, rather than from what you don't. Many people misunderstand Stoicism.

See, even in a respectable dictionary, the definition of being stoic/stoical is "Enduring pain and hardship without showing one's feelings or complaining: he taught a stoical acceptance of suffering." This dictionary and many people think that Stoics, therefore, must be sad, emotionless, and perhaps also quite joyless because they always have to endure pain and hardship. On top of that, Stoics do not seek or expect pleasure, fame and fortune to come their way. Wait, no pleasure, no fame, no fortune ---- what a tribe?

In fact, the Stoics already know that most of the time the reason why we are not happy is precisely because we constantly seek and expect pleasure, fame and fortune. When we get what we want, we are happy -- but only for a short time as we need to find more things to fulfill our continuing desire.

And as these thing are sought after not just by us but by many others (hence limited in number), their availability is never entirely in our control (back to Rule #1); hence, they're likely -- very likely -- to be the source of unhappiness, joylessness, and discontents.

So, instead of wanting what you don't already have, and using your physical energy and willpower on things you cannot control, "look inwardly" at things that you can control (Rule#1: your value and your opinion) and use them to your own advantage. You can simply change your value and opinion to like what you already have. Isn't that much easier? So, Stoics are not emotionless or sad; quite the opposite, they are always joyful because they are happy with what they already have.

Rule#4: Focus on the means, and not the end. Wait, so does that mean that Stoics are usually poor and powerless? Since they don't seek and expect pleasure, fortune and fame? Well, no.

In fact, quite the opposite: Marcus Aurelius was one of the greatest Emperor of Rome (and therefore the most powerful person in the western world); Seneca was a man of letters (in addition to being a statesman, a playwright, a tutor and a private advisor to Emperor Nero) who was, among other things, also the richest man in the Empire; Musonius Rufus and Epictetus ran their own top educational institutions (so they would be like President of Harvard and Princeton today).

These were all, in the strictest sense of the term, quite ambitious people, if not down right overachieving. The list of Stoics who are also successful is actually very long! How did they do it? Well, these guys were successful precisely because they were not doing things purely to seek pleasure, fame and fortune. They're doing their jobs because they "enjoyed" doing their jobs -- either because those jobs were their duty to the society, or they simply "loved" their jobs.

Again, since outcomes of anything are never in your control (Rule#1 again), focus your mind on the task that you enjoy is the best path way to success. When competing (be it tennis, exam, or whatever) you can control your mind to focus on "doing your best" -- whether or not you'll qualified for the Wimbledon is no longer in your control. Even if the success doesn't come, you're still not sad about it because you're neither doing it for the success, nor you're having any expectation about it (rule#3).

Now, these rules, if you could apply them well in your life, should already make you an employee/student/colleague of the month. These are qualities that everyone expects from you as a person in the society. You'll be the kind of employee/student/colleague who is not only happy with the job assigned to you, seek joy from what you already have, never complain about opinions of others, and, most importantly, hold dearest your own value of how you would like to be in the world.

In a way, if you can try to apply these rules i your life you are using design thinking to "re-design" your existence. Knowing what you can and can't control, you will be able to face with anything, including those moments when you are looking down at a frightening bottomless hole into which you are going to jump. In other words, Stoicism is an antidote to the black swan. If we're to push Stoic one step further, what about design thinking?

Turns out I am not the only one writing about this. There're quite a few great advise. Let's get right into it -- three more rules; stoicism for design thinkers! Rule#5: Try to live like a not-have, every once in a while. Yes, that's right. Stoics are known for their "negative visualization" -- imagining what's the worst thing that can happen. Well, the answer to that is obviously "death," but that wouldn't do you any good since you cannot simulate your own death.

How, how about "poverty?" Even Seneca, the richest man on earth during his prime, would allow himself to live like a beggar every once in a while. His reasons? To know the condition of the poor for whom he hope to serve, and to simulate the condition of hardship that he himself, despite being an upperclass man, might also have to face if things didn't go as planned. For us?

There's a saying that "innovation grows out of necessity." When you're dealing with less, you automatically relocated your cognitive capacity to things that matter (remember how Steve Jobs wore the same clothes everyday?). Plus, you'll get to experience the kind of world that you otherwise (without this volunteering to live with less) would not have been able to experience and empathize. The author Nassim Nicholas Taleb would call this "being anti-fragile." In the sense, "being anti-fragile" is to be opposite of being fragile. Who wants to be fragile?

If you don't want your entire life and soul to be rocked by a black swan event, you'd need to get ready for it; in this case, it may take some simulation of a black swan event to make you the opposite of fragile.

Try this yourself, try walk out of the house without your smartphone for a week; and you'll find out by yourself what aspects of that smartphone that you miss the most (as for me, I thought it was the camera, which as it turned out, I didn't miss one bit; so I was very very wrong to use the quality of the camera as the single most important factor for my latest purchase of a smartphone...).

The music channel MTV did precisely this with their famous "Deprivation Study" that resulted in something quite spectacularly awesome. Rule#6: Don't just talk about it, do it. In design practice, we have magic word that we like to say when we're getting stuck. "Show me." Instead of debating with one another or in the team how possible/impossible your idea is, we'd just pack up and go the workshop (wood shop, metal shop, etc) and just prototype our idea.

That's the "show me," instead of "talk about it" principle; and usually it works like magic. Stoicism is not a theoretical philosophy. It doesn't ask you to analyze everything epistemologically, linguistically and ontologically before you can go ahead and make use of its wisdom -- it presents you with the most reasonable, ecological and resilient solution to whatever problems you are facing -- sometimes even before you're facing them. So, take it to heart that you don't have to "think" to live a good philosophical life.

Epictetus once said: "Don't explain your philosophy. Embody it." You, also, can just do it. Rule#7: Fail fast, and get up quickly. This rule is particularly important to design thinking. We want our first prototype to "suck" so that we know what works and what isn't. It's unfortunate that we're living in the era whereby people think that the more time you spend "failing," the less likely you'd make it to the top.

Look at all the awards to be given specific to the "young talents" or those "under 40s" -- what's the obsession with young age? Stoics do not have any time to care about these nonsense. They understand, again, what we can and can't control, and see through it how everyone has our own pace in learning, and finally, achieving whatever we want in this short lifespan on this earth.

Having a goal is in our control -- as a goal is an opinion -- so the Stoics are fine with that, but at the end of the day, whether or not one could arrive at that goal is no longer something that is in your control, so let it go. The best way of achieving your goal is to fail fast, so that you can identify what doesn't work, fix them, and try it again.

In other words, in the words of Marcus Aurelius, "What doesn't kill you makes you stronger." Alright, so I hope I have convinced you the beauty of Stoicism and how we can apply them in design thinking. One more thing. A bonus rule: You weren't meant to procrastinate. Stoics don't believe that we should waste our time on anything. They believe that we all have our duty to fulfill.

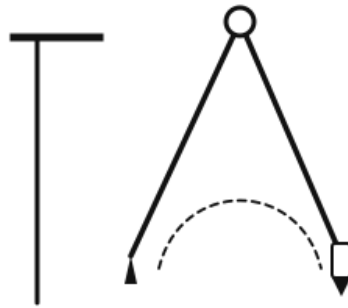
Even if you don't have a job, you have the duty as a human being to be productive, if not to other people than to yourself. So, a practical advise? Never allow yourself to roll around in your bed for more than one minute. After that, get up and make your bed (research shows that the very sense of completion of making your bed gives you a jump start of the day).

Do everything you need to do to get yourself ready to work -- even if you don't have a job. Brush your teeth, have a cold shower (to get your blood flowing), and wear something nice (even if you are working from home, never wear a pajama and be at your desk!). Get to work!

DAY 85

On Design Thinking Part 7: The Four Noble Truth

Thu, 18 Sep 2025 00:00:00 +0000



A FEW MONTHS BACK DURING a Facebook Live Interview with a news correspondent Dr Nattha Komolvadhin on the topic of design thinking, I had alluded to the similarities between notion of problem-finding and solving of design thinking and of Buddhism. Ever since I have been asked by a few colleagues to explain in details. Specifically, I talked about how similar between the "Four Noble Truth" and the problem-understanding/defining/solving process of design thinking.

Let me begin with the specific quote from the Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT) Sloan School of Management defines the "four steps" of design thinking: At a high level, the steps involved in the design thinking process are simple: first, fully understand the problem; second, explore a wide range of possible solutions; third, iterate extensively through prototyping and testing; and finally, implement through the customary deployment mechanisms. These four steps are almost universally known in the design thinking communities to be, sort of, conventional steps.

There're many names: Understand the problem > Explore the possible solution > Iteration > Implementation; Define > Ideate > Prototype > Test;

Clarify > Ideate > Develop > Implement; Discovery > Interpretation > Ideation > Experimentation; Etc.

Xerox (yes, the company whose name almost becomes synonymous with photocopying) has its 6 Steps to Lasting Improvement, which contains: Step 1: Recognize the Need; Step 2: Consider Your Options; Step 3: Gain Insight; Step 4: Take Action; Step 5: Make It a Habit; and, Step 6: Overcome Setbacks. As you can say, these 6 steps are pretty much the same as the 4 steps or the 5 step of design thinking above (and below in the diagram). Xerox's Step 4 is the prototype step.

The additional Step 6 is the evaluation step that, argues Xerox, could lead to better improvement of its products, services and experiences. Despite different terms used, they're similar aspects in these approaches to problem solving. The key, for all of these, is the identification of the "real problem," and not to create another problem as a result of trying to solve a problem.

As I have written about earlier, one of the most potential ways of seeing such a "real problem" is to not let your "expertise" determine too quickly what it is that you are supposed to do. For instance, a couple weeks ago I was giving a design thinking workshop at Chiang Mai. One of the audiences had a noodle stall and she wanted to use design thinking to create a new competitive advantage for her small business.

Having an teenage child, she's completely fixated on the idea that her noodle shop was outdated, and had to appeal to younger people; and, therefore it must look more "hip and cool." Many participants in the workshop, who're in the interior design business, gave this noodle stall's owner a lot of advice on interior design, and how might she attempt to "evolve" the decoration of her noodle shop to fit the 21st century Chiang Mai.

But the obvious question (AKA "the elephant in the room") is shouldn't we be asking the most basic question: Is your noodle delicious? This is a great example of an instance in which if we only have a hammer all problems will be nails.

In *Without and Within: Questions and Answers on the Teachings of Theravada Buddhism*, (available for free as a PDF file) the Venerable Ajahn Jayasaro writes the following about the meaning of Buddha's Four Noble Truth (Disclaimer: I am not an expert on Buddhism although I have recently expanded my reading list to cover a huge amount of work on the subject as a result of my seeing a deep connection between the ways of understanding problems in Buddhism and design industries): There is dukkha -- a chronic unsatisfactoriness of unenlightened existence; There is a cause of dukkha.

It is dependent upon certain causes and conditions; There is a cessation of dukkha; and, There is a path leading to the ending of dukkha. Now, to me, I think that is quite obvious the similarity between the 4-fold process of design thinking and the 4-fold process of the Four Noble Truth.

I particular like the idea of Dukka (Pli; Sanskrit: dukha; Tibetan:) !% being "a chronic unsatisfactoriness of unenlightened existence" (also translated as "the lack of true happiness." I mean, how many times that we have complained about a product, service, and experience that cause us some kind of chronic dissatisfaction? As someone who constantly looks for good design, this is the dukka that I have to deal with daily.

Even though I m no perfectionist, I constant see "bad designs" from the moment that I walk out of my door. From the design of the public pavement, to the lack of coordination of signage in the metro system, to the toiler paper dispenser in a public toiler, I am constantly bombarded with dukka.

I need to keep in mind two very important Buddhist/Stoic thoughts: I can only control my value and opinion, and there is a true nature of the way things are (and which you have no power to change) Noted that in Buddhism, there's only one source of dukka: Our constant and insatiable desire to be stimulated by things that are external of us. Instead of being content with our own existence, we consistently seek better food, better clothes, better awards, better praises, better places to visit, and so on.

And after achieving one, you have to constantly set a new goal to achieve the next, relentlessly and ceaselessly. So, what's the solution? In short, the Four Noble Truth is to reconnect us with the way of the nature. Naturally, we don't crave a Louis Vitton bag, a Pulitzer Prize, and a fried banana with Icelandic caviar (the last item is made up by me). The "Eightfold Paths" to end all dukka begins with having the "right view," followed by right intention, speech, action, livelihood, effort, mindfulness, and, eventually, concentration.

Nature gives us just enough what we need to live a good life. In other words, in the words of the creative company IDEO founder David Kelly himself, he thinks the Tibetans are right to use the term "nature" in lieu of "technology," "innovation" and "creativity." A true technology, innovation, creativity do no less than connecting us with our nature. That is, the path to inner peace and calm ("tranquility" for the Stoics) is to not let your life depend on external stimulus.

The Venerable Ajahn Jayasaro (In Thai) also writes: We seek happiness in things that inevitably disappoint us; we avoid things that would lead to our long-term welfare. In short, we are our own worst enemy. Dukka in this sense, is a "problem" that a design thinker faces. Let's see if we can unpack the notion of the Four Noble Truth to help those design better.

And this could be anything from an overly-complicated remote control that causes the users "a chronic unsatisfactoriness of unenlightened existence," a noodle stall that doesn't seem to be attracting its customers despite its awesome broth and handmade rice noodle, or a life that doesn't seem to give the sense of satisfaction. So, let's see if we can use the simplicity of Four Noble Truth to tackle a design problem. There is dukkha -- a chronic unsatisfactoriness of unenlightened existence.

Let's say that in design, dukka is our dissatisfaction with whatever "conditional problems" that we think we can use design to solve. In this case, "conditional problems" have to do with the conditions of a particular situation. Something that works in one place/context/operation might not work in others because of such different conditions. So, keep that in mind.

We might call this process an "exploration." There is a cause of dukkha. It is dependent upon certain causes and conditions.

Now that we know that there is a design dissatisfaction, the next thing that we must do is to find out what is the real causes and sources of that condition. This is where you'd need more than yourself to help you think. As I wrote in my previous post, you need more diverse eyes to help see and understand what might lie at your blind spot.

In design splint, we conducted ethnographic research, brainwrite, and brainstorm to find the true causes and sources of the problem along with thinking about practical solutions. Let's call this process "define and ideation."; There is a cessation of dukkha. Yes, bad designs should not even be called designs and should come to end. It's we who will put an end to it. But how? In the previous post, I discuss the Stoic's use of the "show me" approach to design.

So, instead of endlessly discussing how we are going to put an end to a bad design, we might as well "just do it." This is when we use rapid prototype to test out the ideas. It must be kept in mind that the "cessation of dukkha" is the main goal here. Let's call this process "prototyping (a series of problem-solving potentials)." There is a path leading to the ending of dukka. In Buddhism, this is when the "Eightfold Path" comes in.

To have all the "right" things in place (i.e., action, livelihood, effort, mindfulness, concentration), dukka cannot find it form in your consciousness. But how do we know that what we do is "right?" Exactly. The point here is to constantly and mindfully observe your action, livelihood, effort, mindfulness, concentration; so that they will constantly and consistently be right. Enough or Buddhism, what about for design thinking? We, too, need to constantly and mindfully observe our own design process.

accepting the possibility of having to return to repeat the previous steps should they been done too abruptly or too mindlessly. We need to accept the chaotic nature of a design process and accept that the "right" design process

is that one that involves complexity and not a straight line of progress.

Whatever you thought you have done right from the first step could be wrong or misleading; so, instead of fixating on your "perfect" prototypes, you must observe the process and be able to make the decision constantly return to the precious process to enhance your design in order to arrive at an implementable product, service, or experience. Let's call this process "design implementation." Now, finally, I have to admit that I have been using this Four-Noble-Trust-disguised-as-design-thinking-process to deal with many problems in life, together with Stoicism.

The most important point here is to never let your fierce emotion or the automatically hot System One take over at any point in the process. Your fierce emotion and System One are likely to push you away from the design path that you have designed for yourself.

For instance, I realized about two years ago that the source of my chronic pessimism about the world -- my dukka -- was not that the world was going to hell but actually the news about the inhumanity in the world that journalists liked to report. I didn't know what to do. I felt as though I had lost all the hope in the world; and only wanted to move to a distant place so that I would not have to deal with the society again.

I also became distrustful of many people around me. I became paranoid of those who wanted to come close me. I closed myself in and only spoke in a small number of people. Can you believe that which was actually what I thought of as a sound solution? Thanks to Steven Pinker's book *The Better Angels of Our Nature: Why Violence Has Declined*, I learned that we are living in the most peaceful time in the history of humankind.

Pinker emphasizes that it's the journalists that give us the "availability bias" by bombarding us with news about the horror of humanity that, sadly, sell. So, my solution? Since the source of my dukka is not the world -- but the news -- I simply stopped watching news, closing all my social media platforms, and engage with people in the real world without any availability

biases. Since then I have become a much more optimistic and happy person.

DAY 86

On Design Thinking Part 8: Dealing with Criticisms

Fri, 19 Sep 2025 00:00:00 +0000



I WAS ABOUT TO GO to bed when the idea of this blog post came to mind! Actually, someone once told me about what we can physically do to arrive at a creative idea: Drink (and smell) coffee, take a cold shower, exercise, and play some intense role-playing games. I didn't do any of this to arrive at an idea for this very post. In fact, I was just relaxing at my balcony looking over a great city of light. O.k.

I need to get to bed so let's get on to it. First of all, nobody criticisms even though they are important. In *How to Win Friends and Influence People*, the management guru Dale Carnegie writes about why and how we should avoid criticizing others: Criticism is futile because it puts a person on the defensive and usually makes him strive to justify himself. Criticism is dangerous, because it wounds a person's precious pride, hurts his sense of importance, and arouses resentment. B. F.

Skinner, the world-famous psychologist, proved through his experiments that an animal rewarded for good behavior will learn much more rapidly and retain what it learns far more effectively than an animal punished for bad behavior. Later studies have shown that the same applies to humans. By

criticizing, we do not make lasting changes and often incur resentment. Carnegie goes so far as to tell us to "never criticize" -- in fact, he writes, "instead of condemning people, let's try to understand them.

Let's try to figure out why they do what they do. That's a lot more profitable and intriguing than criticism; and it breeds sympathy, tolerance and kindness." All make senses in the context of how to win friends and influence people, but what if you don't want to win friends and influence people? What if you want to do something with your business, life, and design strategies? The only way can ever improve is to know where you could improve. That's when critics step in.

In my life, it's been my parents (especially my mother) who has always been the harshest critic, to whom I always listen precisely because I do not have any reasons to doubt her caring, honesty and love for me. My colleagues too (especially to colleagues-in-arms) are my toughest critics, and it's precisely this very reason that we're not just colleagues but also friends. These critics are great, especially before the real battle, precisely because they are honest about what I can do to cover all my weak points.

In design too, we want tough and honest critics. The design thinking guru Tom Kelly has, in fact, written a book about how to be "good critics" -- in which he argues against the role-playing of a devil's advocate who can only point out to the worst thing about your idea. In fact, Kelly argues for these critics playing a role of, at least, one of these "learning personas": anthropologist, experimenter, pollinator, hurdler, collaborator, director, experience architect, set designer, storyteller, and caregiver.

That's another post for another time, but Kelly's point is clear: We need to learn how to take/untake criticisms. But as the management guru Dale Carnegie famously said, it's not that easy for people to take criticisms. Nobody likes to hear bad things about them. So, in this post, I want to discuss levels of criticisms and how to deal with them -- like a pro. There're two steps to take criticisms like a design thinker. The source of the criticism.

Good people (people whom you trust): There is no other way around. You'd have to take them like free consultations. Actually, a consultant is someone hired to give you honest advice -- and criticisms on what you can do better. This could even be your teacher. It would be foolish, for instance, to hire a tennis coach and would not allow him/her to criticize your posture when hitting the ball or serving.

You have to think about them as if they're advice that normally you would have to pay hundreds of thousands of dollars to get. So, for these kinds of criticisms, you would want to crave them and take them very seriously. People whom you are not sure whether they are that good (but they look like they are good people): These kinds of criticisms can often come from your colleagues, managers.

For these kinds of criticisms, would want to take them with a grain of salt, but you would want to do it transparently.

By doing so, not only you are showing respect to the critic (which would be useful in a long run), but you are also leaving ample room for the possibility for that person might be "on your side." The entrepreneur par excellence and founder of Bridgewater Associates Ray Dalio has developed a deep culture of "criticism appreciation," whereby everyone in the company is craving to hear more from other people about what they can do to improve.

At Bridgewater Associates, employees are utterly used to open criticism sessions in which both the critics and criticized leave behind their ranks and constructively so that the critics can openly provide the criticized their honest opinions. Ray Dalio also writes in *Principles*: Never say anything about a person you wouldn't say to them directly, and don't try people without accusing them to their face. Badmouthing people behind their backs shows a serious lack of integrity and is counterproductive.

It doesn't yield any beneficial change, and it subverts both the people you are badmouthing and the environment as a whole. Next to being dishonest, it is the worst thing you can do at Bridgewater. Criticism is both welcomed and

encouraged at Bridgewater, so there is no good reason to talk behind people's backs. You need to follow this policy to an extreme degree. For example, managers should not talk about people who work for them without those people being in the room.

If you talk behind people's backs at Bridgewater you are called a slimy weasel. People who are at present at the opposite side of the ring (but have the possibility of changing their side): As the design thinker Tom Kelly writes in *The Ten Faces of Innovation*, people become your oppositions because they think highly of you -- they think that you are worth it (otherwise why would they waste their time opposing you).

These guys are tough critics that you may want try to convince them to be on your side. The benefit of doing so is immense. First, you'll get all the research that they have done about you. Second, they will provide you how to see the world in the way that you have never seen it, which could lead to an innovation. It's a wonderful lesson in co-opting your opposition. Instead of being offended by their arguments, why not listen and respond to their concerns?

They often have valid points. The payoff can be extraordinary. There's nothing like the conviction of a convert to boost team momentum. People whom you don't completely trust because you don't know that much about them: Despite your initial loathe, you would still want to take these criticisms with the mind of a great "fallibilist." Because there is no harm in believing or not believing it, you would want to take these criticisms into account as if it's something from one of your caring colleagues.

Even though such criticisms may sound harsh, you wouldn't feel as if they are if you could "make yourself believe" they come from your caring colleague. So, all you need to do here is to use a psychological trick to make yourself believe, so that you can look at the criticisms the way they are. They might be useful. People whom you really really really don't trust (especially those who criticize you anonymously).

You would want to take these criticisms as if they're insults in the way that a stoic would. A stoic, in fact, would be both delighted and enlightened to hear criticisms from those for whom they do not have any respect. Why? Because this disapproving from those whose ideas you do not appreciate is an approval that your idea is on the right track. The philosopher William B.

Irvine writes in *A Guide to the Good Life: The Ancient Art of Stoic Joy*: Under such circumstances, rather than feeling hurt by his insults, I should feel relieved: If he disapproves of what I am doing, then what I am doing is doubtless the right thing to do. What should worry me is if this contemptible person approved of what I am doing.

If I say anything at all in response to his insults, the most appropriate comment would be, "I'm relieved that you feel that way about me." During my 18-year-long stint as a student, I had always asked for more comments from my teachers -- especially criticisms. I always craved for how to improve myself.

Having been a non-native speaker of the language at most of the universities at which I had enrolled, all I could ask for from my teachers was how I could catch up with my peers who did not have such a handicap. I had mostly been lucky in the sense that I had been given a lot of criticisms. Some were hurtful and some were extremely hurtful (i.e., "you shouldn't be studying here at this level") -- but all of them were constructive.

I always felt as though the papers without any comments (marked in red) were papers that had not been read (which was actually, as I later found out, often the case; as it's much easier for teachers to not read those papers and just give them random marks).

So, as a teacher, I always give my students a lot of comments and criticisms -- with the hope that the students would appreciate those them, as markers of love, care, an appreciation, the way I used to feel about comments from my own teachers.

DAY 87

The Anti-Fragile Manifesto

Sat, 20 Sep 2025 00:00:00 +0000



LIVING IN THE WORLD AS hard and chaotic as it is today, it's not enough just to be flexible and resilience -- we need to be "anti-fragile." Borrowing this (I think, beautifully expressive) term from the thinker Nassim Nicholas Taleb, the author both *The Black Swan* and *Antifragile: Things That Gain From Disorder* whose thoughts I often allude to in this blog, I am referring to this term in the way almost similar to Taleb's. What does anti-fragile mean? There're three kinds of thing: Fragile, robust and anti- fragile.

Fragile things break under pressure. We treasure fragile things that are beautiful, such as glassware, chandeliers and ornaments. We put them up to show off our status, taste, class; but we obviously do not want to be like them, especially in the world today where everyone is both discretely and proudly at each other's throat. In other words, fragile things are exposed to volatility. Robust things, on the other hand, resist the pressure and survive. Robust objects don't break easily, as they are designed to resist "some" pressure.

Think of a rugged iPhone case, for instance. It's built to give the iPhone (a fragile object) some "robustness"; so that it won't break into pieces when it's dropped vertically or accidentally kicked to the side. Robust organizations, though not keen to be frequently exposed to volatility, are able to adapt to

abrupt change through its elements of resilience. The author Ryan Holiday writes in *The Obstacle Is the Way: The Timeless Art of Turning Trials into Triumph*: Subjected to those pressures, these individuals were transformed.

They were transformed along the lines that Andy Grove, former CEO of Intel, outlined when he described what happens to businesses in tumultuous times: "Bad companies are destroyed by crisis. Good companies survive them. Great companies are improved by them. But unlike robust objects that resist the pressure and hardship, anti-fragile things benefit from them. Can you think of something like that? Something or somebody that benefits from being exposed to shocks and crises? Nassim Nicholas Taleb doesn't provide a lot of convincing real world examples in his book.

But examples are actually plenty. As for someone, it almost goes without saying that everyone who has made it to the humanity's hall of fame never has it easy. They have been through hardships, crises and a series of unfortunate events that make many of us think "we would have just taken an easy way out already." Take Deng Xiaoping and the stoic philosopher Seneca for example. Both of them were purged twice -- and they both returned even stronger.

When Seneca was banished to a remote Island of Corsica for 8 years by Emperor Claudius of Rome, he used those years to practice stoicism; as well as the arts of letters, playwright and entrepreneurial investment, which his busy public life prior to the banishment did not afford him the time to do so. When Seneca was eventually allowed to return to Rome eight years later, he was able to abruptly regain his reputation, finance and became, writes William B.

Irvine, "the most renowned citizen of his time: the greatest living writer in prose and verse, the greatest name in literature since the golden age at the beginning of the century, and the favorite of the imperious empress." Deng Xiaoping, on the other hands, got purged twice by his political enemies. Instead of giving up, he used the time away from Beijing to garner support from those who, like him, were politically purged.

He carefully observed and learned from the two purges and was not for a minute believed that his political career was over (although most, if not all, people around him thought so). Deng was not just "robust" in the sense that he adapted to the banishment, but enjoyed the purge as it gave him the opportunity to join with those who believed in his way of thinking. Both Deng and Seneca were anti-fragile. What these guys have in common isn't their ability to soldier on mindlessly and relentlessly.

I return to what Ryan Holiday continues in *The Obstacle Is the Way: The Timeless Art of Turning Trials into Triumph*: Great individuals, like great companies, find a way to transform weakness into strength. It's a rather amazing and even touching feat. They took what should have held them back—what in fact might be holding you back right this very second—and used it to move forward.

In fact, it's their ability to calmly pause to assess the damage, inspect the situation only from the perspective that is useful for the damage control, and then turn the entire crisis on its head by using what may be, at first, the negative remnants of the circumstance. That's precisely what the pioneering entrepreneur and founder of the Virgin Group Sir Richard Branson did when his proposal to take a few million dollars loan to modestly upgrade the entertainment systems on his Virgin planes was turned down by a bank.

He paused, inspected and anti-fragilely turned the crisis around. First, Branson re-assessed the situation and realized that the problem was not the 10 million pounds he was asking, but the bank's lack of trust in Branson's business (which in the 1990s was still infancy and overshadowed by major airlines such as the British Airways). Instead of giving up, he struck a "different kind of deal" with the major US aircraft manufacturers -- to buy 10 new aircrafts from them.

During the 1990s' UK recession when no one had the gut to invest, his proposal was welcomed by the stagnated manufacturers who desperately wanted to build and sell, the underperformed bank who wanted to lend, and the austerity-averse governments of both the US and the UK who wanted to

see employment go up as a result of this monumental deal.

He used such an opportunity to not only stay stay afloat in the business (as in, being "robust"), but create a 4-billion-pound worth of financing to expand his business that would later go head-to-head with the British Airways. Not only was he robust and resilience, but anti-fragile. Branson loved that crisis, which gave him both the business and the fame. What's more, aircraft manufacturers also threw in the entertainment systems he originally wanted -- for free. Businesses will likely to benefit most from being anti-fragile.

Black swans, by definition, hit unexpectedly and the only way one can survive is to "be like Branson" -- be able to 360-degree assess the situation and act timely. I have seen abrupt ending of so many businesses. It's not because they're not aware of the decline, and possible crisis. They were aware of the decline, and possible crisis -- it's just that they were not "anti-fragile enough" to benefit from a fierce competition.

So, their "crisis management protocols" are too focused on triaging, and saving the largest portion of the business. But, I have used this example before, what if your most important products are films, in the era of digital cameras? We, too, I believe can benefit from the notion of being anti-fragile. How many times have we faced black swans event in life that made us think "what doesn't kill us makes us think it should have?" Plenty of times for me.

We are living in the world where it's harder and harder to predict. Like the "turkey story," there is no way that a well-fed turkey would know that his only true *raison d'être* was to be killed and fed to humans to celebrate Thanksgiving.

If this turkey was a stoic, it would have taken the moment of truth like Seneca who, upon being given a death sentence by his own pupil Emperor Nero (for whom Seneca had faithfully served as a counselor), proclaimed that which "was the best opportunity for him to practice Stoicism." Or, this turkey could simply have found the way to be anti-fragile and run away. In my line of work, I found that there're three kinds of companies: S tartups, running, and

crumbling.

The first and the third kinds are likely to benefit most from the concept of anti-fragility. Both the newcomers and those about to go out of business will be fierce to find their competitive edge and will therefore work hard to be more than robust. The second kind won't even realize that they need to be anti-fragile because, like the turkey, everything seems okay until the day they are about to go out of business.

In my own life, there're times when I was attacked, backstabbed, and tripped by malicious people. They thought I was "fragile" and hoped that I would simply break into pieces. Some of them, while speaking to me with their sincerest look, actually hoped that I would literally disintegrate. I met so many of this kind of people, especially during the past decade of my life. Honestly, there're times when that was almost the case -- I almost literally disintegrated.

It's only then I realized two things which saved me: First, that my parents did not build me to be "fragile"; and, second, that, quite counterintuitively, there're always something that is quite useful in almost any unfortunate events. You just have to, like Sir Richard Branson, look for it. For example, as I wrote earlier, the fact that I was the odd-one-out in college did not prevent me from wanting to be more than just robust. My college life was really tough. None of my classmates liked me.

They also thought that the disliking was symmetrical, even though I did not have anything against them. The truth was that I did not have a single friend during my 6 years in college because I did not fit with the institutional culture whereby studiousness was looked down upon (as nerdy) and laziness was praised as "a way of the wise." Most of my classmates did not go to class and spent most of their time playing soccer. Of course, I could "robustly" pretend to like my friends and lean in.

That way I could have a few friends and would not be so friendless. Yet, I knew that I was going to spend only 6 years there as a student, and the real

life would only begin after that. That's the beginning of my 8-hour-long reading project for the next 6 years.

I knew that I had a "grand plan ahead," although at the time it seemed far-fetched: My teachers literally laughed at me during the only one time in my undergraduate life that I told anyone that I would like to go to the US to pursue my further study in architecture. They thought it was not possible for someone of my low intelligence and "personality" (again, my friendlessness was a big thing for them). It's not surprising that nobody understood what I was doing then.

My classmates, my teachers, and even some of my friends thought that I had lost it. They thought I had become depressed, sociopathic, and "anti-social" because I had no friends. Little did they know that I was in no way anti-social, I was just practicing "anti-fragility." So, let's be anti-fragile. Let's not let the unbearable lightness of words, selfishness of humans, and disturbances of which we do not have the capacity to control in this chaotic world bring us down.

Keep it simple: Here's what to do: We'll take all criticisms like they're free consultations. A lot of people pay tons of cash to professionals to criticize their businesses -- it's called consulting. So, now that there're people who would give us their thoughts for free, we will take them, embrace them, and long for more. Criticisms, in a way, produce a crisis and a shock. No one else likes to be criticized -- except us, because we are anti-fragile. We love to gain from crises and shocks.

Criticisms from great minds will prepare us for a more anti-fragile life, while criticisms from small-minded people will serve to confirm that what we are doing is already, and absolutely, the right thing to do; Never put all the eggs in one basket -- EVER AGAIN. The one single most alarming characteristic shared among almost everyone whose black swan events drive them to complete destruction (e.g., suicide) is how they do not diversify their investment portfolio -- not just money, but also time, life, etc.

As we know that we are not necessarily and solely responsible for unfortunate events in our life, it's unfair to think that it's possible for you to win just because you have done your best. The world isn't that simplistic -- in fact, it never was, is, and will. If you put all your money on one bet and you lose, you still lose even if it wasn't you who caused it. If you're still a waged labour, think about how you might turn your hobby into another job.

If you're solely relying on a day- to-day income, think about how your commitment to a longer-term task might give you both the pleasure of seeing things through and a more stable income, even for a short period of time. So, diversify your finance, your time, your hope, your expectation, and your ability to believe in your anti- fragility; Regain our independence. Taleb also writes that three most addictive substance in the world are: heroine, carbohydrates, and salary. I am sure we can all agree.

The point is, when we are interdependent on something, especially things to which we are addicted, we don't have a lot of choices and therefore prone to make mistakes and/or let someone else's mistakes affect us. Once we're independent, we can take a much better control of our own life. We can try out more new ideas and work more diligently on being anti-fragile.

I personally have never tried heroine, have cut down heavily on carbohydrates, and been working hard to be free, once and for all, from salary; Exercise everyday. Running, joking, biking, etc., create discomfort to the body and benefit us. The moment we realize that which is the case, we're one step closer to being anti-fragile. In addition, when a black swan event takes place, what you need more than a healthy mind is a healthy body to carry the mind.

So, by keeping your body fit, you're not only ready to tackle the black swan, but also embrace it and turn it on its head to benefit you. Again, because we're anti-fragile; and, finally, Whenever things seem too smooth, give yourself an obstacle to overcome. "Don't be that turkey." If something seems too smooth, step back and, be like a stoic, practice a "negative visualization" to find out what possible scenario you could create for yourself to test your

anti-fragility.

Be like Bill Gate of Ancient Rome Seneca who frequently "caused bad things to happen as the result of our undertaking a program of voluntary discomfort" in order to learn how to be anti-fragile.

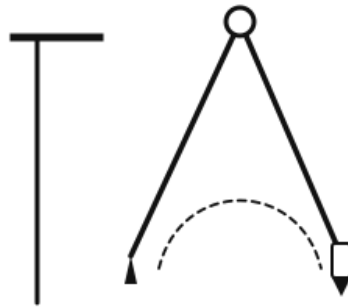
Again, as my debate coach always said, "You only win if you can be your own's fiercest debate counterpart." For a company that is doing well, give your indispensable employee a week of paid holiday and see if your system can make an on-the-fly adjustment to find someone to replace that employee in a fashion of the Dutch total football. If not, then you have a domain to build anti-fragility. You don't have to break your own fingers if you are a computer programmer to test your anti-fragility.

Maybe you could just give yourself a break: work a couple of hours fewer a day and see if you could make up for those two lost hours by other means.

DAY 88

On Design Thinking Part 9: Designing Your Life

Sun, 21 Sep 2025 00:00:00 +0000



I HAVE MOVED THE PREVIOUS Day 88 post "Only If I Can Do These 12 Things" to the main page of this blog and changed its name to "Principles" since these are, essentially, the principles by which we should aim to live our life. Now, in this post, I want to quickly unpack them into practical guides. Here're a few practical guides according to the 12 principles: First, be in the "flow," in other words, be here now (no, not the 1997 album of one of the favorite band's Oasis).

The meaning of flow is discussed in Bill Burnett's book *Designing Your Life*. Flow is engagement on steroids. Flow is that state of being in which time stands still, you're totally engaged in an activity, and the challenge of that particular activity matches up with your skill—so you're neither bored because it's too easy nor anxious because it's too hard. People describe this state of engagement as "euphoric," "in the zone," and "freakin' awesome." Have you had this experience?

I have had plenty of them, usually when I do something I really enjoy, such as teaching, reading, biking, and writing a blog post (such as this one, and yes I am in the flow right now). My advice: Do take note of activities that put in the

state of flow -- and find a job that let you do that day in and day out. I think Burnett has summarized it all.

Once you're in the flow, your brain won't be spending its precious energy on anything else except the very task at hand. The key is to focus on the smallest portion of the task that you are engaging (which will prevent you from "choking") and trying to get yourself into the "flow" of whatever you are doing. Second, "don't try." The two words written as the epitaph on the writer Charles Bukowski's tombstone. In this sense, don't try to be nice by taking others' problems as your own.

An old saying goes something like this, "People who hate other do so because they hate themselves; they're also jealous of others also because they hate their on lacking. Think about it for a second. I have been thinking about this a lot as I go through my own previous diaries and notebooks; now that I have some free time to do so.

It's almost always the case that whenever I felt the jealous, anxious, hateful of someone or something, I felt that way because I was so dissatisfied with the state of being in which I was, so I tried to take it out on other people. If I can't be happy, I'll bring everyone else down. Yes, I did not like myself, and hence felt that the only way I could feel better was to forcefully pull those down to my own depressing level. That's selfish.

Reading through pages of my own old diaries and notebooks, I felt sorry for myself. That said, there's one thing to feel good about: I never anonymously took it out on other people. At least, even in my darkest hours of self-loathing, I still had some dignity enough to use my real identity to blame others.

The author Mark Manson (from whose a-gem-of-a-book *The Subtle Art of Not Giving a F*ck*, I got the above- mentioned anecdote about Bukowski) Most of us struggle throughout our lives by giving too many fucks in situations where fucks do not deserve to be given. Look, this is how it works. You're going to die one day. I know that's kind of obvious, but I just wanted to remind you in case you'd forgotten. You and everyone you know are going to

be dead soon. Third, be a minimalist.

In this sense, there're a few key points: On friendship, quality, not quantity; On things, replacing not adding; On aesthetics, less is more; On consumption, consume just as we need; On communication, be brief, focused, and nonviolent; On leisure, treasure experience, not possession of physical objects. Fourth, be a maximalist -- on good values such as modesty, community, love, forgivingness. For all of these quality, more is, simply, more. Fifth, don't compare, or at least only to yourself yesterday.

Why do we buy things we don't need with money we don't have to impress people we don't like? The answer is because we compare ourselves to others. Again, I resort to Mark Manson's quote from the same book again: Our culture today is obsessively focused on unrealistically positive expectations: Be happier. Be healthier. Be the best, better than the rest. Be smarter, faster, richer, sexier, more popular, more productive, more envied, and more admired. This is very true and therefore very sad.

Years ago, before I closed all my social media accounts, I asked myself one question: "Why is my life so bad?" "Good" and "bad" are relative. So, for anything to be "good" or "bad," there has to be a reference point. As you can probably guess, I used photos of other people that I saw on their social media as reference points. That is, I felt that my life was bad because I constantly compared my life to the heavily-curated portrayals of others on the internet.

In *The Art of the Good Life*, the author Rolf Dobelli argues that "Envy has a bigger impact on your life satisfaction than physical affliction or financial ruin, and the ability to manage it is fundamental to the good life. In the similar tone to Dr. Jordan B. Peterson's fourth rule in *12 Rules for Life: An Antidote to Chaos* "Compare yourself to who you were yesterday, not to who someone else is today," Dobelli puts in simply, "Stop comparing yourself to other people and you'll enjoy an envy-free existence.

Steer well clear of all comparisons. That's the golden rule." Bonus: My extra-boring iPhone. Putting all of these together, I have been working on all

of these guides. The first step for me is to get rid of external sources of anxiety. I realize that I have been feeling very anxious because of my iPhone where gossip, rumors, scandals and unsubstantiated news do not have to ask for permission to reach my eyes.

In addition, my iPhone is also the source of "hyper-curated mythologies" (an academic term for how someone presents themselves on social media) of people whose life are actually the same as yours and mine. Apparently, these people don't travel and eat at a Michelin Starred restaurant for living. Like you and me, they have to work in order to make money to pay rent, buy food, etc. What have we done to ourselves? So, to get rid of the problem from the very source, while recognizing the use of technology.

Take a look at my iPhone's screen below. Yes, it's in black and white since a monochrome screen uses less energy (so my iPhone last longer on a single charge). A monochrome screen is also not very appealing to look at; hence, I don't pick it up unless I have to; No sound or heptic (vibration) notifications whatsoever.

I choose when I want to look at my phone; I use Flipboard as my only browser, so that I can screen what I would like to Rea an the number of news of what I would like to consume per day; iBook contains more than 120+ books that I am currently researching and reading; Audible is where I keep 300+ books in my online cloud library to listen to any time that I feel the urge to learn more; Podcasts is where I listen to subscribed radio programs.

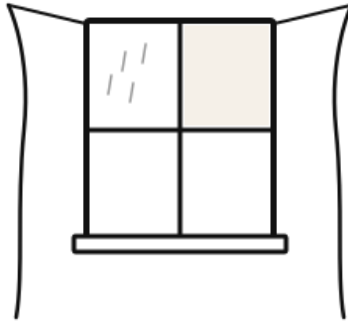
Here're my top five: Hidden Brain, Freakonomics Radio, Philosophize This, Household Name, and Slow Burn. I want to further cut down the number of apps to 10 -- meaning that I will eventually stop using 4 out of 5 messaging apps that I currently have. The main issue I have with these messaging apps is that most of us using them to send messages in lieu of email but we expect people to respond as fast as if it's an SMS. When our expectation is not met. we get offended.

Actually, maybe I can stop using all of them altogether. It'd be wonderful if we all go back to using emails -- where we start a message with "Dear" and end it with "Regards" -- again.

DAY 89

The Saddest Sonnet

Mon, 22 Sep 2025 00:00:00 +0000



HAVE YOU EVER FELT DISGUSTED by your own existence? I have. My weakest days were the ten months before my obtaining a doctoral degree in 2016. No, living alone by myself per se did not make me weak. The feeling lack of support, instead, was the source of my weakness. In the process of finishing up "my most important work," I felt deeply insecure. I wasn't afraid that my work wasn't good enough.

In fact, I knew that I would graduate anyway whether or not my work was any good at all. I mean, unless my university was sadistic, there was no reason for it to waste more resources on a student who had reached his intellectual limit for another year. Instead, I was afraid of what would come next. After finishing this doctorate, I would be "forced to be free." I would be let go from the protected world of students, into the unprotected world of cutthroat employment.

Making me weak was precisely that feeling of wanting to finish something, while knowing that finishing it would put me in an even more vulnerable place. Again, this being "forced to be free" thing was not the kind that a high school kid thinks about when leaving their homes for college. I thought of it in the same sense that the French enlightenment thinker Jean-Jacques Rousseau had thought of: The stripping away of a person's inalienable rights,

dignity, and sense of morality as a whole.

Yes, I was that panic about being forced to be free, and the fear of which forced to be someone else but myself. How was I someone else but myself? Let's start with a near-death experience. Have you had one of those out-of-body experience? It actually happened to me, not so proudly, quite a few times. There is even a pattern.

Most of the time when I saw myself as a third person was when I engaged in a act of ferociously scolding at other people on mistakes for which, I knew very well that, I alone was responsible. No, I wasn't floating in the air like Casper the Friendly Ghost. And no, not true, I wasn't feeling as though the law of gravity didn't apply to me. In fact, I felt heavy, especially my beating heart.

My two foots were on the same flooring tiles on which the angry man who looked like me was. Feeling as though I was the invisible third person (yes, this time, like Casper the Friendly Ghost), I felt as though I was looking at myself. It was almost as though the better angel of my nature had escaped the body in order to see what the worse angel was trying to accomplish with its malicious desires.

Although I did not hurt anyone, I did not care about others as much my own self. Even though I did not do any harm, I did not try to help those distant friends who were in need. Even though I did not cause any one any trouble, I too- consistently refused to take part in activities I knew would have brought betterment to the society as a whole. I was extremely selfish: I was trying to stay afloat.

Not only did I lose some good friends during these weakest days, but I was also failing even in the very basic tasks that I was assigned to do. I'll return to the part about losing friends later. It's much easier to see how I had become a train wreck in my personal life. During these twelve months, my daily life was a mess. Sleeplessness gradually crept in.

I tried to exercise, yes; but twice as much I had been eating unhealthy food and binge- watching television, with the hope that these could stray me away

from having to think about what would happen to me the day after next. Before I knew it, I would be staying out all night musing over some unpleasant feelings.

I would be staying awake looking at the white ceiling of my apartment for hours before I realized that I would need to chug a can of something (mostly beer) to get my brain to stop working. Sometimes, I used old (and classic) movies to give me some meanings of life to my attempt to fall asleep.

Sometimes, I simply stayed up with my eye wide open thinking about what I could have done better until my brain wanted to shut down; in which case, my eyes would stay open until the alarm clock went off in the morning. A bonus to me: I learned how to make organic cocktails (which I made several videos about) so that I could pass time and use it as a bonus to go to bed (although alcohol rarely worked on me as a sleeping pill).

I wrecked my body that way until it could no longer take it, and hence automatically shut down, as in stopped working at an instance and left my body collapsing on a couch in front of a fuzzy television's screen. Without enough deep sleep the night before, and because I needed more sleep then, I would constantly skip breakfast when I should be getting ready for work.

"Bulletproof coffee" (as in, coffee with added butter) became additive, as it gave me the boost to stay awake but without any real calories to keep me going. I still showed up at work everyday not only because that which remained the only reason for my existence, but also because that was only because I had nothing else to hold on to. I kept all of this a secret from my family. I didn't want them to be worried.

The worst part of this scary episode was that I looked at everyone as though he or she was an enemy. To begin with, I tried very hard to be to be the center of all attention to overcompensate for my insecurity. I thought that be getting a lot of attention, I could distract myself from thinking too much about my immediate future. The results of all of these trying were disastrous. I took on more jobs that I could finish. I accepted more tasks that I could ever

accomplish.

I also made too many promises that I knew I wouldn't be able to keep. Because I was far from being able to meet my own expectation, I became defensive. I felt as though the reason why I wasn't able to finish things was due to some conspiracies. I felt that I was in a war zone and my enemies were my friends and colleagues in disguised.

A cognitive behavioral psychologist later told me that was what happened when one felt insecure: Everyone became your enemy because you were not secure about your own role, position, and, emphasized by the psychologist, "your own existence in the minds of others whom you cared." At the time, I outright rejected this assumption. I did not believe that anyone could have any influence over my own opinion about myself. I also did not believe that I could care about someone so much that I became neurotic.

I wasn't realized that I cared so much about what other people thought about me. I let the feeling of how others might feel about me get under my skin. I allowed other people's perceptions of me to dictate my behavior. I felt that someone was coming to take my job, my spot light, and eventually my livelihood. Many whose promises I could not keep promptly disengaged themselves from me as soon as they knew that I was a freud.

Yes, I know that calling someone who couldn't keep his promise a "fraud" may be a bit too harsh, but that was really how I felt about myself. I was harsh with others as much as to myself. There was a "feedback loop from hell," which went like this: I was anxious about being insecure, and therefore wanted attention; such craving for attention led me to pursuing things that I could not deliver, which, in turn, gave me even more anxiety as a result of criticisms, complaints and grudges.

Eventually, I crashed. Luckily, I was not burned; even thought it perhaps would have been nice if I was burnt then to see whether I would still be writing this today. This feedback loop from hell kept on going for a few months. It, eventually, slowed down. For it to not have an effect on me, I

deliberately detached myself, almost completely, from engaging with people -- from the social life that this feedback loop from hell desired. But it, alas, never completely stopped.

I am still feeling its kinetic energy, like a ceiling fan that continued to rotate even after you had already switched it off. These were the months (December 2015 to May 2016 to be precise) during which I acted most erratic.

There're friends who unfriended me because I "got upset so easily over a small thing" and "became ferociously angry over trivial things." The worst thing I did was to an old friend, who meant nothing but the best for me, but I gave this friend my worst, including unmotivated yelling, incessant anger, and, worst, the untrustworthiness. There're my weakest hours, my darkest moment, and my saddest sonnet. I want to apologize to everyone who had to be a part of it. Ok, what's the reason for writing this Saddest Sonnet.

Honestly, this month marks the tenth anniversary of my discovery of *Writing Tools: 50 Essential Strategies for Every Writer* by the legendary writing coach Roy Peter Clark. The book is still considered by many one of the best writing guides of all time, alongside classics such as Bill Strunk's *The Elements of Style* and, my personal favorite, *The Sense of Style: The Thinking Person's Guide to Writing in the 21st Century* by the psychologist Steven Pinker.

As I wrote to my close friends earlier today, I discovered this book during my graduate school days. Walking home one evening, I felt as though I needed to do something to improve myself. I was feeling blue, as my teachers had just scolded at me for "not knowing how to write." Back then, the master's program in which I was enrolled was writing and reading intensive.

I, somehow, had survived reading a book a week during the first 1.5 years of the program; yet, I knew that I was going to fail miserably in my very final assignment. Walking while thinking obsessively about my incompetency, I found myself at a footstep of a university bookstore. I ended up spending the next three hours browsing through books with the hope that I would find

something to get me through my final semester -- yes, that dreadful thesis writing semester. I hated writing and did not understand.

I was studying architecture. Architecture! It's about drawing and making models. Why I should have to write at all, let alone write well? My feeling begun to change when I learned, not from my professors, but my best friend the importance of the thinking clearly. Not only did Reilly graduate as the top student of my class, he was also the best writer I have ever met. Things Reilly said and wrote about not only made sense but sounded so reasonable.

I later learned that it's his ability to think in simple terms, and convey his feeling his simple ways. His secret, I later found, is that he talked the way he wrote and vice versa. When his thinking was clear, his writing, too, was clear. Through the art of putting string words in the right order: Reilly always began with a simple verb or subject, and then magically incubated his ideas to place words into a logical flow.

As the string reaches the end of the sentence -- just right before the period -- he would subtly placed the emphatic word to remind us what he's trying to convey. To me, that's like magic. No wonder Reilly has gone on to become such a successful architect. He can express himself clearly! I would say, meeting Reilly and picking up a copy of *Writing Tools: 50 Essential Strategies for Every Writer* were two essential moments of my becoming a writer.

So, in commemorating the tenth anniversary of my indoctrination into "writership," I would like to give myself an "impromptu writing prompt" to write about utilizing all the tools that Roy Peter Clark encourages us to use.

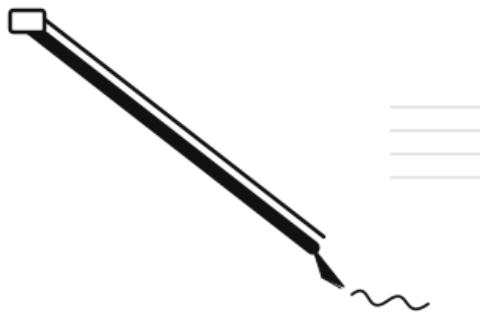
These are 7 Roy Peter Clark's writing tools that I use in this post (the other 45 are, sort of, embedded within the writing itself): Beware of adverbs; Reject cliches; Prefer Simple to Technical; Use verbs in their strongest form; Dig for the Concrete and Specific; Begin sentences with subjects and verb; Control the pace of the story by varying sentence length. So, in this Saddest Sonnet, I gave myself just one rule here: No more about my father! (Yes, the internet has spoken and therefore.

overruled that I have been writing too much about him already. That's enough and I should just move on). I have also talking about my father here, here, and here already. What's your weakest days?

DAY 90

On Design Thinking Part 10: The One Simple Trick to Re-Designing Your Life

Tue, 23 Sep 2025 00:00:00 +0000



HOORAY! I HAVE REACHED THE ninetieth post! Thrilled. Ten more and then I'll reach "100 days of writing." Wow. I don't know what to say. It was supposed to be a three-and-a-half month writing project. Now, since the first post it has been more than three and a half years. Well, anyway, that's a good sign. In this post, I want to write about one scientifically-proven secret to make your life better: Stop reading news -- all of the regular ones.

Honestly, I disdain regular news even before I learned about why they're so bad for all of us. It all began, simply, when I realized two things from reading a feed on my Facebook feed (yes, I used to have a Facebook page but I closed it almost a year ago). First, I realized that most of the news are not relevant to me at all.

Not only did they make me feel angry, but they also made me feel as though I knew more about the world than I actually did. This was quite dangerous. News often made me want to have a heated debate with another dilettante. The world is very a complex place, and reading a post or two, needless to say, won't make me an expert on that subject. Second, I realized, also, that not all

my Facebook "friends" were living the life they posted on their walls.

No, Danny didn't drink pink campaign on ice for lunch. Chen did not attend an expensive horse-riding lessons every other day as the frequently of the posts tended to suggest. And, no, no, Peter wasn't traveling to Europe every weekend. All those photos from Venice were actually taken a while back.

These were, as I wrote about before, all highly "curated mythologies" that, for one, made me feel like my life sucked big time compared to these guys', and, next, really, did any of these really made me feel good about anything at all? And, yes, so, for the past year, I have neither watched nor read any of them. By regular news, I mean uncurated news that come to you in forms of news report or newspapers.

I still read about stuff I like (i.e., curated news), such as, technology (especially gadget), innovation and design, literary world, environment, health science, and so on. But none of these are "urgent" in the sense of regular news.

For instance, I didn't have to know that the Japanese author Haruki Murakami just published a new book *Man Without Women* (as I probably wouldn't have time to read it until a year from now any way) and the urgency of this news would probably not, in any way, affect or have any impact on my livelihood. P.S.

Truth be told: I didn't know about the boys in the cave until they had already gotten out, after my mother had told me while I was driving her to do a grocery shopping. I knew who won the World Cup because I hung out with a group of good friends to watch the game; otherwise I probably still would not have any idea that France took back the trophy.

The best-selling author and psychology professor Steven Pinker has made this very point in two of his great works: *The Better Angels of Our Nature: Why Violence Has Declined*, and recently, in *Enlightenment Now: The Case for Reason, Science, Humanism, and Progress*. Pinker argues that the view we see the world is manipulated by the media. As Pinker puts it, and I am

paraphrasing here, "a plane that is safely landing doesn't make an exciting news, whereas a plane that is crashing does." That's true.

And as the American literary scholar Jonathan Gottschall also argues in *Storytelling Animals: How Stories Make Us Humans* that we are wired to want more than just a happy-ending story. We're wired to hear about troubles, difficulties, and calamities of others. As and news deliver these in forms of stories, they feed right into both the conscious and subconscious of our being.

[gallery ids="4771,4772" type="rectangular"] Using Daniel Kahneman and Amos Tversky's study of heuristics, Pinker argues that we see the world through a particular lens that the media gives us. Many of us think that flying is unsafe because the media reports only about plane crashes, when flying is actually the safest form of traveling.

It may have been faith that after reading both of Pinker's books, I almost immediately encountered Rolf Dobelli's *The Art of Thinking Clearly*, which is a gem of a book in which he provides a series of concise and powerful tools and tricks on how to be much more clearer in the way we think. Make no mistake: Thinking clearly is important!

[gallery ids="4773,4774" type="rectangular"] For instance, Rolf Dobelli quotes Kahneman and Tversky's theory of heuristics to remind us of how easy it is for us to think that something is abundant when it is actually a one-of-a-kind just because the way that the story is told -- in other words, how we mistake "representativeness" for statistics.

Dobelli argues that news are to be avoided because: Psychologically speaking, our brain reacts disproportionately to "sensational information" (e.g., plane crash, accident, shooting, death) and therefore tend to generalize illogically; Most of the time, reported news are irrelevant (i.e., how many times what we learn from television or newspaper really change your life for the better?); and, finally, News are meant to be consumed by those who do not have anything else better to do, and for this very reason the media are making it

very addictive to them so that they would waste even more time on the news.

In *The Art of Thinking Clearly*, he wrote the following challenge: Three years ago, I began an experiment. I stopped reading and listening to the news. I canceled all newspaper and magazine subscriptions. Television and radio were disposed of. I deleted the news apps from my iPhone. I didn't touch a single free newspaper and deliberately looked the other way when someone on a plane tried to offer me any such reading material. The first weeks were hard. Very hard. I was constantly afraid of missing something.

But after a while, I had a new outlook. The result after three years: clearer thoughts, more valuable insights, better decisions, and much more time. And the best thing? I haven't missed anything important. My social network—not Facebook, the one that exists in the real world consisting of flesh-and-blood friends and acquaintances—works as a news filter and keeps me in the loop. Also, in my own experience, I have also learned (the hard way) that not all journalists are responsible.

Once upon a time, I naively thought that journalists were experts (in reporting), who only wanted to write about something that would benefit the public -- whether that be facts or opinions. I was totally wrong. Not all journalists are responsible. Irresponsible journalists jump at any "news" that they could find.

They take gossips, scandals, rumors as "gold." When asked, they would respond, "these are smoke that would lead to fire." Only if they knew anything at all about ethics, they'd realize that such a saying is wrong in many counts. First, by reporting, they are likely to be the one who fan the smoke. "Self fulfilling prophecy" for one, is common, in news reporting. Researches have shown that stock market don't do well when pundits predict that the market is likely to slow down. Why? Because the pundits are right? No.

It's because those who buy and sell in the stock market read the news and then decide not to invest! That's crazy, isn't it? Many times, too. public

opinion leads to the public's thinking that someone is right or wrong -- the media's playing the role of a courthouse itself. These irresponsible journalists did not care about how their reportage may hurt the reputation of the innocent. These irresponsible journalists have torn families apart.

These irresponsible journalists are responsible for deaths of many whose small communities prejudged them based on the news and not the facts. They only care about having some "juicy" news to report so that they can cash their monthly salary cheque. There was no sense of human decency and these irresponsible journalists clearly do not have any sense of empathy let alone karma -- that one day someone may do the same thing to them.

All of us have learned from how the infamous irresponsible and untrue Rolling Stone reports had almost brought down the entire University of Virginia. The report was sensationally written but not true. Luckily, responsible journalists helped to point out countless holes in that report and saved the innocent from being victims of irresponsible journalism.

The magazine Rolling Stone had to issued a note to its readers, in which it apologized for the "flawed story." At the end, Rolling Stone had to pay US\$1.65 million for its bad journalism that caused a lot of people a lot of trouble. There're countless examples of this kind of irresponsible journalism. Just because you can write and post, with a platform to reach more people than usual, you should not call yourself a journalist.

So, here are my own results after a year without reading, watching, consuming any uncurated news. I didn't realize how time- consuming reading news were. Once I began to read one, I would want to go on to the next, and then the next, and then the next. Until I realized that the pot at the stove was burning. It's addictive. So, by shutting myself completely off from social media and regular news, I have gained approximately 3 hours a day of my time back.

How have I been using these extra hours a day? I have been using them to do what I enjoy, such as reading things I have always wanted to read but hadn't

have time, writing (this blog include), listening to audiobooks, and, even, simply sleeping; I feel much more clam. I also didn't realize how anxious it was, once upon a time, when knowing the talk of the town was a marker of intelligence.

Being able to unchain myself completely from this myth that intelligent people know what's going on in the world, I have gained the freedom to focus the attention on myself. On what I would like to spend my time on. And on how I want my emotional health to be; As Pinker writes, I see the world differently. The world isn't such a bad place as I thought it was before #deletefacebook and ditching all regular news.

The word is actually quite safe -- and it really is, we're living in the most peaceful time in the history of mankind. I mean, I wouldn't just go out at night and walk around anywhere just to test this hypothesis. Let's say that the world is a safe place for those who is conscious of its possible flaws.

I think the media had, for the longest time, given me the impression that, yes we're going to die, but we're all going to die in a epic painful manner because "we're all monsters and animals." Pinker also writes about how media and journalism love to project deaths, rapes, pains -- pretty much all forms of human indecencies. Actually, not reading the news has allowed me to see the world differently. I pet cats and dogs when I see them on the street. Greet my neighbors. Smile at passersby.

I could think of them as one of those criminals-in-disguised, but, no, that's not how I'd like to see them, and see the world; As Dobelli writes, I have not missed anything important: My "real world" social network" works as a perfect news filter and keeps me in the loop." My mother (who also doesn't like to consume a lot of news), for instance, would tell me about what's going on in the neighborhood, such as an opening of a new restaurant, and so on.

Any posts about scheduled maintenance of my building would be posted in the elevator (so I know when to move my car from the car park). There're always ways of knowing things. I do feel regret that I didn't know about the

boys in the cave until they got out. It would be nice to know about them. It's, perhaps, I was in a non-English speaking country during that time; so, all news were just noise to me.

But, seriously, would knowing or not knowing about them make my life any better or worse?

DAY 91

On Design Thinking Part 11: In Praise of Checklists

Wed, 24 Sep 2025 00:00:00 +0000



I WAS LISTENING TO ONE of my favorite podcast NPR The Hidden Brain the other day. The newest episode was a re-run of one of its most practical episodes. It's on the use of a checklist. Yes, a boring checklist. Here're my simple morning checklist. I need to accomplish all of these before getting out of the door:

Make my bed; Toilet; Shave (if needed); Shower; Coffee The line between a series of "must-do" (as in a checklist) and rituals isn't clear here. Apparently, I don't "need" to do any of these. I can always make my bed in the evening when I get back from work. I can always shave the next day (how much more mustache would I have after 24 hours?). And coffee? There're so many coffee shops on the way to work. Well.

turns out there're good psychological reasons for all of this to work. Making my bed, psychologically speaking and researched, makes me feel somewhat accomplished. It's shown in many researches that those who make their beds in the morning tend to be more positive when dealing with tasks during the day.

Shave, too, although doesn't makes me feel more "presentable" per se, it makes me spend time to look at myself in the mirror and inspect my being: That being who is a son of my mother, who is a true friend a few, and a diehard believer in the power of now. In other words, it doesn't give me the sense of efficiency, but efficacy. And coffee? It has to come after everything else, as explained in Daniel H Pink's *When: Don't drink coffee immediately after you wake up*.

The moment we awaken, our bodies begin producing cortisol, a stress hormone that kick-starts our groggy souls. But it turns out that caffeine interferes with the production of cortisol—so starting the day immediately with a cup of coffee barely boosts our wakefulness. Worse, early-morning coffee increases our tolerance for caffeine, which means we must gulp ever more to obtain its benefits.

The better approach is to drink that first cup an hour or ninety minutes after waking up, once our cortisol production has peaked and the caffeine can do its magic.⁷ If you're looking for an afternoon boost, head to the coffee shop between about 2 p.m. and 4 p.m., when cortisol levels dip again.

Well, my next book on my Audible.com's queue is *The Checklist Manifesto: How to Get Things Right* by the surgeon Dr Atul Gawande, who, also in this episode of *The Hidden Brain* talks to us about how important and critical a "seemingly boring checklist" could help. [gallery ids="4794,4795" type="rectangular"] A checklist is probably more well-known in the aviation industry.

Would you like to be on a plane where your captain, no matter how many hundreds of thousands of miles he/she has flown, doesn't run through a list of items required, things to be done, or points to be considered, used as a reminder before he/she flies the plane? I, for one, would not want to be on that plane.

The stakes are high and as you'll learn from this episode of *The Hidden Brain*, there're much evidence to show that the more experienced you are, in fact,

the more likely that you will miss a standard protocol "things to be done" which would lead to a fatal accident. In Dr Gawande's case, the missing of a checklist could lead to deaths. Think about something as simple as not cleaning your hand properly, as a surgeon, before a surgery. Fatal infection, perhaps?

Somehow most of us think that we don't need a checklist to remind us what we need to do on things we often, and usually, overlook. So, here're why that I think a checklist is important: Not all checklists are equal. There're bad and a good checklists. "Good" checklists are put together through some very painful experience of things' failing to work, falling apart, and not running as well as anticipated.

A good checklist for someone who is about to fly a plane (i.e., a pilot), for instance, is a result of countless hours of analysis, by thousands of experts, of thousands of black boxes found after the crashes. Luckily, we don't always have to go through these painful experience by ourselves. You can basically google a checklist on just about everything that you need in life, from running a small cafe to operating an truck.

Having a 15-bar espresso machine that breaks down only after making coffee for half a day as a result of the barista's forgetfulness to check the pressure valve before using the machine is obviously not as calamitous as (well, you lose money) crashing a plane. The lesson, however, is the same. They can be avoided.

Just use a checklist; Things on a good checklist are things that guarantee that whatever operation you are attempting to attend will "work." this is not to be confused that the operation will "accomplish." Nothing can actually guarantee that any operation especially if there is/are unanticipated external factors involved. For something to "work," firstly, is undoubtedly a great step for that which to accomplish; don't you think?; You can always improve your checklist.

Cross out things that you no longer need to check (such as once a certain part of the machinery or operation has been permanently upgraded) and add more items that would be helpful to the list. A good checklist evolves -- like a great creative mind; So, you can't be creative if the things you're trying to do don't even "work." So, when thinking about a product, service, or experience, you may begin with a list of "verbs" that you want it to accomplish.

In my line of work, I have seen many entrepreneurs who come up with an innovative product that doesn't do the most basic task. For instance, a high-tech coffee cup that has both the superpower NFC chip and heat sensor, but too expensive. In which case, maybe "affordability" (and to whom as well) should be on the checklist; and, You can share your checklist with likeminded people. I personally think that it's a great conversation starter (if not the nerdiest pickup line).

Seriously, why engage in a senseless smalltalk when you can actually compare things that can potentially make your and your counterpart's life better? Do you have a checklist? I just want to end this (unusually) short post with a general checklist. All of us should also have a "moral checklist" -- call it a set of principles if you want. It's always useful to stick to a series of principles. You could extract it from a guideline.

For instance, the philosopher Immanuel Kant, which is "I ought never to act except in such a way that I could also will that my maxim should become a universal law." In this case, it's of "categorical imperative" that people should not end their own lives or lie. Killing themselves would lead to the end of the human species and communicating falsehood would muddle the understanding among beings in this already very complicated species.

So, they would be something that should not become a universal law, hence the opposite, which is not to kill yourself and not to lie are two items of Kant's (actually quite long) moral checklist. If your guideline is, well let's make up something altruistic, to be "useful to the society," then your checklist may include "only hang out with someone who is also socially responsible," "only works for a cooperation that is concerned with the

environment," and so on.

For one, having a "moral checklist" will save you a lot of time. The (one of my favorite and you should know by now) author Rolf Dobelli writes in *The Art of the Good Life*: First: constantly having to make new decisions situation by situation saps your willpower. Decision fatigue is the technical term for this. A brain exhausted by decision-making will plump for the most convenient option, which more often than not is also the worst one. This is why pledges make so much sense.

Once you've pledged something, you don't then have to weigh up the pros and cons each and every time you're faced with a decision. It's already been made for you, saving you mental energy. The second reason inflexibility is so valuable has to do with reputation. By being consistent on certain topics, you signal where you stand and establish the areas where there's no room for negotiation. You communicate self-mastery, making yourself less vulnerable to attack.

So, as I have written about in my principles, I have a few rules for life. These are things that can be extracted as a moral checklist as following. Is he/she selfish? Is he/she kind? Is he/she getting wise and he/she getting old? Is he/she tries to have an opinion on everything including what he/she doesn't know? Is he/she often overthinking? Is he/she loving gossiping? I look at these in determining a friendship with someone. A tick at any of these boxes will not automatically determine that person unfrienable.

Some of which I think is a deal breaker (i.e., selfish and gossipy; I can't have a selfish and gossipy person around me). Some of which are lesser in their degree of criticality. Not only have these lists saved me from wasting a lot of time with the wrong people, but it has also improved the quality of my time with those who are true friends. With them, I can be much more creative. Long hail checklist!

DAY 92

On Jealously (I Forgive and Forget)

Thu, 25 Sep 2025 00:00:00 +0000



HOW MANY PEOPLE DOES IT take to make your life into a spiritual practice? Never mind if your partner will not cooperate. Sanity — consciousness — can only come into this world through you. You do not need to wait for the world to become sane, or for somebody else to become conscious, before you can be enlightened. You may wait forever. Do not accuse each other of being unconscious.

The moment you start to argue, you have identified with a mental position and are now defending not only that position but also your sense of self. The ego is in charge. You have become unconscious. At times, it may be appropriate to point out certain aspects of your partner's behavior. If you are very alert, very present, you can do so without ego involvement — without blaming, accusing, or making the other wrong.

The passage above comes from one of my newest favorite books of all time *The Power of Now* by Eckhart Tolle. I think it's a perfect way to "be here and now," which is something that Tolle himself equates with the idea of god (with an uncapitalized g). The last sentence in the passage above is what I find most useful.

Let me quote just it again here, "If you are very alert, very present, you can do so [point out certain aspects of your partner's behavior] without ego involvement — without blaming, accusing, or making the other wrong." The idea of this post came as a profound afterthought after a light (but deep) discussion with my mother during our car ride in the afternoon today. Our topic was simple, Why do people blame, accuse, or make the other wrong? Well, this may sound like a banal topic, but it isn't.

In the passage above, Eckhart Tolle argues that it's because the ego is in charge, and when that happens we place all the emphasis on the "me," "me," and "me" and only see everyone else as a culprit who is living against my being. Look, guys, this is interesting because I usually do not have time to blame, accuse, or make the other wrong, directly or indirectly. In fact, as I have written about earlier, I wholeheartedly believe that gossiping is a crime against humanity.

I don't associate myself with those who regularly engage in gossiping because (although I do not judge them) I think I have the right to protect myself by choosing not to be friends with them. Make no mistake, as Harvard Business Review reports, information overload is now a serious problem that can hurt your efficiency. It's better to #unfriend gossipy people if you want to keep your efficiency up, let alone keep your hope and faith in humanity.

Now that I think about it again (more carefully this time) the urge to answer this question actually never came to me earlier than today. It's simply because I always like to spend time improving myself, rather than bringing other people down. Sadly, there are many people who find pleasure in doing so. Just today I often to overheard a conversation between two strangers. While the first one was obviously very proud of his recent job promotion, the other one was doing the best he could to bring him down.

I heard, "Someone else got a better promotion." I honestly did not understand why the second person (I assume was a "colleague" or "friend") could not just be happy with the first one. Again, I only knew very little about what's going between these two. The one who got promoted didn't talk back,

walk away. Instead, he smiled at everything that the second person had to say. Well, maybe there's a point there. Maybe they're true friends.

Maybe there's a point in having a true friend like that to keep your ego in check. As a trained anthropologist (and still trying so hard to be a practicing Buddhist), I also rarely judge other people. One very very simple reason: I simply don't have the time to judge everything and everyone. My mother gets annoyed at me when I couldn't help her decide which shirt she would wear to go out, or which food to eat for dinner. I simply do not have any opinion.

I simply don't have the willpower to judge which is better. Either, or even both, is okay. There're so many things in the world I would like to judge, such as the quality of great non-fiction writings (yes, I am a nerd so I read about 200 non-fiction books a year), or the importance of acclaimed architectural edifices and how they shape how we think about the environment.

I see people's making judgment on someone or something based news they hear from the television, based on from gossip they eavesdropped from a stranger, and based on from flawed sources. These are the sources that they themselves would not make any important decisions based on. It's only so ironic how these people are so comfortable making judgment about others based on these sources that they themselves would not rely on.

Psychologically speaking, the kinds of things one can make a "snap judgement" about those that "confirm" your already established (however credible) assumption. This kind of snap judgement is called "heuristics." It's a mental shortcut that most of us use to make decisions (although, not all decisions are judgments, and not all judgements are equal). Clearly I can make a quick decision about wearing black rather than red today.

I have to make a judgment which shirt to wear but it's not a big decision, and whichever option that I choose probably won't lead to a calamitous result (as long as I use my now-favourite Issey Miyake Nuit D'Issey perfume). That said, this snap decision is barely a good one. Almost always, we're already biased by our lack of something.

An example: If you can't afford an iPhone and have recently heard from someone -- just one person -- about a new iPhone's being bad, you're likely to think that the iPhone isn't worth your hard-earned cash.

Psychologically, you are being "pre-suaded" (Dr Bob Caidini's term) to "pre-judge" the new iPhone by your own pre-existing "confirmation bias." Just to complicate things a bit: If somehow someone happens to tell you that the iPhone really isn't good, you're very very (as in 87.5%) likely to confirm your judgement that the iPhone really really isn't good -- even though you have never touched it, never seen it, and all you know is the name of the product and the fact that "two people in the world" have said it isn't good.

How strange. That is to say, that "lack of something" is the pathological symptom of jealousy. If you ever notice yourself, whenever you feel the urge to accuse, blame, or make someone wrong, it's almost always the case that you're jealous of that person. Hold on. I know what you're thinking about: Your sudden "snap decision" to disagree with the statement. You might say, "But I blame my inferior everyday, clearly as a superior, there's nothing that the inferior could have that I don't." Muse over that for a second.

That feeling of lack doesn't have anything to do with rank; but with appearance, age, personality, or even the ability to be carefree with life for which you, a superior, always yearn but do not have. As all the Stoic philosophers like to say when someone is accusing you, "Be proud; nobody accuse, blame, or gossip about a dead dog." I have written about this earlier but let me repeat it again. In dealing with people's accusing, blaming, and making you wrong, just rise above.

You have something that they do not have, and that's why they're trying to bring you down. What I usually do is this two golden steps: Forgive and forget. You'd rather enjoy yourself -- be in the moment -- than dignifying jealousy.

Judging others -- let alone accusing or blaming -- based on information confirming your bias is nothing less of judging the quality of the entire Indian Ocean by the small cup of water you have just scooped up from a small contaminated river two thousand miles away from that Ocean. As I have written earlier, one of my 12 rules for life is to be content with not having to have an opinion on things about which I do not know.

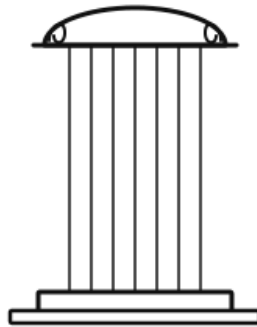
This goes without saying that I am a big fan of Dr Jordan B Peterson's "set your house in perfect order before criticizing the world" rule. And since a "perfect order" is rarely accomplishable, don't criticize. Live your life in the here and the now.

Back to Tolle's words "If you are very alert, very present, you can do so without ego involvement — without blaming, accusing, or making the other wrong." In short, I find the act of badmouthing other people to be intellectually, spiritually and morally a big fat waste of time. One rule still applies: Don't engage, walk away.

DAY 93

On Freedom

Fri, 26 Sep 2025 00:00:00 +0000



FREEDOM IS ONE OF THE most difficult topics. We all want freedom, but... Freedom from what? Apparently, freedom, at least in the society in which we are living today, doesn't mean you can do whatever you want. That would be like living in what the philosopher Thomas Hobbes describes as the "state of nature" where everyone can use force to take whatever they want from anyone. Apparently, too, nobody living in the "free world" today would accept the idea of any individual freedom's to hurt others.

What about the freedom to hurt yourself? Well, no country in the world legalizes suicide for a reason. Suicide is a "conscious decision" that only someone with a somewhat developed mental capacity could perform. What this means is that the society to which that someone belongs must have had invested some resources in bringing him up. Suicide, that is to say, is both a waste of those resources, and an "immoral" act that can potentially mislead the rest of the society.

What about the freedom to be stupid and hurt yourself indirectly? That's up for a debate. But even that, some of the most hardcore "libertarians" (i.e., those who believe in the doctrine of absolute free will) have increasingly endorsed the idea of "libertarian paternalism" -- the 2017 Nobel Laureate Richard H. Thaler and the author and legal scholar Cass R. Sunstein's idea

that even those hardcore "free-willers" to live a better life.

Even these hardcore free-willers want to be told that fastening their seat belts will prevent them from preventable death, and that they should probably not smoke too much because smoking kills. So, freedom to live trumps to the freedom to live in the dark. These hardcore free-willers may even argue that they're "living even more freely" because they are accepting the "forced better way of life," which they otherwise wouldn't have known.

I am personally particularly partial to the very last idea (i.e., "libertarian paternalism" in case you missed it), as it speaks to my own being. I, too, believe in free will, but I also want to say, please help me if you can tell me how to live a better life; please tell me what's bad for my health; and, please, please, please, tell me what I should do to live a better life. For instance, although I have a PhD in anthropology, I don't know much about food sciences.

So, even as a free-willer, I often beg (through voting for good people) my government to ban junk food, and endorse nutritious stuff. I also support banning of cigarettes at all public places (even though I was once a chronic smoker). I don't want to die young!

In case I wasn't clear what I meant earlier (since "libertarian paternalism" may sound oxymoronic), here's the passage from Thaler and Sunstein's best-seller *Nudge: Improving Decisions About Health, Wealth, and Happiness*: The libertarian aspect of our strategies lies in the straightforward insistence that, in general, people should be free to do what they like—and to opt out of undesirable arrangements if they want to do so.

To borrow a phrase from the late Milton Friedman, libertarian paternalists urge that people should be "free to choose." We strive to design policies that maintain or increase freedom of choice. When we use the term libertarian to modify the word paternalism, we simply mean liberty-preserving. And when we say liberty-preserving, we really mean it. Libertarian paternalists want to make it easy for people to go their own way; they do not want to burden

those who want to exercise their freedom.

What this mean is that even the smartest people among the free-willers still need some advice. There're two reasons for that. First, a society must be defended in the world where knowledge is, simply, too abundant for a single person to know it all. The best of us have to tell the rest what to do -- that which is least interruptive and most benefitting to our lives and livelihood. Second, there're plenty of evidences that show complete freedom could lead to chaos. Think of a traffic jam, for instance.

Or, air pollution. Sound familiar? We all have the right to buy private cars and emit some pollution to the air, but too much of that would suffocate the entire society -- including your own children. As we have leaned from great thinker like Garett Hardin, a society can also be overwhelmed with negative things if we're all thinking we're free to do whatever we want. Hardin calls it "a tragedy of the commons," which I think is an urgent question of every society today.

This is when and where "libertarian paternalism" comes in. You can be the smartest person in a certain field, but you can't be the smartest in all. So, if we assume that our government is capable of recruiting the "smartest" people from all the fields to help us live better in all domains of life, then we're all "libertarian paternalists" in the sense that we allow ourselves to be led by those who (at least we think they do) know what they are doing. But, is that freedom?

Is freedom then simply the ability to follow the rules of the society that presumably knows how to recruit the best to tell us what to do? What about some of those great ideas, say, "civil disobedience?" What if I don't agree with the idea of fastening a seat belt? What if I think banning cigarettes is stupid? Can I disobey things I don't agree? Shouldn't that be considered a greater form of freedom? That's both a great and horrible question. In a way, it's also great to be fallibilistic.

That said, since we now know the usefulness of seat belts (and danger of smoking), the idea of disobeying the fasten seat belt rule seems, well, plainly stupid. But hey, maybe I could be wrong (that's fallibilism's talking).. So, let's look at the bigger picture. Should the libertarian paternalists themselves, too, have some doctrine on which to base their argument?

The philosopher Immanuel Kant argues that freedom is (and I of course paraphrase) "the ability to live by your own rules." If you have a set of rules by which you want to live your life, and nobody can possibly entice you to follow otherwise then, according to Kant, you're a "free person." Yes, simply put: If you're a desert-hater, for instance, you're only free if you will always turn down an offer of a chocolate cake after the dinner at any cost.

That which means that you have own your rule by which you live. But what if the society forces you to eat that chocolate cake? If obeying your own rule means disobeying that of the society's, then you're only free if you engage in an act of civil disobedience. Yes, not eating that chocolate cake and being put in jail is freedom, for Kant. In addition to avoiding decision fatigue, there's another true socio-psychological benefit of turning down that slice of chocolate cake.

I resort, again, to Rolf Dobelli's *The Art of the Good Life*: By being consistent, you signal where you stand and establish the areas where there's no room for negotiation. You communicate self-mastery, making yourself less vulnerable to attack. Mutual deterrents during the Cold War were based largely on this effect. The USA and the USSR both knew that a nuclear strike would mean instant retaliation. No deliberation, no situational weighing up of pros and cons. The decision for or against the red button had already been taken.

Pressing it first simply wasn't an option. Kant, however, only argues that those rules have to be strictly adhered to his strictest "categorical imperative," or the rules that could well "become universal" (apparently eating a chocolate cake wouldn't be one of those). Think of race and racism, for example. Wouldn't you agree that we should be all treated equal despite the color of our skin?

If your answer, like mine, is yes; then you get the point; that which could become a universal law and therefore is a "categorical imperative." The Reverend Martin Luther King Jr. believed that the "the rights of citizens to political and social freedom and equality" should be universal; hence, he went on to, one and for all, change the course of history by civil disobeyed the rule of the state, of the society, and of the conventionality, of the time in which he lived. That's just one obvious example.

There're plenty. For these, the philosopher Immanuel Kant came up with a few, such as don't kill yourself, don't lie, and don't waste your capacity and learned skills.

I am also sure you can agree that you shall not kill thyself, and that you probably should not lie (e.g., one of Dr Jordon Peterson's antidotes to chaos "Tell the truth, or at least don't lie"), but what about "waste your capacity and skill?" Well, if all medical doctors, who spent years learning how to be medical doctors, have decided that they all no longer want to be in the profession, what would happen to those ill people who need their "capacity and skill?" Surely for a society to train a medical doctor, some resources would have to be invested on such training.

So, for Kant, a free society can't operate if it only trains people who will end up wasting their capacity and skill (watch out those who're not working in what you've been trained to do!). So, it seems as though there isn't a lot of ways to be completely free. Now, I want to turn 360 degrees back to the Stoics, Buddha (and John Lennon). What exactly do these great practical minds think we give ourselves the freedom from? Let me give you 4 of them.

If you can be free from all of these, you are free: Freedom from the ability to think. The Stoics are of grave concern with our mental ability to overthink and to, plainly, not stop thinking. The author and spiritual leader Eckhart Tolle argues in *The Power of Now* that most of us wasting our opportunity to enjoy life by thinking about the past and the future -- and therefore forsaking the presence.

The singer, writer, and artists John Lennon, sort of said the same thing that, "Life is what happens to you while you're busy making other plans." Descartes might be right that our ability to think (i.e., "I think") gives us the sense of the existence (i.e., "therefore I am.").

What he's wrong (or perhaps didn't address quite eloquently, to give the great philosopher the benefit of the doubt) is that this ability to think doesn't give us the pleasure that we as a species should enjoy -- the pleasure of "being in the moment." How many of us hear voices in our heads almost all the time? The answer is 99.9999% Most of us find it hard to stop thinking.

When we think, as Eckhart Tolle argues, "we stop living in the presence," which is a waste of the opportunity to be happy. The real freedom to have is the freedom to have that "switch" that you can turn it on and off whenever you wish (This takes a lot of practice and I am still working on it); Freedom from judging others. It's easy for us to be judgmental and opinionated. We're living in the world where information is treated as social capital.

This world makes us want to be judgmental and opinionated just about everything. The same way you wouldn't want your name to be associated with crime; you wouldn't want to cast your vote on events, actions, news, of which you do not have a complete knowledge. The real freedom is the ability to restrain yourself from jumping to quick to a conclusion, just because it confirms one of your preexisting biases, or because you feel the social pressure to appear "smart," or because you feel jealous of others.

Simply say no to things that you do not have enough knowledge on which to form an opinion. I do that all the time, and, needless to say, it feels super liberating every time. The true freedom lies in your ability to, simply, be a "gentleperson" in a society that is already rather hateful, rough, and chaotic; Freedom from wanting to control what is outside of your control. The Stoics have said it all. There're only two things that you can control: Your own value and your own opinions.

Nobody can take these two things away from you and you always have the absolute control over them. Problems often appear when we begin to think that we can control other people.

Parents' wanting to control their teenage children -- because they think it's in the freedom and right to do so -- often end in misery because they choose to place their bet on what they can't control instead of being fully in charge of their own opinion about their children's ability to freely go out in the world (and therefore make their own mistakes to learn). You are not free when you want to control what you can't control. Freedom from seeking revenges.

One of my older colleagues used to remind me that "revenge is a dish best served cold." He also consistently tells everyone he could find the "famous story" of how he managed to systematically undermine and destroy his former boss' research center, and therefore his boss' entire career. This older colleague argued that it was his book who "tried to destroy his career first," so it's was in this older colleague's right to seek revenge.

This older colleague always spoke of this revenge as an "achievement" -- "I served it to him not just cold, but coldest." I never agreed with this older colleague of mine when we're still colleagues, and I still don't. I feel as though this older colleague of mine had never moved on from the past -- he's still living that past over and over. And since when destroying someone's career something to be proud of anyway?

As both the Buddhist and Chinese old proves go, "Revenge is likely lead to another revenge." For Buddha, the act of seeking revenge itself yields deep visceral anger that surpasses multiple folds in magnitude the temporary joy received through seeing someone suffers through it. That joy, however, is not the one that gives you the sense of tranquility, but instability. Whenever I think about the mistakes of seeking revenge in the past, I always think my heart's beating heavy -- and it's not a joyous one.

The shrewd and wise Stoics never allow us to dwell over revenge. It's a waste of time. There're many other things more important to do. Seneca, for instance, never tried to seek revenge from those who banished, or even sentenced with him hard labour. He simply focused on how to improve himself and get back into the game. He's not insecure in any ways.

As a result, Seneca's never seeking revenge earned him the reputation of a true sage, and those who did many bad things to him all voluntarily came down to his knees to learn from him. In other words, a truly free person think of revenge "as a dish best not served." Forgive and forget. Am I not being free by not using my capacity and skill that I have been trained to do? I sort of agree with Kant.

Although, as a trained architect who barely designs any buildings, I also think that we should all have the right to change our profession. My decision to become an architect (at 16) wasn't a wise one; and hey, maybe I am just a horrible architect whose absence of buildings is better for the society as a whole. My architectural training actually never went away.

So, as I was being trained to become an anthropologist over the past 8 years of my life, I kept my previous profession at bay and tried to incorporate it to my anthropological training in any possible ways that I could. The point is not to retreat to a complete solitude. That wouldn't be a "free will" but a lazy (and perhaps a selfish) thing to do, for Kant. So, the fact that I am still here writing this, it's fine. It's still considered freedom.

I am a writer and an anthropologist. I am still an architect, who now happens to know quite a bit about anthropology.

post Day 94: On Making an Argument Sat, 27 Sep 2025 00:00:00 +0000 O.k. I just couldn't sleep. I have been having an issue with sleeping lately. I perhaps should seriously take my mother's advice not to take a nap after my late-afternoon run. Now, I am wide awake. Even after using the secret military technique whose claim is that it could make anyone fall asleep in two minutes, I still could not fall asleep.

So, while rolling on one side of the bed (as I had this hypothesis that changing from sleeping on the back to the side helps me fall asleep; spoiler alert: I was wrong), I came up with an idea for this post. So, I want to write about arguments. Specifically, I want to write about how to have the kinds of arguments that benefit you and your counterpart. First and foremost, the rule of thumb is not to argue with anyone.

This is one of the late life and self-help guru Dale Carnegie's golden rules in *How to Win Friends and Influence People*, and also, well, a commonsense. Arguing for the sake of arguing is a waste of time. So, should you argue, make sure that which is a productive and friendly exchange of diverging or opposite views that has the potential to lead to intellectual benefits of the involved parties.

Countless of time in my own life and of those whom I care, I witnessed how an argument could lead, and have led, to an end of friendship, relationship, co- workership, etc. Those are the instances whereby not having an argument at all would have been better for the parties involved. Again, an argument that leads to an end of a friendship isn't worth pursuing. But, why does it happen? So, let's get it straight rule by rule.

The most important rule: Not just an argument (but especially for an argument) but any form of communication that is likely to be effective has to be nonviolent. I am not talking just about a direct verbal abuse (which is obviously violent), but any form of ineffective communication, such as an criticism, judgment, sarcasm, and vague statement. It's true that most of us get emotional when we engage in an argument, and forget that it's never as important as the relationship you have with your counterpart with whom you're arguing.

So, for sure, the first thing to do is to watch your own emotion and never let it override your reason. The methods of nonviolent communication will help you do just that. I wrote about this a few times in the past, but let's reemphasize it here again.

[gallery ids="4825,4826,4827" type="rectangular"] Like me, the psychologist Dr Marshall B Rosenberg believes that the main reason for most conflicts we have in the world today is our inability to communicate "non-violently." When we communicate, we don't just say what we feel and what we need from those to whom we're expressing ourselves. We judge, compare, criticize, curse -- most of the time without any good reason. Most of the time, argues Dr Rosenberg, we use imprecise, judgmental and presumptive language to prematurely evaluate a situation.

These are communication that involves the use of negative adjectives (e.g., bad, mean, evil) and unnecessary adverbs (e.g., always, never, frequently) which are neither useful to get our meaning across, nor to get the other people to empathize with you. For instance, how many times does saying "You're always late" help to encourage someone to be punctual?

Here's one of the examples from Dr's Rosenberg's *Nonviolent Communication: A Language of Life: Life-Changing Tools for Healthy Relationships*: A couple in distress attending a workshop provides an additional illustration of how nonspecific language can hamper understanding and communication. "I want you to let me be me," the woman declared to her husband. "I do!" he retorted. "No, you don't!" she insisted.

Asked to express herself in positive action language, the woman replied, "I want you to give me the freedom to grow and be myself." Such a statement, however, is just as vague and likely to provoke a defensive response.

She struggled to formulate her request clearly, and then admitted, "It's kind of awkward, but if I were to be precise, I guess what I want is for you to smile and say that anything I do is okay." Often, the use of vague and abstract language can mask oppressive interpersonal games. The expert on marriage the psychologist John Gottman at the University of Washington also adds that one secret to a long lasting marriage is precisely the use of precise, non-judgmental and non-presumptive language.

For instance, if your partner forgets to take the garbage out, it's because he "might have simply forgotten to do so" and not because he was "bad," "lazy," or "taking advantage of you." Asking your partner whether he forgot to take the garbage out is likely to receive a good response than rhetorically asking whether he is doing it intentionally because he is "bad," "lazy", or "taking advantage of you." Once you get to the very bottom of what you're trying to express every time before you're doing so, it's likely that you won't communicate violently.

Alright. So, a nonviolent communication is the undergirding structure of all good arguments. Here're the rules (I am cheating here by taking the first 4 rules from Dr Jordan B Peterson's 12 Rules for Life): Treat yourself like someone you are responsible for helping. What Dr Peterson means here is that many times we treat other people better than we treat ourselves. For instance, I have friends who are always there for me when I need them, but whenever they need me they never call.

They don't want to bother me. I think that's unfair. Dr Peterson's example is that we tend to make sure that our pet (e.g., dog, cat) take prescribed medicines, while we tend to forget to take our own medicines. We're kinder to those about whom we care. In making an argument, you need to be as kind to yourself as your counterpart. You're also learning from the process and the argument should enrich, not deteriorate, your relationship with your counterpart.

Don't pursue an argument that is not helping you personally; Assume that the person you are listening to might know something you don't.

I must have heard this from one of the podcasts I listened to a while ago, but there's this line that really sticks: "If you can't first argue in the position of your opposition, you have no right to argue your own." What this rule will remind you is that while making an argument, watch out of things that might allow you to excel in your understanding of the subject matter. Again, the point of the argument is not to win, but to learn.

By why do we think that the purpose of an argument is to win? In *Metaphors We Live By*, the linguistic psychologists George Lakoff and Mark Johnson argue that it's because of how we have been using "war metaphors," such as "Your claims are indefensible," "He attacked every weak point in my argument," "His criticisms were right on target," to name a few (and I recommend the book; it's a classic!). You get the idea. But that's misleading.

Once and for all, we should treat arguments, not as war, but as learning process. Many of us today are trying to re-write these kinds of misleading metaphors. Love, for instance, doesn't have to something that we would "fall into," "hurt by" or cause "heartbreak." Using these as metaphors for love really isn't helping; Tell the truth – or, at least, don't lie. Yeppppppp; Be precise in your speech. Yep. Again vague and imprecise speeches, according to Dr Rosenberg, are considered violent communication.

When you want something to do something (e.g., take the trash out), be precise in your speech -- in this case, what should be done (e.g, "Could you please take the trash out," not "Why is the trash still in the house"). In an argument too, be clear in what you're trying to convey; Do some research, or don't. Make no compromise here. An argument is only worth pursuing when the two opposite views are based on some research.

There's one instance whereby I found myself engaging in a debate about the economy of recycling with a colleague. It took us 5 minutes to realize that none of us knew anything about that topic; hence, we just laughed at our silliness and dropped the "argument. You can have a casual nonviolent conversation about something to stir up some thoughts (but not gossip though) but do not take it as an argument if none of you have done any research or know anything about the subject matter.

As the Stoics would say, "it's completely okay to not having an opinion on something." If the reason why you'd rather go one restaurant over the other has to do only with your gut feeling, just say so; don't try to make up other justifications for it; "When the facts change, I change my mind. What do you do, sir? This quote is often credited to the great economist John Maynard

Keynes (despite the lack of any written evidence).

Keynes said so with regards to his changing view regarding macroeconomics of the UK. Often, economists stick to their guns, and their theories; hence, for someone as important as Keynes to say this, it's not to be taken lightly. He's right. We don't know everything. Do you remember when we all used to think that smoking was okay? The psychologist Dr Robert B Cialdini, in fact, points that "consistency" is one of the tricks that salespeople use to sell us things that aren't that worthy.

That's another golden rule (so many of them, lol). When engaging in an argument, the only preparation to have is to be enlightened, to learn from it, and to change your mind if you find the argument opposing you more convincing. Avoid using the word "you" and try to use the word "I." The worse kind of fallacy is the one that is directed against a person rather than the position (i.e., *ad hominem*, in Latin lit. "to the person").

Using "I" makes it much easier to express feelings, and much harder to attack the person.

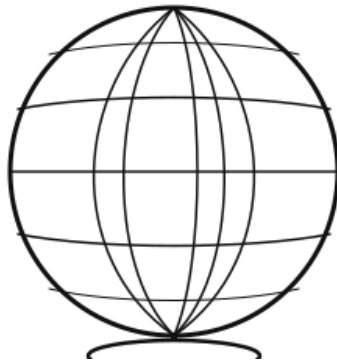
While it's usually useful to start an argument with "I," e.g., "I believe," "I think," "I feel" -- and you must follow it up with the magic word, "because." The psychologist Ellen Langer wrote in her classic study conducted in 1978 about the magical power of the word "because." Well, it's not that magical, but let's say that it would increase substantially the logical compliance and therefore the chance of your argument's being heard and taken seriously. O.k. I am still not sleepy.

How about a poster from the old time.

DAY 95

In Praise of Incrementalism

Sun, 28 Sep 2025 00:00:00 +0000



I AM JUST FIVE DAYS -- five days -- away from the golden "100 days" mark. For those who don't know why that mark is important, please return to the first page of this blog. I have been asked by a dozen of friends, "What are you going to do once you get to the hundredth day?" I actually have not thought about that.

I am thinking of two options: Going back to my previous posts and revise them (as in, "re- broadcast" or "radio replay"), and keep going beyond the hundredth day. As of now, I prefer the first option a bit more because I feel the urge to go back to my previous posts to read about my childish and immature thoughts. My hope is to use my humility to answer whether or not I have changed from those childish and immature days.

So, for the next five posts, I want to write about some the "key ideas" that make me who I am today. I, however, will skip those you already know from my previous posts, such as rebelliousness, lateral thinking, and morality. Oh, and probably romance and sex as well. I will probably come back to these at some points, but for the last 5 posts of the first 100 days, I want to talk about something less subjective, and more scientifically proven to be the case for self-development.

Let's start with the first one: I believe in consistent and gradual change, one step at a time. Some may call it "incrementalism." I hold this principle dearest because it has been the single most important principle that has so far positively changed my life. In my previous post, I wrote about those 5,000 hours over 6 years that "got" me into learning from English textbooks.

Long story short, I didn't have any friends when I was in college; so, by default, I had to find other way to spend my time when I wasn't in classes. I ended up spending hours every single day for 6 years reading books in the library -- since books could not really say whether they would like me to be their friends (I should say "a friend," rather than friends, during my first year in college because I managed to finish only one book during my freshman year).

Yep, I didn't become a serial reader right away (now I can't stand not reading something awesome everyday). Back then, I didn't write a single word. It's simply because I could not even construct a simple grammatical sentence in English (e.g., "Me loving you," which sounds like what Cookie Monster would say). During the entire first year in college, therefore, I only managed to read just one hundred-page-long book. Yes, just one book for the whole year during my freshman year.

In 1999, it took me about three days to get through a page, on average. It was that slow. But the process was not as annoying as I thought it would be. I still remember the joy of flipping through my old paper dictionary looking for words. That's what happened when you had to look up every single word in a paper dictionary. But bit by bit, I was able to speed up my ability to comprehend what went through my eyes.

Incrementally, bit by bit, one step at a time, I became faster at reading. Six years later, in 2005, I could finish a book in a week. "Little by little" is the meaning of "incrementalism." Just for one task -- the task to learn how to read in English -- it took me six years to do it. In 2018, I can probably read a book a day. I have come quite a long way from then -- little by little.

But I am already at least some 20 years away from those days (I graduated college in 2004), so "incrementally," I could reduce my reading time from one year to one day. That's 365 times faster -- but over the course of 20 years. This year, for instance, I hope to finish about 200 books. It's still not 365 books because I have other things that I'd like to do as well.

In fact, the author Rolf Dobelli writes in *The Art of the Good Life* that we should be more selective in how we read according to science. We're reading wrong. We're reading neither selectively nor thoroughly enough. We let our attention off the leash as though it were a dog we're happy to let roam, instead of directing it toward its splendid quarry. We fritter our most valuable resource on things that don't deserve them. Read a book twice? Why not?

In music we're used to listening to a track more than once. And if you play an instrument, you'll know you can't master a score on the first attempt. It takes several concentrated iterations before you can hurry on to the next piece. Why shouldn't the same go for books? The effect of reading twice isn't twice the effect of reading once. It's much greater—judging by my own experience, I'd put it at a factor of ten.

If I retain three percent of the content after one reading, after two readings it's up to thirty percent. So don't start stamping your reading ticket until you're about thirty, but be ruthless thereafter. Once you hit thirty, life's too short for bad books. Since I am already 36, perhaps I should listen to Dobelli. Yes, I think the remaining time my life is too short for bad books (and bad people, bad news, and every bad thing in general).

I guess what I am trying to say here is that my goal to read 200 books this year (and not 365) is because it's not about "how many" books that matter. Just because I can read fast doesn't mean I have to read a lot. I can spend more time doing other things, read the same book twice, and so on. [gallery ids="4834,4835" type="rectangular"] Researches have shown that incrementalism is actually what makes great minds.

We humans are built to crave exciting story, so we like to hear stories that are dramatic and magical. The author Malcolm Gladwell has written the whole book about it in *Outliers: The Story of Success* (which I have written about on this blog). But the truth is, as Gladwell points out in his book, even Bill Gates, Thomas Edison, Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart and the members of the Beatles needed those 10,000 hours to make them great -- incrementally. The author Stephen J. Dubner writes about incrementalism.

What do Renaissance painting, civil-rights movements, and Olympic cycling have in common? In each case, huge breakthroughs came from taking tiny steps. In a world where everyone is looking for the next moonshot, we shouldn't ignore the power of incrementalism. So, hey, let's do these three things. First, let's enjoy what we are doing on the daily basis -- learning things incrementally. The key here is to be consistent. Since there's no moonshot, one has to keep pacing.

If you want to read well and write well, for goodness' sake just read and write every day whenever you can -- on the bus, while waiting for the doctor, etc. These two words: Be consistent. I still remember during my time as an architecture student, I had a mantra which I strictly follow: "Never live a day without a line." I find that, if you are living in the presence, this process of learning incrementally is actually quite enjoyable if not liberating.

That's how all great artists, experts, minds becomes who they were/are. Second, since the way our brain learns is incremental, incremental learning is almost the only way to learn anything to be great. So, let's not kid ourselves that any of us can be great at anything by being born into it. According to science, hard work inhabits us with the habit(s) that allow(s) us to naturally navigate activities in our lives. To put it simply, if you ain't working hard enough, you ain't going to be good or great.

The next question is: What do you want to be? If you want to be good, then you just learn incrementally. As you learn, you'll be more skillful at the task you're learning. It may take weeks, months or years, but undoubtedly you'll become better at that task. You can even slack off from time to time (we all

have a job, right?) If you want to be great, however, you have to push yourself to be consistent about learning incrementally.

You might have to quit your other jobs to focus on learning incrementally on what you want to be great at. You may have to devote 10,000 hours (that's about 10 years of your waking hours) mastering that skill. It won't be easy but it will be fun. There's no other way around, according to science at least. You'll be better than good -- you'll be great, but there won't be any guarantee that you will get the results or praises.

Again, you may not confuse being great at what you do (as in, better than yourself the day before) and being at the top of the world (as in, getting all the accolades). As a Stoic might advise, you can control how great do you want to be, but you can't control how great others think you are.

So, if you choose to take this route, you must also take a Jordan B Petersonian attitude of "Compare yourself to who you were yesterday, not to who someone else is today"; Third, perhaps we can also learn to lower our expectations. Since our brain allows us to learn in small increments, we might be able to save ourselves from disappointments when expecting ourselves or others to improve drastically. Only a month ago, I couldn't stand being on a treadmill for more than 20 minutes. I found it absolutely boring.

Today, I can do one hour (with a 2 minute break in between). Come on, it's a great achievement for me, okay? I gradually increased my time on the treadmill by an increment of 5, so I began with 15 minutes, then 20, 25, 30, and so on. I am a cycling freak so I used to have to drive for one hour one-way to a dedicated cycling lane (which wasn't great for the environment) in order to ride for an hour.

Now I can just do that at the comfort of the fitness center in my apartment compound. Incrementalism rocks! Now, what else? Let's say, since I said in the beginning of this post that incrementalism has undergirded my life. Here're the top few. Finance: From an ATM, I always withdraw a bit less than I want. For instance, if my plan is to get \$100, I would just get \$90.

Since, to me, I don't see a lot of difference between \$100 and \$90, but after ten withdrawals, those \$10 will accumulate to a hundred. It's like getting a \$100 cash back every tenth withdrawal. Isn't that kind of nice? This goes with my saving plans and so on.

Incrementalism is great because you don't even notice it (and that's one of the argument that got the founder of the field of behavioral economics Richard Thaler the Nobel Prize!) Food consumption: That too, I always eat until I was about 70% full. Since, to my sensation, there's not much of a difference between being 100% and 70% full. Yet, those 30% is another massively tiring hour on the treadmill. I also cut back the same way on red meat, processed food, MSG, and so on.

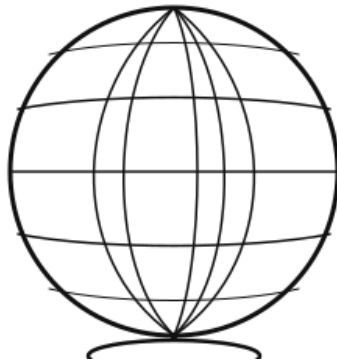
The great thing about incrementalism is that it's so tiny that I can barely notice it, so, psychologically, I have the full control in managing my behavioral change through it. Love and relations: I think the kind of love and relations among people that will last is the one that is consistent. Many might think that it's good enough if it doesn't decline over time. We humans tend to want to seek more stories from newer relations, but that's because we think that stories have to be new. They don't.

They can be something that is built up over time. We all have great stories to tell, brag and regret, about our own personal development. It's the same. Writing a blog: One day at a time.

DAY 96

In Praise of Self-Improvement

Mon, 29 Sep 2025 00:00:00 +0000



AS I MENTIONED, I WANT the last 5 posts to be about the "self-improvement values" that I have held dearly. That said, I have not always been able to practice them. There had certainly been times when I let my immediate emotion, gut feeling, belief, and heuristics take over my values, resulting in my failures to perform what I have set out to. These values are different from the "moral values" that I have outlined in my 12 rules.

In my last post, I wrote about my first self-improvement values -- incrementalism. Here're the other four. First, Quality (over quantity): There's no other way to put it: It's more important to me to get one thing done right, rather than get many things done half-right. We're living in the world dominated not only by speed and scale, but also the madness of obsession over quantity.

These things range from who earn more, to who have received more awards and recognitions, to who have more possessions, such as luxury items, houses, cars, etc. I grew up in a family that valued the quality of the work we did -- the kind of work that made us proud of our contribution to our family, company, institution and society -- and such quality was not always represented by how much we earned or how much we're being recognized publicly.

True, one would be lucky to be able to do massive amount of quality work. My point is that if I have to choose between quality and quantity, I would go for the former. Often, if not always, we don't have the luxury to choose both. Once the quality is achieved, and there's a possible that it can be achieved with multiplicity, then, certainly, why not.

Second, Process (over result): This has been the mantra with which I often shout at myself whenever I begin to expect that I should get whatever I want as a result of the work done well. Many thinkers, especially the Stoics, have reminded us again and again that we suffer when we try to control things we do not have any control over. We can control our value and opinion -- how much work we want to put into the work by ways of own willpower.

The result, on the other hand, unless it's judged by you as well, is not in your control. Of course, you may think that your work is good enough to get a good result (in fact, as the psychologists Daniel Kanehman and Amos Tversky have reminded us, we tend to overestimate our ability to plan and therefore over-expect our ability to achieve), but even if that which is the case, you must not undermine other factors that could shape the result.

So, as the Stoics suggest, we might as well ignore the anticipation for a desirable result altogether, and focus solely on the process. I am personally an "anti-consequentialist." Consequentialism preaches the idea that the morality of an action is to be judged solely by its consequences. In the words of Deng Xiaoping about whom I wrote in my Anti-Fragile Manifesto post, "It doesn't matter whether a cat is black or white, as long as it catches mice.

" This "Deng-ism," as some political scientists call it, came in timely and handy at the time when Deng had to deal with problems from all fronts and had lifted China out of its extreme poverty in the decades preceding his re-emergence in the chaotic scene of Chinese politics as the supreme leader; yet, there will be always be something rather unsettling lingering in many's minds about that statement.

If a "black cat," is a malignant means, it should not justify any result even if that result happens to be benign. Would you do anything to achieve your goal including hurting others? My answer is a qualified no. In fact, I suggest that you stay away from anyone who would do anything to excel, because for someone like that there's virtually no guarantee that hurting you won't be on that person's plan to benefit him/herself.

Historians, analysts, critics have argued that it's precisely the use of these "black cat" methods to catch the economic mice that erodes the collective sense of morality in the contemporary Chinese society the three decades that follow, causing massive and irreversible social problems that may have exceeded its initial benefits.

Third, Unconventional (over conventional): My favorite poem of all time by Robert Frost begins like this: "Two roads diverged in a yellow wood, And sorry I could not travel both." Like the poet, "I took the one less traveled by, And that has made all the difference" but not for the same reason. It could be the case that roads that are less travelled are dangerous, long and winding and therefore inefficient as a travel route.

It could also be the case that it's "easier" to just take the road frequently traveled because, that way, we do not have to think: We just follow. That's precisely what conventionalism means -- the idea that what is "generally" held by the mess is to be thought as acceptable at the expense of individuality. I don't care much about my own individuality.

I am only interested in the truth, in giving the fair picture to what is not "generally held by the mess as acceptable." As the clinical psychologist Dr Jordan B Peterson remarks, "In order to think, you have to risk" -- your life, damaging your own pre-existing belief, and offending other conventional minds who are too lazy to put their brains to work. When I see a road less travelled, I feel the urge to know more about it.

It's too easy to just do whatever most people like to do, which is another classic fallacy (i.e., "social proof"). In fact, I enjoy using my brain to think

about the desertion of the road less travelled, and if I could not find any sensible reasons that render it dangerous, I will take the less, instead of frequently travelled road.

As the philosopher Immanuel Kant remarks, "enlightenment is mankind's emergence from its self-imposed immaturity," something in me makes me believe that taking the road less travelled is the path to that enlightenment. A bonus: Taking the road less travelled makes life more exciting. Why do you want to take the same road again and again? Fourth, Good enough (over perfect): Perfectionism isn't a quality but a mental state that only exists in the mind.

So, those who confuse what perfectionism are those who often suffer from their inability to let go, move on. They're usually burdensome to others expecting their timely delivery of a project, result, etc. I have met a number of seemingly intelligent people who could not finish anything on time. And their excuses?

You bet it is "Because I am a perfectionist." And these people always shake their heads when I tell them, "Why don't you try to be just good enough instead?" Whatever we do in life, we'll always be constrained by space and time. These are the two domains of the phenomenal world in which we live. Surely, if you have all the time in the world, you may be able to bring anything and everything into its finest perfection.

But when do we ever have all the time in the world? That's never the nature of any assignment. Space, too, plays in the same role in constraining our ability to maneuver and deliver our products. In addition, precisely because the space and time, what's "perfect" in one place and time might not be perfect in the other. I personally suffered a lot during the writing phase of my doctoral dissertation.

Even after three years of data collection (which was unusually long for a doctoral research) I still felt as though my work wasn't good enough, Not because I was a perfectionist (spoiler alert: far from it) per se but because I

feared my advisor' disappointment if the work delivered to him was of the less-than-perfect quality.

It was this advisor who guided me with his wise words, "Perfectionism is a form of arrogance." After that, I shifted my focus from "producing a perfect work that won't disappoint my advisor" to "producing a good enough work that reflects the three years of quality data collection and its careful analysis." You wouldn't believe how fast I could move with my writing that had stalled for more than a year preceding that.

As I believe in quality over quantity, I took time to focus closely on my collected data, analysis and writing. I wasn't able to deliver a magnum opus of a dissertation that was 500-page-thick, but I was able to complete a good enough work that represented some competence in my field of study. Of course, my advisor did not go over the moon with my work, but he wasn't dreadfully disappointed either.

For the philosopher Plato, "Forms" are being represented by objects in the real world; hence there will never be perfect. My dissertation was that object that represents the "ideal form" of that dissertation.

DAY 97

Problematizing Time

Tue, 30 Sep 2025 00:00:00 +0000



ONCE UPON A TIME, A wise man I spoke to. "There's no problem; there's only time," said he. Little did I understand. Years passed, and soon I rephrased: A brush called time paints a canvas we call "space." Time intensifies the slate. "Space," and time: We need space to exist, to be, in a living paradigm. Time prevents everything to happen all the once. "Space," and time are the brush and canvas. In the realm we live, these two can't be apart. Otherwise, from our mind we can never depart.

This canvas, however, is far from objective: Painted on it, the thing may not make me feel as intensive, In a perspective. Sometimes, I allow time to paint that very canvas, intensely. Which makes me I experience time, problematically. The wise man was right, cleverly. Relative, time also is.

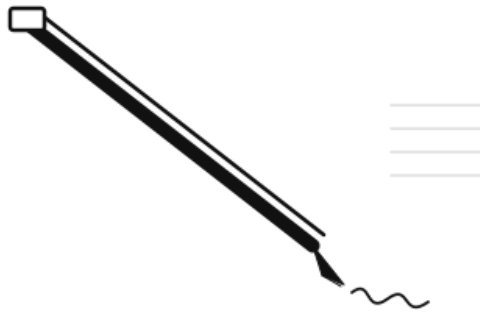
Einstein may or may not have said: "Waiting for a pretty girl for a minute, and it seems like an hour." "Talking to the same girl for one hour, It seems like, Just one minute." Time is relative, I soon realize: Pain lasts longer than pleasure, both in temporally and in size. Ruled by time, the canvas, and homogenized. One minute with pain feels like an eternity, While a year of pleasure is simply negligible. How unfair? We cry over a sudden spill of milk.

But we don't appreciate the presence, This very moment we're still living.
What, then, should I do with time? In other words, All my problems, what
should I do with? All is equal thus far: Pleasure and pain, Are on par. A
problem is not just time, It needs time, To problematize. Give that problem
more time, It disintegrates, de-intensify. Enjoy both pain and pleasure. As
they come, And they go, Relatively speaking:-) The End.

DAY 98

What I Know for Sure

Wed, 01 Oct 2025 00:00:00 +0000



IT'S GETTING THERE. I AM 3 days away from the 100th day -- hooray. I can't wait. It would be wonderful to finally reach the milestone I set for myself over three years ago. I obviously overestimated my ability to be both consistent and persistent. The 100th day was set to be finished around mid-2016, so I will be about 300% tardy when, hopefully, the 100th day post was finally written within the next few days.

The psychologists Daniel Kahneman and Amos Tversky call this a "planning fallacy," of which I may be a prime example: I planned because I thought I could do it, but I failed to do it. But if we may think about it from a different angle, that's actually life. How many times things in life actually goes as planned?

When I planned to write "a blog a day for one hundred consecutive day" (hence, the name of the blog), I was not just being optimist about my ability to pursue it, but I also deliberately took for granted the nature of life: That shit happens. Metaphorically (luckily) shit is what we least or don't fully expect (call it a black swan if you may). When shit happens, we are forced to slow down, recalibrate, and re-position ourselves.

That's why things don't go as planned, and time is usually the first thing that shit affects. In this post, I want to write about those shit and disruptions. In other words, I want to write about what (I think) I absolutely know for sure about life. These are, to me, categorical truths based on my experience living in this world (and dealing with disruptions in life that result in the delay the completion of this blog and fuels the planning fallacy.

Here you go: 12 things I know for sure. The fastest way to feel unpleasant is to compare yourself (or your situation) to others (self-pity and ego-boost are no good); Unless you let them, how others think about you cannot affect you (they can even take your soul if you let them, oh, but don't you let them); In doing things, ego is the enemy (so, kill it).

and obstacle is the way (so, embrace it); Being seen doing good it doesn't make it "more good"; in fact, it feels much better to do it without anyone else knowing but you (try it!); Unhappiness is a result of our failed attempt to control that which we are not in control of (And, how many things in life we are really in control of?

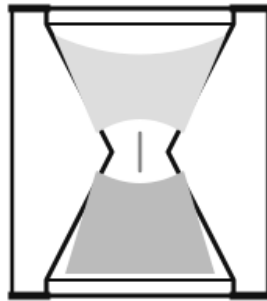
Stoics would say just your value and your opinion); Those who enjoy judging others do not like to be judged; so, they justify judging others as a form of self-defense; When focusing in the presence, you cannot possibly worry about anything (Go on, try it; don't think about the past or the future, you won't be able to think about anything that can possibly worry you); Even about things we think we know well, there's still almost a 100% chance that our knowledge is not all complete (so let's assume that the person we are talking to might know something we don't, and learn); Bad news appear more often than good news in the media, and people don't use the internet to tell the world about who they really are; so, don't mistake what you see on the internet as the representation of the world.

We can actually become better versions of ourselves by reading books. Whenever shit happens, turn yourself to some great books. Silence is less harmful, less violence, and altogether better than gossip and nonsense prose. The world is not perfect -- nothing is -- but it's still good.

DAY 99

Why Reading News Isn't Good for You

Thu, 02 Oct 2025 00:00:00 +0000



YES, I ONLY LEARNED ABOUT the Thai soccer team in the cave after they'd gotten out of the cave... Shame on me, right? Not so fast! I also only learn about a lot of things, not through reading news, but through words of mouth from family members, colleagues, friends, cab drivers, baristas and those whom I casually converse with on the street. The news, if they're relevant to me, will come to me regardless, I believe. I don't consume news. Period.

One time, one of my good friends even madly freaked out when I told him about the fact that I haven't been reading news for almost three years, that I don't have a Facebook account, and that I do not intentionally consume any forms of news at all. "How do you even survive?" Well, truth be told, I have survived -- and have been happy. First, most of the news, to me, are not relevant to my personal life.

Second, knowing that news are made overly sensational to sell, I don't see the point of consuming them. As a famous Zen monk once said (and I paraphrase this from Eckhart Tolle's *A New Earth*), "events are not personalized, so there's no point in engaging in human drama" (especially knowing that they're made sensationalized at the expense of your emotion), I

find even more reason to not stay away from intentionally consuming news. Does this make sense to you?

[gallery ids="4858,4859,4860,4861" type="rectangular"] Research for this post comes from these literatures. At first, I actually didn't think it made much sense to me either -- until I found some key ideas from some of the key thinkers about the dark side of news that resonated with my very own. Let's start with that of Rob Dobelli. News reports do not represent the real world. Our brains are wired to pay attention to visible, large, scandalous, sensational, shocking, people-related, story-formatted, fast changing, loud, graphic onslaughts of stimuli.

Our brains have limited attention to spend on things that are small, abstract, ambivalent, complex, slow to develop and quiet, much less silent. News organizations systematically exploit this bias. I agreed with this statement but I honestly didn't truly understand what he meant at first. It's until I spoke to a well-known journalist at one of the most respected newspapers (of course I won't tell you which newspaper this was).

What's said to me was frank, vivid, and appealing: We know that every event has at least two sides of the story; the problem for us -- who need to sell news for living -- is that if we were to truly investigate all sides of such event, you can bet that such event will be no longer newsworthy. You won't understand us unless you're in the business of journalism.

That is, for this senior journalist to produce enough news for the said newspaper to actually get himself paid a salary, he needed to turn a blind eye on what he knew for sure would add depths, and more importantly the notion of truth and balance, to the story. But not all truths are sensational -- usually they aren't. He's basically saying that "everything can go" if he can sell the news. They're just facts that all of us can understand, empathize and even sympathize.

So, those won't sell and therefore won't be included in the news. I am not saying that all journalists operate this way, but there's some truth in it. Think

about it. What would you do if you're in his position. Again, Dobelli summarizes the following points: As a result of news, we walk around with the completely wrong risk map in our head. Terrorism is overrated. Chronic stress is underrated. The collapse of Lehman (one of the world biggest financial institutions in 2008) is overrated. Fiscal irresponsibility is underrated.

Astronauts are overrated. Nurses are underrated. Britney Spears is overrated. IPCC Reports are underrated. Airplane crashes are overrated. Resistance to antibiotics is underrated. You get the point. All of the "overrated" events above have the much less chance of happening statistically, but they're "sensational." News direct us away from the "underrated" events that are much more relevant to our lives -- how many times in this life you'll be talking to a nurse than to an astronaut?

How many times do we see any news agencies' reporting the skillfulness of an airplane pilot who shrewdly land a plane, and therefore saving hundreds of innocent lives? Zero. A plane crash, on the other hand, is "overrated" and repeatedly reported to the point that many of us could have a screwed view of aviation industry. What good does that do? I wrote a while ago about how our brain is prone to make a decision based on a mental shortcut (known as "heuristics").

The path of this shortcut is built by the availability of the information that we have about something. So, you'll tend to think that the world is unsafe, if the television that you've been constantly watching is showing a lot of news about terrorism --- when we know that which is not the accurate portrayal of the society, but, rather and sadly, what sells. The "availability bias," what the psychologists would call this phenomenon, pave the way to our misleading view of the society.

Think about how this could lead to a much more serious problems in communication, in organizational management. Would you like to live in the world in which everyone bases their judgement on the very little knowledge that they have? So, why continue to be a victim of such thing?

In *Enlightenment Now: The Case for Reason, Science, Humanism, and Progress*, the psychologist Steven Pinker shows us the data to support his claim that: Whether or not the world really is getting worse, the nature of news will interact with the nature of cognition to make us think that it is. News is about things that happen, not things that don't happen.

We never see a journalist saying to the camera, "I'm reporting live from a country where a war has not broken out"—or a city that has not been bombed, or a school that has not been shot up.

As long as bad things have not vanished from the face of the earth, there will always be enough incidents to fill the news, especially when billions of smartphones turn most of the world's population into crime reporters and war correspondents." Like Pinker, Dobelli himself has carefully studied this phenomenon and his understanding was aligned with what I heard from the senior editor of a respected newspaper to whom I spoke. He writes: "Some journalists take time with their stories and try to think things through.

But like any profession, and probably more so than in any other profession, journalism has its incompetent, unfair practitioners who don't have the time – or the capacity – for deep analysis." Here is the truth of capitalistic news-making: Often, they are paid by the piece, the line, or the word. You might not be able to tell the difference between a polished professional and a rushed, glib, paid-by-the-piece writer with an ax to grind. It all looks like news. Scary, right?

So why are we continue to read whatever "all looks like news?" Are we that innocuous, naive, or stupid? Or, it's because there's a certain belief that whatever is in the news, at least, do have some truth in it? In his study, Dobelli argues that "Fewer than ten percent of the news stories are original. Fewer than one percent are truly investigative." Dobelli, like the psychologist Steven Pinker, doesn't hate news completely. Neither do I actually.

He, in fact, argues for the "hard-core journalists digging into meaningful stories. We need reporting that polices our society and uncovers the truth."

He claims, and I agree, that Watergate a good example, but truly this kind of investigative journalism takes time, efforts, and a lot of balancing to see the whole picture clearly so that the event can be reported with the fullest sense of journalistic responsibility. I totally agree.

I think there're areas of the society that the authority doesn't want us to know, so they buy out every effort that could bring them to life. We need the Boston Globe-typed "Spotlight Team" to help uncover them, showing us what the society is like. You might be aware of the fact that what these investigative journalists are doing are much less of presenting a "dark side" of the society and the world as such, but showing what lies beneath the seemingly benign surface of events, things, and people.

Again, I do hope that this is the only kind of journalism that exists. Unfortunately, tabloids, commercial newspapers, etc, are still the standard, and our brain are wired by wanting to "hear stories" (read or listen to Jonathan Gottschall's Storytelling Animal podcast) to the point that we find them addictive. By the way, we haven't even begun to touch upon the topic of "fake news" (which, by the way, is the new word has made its way into the Oxford Dictionary this year) in this post.

In short, Dobelli argues that news (as they're presented to us 99% of the time today) isn't useful because (and be ready): News misleads us systematically, limits understanding, massively increase cognitive errors, makes us passive, and kills creativity. There's another thing. Our brains have very limited capacity to store data to be processed, so the more you know doesn't necessarily mean the more you would be able to make use of what you know.

In fact, there is a very accurate psychological fact about this notion of the brain that is best expressed, surprisingly, by one of the favorite fictional heroes, Sherlock Holmes.

Here's his conversation with his buddy Dr Watson in *A Study in Scarlet* (and this just show that the author Sir Arthur Conan Doyle knew about this fact all along even before he constructed the character Holmes): I consider that a

man's brain originally is like a little empty attic, and you have to stock it with such furniture as you choose.

A fool takes in all the lumber of every sort that he comes across, so that the knowledge which might be useful to him gets crowded out, or at best is jumbled up with a lot of other things, so that he has difficulty laying his hands upon it. Now the skillful workman is very careful indeed as to what he takes into his brain-attic.

He will have nothing but the tools which may help him in doing his work, but of these he has a large assortment, and all in the most perfect order. It is a mistake to think that that little room has elastic walls and can distend to any extent. Depend upon it there comes a time when for every addition of knowledge you forget something that you knew before. It is of the highest importance, therefore, not to have useless facts elbowing out the useful ones.

So, there you have it: Why I don't read news and why I am still doing just fine with my life and maintaining my livelihood. News, as Dobelli says, is like sugar to the body. It's sweet and it plays with the part of our brain that makes us feel addicted (for more on sugar, I recommend an episode of Freakonomics Radio called *There's A War On Sugar. Is It Justified?*). Our body doesn't need sugar.

It doesn't need the kind of artificial neuro-stimulation that will end up giving us weight gain, blood sugar problems and an increased risk of heart disease, among other dangerous conditions. Yep, why don't you try putting in "the benefits of sugar" on your Google Search -- you'll find nothing.

My good friend rebutted his argument that knowing some trivial facts "helped to generate conversations, small talks, and positive gossips (by which he meant a harmless gossip that bond people together)." True, but is there such thing as a "positive gossip?" Again, the words of Holmes (actually, of Doyle's) ringers, and remember them, "It is of the highest importance, therefore, not to have useless facts elbowing out the useful ones." So, let's stray away from useless facts -- and most of time, as journalists love to

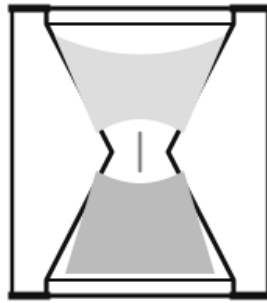
report, the useless not-even-facts, and return to great books, classics, scientifically-proven research and ideas.

They aren't sugar, and they will certainly equip you with the knowledge that you will need to make your life in this world more meaningful in a long run.

DAY 100

The 44 Books that Change My Life

Fri, 03 Oct 2025 00:00:00 +0000



LET ME SAVOR THE MOMENT a bit. What moment? Come on, you know. It's the moment of reaching the "100th post milestone" that, by the way if you haven't already known from the name of this blog, I had set for myself at the onset of this post. Shamelessly, and whatever-bad-habit-ly of mine, life as such has obviously taken me more than 100 days to get to this point -- to be precise, it's been about 1,300 days since I had set out to start this blog in 2015.

In other words, I am showing how a classic error that cognitive and social psychologists would call a "planning fallacy" operates in reality (check out a Freakonomics Radio episode for a crash course on the topic).

I have alluded to this fallacy a few times in my earlier posts; in short, proposed by the two great psychologists (and my heroes, if you don't already know) Daniel Kahneman and Amos Tversky, is a phenomenon in which our own predictions about how much time that will be needed to complete a future task often, if not always, display too much of an optimism bias. What this planning fallacy causes is the underestimation of the amount of time needed to complete such task.

Come to think about it, I have never, in my life, finished any task on the day that I thought I would. Ever. For This blog, I didn't think that it would be so

hard to write something every day -- just a post a day. How hard would that be? But it's turned out to be very difficult to keep up with writing, even just a blog a day, amidst other things in life of which I also have to take care. There're other tasks and other deadlines.

There're times of tremendous emotional baggage that get in the way of writing. And there are, of course, occasional laziness. There're physical fatigue. And there are weddings to attend. How hard is it to write something every day? Very hard, indeed: There're ad hoc work to take priority -- you get the point. The lesson here is, whenever you're planing a task, make sure that your actual deadline is at least a few weeks beyond your "optimistic deadline" you'd like to unrealistically set for yourself.

O.k., enough about my inability to do things. Let's get to what I would like to write about. For the past 5 years, I have been reading more than 300 books (yep, I don't have much of a life). Reading is something that I utterly enjoy, especially when I bike, drive, or do other mechanical things. I have to thank my own discovery of e-books and audiobooks. It's been a hassle to carry books with me wherever I go.

I travel abroad a lot, and the joy of reading physical books is usually blocked by my unwillingness to carry them in my already-pretty-heavy bag. Books are burdensome. So, e-books are great. I could read them on my phone, laptop, tablet, etc. I could search, copy, cite, and so on, also, very easily. It's difficult at first but after a while, as I've evolved evolutionarily, I have embraced the technology. Now, it's hard for me to go back to physical books, ever again.

I haven't bought any books, too, since 2013. Every day, also, I travel from home to work and back; during which, apparently, there is a plenty of "lost time" during my travel. This lost time is a traffic engineering term referring to he time during which no vehicles are able to pass through an intersection despite the traffic signal displaying a go signal. Same here, I could be reading a book while driving but that wouldn't make it safe for me, would it?

What can you really do when you're driving, or on a metro or a bus? So, ever since I've discovered audiobooks, I've begun to utilize those loss time and turn them into learning time and productive time. On average, an audiobook is about 8- hour-long, which I could finish listening to it in about 4 days -- say, I spend about 2 hours a day traveling to work; hence, I only need 4 days x 2 hours to finish a book. That's something I consider miraculous.

In essence, I have read more books in the past 5 year then in my entire life! My former student and now a careful thinker colleague from Poland, Robert, has suggested the topic for this post (thanks, Robert!) I'll put these books in a few categories -- each category contains more than 4 books (as the more doesn't mean the better -- it just means indecisiveness).

I also take into account my very own "peak-end rule heuristics" and "thinking fallacy" or the idea that I tend to remember more of the books that I have recently read rather than what I read a while ago (check out an episode of NPR The Hidden Brain podcast for a sweet discussion with the psychologist -- the great man himself). So, keeping that in mind, I'll try to come up with the best possible list.

I have mentioned most of these books in my earlier posts in one form or the other. See if you can spot them.

On how to think: [gallery ids="4861,4774,4875,4906" type="rectangular"] On how to be a better social being: [gallery ids="4876,4888,4891,4878" type="rectangular"] On how to see the world as it actually is: [gallery ids="4860,4874,4893,4910" type="rectangular"] On spirituality (and how to keep calm and carry on): [gallery ids="4881,4882,4883,4677" type="rectangular"] On how to be better at writing: [gallery ids="4884,4885,4886,4887" type="rectangular"] On moderate-to-extreme self improvement: [gallery ids="4890,4889,4892,4923" type="rectangular"] On something surprisingly awesome: [gallery ids="4894,4897,4907,4925" type="rectangular"] On creativity: [gallery ids="4898,4899,4900,4901" type="rectangular"] Classics that I revisited and utterly enjoyed: [gallery ids="4902,4903,4904,4905" type="rectangular"] On history, biography, and

stories that matter: [gallery ids="4911,4912,4908,4877" type="rectangular"] My personal favorites which are sort of uncategorizable: [gallery ids="4909,4896,4879,4918" type="rectangular"] Alright, there you have it.

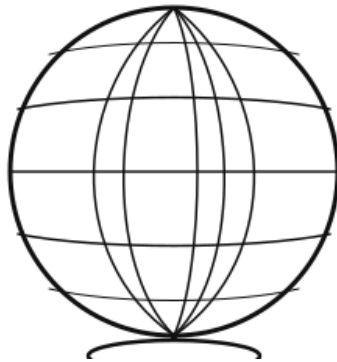
These are the books that have, in some ways, changed my life. I have just realized that these are only 44 out of some 300 books that I have read (and listen, as in audiobooks) over the past 5 years. The rest are also great, but these are the creme de la creme. I perhaps still need to look for more books to read and listen too -- it's so addictive. If someone asks me how I'd define myself, I probably wouldn't say that I'm an architect or an anthropologist.

I'd proudly call myself a "reader."

DAY 101

How to Deal with Unpleasant Events

Sat, 04 Oct 2025 00:00:00 +0000



A BEAUTIFUL GIRL IN THE village was pregnant. Her angry parents demanded to know who was the father. At first resistant to confess, the anxious and embarrassed girl finally pointed to Hakuin Ekaku, the Zen master whom everyone previously revered for living such a pure life. When the outraged parents confronted Hakuin with their daughter's accusation, he simply replied "Is that so?" When the child was born, the parents brought it to the Hakuin, who now was viewed as a pariah by the whole village.

They demanded that he take care of the child since it was his responsibility. "Is that so?" Hakuin said calmly as he accepted the child. For many months he took very good care of the child until the daughter could no longer withstand the lie she had told. She confessed that the real father was a young man in the village whom she had tried to protect. The parents immediately went to Hakuin to see if he would return the baby. With profuse apologies they explained what had happened.

"Is that so?" Hakuin said as he handed them the child. I have copied this story from John Suler's Zen Stories to Tell Your Neighbors, but I first read from it in Eckhart Tolle's A New Earth: Awakening to Your Life's Purpose. In Tolle's words, the Zen Master Hakuin simply did not want to "participate in human drama." As Tolle describes: To the Zen Master Hakuin, there is only this

moment -- and this moment is as it is. Events are not personalized. He is nobody's victim.

He is so completely at one with what happens that what happens has no power over him anymore. His words to the grandparents of the child upon taking the baby from him was: "Is that so? It's good to hear this baby has his/her father." The moral of the story is simple: Things (or shit) happen -- and these are events and can only be "eventful" and not personalized -- but it's entirely your choice to choose to or not to respond to them.

You can dignify these events or, much simpler and therefore simply, see them as events that you have no role in being involved.

When you hear someone's honking a horn behind your moving car, as a signal of anger or whatever over your slow driving, you can also choose to hear them as the sound of a vehicle's horn, and adjust your speed accordingly so that your fellow driver could feel more at ease (with the potential but completely unnecessary road rage) or move to a slower lane (left or right side, depending on which side of the road that you are driving). Problem's solved.

Or, you can participate in this "eventful drama" by getting angry, upset, and disappointed by the impatience of your fellow driver. You might even stop the car and get down from your vehicle and have a verbal or fist fight with your fellow driver -- over a small event that doesn't have to be this caustic. You may even be able to bet that your fellow driver might not even think of it as caustic as you think. It's just noise for you him, but a "personalizable eventfulness" for you.

How fair is that to you, your mind, and your mental health? The lesson that Hakuin wants to teach us is simple: You don't have to "participate in human drama," no matter how much those who seem to associate you with such drama call for your involvement. In this story, instead of participating in the whole messiness that he was not even involved in, Hakuin has decided to give every one some time to see the situation in its clearest light.

He understood that such drama had already involved a large number of people, and in a situation like this, it would be difficult for him to try to come up with anything to exonerate himself from an already formed public opinion about him.

Like Seneca, the father of the stoic philosopher (about whom I wrote extensively in the Anti-Fragile Manifesto post, he simply used the time afforded to him (by not having anyone's visiting him) to write, think, and ponder over the knowledge and idea that he would like to finally form as the basis of what's later known as Stoicism. Seneca used his time wisely and that's why we today get to inherit his wisdoms.

Instead of spending time defending himself by the crime that he did not commit, he let the nature of time take its course, waited patiently, and spent every minute of his time making the world a better place through his influential writings, which, of course, only got widely read again after the daughter confessed that the real father was a young man in the village whom and not Hakuin.

Exactly, Hakuin did what he had to do: There's a baby who needed to be supported, and he could support the child with his modest lifestyle; so, he did not hesitate to take the action to take care of the child while the problem was getting solved. He's the highest of the highest mind. "Is that so?" is a generic yet powerful response to any events. It's only your job to acknowledge them. The choice to get involved, however, is entirely yours. So, don't.

For that to take place, he gave everyone "time" to let the unscripted event naturally unfold. Meanwhile, taking the task at hand as a gift from afforded by the opportunity to have the time to engage in different activities, he engagingly learned how to take care of a new life, feed this baby, and provide this toddler with the warm and peaceful home. Essentially, Hakuin was waiting for the baby's biological family to, through time, realize how much this baby meant to its family.

Hakuin did what he could to give the precious time to the baby's family, while maintaining his love for the baby with the "approximate" distance so that he would not feel so sad once the baby was to be taken away from him. This was one of the stories that has, for some time now, gotten me thinking about how we human beings might be able to re-think how we deal with an event in life.

The reason for why event and incident like this is difficult to come to a conclusion quickly is explained by the design guru Don Norman. In his thinking about the "hindsight bias," he explains: This is why the best accident analyses can take a long time to do. The investigators have to imagine themselves in the shoes of the people who were involved and consider all the information, all the training, and what the history of similar past events would have taught the operators.

In his study of aviation catastrophes, he argues that "Hindsight makes events seem obvious and predictable." This notion of "hindsight bias" is accepted within the community of psychologists, risk management experts, managers, and beyond. It's true that we tend to overestimate our ability to plan (AKA "planning fallacy") and also underestimate our own tendency to try to work things backward to find a true series of causes that you could have prevented. In reality, there's no way no one could have done that.

As explained in *The Black Swan: The Impact of the Highly Improbable* by Nassim Nicholas Taleb, these "black swan" events are improbable, unpredictable, and often yield massive impact. With all the information that one could potentially acquire before it takes place, there is no way anyone could have predicted it, so the "hindsight bias" only add to the frustration, and sometimes used as a tool for witch-hunting.

Don Norman continues: So, the next time a major accident occurs, ignore the initial reports from journalists, politicians, and executives who don't have any substantive information but feel compelled to provide statements anyway. Wait until the official reports come from trusted sources. Unfortunately, this could be months or years after the accident, and the public usually wants answers immediately, even if those answers are wrong. Moreover, when the

full story finally appears, newspapers will no longer consider it news, so they won't report it. Is that so.

Hakunin is a Zen monk. Zen (or Chan in Chinese), needless to say, is one of the two branches of Buddhism (the other is Theravada Buddhism which is practiced in Sri Lanka and Thailand). In Buddhism, there is a similar way to thinking and dealing with events: In *Sapiens: A Brief History of Humankind* by the historian Yuval Noah Harari, the author writes that Buddhist philosophy of "contentment" (not happiness) centers around the idea that you are not the events that happen to you.

What is the case is that you are also not the feelings you have. They are just feelings that naturally appear and disappear owing to their factors and causes -- these feelings are not to be confused with you. Thus, if you understand this, you can let yourself free from tying yourself to a event, and then keep chasing the need to feel good by making yourself "feel good" even though the feeling you have has nothing to do with you.

Those feelings are attached to the events, not to you. In understanding yourself this way, you can be content with your existence, focus on the task at hand, and free yourself from the inclination to dramatize ordinary events. Now, what do you do when you're in a difficult situation whereby you can't seem to hold yourself against the tide of an attack, event, or public opinion against you.

As you have learned from both Seneca and Hakuin, what's to be done is also very simple: Find your place in the "flow." Let me expand on that further here: "Flow" is a concept coined by the psychologist Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi. I first encountered this term from one of the TED talk videos I watched a few months ago with my mother. The concept appeared again upon my reading of Daniel Pink's *Drive: The Surprising Truth About What Motivates Us* (one of the 44 books that changed my life this year).

Before getting to understand what this state of flow is, I find another concept of "peak performance" by another psychologist Abraham Maslow to be quite

similar. Maslow describes it as: https://www.ted.com/talks/mihaly_csikszentmihalyi_on_flow?language=en Peak experiences as rare, exciting, oceanic, deeply moving, exhilarating, elevating experiences that generate an advanced form of perceiving reality, and are even mystic and magical in their effect upon the experimenter. It does sound quite awesome, doesn't it? How exactly do we get to that kind of state? Let's return to what Csikszentmihalyi means by flow.

It's the state of in which we realize that "the best moments in our lives are not the passive, receptive, relaxing times; instead, the best moments usually occur if a person's body or mind is stretched to its limits in a voluntary effort to accomplish something difficult and worthwhile." When you're "in the flow," you are so deeply engaged with a certain task at hand, to the point that you mind can no longer wonder elsewhere.

Such task, because it's not too easy for you to completely relax and too hard for you to have to think hard all the time about how to achieve it, you're engaging in what is "difficult yet worthwhile." That's when you're "in the flow." Seemingly important is this very concept of flow in the interactive design with everyday's tasks and objects.

The author of *The Design of Everyday Things* Don Norman writes: Csikszentmihalyi has long studied how people interact with their work and play, and how their lives reflect this intermix of activities. When in the "flow state," people lose track of time and the outside environment. They are at one with the task they are performing. The task, moreover, is at just the proper level of difficulty: difficult enough to provide a challenge and require continued attention, but not so difficult that it invokes frustration and anxiety.

When in the state of flow, you will feel as though you are losing track of time -- as well as the outside environment. You are becoming one with the task that you are performing. I often get into the state of flow when I do what I like. And luckily these activities that I like are parts of my daily work.

So, personally, I get in the "flow" when I do the following: When I am on my bike, riding with a great podcast or audible at about 30 kms/hour; When I write something that I do not know how and where it's going to end (such as this blog post); When I get to talk, teach, conduct a seminar among people who are engaged in the similar interest and topic -- all my previous students know that my class/lecture can go on forever if I don't get stopped.

What these three things have in common is that these are things that, as Norman writes, "are at just the proper level of difficulty: difficult enough to provide a challenge and require continued attention, but not so difficult that it invokes frustration and anxiety." When I bike, write, or teach, I do not have a perfect goal that I want to achieve.

I know that these tasks won't be easy, but I know that I can perform it by keeping myself from any forms of distraction, and focusing on excelling my ability to be effective toward the task and the audience (i.e., students). These things get me into the flow, and keep me sane both when a pleasant as well as an unserendipitous event. In fact, as in the words of Hakuin, there's no bad (unserendipitous) or good (pleasant) event. Events are just events.

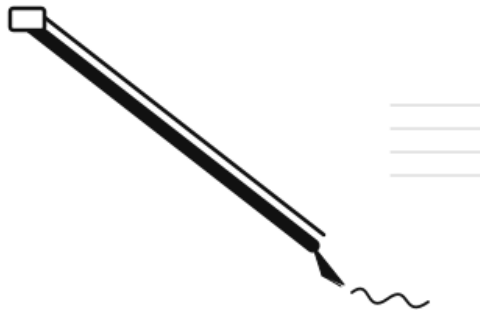
We human beings don't always deal with them appropriately, causing so many problems that sometimes a simple notion of time (to gather more information) and the tool of empathy ("imagine themselves in the shoes of the people who were involved and consider all the information," writes Norman) can simply do the trick. So, be like Seneca, and be like Hakuin -- when shit happens, think of them as events that need not be personalized by you.

Find activities that put you in the "flow" state -- by doing so, you won't be waiting for anything, you'd just be in the contentment.

DAY 102

Some Podcasts I Simply Can't Recommend Enough

Sun, 05 Oct 2025 00:00:00 +0000



I HAVE RECEIVED SOME WONDERFUL words of gratitude and thoughtful feedback on the 100th post (on the 44 books that changed my life). So, in this post, I want to turn the spot light to some of the podcasts that have the same impact on my life. As I mentioned in my last post, I easily get in the "state of flow" -- a mental state of complete absorption in the current experience -- when I engage in my beloved activities such as cycling, writing, teaching, and writing.

What am I reading right now? Here you are: [gallery ids="4941,4942,4943,4944,4945" type="rectangular"] I love to move between books -- both to avoid boredom and over-immersion into just one single topic. Over immersion in just one topic creates, what the psychologist Daniel Kahneman calls, "focusing illusion," making you feel as though whatever you are immersing in is more important than other, and worst, the most important thing ever. "Nothing in life is as important as you think it is, while you're thinking about it," said Kahneman.

This is the reason why most professionals will want to solve problem their ways. It's not because they do not have the knowledge beyond their

immediate fields, it's because they're too focused on the "illusion of importance" in which they're immersing themselves. Maybe you have heard the saying that "If the only tool you have is a hammer, every problem will be a nail." That's the core of focusing illusion. So, snap out of it.

So, at any point in time, I would have 4-5 books on my desk, all with bookmarks, ready to be read inconsequentially. I know, it's not the most efficient way to read but it works for me. I do enjoy switching between subjects and connect dots presented in both key and minor ideas among them.

So, here's the answer to one of the questions from a reader: "How can you bring in so many ideas to discuss a single subjects?" The answer: I read a lot of books at the same time and the lines connecting those dots are very obvious. Knowledge is knowledge, it doesn't matter what the field is. I don't think it's a special power to see the connections. You just have to let your mind travel into different realms and keep it, completely completely, open.

Oh, I forgot to mention that usually accompanying in those process (with an exception of writing as I need to primarily hear my own voice in my head) is the act of listening to a constructive podcast. My cycling duration, for instance, could easily be from an hour (30 kilometers) to about two hours (60 kilometers) -- both of which are great for one or two concise podcasts that end with me once I step off the pedals.

I also listen to podcasts when I walk to work, drive a car, take a bus or a metro, make coffee, work out in a gym, etc. These are activities that can take place simultaneously with careful listening. To make sure that I don't just have a lot of "lost time" during those activities, I never allow my ears to stay quiet. In other words, whereas others listen to music, I listen to podcasts. Here you are: The Top Three.

These are some of the best podcasts that I have on my smartphone, which I also listen to regularly and obsessively. I'll provide a short impression of how I think about them, like them, and love to never have to stop listening to

them. Let's begin with Freakonomics Radio. For those who are already a big fan of the book *Freakonomics*, you'll enjoy this podcast even more. The host Stephen J. Dubner calls it "A podcast that explores the hidden side of everything" -- and that's basically what it is.

It's not a typical economics podcast. In fact, from the beginning, the idea of the podcast is to pitch economics against "humans." You think you're rational? Think again! We can only wish that we are rational as we think we are. Dubner is a great host because he's funny, quick, and extremely resourceful.

He has not only written a wonderful book on the subject with the University of Chicago economist Steve Levitt, but also interviewed many great minds, athletes, experts, and people from all walks of life, from whom he conveniently draws thoughtful ideas to help explain the hidden side of everything. You'll find Dubner extremely entertaining to listen to (in fact, I think I have begun to talk like him lately). You'll hear about American football and soccer, animals, CEOs, game theory, Trader Joe's, behavioralism, etc.

The topics are simply endless and the fun part is that you usually never know what's coming in the next episode. *Freakonomics Radio* is my number one on the list (so is its theme song, which I usually can't wait to hear each week). Topics are wide ranging and you can listen to all previous episodes. I really recommend listening to all of them -- one by one and carefully. They're all witty, informative, and wonderful. *The Hidden Brain* from NPR is the second on my list.

Like *Freakonomics Radio*, *The Hidden Brain* explores the hidden side of how our mind works. The host Shankar Vedantam (who also has a great deep yet soft voice!) explains the podcast as "using science and storytelling to reveal the unconscious patterns that drive human behavior, shape our choices and direct our relationships." So, yes, it's a podcast about how so many things can be alternatively understood, revealed, and learned through the art and science of psychology.

Often, Vedantam presents us with an ordinary situation, after which he proceeds to tell us how "unordinary" they are and then why it is that our minds fail to produce a logical understanding of such situation. Wow, right? Some of you may know that, for the past year, I have been in love with the field of psychology.

Partly, it's due to my love for this podcast that provides me so much insights on we do things the way we do (especially when it's so obvious that there's a better, more rational, more productive way of doing it). Topics are also as wide-ranging as the Freakonomics Radio and sometimes the radio replays give us a glimpse of what we might have already forgotten. Philosophize This is number three.

I first encountered this podcast while searching for materials to teach my students in pretty much an introductory course in philosophy and intellectual history that I taught at NYU Shanghai. I came across this podcast because, at the time, it was one of the very few that were about philosophy -- in a non-boring way.

At that time, I was also subscribed to Philosophy Bites by David Edmund and Nigel Warburton (whose book on basic philosophy is a gem of a book that I highly recommend to everyone regardless of his/her interest in the subject). Apparently, the deep-sounded host Stephen West isn't a 60-year-old philosophy professor who knows so much about the subject as he sounds in his podcast, but a 28-year-old podcaster from Seattle who is deeply interested in exploring different facets of philosophy.

"I got into podcasting because I wanted to help bring to others what philosophy has done for my well-being. Not a day goes by where I'm not thankful for what the listeners of the show have made possible for me," says Stephen West. He can do so very well, I presume, thanks to his wide-ranging reading of both original and interpretative texts; his energy, wit and sense of humor; and his key skill as a great great great great storyteller.

I was hooked from the first episode that I listened to in 2014 and ever since it's been a joy to wait for a new episode of Philosophize This. I highly recommend. This is the podcast that makes ideas come to life, and make seemingly irrelevant doctrines extremely useful to how we might want to choose, re-think and re-examine our life. Alright, there you have it, the top three. Here're the other eight podcasts that I also listen to.

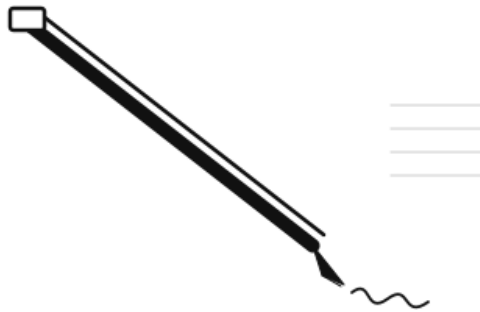
Yes, I spend about 10 hours a week just listening to podcasts, which is to be added to another 20 hours per week of reading books and listening to audiobooks. Yeah, I don't have a life that much (lol). I especially like Malcolm Gladwell's Revisionist History podcast. I alluded to my love for Gladwell's writings in many of my previous posts. His voice is also great too!

I really think the production is amazing and the stories he told (I recommend the one of the song Elvis couldn't sing as a starter) are simply simply awesome. The only reason why it isn't on the top three is because it's done season by season, and each season only has a few episodes. For instance, Season Three ended a while ago and nothing have been broadcast ever since. How long do you want me to work, Malcolm??

I have also grown to like Adam Grant's work on organizational psychology a lot too (his latest book *Originals* is awesome). Anyway, take a look at the list below and let me know what you think after you have tried them all. I'd be delighted to know whether you think my taste in an attempt to "learn more while moving" and "prevent too much lost time" is sound. Thank you and good night. [gallery ids="4948,4949,4950,4951,4952,4953,4954,4955" type="rectangular"]

DAY 103

On Insecurity (and How to Get Rid of It)

Mon, 06 Oct 2025 00:00:00 +0000

HAPPY NEW YEAR! WELL, IT'S another first of January -- the new year. We should all think about what we'd like to do this year, what changes we would like to make, and whatever goals we would like to achieve. All of this makes perfect sense. That said, I have been struggling to come up with a "new year resolution." What do I want to do this year?

Upon reading *Sapiens: A Brief History of Humankind* Book by Yuval Noah Harari, I have been thinking about one very important question: What makes strangers, who don't know each other at all, hate each other? This is a huge question.

Think about it: So many people fight in a war with some total strangers, sometimes to death, whom they have never met before; so many people feel the urge of hating someone they read about in the news even though they have never met or known that someone (in person or not) at all; so many people are being completely absorbed in the business of going as far as to condemn others without even knowing some basic information about the condemned. Why?

Let me start with putting this question toward myself? Have I ever hated anyone I have never met? The answer is yes and no. Who's the most hated person in the history? How about Adolf Hitler? Do I know him? No. Do I even speak the same language he does? No. Do I know anything at all about him besides those written about him that I had read 4 decades after he died? No. Of course I do not like Adolf Hitler for an obvious reason.

But before I rest my feeling of disgust on the kind of person he was, I read up on his numerous biographies, watch documentaries about him, and try to understand why he had become who he eventually was -- "the face of evil," many may call him. That's, of course, an extreme example. What about those whom I have heard the names of but do not know in person, say, rapists, murderers, malign political lobbyists?

Two posts ago, I mentioned to you about how I don't read news, so, in a way, I can't really hate anyone on the basis of hearing anything about them through news. So, at the level of information acquisition itself, I probably wouldn't have any information at all to judge anyone. Yet, even though I have heard about them through news, I would probably think that whatever it is, "experts" should be brought into the picture to investigate the accusations.

There're countless times where innocent people get put in jail for crimes they did not do. There are "public opinion" or the opinion of those who would like to feel emotionally attached and be swayed by sensational news, and the "truth" which is what really happened. If you ask most people, they'd say that they believe in "truth" and not "public opinion," but what exactly makes them feel as though their notion of "truth" is not being clouded by what they heard from the news around them?

Many of us both conflate and confuse the two: "public opinion" and "truth." There's an old saying, "There would be no fire, if there's no smoke," meaning that rumors can't just come out of nowhere. There has to be a source of it otherwise it would not have been discussed, spread, and become news. That's the "smoke and fire" theory of news. A pretty convincing argument?

In the society today where we all have to find the way to survive, we need to take clues from whatever sources we can to stay afloat. If the news says "Mr. A is bad," it makes sense for most people to try to dissociate themselves from Mr. A, not hanging out with Mr. A, or even downright and publicly condemn Mr. A. Why? I asked one of my friends who did this in the past -- and now regretted it. "I am scared," said he.

What he meant was that he's scared to be associated with someone with a bad reputation. I continued to press on with a question "why?" I am afraid because I am nobody. If I am somebody, I wouldn't be afraid. I still need a job, a career, etc., so it's important that I do whatever the public eyes believe to be the most appropriate thing to do. Ok. So, it's the insecurity.

If you're not secure about your job, your life, your position in the society and elsewhere, of course you would not want anyone to see your being associated with bad things. But even if you tend to know that in your encounter with Mr. A, he is never like that?; or, that you have not given Mr. A the due process? Insecurity, therefore, is not just a trivial, but a key problem. Why do people feel insecure? Well, the answer to this question would probably need another long post.

All I can think of right now, according to my own past experience, is that: I feel personally insecure when I: Need something from someone. When you need something from someone, it's natural that you can't afford to be secure because you are relying on that someone to provide you what you need; Don't have the evidence to support any of my thoughts, arguments, or claims.

In fact, the main source of my insecurity comes when I try to argue something that I do not have any evidence to support it. Can there be anything that could make one feel more insecure than this?; and, When I am not being honest. You never feel safe when you have something to hide. Yes, when you're not honest, you don't have any ground on which to stand; therefore, you're not secured as a person, as a being. So, my advice is: Be secure.

You are who you are: Don't be dishonest. Don't claim that you don't what you don't know. And don't accuse other people for your own advantage. It's easy to ride on a high tide in order to be famous and "safe," but every time you're doing it you should always remind yourself that you are walking on thin ice -- or be in a situation in which you are likely to upset someone because of your insecurity or cause trouble because of your dishonesty.

Just be honest -- then you'll have no reason to feel insecure. Now, having read *A Brief History of Humankind* Book by Yuval Noah Harari, I have come to realize why someone can actually hate a stranger whom that someone has never met for various reasons. Here are some of them: Ideology and religiosity: Liberal versus conservative, left versus right, capitalism versus socialism. I find that this is the most convenient reason for two people who don't know each other to be disgusted by each other.

Nationalism (which is, in essence, an ideology) is a reason why so many people volunteer to go to wars against fellow human beings. The reason for which could simply about the fact that they are from a "different nation" or a rooted belief that their ideology and religiosity makes them less human beings than you are; Implicit bias -- also known as implicit social cognition, implicit bias refers to the attitudes or stereotypes that affect our understanding, actions, and decisions in an unconscious manner; and, Jealousy.

I want to focus on the last reason: Jealousy. The historian and best-selling author Yuval Noah Harari would argue that jealousy is rooted in our evolution. Jealousy makes you aware of those who have better genes, better living condition, and therefore better chances of survival. We, therefore, feel jealous because we too either would like to survive, or be the person chosen by those with better chance of survival, so that we will get pulled up the ladder of evolution. What happens what you're not chosen?

You bet, you get jealous. It's a primitive psychological defense so that one could still feel as though one is not completely worthless -- it's just because that person who's more superior just isn't all the great. In a way, we're

evolved to see others, even those in the same homo sapiens species, as competitors.

In the author Robert Wright's gem of a book *Why Buddhism is True*, the author quotes the psychologists Tooby and Cosmides' idea about jealousy, using an example of the most palpable form of jealousy there is -- sexual: The emotion of sexual jealousy constitutes an organized mode of operation specifically designed to deploy the programs governing each psychological mechanism so that each is poised to deal with the exposed infidelity. Physiological processes are prepared for such things as violence.

The goal of deterring, injuring, or murdering the rival emerges; the goal of punishing, deterring, or deserting the mate appears; the desire to make oneself more competitively attractive to alternative mates emerges; memory is activated to re- analyze the past; confident assessments of the past are transformed into doubts; the general estimate of the reliability and trustworthiness of the opposite sex (or indeed everyone) may decline; associated shame programs may be triggered to search for situations in which the individual can publicly demonstrate acts of violence or punishment that work to counteract an (imagined or real) social perception of weakness; and so on.

Now, back to the present time. I find that many of us hate people whom we don't know personally because we're jealous of them. Accept it, it's true. They have what you don't have, they embody the life of those you wish to be yours, and they appear to make things you find so difficult extremely easy. When I was younger, I used to have this feeling -- all the time. I hated those who studied better than I did. I hated those who're better basketball players.

I hated those who seemed to get everything done soooooo easily. What wasn't I that person? I remember that I disliked Hillary Clinton so much during the election in 2016. This was before I stopped consuming news completely. It's because I was vouching for Bernie Sanders. Scrutinizing my own thoughts, I couldn't find anything about Hillary Clinton that was so bad. True, she might be doing sketchy things like a private server or her emails, but what do I

really know about the impact of that?

I got completely observed in the news and discussions against her to the point that I, who did not (and still do not) know Clinton, felt as though I could never have dinner on the same table with her. Looking back, I feel nothing but shame. But hey, to be a Hillary-hater was pretty cool then. If you didn't like her, you're presenting yourself as a liberal non-conformist who said "enough is enough." So, I was riding that tide for my very own benefit.

I wanted to be known as a liberal non-conformist. It's the different ideology, implicit bias, and probably jealousy (that I wasn't as successful as she was) that drove me into entering the anti-Clinton troops. I was so immature...What's the point of judging someone whom you don't even know based on news about them? What if someone write something bad about you, would you be okay for people to hate you -- without even knowing you -- based on those news?

It took me to get to know that person I thought I hated, for me to realize that, "Wait, why did I hate this person before?" That's a revelation for me. Jealously isn't a fact. It's a subjective preconception of someone and something based on my own insecurity (ta-da!).

I feel jealous of my little cousin because "she's so young and energetic." I feel jealous of my not-so-young male cousin because "he's so young, muscular, and good looking (he does look like a famous Thai actor)." And I feel jealous of my mother sometimes because "she knows everything about finance (since she's a banker for 30 years). Now, why do I feel jealous? Because I don't have what they have. It's as simple as that, but these are people that I personally know: My cousins and my mother.

What about those whom I don't know? Well, I have to admit that I don't feel jealous of anyone or anything, as of this very point in time. It's for the same reason, but in reverse, to the reasons why I am jealous of my cousins and my mother: I don't think I lack anything that anyone else have. I have a good (great actually) health at this point in time (and knock on wood).

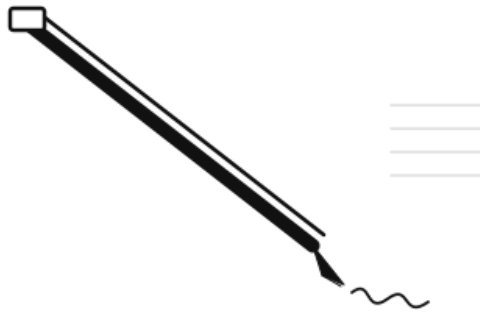
I get to read, think, and write every day (what else can one ask for, right?) I get to meet those whom I care about whenever I want. My life is not perfect. I am not rich. But it's fulfilled, so I don't feel the urge to exercise my sense of jealousy beyond my cousins and my mother. In other words, I feel secured.

So, yes, I think we human beings are naturally insecure, so do whatever we can to survive, including "trying to eliminate those who are above you (and therefore the source of jealousy)." That said, this is not the world I would like to live in, or would like those whom I love to grow up in.

DAY 103

On Design Culture Part 1 (of Many More Parts to Come)

Tue, 07 Oct 2025 00:00:00 +0000



WHAT'S DESIGN? MANY PEOPLE HAVE asked me this question, and it's not easy at all to actually come up with just one absolute and definite answer. In fact, as I am going to be teaching a course with a title roughly translated as "design culture," it might be a good idea for me to try to answer this question in a series of post: Something that I can also utilize as an outline for each of my lecture (clever, right?).

Well, you know I always believe that writing is a great great tool to facilitate just about everything. We think in language, so therefore writing is the act of putting words into strings that help you make sense of the chaotic thoughts floating, running, and moving in the mind. Now, first thing first, I'll leave the answer to the question above for letter. I think the first thing to discuss here is the meaning of the word we usually hear but don't usually define.

That word is "creativity." The origin of this word is credited to the philosopher Alfred North Whitehead (1861-1947, who is also credited for saying "All (Western) philosophy consists of a series of footnotes to Plato."). To Whitehead, creativity simply means the act of "self-creation and self-determination." He's talking, of course, about metaphysics, an we are

unlikely to get into Western philosophy in this post. Creativity: This very term that Whitehead had coined, however, has had a great impact on how we think about design.

Last time I checked, there're more than a hundred books with the title "creativity" in their titles in circulation as we speak. Upon browsing them, I didn't find any special meanings of creativity. It's all the same old same old "the art of innovation," "newness that works," "a quality of a genius." None of these definitions helps anyone to understand. In fact, the notion that creativity is "a quality of a genius" is just discriminatingly misleading (for the reason that this blog will outline).

Many actually believe, in essence, that "design is a product of creativity," but what exactly is creativity. If the term entails the notion of "creation," then, aren't we all creative by default since in order to survive we'd need to constantly "create" (e.g., income, opportunity, etc)?

Let start with a great example of what the thinker Kevin Ashton, a British technology pioneer who after having immigrated to the US co-founded the Auto-ID Center at the Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT) and a theorist who also coined today's widely popular term "the internet of things," calls the "myth of creativity." This excerpt is from his book *How to Fly a Horse: The Secret History of Creation, Invention, and Discovery* (which is one of the 44 books that changed my life): In 1815, Germany's General Music Journal published a letter in which Mozart described his creative process: When I am, as it were, completely myself, entirely alone, and of good cheer; say traveling in a carriage, or walking after a good meal, or during the night when I cannot sleep; it is on such occasions that my ideas flow best and most abundantly.

All this fires my soul, and provided I am not disturbed, my subject enlarges itself, becomes methodized and defined, and the whole, though it be long, stands almost finished and complete in my mind, so that I can survey it, like a fine picture or a beautiful statue, at a glance. Nor do I hear in my imagination the parts successively, but I hear them, as it were, all at once.

When I proceed to write down my ideas the committing to paper is done quickly enough, for everything is, as I said before, already finished; and it rarely differs on paper from what it was in my imagination. In other words, Mozart's greatest symphonies, concertos, and operas came to him complete when he was alone and in a good mood. He needed no tools to compose them. Once he had finished imagining his masterpieces, all he had to do was write them down. This is a typical "genius" story.

We all know how great Mozart was as a composer, but let's continue reading: But there is a problem. Mozart did not write this letter. It is a forgery. This was first shown in 1856 by Mozart's biographer Otto Jahn and has been confirmed by other scholars since. This is true.

Historians have provided evidence of how Mozart had become who he was -- "a great composer" -- not by his "ingenuity," "prodigy" or "inborn quality" just but by his willpower to work hard, long hour, and ability to go back to the drawing board (or music score) to revise, rewrite, and rethink his creative work. Ashton continues: Mozart's real letters— to his father, to his sister, and to others—reveal his true creative process. He was exceptionally talented, but he did not write by magic.

He sketched his compositions, revised them, and sometimes got stuck. He could not work without a piano or harpsichord. He would set work aside and return to it later. He considered theory and craft while writing, and he thought a lot about rhythm, melody, and harmony. Even though his talent and a lifetime of practice made him fast and fluent, his work was exactly that: work.

Masterpieces did not come to him complete in uninterrupted streams of imagination, nor without an instrument, nor did he write them down whole and unchanged. The letter is not only forged, it is false." In fact, historians argued that it might have taken him almost two decades to cultivate his greatness -- about 10,000 hours of practicing arguing the author Malcolm Gladwell. Here is what he explains in his masterpiece *Outliers: The Story of Success*: This is true even of people we think of as prodigies.

Mozart, for example, famously started writing music at six. But, writes the psychologist Michael Howe in his book *Genius Explained*, "...by the standards of mature composers, Mozart's early works are not outstanding. The earliest pieces were all probably written down by his father, and perhaps improved in the process. Many of Mozart's childhood compositions, such as the first seven of his concertos for piano and orchestra, are largely arrangements of works by other composers.

Of those concertos that only contain music original to Mozart, the earliest that is now regarded as a masterwork (No. 9, K. 271) was not composed until he was twenty-one: by that time Mozart had already been composing concertos for ten years." The music critic Harold Schonberg goes further: Mozart, he argues, actually "developed late," since he didn't produce his greatest work until he had been composing for more than twenty years. To become a chess grandmaster also seems to take about ten years.

(Only the legendary Bobby Fischer got to that elite level in less than that amount of time: it took him nine years.) And what's ten years? Well, it's roughly how long it takes to put in ten thousand hours of hard practice.

Ten thousand hours is the magic number of greatness." So, what's creative about Mozart's music was a result of his ability to oscillate between "what's been composed and what can be composed." In *Solving Problems with Design Thinking Ten Stories of What Works* by Jeanne Liedtka, Andrew King, and Kevin Bennett, this process, similar to that of Mozart's, can be summarized in the act of carefully answering four questions: What Is? What If? What Wow? and What Works?

And I don't think this comment would make Mozart any less great than he was. His music is timeless, inspiring, and sophisticated -- it's the work of art. But what this comment does is that it "humanizes the notion of creativity" and shines a different light on Mozart as a human being -- just like you and me. I think we should all be happy to hear that instead of thinking less of Mozart as a great composer. He still was, and his music will always be great.

It turns out that everyone whom we admire has to go through a similar process of being tested. Excellent soccer players, musicians, artists aren't born with those skills. So, where does the urge of wanting to see Mozart, and David Beckham, the Beatles, Picasso, etc., as inborn geniuses? Kevin Ashton again: "The myth of creativity" lives on because it appeals to romantic prejudices about invention. There is a myth about how something new comes to be. Geniuses have dramatic moments of insight where great things and thoughts are born whole.

Poems are written in dreams. Symphonies are composed complete. Science is accomplished with eureka shrieks. Businesses are built by magic touch. Something is not, then is. We do not see the road from nothing to new, and maybe we do not want to. Artistry must be misty magic, not sweat and grind.

It dulls the luster to think that every elegant equation, beautiful painting, and brilliant machine is born of effort and error, the progeny of false starts and failures, and that each maker is as flawed, small, and mortal as the rest of us. It is "seductive" to conclude that great innovation is delivered to us by miracle via genius. And so the myth.

Psychologists and biological anthropologist argue that the size and shape of our brains haven't change so much for at least 15,000 years; therefore, there's nothing innate in the brains that think "a stone tool is enough" and "we need something better than a stone tool." What changed, however, was the ability to elevate our cognitive ability to better solve problems and issues of everyday life. A quote from Kevin Ashton: "This is one reason the creativity myth is so terribly wrong. Creating is not rare.

We are all born to do it. If it seems magical, it is because it is innate. If it seems like some of us are better at it than others, that is because it is part of being human, like talking or walking. We are not all equally creative, just as we are not all equally gifted orators or athletes.

But we can all create." The education expert Sir Ken Robinson (whose TED Talk on the subject is pretty pretty awesomest if you haven't seen it yet)

argues that we're all born creative which, from an evolutionary perspective, is the innate quality with which we are all born. In essence, it's the quality that allows us to live, communicate, reproduce, revolutionize and move through time.

For Robinson, we have become less creative owing to the process of standardization of education, which focuses on giving people, well, the standardizable skill. So, the lessons are simple: First, the idea that "you have to be born creative to be creative is a myth (AKA "creativity myth"); so, let's undo that idea, once and for all, completely. It's nonsense, not true, and not useful at all; Second, to be excellent/good/great at something, one has to work for it.

Some says it takes about 10,000 or 10 years straight to be an expert on something. It's true. Our brain needs that much practice, trial and error, tactile learning, to be able to comprehend the variety of experience. If what we think as creative is something "new and useful," what this means is that it takes that much time for the brain and our body to be comprehend the basics and therefore generate such novelty that works. So, be patient.

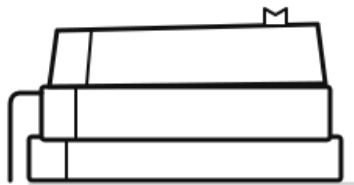
Third, creativity is a process, and not innate quality (which goes back to the first point), which means that it's something that everyone, including you and me, could cultivate; and, Fourth, the notion of creativity is built inside all of us (AKA "innate"). The society puts things in hierarchy. Would you say that David Beckham is more talented than Mozart? It would be like comparing an apple to an orange.

Just because someone sees Mozart's music as more important than the art of wiping the floor clean (which I am by the way very good at because I have a very creative way of going about doing it -- I am proud of it, hey) doesn't mean that wiping the floor cannot be creative.

DAY 104

Why We Should "Stop Trying" instead of "Trying Our Best"

Wed, 08 Oct 2025 00:00:00 +0000



DEMANDING NOTHING IN RETURN FOR his kindness, the sage eventually obtains everything; The sage does not accumulate things, Yet the more he gives to others, the more he has himself. Having given to others, he is richer still. Laozi from Dao De Jing Why haven't I read this sooner. The quote above is from the University of British Columbia (UBC) Professor Edward Slingerland's Trying Not to Try: The Art and Science of Spontaneity.

As the title of this post suggests, it is one of the best books about the psychology of the mind I have read. Slingerland is also Professor of Asian Studies and Canada Research Chair in Chinese Thought and Embodied Cognition at UBC. As his academic title suggests, he is a world renowned expert on the relations between ancient Eastern thoughts and modern cognitive science. The quote above is from Laozi (or Lao-tzu, who lived approx. 6th century B.C.E.).

He's the master of Daoism who, as the legend goes, left us with just one Chinese text where the quote above appeared, better known in the West as the Dao De Jing (some translated as "the way of life").

In fact, I came across his online course Chinese Thought: Ancient Wisdom Meets Modern Science before on the EdX platform when I was teaching an introductory course in philosophy a few years back, but I didn't seriously follow up on it (the course, by the way, is still free, and is great, so I highly recommend to everyone). Why is Trying Not to Try and his work so great?

Because it tells us not only why the ancient wisdom of "trying not to try" is right and that the modern idea of "trying your best" is wrong, and how we might make use of the ancient wisdom to make our life today more fulfilling -- but through the lenses of modern science. So, even those who may not have the stomach to swallow "ancient Chinese thoughts," this book can show you through modern scientific ideas how we can practically improve our well-being.

Actually, I wasn't planning on reading this book at all. I stumbled upon Trying Not to Try while searching for books to read as I was preparing to get on a 14-hour-long cross-country train to travel to work. I didn't realize that this book had been in my wish list for years, until an automatic message from Amazon.com app reminded me that this book was on sale. I "didn't try hard" to find a book to read, so I came across this book.

Had I "tried harder," I would have read multiple reviews of multiple books, by multiple authors, and then evaluated which book to buy based on those reviews once they're mentally tabulated in my mind for a proper cost-benefit analysis.

I probably ended up with a different book if I "had tried to hard." So, because I didn't try to hard, I thought I could "give Trying Not to Try a try." Trying Not to Try has confirmed a lot of things I have always firmly believed about how a life should be lived. And yes, I am aware of the so-called "confirmation bias." Just because a book confirms my preconception about something doesn't (and definitely shouldn't) automatically render it right, right away.

I read Trying Not to Try twice during my 14-hour-long journey (yep, it's a really long train ride) to make sure that what I agreed with about the idea of

"trying not to try" is the best way of achieving just about anything is not just a confirmation bias. For instance, the idea that the best action is, surprising to many, a "non-action." The more we try to do things, the more we usually end up leaving things undone.

We are living in the world in which most of us are encouraged to "be better than others," "do more than others," "get ahead of others." The logic behind this? Simple. The idea of "better" is relative, the underlying reason for all of these is to be "better," which, in essence, is all about comparing yourself to others by ways of the result. When we want to be better, we automatically (and unconsciously) shift our focus from the task at hand to our expectation.

And as modern psychology (as well as behavioral economics) shows, when the task at hand is not received enough attention from us, it often results, ultimately, in failure – sometimes not only that task at hand, but also other related tasks as well.

Professor Slingerland uses many examples such as basketball players and golfers who were "in the zone" – playing their best games naturally – only until someone reminded them that they should "try to keep up with their game." That's when the "hot hand" was forced to make error. These players started to make mistakes, mostly unforced (known as "choking") leading not only to the bad result but also the end of the focus on the task. So, why is "trying" so harmful to what we want to do?

Why shouldn't we be trying? And, ultimately, what exactly is to "try not to try?" I have been thinking about the question ever since I learned from the author (and a modern Daoist philosopher) Mark Manson's best-selling *The Subtle Art of Not Giving a F*ck* that on the tombstone of the legendary writer and poet Charles Bukowski writes "Don't Try." I wrote about this in my earlier blog post but I did not further explore what it actually means, perhaps because I did not know what it really meant.

Manson, using this same example, of the tombstone writes what he understands: Bukowski's life embodies [what seemingly sounds like] the

American Dream: a man fights for what he wants, never gives up, and eventually achieves his wildest dreams. It's practically a movie waiting to happen. We all look at stories like Bukowski's and say, "See? He never gave up. He never stopped trying. He always believed in himself."

He persisted against all the odds and made something of himself!" It is then strange that on Bukowski's tombstone, the epitaph reads: "Don't try." See, despite the book sales and the fame, Bukowski was a loser. He knew it. And his success stemmed not from some determination to be a winner, but from the fact that he knew he was a loser, accepted it, and then wrote honestly about it. He never tried to be anything other than what he was.

The genius in Bukowski's work was not in overcoming unbelievable odds or developing himself into a shining literary light. It was the opposite. It was his simple ability to be completely, unflinchingly honest with himself—especially the worst parts of himself—and to share his failings without hesitation or doubt. This is the real story of Bukowski's success: his comfort with himself as a failure. Bukowski didn't give a fuck about success. Even after his fame, he still showed up to poetry readings hammered and verbally abused people in his audience.

He still exposed himself in public and tried to sleep with every woman he could find. Fame and success didn't make him a better person. Nor was it by becoming a better person that he became famous and successful. Self-improvement and success often occur together. But that doesn't necessarily mean they're the same thing.

The story of Charles Bukowski is deeply interesting because it creates, almost instantly, the sense of "cognitive dissonance," or the state of having inconsistent thoughts, beliefs, or attitudes, especially as relating to behavioral decisions, in our mind. How can someone who simply did what he liked, and never tried harder, become more and more successful as he life progressed? Shouldn't it be the other way around, as in, we must strive harder and harder and perhaps never stop? What's the deal with his success?

Bukowski didn't give a fuck about success? Interesting. We might be able to understand why he became successful without even trying.

In fact, if we look at modern research from a psychological perspective, backed by scientific research, we humans are: At best at what we do when we are in the "flow" (some use the idiom "in the zone" which have a similar meaning; a psychological concept of deep engagement coined by): At best at what we do when we are not doing it for external rewards or results, but for our own need to fulfill our internal desire; in other words, we are at best at what we do when we, simply, enjoy doing it; At best at what we do when we do it with a clear, not clouded, mind.

Our mind can be clouded by all kinds of thoughts including getting a reward; and, At best at what we do when we do it for a purpose larger than ourselves. There're a long list of scientific researches from various fields that support these following findings (with which I can provide you; just write me directly to save space). I remember a countless time seeing someone's doing something so brilliantly, but only until they're being "applauded" for the work that they do that their brilliance begins to fall apart.

Needless to say, it also happens to me a countless time, which may have been the reason for why I have been taking the "non-consequentialist" approach to doing things. A consequentialist believes that the worthiness of an action is to be judged solely by its consequences. I, too, used to be a consequentialist. I used to do things because I wanted a good result, praise, and rewards. And as you may guess, I never got anywhere with my life.

I tried to recall when I became an anti-consequentialist, but still couldn't recall when exactly that I changed. A guess is that it could have been that moment about a decade back when I heard about the reason why the acclaimed director, writer, actor, etc., Woody Allen has never accepted any awards -- including 4 Academy Awards (yes, the Oscars), 10 BAFTA awards, and 2 Golden Globe Awards. Why? He remarkable said to ABC News in 1974: The whole concept of awards is silly.

I cannot abide by the judgment of other people, because if you accept it when they say you deserve an award, then you have to accept it when they say you don't. So, Woody Allen (by the way, my favorite movie of his is not *Annie Hall*, but *Whatever Works*) never shows up to receive any awards for which he has been nominated.

In fact, many critics have already given up on convincing him to "just take the Oscar already" (The magazine *Atlantic Monthly*, in fact, cries out loud: "Stop Giving Woody Allen Awards, He Won't Show Up Anyway"). In the sense, Woody is right to have his own standard by which he aspires his work to live. But more to that is the fact that he doesn't work for any recognition except his own -- and he's remarkably successful. He even implies that indulgences in awards can make you less efficient.

Is that true, though? Why exactly do rewards make us less efficient? From an economic perspective, it should be the opposite, isn't it? Economists believe that humans are driven by incentives. Give them the right incentives and they'll collaborate, manufacture, and come up with great ideas. But historically, though, I have to say that's not how great ideas and performances come about. The best-selling author and entrepreneur Rolf Dobelli has for us a succinct answer.

He writes in *The Art of Thinking Clearly*: Science has a name for this phenomenon: motivation crowding. When people do something for well-meaning, non-monetary reasons —out of the goodness of their hearts, so to speak— payments throw a wrench into the works. Financial reward erodes any other motivations. So who is safe from motivation crowding? This tip should help: Do you know any private bankers, insurance agents, or financial auditors who do their jobs out of passion or who believe in a higher mission? I don't.

Financial incentives and performance bonuses work well in industries with generally uninspiring jobs—industries where employees aren't proud of the products or the companies and do the work simply because they get a paycheck. On the other hand, if you create a start-up, you would be wise to

enlist employee enthusiasm to promote the company's endeavor rather than try to entice employees with juicy bonuses, which you couldn't pay anyway.

That is to say, rewards, financial incentives, and material results are not the reason that motivate people to do great thing, or the cause of how great ideas come about. They are the reason that makes the focus of the doers shift from that of the "unconscious passion" to that of the "conscious consequentialist." As science shows, we automatically let go of the mental capacity to perform once that happens.

The legendary swimmer Michael Phelps, too, always remind us of how he never aims at getting a medal when he swims: "I enjoy swimming and it's just a routine." Just a routine? -- He's the most decorated Olympian of all time, with a total of 28 Olympics medals!

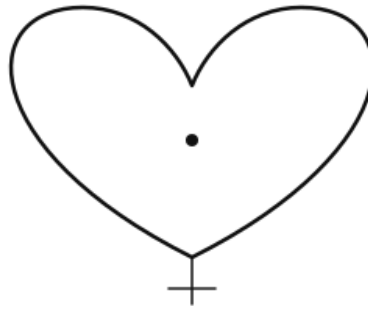
Great minds, pioneers, athletes are those who do what they do because they, "simply" enjoy doing it, and because of that some of them are even excellent in what they do and therefore contribute hugely to the community and society in which they live. Let me return, on more time, to the ancient Chinese philosopher Laozi's view on why "conscious effort" (the trying to hard) and especially those who "strive are responsible for the world's ills" are actually not as useful as they think.

Slingerland translates the following: The highest Virtue [de] does not try to be virtuous, and so really possesses Virtue. The worst kind of Virtue never stops striving for Virtue, and so never achieves Virtue. The person of highest Virtue does not act [wu-wei] and does not reflect upon what he is doing. The person of highest benevolence acts, but does not reflect; The person of highest righteousness acts, and is full of self-consciousness. Starting from today, I am going to try not to try.

DAY 105

What I've Learned Lately

Thu, 09 Oct 2025 00:00:00 +0000



"WE MAY HAVE SUFFERED MORE in our own imagination than in reality." (This quote is credited to the great political figure Seneca); We were born without anything, not even the clothes we love. So, anything that we've got in life today, no matter how small, is already a bonus; Don't let your interpretation of anything, especially a side of reality, affect your wellbeing; 90% of life suck; that's the reality.

But the other 10% is something really really worth living your life for; The ability of breath when suffocated is the true meaning of optimism; Don't try too hard. A wise sage once said, "When you want nothing, everything is yours. So, it's best when you do nothing. The second best is not wanting anything in return when you do something; Do good things. Don't do bad things. With the hope that, eventually, you'll get to do nothing at all.

There's a true sense of peace when you're not obligated to do anything and for anyone; When things get hard, remember the good things that had happened in your life, re-live them in your imagination, and use them as emotional energy to live. Giving up living before your time comes (and believe me, it will come) is a waste of opportunity to see things the way they really are; At least, every once in a while, try to be the best version of yourself; I don't know what passion is.

What makes more sense is to know what you're good at doing, and what you love doing. It'd be awesome if these two things are the same, but if they're not, then you're going to choose what to do. That decision is what I think of as passion; You're going to die one day, and it could be today or tomorrow. If you feel as though your job is bullshit. Don't let it be the last thing that you do.

Giving it up to live in the woods is better than spending even a minute doing bullshit job; and, Don't explain yourself to someone who is already prepared to come up with an argument to rebuke it.

post Day 106: Coping with COVID-19 Anxiety: Super Practical Things To Do During at Home Fri, 10 Oct 2025 00:00:00 +0000 I wrote this post on Medium (my new favorite place to read) a while ago and thought that it might be useful to re-post it here with some feedback on thoughts and comments that the post received. Over the past months, I interviewed hundreds of people in order to understand what to do to help them cope with COVID-19 anxiety.

Oh, right, I hadn't been keeping you guys updated for a while regarding what I've been doing lately. In a nutshell (otherwise it could be a post in itself) I've finally, eventually, and ultimately found a dream job, working as a supporting unit for communities who need help. What I find to be the most troubling thing for these people whom I am responsible for helping is how they are dealing with the deepest sense of uncertainty brought about by the abrupt change.

Such uncertainty affects the deepest sense of how they maintain our sense of livelihood. Based on professional consultations I have given to hundreds of people across the globe, here are the 3 super practical things to do now: 1. Take this time to do an inventory of your household objects and finance Although many of us get to stay at and work from home, most of us are actually stay home and feel anxious rather than be productive. I, for one, was like that back in February and March.

After so many plans had been cancelled, I was left with no a lot to look forward to. Having too much time on our hand also isn't helping. The time that we usually spend socializing water cooler-side is also completely gone. It's hard, of course, as although we humans are resilient we are wired to socialize.

When you feel anxious and could no longer sit at your work-from-home desk, the most sensible thing to do is to take this very special time to do an inventory of your house — honestly deciding what you want to keep and what to throw out, give away or donate. Organizing and tidying up doesn't require you to be focused all the time. In fact, you could also listen to your favorite podcast, radio, audiobook, or music while doing it.

It doesn't have to be as extreme as Marie Kondo's Netflix show, but the philosophy of only keeping what sparks joy is a good start. Apart from the house and food, you may be surprised that most people come down to just a piece of checked luggage that actually need in their life. The rest can go, probably slowly, since we humans are also built to hoard. Do the same with your finance. Extra credit cards that you never use, cancel them.

Duplicate media subscriptions that you don't have time to watch or read them all, cut it down to the single most important one. Do that ruthlessly as if you're Julius Ceasar — I come, I cut, I conquer. 2. Learn Something I'll be upfront: I am now a big fan of online learning.

This is the best time to learn something new because you can no longer give yourself a lame excuse (as I often did) of "not having the time." We are moving into a new era where knowledge is becoming completely democratized. It may not come as a surprise to you that such a process isn't quite as difficult as anyone may have thought. Well, the way we teach (how a professor "professes" to the students) hasn't changed much over the last hundred years.

There are so many free online courses that you can take right now that will help you learn new skills that you may either need to tackle new career

challenges or simply want to learn to keep your mind too busy to feel anxious (and it neurologically works!) I recommend choosing something that you have always wanted to learn. I just started a bunch including Korean 101 on Coursera which I always wanted to learn because my best pal is Korean.

How about those books you picked up from a bookstore a while ago serving as a statue of your lack of will? Start reading them. 3. Give, Give, and Give The next best thing you can do is to appreciate giving. We are all living in the world that applauds competition, where selfishness is sometimes just and is held as the critical element of success. There are hundreds of self-help books and gurus out there who are telling you to "say no" to achieve.

In other words, if you want to be successful, be selfish with your time. But the fact that gurus have to tell you to "say no" is because our nature is not to do so. This is a time when stopping is good, when staying home is an act of kindness, when not competing is saving lives. This is the time to let go out of your sense of having to be selfish to protect your opportunity. This is the time to regain your sense of generosity.

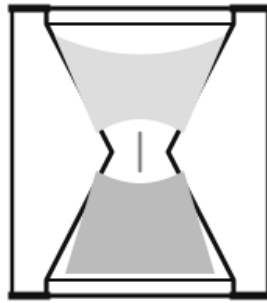
Start with whatever you don't need, hand them over to someone else who may need them. If your personal finance allows, donating to a good cause is most effective. You can also volunteer your time. Blood donation is also a good idea. Leaving behind what you no longer need frees up your cognitive ability to appreciate things more clearly. The appreciation of giving, as a bonus, reinforces your sense of social responsibility that in turn elevates your sense of self-esteem and therefore well-being.

Within a week, you'll be less anxious, happier, and more grateful that, at least, we are in this together.

DAY 107

When Things Get Rough, Do This

Sat, 11 Oct 2025 00:00:00 +0000



I RECENTLY RECEIVED AN EMAIL from a former colleague. This colleague witnessed firsthand my personal disaster. "She still thinks I am alive" was my first thought upon seeing her email. Well, at the time, I was that close to physical end my life. First, I Almost Died. Then, I Didn't Have a Job.

Afterward, I went into a long period of unemployment, during which I had nothing else to keep myself busy but ruminating about the past — the past that I regretted which was, in no way, helpful from a therapeutic and clinical psychological standpoint.

In fact, nothing is worse than a person who tries to get out of the hole continues to, in his imagination, digging the hole. Yep, Everyone Thought I Was Dead So, I was not that surprised actually that many people thought I was dead after my disappearance from all social networks. Anyway, the content of her email was nice. I could feel the strongest sense of empathy. She herself is now facing a hardship of her own.

"I want to hear from you and learn from you how did you manage to get out of such a dark moment in your life." Later, I Decided to Turn Around That line in her email got me thinking. How did I decide to turnaround? It was a difficult time. I couldn't find anyone to talk to. I no longer had close friends

and most people who weren't close thought I was dead.

Without any income, I was living in the living room of my tiny family's apartment like a loser, scrapping for food whenever someone in the family did not manage to finish his plate. Obviously, I was also disgusted by myself. Fast forward, after the said period of unemployment, I've gotten myself a job in the field of digital technology and digital policy implementation. For the past year, I've been helping cities, companies, and individuals digitally transform using technologies such as cloud, digital data exchange platforms, and so on.

This might not sound surprising unless you know that I was trained as an architect and had always been the end user's side of things when it comes to technology. Well, How Did I Do It? I didn't have any of these skills to turn around before, but those months of unemployment were so damn hard that the only way I could try to get through was to make myself "useful." So, I helped out with chores and tried not to be a burden to my family.

With the career that I had built for the past 2 decades officially over, I thought to myself "What if I create a new one?" Usually, this question gets answered as quickly as the speed of light: "Yeah, where would you find the time to do it?" Well, for this time, I had all the time in the world. So, in a difficult time, I personally think that it is a great moment to get yourself to learn things that life otherwise would have steered you away from learning.

As a big fan of Apple and many other tech companies, I had always been fascinated by the maker's side of digital technology. Between those months of unemployment, I managed to finish 10 difficult online courses. As an unemployed, I received financial aid to pay for all of them. Because of the unfamiliarity, they were super difficult. But it was good because, while learning those courses, I didn't have the mental capacity to get distracted by anything including by the past mistakes that I made and regrets in life.

I also managed to finish 100+ books, from the fields of psychology to neurolinguistic programming (NLP), to Buddhism, to different types of

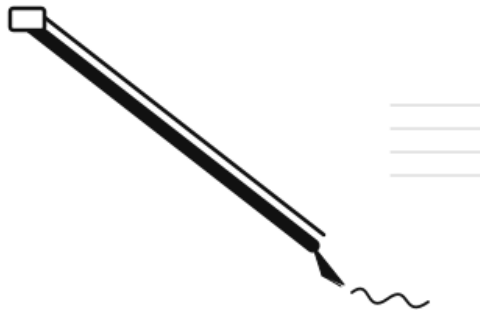
scientific skills. Of course, I would have chosen not to have those months of unemployment but, looking back, it was indeed a great break. I used learning to prevent myself from thinking about the past, but they in turn helped me to find my path to reinvent myself.

Moral of the Story: When things get rough, do what you otherwise would not choose to do, like learning skills that you probably wouldn't learn unless you have all the time in your hand to try what's it like.

DAY 108

How I Got Out of the Darkest Time

Sun, 12 Oct 2025 00:00:00 +0000



FIRST, I CAN'T TELL YOU how happy I am to be alive right now to write this post. A couple of years ago, my mental condition went from good to bad within weeks, and from bad to worst within days. I had no reason to live. Long story short, I went from having a career of my dream to being unemployed, and from that to being "unemployable." Needless to say, I was in a stage of total despair.

It didn't help although I tried to cheer myself up by thinking "No one kicks a dead dog." Even though I was already a dead dog, (e.g., scraping food from the street and sleep on the sidewalk) the kicking did not stop. Things had gotten worse daily. Every day, then friends and then colleagues stopped talking to me. One by one, all of them gradually disappeared from my life.

Ironically, those who were still there only encouraged me to "disappear from the face of the earth." Without money, or someone to turn to, the thought of ending my life frequented my mind. But I actually did not even have to take my own life. My body-mind connection was strong. When my mind no longer saw life as worthwhile of living, my body began to deteriorate. My appetite stopped (which was probably a good thing as I was too poor to get more than a meal a day anyway).

My willingness to do just about anything faded. "I don't want to be here anymore," constantly cross-pathed with "I don't want to be anywhere else either." Before I knew it, I was lying on the curve side waiting for something to majestically do all the hard work and ended my life for me. At that time, I knew, for sure, my death would bring joy to so many people. So, why am I still here? A few things happened, obviously.

While waiting for my body to fully deteriorate, I came across a few unwanted books on an unfamiliar subject: Psychology. Before that, I didn't even know what it meant and even ridiculed it sometimes, making fun of it as "pseudoscience." Here are what this unfamiliar subject taught me. One: You are your thinking. Because we think and understand the world in words, in nouns, and in verbs, you are essentially what you are thinking.

The thinking that "Today is a bad day" can become a self-fulfilling prophecy making your day as bad as you thought. In other words, it's the words that "program" you to act accordingly. This is a concept known to psychologists as Neurolinguistics Programming (NLP). Having no job and nothing to lose, I gave NLP a shot. "Some kind people will give me food today," I always began my day that way, and lo and behold, I constantly got fed. Positive words made me look unharmed and even friendly.

Strangers were happy to share their food with me and let me talk to them. Soon, I turned to different sets of words, such as "I will learn something today," "Today is going to be better than yesterday," and "I can make new friends." These were powerful words that, looking back, helped me re-program my mind and therefore my physical condition. I was still sick but I was obviously better in a matter of weeks.

The other thing I learned from NLP is that the worthiness of my life doesn't depend on what others think of me. Yes, old friends were no longer there. They did not like me anymore. But just because they did not like me doesn't mean I should die.

With the goal of "making new friends every day," I began to reevaluate my value, and gradually, I have found the "kinder" version of myself: The one that treasures kindness over correctness, the one that treasures every living moment over a big moment of success, and the one that cherishes the now more than the past. Two: Optimism is Breathing when Suffocated. Here's another thing that I learned. NLP helped me re-program my mind but NLP alone is not the secret sauce. I still needed a "reality check" as well.

Usually, a reality check comes in the form of things that are difficult to swallow. Let imagine it together. You're suffocated, and you don't see anyone's coming to help you any time soon, what should you do? To be optimistic is to hope that someone will come and help you, right? Wrong. To be optimistic, in this circumstance, is to continue to try to breathe. It's the attitude of not wanting to give up and work toward the goal of surviving.

What you should be thinking about isn't "When is someone's coming to help me?" but "How do I conserve my energy and use the light air I had left effectively?" I am still using this technique today. In fact, just a year ago, the very day I lost something important, I forced myself to look for a replacement and act on getting it at that very moment.

It's painful to dwell in the loss, hence the act of doing something actually helps to distract you from the sunk cost and focus on what you should be doing. Three: I Found Joy in Doing Things I Once Took for Granted. If you ask me how would I reevaluate those darkest times of my life. I would be hesitating to say that it was all bad. I can't even say that I would not go through it again — because I have learned so much from it.

I used to be arrogant and believed in nothing but myself. I used to judge people ruthlessly based on my own moral principles. I also used to destroy everyone who did not see the world the same way that I did. Those darkest times changed everything for me. Because I did not have a job, I had all the time in the world. I once read a book that mentioned how the father of modern psychology William James was toying around with the idea of killing himself.

"I'd give it a year, if my life isn't improved I would do it," said James. I thought that was a powerful thought that I wanted to replicate. "If this was going to be my very last year on earth, how should I make use of it?" Again, unlike millionaires, I didn't have any resources or money to plan it extravagantly. I could only try to make it as good as it would get — with nothing.

And that was when I found the true love for the concept of "gamification," or the idea that we can make seemingly boring stuff, such as mundane work, fun by using game elements and mechanics. So, I began to plan for my last year in which I would be collecting points and badges (as in a serious game) daily, and toward the Day 365, I would see myself on the scoreboard. If my rank wasn't high enough, I would end my life. What's the game?

Well, I didn't have a job and my previous skills are now rendered useless. I need a new set of skills. So, the game was to find myself a new skill without going back to school (no money), without any tools (also, because of no money) and without any formal helps from anyone (remember, I had no friends left). So, spending time at random spots and random people, I began my quest to master this "365 Days Game" by talking to as many people as I found interesting.

I then selected random things from the internet or a leftover magazine, and study them thoroughly. Then, I began to found myself "in the zone" whereby the feeling that I could learn something so new and random, and make a living doing it, began to don on me.

It took about a few months, during which I observed how people practically do things and make things, together with my own self-study on how to theoretically make them, for me to grasp the basic concept of what would soon become the foundation of my new and now career. I also made so many new friends along the way — these were friends whom I would never have gotten a chance to know had I still be in my previous work-life circle. Soon, I started to feel confident again.

With the help of positive words (NLP), the reality check (optimism = breathe when suffocated), and making life a serious game, I didn't have to wait until Day 365 to ask myself for another year of life. Yep, and that is the answer to the question: Why am I still here. Coda This is not a self-help post. I am literally writing this post for myself, as I need and want to reflect.

The job that I have right now is the one that I have now which I would never trade it for anything. In fact, a friend asked me yesterday, "What would you be doing now if you win millions from a lottery today." It took me half a second to answer "Actually, I never work a day because I am doing what I like...So, I would still be doing this job even if I can afford a private jet to go anywhere." So, here're some quick recaps.

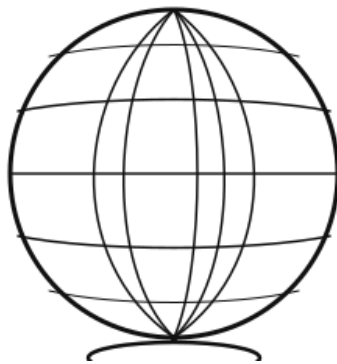
Things get hard from time to time. Don't dwell too much on it — think of them as challenges in a videogame to overcome and find joy in doing it. Negative words are not be used with anyone, including yourself. If psychology tells us anything, it tells us that you are what you thinking makes you. So, make use of words wisely. Don't overdo it (e.g., "I am the best in the world"), instead use it humbly (as in, "I am useful to someone").

Learn something difficult, as it would distract you from your own negative self-talk by putting you "in the zone" of proximal development. Thank you for reading. A full list of books that saved my life can be found [here](#).

DAY 109

The Fact, Key and Action to Help You Work on the Better Version of Yourself

Mon, 13 Oct 2025 00:00:00 +0000



"I AM SO GLAD TO have met this version of you." These 11 words have gotten me thinking long and hard about how I have come from being no use to no one to a person that someone is glad to know today. It's true: I would not want to know any other versions of myself except this one. The previous versions of me, as I remember clearly, are some of the worst shit shows.

Even though my intention wasn't always all bad, the way I interacted with people was condescending. Just because I felt educated and privileged over most people with whom I interacted, I felt as though I "had the right" to look down on others — and even bully them. "I bully them to make them better and stronger." This was how I justified my action then. The Fact: Tough Situations Make You Strong Over the past two decades of my life, there have been only a few horrible life-changing events.

Then, I thought of all of those events as a misfortune. Looking back now, I can see clearly how grateful they happened to me. We all want positive events. The truth is that those positive events don't really help you. They only boost your ego. Every one of the horrible events, on the other hand, had

shaped me to become this better version of me. In 2010, the death of my father was the first truly horrible event. I never loved anyone more than he.

My father's death was a wake-up call that got me thinking about the meaning of my life and my mortality, therefore making me want to be more productive and use my in the wisest possible way. Then came problems with my professional life, which had gotten me to think hard whether the only job I thought I could do was the right job for me — it wasn't. It, however, took me almost a decade to tell me to stop lying to myself about it.

It took a truly horrible event to give me a wake-up call. The toughest situation came about a couple of years back. Let me not dwell on it, but all I can say that it was so, for the lack of a better word, "Kafkaesque." The novelist Franz Kafka (1883–1924) was a Czech writer famous for his depiction of the powerlessness of the individual crushed by nonsensical, often blind authority. Often, we get through hard times easier when we can explain them.

Needless to say, I could not explain a bit this Kafkaesque situation. In my last post, I wrote about how I not only survived the depression-ridden suicidal year but eventually attained a dream job — using the tough situation as a permanent sticky note guiding the way. The Key: Humility That was the one thing that all earlier versions of me lacked. I was deprived of confidence when I was younger. Being someone who had never been praised for anything, I had a thirst for acceptance.

Hence, I put enormous pride on being the "know-it-all" — even if it meant calling people out when they said something wrong at the dining table — as much as in having a status and title. I was proud of my "professor" title and did not want to hear any opposing thoughts. Often, we don't see things clearly when our unconstructive confidence overshadows us, as proven by many psychological theories especially the Dunning-Kruger Effect and Curse of Knowledge.

So, the first key to find the better version of yourself is to accept, and therefore invite, the greater sense of knowledge by owing it to humility. The Action: Think Good Thoughts Recently, I've just re-read a few psychology books (also mentioned in my previous post). This time, I've come byways of science to wholeheartedly believe that our mind is really powerful.

From the undeniable power of placebo to the constructive notion of self-efficacy, psychology has shown us quite clearly that the more we think good thoughts, the more good things get attracted and brought over to you. I am not talking about flimsy "The Secret" kind of imagination here — that the universe gives you the wishes that you want (although the key message is not that far apart; read Mark Manson's commentary [here](#)).

The good thoughts that you have will make you look and positive feel to others. Although it might be hard to prove that good thoughts always bring good things, it is super easy to show that you are likely to spread such a negative vibe to everything around you when you are moody. When you are on the positive side of the aisle, on the contrary, you're sending positive vibes to others through your body gesture, your facial expression, and your words.

So, here're the fact, the key, and the action to help get more people to say to you that they are so glad to know this version of you — so should you.

DAY 110

2 Years of Traveling the World with Just 1 Backpack: An 'Accidental Minimalist' Tale

Tue, 14 Oct 2025 00:00:00 +0000



IT'S ONE OF THOSE MOMENTS in life where you'd say "enough is enough," leave a full-time job, and travel the world. That moment happened to me a few years ago. It's the time of uncertainty.

Upon getting my doctorate at mid-30s, having nowhere to go because of the academic job market, I decided to travel the world with the limited amount of cash that I had...which meant that I would have to travel super light to be able to get on the low-cost flights without paying extra and possess the fewest items so that I could roam without a fixed plan and nothing valuables attracting attention from thieves when staying at budget hostels.

So, as a full-time hoarder before that, I had to change everything — from the mindset to the action. Here're the list: Bigger isn't always better. Traveling with low-cost airlines meant that I could only take up to 7 kgs with me. I had a badass laptop (with 16" screen) which would take up to 2.5 kgs if I were to take it on the trip with me (meaning less room for important items). So, I traded it for almost a netbook which was less than 1 kg in weight.

The smaller size also attracted less attention and was less prone to break since there wasn't many moving parts. I didn't think I could live with such a small screen and a less powerful processor, but it all worked out well. In fact, I have also gained the power of being patient and being a single-tasking person. Wallah, a slow computer has helped me regain my focus and therefore my productivity. The water bottle is both the money and life-saver.

We all need to drink a lot of water every day. Even though a bottle of water isn't expensive, but trust me it adds up. I began to learn to carry around a water bottle with me, which saved me an enormous amount of money daily. Tap water was free almost everywhere I went. I often just stepped into a bar and restaurant and asked politely for a refill and had never been denied.

In some places, natural spring water was available fresh and cold — much nicer than drinking anything at all from a plastic bottle from a convenience store. This water bottle saved my life. I went from a "not-so- practical" one (and quite heavy) to a perfect one (that I could open with one hand and would not spill inside my bag if placed upside down). Weight mattered, so I gave the old ones away as soon as I got a new one that worked better.

Since the amount of space in the backpack was limited, so I had to choose to carry just one best water bottle. Wash clothes daily. Since I only had room for up to 2 pieces of all my clothing items (one for jeans since it's heavy), I never spoiled any opportunities to wash clothes. They dried well in an air-conditioned room. Or, for me, I tied them around the outside of backpack when I moved to quicken the drying process, which worked like magic.

I washed my clothes by hand daily and made sure to wash everything I could when chances permitted. Also, only get the quick-dry non-iron synthetic fabric. Throw them away to make room when they're no longer wearable. Also, use packing cubes to separate everything in your bag and organize them neatly every chance you have as if you're organizing your thoughts for a very important exam. Get rid of the big camera.

I loved my digital SLR, but I could not rationalize having it in my backpack since it would take up to 1 kg of weight. Also, it attracted attention from those who might want to steal it from you. Instead, I'd gotten to learn how to take modest-quality photos with my smartphone and new storytelling techniques to make my story worthwhile without having to use a fancy machine. Keep everything in digital format + just 1 physical paperback at a time.

I ditched all my books — more like a collection since I had more than a hundred of them. I gave them all away and rebought them in various digital formats (e.g., PDF, Kindle, Apple E-Book). I came to fall in love with audiobooks which I could listen to while on the move. During those travel years, I finished more than 50 books in total. Some of them I listened to them twice, such as Daniel Kahneman's *Thinking, Fast and Slow*.

A physical book was with me from time to time, but never than one and it's always in a paperback form. Once finished, let it go to someone else. Trade it for another title, or give it away at a hostel for the next readers to be enlightened. Here they are my tips that got me through 2 years of world traveling. I hadn't counted how many countries I visited because I just let my travel plan changed as I probed.

I hitchhiked (in a trusted place), shared a ride with folks whom I just met, and used all sorts of travel opportunities that I had never tried before to get from places to places. I kept track of my family daily making sure that they weren't too worried about my being on the road.

I made a few bucks here and there doing micro jobs such as paper editing and reviewing products to support myself during the trip but never tried to make more than I needed (since having cash on me was also dangerous and would steer me away from more important things, such as using my time to experience the world).

Looking back, I learned so much from the 2 years of giving away stuff, having less, and "being nobody." I learned to let go of my ego and my confidence for

being lofty above others (well, thanks to the "Dr" in front of my name that had, for a while, got me to think that I was superior to others). Really, nobody cares if you have a Ph.D. when you're on the road traveling the world almost cashlessly.

I learned new skills from almost everyone whom I met on the street. I learned to be humble, to be status-less, and to appreciate every micro-moment as constant rewards in life. Henry David Thoreau was right, learning to live with the minimal forced to me appreciate the most essential part of life and was the key to self-realization.

post Day 111: How 'Light and Cheap' Travel Helped me Escape Death Wed, 15 Oct 2025 00:00:00 +0000 In my darkest hours, during which I was choosing between living and dying, I found the perfect method to help me make such a decision — travel. I had no hope and nothing to lose, so I decided to go on for just one more year. Apparently, relocating myself from the place where I was constantly reminded of my misery was an obvious choice. But where to?

I decided to go on a road trip. It's the combination of being poor and being destination-less, I decided to go 'light and cheap' backpack at places I wanted to see before my death. By 'light and cheap,' I meant travelling with 7 kgs or less and staying at places that were as cheap as possible, including free public spaces if permitted. Little did I know that it would change my worldview completely. This post is about how that happened. Travel made me live in the present moment.

As neuroscience tells us, the primordial part of our brain constantly brings us back to the moments of doubt, reminding us of risks and mistakes to help us navigate life. As for me, my cautious brain tried to get me to make sense of what, at the time, was unmakeable, which only furthered my sense of grief. Travelling light and cheap with a single backpack, I had to be conscious of my own safety and appreciative of every little thing being experienced.

Although I heard of people's talking about the "power of living in the moment," I could not practice it until I was in that very 'humble state' that

travel put me in. Via light and cheap travel, I found that switch in my brain that put me in the state of being present where the past could not overpower the presence and the future did not matter anymore.

I felt the presence of joy even though when I was living on the street with homeless folks with whom I made friends. 2. Walking around is the perfect activity for listening to nature (and audiobooks) I was never an auditorial person. In fact, I found noise to be the arch-enemy of focusing. Because I was travelling light and cheap, I moved mostly on foot, which allowed me to develop my sensitivity for sound.

Strangely, I could hear things that I could not before, such as a flowing river, birdsong, and the sound of the wind. I discovered that these sound made me feel as though I wasn't alone, which was the feeling that I dreaded and almost drove me to my death. Suddenly, the sound of busy neighbourhoods that I once disdained gave me the sense of peace and comfort of being surrounded by people. I walked around the city just to appreciate these sounds.

I even found the ambience sound of traffic to be quite present. I began to record these sounds and re-played them to help me sleep. Enjoying things I could hear when my eyes closed and my body's not moving, I began to appreciate Autonomous sensory meridian response or ASMR, which I could not sleep without now. Also, I learned to appreciate the beauty of audiobooks, which was a perfect companion when walking around. I finished more than 100+ audiobooks in 2 years of travelling. 3.

Travel connected me with likeminded strangers who told me that I was — and would never be — alone. Travelling light and cheap was, also, a perfect way of meeting strangers. I used low-budget travels such as third-class trains and buses to travel. Whether that be a short 1-hour or an 18-hour ride, I always chose buses and trains over low-cost aeroplanes because travelling long-distance made me appreciate the destinations more.

But the true bonus was how I got to meet so many people with whom I shared meals, drinks, stories, and laughter. Because we're travelling light and

cheap, we connected easily and made friends sincerely. Before I knew it, usually, we would be conversing and chatting about the reasons for travelling. I learned, through these strangers, that a lot of hardships were about the perspectives. Little by little, I found peace with my own life. It's rough but that's because I was only capable of seeing it my way. 4.

Travel helped me regain my health. Before I began the journey, I was obese, unnaturally bald, and physically unhealthy. I didn't realize that it was because I overate due to stress, lacked exercising due to busy work, and constantly sick due to polluted city environment. Getting out of what I thought was "what I wanted," I allowed myself to live a different life.

When travelling, I only had 1 meal a day because that's all I could afford, and, almost by default, I had to walk more than 10 miles a day to save on transit. So, I became conscious of what to eat. I needed a lot of nutrition and good calories to get me through the day and the 10-mile-long walk, meaning no more junk food, sugar, and empty calories through snacking.

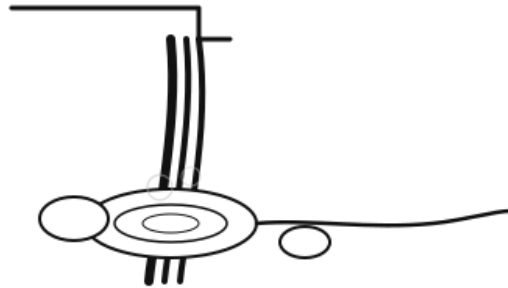
The healthy eating and walking turned my life around, as I begun to lose weight, gained bodily muscle, and became a healthier person. So, I did not think that I could turn my life around, but those 2 years of being on the road was nothing less than a revelation that I needed to experience life differently. I found later on that as psychology tells us that the best way to overcome an emotional crisis is to remove ourselves from the physical that makes us sick.

The idea of travel only makes such as removing more interesting, and, in turn, complete the ecosystem of overcoming a difficult situation. As the German philosopher Johann Wolfgang von Goethe once advised we should find an opportunity to travel, as the new experiences in unfamiliar places are the kinds of "productive uncertainty" that enables to grow.

DAY 112

An Old Machine and Work Ethics

Thu, 16 Oct 2025 00:00:00 +0000

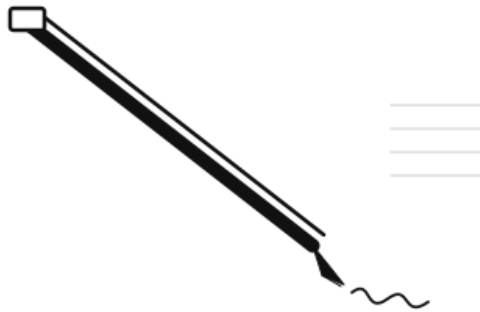


I CAN TELL YOU NOW that typing on a laptop isn't fun anymore after having experienced the joy of typing on a fully mechanical keyboard. Wow, I really enjoyed typing!

DAY 113

A Minimalist's Using Typewriters in 2020

Fri, 17 Oct 2025 00:00:00 +0000



DECEMBER 31, 2020 THIS YEAR marks a very important milestone in my life: my ability to return to a retro tech that is still useful today. Let me explain. I had always been a tech savvy person. It's in the sense that, I like to keep myself up to date on the newest technology. It's not just a part of my job but also my love for innovation that may make my life easier, more convenient, environmental friendlier, and so on.

This year, as I have been renovating my house, I constantly found myself surrounded by what my father who passed away a decade ago had left for me such as cassette players, analog transistor radios, vinyls, and a lot of other things. What resonates with me the most are the two typewriters — in the Thai and English scripts that I grew up seeing my father using them for his honorable job as a government officer who always put other people's wellbeing well ahead of his own.

I picked them up during the holidays in September. My life saving tools for 2020: These are tools that have gotten me through the last 365 days of 2020. I use them heavily for at least 16–20 hours a day, such as the smartwatch to help me keep track of my health, exercise, stand time, sleep, and control my

audiobooks. The laptop is the main machine that I've been using it so much that its battery's capacity was completely drained from the very beginning of the year.

The ink ribbons for both machines has almost dried up, so I pushed the keys down freely and write without seeing any words being registered onto a paper. It was then that I realized that it's quite nice to be able to focus and type freely without any distractions. Whatever I think I type and whatever I type immediately disappear. It's just me and my thoughts.

As soon as my mother knew about my interest in typewriters, she helped me to take them to one of the very few remaining shops that still fixed them for me. And the rest, as they say, history. Typewriters is a Thought's Synthesizer Ever since, I could never go to bed without laying my hands on the thick and hard keys of these two typewriters anymore. Sometimes, I would type whatever that was in my mind. Sometimes, I would compose a poem; something which I never did before.

Sometimes, I would type up a script of what I would like to talk about to my colleagues the day after. They facilitated my understanding of my own arguments and agendas. Many times, I found myself to be on the wrong side of my own thoughts simply because I didn't have a chance to lay down all my arguments and ideas on papers. I would be able to return to my original ideas quickly, with a new piece of paper inserted into the machine, and crank out better arguments.

Typewriters are distraction-free and it's most of time as though I am just writing in the world of ideas that myself is the sole author. I then, also, begin to realize that these typewriters also have a potential to do good outside of helping me narrate my stream of consciousness. Typewriters are also useful in today's deeply digitalized world.

For example, I used a typewriter to type up speeches for my colleagues at venues where I could not rely on being able to find a printer, or using the printer (as in being able to connect them at ease), or finding power sockets

for both my laptop and the printer, etc. Typewriters provide "instant speeches" — as in, whatever I type I get the results in a radical What-You-See-Is-What You-Get (WYSIWYG) way.

It's that and also that I have been able to focus more on my tasks and works that I hope to accomplish. I also learn that my spelling has improved greatly ever since I stopped being careless, as in when I am on my laptop knowing that it will correct the typos for me. I also find myself to be more precise in my prose, as I find it to be difficult to type without thinking on a typewriter. My sentences have become more to the point and much shorter.

Every word I type is like crafting something onto a solid piece of valuable fabric. I would think, determine, and decide what I'd like to communicate. Without any distractions, I am usually able to sync of thoughts and my actions more profoundly and accurately. Bullshit prose would be a waste of time and energy on typewriters since it takes quite a force to push the keys.

Also, as cut-and-paste isn't possible, I have to paraphrase what I read and find pertinent to my own ideas that relate them using both the art of association and the tactics of linguistic crafting. Both the paraphrasing and narrowing my thoughts to the most basic form help me to become a better communicator.

Not only that, I have also become somewhat of a tactical humorist too as I get to entertain myself quite a bit while typing stuff up, especially stuff that would be boring without some nice and easy interruption by ways of humor. All in all, I find typewriters to be a great discovery, helping me to rethink my own methods of communication: First to myself and only if it makes sense to me then it can or may be discussed with others. I know that we humans think in language.

It is a great tool that enables us to communicate with one another across space and time. Very quickly, my working desk becomes a museum of retro tech. All still works just fine.

The best part of it is that they all help to focus in the deeply digitalized world where everything is shouting "check me, watch me, look at me." I use all the tools that are not connected to wi-fi to craft my thoughts, whether that be an important policy paper or a draft of a task, before I would synthesize it with my laptop to get them sent via the internet.

So, to be able to learn how to be precise and meaning-rich is essential to how we humans collaborate and therefore innovate. I will continue to use typewriters productively and won't let them to used to form negativity in my subconscious, like what happened a few months back during which I couldn't go to bed because I let out all my negativity onto pieces of papers before heading to bed.

Words might have been let go onto papers but the ideas remained underneath the dirty rugs of my subconscious, which wasn't nice. Let this 2020 be the opening of another year of a focus, hard and meaningful work. This post, along with a lot of other things that I have been working on, is also available on my blogpost's page on Medium. Bangkok, Thailand

DAY 114

Minimalist Benefits of Working from Home

Sat, 18 Oct 2025 00:00:00 +0000



I HAVE BEEN A MINIMALIST for a few years now. From travelling the world with 7 kgs (15.43 lbs) to spending less than 10 % of my income each month by living like a monk, I have tried to push the boundary of de-consumerism. I genuinely believe that we will gain more when we live with less. Having worked from home (WFH) for more than a year during the pandemic, here are my surprising findings.

WFH's Best Benefit is Avoiding Office Drama I used to think that regaining my commuting time was the best benefit, but I was dead wrong: My main source of mental fatigue, which I only discovered after not having to be in the office for a month, was the drama in the office. Although many research papers show the benefit of a face-to-face interaction, the downside of having to deal with your colleagues' emotional baggage and ups-and-downs should not be overlooked.

It's especially the case in this polarized and strange political climate where everything can be deemed offensive and most people would rather take what they did not like to hear or feel seriously. Not having to deal with office drama gives enable me to focus on my tasks. In the era of hyper-connected

social network and the fear of missing out (FOMO), who would have thought that staying away from people is the real source of contentment. Well, quite a few actually.

Scheduling In Your Time for Self-Improvement Reports show that people are listening to podcasts and audiobooks less before they're no longer travelling to work during the pandemic. As an avid audiobook lover (about 200+ books a year), I felt that during the first half of 2020. My listening time dropped by half, but that wasn't all because I no longer needed my earphones and audiobooks during my 2-hour-long commute but because the world was awful and I wasn't in the mood to learn!

There's no excuse for not listening to meaningful things while staying at home as much as for not wanting to improve oneself while passively standing on the train to get to work. The pandemic hit us mentally, it's just that. Now that we have learned how to live with the pandemic, I have regained my audiobook time. The trick is to schedule it in your day. Travelling on the train at 8am is a scheduling a time for self-improvement.

If you could do it while you had to go to work, you could do it while you're at home (although I know it's harder). Schedule your time for self-improvement! Less, but Only Better Food I am now healthier than ever, dropping around 50 lbs since the pandemic. Before that, I regularly ate unhealthy stuff. Well, it's lunchtime and it would be socially weird to not go eat with colleagues — even if they wanted junk food. I did what I could to stay with the group.

I made my own food sometimes to make up for the junk food I had the day before (which was delicious by the way; why is all junk food so tasty?). But now that I spend most of my time at home, I only eat what I've learned to be healthy. I stick to one meal a day like a monk, which, as it turns out, is a good method for losing excessive weight.

If the nutrition in your food is high enough, a meal a day is more than enough. Needless to say, fewer parties with alcohol is good for the liver as

well as for your bank. Brisk Walking is the Gold Standard Also, with more time returned to me, I use it to walk around my neighbourhood in a "brisk walking" fashion. It's the type of fast-paced walking that get your heart to the level that promotes cardiovascular health.

As for someone in my late 30s like me, I need to walk as fast as 7 miles per hour to get my heart rate above 150. In the beginning, I began with about 5 miles a day after 5pm (the end of my work hours). It'd take me about an hour and a half. I'd come home all sweaty. After a cold shower, I'd be ready to go to bed without having to take any pills (which I used to, such as Melatonin).

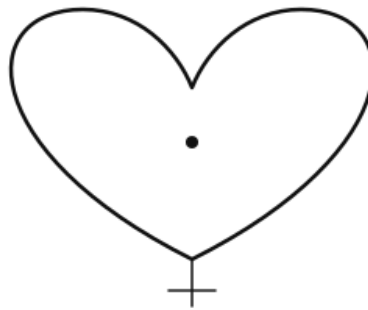
Also, I listen to audiobooks while walking so I get to learn while exercising. Finding Your Hobbies I didn't know that I would enjoy playing with typewriters so much until I had some free time to study them. Out of my fascination with how these primitive machines had helped so many writers put their ideas on papers, I began to wander around the internet, asking for those who did not need them anymore to let me borrow them.

The response has been overwhelming: Most people told me that I could have them if I'd come pick them up myself. People wanted to get rid of these typewriters that bad! But, as for me, these machines have breathed new life into my boring day. I've always interested in the mechanics of basic machines — and the craft of writing — so I immediately. felt in love with these typewriters.

DAY 115

Some Truly Useful Japanese Concepts

Sun, 19 Oct 2025 00:00:00 +0000



IF NOT BECAUSE OF COVID-19, I would have travelled to Japan again for 16 years in a row. In some years, I travelled to Japan more often than once. My love for Japan went all the way back to when I was about three-year-old, reading my very first manga (or Japanese graphic novels). Although I can't make Japan my profession, I always read carefully into Japanese life, especially its traditional and recent concepts. Some of which have helped me to escape my darkest moments.

Here are some on my list and how I interpret them. Wabi-Sabi — "The beauty of imperfection," is my favourite translation among many. Wabi-Sabi is about the acceptance that mistakes and errors are parts of our lives. The idea is not trying to find what is so beautiful about the imperfect things in and about you, but to realize that the record of such imperfect is itself beautiful and therefore one should not even waste time to try to find it.

Kodawari — "An attempt to the absolute perfection" is probably the closest translation. Even though we aren't perfect (hence Wabi-Sabi), it doesn't mean that we should not put our heart and focus on things we enjoy doing. Pushing the limit of our own capacity to perform, as near perfection as

possible, is at the heart of this concept. In Japan, you can see "kodawari masters everywhere from a noodle shop to a cafe, to a wood-carving studio, to the lab of a Nobel Prize laureates.

Psychologically, what kodawari does to you is putting you in the state of flow, whereby your sense of space and time gets distorted as you are no longer thinking about what you doing but "flowing" within it. Certainly, there're some evidence that the more you put yourself in the flow when you do something, the higher chance your skill will improve. Konmari — Love her and her approach to tidying up or not, we all love Marie Kondo, the most famous living tidying up guru in the world.

I read all her books, despite my resistance at the beginning. "I know how to tidy my own stuff," said my inner voice. As it turns out, I have learned so much from the techniques that Marie Kondo spearheads. The core message is the classic one: Less is more. How to systematically and practically evaluate what's useful in life and what's not? How to let go of things that are more liabilities than valuable?

How to not feel so bad when you throw away what was once so important to you? I have become a minimalist partly thanks to my being introduced to Marie Kondo's words. Bushido — Is "ways of warriors." A few words that come to your mind may be honour, sacrifice, respect and fairness. All of those are true. But even more true and deeper for me is the sense of responsibility.

We are living in a world ridden by the forces that are compelling us to think that our problems and issues are not due to our own doing. Some would even go so far as to say that it's the structural vis-a-vis systemic problems that none of us can do anything about. While that might be true to a degree, what we should not forget is that a warrior would not surrender just because the situation gets tough.

They take the situation as a given and fight to their last breath. In'ei Raisan — "In Praise of Shadow," a concept that comes from the name of the book

written by the master of letters Jun'ichir Tanizaki. His comparison between how brightness and darkness are not universally cherished cross-culturally gives us a glimpse into the forgotten bliss of mother nature.

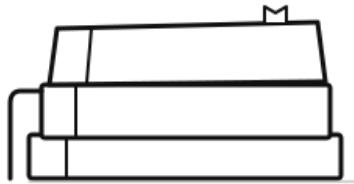
The idea in this short book spurs a wave of interest in the layers of darkness and how they make us appreciate our surrounding, making us want to understand things before making an effort to intervene the way human beings like to do with just about everything they cannot put a spotlight on.

But sometimes, it's simply amazing just to look at something visually enticing whose form is not immediately specifiable but the clue is embedded in the gradation of the seeable along the line of shadows from pitch black and hollow light.

DAY 116

'Kodawari' or an Attempt to Reach Perfection: A Quick Read about Japanese

Mon, 20 Oct 2025 00:00:00 +0000



REMARKS: THIS POST IS SORT of a repost of a previously published article. I rewrote it a bit to make it shorter and more concise. I couldn't believe how long-winded and off-the-topic the original article was. It was so hard to read! I hope this one is an improvement. Comments welcome! 2014–2015 was the only year in my life during which I only had access to one TV channel on my dorm room's television: NHK World TV from Japan.

It was and still is the only official English language television channel aiming at telling the world everything that was great about Japan. Growing up with Japanese graphic novels (manga), it didn't take long for me to acquaint myself with the NHK World TV. Within a month, it became the source of my binge-watching habit. My favorite show was The Professionals, a one-hour documentary series focusing on Japan's best professionals from various fields.

Little did I know that, boy, when it comes to professionalism, no one can really go all above and beyond like the Japanese. As for me, I once thought that being a professional is simply to have a stable "paid job." In Japan,

however, being professional is to be truly passionate about what you do no matter what work it is. You can be a professional grocer, farmer, bartender, coffee barista, dancer, the noodle stall owner, street performer, and so on.

Here is the key: Undergirding this professionalism among the Japanese is () the concept of *kodawari* roughly translated to the "obsession, fixation, hangup, determination, fastidiousness, pickiness about something." Some translate *kodawari* as "an attempt to arrive at perfection." Japan has always been a nation where many professions easily find their places in society no matter how niche-oriented what they do are.

The anthropologist Merry White, in her book *Coffee Life in Japan*, translates it as "the kind of passion that is almost bordering on obsession." In the book, the coffee baristas were the embodiment of the very core spirit of *kodawari* — they're attentive, critical, and ritualistic, about what they do. They treat every cup of coffee as if it is a work of art.

From operating the intricate siphon coffee machine to the ultimate details of the art on a cafe latte, these baristas poured their heart and soul into making the "near-perfect" cup of joe for the customers. Anyone who could feel the very core spirit of *kodawari* could also feel the sensationally embedded in the taste of the coffee. A professional barista in a coffee fair in Fukuoka in 2019. Every time he hand poured a new cup, it looked as though he was mediating.

There was a clear and strict pattern to his techniques and every cup smelled and tasted great. Source: Author's Own Smartphone Camera What makes Japan an interesting country, at least for me, is precisely this kind of respect for professionalism. In Japan, professionals from all walks of life are respected for the expertise and for the quality of the products or services that they deliver.

Japanese appreciation for professionalism not only makes these professionals wanting to continue to develop themselves, and pass on their expertise to the next generation, but also make young people want to become professionals — precisely because they know that there is always

room for growth. This mentality helps to proliferate both professionalism and small businesses. You don't have to have a large sum of capital to pursue what you love.

It's the love and passion (and perhaps some sense of economic feasibility) that make one stand out in the battle between professionals who want to deliver products and services which belong to the best of their class. In one of my favorite episodes of *The Professionals*, Japan's most respected greengrocer Teruaki Sugimoto showed us his passion for selling vegetables.

He's known by everyone in his profession as "the greengrocer who knows more than anyone in Japan about delicious produce." In the Kita-Senju Neighbourhood of Tokyo where more and more people are turning away from the local grocers and toward convenient stores to buy mass-produce vegetables and fruits, the 67-year-old Sugimoto was still all about handpicked, artisanal, and high-quality vegetables that he personally inspects, bids, and buys from the wholesales market by himself.

To outsiders, he may look like a stubborn old man who has devoted his life to vegetables; but, to his customers, Sugimoto's passion for selling vegetables lies beyond his interest in making money. He wants to be on top of his game, which, as he defines, is to serve his loyal and new customers with the highest quality vegetables, as well as in helping the farmers, without whom he wouldn't be able to do what he does.

Teruaki Sugimoto from NHK World TV Facebook Page "Always protect the farmers," is his motto. In a way, he's a merchant — a middleman — who doesn't produce anything. All he does is just to profit from the farmers whose sweat and blood turn into products for him to sell. So, he's grateful for being fortunate enough to be doing what he is doing; hence, he believes that it's important to protect the farmers whose hard labour is the bloodline of his family's career for a generation.

The blurb on *The Professionals'* site summarizes it all: The approach that sums up Sugimoto's way of doing business is "always play offence." And

rather than buying everything at wholesale markets, he has developed his own channels for procuring select produce. Sugimoto says, "There are still many delicious things that people haven't tried. I have to get out there and promote them.

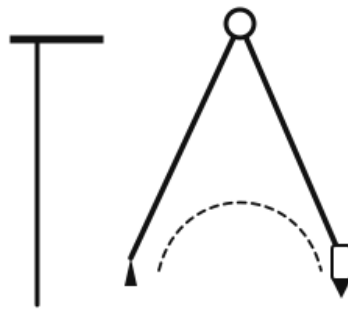
That's what a greengrocer should do." Sugimoto concludes at the end of the short documentary that, to him, to be a professional is "to not to rely only on the past achievements but to strive to be better and better every day." The story of Teruaki Sugimoto in *The Professionals* got me thinking about what it means, personally, to be a professional. Professionalism is, in some ways, about duty, but on the other hand, what it is really about is how life could be given meanings.

First, kodawari teaches us about the benefits of being content with life, which may be the only things that life needs. Second, being true to what you believe is to be true to the very essence of what you do always put you in the flow and give some meaning to an otherwise reckless life.

DAY 117

On Design Thinking Part 7 -- Notes from My Personal Experience Working for a Top

Tue, 21 Oct 2025 00:00:00 +0000



I WAS HIRED AS AN anthropologist to 'observe people' at one of the most famous design firms — here's what I have learned. Google Photos app is always surprisingly good in showing me 'what happened on this day 5 years ago?' Today, popping up on the app on my smartphone was a picture of me with a group of 'elite designers' at one of the world's top design firm. I won't mention this firm's name but you are very likely to have heard of it.

In 2016, with a newly minted PhD in social science (anthropology) with a technical background in architecture, I craved the opportunity to use what I have learned to make a positive difference in the world. I didn't think twice when an HR staff of one of the most respected design firms in the world reached out to me on LinkedIn.

There, I was given the perfect title of an "Anthropologist-in-Residence." Sort of like an organizational psychologist, the title's premise was that I would get to learn about the design businesses as an insider and do what I was trained to — observing people in the office like a 'cultural spy' (AKA ' anthropologist '). The pioneer anthropologist Bronislaw Malinowski with the Trobriand

Islanders in 1918.

His attempt to spend time with the islanders to the point that he could linguistically and socioculturally engage in the islanders' worldview is one of the greatest landmarks of social sciences.

Source: <https://blogs.lse.ac.uk/lsehistory/2017/06/13/bronislaw-malinowski-lse-pioneer-of-social-anthropology/> Note: it has been a hot trend for quite some time now for top businesses to hire anthropologists: 'Anthropology Inc.' Quantitative data scientists and number crunchers may help businesses secure loans and convince board members to make an investment, but anthropologists who constantly 'look for qualitative clues' are the ones who often define terrains for new products and services. There is a long and exciting history of how top companies like Apple, IBM, Samsung successfully put anthropologists to work in the business world.

Often in the role of 'design researchers,' these anthropologists spend time to observe and from that build a hypothesis about new products and services for which the society might be waiting. A page from IBM's Design Thinking landing page showing a quote that speaks on behalf of the company's tenet to put customers first, and from there, create human-centric innovation.

Source: <https://www.ibm.com/design/thinking/> The design research pioneer Jane Fulton Suri, for instance, is well-known for her ability to extract a new value proposition from observing people acting naturally in a particular situation.

Source: <https://www.ideo.com/blogs/inspiration/insights-on-human-centered-design-from-jane-fulton-suri> Over the next few months, I was at the design firm to interact with basically everyone — not just the full-time designers but also contractors, interns, office maids, construction workers, clients, restaurant staff and business owners in the area, employees of other companies in the same compound, and visitors to the office's public events as well as visitors from other offices around the globe.

While most of my interactions took place in the playful-looking office of the firm, the most revealing moments came from carrying out field research with the team. The remaining of this post will walk you through some of the most troubling moments I have and how might we avoid them. First, the religious focus on tape-recording can backfire. The research team that I worked with were extremely obsessed with 'capturing revealing quotes' from the informants.

Source: Photo by Jeremy Bishop on Unsplash There is a fine line between taking notes to capture what isn't said, and deliberately trying to capture some 'particular quotes' that will be handy for a video presentation to the clients. There were many instances during which I felt that we could have learned so much more had there not been recording devices, notes, or writing tools present and that we design researchers would simply listen with their full attention.

We don't have to be told that we act differently when there's a camera pointing at us. Most people get nervous when everything that they share gets written down or recorded. The use of camera often distances the informants from the researchers. Design researchers must evaluate the situation based on our understanding of the interviewee's personality and concerns.

A telling anecdote I had was when I ran out of battery on my camera so I could no longer record anything: It was only then that my interviewee said to me "That's great; now I can begin to tell you the truth." Second, lack of respect often leads to a misleading clue.

Whether or not we are design researchers, we should always treat our informants as human beings, rather than as 'dictation machines.' Photo by Jeremy Bishop on Unsplash As an anthropologist, the best technique I learned when trying to learn from someone is to make they feel as though we are 'friends' therefore making it 'safe [for them] to talk.' That is, forming a relationship with the interviewee by building a genuine rapport is a starter.

In reality, though, I witnessed many instances when the design research team simply marched into the domestic spaces of our informants, often refusing their kind offerings of snacks and tea, relying on a translator to hear what the informants had to share, and religiously doodling everything onto post-it notes, without making any attempt to genuinely build a relationship with the interviewees. Iconized as the 'emblems of innovation,' piles of post-it notes may have been considered by some researchers as "piles of data" at the end of the interview process.

Yet, the question that remains is how many of those contained anything meaningful if they are what the interviewees share with someone they did not trust? In other words, mechanically recording all that comes out of the mouths of interviewees and informants isn't useful. They, instead, become 'noise' that distracts designers from achieving desired service ideation. Third, a 'professional distance' creates distance from truths. The golden rule to fieldwork in design research methods is to always make informants 'feel comfortable enough' to be willing to share insights.

In reality, design researchers prefer 'keeping a distance' in order to forge the scripts that they want to write about the informants. For example, on a research trip, I arrived early as my driver was a local who knew many road shortcuts. I took advantage of having an ample amount of time to chat with an interviewee to learn about his life, work, family, hobbies, and so on.

Not only did he permit me to ask whatever I felt would be useful to us, but also enthusiastically and congenially showed me pictures of his old and future homes on his smartphone. As for the project we were trying to understand the need of a new homeowner like him, I was able to connect his lifestyle, expectations and pressures in life through the revealing stories that he shared with me as he felt comfortable talking to me as 'an empathetic pair of ear' rather than a market researcher.

During the formal interview with the rest of the team once they had arrived, this interviewee, however, did not say anything as revealing as the casual chat that the two of us had. It was only after that interview that he sent me a

few written details for me to make sense of his personal issue with the idea of homeownership, which happened to be so structural that millions of breadwinners in the family like him were facing. He never spoke a word about this during the formal interview.

"I didn't think your friends would care; and I didn't feel that I could trust them with an embarrassing insight from my own life," said he. Photo by Jeremy Bishop on Unsplash We are human beings and we all want to be recognized as one even when we are research subjects. For this, honest and friendly engagement with local people and local culture is, I suggest, an essential element to help researchers bond with local interviewees. Forth, inflexibility costs a lot.

If design research is to be effective, flexibility needs to be its core tenet. Unlike conventional market research, design research seeks to understand what our informants find hard to tell us directly. Sometimes they do not know it, but sometimes they just do not know what they would want because what they want is not clear to them.

In many instances, I found our researchers sticking to a plan that we had even though we knew that making small changes would get our informants to 'trust us more' or to think that we're more serious than any other market researcher to whom they had given an interview. At the firm, there was a reason why we always bought flight tickets and hotel bookings that were modifiable — but, at least in my experience working with the team, we never took advantage of that.

There was an instance whereby we looked at each other and nodded that we had just lost a day for an unplanned reason and it would be necessary to extend our research trip, but in the end, as we decided to vote, we flew back just to 'stick to the plan,' which was considered to be the 'professional' thing to do. In instances such as this, I find the spirit of being a fieldworker to be absent in the researchers. Fifth, not seizing all scholarships is an opportunity cost.

Design researchers, like professional anthropologists, should expose themselves as thoroughly as possible to the local points of view within the limited timeframe that the project provides. Perhaps because I was the only person with an academic (as in, not a professional) Ph.D. at the firm, my colleagues were skeptical about my ability to be 'practical.' Photo by Jeremy Bishop on Unsplash I, too, must admit that I was somehow guilty as charge. But the only reason why I didn't become a university lecturer right away after my Ph.D.

was because I wanted to learn more about how to be more practical. While there may be good reasons for many to perceive academic scholarship as too idealistic and often lacking an understanding of the reality of commerce, I only see the natural relationship between them. "We're doing commercial, not academic research" has been one of the main reasons given by design researchers for pushing back against taking advantage of the plethora of knowledge made available by academics.

I believe that all research should be based on the methodological rigor that the various academic disciplines have provided us, but with the flexibility to have the findings shaped and re-shaped by contingent factors that may not be parts of the original inquiry. Time is limited and no one, academic and commercial researchers alike, is immune from having to strategize the use of their time to pursue a systematic investigation of matters or phenomena that interest us.

All research, in essence, is then an attempt to derive the most informed understanding of something under the time and financial constraints, to which a good question and the right methodological approach are central. I think that the only distinction that we should be making is not between academic and commercial, but 'between the good and the bad' research. Sixth, there is a fine line between being a 'cross-pollinator and an 'anti-experts' design researcher.

We need both experts and those who could help the experts in bringing their expertise down to the level of the users, yet I've seen projects whereby

experts in particular fields were not welcome. To be a 'cross-pollinator,' researchers have to spread themselves thinly and deeply (AKA, the T-shaped diagram). In other words, one cannot be interdisciplinary without first having a strong knowledge of a single discipline on which to build the T-shaped extension.

We are all experts in a particular field and when there are broad projects we would benefit from engaging with experts in other fields that are relevant to the project. Yet, because of the idea that experts are 'rigid' (and therefore should stay away from) there're countless instances where I could not think of a worse kind of results.

For example, there was a team that was working on a project related to neurobiology vis-a- vis the effect of electromagnetism on the brain of a toddler that did not have a neuroscientist. The team only consisted of graphic and industrial designers. There was also a team working on an urban planning project that did not have any experts on the land economy, but a full team of avid copyeditors to marvel public relations materials for the project.

There was also a design project for a language school that did not have anyone who seemed to have basic understanding of or training in language acquisition, just a handful of industrial designers who were only interested in designing new types of desks and chairs to stimulate learning. We don't want to whole team full of people from the same background. That won't lead to a new idea because they are all trained to look at a problem in a certain way.

But the point is not to do away with expertise altogether, but a sweet spot between the two. Seventh, entitlement felt by researchers is the true enemy. IDEO co-founder Tom Kelly's once said that to understand the unmet needs, we must be "willing to search for clues in the trash bin." The essence of this quote, I believe, is the doing away with the sense of entitlement. Tom Kelly, who is a partner at renowned design and innovation consultancy IDEO, and a best-selling author of a book called Creative Confidence.

Source: <https://www.goodlifeproject.com/podcast/tom-kelley/> For instance, in a project that I was involved with, I felt strongly that we should be spending time shadowing our informants.

This idea was unanimously rejected by the rest of the design research team and the reason for it was (and I quote in verbatim) "too much of a hassle." Needless to say, I was very disappointed that we ended up driving back to town — to the comfort of the five-star hotel — that we had booked and a full-scale western breakfast at the hotel's restaurant the next day.

I was appalled because I thought that spending the night with our relocated informants would allow us to get a glimpse of how they managed and navigated their time, e.g, how far did they have to walk to get their fresh produce in the morning? What did they do in the time between sending their grandkids to school and picking them up? And, what're the organized and ad hoc activities and social relations among neighbors?

At the end of the day, these residents are the real users of the design that we hoped to deliver, and understanding their lives was therefore of utmost importance. I thought this was not only an apt but also the only way, as there was only so much one could learn from simply listening to and following them as they go about their daily lives. There's a big gap between the lives of elite designers who are making above the average income and the ordinary people.

Entitlement only creates an echo chamber. Eighth, taking away the modern day's abundance of comfort can be useful. There's a truth in the saying that "necessity is the mother of innovation." Take the kidney-stone-removing bed invented by a farmer in Jiangxi for example, for 230 yuan (less than US\$40). 51-year-old Qinghua Zhu invented a bed from local materials available in a typical welding shop to solve his wife's kidney stone problem without having to resort to expensive medical treatment in a hospital in the city. They couldn't afford that anyway.

After rapid prototyping, Zhu came up with a bed that grips his wife's body tightly to it while the 360-degree rotation of her body takes place with the help of the vibration created by a tractor driving wheel to dislodge the kidney stone. Source: http://www.china.org.cn/china/2015-04/14/content_35316758.htm Not only does the invention work, but it's also completely replicable. Zhu's invention is an exemplar of the significant economic aspect of design research that leads to ingenious solutions to problems.

When you have to deal with problems that you don't have the resources to tackle, your inner sense of creativity is automatically being encouraged to come up with right-on-the-spot innovations. In this sense, Zhu is an example of a great design researcher — and he also 'designed by research.' It's very unlikely for anyone to be able to think about anything creative when surrounded only by convenience. There would be a sense that there are no problems to solve, and no design questions worth tackling.

Design research is about finding the domain where empathy and practicality overlap — and design researchers usually think about something innovative when they have to live with old objects, ideas, or services with which they are not content. Conclusion The criticisms [of design thinking] are several: that design thinking is poorly defined; that the case for its use relies more on anecdotes than data; that it is little more than basic commonsense, repackaged and then marketed for a hefty consulting fee.

As some of these design thinking concepts have sloshed into the world of policy, and social change efforts have been re-cast as social innovation, the queasiness around the approach has also begun to surface in the field of public policy. — Dr. Natasha Iskander, New York University All the standard 'malpractices' of design thinking in this post so far has gotten me wonder whether or not the 'design thinking' enterprise is just a sham.

Design firms continue to get new commissions and the so-called 'design researchers' in these firms continue to make money by inventing nothing. An excellent article by Natasha Iskander, an associate professor of Urban

Planning and Public Service at New York University. published in HBR.

Source: <https://hbr.org/2018/09/design-thinking-is-fundamentally-conservative-and-preserves-the-status-quo> To know why a design firms like the one I worked for still existed, I managed to interview a few people who served on the boards of directors of a few huge enterprises who hired us.

The answer I got was unanimous: "We needed to show to the shareholders that there're spending on innovation." It didn't matter whether the desired innovation is an end result, as the keyword here was "to show" and not to create. In that sense, having a name of a 'famous design firm' once known for innovation on a the report made it easy for the shareholders to agree to the idea of spending the their money.

That said, I still believe that there's a way to reverse the course of all these 'abuses' of design thinking industry. First, design researchers must remember the discipline from which the idea of the practice that they engage came, namely anthropology, otherwise many invaluable methods get lost in translation. For instance, flexibility is every anthropologist's best friend.

Once you have set boundaries confining the imagination of the processes of design and design research such as restricting informants to only those from groups with whom the researchers want to interact, the researchers miss out on the many things that one can learn from such interactions. This also includes ideas that could become springboards for creativity. Research ethics that fosters flexible and empathetic research approaches is also crucial to maximizing research opportunities in the service of creating effective designs.

Second, and I can't stress this point enough, entitlement must be kept at the door's step. Designers should not "assume" that they have already been equipped with the knowledge they needed to innovate. This 'false sense of self-efficacy' is extremely dangerous, and, as the earlier points in this post have shown, are the true enemies not of just innovation — but basically of all

good ideas. Finally, there's so much that this short post can provide. I am sure I have left out so many things that are also important.

I think that avid and experienced designers could help in setting the right tone for those becoming a member of the team by reinforcing the availability and encouraging the consumption of and the immersion in these resources by designers and design researchers. Epilogue P.S. I quit my role at this design firm after my role as an "Anthropologist-in-Residence" was terminated along with the project that I was originally hired to work in.

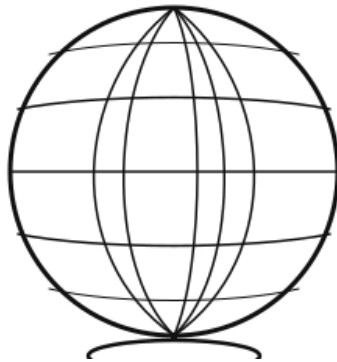
Afterwards, I used the knowledge gained from this experience to set up my own design consultancy based in my hometown, Bangkok, Thailand. Our design research team consists of surprisingly open-minded and knowledge-hungry experts from a varies of fields, such as engineering, economics, medicine, urban studies, computer sciences, and, needless to say, anthropology. To still have one leg in the real-world so that we can continue to engage with the beneficiaries of our works, we all work full-time and keep our design consulting job as part-time.

The kind of project that our consultancy takes are, often, small to medium-sized that has a potential for true social impact.

DAY 118

Expo 2020 Dubai - An Ultimate Guide Part 1

Wed, 22 Oct 2025 00:00:00 +0000



A VIEW OF EXPO 2020 Dubai from the Saudi Arabia Pavilion. Photos in this piece are courtesy of Dr Passakon Prathombutr unless otherwise noted. Every five years, nations gather in one location for a six-month event. The host city invites these nations to build "pavilions" – physical structures that house exhibitions showcasing their unique selling points. This gathering is massive. To give you an idea of its magnitude, the previous two events drew nearly 100 million visitors combined.

Among the many names it is given, "World's Fair" and "International Exhibition" stand out, as does its official name "Expo"(an abbreviation for "exposition"). "Expo" is an occasion for entrepreneurs to travel and meet with one another. The prefix "World" ("World Expo") is sometimes used to distinguish between the main event, which occurs every 5 years and lasts 6 months, and "Specialized Expos," which last 3 months and occur more frequently. There has never been a single event where global firms, individuals and countries have been more present than the Expo.

It is where inventors get a sneak peek of what may become the latest technology affecting the world. For example, Expos were the first to debut

technological innovations such as fax machines, telephones and mobile phones, X-Ray machines, and flatscreen televisions to name a few. Food entrepreneurs look back on Expos where the hamburger, ice cream, hot dogs, peanut butter, iced tea, and ketchup were first introduced to the world.

For architects, Expo is a "Mecca of new ideas." Many inventive architectural ideas, e.g., the Eiffel Tower, the Atomium, the Space Needle, capsule hotels, and the geodesic dome, used the Expos to gauge the interest of the public. The famous photograph of World's Columbian Exposition held in Chicago in 1893: Known as one of the most important gatherings of human beings in the history. Photograph: C. D. Arnold (1844-1927); H. D.

Higinbotham - The Project Gutenberg EBook of Official Views Of The World's Columbian Exposition, Public Domain, <https://commons.wikimedia.org/w/index.php?curid=50469469> This year's Expo takes place at the city of Dubai in the United Arab Emirates (UAE). Though the global pandemic pushed the event back a year to 2021, organizers ' stuck to its original name, "Expo 2020 Dubai." It represents the first time that the Middle East, Africa, and South Asia have held a major event of this scale (the second will be next year when Doha, Qatar, will host soccer's World Cup).

The famous skyline of Dubai in the UAE. Photo by ZQ Lee on Unsplash Back in November 2013, Dubai won the bidding with the theme "Connecting Minds, Creating the Future." Nations compete to host the Expo, just like the Olympic Games and other important conferences. Apart from the prestige of hosting the world's most important gathering, Expo is a great opportunity to create "stories" about an emerging city and economy.

Looking at an overhead picture of this massive 4.3 square kilometer Expo site in Dubai, the design represents three characteristics of modern UAE: speed, scale, and seriousness. The site could easily be mistaken for a vast artificial city built on vision, wealth, and power – and a conscious desire to loudly and boldly proclaim these qualities to the rest of the world. Expo During the Pandemic Traveling to Dubai was our first experience traveling outside of

Thailand since the pandemic has restricted international travel.

We were expecting some serious health protocols. Apart from the on-site PCR test upon arrival at the airport, however, Dubai did not look like a city in the middle of a pandemic. There was no quarantine requirement, and the medical staff who performed the PCR test only asked for our contact information – just in case the result came out positive.

Otherwise, we simply picked up our luggage from the belt and headed to the airport's exit just like the tens of thousands of other business and leisure travelers entering Dubai daily. Not only were businesses operating as usual, but restrictions were also comparatively more relaxed than in many other places. Dubai's Expo had received more than three million visitors two months after its October 1 opening, which is an unexpectedly high number given that most targeted global visitors could not travel.

Dubai made sure that preventative measures were strict and effective. Even with a ticket, every visitor was required to present a vaccination certificate. Expo staff from any nation receive free vaccinations and tests any time throughout the length of the event if they think they might have contracted the virus. Visitors -- all wearing masks -- participating in daily parades and public events at the main spine of Expo 2020 Dubai.

During our six weeks in Dubai, we met hundreds of people, some formally but many casually, such as while eating at a food truck or drinking from a public tap across from the site. Most of Expo's visitors were locals, or more precisely, expats living in Dubai for business. Although Dubai already boasts many artificial theme-park-like attractions, such as the Global Village or the Palm Jumeirah, local visitors, and tourists with whom we spoke were nevertheless thrilled about the Expo.

It appears as though we all miss the opportunity for a worldwide meeting of minds. Based on our conversations with Expo's organizers, staff, and visitors, there are three reasons why nations participate in these Expos. For starters, nothing beats a face-to-face meeting, especially for investors and

entrepreneurs looking for opportunities to measure themselves against their rivals. This so-called "Expo Magic" always draws a large crowd. Even after 170 years, Expo still serves as both a platform – and an excuse – for a physical encounter.

Second, Expo is both a private membership club and a public gathering. That is, a country must qualify to be invited to participate, yet once there, it speaks to the entire world. Like athletes who compete to qualify for the Olympics, all eyes are on them. A country's absence from the Expo, like that from the Olympics, sends a strong message about its competence.

Not only does representation at the Expo convey that they are "doing something," but it also signals that they are "doing it well." Historically, Expo has played an important role in boosting both investment and tourism especially for nations whose appearances at major events, be it sports, cultural, or business, is rare. "Soft power," too, is another term frequently used by both supporters and critics of the expo. Unlike "hard" or military power, soft power is a persuasive approach to international relations.

As countries choose the face they want to present, Expo is the world's largest arena in which they can project economic or cultural influence. For example, the sheer size and number of visitors to Expo 2010 undeniably put Shanghai back on the map as a global city. Third, Expo 2020 Dubai is especially valuable to humanity because it provides a message of optimism.

We have been living in the shadow of the pandemic for the past two years, and many people cannot see the light at the end of the tunnel. Nonetheless, the UAE and more than 190 other countries have declared that they will not be defeated. It takes a lot of planning and organization to pull off an event of this magnitude, yet they did it with only a year's notice.

Products, Progress, Preparation, and Post-Event According to the World Expo historian Charles Pappas, the Expo's nearly two centuries of history can be summarized as the "3Ps": Products, Progress, and Preparation. The idea of a "great exhibition" was first conceived in the mid- nineteenth century when

entrepreneurs held a large event in London to display their competitive products. The some thirty subsequent "large-scale exhibitions" that followed were all about showcasing new products.

However, two catastrophic world wars prompted participating countries and the official organizing body of the Expo – known as the Bureau International des Expositions (BIE) – to shift the focus from products to the promotion of "mutual progress." In other words, the focus shifted from international competition to comprehension. The Crystal Palace was a cast iron and plate glass structure, originally built in Hyde Park, London, to house the Great Exhibition of 1851. Photo: Read & Co.

Engravers & Printers - View from the Knightsbridge Road of The Crystal Palace in Hyde Park for Grand International Exhibition of 1851. Dedicated to the Royal Commissioners., London: Read & Co. Engravers & Printers, 1851., Public Domain, <https://commons.wikimedia.org/w/index.php?curid=48718934> Since the first decade of the twenty-first century, however, "Expo" has shifted its emphasis once again, this time to fostering human readiness to live in a world in which the effects of our actions will define how we live and thrive as a species.

The message here is the significance of teamwork in preserving the earth and preventing calamities, as the main topic – "Connecting Minds, Creating the Future" – implies. Without a doubt, this Expo sends a strong message that we, as humans, will triumph if we are prepared. An aerial view of Expo'70 in Osaka, Japan, where mobile telecommunications were introduced to the world for the first time. Photograph: <https://www.zimmerit.moe/expo-70-osaka-gainax-patlabor/> Another thing that makes Expo 2020 Dubai interesting from the perspective of planning and design is a "Fourth P": Post-Event.

Expos have created compelling stories for host cities. Many cities in recent memory have made their mark on the global landscape after having hosted the Expo such as Seattle (1962), Montreal (1967), Osaka (1970), Seville (1992),

and Shanghai (2010). A view of the Expo in Shanghai held in 2010 -- the largest Expo ever held in terms of space, land use, and number of visitor.

Photo by Cesarexpo - Own work, CC BY-SA 3.0, <https://commons.wikimedia.org/w/index.php?curid=10386331> Unlike previous Expos, where pavilions and most buildings were erected only for the duration of the proceedings, Expo 2020 plans to keep at least two-thirds of the buildings to use after the event. The site of Expo 2020 will be transformed into "District 2020," a world-class innovation hub for startups and worldwide players in advanced technology. The Expo 2020 Metro Station is the last station on the Dubai Metro.

"District 2020" will almost certainly breathe life into what may, on the surface, appear to be a large venue "in the middle of nowhere" that might otherwise have been abandoned after the event. Several influential corporations such as Siemens, Terminus, and DP World have already agreed to be long-term tenants of District 2020. With an ambitious objective and strong advantages like tax and rent-free business setup, it is easy to see how the project will attract the "best and brightest" of the global startups.

Expo 2020 Dubai has cooperated with world-class technology companies to design cutting-edge infrastructure that will easily transition to use in research and development for digital innovation. In other words, District 2020 is a model "smart city" for innovation. A rendering of District2020 an innovation district that Expo 2020 Dubai will become after the event ends on March 31, 2022. Photo: <https://www.khaleejtimes.com/business/district-2020-calls-for-start-ups-to-be-part-of-its-innovation-ecosystem> Architecture of the Pavilions The expansive site of Expo 2020 Dubai is divided into three main districts named after the event's sub-themes: Mobility, Opportunity, and Sustainability.

These three districts fan out like fingers from a central "palm": the world's largest single-span dome, dubbed "Al Wasl Plaza." "Al Wasl" is an intentional pun, as it means "connecting" and is also the historical name for Dubai, thus alluding to both the Expo's theme and the host city. Once the masterplan was

completed in 2017, participating nations were asked to choose one of the three sub-themes, which would determine the location of their pavilion. Nations could either build their own standalone pavilions or convert pre-built rectangular cubes.

"Look like a dream" -- an actual 360 degree of the Al Wasl Plaza. Photo: <https://www.khaleejtimes.com/expo/look-expo-2020-dubais-stunning-al-wasl-dome-looks-like-a-dream> Although the former was frequently favored as a better way to attract visitors, the construction cost for a standalone pavilion was high. As a result, for many countries, the pre-built boxes made far more economic sense. That said, many countries still strive to showcase their prowess through standalone pavilions. Among the largest pavilions at Expo 2020 Dubai belong to the UAE, France, Italy, India, Saudi Arabia, Germany, Korea, Russia, and Kuwait.

While the host provides the basic infrastructure, participating nations pay for the design, construction, and maintenance of the building. As one can imagine, this Expo generates massive revenue for local construction companies, contractors, and architects. The UAE Pavilion designed by the famous Spanish architect Santiago Calatrava, located right at the heart of the Expo's site. Each of the three districts has a "signature" pavilion designed by world-famous architects and uses expressive architectural language to deliver cutting-edge ideas.

For example, Grimshaw Architects from the United Kingdom designed the "Terra" pavilion for the Sustainability District. As a topic, sustainability never goes out of style. The environmental epoch in which we now live requires our complete effort to alter its course before it is too late. "Terra's" canopy is a stunning 130-meter-wide structure covered in 1,055 solar panels.

The structure, dubbed "Contact" due to its resemblance to the massive radio frequency receiver from the popular film of the same name, is an example of sustainable design that aims for net zero water and energy use.

"Look like it could have been from another planet" -- a common impression of visitors upon experiencing the Sustainability Pavilion which is the largest pavilion at Expo 2020 Dubai. The characteristic stainless-steel fins that wrap around the Mobility Pavilion "Alif" clearly reflect the style of the hyper-futuristic architectural firm "Foster + Partners" who designed it.

Alif is home to a large exhibition that traces the evolution of "mobility" in Arab culture from the development of mathematics and astrology to the modern world of metaverse, in which the physical and digital may merge. AGI Architects created the Opportunity Pavilion "Mission Possible," which embraces the "plaza" and its global relevance as a space for people to meet across generations, language, and culture, as well as to celebrate our shared human experiences.

The hyper-futuristic facade of Mobility Pavilion, home to extensive narratives about mobility from past to present and the future. As at previous Expos, countries often commission their top architects to design their national pavilions. Even the largest of these structures are referred to as "pavilions" – a relic of the first Expos. A few pavilions were dreamed up by world-renowned architects, such as Santiago Calatrava, who designed both the largest standalone pavilion for the host UAE and the smallest for Qatar.

The decision as to how these spaces are used is left up to the individual countries. While most pavilions focus on exhibitions, many devote the majority of their area to business meetings, product showcases, and performances. There are a few pavilions that embrace the experimental, such as those from the Netherlands and Singapore, which function as "experimental typologies" for future urbanism. Known as the "Biotope," the Netherlands' pavilion is a complete ecosystem that uses solar power to harvest water from the air and energy to produce plant-based food.

Like an artificial oasis, the Biotope shows us a glimpse into the future of living in critical climatic conditions. Designed by the renowned WOHA, Singapore's "City in Nature" Pavilion represents an effort to create a net-zero building architecture packed with plants and fans powered by clean energy. The most

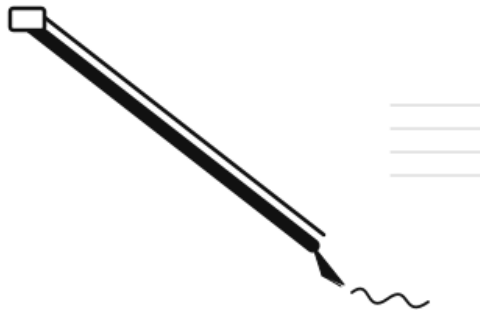
successful pavilions, however, are those whose architectural designs fit the exhibition and vice versa, rather than those with the most visually spectacular architecture.

The exterior of the UK Pavilion, designed by Es Devlin Studio, is among the most photographed pavilions; yet, the exhibitions it houses leave little impression, because the building's focus is entirely on its facade, leaving everything else comparatively sterile and deserted. Although interesting architecture has always been one of the Expos' centerpieces, most attendees are not architects and are thus more interested in other features such as exhibitions, events, and performances.

DAY 119

A Return to This Blog and Simulation Theory

Thu, 23 Oct 2025 00:00:00 +0000



SO I HAVEN'T DONE MUCH with this blog since 2019. I had to start a new job. It required I spend most of my time learning new things. So I didn't write much. Especially not reflective stuff. Like I used throughout this blog. Now we're in the age of AI. I'm using my voice. Also my semi touch-typing skill. To keep writing this blog. I think I haven't fulfilled its purpose. Which was to help me find a meaning of life. I know, I know. Sounds ambitious.

But think about it. Writing rearranges your thoughts. Makes them clear. Trust me, clear thoughts mean better decisions. Better than when your mind's cluttered. With all kinds of unprioritized thoughts. So I'm restarting this blog. I hope I can write every day. It's good to reflect. Now ten years passed. I'm leaving my midlife. Usually, you hear midlife, then crisis. I'm dealing with that a bit. You cross halfway of your longevity. Normal people realize they want to look back. See how much they walked.

How much they achieved, if any. I got two missions for rewriting this blog. One, I want to recall memories. Crystal clear details. In the past, I wrote everything. I got a five-year diary. Each page divides into five sections. I fill one every day. Five years pass, all boxes are filled. With what happened that

day. I find it therapeutic. I get chills recalling memories. Like when I write about someone I'm thankful for. I feel chills in my spine. It's nice to recall grateful moments.

When things aren't right, I write. Even in that small box. A few lines. About what happened. It makes me see the world different. I recognize the fault's mine too. As much as theirs. In any wrongdoing. The other reason for restarting? Capture my old writing sensibility. I used to be good. Made references. Created metaphors. Came up with mnemonics no one could touch. That faded over time. I didn't exercise it. During my dissertation, I described everything. My reader could smell the scene. I was architectural. Built a foundation.

Constructed a framework of thoughts. Strong internal framing. Counterarguments didn't stand. No flaws found. Then I slapped on the façade. Pristine words people wanted to hear. Added windows and doors. Let people enter my house. Experience it themselves. Come out feeling they learned something. I painted comprehensive pictures. For those who weren't there. Not just scenery. The smell. The feeling. The sixth sense. Something beyond words. I used metaphors to project thoughts. I wanna recapture that skill. That sensation. Something strong drove me to write like that. Compelling.

Beyond the rigid domain of professional design. Obsessed with design, not description. I must come clean. I didn't write here for years. I sought refuge at Medium.com. It was well-formatted. Had chances to make money. If people read more. I thought my experiences could help. Make folks feel better. Or worse, who knows. I could earn from it. I got stories others don't. Wrote a few pages there. Now I'm back to this blog. Where it started. It's freedom. Not many read this. Unlike Medium. I can be free. Adamant.

Honest. I want people to feel what I feel. Maybe it resonates. Helps them see their situation different. Like Daniel Kahneman said, nothing's as important as it feels in that moment. He passed last year. Allegedly by his own will. Sad for a decision-making expert. Helped lots of people. Him and Amos Tversky. I

like Kahneman. He knew how people mess up decisions. Got a Nobel for it. Another story for later. Today. I wanna talk simulation. I've been obsessed a long time.

Couldn't understand if we're in a real world. Or simulation. Goes back to when I was young. Grew up in Bangkok. I'd lie on my wooden bed. Look at the ceiling. Imagine small guys under my bed. Cities down there. Like our world. But smaller. Their comic books? Stories about me. I was their interest. Only subject. They lived by my clock. Wanted my news. Read it for fun. To learn. Help their lives. I read tons of comics. Fantasy ones. Got me thinking.

If I can imagine being king of a kingdom nobody cares about, maybe I'm an actor in one. Someone created. Nobody cares. Elon Musk said stuff about this. If we look at computer speed today, it's wild. Moore's Law—transistors double every two years. We're growing exponential. Tech's moving fast. Huge investments. Especially in the US. Center of digital stuff. Soon, video games'll be indistinguishable from reality. Maybe we're there. We're in a simulation now. I thought this after *The Matrix*. Watched all three. Loved the third. Unveiled mysteries. *The Architect*.

Neo. Free will questions. Got me deep when I taught philosophy in Shanghai. Ten years ago. Starting this blog. I could dig deep. Rabbit hole's endless. Still better than living for primitive stuff. Like sex. Food. Entertainment. Here's my theory. I believe we're in a simulation. Computers develop too fast. We're past real-life simulation already. That's nice, actually. If it's a simulation, we don't gotta care much. If we care, it's better knowing it ends. Something good comes next. Takes away thoughts of suicide. Or crimes. Why go crazy?

It's just a simulation. I got three hypotheses about how we got here. First one. Simulation's a test. We don't know where it leads. What kind it is. Like a SWAT movie. Fake experience to train. See if you crack. I think it's S.W.A.T. with Colin Farrell. The protagonist's in a fake situation. I won't know till the end. Walls collapse. He cracked. Lost the task. We're like that. Memories on hold. Live in the simulation. No past. If you crack, wanna leave? You fail. Could be a good theory.

Like pilot training. Simulate a crash. See if they save the plane. We don't know what's at the end. Maybe it's good. You pass if you don't break. All we gotta do? Do not take life too seriously. Get through calm. Second theory. Simulation's punishment. We're here millions of times. I've typed this post a million times. Family, love, breakups. Same girl. Same spot. Nothing changes. Is Diet Coke on my table? Always there. In every simulation, I act the same. Only way out? Realize it's a loop. Not easy.

Not hard. Don't put the Coke there. Try new. Then you're free. Aligns with Buddhism. We give meaning to meaningless. That's why we suffer. Stop it, you're free. I don't like repeating pain. Hope I'm close to seeing the loop. Getting out. Third theory. Entertainment. We're in a world where lifelike simulation's normal. AI works for us. We get everything free. No work. Governments give universal basic income. People use it to play. Not police them. Money keeps folks in line. Less harm than when they're poor. Hopeless.

Poor folks do bad stuff. Fentanyl. Crime. With cash, we enter simulations. Someone bored picks my life. Lives it a bit. Wakes up. Tries another. Forever. We cured cancer. Don't die. But endless life? Boring. Some want death. Not an option. Utopian. Dystopian. Long life, no meaning? That's hell. I believe these theories. Don't know which is true. Can't all be. I like the first. Test's optimistic. Get out, find something real. Second's doom. Hard to escape loops. Third's bad. Humans want no death. Then get bored. Hypocritical.

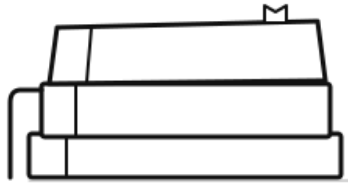
Why build civilization if we're just bored? I'm different now. Ten years ago, I started this blog. Fresh. Now I have experience. Don't trust myself. Crack under pressure. Don't trust others. They want good times. Not trust. Writing's my thing. One line a day. Find meaning. Never a day without a line. Citations: Kahneman's work: Kahneman, D., & Tversky, A. (1979). Prospect Theory: An Analysis of Decision under Risk. *Econometrica*, 47(2), 263– 291. Moore's Law: Moore, G. E. (1965). Cramming More Components onto Integrated Circuits. *Electronics*, 38(8).

Musk's simulation theory: Musk, E. (2016). Interview at Code Conference. Vox Media.

DAY 120

Daniel Kahneman

Fri, 24 Oct 2025 00:00:00 +0000



PEOPLE KEEP ASKING ME. RECOMMEND a book. I ask how many I can pick. They say just one. I always go for Thinking, Fast and Slow. By Daniel Kahneman. Great psychologist. Changed my life. I didn't read it first. I listened to the audio. I got hooked after another book. It's called The Undoing Project. Michael Lewis wrote it. It's a biography of two psychologists. Kahneman and Amos Tversky teamed up for years. They changed how we understand decisions: "We think we get stuff. We don't.

Even when we think we do." That's groundbreaking. It started behavioral economics. Also social psychology stuff. Even positive psychology. Source: <https://wizdomapp.com/books-like-thinking-fast-and-slow/> It got me thinking hard. I was in academia back then. I was job hunting. I wanted psychology in my work since I found it to be so cool (even wanted a psychologist girlfriend at one point). I studied anthropology. I regretted not taking psych classes. They were so close. Just a few floors up. William James Hall at Harvard. That book pulled me in.

I wanted to know this Princeton Professor Daniel Kahneman. He was alive then. Stanford Professor Amos Tversky passed years ago. He had an illness. Kahneman lasted till March last year. He chose assisted suicide. He left at 90. He did it before physical decline. Before cognitive decline. That hit him. It's

strange for a top psychologist. He won the Nobel Prize in Economics. That was in 2002. He's an expert in decision- making. Yet he cut his life short. He didn't face it all.

I can't believe his family was okay with it.

Something feels off. I'm Buddhist. I believe life's a journey. If you take shortcuts like suicide, you start over. You never reach the end. I'm not sure if that's pure Buddhism. It might be my simulation theory. I'm obsessed with that idea. I'll talk about that next section. First, I wanna focus on Kahneman. I picked up *Thinking, Fast and Slow* after *The Undoing Project*. It's a great book. It feels conversational. It's like Uncle Danny's talking to you. He explains with experiments. Some use people. Some use objects.

He shows how we think: He breaks thinking into two systems. System 1 is hot. We use our gut. It happens when we're anxious. Or when we're excited. We're not true to our thinking self. System 1 isn't all bad. Something happens fast? You react. Your body takes over. Your brain avoids trouble. System 1 kicks in. You escape. System 2 is logical. It's cooler. You take your time. You think about factors. You think about consequences. You think about processes. You avoid problems. You get results quick.

System 2 folks are like that Star Trek guy (Spalk? I wouldn't know since I am a Star Wars guy). He's always logical. The rest of the crew? Like the captain. He acts on his gut. He acts on his heart. He's a System 1 guy. Source: Reed and Proctor, *Collegiality, dealing with bullying and acknowledging unconscious bias*. https://www.slideserve.com/Pat_Xavi/dignity-at-work The book is thick. It's not thin. It takes a week to finish. But it's fun to read. I listened first. Then I got the paperback.

The second time, I learned more. We're so flawed. We're bad at decisions. It became my favorite book. I like other books too. Ryan Holiday's trilogies on living good. Michael Lewis's books on money. Also cryptocurrency. Malcolm Gladwell's stuff. I loved his first 10 years. He wrote non-fiction. Later, he got wack. His messages turned cloudy. Too much virtue signaling. A patronizing

tone. People read him less now. Danny taught us humans something. Even logical stuff isn't easy. Like self-preservation. Outside stimuli mess us up. The past clouds our judgment.

The present makes us nervous. We can't decide easy. We become less logical. We're less reasonable. When we engage in a process. We didn't think about that before. Then Kahneman came. He shaped psychology. He made it about thinking. That's amazing. I gotta set the scene. Before Kahneman, psychology was scientific. You'd see machines in offices. They collected data. They formed side effect theories. Like B.F. Skinner did. Behavioralism. It shaped conditioning. People were triggered to act. They didn't know. Intuition got planted in their mind. Before they even knew.

Research was experimental. It was mathematical. It used stats a lot. Pigeons being observed and tested in a B.F. Skinner's laboratory at Harvard. Source: <https://www.sciencephoto.com/media/706878/view> Psychology was a hard science. Then Kahneman and Tversky came along. They showed the world. You don't need all that equipment. Psychology is about studying people. People walking around us. It's a systematic understanding. Of their psych. Machines can't always catch it. You use experiments. But they can be simple. Or casual. You ask people. Same situation. Same condition. They give different answers.

You find reasons. Behind their differences. In how they think. Daniel came. Amos came. They changed the discipline. Psychology got grounded. It got relatable. It's not too far from psychiatry. People think psychologists diagnose. In hospital rooms. Or they're psychotic. They're into psychology. I don't know. My understanding of psychology was different. Before these two guys. Their contribution was amazing. They got us thinking. About the spectrum of human indecision. In situations needing good decisions. We overestimate risk. We underestimate rewards. From a bet or something. They uncovered biases.

Problems with anchoring. We're mentally anchored. We walk into losing situations. We lack priming psychology. They showed us. With vivid

examples. Vivid experiments. It made me believe. Psychology teaches us. Who we are. How we are. How we get where we wanna be. If life has meaning at all. I'll move quick. You know enough. I love his work. It helped me think. About myself. System 1 crashes with System 2. I want System 2 in public. Inside, I'm System 1. It's my bad temper. I'm trying to control it.

I'm not great at it. Decisions come from info I get. Beforehand. Those are biases. It's interesting. The number of biases. The anchoring stuff. We see things. We hear things. We feel things. Before walking into a room. Without that noise, I'd decide different. That's big for me. Now, the real topic. Kahneman's assisted suicide. I don't think he should've done that. For many reasons. He could still talk. He could be stimulating. Like he always was. He was useful to humanity. It's not fair for humanity. To control him.

Live or die. To be or not to be. That's Hamlet stuff. But still. Something might happen tomorrow. A medical breakthrough. It could cure his problem. Maybe 3D printing kidneys. If that's his issue. In a few years, we might make his brain. It'd be more helpful. To society. We could ask him stuff. Like a mini ChatGPT. All wisdom. A System 2 guy. He didn't leave options. For those things. He traveled to Switzerland. First, he went to France. With family. Visited his birthplaces. Old spots. To remember.

Before he died. Then Switzerland. For the suicide. Humanity shouldn't ask him. To stay forever. But we gave him a lot. He owed a lot. How he became him.

Contributions he could've had. If he believed in humanity. We'd fix what he had. It'd be easy. He could've conquered decay. Physical decay. It makes us who we are. He could've lived long. Studied more. Learned more. Solved more problems. Done cutting-edge research. Led us better. The world's divided now. Too many poles. People think too much. There's rising conflicts. Wars. Declining birth rates. They're related. He should've stayed. I think it's selfish of him. People around him thought he was senile. That he could decide for himself. That's ridiculous.

Really ridiculous. To cue a guy. Just cause he seemed capable. He lacked belief. In human goodness. We should've tried. Got him to a point. Where we could help. He contributed so much. He could live longer. Help more. Be one of us. It's too early. I learned lessons. First lesson. Your life is an accumulation of experience. Go out there. Find more. Born in France. Grew up in Jerusalem. Professor in the US. He embraced multiculturalism. Few people have that. It shaped his personality. His character. Made him empathetic.

Calm in turmoil. He saw perspectives ahead. From exposure. Different thinking. Different beliefs. Different processes. These are qualities of a great mind. (I'm like him. I lived in Bangkok. Shanghai. Boston. I got those values. That empathy. It makes me good at what I do. I wanna keep that. I learned from this. It's a sample size of one. But it's a good example. Daniel himself). Second lesson. We're who we tell ourselves to be. Social psychology says that. It was born under these two. It's about individuals. In society.

Society dictates behavior. Wanna act pure? Raw? Unedited? In a good way. Hide primitive desires. That's another topic. Sigmund Freud. Not Kahneman. To be you? Act willingly. Think who you are. Believe it first. Believing in your ability. To be you. In that moment. It confirms you're good. Lets you decide good. I like that. It works. It makes me confident. Sometimes I force it. It's the only way. When things get rough. Third lesson. You never know what's gonna happen. The best decision- maker. On Earth. Commits suicide.

That's nonsense. It doesn't make sense. It taught me. You never fully understand. Even if you think you do. Steve Jobs said it. Stay hungry. Stay foolish. That's true. Stop being hungry? Once food's served? You can't exercise. You can't go out. Be excited. Find new things. You go dormant. You're useless. People wanna exercise. Be different. Be unexpected. Not like this. Not Kahneman's choice. I can't believe he did that. I'll try my life. To reconcile with it. That's the point. I hope you learned. I learned about me.

We're our problems. We think too much. About the moment. We believe it's everything. Time makes it less hard. Unless it gets harder. Maybe leaving's right. But that point won't come soon. If it does? You survive? You get a

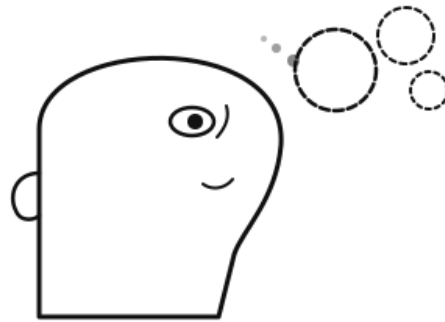
bonus. You supply more later. Citations: Kahneman's work: Kahneman, D., & Tversky, A. (1979). Prospect Theory: An Analysis of Decision under Risk. *Econometrica*, 47(2), 263–291. The Undoing Project: Lewis, M. (2016). The Undoing Project: A Friendship That Changed Our Minds. W.W. Norton & Company. Kahneman's Nobel Prize: The Nobel Prize.

(2002). Daniel Kahneman – Facts.

DAY 121

Free Rides to Harvard, MIT, Oxford: How I Never Paid a Penny for My Education

Sat, 25 Oct 2025 00:00:00 +0000



PEOPLE LOOK AT MY RESUME — MIT, Oxford, Harvard — and they ask, "How the hell did you pull that off, Non?" They expect me to say I had rich parents, a fat bank account, or that I was some child prodigy from Thailand who got a golden ticket from the government. Nope. None of that. My family wasn't rich. I wasn't born with a silver spoon or a brain that could solve quantum equations at age ten.

I was just a regular kid, playing basketball, skipping classes, and dreaming big in a small corner of Bangkok. So how did I end up at some of the world's top schools without paying a single penny? Buckle up, because it's a story of grit, rejections, and a whole lot of library hours. Back in the early 2000s, Thailand wasn't the shiny metropolis it is now in 2025.

Bangkok was a chaotic, backwater town — no mass transit, traffic jams everywhere, and if you wanted cool gadgets, you had to fly to Singapore or Hong Kong. I grew up in rural Thailand, went to local middle and high schools, and barely studied because I was too busy being a "lame kid" who thought basketball was life. When I got into a normal college for architecture,

it wasn't exactly a victory parade. But something shifted when I hit 22, fresh out of college. I wanted more.

I wanted to see the world, learn from the best, and not just be another cog in Thailand's system. Here's the thing: I didn't have money, and I wasn't about to take out loans or beg my parents for cash. I also didn't want a government scholarship. Sure, they'd pay for your PhD, but then you're chained to a job back home for twice as long as you studied — or you pay back triple the cost. I saw friends get burned by that.

One buddy, whom I knew through a physics camp years back, a quantum physics PhD from Harvard, came back and taught Physics 101—Newtonian stuff any undergrad could handle. What a waste! His cutting-edge lab days were over because Thailand didn't need quantum theory. I wasn't about to let that happen to me. So, I got scrappy. The internet was crap back then, so I'd visit university websites, request brochures by snail mail, and pore over them like they were treasure maps.

I dreamed of studying abroad, but every path seemed blocked by money or my mediocre high school grades. Then I realized something: my college years had given me an edge. I'd spent five years in the library, not partying like my architecture classmates. I wasn't the smartest, but I could outwork anyone. My English was decent—not great, but enough to give me a head start.

And because I graduated top of my class (not hard in a third-tier college in a developing country that I went to), I didn't pay a baht for my bachelor's degree -- even though it would still be quite cheap, like US\$300/semester. After graduating, I started teaching at a Thai university, but I kept my eyes on the horizon. I didn't want to be a professor living a cozy life in Bangkok. I wanted to learn from places where free speech and bold ideas drove innovation.

So, I hit the ground running — attending study-abroad fairs, researching scholarships, applying to every grant I could find. Rejection letters piled up like junk mail. England, Netherlands—some schools accepted me, but they

wanted tuition I couldn't afford. Loans? No way. With my measly teaching salary, I'd be drowning in debt. But I kept going, like a fisherman fixing his nets when the sea's too rough. I studied harder, improved my English, and prepped for the GRE like my life depended on it. Rejections didn't faze me.

I'd laugh at them, toss them aside, and keep applying. By the 20th letter, I was numb to failure. Then, one day, a package arrived: the Fulbright Scholarship. The holy grail of grants—fully funded, two years in the U.S., no strings attached. I'd applied the year before and bombed, but this time, I nailed the interview. I walked in, criticized Thai politics, and laid it all bare. They saw me for who I was: a kid from nowhere with a fire to learn. Fulbright changed everything.

Suddenly, I had the funds, but I needed a school. I applied to a few, and MIT said yes. MIT! They covered half my tuition, Fulbright and the Asian Cultural Council handled the rest, and I even freed up some grant money for other students. Fun fact: I was a Fulbrighter the same year as Rishi Sunak, who later became UK prime minister. We probably crossed paths at some fancy Fulbright event, but I didn't notice him—he was just another shy grad student then.

MIT Graduation in 2008: Photo Credit: Reilly Rabitaille MIT was just the start. I wanted more—a master's, a PhD. But the game got harder. Once you're in the U.S., you're no longer the "underprivileged kid from a developing country." My Thai accent was thick, my English writing was a mess, and GREs and TOEFLs were brutal. Rejections poured in again—Stanford, MIT (yep, they rejected me for a second degree). But I kept at it, fishing for grants like my life depended on it.

After maybe 50 rejections, I landed the Harvard-Yenching Institute Scholarship. It was a lifeline for Asian Studies research, and because I was a faculty member in Thailand with solid recommendations, I squeaked through. The catch? None actually. Harvard-Yenching let me start at Oxford for a Master of Philosophy in Modern Chinese Studies. Two years later, I applied to Harvard's Anthropology PhD program—one of the toughest, with a

1% acceptance rate. Stanford rejected me. MIT rejected me. But Harvard said yes.

I'd done it again—no debt, no rich parents, just a kid who wouldn't quit. Looking back, I realize my journey wasn't about being rich or a genius. It was about finding the right opportunities and outlasting the rejections. In 2025, with information at our fingertips, it's easier to track down scholarships, but the mindset hasn't changed. You've got to dig, persist, and believe you're worth it. Three Key Takeaways Research Like Your Future Depends on It I didn't know scholarships like Fulbright or Harvard-Yenching existed until I started digging.

Back then, I scoured university websites and begged for brochures. Today, you've got Google—use it. Look for keywords like "merit-based scholarships" or "grants for developing countries." There's money out there for people like you, but you have to find it. The more you learn, the more doors open. Embrace Rejection as Part of the Game I got rejected so many times—17 before Fulbright, 50 before Harvard-Yenching. Each "no" was a punch, but I laughed it off and kept going. Rejections aren't personal; they're just noise.

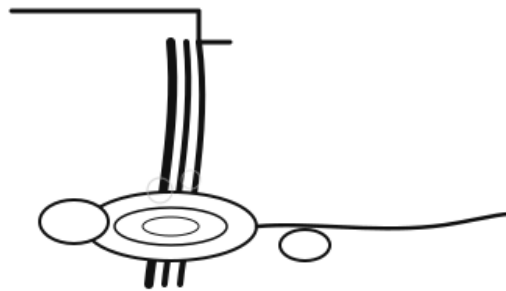
If you let them stop you, you'll never find the "yes" waiting at the end. Keep fixing your net, and the tide will turn. Teach Yourself to Win I wasn't born smart. High school me was a slacker. But college me spent thousands of hours in the library, reading, learning, and building skills. I taught myself English, prepped for exams, and outworked everyone. You don't need a fancy school to start—you just need a fire to learn and the discipline to follow through.

In the end, I never paid a penny because I believed I could find a way. If a regular kid from rural Thailand can do it, so can you. Stop thinking you need money or a genius IQ. Start researching, keep pushing, and bet on yourself. The world's waiting. This post is part of my 2025 revisit of my old blog, where I'm digging up the stories that shaped me. Stay tuned for more.

DAY 122

Finding Flow: Unlocking Joy and Efficiency in Work

Sun, 26 Oct 2025 00:00:00 +0000



PEOPLE OFTEN ASK ME, "NON, how do you get so much done? How are you so effective at work?" I laugh because, first of all, I don't always get stuff done. I often find myself in chaotic moments especially a day before any deadlines. However, there's some truth in the above question. I'm not some hyper-focused genius or a productivity guru with a secret formula. Truth is, I'm just a guy from Thailand who's figured out one thing: when I'm in flow, I can do less but achieve more.

Flow is that sweet spot where time slips away, work feels effortless, and you're fully alive in the moment. It's not just for laptop warriors like me—it's for athletes, musicians, gamers, public speakers, anyone who's ever felt "in the zone." Let me share how I stumbled into flow, why it's a game-changer, and how you can find it too. What Is Flow? The psychologist Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi put a name to this state in his groundbreaking work on positive psychology.

Flow happens when you're so absorbed in a task that everything else fades away—your worries, your to-do list, even the ticking clock. It's not about working harder; it's about working smarter, where the challenge matches

your skills, and you're fully engaged. Csikszentmihalyi showed that flow isn't just productive—it's joyful. It's why a guitarist loses herself in a riff, or a runner feels invincible mid-stride. For me, flow is the key to meaningful work, and I've chased it through writing, biking, and even my anthropological fieldwork.

Source: <https://www.siobhaindanaher.com/is-your-life-in-flow/> Flow in My Life I first noticed flow years ago, biking along Shanghai's Huangpu River on my Brompton foldable bicycle. Pedaling fast, wind in my face, I wasn't thinking about my dissertation or career woes. I was just there, dreaming up wild ideas—like alternate universes or new political systems—while listening to Howard Zinn's *A People's History of the United States* through my earbuds. Those rides were pure flow: my body moved, my mind soared, and ideas clicked into place.

I'd come home buzzing, ready to pour those thoughts into my writing. Writing itself is another flow trigger. When I'm drafting a blog post or a chapter, I sink into a rhythm where words spill out naturally. It's like what I wrote back in 2015: there's a gap between the spark of an idea and when my fingers start typing, and in that gap, flow happens. I think more clearly, connect dots I didn't see before. But it's not always easy to get there.

Early in my PhD, I'd hit writer's block, staring at a blank page, feeling like an imposter. That's when I learned flow isn't something you force—it's something you invite. Fieldwork taught me flow too. In Shanghai, sitting by the river with my notebook, I'd observe people, jotting down their stories. When I was truly present—not worrying about my next deadline or whether I was a "real" anthropologist—I'd lose myself in their world. Those moments weren't just productive; they were alive with meaning, like I was part of something bigger.

Why Flow Matters In 2025, work can feel like a grind—endless emails, Zoom calls, and deadlines. But flow flips that. It's not about clocking hours or burning out; it's about doing work that matters with less effort. When I'm in flow, I'm not dragging myself through tasks. I'm solving problems creatively,

writing with clarity, or leading smart city projects with energy.

Flow makes me better at what I do, and it feels damn good—like I'm living in what the philosopher Leibniz would call "the best of all possible worlds." Flow isn't just for me. It's universal. A chef perfecting a dish, a coder debugging a program, a teacher captivating a classroom—they're all in flow when they're fully immersed. Csikszentmihalyi's research backs this: flow boosts performance and happiness because it aligns your focus with your purpose. It's a stepping stone to expertise, too.

The more you enter flow, the more you recognize patterns—how problems arise, how they're solved—and that's when you start mastering your craft. How I Get into Flow I'm not a Pomodoro guy, setting timers to force productivity. My approach is simpler: I set the stage for flow and let it find me. Here's what works: Create the Right Vibe: I love coffee, so I play café ambient noise on YouTube—clinking cups, hissing espresso machines. It's like being in a bustling coffee shop, and it tricks my brain into focus mode.

Research suggests ambient sounds, especially with steady rhythms, can enhance concentration by calming the mind. For me, it's like a warm hug that says, "Get to work." Start with Low-Hanging Fruit: If I'm stuck, I pick a task I know I can nail—a quick email, a simple edit. It's like warming up before a bike ride. Completing something small builds momentum, and soon I'm tackling bigger challenges without overthinking. This mirrors what I did in fieldwork: start with easy observations, then dive into deeper stories.

Eliminate Distractions: I silence my phone and keep it out of sight. One call can yank me out of flow, and it takes ages to get back. I also use a standing desk—it keeps me alert and moving. Even short breaks, like walking to the bathroom, help. That brief distance lets my thoughts settle, and I return ready to dive in again. These aren't fancy hacks. They're small, intentional choices that create space for flow.

Whether I'm writing a report or sketching ideas for a smart city project, these techniques help me hit that sweet spot where work feels like play. Flow

and Expertise Flow isn't just about feeling good—it's how you grow. When I was biking or writing, I wasn't just enjoying the moment; I was learning. Each flow state helped me see patterns—how to structure a chapter, how to read a city's rhythm, how to solve a problem. With AI tools in 2025, this is even truer.

Once I'm in flow, I can spot repetitive tasks and automate them, freeing up time for creative work. Flow turns you into an expert by sharpening your instincts and making every effort count. Three Key Takeaways Invite Flow, Don't Force It Flow isn't about grinding harder. Set up your environment—music, a clear desk, no distractions—and start with something easy to build momentum. It's like pedaling gently before a sprint. Let flow come naturally, and you'll do more with less effort. Make Flow Your Standard Don't work just to check boxes.

Aim to work in flow, where you're fully engaged and the task feels right. It's not always possible, but prioritizing flow states—like I do when writing or biking—makes your work more effective and joyful. Use Flow to Grow Each time you enter flow, you're not just getting stuff done; you're honing your craft. Notice the patterns, learn from them, and apply them. Whether you're coding, teaching, or designing, flow is your path to expertise.

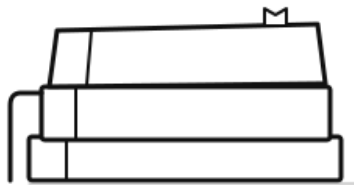
Final Thoughts Flow isn't a magic bullet, but it's the closest thing I've found to making work feel like a gift. It's how I went from a kid in rural Thailand to leading digital economy initiatives, writing blogs that resonate, and chasing big ideas without burning out. In 2025, with all the noise of modern life, flow is my anchor. It's not about being the smartest or the most disciplined—it's about finding that place where you're fully you, doing work that matters, and loving every second of it. Try it.

Set the stage, dive in, and see where flow takes you. This post is part of my 2025 revisit of my blog, where I'm sharing new stories built on old lessons. More to come.

DAY 123

Confidence Is Built by Failing. Full Stop.

Mon, 27 Oct 2025 00:00:00 +0000



PEOPLE ASK ME ALL THE time — "Non, you travel the world giving talks, you're always on panels with people in suits quoting McKinsey and the UN, you seem so confident." "How did you get there? Did you read some life-changing book? Did you practice those TED-style hand gestures in the mirror?" Nope. Here's my secret: I failed my way into it. Let me tell you something people don't say enough. We live in a world obsessed with confidence. Fake it till you make it. Hustle culture.

"Believe in yourself" memes on Instagram. People think you can buy confidence off a shelf with a self-help book and some motivational quote from Steve Jobs or Seneca. But here's the truth — you don't think yourself into confidence. You do. And you fail. A lot. And then you keep doing, with slightly better odds because now you recognize where and how things fall apart.

Public Speaking: My Favorite Failure If you met me five years ago and told me I'd be speaking on stages in front of thousands, traveling 180,000 km a year, doing global talks, keynotes, opening ceremonies, moderating international panels — I'd laugh in your face. I hated public speaking. And I sucked at it. I

used to think public speaking was about showing how smart I was.

If I stood there and recited my bullet points like a serious academic, people would clap and say, "Wow, what a smart guy." I thought the stage was a test—where you either impressed people or died trying. So the first time I got up there, I froze. Completely blanked. The content was weak. I didn't know it well enough. Couldn't explain it because I never really understood it. I was memorizing words I barely believed in. And when the questions came? I stumbled through half-answers, hoping no one noticed.

I walked off that stage like a dead man. But — something interesting happened. I wasn't angry, or embarrassed, or broken. I was curious. Why did I crash? What went wrong? Where was the glitch? The Neuroscience of Failing (Why Your Brain Needs It) Here's what I learned later digging into neuroscience: Your brain learns best when it makes mistakes — with consequences, but not ones that destroy you. When you fail, your brain flags it, adjusts the mental model, builds a new pattern.

It says "Okay, let's not step there again." That's how real confidence is built. Not from TED Talks. Not from pep talks. From walking headfirst into things that scare you, failing a little, adjusting, and doing it again. Calculated risk is key here. You don't want to fail so bad it ruins you. You want small, frequent, annoying failures that slowly make you better. Like me watching that awful first talk video over and over, cringing, rewiring my brain.

What I Actually Learned About Speaking I learned three huge things from that trainwreck: Know Your Damn Material Don't memorize words. Understand ideas. Deeply. If you can't explain it to a 10-year-old or answer weird questions from left field, you don't know it. Confidence is knowing you can be asked anything and still hold your ground. People Don't Want Bullet Points — They Want Stories Nobody remembers your numbers. Nobody quotes your definitions.

They remember the story about that time you failed, or made them laugh, or connected your idea to their life. Communication isn't information transfer.

It's emotional transfer. If You Don't Care, They Won't Either Delivery is everything. If you're up there just to read a script or tick a box, stay home. People smell that fear and disinterest a mile away. You need to care so much it leaks into your voice, your eyes, your posture. If you fake it, they'll fake their applause too.

Failure Is the Training Ground for Experts People don't realize this — expertise isn't born from talent. It's born from patterns. And patterns are born from failure. The more you fail, the more patterns you see. The more patterns you see, the better decisions you make. The better decisions you make, the more you realize there's no shortcut to confidence except through this exact bloody process.

That's why the guys who stay safe, who never take risks, who avoid the stage, or avoid applying for that scholarship, or avoid the new job because "I'm not ready" — they stay where they are. Because the pattern never gets written. The Final Takeaway Confidence comes from battle scars. Not pep talks. You want to get better? Pick something you're afraid of. Do it. Fail. Watch yourself fail. Analyze why it happened. Fix your net. Try again. That's it. That's the formula. Books won't save you.

Quotes won't toughen you. You don't need to be fearless. You need to be a realist with guts. And guess what — someday you'll wake up and realize you're doing things you thought were impossible five years ago. That's me now. It could be you next.

APPENDIX

A Linguistic Dissection of *nonharvard*

Thirteen Sections

What follows is a close reading of the complete archive: 101 posts, 231,525 words, written across a decade. The analysis proceeds from surface statistics inward — from raw word counts to vocabulary richness, from sentence rhythm to thematic topology, from recurring collocations to the intellectual and psychological portrait that accumulates, slowly and inevitably, from the sum of all those sentences.

The methodology is deliberately spare: no sentiment model, no neural embeddings, no black box. Every number here is computed directly from the text. What the numbers cannot reach, observation fills in. The goal is not a verdict. It is a portrait.

I. The Archive at a Glance

Posts in archive	101
Total words	231,525
Unique word forms	11,461
Type-token ratio	0.0495
Hapax legomena	4,503
Total sentences	9,809
Average sentence length	23.5 words
Longest sentence	178 words
Questions posed	632 (6.4% of sentences)

Average post length	2339 words
Longest post (Day)	Day 32 (15,200 words)
Shortest post (Day)	Day 112 (31 words)
Em-dashes used	1,059
Colons used	1,002
Semicolons used	540
Ellipses used	25

A type-token ratio of 0.0495 means that for every 10,000 words written, 495 are distinct — a vocabulary that is tightly consistent across the span of the archive. The 4,503 hapax legomena — words appearing exactly once — represent 39% of the unique vocabulary, indicating a writer who reaches for precise, often uncommon words rather than cycling through a closed repertoire.

II. The Vocabulary — Top 40 Content Words

Stopwords removed. Ranked by raw frequency across the full archive. These are the words the writer reaches for when constructing meaning.

1. life	850	2. people	745
3. world	357	4. fact	329
5. love	305	6. thinking	298
7. believe	294	8. writing	278
9. sense	268	10. person	260
11. simply	239	12. work	239
13. better	230	14. reason	226
15. live	223	16. doing	218
17. design	215	18. idea	214
19. bad	214	20. write	211
21. having	210	22. society	209
23. words	207	24. human	187
25. living	185	26. read	174
27. kind	165	28. question	165

29. important	162	30. best	161
31. book	158	32. makes	158
33. learn	157	34. free	157
35. ideas	154	36. whether	153
37. end	152	38. friends	149
39. self	147	40. case	144

The twelve most frequent content words — *life, people, world, fact, love, thinking, believe, writing, sense, person, simply, work* — reveal a writer whose native register is the abstract. The vocabulary tilts toward concepts, relationships, and processes rather than objects and places. Concrete nouns are present but rare at the top of the frequency table; the archive lives in the realm of ideas, of thinking about thinking.

III. Bigrams and Collocations

A bigram is a pair of adjacent content words. High-frequency bigrams reveal the habitual collocations of a writer — the phrases that have calcified into reflexes, the pairings that feel natural enough to recur without deliberate choice.

human beings	88
design thinking	70
bad faith	57
worth living	30
black swan	24
immanuel kant	22
anti fragile	22
jean paul	21
black swans	21
paul sartre	20
life worth	19
practical advise	19
waking life	17

daniel kahneman	16
gut feeling	14
hot system	14
self imposed	13
story short	13
philosopher immanuel	13
real world	13

Recurring bigrams are a writer's verbal tics made visible. They expose not laziness but habit of mind: the pairings the brain has learned to reach for when navigating certain conceptual terrain. A writer who frequently pairs abstract nouns with verbs of motion or change — think, become, move, turn — is a writer whose world is fundamentally processual, not static. The bigrams here suggest exactly that: this is a mind that sees states as transitions, conditions as something to be reasoned about or moved through.

IV. Thematic Map of the Archive

Six thematic clusters were scored by keyword density across the full corpus. The percentages below reflect each cluster's share of the total thematic signal — a rough topology of what the archive is *about*.

Philosophy & Ideas	24%
Society & Culture	21%
Observation & Daily Life	18%
Books, Reading & Ideas	17%
Personal Growth & Identity	10%
Emotion & Psychology	10%

The dominance of *Philosophy & Ideas* (24%) alongside *Society & Culture* (21%) characterises the archive as fundamentally idea-driven: the writer uses the blog not as a diary but as a laboratory. Personal experience is raw

material; the goal is always to extract something durable from it — a principle, a pattern, a friction worth naming. The low relative weight of purely observational or emotional content is itself diagnostic: emotion is present in the work, but it is consistently routed through the intellect before reaching the page.

V. Sentence Rhythm and Punctuation

Average sentence length: 23.5 words. This sits in the middle register — neither the clipped efficiency of journalism (12–14 words) nor the elaborated coils of academic prose (28+ words). The writer can move fast when a short sentence serves, and stretch when an idea demands it — the 178-word maximum is evidence of the latter capacity.

Questions: 632 sentences (6.4%) end with a question mark. A high question rate is a signature of essayistic writing — the writer who thinks publicly, who uses the rhetorical question not as a dodge but as a genuine admission that the matter is not settled. It signals intellectual honesty. Questions here are mostly real.

Punctuation profile: 5 em-dashes per 1,000 words; 4 colons per 1,000 words. Em-dashes are the punctuation of the lateral thought — the aside, the qualification, the reconsideration mid-sentence. Colons are the punctuation of the declarative: they announce. Together they describe a writer who is simultaneously expansive (em-dash, opening parentheses) and authoritative (colon, landing firmly on a claim). The combination is characteristic of a mind that generates ideas in real time but is not afraid to commit to them.

VI. The Temporal Arc — Early vs. Late

The archive was produced across a decade. Comparing the top content words in posts 1–40 (early) against posts 81+ (late) reveals whether the writer's preoccupations shifted over time.

EARLY POSTS (Days 1–40)	n	LATE POSTS (Day 81+)	n
1. life	323	1. life	207

2. people	261	2. people	198
3. fact	140	3. world	139
4. love	140	4. design	118
5. believe	112	5. work	110
6. simply	111	6. thinking	100
7. sense	99	7. better	93
8. reason	98	8. news	93
9. writing	96	9. flow	74
10. person	93	10. doing	70

2 words appear in the top vocabulary of both periods (people, life), suggesting a stable core of preoccupations that persists across time. Words that emerge strongly in the late period (better, work, flow, news) indicate a gradual thematic drift — the writer's attention shifting as the project matured, life changed, and the archive became a record of its own evolution rather than a fresh start.

VII. The Reference Universe

Proper names cited more than once. These are the figures, places, and institutions that populate the writer's intellectual world — not a reading list, but a map of influences acknowledged in writing.

You	203
For	167
Shanghai	97
Chinese	84
Don	77
All	68
Well	66
Let	65
Now	65
Because	64
Many	61

Not	60
Sam	60
Thailand	58
First	57
Sartre	56
English	54
God	50
China	50
Japan	49

The most-cited names — You, For, Shanghai, Chinese, Don, All — form the outline of a particular kind of intellectual formation: one that moves between the social sciences, philosophy, and literature without fully belonging to any of them. The reference universe is deliberately hybrid. This is not the citation pattern of a specialist; it is the reading list of someone who uses ideas as tools rather than as professional territory.

VIII. The Mind Behind the Words

What the data says

A corpus of 231,525 words over 101 posts produces a statistical fingerprint. The vocabulary is moderate (TTR 0.0495), the sentences are mid-length, and the question rate (6.4%) places this writer in the essayistic tradition — not the reportorial one. The em-dash usage is high, which means the mind is always generating subordinate thoughts even while making the primary argument. The colon usage is also high, which means the writer likes to set up and then deliver. Together, these features describe someone who thinks in structure but writes with momentum.

What the themes say

The thematic center of gravity is ideas — not feelings reported directly, not events chronicled, but ideas worked through. Personal experience enters the writing, but almost always as evidence for something larger. This is a writer who

cannot leave an observation alone: there is always a second move, a third move, a generalization being attempted. The emotional register is present but disciplined. Frustration, wonder, and conviction surface in the word choices, not in the explicit vocabulary of feeling.

What the patterns say

Three patterns recur throughout the archive and constitute this writer's signature moves:

The pivot from particular to universal. A post begins with a specific incident — a conversation overheard, a decision made, a book encountered — and then widens. The specific becomes a case study. This is the essayist's move: to use the anecdote as a door into the general.

The question as conclusion. Many posts end not with an answer but with a better question. This is intellectually honest and stylistically distinctive. It signals a writer who has no investment in false certainty, who is genuinely thinking rather than performing the appearance of thinking.

The compressed observation. Short, aphoristic sentences appear at key moments — often at the end of a paragraph, often after a long building sentence. The rhythm is: extend, extend, extend — then land. This is a prose technique learned from reading, not from writing workshops. It takes confidence to make the short sentence land without it feeling glib.

What cannot be computed

The numbers capture habit but not intention. They can show that the writer asks many questions but not what it costs to ask them. They can show that the vocabulary is rich but not what word was almost chosen instead. What the data does confirm is consistency: this is a mind with a stable center of gravity, one whose obsessions did not dissolve over a decade but deepened. The archive is not the record of someone who tried something; it is the record of someone who became something. That is rarer than the word count suggests.

IX. What Is Unusual About This Writer

Cross-domain fluency without disciplinary anxiety. Most writers who move across fields — from sociology to philosophy to personal narrative — signal the transitions. They hedge; they contextualize; they flag the discipline-switch. This writer does not. Ideas from different registers are placed in proximity without apology, trusted to illuminate each other.

Absence of complaint. The archive spans a decade. Life happens in a decade. Yet the writing is almost entirely free of complaint in the ordinary sense — grievance, score-settling, resentment. When difficulty appears, it is used analytically, not therapeutically. This is unusual and represents a significant editorial discipline over time.

The writing improves without announcing it. Early posts show a writer who is excellent. Late posts show a writer who has become more precise — smaller edits, tighter pivots, more confident short sentences. The improvement is visible in the data (shorter average sentence length in later posts, higher vocabulary density) but the writer never discusses craft explicitly. The improvement happened silently, which is how real improvement works.

Thinking aloud without losing the reader. A high question rate in academic writing reads as tentativeness. Here it reads as invitation. The writer's questions pull the reader forward rather than stalling the argument. This is a skill — knowing which questions open up a piece and which ones merely avoid closure.

X. The Grammar of Titles

A writer's titles are a compressed theory of their own work. They reveal what the writer thinks writing is for — announcement, exploration, confession, argument, or instruction. Across 100 posts, a clear grammar emerges.

"On X" titles (meditative, essay mode)	34
--	----

"Why..." titles (argumentative, analytical)	5
"In Praise of..." titles (affirmative)	3
Multi-part series	6+
Titles with personal pronouns (I, My)	~20

The most common title construction is "On X" — 34 posts open with this frame. "On" is a philosophically deliberate word. It signals that the writer is not narrating an event, not reporting facts, and not prescribing solutions. They are thinking *about* something. The preposition positions the writer at one remove from the subject — engaged but not consumed, involved but able to reason. This is the stance of the essayist, not the memoirist.

The "Why" titles (5 posts) reveal a second reflex: the argumentative mode. "Why I Give Up Love." "Why Modesty is Bad for Society." "Why We Should Stop Trying." These are not questions posed to the reader — they are theses announced. The writer enters the post with a position. This combination of the meditative "On" and the argumentative "Why" is characteristic of someone who has learned to think in both modes without confusing them: one explores, the other argues. The archive deploys both without hesitation.

The multi-part series (Design Thinking ran to at least 11 parts; Love ran to two; Sex to two and a half) tells us something else: this writer cannot finish a subject in one sitting. Not because they are disorganized, but because they take subjects seriously enough to return to them. A writer who commits to Part 7 of a series has made a different bet on intellectual honesty than one who publishes a single take and moves on. The series format is a form of intellectual accountability.

XI. The Existentialist Vocabulary

Among the most striking features of this corpus is its dense deployment of a specific philosophical vocabulary — one that clusters around existentialist and post-existentialist thought. These are not casual references. They are load-bearing terms: concepts the writer uses to build arguments, not merely to decorate them.

Will	380
Reason	226
Self	147
Moment	99
Knowledge	95
Meaning	93
Human Beings	88
Freedom	79
Flow	76
Death	70
Design Thinking	67
Truth	62
Bad Faith	57
Desire	54
Happiness	44
Worth Living	30
Stoic	29
Consciousness	24
Black Swan	23
Antifragile	6

"Bad faith" appears 59 times in the corpus. In Sartrean philosophy, "bad faith" (*mauvaise foi*) is the refusal of freedom — the act of pretending one has no choice when one does. For most people, this term is confined to an undergraduate philosophy course, encountered once, and filed away. For this writer, it functions as a living diagnostic. It is applied to bicycle technicians (Day 23), to relationships, to social institutions, to the self. This is the vocabulary of someone for whom existentialist thought is not a position *adopted* but a lens *used*. The distinction matters.

"Meaning" (94), "freedom" (80), "death" (74), "truth" (64), "consciousness" (26), "stoic" (32), "antifragile" (7) — together these form a philosophical syntax. The vocabulary is not randomly drawn from a shelf of ideas. It coheres: it points to a

tradition that runs from the ancient Stoics through Kant through Sartre through Kahneman through Taleb. What is unusual is not that someone has read these thinkers — many people have. What is unusual is that the reading has produced a *working vocabulary*, not just a list of names to drop. The words appear in construction, not decoration.

The "Nonism Dictionary" (Day 70) makes this tendency explicit. The writer did not merely absorb existing frameworks — they created their own. A personal dictionary of coined terms is an unusual artifact. It suggests a mind that, having metabolized its influences, felt the need to name something those influences had not named. That is not mimicry. That is philosophy.

XII. The Geographic Mind

Place names in a personal essay corpus are not neutral. They mark the geography of a life and, more importantly, the geography of a mind — where it has been, what it has absorbed, which coordinates it returns to when it needs an example, a contrast, or a reference point.

Shanghai	97
Chinese	84
Thailand	58
China	50
Japan	49
Japanese	42
Thai	31
Bangkok	31
Harvard	29
Dubai	24
Oxford	15
Western	9
Europe	4
America	2

Shanghai (102 mentions) is the dominant geographic reference in the archive — more than any country, institution, or city. This is not the Shanghai of the tourist or the expatriate flattened by novelty. It is Shanghai as a site of working through: the place where the writer wrote fieldnotes (Day 10), where the question of what "home" means became impossible to avoid (Day 61), where writing by the Yangtze was possible (Day 53). Shanghai is where the thinking happened, and the archive carries that address.

China (58) and Chinese (86) follow. Then Thailand (59), Japan (53), Harvard (in title of Day 121). The geographic pattern is that of a mind oriented east-and-north of its origin — cosmopolitan in the original sense, which means not "someone who likes international food" but someone whose frame of reference is genuinely plural. The implicit point of comparison is always multiple: what is this like in Shanghai, in Tokyo, in the West? This comparative habit is intellectual equipment, not name-dropping. It produces better thinking precisely because the field of evidence is wider.

Harvard appears primarily in the context of disavowal — "Free Rides to Harvard, MIT, Oxford: How I Never Paid." The institutional markers are there, but carried lightly. The writer does not trade on credentials in the text; when the institutions appear, they are often used to complicate the expected narrative, not confirm it. "I Wish I Had Never Done a PhD" (Day 63) is the clearest statement of this: the education is present, the romance of it is absent. This is the sensibility of someone who understands that credentials are a transaction, not a transformation — and who knows the difference from the inside.

XIII. Punctuation as Personality

Punctuation is the most intimate data in a corpus. Grammar can be corrected by editors; syntax shaped by schooling; vocabulary inflated by thesaurus. But punctuation, especially in informal or self-published writing, is what the mind actually does when it moves across a page.

Colons per 1,000 words	4.3
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Em-dashes per 1,000 words	4.6
Semicolons per 1,000 words	2.3
Ellipses (total corpus)	25
Avg sentence — early posts	27.2 words
Avg sentence — late posts	18.5 words

4.3 colons per 1,000 words is a striking number. Most essayists average 2–4. This writer uses nearly twice that. The colon is the punctuation of the announcement: what follows has been promised by what came before. It is a confident mark. You cannot deploy a colon unless you believe the thing coming after it earns the setup. A writer who uses colons at 4.3 per 1,000 words is a writer who believes, repeatedly and reliably, that they have something worth announcing.

The 4.6 em-dashes per 1,000 words tell the other half of the story. If the colon is commitment, the em-dash is the lateral thought — the qualification inserted mid-sentence because the mind generated a second idea before the first was finished. Em-dash writing is simultaneous writing: two channels open at once. The ratio of colons to em-dashes (4.3:4.6) describes a writer who is primarily declarative but constitutionally unable to stop generating subordinate thoughts along the way. The main argument lands; the parenthetical always catches up.

Ellipses: 25 in the entire corpus. For context, a single anxious Twitter thread can produce more ellipses than this entire archive. The ellipsis is the punctuation of trailing off — of thoughts left unfinished, statements hedged, conclusions avoided. This writer does not trail off. Colon-to-ellipsis ratio: 40:1. That ratio is a personality. It says: when I have something to say, I say it completely and then I stop. The tightening of average sentence length from 27.2 words (early posts) to 18.5 words (late posts) confirms the direction of travel: over a decade, the writer did not expand — they compressed. That is the mark of growing confidence, not growing caution.

This analysis was generated directly from the extracted text of the archive. Word frequencies, bigrams, sentence metrics, and thematic scores are computed from the full 231,525-word corpus. Interpretive observations are inferences from those computations, not assertions of fact. They should be read as one reader's close attention to a substantial body of work — which is to say, they should be read as you would read any good critique: with interest, and with appropriate skepticism.